BOOK OF

# PROCEEDINGS

## VIOLENT CONFLICTS AND PEACEBUILDING IN TARABA STATE, NORTHEAST NIGERIA



UNDERSTAND CONFLICTS

PROMOTE DIALOGUE AND INCLUSION

BUILD SUSTAINABLE PEACE

DEPARTMENT OF PEACE STUDIES AND CONFLICT RESOLUTION,
BUREAU FOR PEACE AND CONFLICT MANAGEMENT



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# PREFACE

This conference publication brings together scholarly contributions that reflect on contemporary issues, debates, and challenges within the broad field of social sciences and related disciplines. It provides a platform for researchers, academics, practitioners, and other stakeholders to share ideas, present research findings, and engage in meaningful intellectual dialogue.

The contributions assembled in this volume demonstrate the importance of interdisciplinary scholarship and collaborative engagement in advancing knowledge and deepening understanding of complex contemporary realities. The diversity of perspectives presented reflects the richness of academic inquiry and the value of bringing different experiences, approaches, and methodological traditions into conversation.

This publication is therefore intended not only as a record of the conference but also as a resource for scholars, students, policymakers, practitioners, and other interested readers. It captures the intellectual engagements generated by the conference and provides a basis for further reflection, research, and collaboration.

We acknowledge with gratitude the authors, reviewers, editors, organisers, participants, and supporting institutions whose collective efforts made this publication possible. We hope that the ideas and insights contained in this volume will stimulate further scholarship, encourage constructive debate, and contribute meaningfully to knowledge and practice.

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We sincerely appreciate the keynote speakers, guests, paper presenters, and participants for their valuable contributions, insights, and active engagement, which greatly enriched the conference.

We are grateful to the conference organising committee, reviewers, session chairs, moderators, rapporteurs, volunteers, technical team, and support staff for their dedication, commitment, and tireless efforts in ensuring the smooth coordination and success of the event.

Our special appreciation goes to the host institution, sponsors, partners, and supporting organisations for their invaluable institutional, financial, logistical, and moral support. Your contributions provided an essential foundation for the successful organisation of the conference.

Finally, we thank everyone who contributed, directly or indirectly, to making the conference a success. We deeply appreciate your support and commitment and look forward to continued collaboration in future academic and professional engagements.

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## ABOUT THE CONFERENCE

The Maiden National Conference on “Violent Conflicts and Peacebuilding in Taraba State, Northeast Nigeria” was organised by the Department of Peace Studies and Conflict Resolution, Taraba State University, Jalingo, in collaboration with the Bureau for Peace and Conflict Resolution, Office of the Governor, Taraba State. Held at Taraba State University, Jalingo, on 30 November 2025, the conference provided a multidisciplinary platform for scholars, researchers, policy analysts, civil society actors, practitioners, and other stakeholders to critically examine the dynamics of violent conflict and the possibilities for sustainable peacebuilding in Taraba State and the wider Northeast.

The conference was conceived against the backdrop of the complex and changing patterns of violent conflict affecting communities across Taraba State and the Northeast region. It sought to move beyond understanding Taraba merely as a site of insecurity by creating a space for rigorous scholarly inquiry into the causes, manifestations, actors, consequences, and responses to violent conflicts. Particular attention was given to the intersections between conflict, governance, identity, environmental change, displacement, livelihoods, gender, youth, security, and cross-border dynamics.

A major objective of the conference was to strengthen the relationship between research, policy, and practice. Accordingly, contributions addressed a broad range of issues, including banditry and kidnapping; conflict actors and changing conflict landscapes; state and non-state responses; religion and inter-communal relations; indigenous conflict-resolution mechanisms; traditional authority; climate change and communal violence; farmer-herder relations; cross-border conflict; displacement and humanitarian responses; refugees and internally displaced persons; gender-based violence; youth and education; identity politics; transitional justice; security-sector reform; and the role of traditional, religious, and community leaders in peacebuilding.

The conference also foregrounded the importance of local knowledge, local ownership, and community-based approaches to peacebuilding. Discussions around indigenous conflict-resolution mechanisms, traditional authority, women and youth in peacebuilding, and community resilience reflected the need to develop peacebuilding approaches that are grounded in the lived experiences and institutional realities of affected communities. In this regard, the conference recognised that sustainable peace cannot depend exclusively on state security interventions but requires meaningful collaboration among government institutions, communities, traditional and religious authorities, civil society organisations, researchers, and other relevant actors.

Importantly, the conference sought to reposition Taraba State within national conversations on conflict and peace. Rather than portraying the State solely as a conflict-affected location, it emphasised Taraba's potential as a peacebuilding laboratory and a centre of resilience-building in Nigeria's conflict-prone Northeast. The conference provided an opportunity to identify existing peacebuilding practices, examine their limitations, and explore innovative approaches capable of strengthening social cohesion, reconciliation, community resilience, and sustainable development.

The collaboration between the Department of Peace Studies and Conflict Resolution, Taraba State University, and the Bureau for Peace and Conflict Resolution, Office of the Governor, Taraba State, further demonstrated the importance of linking academic expertise with governmental policy and

practice. Such collaboration provides an important foundation for translating research findings into practical interventions and for ensuring that peacebuilding policies are informed by empirical evidence and local realities.

Ultimately, the Maiden National Conference represented an important milestone in advancing scholarship and policy dialogue on violent conflict and peacebuilding in Taraba State and Northeast Nigeria. It brought together diverse intellectual and professional perspectives to interrogate the challenges of violence while simultaneously focusing attention on pathways towards sustainable peace. Through its emphasis on research-policy linkages, multidisciplinary engagement, local ownership, resilience, and sustainable peacebuilding, the conference established a foundation for continued scholarly and policy engagement and reaffirmed Taraba State's potential to contribute significantly to Nigeria's broader search for peace and security.

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# LEAD PAPER: VIOLENT CONFLICT AND THE CHALLENGES OF DEVELOPMENT AND PEACEBUILDING IN TARABA STATE, NORTHEAST NIGERIA

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## Introduction

This discussion is not centered around methodological and theoretical nuances of conflict and peacebuilding, but it is situated within the praxis of reality and fluid discussions around the human challenges that confront our contemporary society, especially in underdeveloped societies such as Taraba State, a state that does not, in a normal sense, have anything to do with violent conflict and underdevelopment. Human interactions have, over the years, created a dynamic of outcomes, either functional or dysfunctional. A relook into Karl Marx's interpretation of the history of all human societies has been that of classes, and the struggle between those classes has confirmed the dynamics involved in today's global politics and all human interaction, which bring out contestation that might be conflictual or otherwise. Tsuwa (2025) argues that a critical look at the dynamics involved in conflict exposes the reality that conflict is a natural phenomenon and can be a word, a perception, and an action. All these elements are woven into socio-cultural, religious, and economic settings of modern societies. Due to the multidimensionality of conflict, conceptualising the causal factors of conflict is usually difficult, as some issues involved in it are not obviously and immediately comprehensible. The dimensions and the stages a conflict takes are also sometimes dependent on issues that are clandestine and remote, thereby making it difficult to locate and describe its modus operandi.

Global events have shown that contestations over resources, human or natural, have aggravated violent conflict in frequency and intensity. From internal banditry to foreign-sponsored insurgency and invasions of communities and states, societies have faced what Ripley (2021) referred to as high conflict, which is magnetic. To her, societies have evolved within the fabric of conflict to the level that living without conflict is like living without love. So, from Ukraine and Russia, to Sudan and South Sudan, to Israel and Hamas, from the USA and Iran, from Syria to the Democratic Republic of Congo, we are confronted with violent conflict with its devastation consequence on life and property, which are the very goals of each state to protect. The diagram below presents a graphical expression of the challenge of insecurity, instability, organised crime, and violent conflict confronting the global community today.




*Source*: Albert (2025)

Nigeria is not too different from other nations around the world, as shown in the diagram above. In Nigeria, violent conflict and violence have been persistent and complex, with their challenges. The emergence and effects of the Boko Haram extremist group in Northeast Nigeria and, by extension, across the country introduced a new dynamic among actors, interests, and strategies of action, thereby shaping livelihoods and the state's response. Within the belly of the Boko Haram group, other forms of violent acts such as banditry, kidnapping for ransom, human trafficking and human trafficking emerged. This situation is exacerbated in the North Central and North East by the herders' invasion of farming communities, ethnic rivalry resulting from political exclusion, and the indegenship/settlership contestations.

As (Omotola, 2010; Iro, 2021) argued, Taraba State has become a microcosm of broader Northeast subregional tensions. Situated at the intersection of multiple ethnic and religious groups, Taraba's socio-political landscape is marked by diversity. While this diversity provides opportunities for collaboration and cultural richness, it has also been a source of recurring tensions. The interplay between traditional institutions, local governance structures, and community-level social dynamics creates both spaces for cooperation and points of friction, which periodically escalate into violent confrontations (Adebayo, 2018). Historical grievances over land ownership, political representation, and access to natural resources have frequently intensified these conflicts, thereby undermined human security and threatened socio-economic development. It is worthy to note that the majority of these violent conflicts have been protracted and difficult to manage due to the interests of the actors, both open and

shadowy. It is based on these complexities that I will share my thoughts with you on the conflict dynamics and the challenge of peacebuilding in Taraba State.

Before I proceed, let me sincerely thank the Vice Chancellor, Taraba State University, Jalingo, for allowing the Department of Peace Studies and Conflict Resolution to invite me to present this lead paper. This has allowed me to once again visit Jalingo, a town I served and loved 21 years ago as a youth corps member. I also appreciate the Dean, Faculty of Social Sciences, and the LOC for pioneering the collaboration between the faculty and the Bureau for Peace and Conflict Resolution, Taraba State, a Bureau I am privileged to share my thoughts with on the processes that led to its establishment. I also appreciate the "oppressors and aggressors" who have made us all vulnerable to the pains of violent conflicts in a state that we should be celebrating daily. Finally, let me appreciate all those who have gathered here for us to brainstorm towards finding lasting solutions to our common challenges.

**Conceptualizing Conflict and Violent Conflict**

Tsuwa (2025) argues that conceptualizing conflict is dicey and contestable due to the meandering and fluid nature of its occurrence, causes, nature, dimension, stages, and impact. He argues that conflict can be ideological, religious, ethnic, racial, territorial, or resource-oriented. This situation is exacerbated by the fact that Nations and individuals come to blows over ideology, territory, and the quest for resources. All these constitute conflict. This is why Andrews (2022) argues that conflict is a difference of opinion between nations, people, or political movements that involves the use of deadly violence. Andrews' definition could be seen as apt because even within the same religious belief system, a difference in opinion, as it is between the Sunni and Shia, could become conflictual, making us believe in Samuel Huntington's argument of the potency of conflict residing with a clash of perspective, which is simply the tension between cultures.

We can also agree with Tsuwa's earlier argument that conflict is contestation over emotions, ideologies, goals, and even perceived interests between people who consider them so dear to them and are not ready to relinquish them to any opponent (Tsuwa 2014). Tsuwa insists that these contestations alone do not translate to conflict, but they metamorphose into confrontations that may become conflictual. This then rolled us into Coser's definition of conflict. My arguments on conflict in this paper are more centred on the arguments of Coser (1913-2003). To him, conflict is "a struggle over values and claims to scarce status, power and resources in which the opponent aims to neutralise, injure or eliminate their rivals". Coser's argument shows that conflict is omnipresent and instinctual in all human societies and all living beings and nature. To him, conflict is a normal and functional part of human life. Conflict therefore not only generates new norms and new institutions but also stimulates the economic and technological realm. However, he also pointed out that the destructive aspect of conflict should not be ignored, but strategic measures should be taken to prevent it through careful management of the actors and their interests.

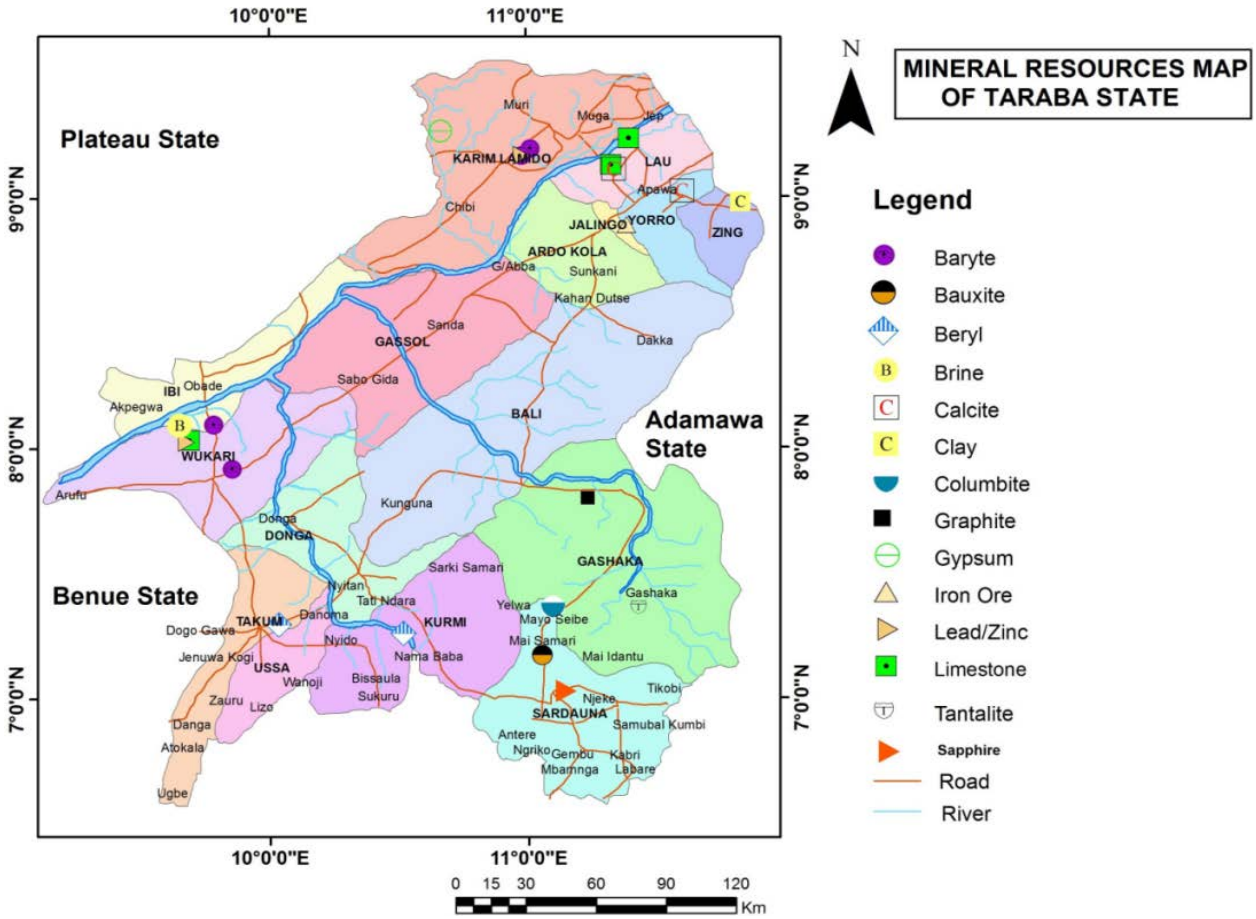
As realists argue, conflict itself may not be destructive until it becomes violent. Violence is the physical, psychological, or structural manifestation of conflict. Conflict therefore becomes violent when it involves actions that cause harm or threaten the well-being of individuals, communities, or institutions. Violence can be direct, such as armed clashes, killings, or destruction of property; structural, such as institutionalised discrimination or marginalization; or cultural, where social norms perpetuate inequality or oppression.

**Conceptualising Peacebuilding**

Peacebuilding refers to efforts aimed at preventing, reducing, or resolving conflict while addressing its root causes and sustaining long-term social harmony (Lederach, 1997). It encompasses a wide range of interventions, including mediation, reconciliation, institutional reforms, economic development, social cohesion programs, and community dialogue. Peacebuilding differs from conflict resolution in that it focuses not only on ending immediate violence but also on transforming relationships, rebuilding trust, and addressing structural inequities that fuel conflict.

**Taraba State and its Conflict and Development Dynamics**

Taraba State is located in Nigeria's North East region with 16 Local government areas and borders Adamawa, Plateau, Gombe, and Benue. It also shares an international boundary with the Republic of Cameroon. The state is highly endowed with huge human and natural resources. The map below shows that the state has great resources to stimulate development in all sectors of the economy.




*Source*: World Atlas Maps (2025)

From the map above, we can argue that despite these resources, development has eluded the state. So many reasons, ranging from poor leadership, corruption, and lack of strategic engagement by state actors, have been considered as being responsible for this. However, a critical look at the conflict occurrence dynamics of the state revealed that the lack of development is more closely associated with the dynamics of conflicts and their effects, a challenge that is only reinforced by poor leadership and corruption. Taraba State is complex, with many ethnic and religious groups with special cultural and traditional skills. These state dynamics, instead of playing a significant role in stimulating development, have turned it into a conflict landscape. The tables below reflect the key patterns, forms, actors, and their interests in the various conflicts in the state. The table below shows multidimensional conflict dynamics of the state.

Table 1: Patterns, Description, Key Drivers, and Groups Involved

| Pattern of Conflict | Description | Key Drivers / Causes | Typical Actors / Groups Involved |
|---|---|---|---|
| Farmer-Herder Clashes | Disputes between crop farmers and pastoralists over grazing and farmland, often seasonal. | Land scarcity, climate change, desertification, crop destruction. | Farmers, Fulani herders, local vigilantes. |
| Ethno-Communal Conflicts | Tensions between different ethnic communities, often over land, chieftaincy, or political control. | Historical grievances, marginalization, competition for political power. | Various ethnic groups, local leaders, community militias. |
| Religious Conflicts | Occasional clashes between communities with differing religious beliefs. | Religious identity, political manipulation, social tensions. | Christians, Muslims, religious leaders, youth groups. |
| Youth / Gang-Related Violence | Violence involving unemployed or marginalized youths, sometimes recruited for local disputes or political thuggery. | Unemployment, poverty, political patronage, lack of social opportunities. | Youth gangs, vigilante groups, political party supporters. |
| Politically Motivated Conflicts | Violence during elections or local political contests, often overlapping with ethnic or communal disputes. | Political rivalry, manipulation of ethnic/religious identities, contest for power. | Political party supporters, local elites, security forces. |
| Resource / Land Disputes | Disputes over land ownership, water, and other resources, sometimes between communities or between individuals and groups. | Customary vs. formal land ownership, scarcity of fertile land, competition over water and grazing land. | Farmers, pastoralists, local authorities, landowners. |
| Cross-Border / Regional Conflicts | Conflicts influenced by neighboring states or countries, including cattle rustling, smuggling, and armed raids. | Porous borders, cross-border ethnic ties, smuggling, regional instability. | Local communities, herders, cross-border actors, security forces. |

Source: Authors' Research 2025.

What the table above shows is that the historical roots of conflict in Taraba State are deeply intertwined with the legacy of colonial administration, migration patterns, and the evolution of traditional institutions. Taraba, located at the confluence of the Middle Belt and Northeastern regions of Nigeria, has historically been a melting pot of ethnic groups including the Jukun, Tiv, Mumuye, Chamba, Kuteb, Ichen, and Hausa/Fulani, and numerous smaller communities. Tsuwa (2014) argued that all these groups migrated from various abodes to their present location. He insisted that, in precolonial days, they were mainly agrarian in nature and produced for sustenance and practiced trade by barter in a non-monetized economy, and intergroup relations were more mutual and respectful. With the colonial invasion of the area, the British indirect rule system reshaped local governance by privileging certain ethnic groups over others, particularly through the recognition of chiefs and the allocation of land. Colonial demarcations often ignored indigenous land tenure systems, imposing boundaries that disrupted communal ownership and traditional land-use practices. They introduced a tax system that was not only brutal but also alien to the people and formed stereotypes between the various groups.

These policies created structural inequalities that persisted long after independence, laying the groundwork for disputes over land, political representation, and traditional authority. The argument that state creation in the 1990s would solve the challenges failed. Tsuwa (2025) argued that state creation, instead of ameliorating intergroup hostility and conflict, through the artificiality of boundaries of the new state deepened the cry for marginalization as new majority and minority emerged with their power struggle. Yakubu (2020) therefore argued that, with this new power dynamics, communities such as the Tiv, Jukun, Fulani, and Mumuye coexist within a delicate social balance, yet competition over land, political offices, and economic resources frequently triggers clashes as groups perceive injustices, social marginalization, and local governance deficits.

Apart from the traditional groups that have over the years contested critical issues of interest in the area. New actors in the controversy have emerged with their various interests. The merging groups and their interests are captured in the table below;

| Emerging Actor | Core Interests |
|---|---|
| Pastoralist Groups | • Grazing routes & water<br>• Protect cattle<br>• Free movement<br>• Weapons inflow concerns |
| Traditional Rulers | • Chiefdom boundaries<br>• Land allocation<br>• Heritage protection<br>• Local governance influence |
| Political Elites | • Electoral mobilization<br>• Govt positions/resources<br>• Security & contracts<br>• Influence traditional institutions |
| Armed Groups | • Forest hideouts<br>• Extortion/rustling/kidnapping<br>• Community defense<br>• Territorial & illicit trade |

The realist perspective argues that conflict has a functional use. It wakes societies from slumber. It also stimulates growth and development. Evidence in Taraba State has shown that the arguments of this perspective are futile and a complete fallacy. Taraba State has faced developmental stagnation, which has challenged its overall peace process and peacebuilding

architecture. This menace is mainly attributed to the consequences of conflict, which have persisted in the state. The following are some of the negative impacts of conflict on the developmental process of the state.

**Social Impacts:** The social consequences of conflict are pervasive and often intergenerational. Communities affected by violence experience displacement, loss of social cohesion, and erosion of trust among ethnic and religious groups. It fractures relationships between neighboring communities, fostering mistrust and social polarization. Inter-ethnic marriages and cooperative ventures are often discouraged due to fear of reprisal or perceived betrayal.

**Economic Impacts:** Economic consequences of conflict in Taraba State are severe, particularly for agrarian communities whose livelihoods are directly affected. For instance, the invasion of farming communities by headers has destroyed crops, resulted in theft of livestock, and restricted grazing or farming areas, a condition that has reduced household incomes and food security. Respondents noted that repeated attacks on farmlands during peak agricultural seasons lead to crop losses and undermine seasonal harvests, creating chronic economic vulnerability.

**Political Impacts:** The political ramifications of conflict in Taraba State are equally significant. Conflicts often undermine governance, weaken local institutions, and exacerbate perceptions of marginalization. For instance, Tsuwa (2024) argued that the conflicts in Wukari and Takum usually happen or are heightened during voter registration and elections. This declines voter registration and voter turnout during elections, political meetings are canceled, local governance processes are disrupted, and accountability is reduced, thereby reinforcing the cycles of exclusion, which are critical drivers of conflict in the state.

**Psychological and Humanitarian Impacts:** The psychological toll of conflict is profound. Individuals exposed to violence experience trauma, anxiety, and fear, affecting mental health and community resilience. Focus group discussions revealed that both adults and children suffer from emotional distress, which manifests in behavioral changes, reduced productivity, and difficulty in social interactions. Women and children are particularly vulnerable, facing heightened risks of violence, displacement, disruption of education and access to health services, clean water, and basic social amenities.

**Reversing the Violent Tides: The Efforts so far**

It is worthy to note that, despite the persistence of conflict in Taraba State, there have been modest efforts towards peacebuilding in the state. Both state and non-state actors have made efforts towards building peace, which needs to be recognized. Recent efforts towards the establishment of the Taraba State Bureau for Peace and Conflict Management with a mandate to coordinate peace initiatives, mediate disputes, promote social harmony, and set up early-

warning and early-response systems to prevent escalation of conflicts is one of the efforts. On the part of government security architecture, both Kinetic and non-kinetic strategies have been adopted. For instance, the military (the 6 Brigade Nigerian Army / Operation Whirl Stroke) in June 2025 facilitated a dialogue and peace pact between the Tiv and Fulani communities in Gassol Local Government Area. The accord commits both sides to reject violence, not harbour criminal elements, and cooperate with security agencies for lasting peace. Similar peace-pact efforts have been applied in other LGAs affected by communal and farmer-herder violence.

There have also been efforts from Civil Society. Some of these include;

i. The Para Mallam Peace Foundation (with support from the UK Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office – FCDO): Through the Zamanlafiya project has worked in Wukari, Takum and Ussa LGAs.

ii. International Organization for Migration (IOM) and partner NGOs: Through the COMITAS I and II Project established Community Response Networks (CRNs), local peace committees, and structures for resource management (land, water, grazing routes), helping communities negotiate and manage shared resources instead of resorting to violence. The state government formally adopted the peace-building structures created by COMITAS, signalling local ownership and commitment to long-term peace. Vanguard News

iii. The GIZ (German Development Cooperation): Through the PeaceCORE Project, Strengthening Media capacity as a component of peacebuilding.

**Conclusion and Recommendations**

As I stated in the beginning, Taraba State is my dear state, a land blessed with natural and human resources for our prosperity. However, the resources have turned into a cause. I have clearly explained that the conflicts in Taraba State are multifaceted, arising from historical, socio-economic, environmental, political, and identity-based factors. Farmer-herder clashes, disputes over land, chieftaincy succession disagreements, and ethno-religious tensions are central manifestations of conflict, reflecting both immediate triggers and deep-seated structural inequalities. The consequences of these conflicts range from the destruction of social cohesion, economic productivity, political stability, psychological well-being, and cultural identity. Communities affected by violence experience displacement, loss of livelihoods, disrupted governance, trauma, and erosion of trust among ethnic and religious groups. Consequently, their resolution becomes a major task if we are to make any progress in the midst of plenty.

Efforts towards achieving a lasting peacebuilding mechanism must be multi-sectoral and multi-actoral. What this means is that, since the causality factors are multidimensional, a community-based multi-sectoral approach anchoring on the various actors with interest in the various conflicts must be developed. It must be an all-research approach where the analysis of the conflict will be collectively done to bring out their core issues and elements. It will be a whole-of-community engagement management approach that will combine dialogue, mediation, livelihood support, early-warning mechanisms, and culturally sensitive reconciliation, which is more sustainable than isolated interventions. When this collective system is adopted for implementation, it will enhance the creation and sustainability of Governance and Institutional Capacity at all levels; it will promote multi-Actor Collaboration towards supporting healing and strengthening Livelihoods and foster social cohesion and interfaith dialogue.

It is wont to conclude that the above measures will improve intergroup relations and confidence, a condition that will strengthen collective Early-Warning and Preventive Mechanisms and integrate peacebuilding into development Planning and ensure Sustainability and Monitoring.

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# XENOPHOBIC ATTACKS AND NIGERIAN-SOUTH AFRICAN INVESTMENT RELATIONS

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**Abstract.** This study examines xenophobic attacks and their implications for Nigerian-South African investment relations. Specifically, it analyzes the historical and structural factors responsible for xenophobic violence, assesses its effects on bilateral investment relations, and evaluates its impact on investment flows between the two countries. The study adopts a qualitative ex-post facto research design based on documentary evidence obtained from institutional reports, policy documents, academic publications, and other secondary sources. Data were analyzed using descriptive content analysis. Findings reveal that xenophobic attacks have negatively affected political, economic, and social relations between Nigeria and South Africa, undermining investor confidence, regional integration, and African unity. The study concludes that persistent violence against foreign nationals threatens sustainable economic cooperation and long-term prosperity in Africa. It recommends that both countries address the root causes of migration-related tensions, including unemployment and poverty, while strengthening human rights protections and creating conducive conditions for migrant workers and their families.

**Keywords:** xenophobia, xenophobic attacks, economic investment, sustainable economic cooperation, Nigeria-South Africa relations

## Introduction

Xenophobia has emerged as a major challenge to social stability, regional integration, and international relations across many parts of the world. In Africa, the phenomenon has increasingly manifested through hostility, discrimination, and violence against foreign nationals, particularly migrants and refugees. South Africa has experienced recurrent waves of xenophobic attacks directed at African migrants, including Nigerians, resulting in loss of life, destruction of businesses, and deterioration of diplomatic relations with affected countries. These attacks have generated significant political, economic, and social concerns within the African continent and have raised questions about the future of regional cooperation and African unity. The roots of xenophobia in South Africa can be traced to historical, economic, and socio-political factors. Although the end of apartheid in 1994

marked the beginning of democratic governance and racial inclusion, post-apartheid South Africa continued to face serious socio-economic challenges such as unemployment, poverty, inequality, and inadequate service delivery. These conditions contributed to widespread frustrations among citizens, with migrants often blamed for economic hardships and competition over jobs and resources. Consequently, xenophobic violence became a recurring feature of South African society, targeting foreign nationals and their businesses.

Nigeria and South Africa occupy strategic positions in Africa as two of the continent's largest economies and most influential regional powers. Both countries have historically played important roles in promoting African development, peacekeeping, regional diplomacy, and economic cooperation. Nigeria remains a major trading partner of South Africa, particularly through the export of crude oil and the presence of Nigerian investments and businesses within the South African economy. Likewise, South African companies maintain substantial investments in Nigeria across sectors such as telecommunications, retail, banking, and entertainment.

Despite these strong economic and diplomatic ties, repeated xenophobic attacks against Nigerians in South Africa have negatively affected bilateral relations between the two countries. The attacks have undermined investor confidence, disrupted commercial activities, and generated diplomatic tensions between both governments. In addition, they pose serious threats to regional integration, economic cooperation, and the broader objectives of African unity and sustainable development. Against this background, this study examines xenophobic attacks and Nigerian–South African investment relations. The study focuses on the historical and structural factors responsible for xenophobic violence, its impact on bilateral investment relations, and its implications for investment flows between both countries. The study further seeks to contribute to discussions on regional peace, economic cooperation, and the protection of migrant rights within Africa.

## Review of Related Literature

### Xenophobia and the Political Economy of Nigeria–South Africa Investment Relations: Diplomatic Strain, Economic Disruption, and Investor Confidence

Xenophobic attacks and Nigerian–South African investment relations reveal a consistent scholarly focus on the political, economic, and diplomatic consequences of xenophobia, particularly its implications for bilateral trade, foreign direct investment, and migrant security. Across the reviewed studies, there is broad agreement that xenophobic violence in South Africa has evolved into a structural challenge that periodically disrupts Nigeria–South Africa relations and weakens investor confidence. Early conceptual and analytical contributions frame xenophobia as a persistent socio-political phenomenon rooted in post-apartheid inequalities, unemployment, and competition over scarce resources. Adebisi (2017) argues that xenophobia represents a recurring "festering sore" in Nigerian–South African

relations, emphasizing its historical embeddedness and its capacity to undermine diplomatic goodwill. Similarly, the retrospective analysis by Fayomi, Chidozie, and Ayo (2015) highlights that recurrent xenophobic outbreaks have consistently strained bilateral relations and created cycles of diplomatic tension between both countries. These foundational works establish xenophobia not as isolated incidents but as a systemic challenge embedded within South Africa's socio-economic landscape.

Subsequent literature shifts attention toward the economic and investment implications of xenophobic violence. Bello and Tunde (2017) demonstrate that businesses and investments cannot thrive in environments characterized by instability and insecurity, noting that xenophobic attacks significantly erode investor confidence and disrupt commercial activities involving Nigerian nationals. In the same direction, Ijisakin and Fakanbi (2019) observe that Nigerian-owned enterprises in South Africa have suffered direct economic losses due to attacks on property and businesses, thereby reducing the attractiveness of South Africa as an investment destination for Nigerian capital. These findings are reinforced by Chibuzor et al. (2017), who argue that xenophobic violence leads to setbacks in bilateral economic relations, particularly by discouraging cross-border investments and weakening private-sector engagement.

More recent studies adopt a broader political economy perspective, linking xenophobia to structural instability in investment flows and diplomatic relations. Umaru and Audu (2022) contend that xenophobic incidents generate negative perceptions among foreign investors, thereby reducing the inflow of foreign direct investment and weakening Nigeria–South Africa economic cooperation. Similarly, Bonga (2021) demonstrates that repetitive xenophobic attacks contribute to declining investor confidence and long-term reductions in investment inflows into South Africa, with spillover effects on partner countries such as Nigeria. In a related argument, Onuoha, Ezeibe, and Onuoha (2025) highlight that xenophobic attacks have resulted in the destruction of Nigerian-owned businesses valued in millions of dollars, thereby deepening economic mistrust between both countries.

A significant strand of literature also emphasizes the human and diplomatic costs of xenophobia. Attah and Sule (2021) argue that the economic losses suffered by Nigerian migrants in South Africa cannot be separated from the broader diplomatic consequences, as such incidents weaken Nigeria–South Africa relations and undermine regional integration efforts. Ogunnoiki and Adeyemi (2019) further note that xenophobic violence disrupts the historical and strategic partnership between both countries, which are considered key economic actors in Africa. The study by Ijimakinwa and Oshinye (2025) similarly concludes that xenophobic attacks have far-reaching implications for continental diplomacy, particularly in relation to trade cooperation and investment flows. From a comparative and structural perspective, Oni and Okunade (2017) situate xenophobia within broader African socio-economic inequalities, arguing that competition over economic opportunities and resources fuels hostility toward migrants, including Nigerians in South Africa. This structural explanation is complemented by Antai (2026), who suggests that weak institutional

mechanisms and inadequate protection of foreign investors contribute to persistent investor apathy in South Africa. These studies collectively highlight that xenophobia is not only a social issue but also a governance and institutional failure with economic consequences.

Despite the depth of existing scholarship, a critical gap remains evident in the literature. Most studies focus on either the diplomatic consequences or the immediate economic losses caused by xenophobic attacks, with limited empirical integration of how these attacks systematically influence long-term investment behavior between Nigeria and South Africa. Additionally, there is insufficient localized analysis that connects xenophobic violence directly to specific investment sectors and Nigerian investor decision-making patterns. Few studies also examine how institutional responses in both countries either mitigate or exacerbate investment risks arising from xenophobic incidents. Furthermore, there is a lack of unified analytical frameworks that simultaneously capture the political, economic, and psychological dimensions of investor response to xenophobia. Therefore, while existing literature establishes a strong link between xenophobic violence and strained Nigeria–South Africa relations, it remains fragmented in explaining the precise mechanisms through which xenophobia reshapes investment flows, investor confidence, and bilateral economic cooperation. This study addresses this gap by systematically examining how xenophobic attacks influence Nigerian–South African investment relations, with particular attention to economic behavior, diplomatic responses, and investor risk perception.

**Theoretical framework**

The theoretical framework for this study is anchored on three complementary perspectives, namely the Liberal Institutional Theory, the Political Economy Theory, and the Push–Pull Migration and Investment Theory. These theories collectively provide a comprehensive explanation of how xenophobic attacks influence Nigeria–South Africa investment relations through political, economic, and behavioural dimensions, particularly within the context of institutional fragility, structural inequality, and shifting investment decisions.

The Liberal Institutional Theory, associated with scholars such as Robert Keohane and Joseph Nye (Keohane, 2012; Keohane & Martin, 1995), and further developed within broader liberal international relations scholarship (Moravcsik, 1997; Johnson & Heiss, 2023), assumes that international relations are shaped by institutions, interdependence, and cooperation rather than conflict alone. It argues that institutions reduce uncertainty, foster trust, and enable mutually beneficial cooperation among states and non-state actors (Ferguson, 2023). From this perspective, liberal institutionalism emphasizes that stable governance frameworks and effective regional institutions enhance economic cooperation and investment flows. In relation to this study, xenophobic attacks weaken institutional trust between Nigeria and South Africa, disrupt diplomatic engagement, and undermine the effectiveness of bilateral and regional mechanisms designed to promote trade and investment. As Keohane and Martin (1995) further argue, institutions matter because they shape state behaviour and reduce transaction costs, but when they are weakened by persistent violence and exclusionary

practices, investor confidence declines. Therefore, the recurrence of xenophobic violence reflects institutional failure and reduces the credibility of governance systems that are expected to protect foreign investors and migrant entrepreneurs.

The Political Economy Theory, grounded in the classical works of Karl Marx and Adam Smith and further advanced by neo-Marxist scholars such as Immanuel Wallerstein, explains that economic relations are deeply embedded in political and structural power dynamics. This perspective emphasizes that inequality, resource competition, and state policies shape economic outcomes and social relations. Within this framework, xenophobia is understood not merely as social hostility but as a manifestation of broader structural contradictions, including unemployment, poverty, and unequal access to economic opportunities. These conditions generate competition between locals and migrants, which often translates into violence against foreign nationals, including Nigerian investors and workers. The theory is applicable in this study because it explains how structural inequalities within South Africa's political economy contribute to xenophobic sentiments that disrupt investment relations and economic cooperation between both countries. It further highlights that such tensions are rooted in systemic socio-economic exclusion rather than isolated incidents of violence.

The Push-Pull Migration and Investment Theory, originally associated with Everett Lee, explains movement of people and capital based on attractive and repulsive forces between regions or countries. According to this perspective, push factors such as insecurity, discrimination, and political instability drive individuals and investors away from a country, while pull factors such as safety, economic opportunity, and stable governance attract them elsewhere. In the context of this study, xenophobic attacks function as strong push factors that discourage Nigerian migrants and investors from operating in South Africa, while relatively safer and more stable environments serve as alternative destinations for investment. This aligns with findings in migration and investment studies that emphasize how risk perception influences capital mobility and investor decision-making. Consequently, repeated xenophobic incidents contribute to declining investor confidence, capital flight, and the relocation of Nigerian investments to more secure environments.

**Methodology**

This study adopts a qualitative research design anchored on a single-case ex-post facto approach, relying primarily on documentary evidence. The ex-post facto design, also referred to as an "after-the-fact" or retrospective research design, is appropriate for studies in which the independent and dependent variables have already occurred and cannot be manipulated by the researcher. The design therefore focuses on explaining observed outcomes by tracing possible antecedent conditions using existing data sources. According to Kerlinger (1977), ex-post facto research is a form of descriptive inquiry in which the investigator begins with the observation of a dependent variable and then works backward to identify possible causal factors associated with it. In this sense, the researcher does not manipulate variables but instead examines relationships that have already occurred. Similarly, Asika (1991) describes

the ex-post facto or single-case design as a quasi-experimental approach in which an existing case is observed over time in order to assess patterns and infer relationships between variables. This implies that the design is particularly useful for studies that seek to understand social, political, or economic phenomena that are already in existence.

Cohen, Manion, and Morrison (2011) further explain that ex-post facto research involves investigating cause-and-effect relationships by examining existing conditions and retrospectively identifying plausible causal factors. In line with this perspective, the present study attempts to link observed outcomes in Nigeria–South Africa investment relations to the phenomenon of xenophobic attacks, without manipulating any of the variables involved. The design is therefore suitable for understanding complex socio-political relationships where experimental control is not feasible.

The study employs qualitative descriptive content analysis as its method of data analysis. Qualitative content analysis focuses on interpreting and making meaning of textual data by identifying patterns, themes, and relationships within documentary sources. Kerlinger (1973), as well as Seltiz et al. (1979) and Holton and Burnett (1997), emphasize that qualitative analysis is concerned with understanding the attributes, characteristics, and meanings embedded in social phenomena. In addition, Asika (1991) notes that data analysis involves the systematic organization and summarization of information to reveal relationships among variables.

In this study, qualitative content analysis is applied to secondary data sources, including academic journals, policy documents, institutional reports, and relevant publications on xenophobia and Nigeria–South Africa investment relations. The analysis involves careful reading, interpretation, critique, and synthesis of documentary evidence in order to identify recurring patterns and draw meaningful conclusions (Holsti, 1969; Fraser, 2004). This method is adopted because it allows for a systematic examination of documented evidence while maintaining the contextual depth required for qualitative inquiry. The choice of this analytical approach is informed by its ability to clearly interpret complex relationships embedded in textual data and to provide a coherent explanation of how xenophobic attacks influence investment relations between Nigeria and South Africa. It therefore enables the study to generate insights into the political, economic, and diplomatic dimensions of the phenomenon under investigation.

**Historical Evolution And Nature of Xenophobic Attacks in South Africa**

The historical evolution and nature of xenophobic attacks in South Africa can be understood as a deeply rooted and evolving socio-political phenomenon shaped by historical inequalities, migration patterns, and post-apartheid socio-economic conditions. Xenophobia in South Africa has been widely traced to a long historical background of exclusionary attitudes toward foreign nationals, particularly within the context of labour migration and colonial-era mobility systems. Osazuwa and Peter (2024) argue that xenophobia in South Africa is not a recent development but one with a lengthy historical trajectory that has evolved in both scope and intensity, manifesting in different forms of violence and social exclusion over time. This historical grounding suggests that contemporary xenophobic violence is an extension of earlier patterns of exclusion rather than an isolated post-apartheid occurrence.

The nature of xenophobia in South Africa is also shaped by competing interpretations of its root causes, particularly the tension between economic explanations and socio-political and psychological factors. Ejoke and Ani (2017) contend that reducing xenophobia solely to economic deprivation is inadequate, as it also involves deeper attitudinal, ideological, and identity-based dimensions that fuel hostility toward foreigners. This indicates that xenophobic violence is embedded in broader social perceptions of belonging and exclusion. Historical analyses further show that xenophobia must be situated within South Africa's broader migratory and labour history. Hagensen (2014) highlights that violent xenophobic attacks reflect the legacy of migrant labour systems and the persistent presence of foreign nationals within South African economic spaces, which have historically generated tensions over access to jobs and resources. This historical continuity demonstrates how structural inequalities contribute to recurring cycles of violence.

The post-apartheid period marks a significant escalation in the visibility and frequency of xenophobic violence. Tella (2016) notes that despite South Africa's democratic transition and infrastructural development, perceptions of foreign nationals as economic competitors have intensified, leading to periodic outbreaks of violence, particularly during periods of economic strain and political tension. This suggests that democratization did not eliminate exclusionary practices but, in some cases, reshaped them. Mutanda (2022) further explains that xenophobic violence in South Africa is often linked to narratives of economic threat and rising nationalism, where foreign nationals are perceived as competitors in an already strained socio-economic environment. This perception has contributed to the violent and recurring nature of xenophobic outbreaks, particularly in urban and peri-urban settlements.

Saleh (2015) adds that xenophobic violence is not only economic in nature but also psychological and socially constructed, involving prejudice and deeply embedded stereotypes about foreigners. This highlights the role of perception, identity formation, and social conditioning in sustaining xenophobic attitudes and actions. From a structural perspective, Kerr, Durrheim, and Dixon (2019) argue that xenophobic violence is embedded within broader processes of uneven development and contested political narratives in post-apartheid

South Africa. They suggest that historical struggles, socio-economic disparities, and unresolved inequalities continue to shape the dynamics of exclusion and violence against migrants.

Choane, Shulika, and Mthombeni (2011) further situate xenophobia within South Africa's historical racial past and contemporary development challenges, arguing that the persistence of xenophobic violence reflects unresolved tensions arising from inequality, unemployment, and social fragmentation. This reinforces the idea that xenophobia is both historically rooted and structurally sustained. Shoyisa and Ilesanmi (2021) emphasize that xenophobic attacks should be understood within a historical continuum, where intolerance toward foreigners has evolved alongside changing political and economic conditions. They argue that increasing social and economic pressures have intensified hostility toward migrants, making xenophobia a recurring feature of South African society. Finally, Hewitt, Masikane, and Toendepi (2020) highlight that xenophobia in South Africa exhibits unique characteristics, particularly its cyclical nature and its persistence despite state-led development efforts. They argue that leadership responses and policy interventions have often been reactive rather than preventive, allowing xenophobic sentiments to resurface periodically.

**Diplomatic Relations between Nigeria and South Africa within the Context of Xenophobic Tension**

Diplomatic relations between Nigeria and South Africa within the context of xenophobic tension have been widely examined in the literature as a complex interplay of cooperation, conflict, and periodic diplomatic strain. Scholars consistently argue that xenophobic violence in South Africa has become a recurring source of tension that periodically disrupts bilateral relations between both countries. Bello and Tunde (2017) observe that xenophobic violence carries significant implications for foreign relations, with the potential to escalate into broader regional instability if not properly managed. In their analysis, they stress that attacks on foreign nationals, particularly Nigerians, undermine diplomatic goodwill and weaken the cooperative frameworks that sustain Africa's two largest economies.

Building on this perspective, Chibuzor, Ajah, and Onyedikachi et al. (2017) situate xenophobia within the broader context of Nigeria's foreign policy and regional diplomatic engagement. They argue that Nigeria–South Africa relations are shaped by a delicate balance of conflict and cooperation, where xenophobic incidents frequently destabilize diplomatic trust. Their work highlights that both countries occupy strategic leadership positions in West and Southern Africa respectively, making their relationship central to continental integration efforts. However, recurring xenophobic violence complicates these aspirations by generating political friction and diplomatic protests. Similarly, Ogunnoiki and Adeyemi (2019) emphasize that Nigeria–South Africa relations are characterized by cycles of conflict, cooperation, and competition, with xenophobic attacks serving as key triggers of diplomatic crises. They note that while South Africa's post-apartheid reintegration into the international community strengthened formal diplomatic ties with Nigeria, incidents of xenophobia have

repeatedly threatened to reverse these gains. From this perspective, xenophobia is not merely a social issue but a diplomatic irritant that undermines long-standing efforts at regional solidarity and African unity.

Ibrahim, Dele, and Ukeaja (2019) further argue that xenophobic violence has contributed to a deterioration in Nigeria–South Africa diplomatic relations over time. Their retrospective analysis shows that repeated attacks on Nigerian nationals have resulted in heightened diplomatic tensions, including official condemnations, retaliatory rhetoric, and strained bilateral engagements. They also highlight that these tensions are often amplified by media coverage and public opinion, which place pressure on both governments to adopt more assertive diplomatic responses.

More recent studies expand the discussion by examining institutional and strategic responses to xenophobic tensions. Ochogwu, Luka, and Abdul (2025) note that despite ongoing diplomatic engagements aimed at strengthening bilateral ties, xenophobic incidents continue to pose challenges to sustained cooperation. Their findings suggest that diplomatic efforts between both countries increasingly rely on conflict management mechanisms designed to prevent escalation and preserve economic and political relations. In a related argument, Ogunnubi and Aja (2022) introduce the concept of citizen diplomacy, emphasizing that non-state actors, including migrants and civil society groups, play a critical role in mediating tensions and maintaining informal diplomatic channels between Nigeria and South Africa.

From a broader continental perspective, Martin (2025) highlights that xenophobia not only affects bilateral relations but also challenges regional frameworks such as the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), which depend on stable diplomatic relations for effective implementation. The persistence of xenophobic hostility therefore threatens broader African integration goals by weakening trust between member states and discouraging cross-border cooperation. Similarly, Awosusi and Fatoyinbo (2019) argue that cultural diplomacy represents a potential tool for mitigating xenophobic tensions and rebuilding fractured inter-African relations, particularly through the revival of historical diplomatic ties and shared African identity. Oni and Okunade (2017) provide an additional structural explanation by situating xenophobia within broader political economy dynamics in Africa. They argue that tensions arising from migration, economic inequality, and competition over resources contribute to strained diplomatic relations between countries such as Nigeria and South Africa. These underlying structural pressures often manifest in periodic xenophobic violence, which in turn destabilizes diplomatic engagement at the state level.

**Economic Impact of Xenophobic Attacks on Nigerian Investments in South Africa**

The economic impact of xenophobic attacks on Nigerian investments in South Africa has been widely documented in the literature as a significant constraint on bilateral economic relations, investor confidence, and cross-border commercial sustainability. Scholars

consistently argue that xenophobic violence creates a hostile investment climate that discourages Nigerian entrepreneurs, disrupts business operations, and generates long-term uncertainty in South Africa's economic environment. Attah and Sule (2021) emphasize that xenophobic attacks impose both direct and indirect economic costs on Nigerian investors in South Africa. Directly, these attacks result in the destruction of businesses, loss of property, and disruption of commercial activities owned by Nigerians. Indirectly, they generate fear, insecurity, and reduced willingness to expand or reinvest capital. The authors further note that these economic losses extend beyond individual victims to affect broader Nigeria–South Africa economic relations, as retaliatory sentiments and diplomatic tensions sometimes influence trade and investment decisions between both countries.

Similarly, Adilieje, Ugbor-Kalu, and Ude (2023) argue that xenophobia, combined with elements of economic nationalism in South Africa, has negatively affected Nigerian investment participation in the country. They highlight those Nigerian investors, particularly in retail, hospitality, and informal trade sectors, face recurring risks of targeted attacks, looting, and discrimination. These conditions reduce profitability and increase operational risks, thereby discouraging both existing and potential investors from maintaining or expanding their businesses in South Africa.

Onuoha, Ezeibe, and Onuoha (2025) further demonstrate that xenophobic violence has serious implications for investment relations between Nigeria and South Africa. Their findings reveal that repeated attacks on foreign-owned businesses, including Nigerian enterprises, undermine economic integration efforts and weaken trust in South Africa's investment climate. They argue that such violence represents not only a social problem but also a structural barrier to sustainable economic cooperation between both countries. Bonga (2021) reinforces this position by showing that repetitive xenophobic attacks contribute to declining foreign direct investment inflows in South Africa. According to the study, investor confidence is highly sensitive to perceptions of instability and insecurity, and xenophobic incidents send negative signals to international investors, including Nigerians. Over time, this leads to capital flight, reduced reinvestment, and weakened long-term economic engagement. Bello and Tunde (2017) add that xenophobic violence creates an unstable business environment in which investments cannot thrive. They argue that the socio-economic disruptions caused by xenophobia have led to a "cold war" atmosphere in Nigeria–South Africa economic relations, where uncertainty and mistrust dominate investment decisions. This environment negatively affects trade relations and discourages sustainable private-sector collaboration between both countries. Ijisakin and Fakanbi (2019) also observe that Nigerian investors in South Africa are often reluctant to expand operations due to fears of renewed xenophobic violence. They note that the destruction of Nigerian-owned businesses during periods of unrest demonstrates the vulnerability of foreign investments in South Africa, thereby weakening investor confidence and reducing the attractiveness of the country as a stable investment destination.

Akinyemi (2025) further situates the economic impact of xenophobia within broader historical and racial dynamics, arguing that structural inequalities and exclusionary economic practices contribute to the vulnerability of Nigerian investments. The study highlights that despite the contributions of Nigerian businesses to South Africa's economy, they remain exposed to periodic violence, which undermines the principles of fair and inclusive economic participation. Ogunnoiki and Adeyemi (2019) add that xenophobic attacks have broader implications for Nigeria–South Africa economic relations, particularly by disrupting trade flows and weakening Africa's two largest economies' leadership roles. They argue that persistent violence against Nigerian investors damages the reputation of South Africa as a regional economic hub and undermines efforts toward continental economic integration.

Ibrahim, Dele, and Ukeaja (2019) further stress that xenophobic violence has historically led to economic sanctions and retaliatory measures, contributing to fluctuations in bilateral economic engagement. Such responses often intensify economic uncertainty and reinforce cycles of mistrust between both countries. Akerele and Adebayo (2021) highlight the human dimension of the economic impact by examining Nigerian returnees from South Africa. They show that many victims of xenophobic violence not only suffer economic losses but are also forced to abandon businesses and return to Nigeria, resulting in capital destruction, unemployment, and disrupted livelihoods. This illustrates how xenophobia produces both immediate economic losses and long-term developmental setbacks for Nigerian investors.

**Investor Confidence and Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) Flows between Nigeria and South Africa.**

Investor confidence and foreign direct investment (FDI) flows between Nigeria and South Africa have been widely analysed in the literature as being shaped by macroeconomic stability, institutional quality, political risk, and perceptions of security within host countries. Across scholarly works, there is a consistent argument that investor confidence is a critical determinant of FDI flows, particularly in emerging African economies where political and social instability can significantly alter investment decisions. Edwin (2014) notes that FDI flows to Africa, including Nigeria and South Africa, are highly sensitive to global economic conditions, but also depend heavily on investor perceptions of domestic stability and policy consistency. The study highlights that although Africa continues to attract global investment interest, fluctuations in confidence, driven by economic uncertainty or instability, often determine the scale and sustainability of inflows. South Africa, in particular, benefits from relatively stronger institutional structures, yet remains vulnerable to shifts in investor sentiment during periods of socio-political tension.

Similarly, Onyeiwu and Shrestha (2004) argue that investor confidence is closely linked to conventional determinants of FDI such as market size, openness, and macroeconomic performance. Their findings show that foreign investors are more likely to commit capital to economies perceived as stable and predictable, with South Africa often emerging as a preferred destination compared to other African economies. However, they caution that this

advantage can be undermined when perceptions of risk increase due to internal instability or external shocks.

Anyanwu (2011) further explains that FDI inflows to Africa are influenced by agglomeration effects, where previous investment patterns encourage further inflows by reinforcing investor confidence. In this regard, Nigeria and South Africa are identified as key investment hubs. Nevertheless, Anyanwu emphasizes that these flows remain highly sensitive to changes in perceived risk, meaning that political instability, insecurity, or weak governance can quickly disrupt established investment patterns. Anyanwu and Yaméogo (2015) reinforce this view by identifying South Africa and Nigeria among the top FDI destinations in Africa, while also noting regional disparities in investment attractiveness. Their study shows that sustained investor confidence is dependent on consistent policy frameworks, macroeconomic reforms, and reduced exposure to risk factors that could discourage long-term investment commitments.

Focusing on Nigeria, Ojong, Arikpo, and Ogar (2015) observe that investor confidence plays a decisive role in determining FDI inflows. Their findings indicate that when investor confidence is high, driven by stable economic conditions and institutional reforms, FDI inflows increase significantly. Conversely, insecurity and weak governance structures erode confidence and lead to reduced foreign investment. In a comparative perspective, Ogunkola and Jerome (2006) highlight that Nigeria has historically attracted lower levels of FDI compared to South Africa, largely due to weaker investor confidence. They argue that South Africa's relatively stable institutional environment and stronger economic infrastructure have made it more attractive to foreign investors, while Nigeria continues to face challenges that discourage sustained investment inflows. Meyer and Habanabakize (2018) further demonstrate the sensitivity of FDI flows to investor confidence in South Africa, noting that political risk and perceived instability can lead to reduced inflows and slower economic growth. Their study underscores

**State Responses, Policy Frameworks, and Institutional Mechanisms for Managing Xenophobia**

State responses, policy frameworks, and institutional mechanisms for managing xenophobia have been widely examined in the literature as essential instruments for mitigating violence, protecting migrants, and stabilizing inter-state relations. Across studies, there is general agreement that xenophobia is not only a social phenomenon but also a governance challenge that requires coordinated legal, institutional, and policy interventions at national and regional levels.

Misago, Freemantle, and Landau (2015) argue that effective state response to xenophobic violence depends on the existence of a coordinated institutional framework that integrates policing, early warning systems, and community-level engagement. They note that failures in

the South African Police Service (SAPS) response mechanisms have often contributed to delayed interventions during outbreaks of xenophobic attacks, thereby worsening the human and economic consequences. Their analysis further suggests that fragmented institutional coordination weakens the overall capacity of the state to prevent recurring violence. In a broader structural sense, Samari, Nagle, and Coleman-Minahan (2021) conceptualize xenophobia as a form of "structural policy environment" shaped by immigration laws and state-level governance frameworks. Their Immigration Policy Climate index demonstrates that restrictive policy regimes tend to reinforce exclusionary attitudes, thereby institutionalizing xenophobia within governance systems. This suggests that xenophobia is not only reactive violence but can also be embedded within formal policy structures that shape migrant experiences.

Similarly, Nyam, Kunguma, and Selelo (2026), using a systems thinking approach, emphasize that xenophobia must be addressed through integrated policy frameworks that combine social, economic, cultural, and institutional responses. Their DPSIR (Drivers-Pressures-State-Impact-Response) model highlights the importance of coordinated institutional mechanisms that go beyond reactive policing to include prevention, governance reform, and community resilience strategies.

Hewitt, Masikane, and Toendepi (2020) further stress that leadership response is central to managing xenophobia, arguing that weak or inconsistent political leadership contributes to the persistence of xenophobic tensions in South Africa. They contend that effective governance requires proactive communication, institutional accountability, and long-term development strategies that address underlying socio-economic grievances. Oyelana (2024) expands the discussion by examining the roles of governments, international organizations, and non-governmental actors in addressing xenophobia. The study highlights that institutional framework at national and continental levels, including African Union mechanisms, provide normative guidelines for managing migration-related tensions, but implementation gaps often limit their effectiveness. This underscores the need for stronger policy enforcement and inter-agency coordination.

Adjai and Lazaridis (2014) similarly argue that post-apartheid South Africa has developed legal and constitutional frameworks aimed at protecting immigrants, but institutional weaknesses and inconsistent enforcement have undermined their effectiveness. They emphasize the importance of civic engagement mechanisms and monitoring institutions to ensure compliance with anti-xenophobia policies. From a governance and policy enforcement perspective, Achiume (2018) conceptualizes xenophobia as a governance issue that requires systemic policy intervention, particularly in regulating state practices that may indirectly produce exclusionary outcomes. In a related argument, Gliszczynska-Grabias and Klaus (2018) highlight how "governmental xenophobia" can emerge through restrictive immigration and security policies that institutionalize exclusion rather than prevent it.

Collectively, the literature suggests that while policy frameworks and institutional mechanisms exist at national, regional, and international levels, their effectiveness is often constrained by weak implementation, limited coordination, and inadequate political commitment. Consequently, managing xenophobia requires not only legal frameworks but also strengthened institutional capacity, consistent leadership response, and integrated governance systems that address both structural causes and immediate triggers of xenophobic violence.

**Findings**

The first major finding is that xenophobic attacks in South Africa are historically rooted, structurally sustained, and continuously evolving rather than being isolated or recent occurrences. The discussion shows that xenophobia is embedded in South Africa's historical trajectory of labour migration, colonial exclusion, and post-apartheid socio-economic inequalities. Scholars consistently demonstrate that contemporary xenophobic violence reflects a continuation of earlier exclusionary systems rather than a break from the past (Osazuwa & Peter, 2024; Hagensen, 2014). This finding highlights that xenophobia is reinforced by long-standing structural conditions such as unemployment, inequality, and uneven development, which perpetuate cycles of violence against foreign nationals.

The second major finding is that xenophobic violence significantly destabilizes Nigeria–South Africa diplomatic relations by generating recurring cycles of conflict, mistrust, and diplomatic tension despite broader cooperation. The discussion reveals that while both countries maintain strategic economic and political ties, xenophobic incidents repeatedly undermine diplomatic goodwill and trigger protests, retaliatory rhetoric, and strained engagements between governments (Bello & Tunde, 2017; Ibrahim, Dele, & Ukeaja, 2019). It further shows that xenophobia functions as a diplomatic irritant within an otherwise cooperative but fragile relationship, affecting regional leadership roles and continental integration efforts such as AfCFTA (Martin, 2025). This indicates that xenophobia is not only a domestic issue in South Africa but also a recurring obstacle to stable bilateral and regional diplomacy.

The third major finding is that xenophobic attacks have a direct and indirect negative impact on Nigerian investments and broader foreign direct investment flows by weakening investor confidence and increasing economic risk perception. The discussion demonstrates that Nigerian-owned businesses in South Africa suffer property destruction, operational disruptions, and reduced profitability due to recurring violence, leading to capital loss and withdrawal of investments (Attah & Sule, 2021; Adilieje, Ugbor-Kalu, & Ude, 2023). It further shows that repeated xenophobic incidents create an unstable investment climate that discourages reinvestment and reduces FDI inflows into South Africa (Bonga, 2021). This finding underscores that xenophobia operates as an economic risk factor that undermines bilateral investment relations and long-term economic integration between Nigeria and South Africa.

**Discussion of the Findings**

The first finding, that xenophobic attacks in South Africa are historically rooted, structurally sustained, and continuously evolving, can be effectively explained through the Political Economy Theory, the Liberal Institutional Theory, and the Push–Pull Migration and Investment Theory.

From the standpoint of Political Economy Theory, this finding reflects the idea that xenophobia is embedded in deep structural contradictions within South Africa's socio-economic system. The persistence of unemployment, inequality, and unequal access to economic resources creates conditions of competition between locals and foreign nationals. As Marxist and neo-Marxist perspectives argue, violence often emerges where material scarcity intersects with unequal power relations. In this sense, xenophobic attacks are not random social eruptions but expressions of systemic economic exclusion that have been historically reproduced from the colonial and apartheid eras into the post-apartheid political economy. The finding therefore supports the political economy argument that xenophobia is structurally produced through enduring inequalities rather than being a temporary or emotional reaction to migration pressures.

The Liberal Institutional Theory further deepens this explanation by highlighting the weakness or failure of institutional frameworks in preventing the recurrence of xenophobic violence. Keohane and Nye's institutionalist perspective emphasizes that strong institutions reduce uncertainty, regulate behaviour, and sustain cooperation among actors. However, the persistence of xenophobia suggests that domestic and regional institutions in South Africa have been insufficient in regulating social tensions and protecting foreign nationals. The historical continuity of violence indicates weak enforcement of protective frameworks and limited institutional capacity to address grievances before they escalate. In this regard, xenophobia reflects not only structural inequality but also institutional fragility, where governance systems fail to mitigate long-standing social tensions, thereby undermining trust in both domestic and bilateral Nigeria–South Africa relations.

The Push-Pull Migration and Investment Theory also provides a behavioural explanation for the historical persistence of xenophobic violence. In this framework, South Africa's economic opportunities act as a strong pull factor for migrants and investors, including Nigerians, while unemployment, insecurity, and social hostility operate as push factors that generate tension between locals and foreigners. The continued inflow of migrants into a constrained economic environment intensifies competition for jobs and resources, reinforcing xenophobic sentiments over time. Thus, the historical evolution of xenophobia can be interpreted as the outcome of sustained migration pressures interacting with limited economic absorption capacity, which continuously reproduces cycles of exclusion and violence.

The second finding, that xenophobic violence destabilizes Nigeria–South Africa diplomatic relations, can be understood through the Liberal Institutional Theory. This theory emphasizes that international cooperation is sustained through institutions that manage expectations, reduce conflict, and facilitate peaceful engagement. Xenophobic attacks weaken these institutional mechanisms by generating diplomatic crises, reducing trust, and disrupting established channels of cooperation between both states. As Keohane (2012) argues, institutions are essential for maintaining order in interdependent relationships; however, repeated xenophobic incidents undermine the credibility of these institutions and strain diplomatic communication. This explains why xenophobia repeatedly triggers diplomatic protests, retaliatory rhetoric, and cyclical tensions despite broader cooperation in trade and regional leadership.

From a Political Economy perspective, diplomatic tensions also reflect underlying struggles over economic power, migration governance, and regional influence. Nigeria and South Africa, as Africa's two largest economies, compete and cooperate simultaneously within a regional political economy shaped by inequality and uneven development. Xenophobic violence, therefore, becomes a manifestation of broader structural tensions that spill over into diplomatic relations. The Push–Pull framework further complements this by showing that migration flows, driven by economic attraction to South Africa, create social pressure that escalates into political conflict when not effectively managed, thereby destabilizing interstate relations.

The third finding, that xenophobic attacks negatively impact Nigerian investments and FDI flows, aligns strongly with all three theoretical perspectives, particularly the Push-Pull Investment Theory and Liberal Institutional Theory. From the Push-Pull perspective, xenophobic violence functions as a powerful push factor that discourages investment in South Africa. Nigerian investors, faced with insecurity, discrimination, and recurring violence, are pushed to withdraw capital or avoid expansion, while safer and more stable environments become more attractive investment destinations. This directly explains declining investor confidence and capital relocation patterns identified in the literature.

The Liberal Institutional Theory further explains that investment flows depend on predictable institutional environments that guarantee security, property rights, and rule-based governance. Xenophobic attacks signal institutional weakness and governance failure, thereby increasing perceived risk and reducing investor confidence. As institutions are expected to stabilize expectations and lower transaction costs, their inability to prevent violence undermines economic cooperation between Nigeria and South Africa.

Finally, the Political Economy Theory situates the investment decline within broader structural inequalities and economic nationalism in South Africa. Nigerian investors often operate in sectors characterized by informal competition and economic marginalization, making them vulnerable to exclusionary practices and violent backlash. This structural environment discourages long-term investment, reduces profitability, and reinforces unequal

participation in the South African economy. In combination, the three theories demonstrate that xenophobic violence is simultaneously a structural, institutional, and behavioural phenomenon with far-reaching diplomatic and economic consequences.

## Conclusion

The study demonstrates that xenophobic violence in South Africa is not an isolated social phenomenon but a deeply embedded outcome of structural inequality, institutional weakness, and sustained migration pressures. Through the lens of Political Economy Theory, Liberal Institutional Theory, and the Push–Pull Migration and Investment Theory, xenophobia is shown to emerge from long-standing socio-economic contradictions, weak governance structures, and persistent competition generated by migration flows into constrained economic spaces. These intersecting dynamics explain its historical continuity, cyclical nature, and resilience despite policy interventions. Furthermore, the analysis establishes that xenophobic violence extends beyond domestic social relations to significantly disrupt Nigeria–South Africa diplomatic relations and weaken bilateral cooperation. It undermines institutional trust, triggers diplomatic tensions, and complicates regional integration efforts, while simultaneously reducing investor confidence and discouraging foreign direct investment. Overall, the findings underscore that addressing xenophobia requires not only reactive security measures but also structural reforms, stronger institutional frameworks, and coordinated economic and diplomatic strategies that jointly mitigate inequality, enhance governance, and stabilize inter-state relations.

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# COUNTER-TERRORISM STRATEGIES OF THE NIGERIAN MILITARY AND SOCIO-ECONOMIC CONDITIONS OF CIVILIANS IN THE NORTH-EAST, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** The persistent threat of terrorism, particularly the Boko Haram and ISWAP insurgency, has profoundly destabilized Nigeria's national security, socio-economic development, and regional integration. In response, the Nigerian military has implemented diverse counter-terrorism strategies, ranging from kinetic military operations to regional collaborations such as the Multinational Joint Task Force (MNJTF). This study critically examined these counter-terrorism strategies, evaluating their operational effectiveness, inherent challenges, and socio-economic implications for civilian populations in the North-East region of Nigeria. Adopting a qualitative research approach, the study utilizes extensive content analysis of military records, policy documents, academic literature, and security reports, alongside insights from counterinsurgency theory as its analytical framework. The findings revealed that while military interventions have curtailed insurgent territorial control and disrupted terrorist networks, several systemic challenges persist, including inadequate intelligence sharing, poor inter-agency coordination, corruption, human rights violations, and limited community engagement. More critically, the study highlights how military operations, though aimed at restoring security, have inadvertently aggravated socio-economic conditions leading to mass displacement, destruction of livelihoods, infrastructural decay, and erosion of civilian trust. The research underscores the necessity of integrating socio-economic development initiatives, youth empowerment programs, and community-based strategies with military operations to achieve lasting peace. It recommends a holistic, multidimensional counter-terrorism approach that combines security measures with socio-economic interventions aimed at addressing the root causes of terrorism, particularly poverty, unemployment, and political marginalization.

**Keywords:** Counter-Terrorism, Nigerian Military, Socio-Economic Conditions, Boko Haram, ISWAP, North-East Nigeria

## Introduction

Terrorism remains one of the most significant global security threats in the 21st century, posing complex challenges to national and international stability. Across various regions, extremist groups continue to exploit ideological, socio-political, and economic grievances to foster violence and insecurity. In Africa, and particularly in Nigeria, terrorism has evolved into a persistent menace that endangers lives and destabilizes socio-economic development. The North-East region of Nigeria remains the epicenter of this crisis due to the activities of Boko Haram and the Islamic State West Africa Province (ISWAP). These groups have orchestrated violent campaigns resulting in mass casualties, destruction of property, displacement of millions, and severe socio-economic decline (Comolli, 2020; Thurston, 2021).

The emergence of Boko Haram in 2002 marked a turning point in Nigeria's security landscape. Initially a religious movement advocating strict Sharia law and opposing Western education, Boko Haram escalated into a violent insurgency by 2009 following the extrajudicial killing of its leader, Mohammed Yusuf. The group became notorious for suicide bombings, mass abductions, and attacks on military and civilian targets. Over the years, its operations have devastated local economies, forced school closures, disrupted agriculture, and triggered a humanitarian crisis in Borno, Yobe, and Adamawa states (Pérouse de Montclos, 2018; Warner & Matfess, 2018).

The rise of ISWAP in 2015 further complicated Nigeria's counter-terrorism efforts. As an offshoot of Boko Haram aligned with ISIS, ISWAP introduced a more structured and ideologically coherent insurgency. Unlike Boko Haram's indiscriminate violence, ISWAP strategically targeted military installations and state infrastructure while providing limited governance to local communities, thereby consolidating territorial control (Zenn, 2020; Onuoha & Oyewole, 2021).

In response, the Nigerian government intensified military-led counter-terrorism operations. Despite substantial resource allocation, terrorism persists in the North-East, raising concerns about the effectiveness of these strategies and their socio-economic impact on civilians (Mustapha, 2022; Ezeoba, 2023). One of the earliest counter-terrorism measures was the Joint Task Force (JTF) in 2011, comprising Army, Navy, Air Force, and Police personnel. The JTF adopted a "clear and hold" strategy to reclaim insurgent-held territories and gather intelligence (Alao, 2018). However, operational challenges such as inadequate funding, poor logistics, and corruption undermined its effectiveness (Okoli & Ugwu, 2019).

The Nigerian military later expanded its approach, establishing specialized units, increasing aerial bombardments, and collaborating with regional forces through the Multinational Joint Task Force (MNJTF). The MNJTF, involving Nigeria, Chad, Niger, and Cameroon, disrupted insurgent supply chains and recaptured territories (Onapajo, 2020). Despite gains, persistent

challenges such as weak coordination and inconsistent commitment among member states limited long-term success (Audu, 2021). The socio-economic conditions in the North-East have worsened due to prolonged conflict. Millions remain displaced, with many living in precarious Internally Displaced Persons (IDP) camps. Critical infrastructure schools, markets, health centers has been destroyed, crippling economic activities and access to essential services (Nwankpa, 2022). Reports indicate that military operations have sometimes exacerbated civilian suffering through human rights violations, eroding community trust and hindering intelligence-gathering (Amnesty International, 2020; HRW, 2021).

Root causes of terrorism poverty, unemployment, political marginalization, and lack of education remain unaddressed. The absence of socio-economic interventions alongside military action has perpetuated a cycle where disenfranchised youth are vulnerable to recruitment (Matfess, 2022; Aghedo, 2023). The lack of post-conflict reconstruction and community-based rehabilitation programs has left the region in sustained insecurity (Nwosu & Okafor, 2023). Internal military challenges outdated equipment, poor intelligence, corruption, and misallocated funds have further hindered progress (Ezeoba, 2023). While Nigeria has sought international support (AU, UN, and foreign partners), delays, inconsistent intelligence-sharing, and reactive (rather than proactive) engagement have limited impact (Onuoha, 2022).

In light of these challenges, there is growing recognition of the need for a more holistic approach to counter-terrorism in Nigeria. A purely militaristic response has proven insufficient in tackling the deep-rooted socio-economic factors fueling insurgency. This study therefore, interrogate the counter-terrorism strategies of the Nigerian Military and socioeconomic conditions of civilian in the North-East Nigeria.

**Statement of the Problem**

Extant literature abounds on the Nigerian military's counter-terrorism campaigns against Boko Haram and ISWAP in the North-East. Numerous scholars have examined the evolution of military doctrine (Omeni, 2024), the effectiveness of joint operations such as Operation Lafiya Dole and Hadin Kai (Onuoha & Tchie, 2023), and the regional role of the Multinational Joint Task Force (Okoko, Peter & Ekpo, 2024). Human-rights groups have likewise chronicled patterns of abuses during these operations (Amnesty International, 2024). However, most of these studies foreground tactical or legal assessments while giving limited systematic attention to how successive counter-terrorism strategies have altered the socio-economic conditions of civilians particularly their livelihoods, access to basic services and long-term development prospects. Even those that do engage socio-economic issues typically analyse a single state (often Borno) or focus narrowly on displacement and humanitarian relief, leaving wider impacts on employment, markets, agriculture and education under-explored. This study therefore seeks to fill this lacuna by interrogating the interface between military strategy and civilian socio-economic well-being across the entire North-East.

The urgency of this enquiry is underscored by a series of illustrative cases. During the 2016-17 Operation Crackdown offensive in Borno, the closure of Maiduguri's Monday Market for security sweeps disrupted the income of over 25 000 petty traders, many of whom never fully recovered their capital. In January 2017 a mis-targeted Nigerian Air Force strike on the Rann IDP camp killed more than 140 civilians and destroyed food-distribution points, deepening food insecurity for 43 000 camp residents. Similarly, the 2020 Auno checkpoint incident when stranded travellers were attacked after a curfew enforcement highlighted the fragile balance between protective curfews and civilian economic mobility. Repeated "return-and-resettle" directives, such as the 2023 repatriation of IDPs to Marte and Kukawa LGAs, have compelled households to leave relatively secure camps for communities lacking functioning schools, healthcare or markets. Meanwhile, UNDP's 2023 Stabilisation Facility report notes that poverty in the region has risen to 72 percent despite declared territorial victories, and Transparency International (2025) links stalled recovery projects to defence-sector corruption and resource diversion. These disjunctures between battlefield gains and everyday civilian welfare raise critical questions: How have specific military strategies clear-and-hold sweeps, aerial bombardments, civilian JTF partnerships and curfew regimes reshaped employment, agriculture, trade and social services? To what extent do security operations mitigate or exacerbate structural drivers of fragility such as poverty, youth unemployment and infrastructural decay? In probing these issues, the present study aims to illuminate the socio-economic consequences of counter-terrorism in the North-East and to inform more holistic, people-centred security policies for Nigeria.

**Objectives of the Study**

The broad objective of this study is to critically evaluate the counter-terrorism strategies of the Nigerian military and examine their impact on the socio-economic conditions of civilians in the North-East region of Nigeria. while the specific Objectives are:

1. To examine the counter-terrorism strategies of the Nigerian military in the war against terrorism in the North-East.

2. To assess the impact of military strategies and operations on the socio-economic conditions of civilians in the North-East region of Nigeria.

**Research Questions**

The following questions are couched to guide the study. They are as follows:

i. What counter-terrorism strategies has the Nigerian military adopted in the war against terrorism in the North-East?

ii. How have the military strategies and operations impacted the socio-economic conditions of civilians in the North-East region of Nigeria?

## Conceptual Clarification

### Concept of Terrorism

The definitional quandary of terrorism persists as a central challenge in international security, with the core issue of "labeling" remaining politically potent and analytically problematic. The subjective application of the term, often summarized by the phrase "one man's terrorist is another man's freedom fighter," continues to hinder universal legal and policy consensus. This is not a mere academic debate; it directly impacts everything from international sanctions and military interventions to humanitarian aid and asylum claims. Recent scholarship reinforces that the power to designate an entity as a "terrorist organization" is a profoundly political act, often wielded by states to delegitimize adversaries while shielding allied or state-sponsored violence from similar scrutiny (Gentry & Eckert, 2019). This "politics of labelling" means that objective criteria are frequently secondary to geopolitical interests, preventing a comprehensive United Nations treaty and allowing divergent national definitions to prevail, which in turn complicates global counter-terrorism cooperation (Cronin, 2020).

In response to this ambiguity, contemporary conceptual frameworks have sought to refine the definition by focusing on the method, intent, and targets of the violence, rather than the identity or cause of the perpetrator. There is a growing consensus that terrorism is distinct from other forms of political violence by its deliberate targeting of non-combatants and civilians, with the primary objective of disseminating fear and terror throughout a wider society to achieve political, ideological, or religious coercion (English, 2021). Modern definitions also increasingly account for the evolving nature of the threat, including the rise of lone-actor terrorism and the use of cyber-terrorism to disrupt critical infrastructure. The United Nations, while lacking a single convention definition, has moved towards a descriptive approach that underscores these elements, particularly the intentionality of causing death or serious harm to civilians and non-combatants to intimidate a population or compel a government or international organization (UN Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy, 2021). Furthermore, scholars like Richards (2023) argue that understanding terrorism requires analyzing it as a communicative act of violence, where the psychological impact on a watching audience is the primary strategic goal, distinguishing it from mere brutality or conventional warfare.

### Concept of Counter-Terrorism

The concept of counter-terrorism has undergone a significant paradigm shift, moving from a predominantly kinetic, state-centric model towards a more holistic, multi-faceted, and

globally integrated approach. The traditional "war on terror" framework, characterized by military-centric interventions and an enemy-focused approach, has been widely critiqued for its strategic limitations, including its potential to cause civilian casualties, fuel grievances, and prove ineffective against decentralized, globalized terrorist networks (Niva, 2021). The contemporary understanding, shaped by lessons from conflicts in Iraq, Afghanistan, and Syria, emphasizes that while military and intelligence operations are necessary to disrupt immediate threats, they are insufficient for achieving long-term security. This has led to the mainstreaming of "whole-of-government" and "whole-of-society" approaches that integrate security measures with efforts to address the root causes of radicalization (Cockayne & Lupel, 2021).

This evolved paradigm places a strong emphasis on Preventing and Countering Violent Extremism (P/CVE), which comprises the "soft" power components of counter-terrorism. P/CVE strategies focus on countering terrorist narratives online, promoting inclusive governance and economic development, strengthening community resilience, and developing rehabilitation and reintegration programs for former extremists (UNDP, 2023). The recognition that terrorism is a "process" rather than a single event has made disrupting radicalization pathways a top priority. Moreover, the cross-border nature of modern terrorist threats, exemplified by groups like ISIS and Al-Qaeda, has necessitated unprecedented levels of international intelligence-sharing, law enforcement collaboration, and financial sanctions coordination through bodies like the Financial Action Task Force (FATF) (Cronin, 2020). Consequently, effective counter-terrorism is now conceptualized as a dynamic and adaptive ecosystem that balances proactive prevention (P/CVE) with reactive disruption (law enforcement, military action), all while navigating complex ethical and human rights considerations to avoid undermining the very values it seeks to protect.

**Concept of the Military**

The traditional concept of the military as a state's instrument for waging conventional war against other nation-states has been profoundly complicated by the security realities of the 21st century. While territorial defense and deterrence against peer adversaries remain core functions, modern armed forces are increasingly configured for a much wider spectrum of conflict. This includes persistent engagement in counter-insurgency (COIN), counter-terrorism (CT), and hybrid warfare environments, where the lines between war and peace, civilian and combatant, are intentionally blurred (Mazanec & Thayer, 2021). The re-emergence of great power competition has not negated this trend but rather layered it on, requiring militaries to simultaneously prepare for high-intensity conflict while managing ongoing irregular threats. This dual challenge demands a level of flexibility, technological adoption, and strategic thought that diverges from the orthodoxies of the past (Biddle, 2021).

This expansion of roles is further accelerated by technological disruption and the changing nature of global threats. The militarization of cyberspace, the use of autonomous and AI-enabled systems, and the strategic competition in the space domain are redefining what

constitutes a battlefield and a weapon (Scharre, 2021). Concurrently, militaries are increasingly called upon to act as first responders in complex humanitarian emergencies and pandemics, and to bolster civil authorities against non-traditional threats like climate change-induced disasters, which act as "threat multipliers" for instability (DPKO, 2019). This evolution positions the modern military not merely as a war-fighting institution but as a key, multi-role actor in national and global security architecture. Its functions now seamlessly blend hard power with softer roles in stabilization, disaster relief, and support to governance, reflecting an understanding that security in the modern age is as much about building resilience and legitimacy as it is about defeating a defined enemy on a physical battlefield.

**Concept of Military Strategy**

Military strategy constitutes the highest level of military art, serving as the critical bridge between political objectives and tactical military actions. It involves the overarching plan for employing a nation's armed forces to secure strategic ends, which are inherently political in nature, such as defending sovereignty, deterring aggression, or compelling an adversary to change its behavior. Classical strategist Carl von Clausewitz’s dictum that "war is a mere continuation of policy by other means" remains foundational, emphasizing that military strategy must be subordinate to and guided by political goals. In essence, strategy answers the "how" of using military power to achieve the "what" defined by policymakers. It requires the integration of ends, ways, and means: defining the desired end-state, determining the ways or concepts by which force will be applied, and allocating the necessary means or resources (Freedman, 2013). A successful strategy must also account for the unpredictable and interactive nature of conflict, where an independent and reacting enemy seeks to impose its own will, creating the "fog of war" and friction that can derail even the most elegant plans.

In the 21st century, the concept of military strategy has expanded beyond the traditional paradigm of interstate warfare to encompass a far more complex and fragmented battlespace. Contemporary strategy must account for hybrid threats that blend conventional forces, irregular tactics, cyber warfare, and disinformation campaigns, as well as the persistent challenges of terrorism and insurgency. This has led to the development of integrated strategies that fuse military efforts with diplomatic, informational, and economic instruments of national power, often termed a "whole-of-government" approach (Mazanec & Thayer, 2021). Furthermore, technological disruption is fundamentally reshaping strategic thought. The militarization of domains like cyberspace and space, the proliferation of autonomous systems and artificial intelligence, and the emergence of algorithmic warfare demand new strategic frameworks (Scharre, 2021). Modern military strategy is therefore no longer solely about the application of kinetic force but about controlling the information environment, achieving decision superiority, and building partner capacity, all while navigating the ethical and legal dilemmas posed by new technologies and the imperative to maintain public legitimacy in an era of pervasive media scrutiny.

## Concept of Socio-economic Condition

Socio-economic condition is a comprehensive, multi-dimensional concept used to describe the collective social and economic standing of an individual, family, or community relative to others in a societal structure. It moves beyond singular metrics like income to encompass a spectrum of factors that determine a group's or individual's access to resources, opportunities, and overall quality of life. Traditionally, it has been measured by a triad of key indicators: economic capital (income, wealth, and employment status), human capital (educational attainment and skills), and social capital (social networks and prestige) (Oakes & Andrade, 2017). This holistic view is critical because these dimensions are deeply intertwined; for instance, educational attainment (a social factor) heavily influences employment prospects and earning potential (economic factors), which in turn affects health outcomes and social mobility. Understanding socio-economic condition is therefore fundamental to social science, as it serves as a primary determinant of life chances, influencing everything from health and nutrition to political participation and vulnerability to shocks.

In contemporary research, the conceptualization of socio-economic condition has become more nuanced, recognizing its role as both a driver and a consequence of broader systemic issues, including conflict and insecurity. There is a growing emphasis on its subjective and relative aspects, acknowledging that inequality and perceived deprivation can be as significant as objective poverty in shaping social outcomes and grievances (Stewart, 2021). This is particularly relevant in conflict analysis, where socio-economic marginalization such as youth unemployment, horizontal inequalities between identity groups, and lack of access to land or public services is widely recognized as a key structural driver of instability and recruitment into violent non-state actors (UNDP, 2022). Furthermore, modern frameworks increasingly treat socio-economic condition not as a static state but as a dynamic condition that is profoundly shaped by and, in turn, shapes the political and security environment. In conflict zones like Nigeria's North-East, the socio-economic condition of a population is not merely a background variable but a central component of the conflict ecosystem, where terrorism actively destroys livelihoods, displaces populations, and cripples public services, thereby creating a feedback loop that perpetuates fragility and hinders recovery (World Bank, 2023).

## Theoretical Framework

This study employed the counterinsurgency theory, the foundational contributions of key theorists to counterinsurgency theory are exemplified by Galula, a French-Algerian officer whose work during the Algerian War of Independence effectively laid the groundwork for modern counterinsurgency strategies, as he consistently emphasized the paramount importance of winning hearts and minds through proactive civilian engagement and the concurrent building of robust local governance structures alongside any military action, with his seminal book, Counterinsurgency Warfare: Theory and Practice (1964), remaining profoundly influential in counterinsurgency theory literature to this day. Further developing

these ideas, Nagl, a former U.S. Army officer and scholar, focuses his work on the critical challenge of adapting military strategies to modern insurgencies, and his book, Learning to Eat Soup with a Knife (2005), powerfully argues that military organizations must institutionally learn from past conflicts and adapt their strategies accordingly, while he simultaneously emphasizes the urgent need for a comprehensive approach that seamlessly integrates military operations with sustained political and social efforts. Complementing this perspective is McMaster, a retired U.S. Army general, whose writings consistently highlight the indispensable importance of understanding the local context in all counterinsurgency operations, and in his critical work, Dereliction of Duty (1997), he incisively critiques the Vietnam War's COIN strategies while forcefully advocating for a much deeper, more nuanced understanding of the complex political and social dynamics at play in any conflict environment.

Counterinsurgency theory rests on several key assumptions, beginning with the Primacy of the Population, which is one of the core tenets positing that the support of the local population is absolutely crucial for success, as winning the "hearts and minds" of civilians is deemed essential to systematically undermine the insurgents' influence and isolate them from their base of support. A second fundamental assumption is the necessity of an Integrated Approach, which asserts that effective counterinsurgency requires a sophisticated combination of military, political, economic, and social strategies, proceeding from the premise that military force alone is fundamentally insufficient and that all efforts must be meticulously coordinated across these various sectors to genuinely stabilize affected regions. Furthermore, the theory is built upon the assumption of Adaptability and Learning, recognizing that insurgencies are inherently dynamic and constantly evolving entities, and therefore, counterinsurgency strategies must be highly adaptable and consciously based on lessons learned from previous conflicts complemented by rigorous, ongoing assessments of the current situation. Finally, a fourth critical assumption is the Focus on Governance, which holds that addressing the underlying political grievances and building legitimate, effective governance structures is absolutely essential for achieving long-term stability, and consequently, that counterinsurgency strategies should deliberately prioritize the restoration of effective governance as the primary mechanism to prevent the re-emergence of insurgent groups after initial military successes.

Despite its utility, counterinsurgency theory has faced several criticisms: Counterinsurgency theory, while influential in shaping military and political strategies, has faced significant criticism from scholars and practitioners alike. One of the most common criticisms is that it places too much emphasis on military solutions, which can lead to the prioritisation of force above true political transformation. Critics believe that this strategy may lead to short-term tactical victories without addressing the core reasons of insurgency, such as socioeconomic inequality, political marginalisation, and local grievances. Additionally, the theory has been criticized for its ambiguity and complexity, as it encompasses a broad range of strategies that can be interpreted and applied in various ways. This can lead to inconsistent implementation, with different military and political leaders adopting divergent approaches that may conflict

with one another. Furthermore, COIN operations can sometimes lead to human rights violations, especially when military forces prioritize security and control over civil liberties and community engagement. Such abuses can alienate local populations and inadvertently strengthen insurgent narratives, undermining the very objectives that COIN aims to achieve. Critics also highlight the sustainability of gains made through counterinsurgency efforts, pointing out that initial successes can be undermined if the underlying social, political, or economic grievances are not addressed. The theory's reliance on the assumption that winning "hearts and minds" can be achieved through effective military and civilian engagement is seen as overly optimistic, especially in contexts where deep-seated historical animosities exist.

**Application of the theory**

The application of counterinsurgency theory to the study of counter-terrorism strategies employed by the Nigerian military is particularly relevant for several reasons, with the first reason being the sheer complexity of the insurgency itself, as the Boko Haram insurgency is multifaceted, involving deep-rooted socio-economic grievances and political marginalization, and understanding these dynamics is crucial for developing effective counter-terrorism strategies that address the root causes of violence. A second reason for its relevance is the theory's focus on local engagement, as counterinsurgency theory emphasizes the importance of engaging local communities and building trust between the military and civilians, an aspect that is critically important for the Nigerian military, which must work diligently to win the support of affected populations in order to effectively counter insurgent propaganda and recruitment efforts. Furthermore, the necessary integration of civilian and military efforts is a core tenet of the theory, suggesting that the Nigerian military's counter-terrorism strategy should integrate military operations seamlessly with political, social, and economic initiatives, a comprehensive approach that aligns perfectly with COIN principles and can significantly enhance the overall effectiveness of counter-terrorism efforts.

The dynamic nature of insurgencies, as highlighted by COIN theorists, necessitates an adaptable approach, meaning the Nigerian military must continuously assess the evolving landscape of terrorism and proactively adjust its strategies to respond to new and emerging challenges. Finally, the theory’s emphasis on building governance structures is vital, as counterinsurgency theory stresses the importance of establishing legitimate governance structures, and in the Nigerian context, concerted efforts to restore governance and provide essential services can directly help address the underlying grievances that fuel the insurgency and thereby create a more stable environment. Ultimately, counterinsurgency theory offers a valuable framework for understanding and evaluating the Nigerian military's counter-terrorism strategies; by focusing on the paramount importance of local populations, integrating military and civilian efforts, and addressing underlying grievances, COIN theory can effectively guide the development of more effective counter-terrorism approaches in Nigeria. While criticisms of the theory certainly highlight potential pitfalls, its undeniable relevance to the complex and evolving nature of insurgencies makes it an essential tool for

policymakers and scholars alike. Through the lens of counterinsurgency theory, this study can critically assess the successes and challenges of the Nigerian military's strategies in the ongoing fight against terrorism, ultimately contributing to more informed and effective responses to this pressing global issue.

## Methodology

The research adopted a qualitative design to facilitate an in-depth exploration of the nature of terrorism, military strategies, and their socio-economic consequences on civilians. This approach was selected for its capacity to interpret meanings, experiences, and perceptions directly from participants, thereby capturing the lived realities and contextual factors shaping responses to conflict beyond statistical data, as supported by Creswell (2014) and Silverman (2015). The study was conducted in the strategically relevant North-East Nigerian states of Borno, Yobe, and Adamawa, epicenters of the Boko Haram and ISWAP insurgencies, with a focus on key urban centers like Maiduguri, Damaturu, and Yola. The target population encompassed a diverse group of stakeholders directly affected by or involved in the conflict, including internally displaced persons (IDPs), women, youth, traditional leaders, humanitarian workers, educators, health officials, and security personnel. Purposive and snowball sampling techniques, recognized for their effectiveness in accessing information-rich participants in complex conflict settings (Patton, 2015; Noy, 2008), were utilized to select respondents across these states.

Data collection was conducted between April 2023 and February 2024 using semi-structured interview guides and Focus Group Discussion (FGD) protocols, meticulously designed in alignment with the research objectives as recommended by Kvale & Brinkmann (2009) and King and Horrocks (2010). These instruments ensured consistency while allowing flexibility, covering core themes such as the dynamics of terrorism, military counter-terrorism strategies, and their socio-economic impacts. Sessions were audio-recorded with participant consent, supplemented by field notes to capture non-verbal cues, and conducted in Hausa or English with interpreter assistance as needed. For analysis, the collected data from Key Informant Interviews (KIIs) and FGDs were transcribed and subjected to thematic content analysis. This involved systematic coding to identify, organize, and interpret patterns (themes) across the data, following the procedures outlined by Braun & Clarke (2006). The emerging themes were categorized according to the research objectives, and narrative synthesis supported by direct participant quotations was employed to substantiate analytical claims, thereby ensuring the findings are deeply rooted in the nuanced perspectives of the participants and enhancing the study's credibility and richness, in line with the guidance of Guest, MacQueen & Namey (2012) and Patton (2015).

**Data presentation and Analysis**

**Counter-terrorism strategies Nigerian military adopted in the war against terrorism in the North-East.**

Understanding the breadth and effectiveness of Nigeria's counter terrorism campaign requires a structured examination of the military doctrines, institutional reforms, and multilateral collaborations deployed since the insurgency's escalation. Drawing on documentary sources, key-informant interviews (KIIs), and focus group discussions (FGDs) with security officials, displaced persons, local community leaders, and civil society actors, the evolution of Nigeria's military response to terrorism is as under;

**1. Conventional Military Operations**

One of the earliest and most dominant strategies employed by the Nigerian military in the fight against terrorism was conventional military operations. This approach was based on traditional warfare tactics, which involved large-scale deployment of troops, heavy artillery, armored vehicles, and airstrikes aimed at dismantling insurgent camps and recapturing territories seized by Boko Haram. Operations such as "Operation Zaman Lafiya" (2013) and later "Operation Lafiya Dole" (2015) were initiated to reclaim lost territories, neutralize insurgents, and reassert state authority, particularly in Borno, Yobe, and Adamawa States (Omeni, 2017).

Field interviews with military officers in Maiduguri (May 2025) confirm that conventional operations were essential in reversing early territorial gains made by Boko Haram. FGDs with displaced persons in Monguno recounted the recapture of towns like Gwoza and Dikwa, but also highlighted the massive destruction and civilian displacement that followed. Many participants described how these offensives forced Boko Haram to shift toward guerrilla tactics, exposing the limitations of conventional warfare in an asymmetrical conflict. While these efforts reclaimed symbolic and strategic locations, they often lacked follow-up mechanisms to stabilize the liberated areas, leading to a cycle of retake-and-retreat.

**2. Formation of Joint Task Forces (JTF)**

In 2011 the Nigerian government created the Joint Task Force (JTF) to improve inter-agency coordination among the Army, Navy, Air Force, Police, and intelligence services. The JTF aimed to enhance intelligence-sharing and conduct unified operations to disrupt insurgent networks (Akinbi, 2015).

Key informants from the Defence Headquarters noted that while JTF operations succeeded in dismantling some key Boko Haram cells, their impact was undermined by issues such as poor coordination and corruption. FGDs conducted in Damaturu revealed that residents often

experienced human rights abuses, arbitrary arrests, and forced disappearances. Amnesty International (2015) had earlier documented these violations, which alienated communities and made it harder for the military to gain local trust. Respondents also expressed concerns about the short duration of JTF deployments and the lack of infrastructure left behind to sustain peace in cleared areas.

**3. Establishment of the Multinational Joint Task Force (MNJTF)**

Recognising the insurgency's cross-border dynamics, Nigeria and its Lake Chad neighbours reactivated the Multinational Joint Task Force (MNJTF) in 2015. This force facilitated joint operations, intelligence-sharing, and border security involving Chad, Niger, Cameroon, and Nigeria (Nwankpa, 2020).

Military informants from the MNJTF command in N'Djamena (via virtual interview, June 2025) emphasized that cross-border patrols and joint offensives helped cut off supply routes and pushed insurgents out of key border towns. FGDs with refugees in Diffa (Niger Republic) highlighted how coordination among states reduced insurgent sanctuaries, though they lamented inconsistencies in force commitment and language barriers among troops. Despite these limitations, many participants viewed MNJTF as a necessary tool for confronting the insurgency's regional dimension.

**4. Counter Insurgency and Intelligence Driven Operations**

As Boko Haram evolved, the military shifted toward intelligence-led counter-insurgency. Special Forces Brigades and community-based vigilantes like the Civilian JTF partnered to collect actionable intelligence, conduct targeted raids, and dismantle sleeper cells (Ekhomu, 2020).

Interviews with intelligence officers and vigilante leaders in Biu and Konduga confirmed the growing reliance on local networks for identifying insurgents. FGDs with Civilian JTF members revealed that familiarity with the terrain and community dynamics improved the precision of operations. However, both key informants and FGD participants acknowledged serious challenges, such as insurgents blending into civilian populations, fear of reprisal among informants, and occasional intelligence failures that led to civilian deaths. While the use of Special Forces yielded successful raids, such as the elimination of key commanders in Sambisa Forest (2021), the sustainability of these gains was often questioned due to resource constraints and coordination issues.

**5. Air Power and Technological Advancements**

The Nigerian Air Force (NAF) expanded its fleet with attack helicopters, fighter jets, and UAVs, enabling precision strikes on insurgent camps and supply routes. UAV-guided ISR improved situational awareness and supported ground troops (Ezeoha & Ugwu, 2021).

Aerial campaign officers interviewed in Yola described successful operations that disrupted insurgent logistics and destroyed several weapons depots. FGDs with residents of Pulka and Damasak, however, underscored the unintended consequences of airstrikes civilians reported destruction of farmlands, homes, and occasional misidentification of targets. This dual impact emphasized the importance of accurate targeting, robust pilot training, and compliance with humanitarian law. Participants also noted that while air power is a force multiplier, it cannot substitute for effective governance and ground-level presence.

**6. Rehabilitation and Deradicalisation Programmes**

Recognising that kinetic force alone is insufficient, Nigeria introduced programmes like "Operation Safe Corridor" (2016) to rehabilitate repentant fighters through vocational training, counselling, and religious re orientation (International Crisis Group, 2022).

FGDs with social workers in Gombe and interviews with ex-combatants revealed that the program provided psychological support, Islamic re-education, and skills acquisition in areas like carpentry and tailoring. However, many ex-combatants reported difficulty reintegrating due to community stigma and lack of follow-up support. Local community leaders interviewed in Mubi described widespread resentment toward returnees, which sometimes resulted in renewed cycles of marginalization. Participants stressed that without comprehensive reintegration including job creation and reconciliation dialogues the initiative risked recycling radicalized individuals back into extremist networks.

**7. Civil Military Cooperation (CIMIC)**

To address root grievances, the military incorporated CIMIC activities medical outreach, infrastructure rebuilding, and basic service delivery in liberated areas (Obamamoye, 2023). FGDs with IDPs in Bama and community leaders in Dikwa praised efforts such as school renovations, borehole drilling, and mobile health clinics delivered through military-led initiatives. Interviews with military CIMIC officers in Maiduguri indicated that these interventions were aimed at winning civilian trust and countering insurgent propaganda. However, respondents also noted that the scale of humanitarian needs far outstripped what the military could provide. Without sustained civilian administrative presence, CIMIC risks being viewed as temporary palliatives rather than a pathway to structural recovery. Nonetheless, many FGD participants agreed that civil-military outreach laid a foundation for future peacebuilding if scaled and institutionalized.

**How the military strategies and operations impacted the socio-economic conditions of civilians in the North-East region of Nigeria?**

Despite tactical gains on the battlefield, the Nigerian military's counter terrorism campaign has produced profound ripple effects on the everyday lives of civilians. By weaving together findings from 22 key informant interviews (KIIs) with humanitarian workers, traditional leaders, traders, teachers, and health officials, plus six focus group discussions (FGDs) with internally displaced persons (IDPs), women's associations, and youth groups across Borno, Yobe, and Adamawa ( April, 2025), Military strategies and operations have reshaped socio economic conditions in the North East as under:

**1. Displacement and Humanitarian Crisis**

Military offensives aimed at reclaiming territory often trigger mass civilian flight. Humanitarian KIIs in Maiduguri (May 2023) estimated that every major offensive displaces an average of 30,000 people within 72 hours. FGDs with women IDPs in Dalori Camp recounted fleeing at night during artillery bombardments on Bama (2022), leaving behind livestock and harvests. According to IOM (2022), more than 2.5 million people are currently displaced.

Interviewed camp managers highlighted chronic overcrowding" A tent meant for five now hosts twelve" (Camp Coordinator, Muna, 12 Jun 2025) and shortages of clean water, leading to recurrent cholera outbreaks. Respondents emphasized that the destruction of homes, granaries, and markets during airstrikes rendered many communities uninhabitable even after liberation, corroborating Amnesty International (2015). Humanitarian access remains complicated: aid convoys require military escorts, yet escorts are limited, causing ration cuts in Konduga and Gwoza between October 2023 and January 2024.

Displacement has not only uprooted communities but also disrupted livelihoods and eroded social cohesion. Interviews with aid workers from NRC and MSF reveal that prolonged encampment in IDP settlements contributes to dependency, hopelessness, and rising frustration among the displaced. FGDs with women leaders in Bama camp highlighted gender-based vulnerabilities, particularly the exploitation and abuse of displaced girls. The absence of durable resettlement plans has transformed many temporary IDP camps into semi-permanent settlements without long-term infrastructure. Participants repeatedly stressed the need for military operations to integrate civilian protection frameworks and post-liberation planning. Without these, the dislocation caused by security offensives risks prolonging humanitarian suffering and delaying reconstruction.

**2. Disruption of Economic Activities**

KIIs with traders at the Monday Market in Maiduguri noted a 70 % drop in livestock inflows since curfews tightened in early 2023. Roadblocks and security checkpoints while reducing IED incidents delay perishable goods; tomato dealers in Potiskum FGDs reported losing "two of every five baskets" to spoilage. Agriculture suffers most: farmers in Michika said they cultivate only fields within a two kilometre radius of military posts, shrinking output by half. Satellite imagery (FEWS NET, 2024) confirms abandonment of over 420,000 ha of arable land.

Destroyed bridges on the Maiduguri–Gamboru road, blown up during a 2022 clearance operation, have rerouted trade 180 km south, adding cost and time. Youth FGDs in Damboa linked unemployment to increased petty crime and susceptibility to insurgent recruitment" No job, no farm, the gun becomes a business," lamented a 24 year old displaced farmer.

Interviews with officials from the Borno State Ministry of Reconstruction emphasized the urgent need for economic revitalization. Yet FGDs with entrepreneurs and artisans in Mubi and Biu identified capital shortages and insecurity as key barriers to restarting businesses. Women traders noted that movement restrictions and harassment at checkpoints disproportionately affect them, curtailing their economic independence. Traders in Gashua market underscored the loss of cross-border trade with Cameroon and Niger due to closed borders and insurgent raids, weakening regional commerce.

**3. Education and Healthcare Access**

School administrators interviewed in Gwoza revealed that 67 of 72 primary schools in the LGA were either destroyed or occupied by troops between 2014 and 2021. FGDs with parents in Dikwa described fear of enrolment after the 2021 Greenfield abductions; many prefer Koranic shack schools within IDP camps. UNICEF (2022) estimates that over 600,000 children remain out of school in Borno alone.

Healthcare has similarly deteriorated. A Médecins Sans Frontières doctor in Pulka (KII, April 2025) noted that military curfews restrict night evacuations, resulting in avoidable maternal deaths. FGDs with elderly IDPs in Yola St. Theresa camp cited walking 15 km for basic drugs after their dispensary was turned into a military forward operating base. Damaged cold chain infrastructure has precipitated vaccine stock outs; polio surveillance data show coverage dipping below 35 % in Gaidam LGA (2021–2023).

Teachers interviewed in Damaturu noted that military occupation of school facilities intended to deter insurgent attacks has had the unintended effect of discouraging attendance and further militarizing childhood. Several respondents warned that a generation of children growing up without education poses long-term threats to peace and development. Community

health workers in Askira/Uba emphasized the rise in unattended births, child mortality, and untreated illnesses due to the absence of operational clinics.

Efforts to rebuild services have been sporadic. FGDs in liberated towns such as Monguno noted a few rehabilitated schools and clinics, often supported by international NGOs, but lamented inconsistent staffing and supplies. Interviewees stressed the importance of securing these facilities through civilian oversight, not continued military use, to restore normalcy and public confidence in essential services.

**4. Human Rights Concerns and Civil Military Relations**

Civilian JTF members in Konduga FGDs acknowledged improvements in soldier conduct since 2020 but recounted cases where young men were detained "for days without charges" after cordon and search operations. KIIs with the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) documented 84 petitions of alleged extrajudicial killings between 2019 and 2023.

These abuses erode trust: traditional rulers in Kukawa reported that villagers withhold intelligence for fear of reprisals if information leaks. An Imam from Bama (KII, February 2025) stressed that "When the army punishes the innocent, Boko Haram's sermon wins." Accountability remains weak; inquiries are slow and rarely lead to prosecution, reinforcing perceptions of impunity.

KIIs with civil society actors from the CLEEN Foundation and Human Rights Watch affirmed that military-led counter-insurgency operations must be subject to democratic oversight. FGDs with women's groups in Gombi emphasized that abuses often go unreported due to fear of retaliation. Participants recommended the establishment of independent complaint mechanisms and community liaison officers embedded within military commands to bridge the trust gap. While counter-terrorism inevitably imposes restrictions, balancing security with human rights safeguards is vital. Failure to address grievances risks pushing communities closer to extremist narratives. Greater civilian oversight, transparent investigations, and public engagement are crucial to rebuilding legitimacy and cooperation.

**5. Socio Psychological Trauma and Social Disintegration**

Psychosocial counsellors in Mubi (KII, October 2023) estimate PTSD affects at least one in three IDP adolescents. FGDs with widows in Ngala relayed recurring nightmares and survivor guilt. Community leaders in Damaturu described erosion of traditional dispute resolution mechanisms: displacement scatters elders, leaving youth to settle conflicts violently. Rising substance abuse was flagged in FGDs with boys in Banki, where tramadol use doubled between 2021 and 2023, per local clinic records.

The social fabric has frayed; mistrust blooms between returnees and those who stayed under insurgent rule. Without targeted psychosocial programs, interviewees warned, inter communal tensions could evolve into fresh cycles of violence. Existing military operations provide limited mental health support, underscoring the need for civil agencies and NGOs to scale trauma services and community reconciliation initiatives.

KIIs with social workers in Michika emphasized the importance of community-based therapy models and mobile trauma clinics to reach remote areas. FGDs with youth leaders advocated for recreational and vocational programs to re-engage displaced youth. Respondents across several sites stressed that recovery must go beyond physical rebuilding to include healing minds and mending fractured social relations. Overall, interview and FGD evidence reveal that while military strategies have reclaimed territory and degraded insurgent capabilities, they have simultaneously generated displacement, economic paralysis, service delivery collapse, human rights grievances, and widespread trauma.

**Analysis and Discussion of Findings**

The effectiveness of Nigeria's military counter-terrorism strategies in the North-East is shaped by the combined impact of tactical successes and deep socio-economic challenges. While joint operations, intelligence-driven missions, and regional collaboration have enabled the recapture of territories and the disruption of Boko Haram and ISWAP activities, the absence of a coordinated "whole-of-government" approach has left security vacuums that insurgents often exploit. Interviews with military personnel, humanitarian workers, and community leaders reveal that inadequate civil administration, mass displacement, destroyed livelihoods, gender-specific vulnerabilities, and human rights concerns continue to undermine public trust and hinder sustainable peace. The destruction of economic activities, essential services, and community structures has produced widespread humanitarian crises, heightened youth vulnerability to radicalization, and eroded cooperation needed for effective intelligence gathering. Although military offensives have delivered important battlefield gains, their long-term impact remains limited without immediate governance follow-up, improved civil-military coordination, and socio-economic reconstruction reinforcing counterinsurgency theory's assertion that durable security depends on winning the support of the population, not solely defeating insurgents.

**Conclusion**

In conclusion, this study highlights that while the Nigerian military has deployed a range of strategies to combat terrorism in the North-East, the predominantly kinetic and state-centric approach has proven insufficient for achieving sustainable peace. Despite tactical successes in reclaiming territory and degrading insurgent capabilities, these operations have generated profound and often counterproductive socio-economic consequences for the civilian population. The persistent cycle of mass displacement, economic paralysis, destruction of

essential services, and erosion of community trust has exacerbated the very conditions of poverty, grievance, and marginalization that fuel the insurgency. The lack of a holistic, "whole-of-government" strategy that integrates military action with robust political, developmental, and humanitarian efforts has significantly impeded long-term stability. To enhance the effectiveness of counter-terrorism and foster lasting security, it is crucial to reorient strategy towards a people-centred approach that prioritizes civilian protection, addresses root causes, and ensures that military gains are consolidated through immediate and sustainable post-conflict reconstruction and reconciliation.

**Recommendations**

Arising from the findings, the following recommendations are made:

i. The Federal Government of Nigeria, through the Office of the National Security Adviser (ONSA), should champion a decisive shift from a military-led to a "whole-of-government" approach to counter-terrorism. This should involve establishing a high-powered, inter-ministerial stabilization body for the North-East to ensure seamless coordination between security operations and simultaneous, large-scale interventions in governance, education, healthcare, and economic development. This integrated framework is vital for addressing the root causes of insurgency and ensuring that cleared territories are stabilized and not lost again.

ii. The Nigerian Military High Command should institutionalize mandatory training on International Humanitarian Law and human rights for all personnel and establish an independent, transparent Civil-Military Complaints Commission. This commission should be empowered to receive, investigate, and adjudicate allegations of abuses, ensuring accountability and rebuilding community trust. Furthermore, investing in modern intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR) technology and ensuring robust pilot training will minimize collateral damage from airstrikes and enhance operational precision.

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# FARMERS-HERDERS CONFLICT AND FOOD SECURITY: AN EXPLORATION OF NEW EVIDENCE FROM THE NORTHEAST, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** This paper examines how the farmer-herder conflicts impact food security in the northeast, Nigeria. The objectives of the study are to investigate the causes and patterns of the conflict, its negative impact on food insecurity, and assess responses of government at the various levels in resolving the conflict. The paper adopts survey research design using key informant interview, focus group discussion, and observation to collect data. The study is anchored on environmental scarcity theory (EST) developed by Homer-Dixon as theoretical framework of analysis. The findings of the study reveals that open grazing system, child herding, night grazing, and environmental scarcity contributed to fierce competition for access to water, forest, pasture, and land resources by herders and farmers. The study concludes that the conflict is a resource-based conflict precipitated by the dynamics of climate change and environmental scarcity over the years. The study recommends the establishment of grazing reserves, use of multi-stakeholder dialogue, and use of hybrid and resistant seeds for farming for national development.

**Keywords:** Farmers-herders conflict, Food Security, Environmental scarcity.

## Introduction

The traditional method of livestock rearing has been a global practice for a very long time. However, the practice differs across cultures, places, and civilizations as the human population continues to evolve and the need for food and survival increases. Herders move their cattle to graze on farmlands belonging to crop farmers or settle on the land to fertilize it with cattle dung, while farmers exchange food for herders' other dairy products. This relationship remains complementary as they share land, water, pasture, and other resources for their livelihoods (Oruonye, Ahmed & Fatima, 2020; International Crisis Group, 2017).

However, this symbiotic relationship has been disrupted in recent years due to increased human population and livestock, urbanization and industrialization, environmental

degradation, agricultural expansion, and the use of technology in both farming and pastoralism. This development is marked by 21st-century human and scientific advancements impacting socioeconomic development, ecology, and agricultural practices (Mohammed, 2024; Blench, 2004).

Evidence has shown that the Sahel region has experienced serious drought in the last 40 years, intensifying fierce competition over renewable and non-renewable resources. The population of humans and animals increased during this period, putting pressure on scarce water, land, and pasture. Drought and rinderpest epidemics in 1901 and the subsequent drought of the 1970s in Northern Nigeria also contributed to the migration of Fulani herdsmen (Ahmadu, 2021; Harshbarger, 1995). Similarly, in 2017, Nigeria was ranked as the 11th country in the world to be severely affected by climate change, as revealed by the Global Climate Risk Index (GCRI). The index measures the impact of weather-related loss events in 183 countries, considering the number of events and the damage they caused. Nigeria experienced an increase in the number of extreme weather events between 1997 and 2017 (Friedrich Ebert Stiftung, 2017).

The upsurge in violent conflicts between farmers and herders in the two pastoral corridors of Northern Nigeria (Northeast and Northwest) marks a defining moment. In the Northwest, the difference between bandits, kidnappers, and violent herdsmen is blurred. Over 30,000 armed non-state actors operate in Northern Nigeria (Rufa'i, 2021; Bukarti, cited in Arvin, 2021). The Lake Chad Basin has been a battlefield for these conflicts in recent years. The basin's economic potential for both fishing, herding and farming has attracted herders from neighbouring countries (Chad, Niger, and Cameroon) to settle in the hinterlands of the Nigerian lake basin. Violence and competition have become common and widespread between the newly arrived herders and their host communities, leading to several killings and destruction (Amnesty International, 2018; Ahmadu, 2011).

According Ogundipe and Oluwale (2016) violent conflicts between farmers and herders are not unique to Nigeria they have manifested around the Sahel and West Africa regions. The situation deteriorates due to poor resource policy and management. Farmer-herder violence is an old conflict that transition to become not only an intractable but a national security threat in Nigeria. Sadly, in 2016, it was estimated that Nigeria lost over USD 14 billion due to herdsmen and farmers conflicts.

The farmers-herders conflict has become widespread in all the geopolitical zones of Nigeria and has varying devastating negative impacts. This is attributable to the transhumance nature of pastoralists complicating the environmental problem. The most affected zone by the farmers-herder conflicts is the northeast sub-region, where both the Lake Chad Basin, River Gongola, and River Benue serve as sources of water for farmers, herders, and the general population.

Okoye, Ezeani, Onah, Ekekwe, Akov, and Agbo (2024) argued that tthe growing concern of the promulgation of contradictory laws and poor access and management of land resources has aggravated the herder-peasant farmer conflicts in Nigeria's Middle Belt state of Benue that spread to neighboring states of Taraba in the northeast. Over 90 percent of Lake Chad water sources have dried up and its size shrinks. This environmental change has already affected the livelihoods of over 17 million people living around the area (European Union Nigeria, 2023).

However, conflicts between farmers and herders have been classified as Low-Intensity Conflicts resulting from environmental degradation, resource scarcity, population growth, and climate change (Shettima & Tar, 2008). It is against this backdrop that this paper will explore new evidence from the farmers-herder's conflicts with a view to finding out how its impacts on human security and food security in the northeast, Nigeria.

**Objectives of the Study**

The study aims to interrogate new evidence of the farmer-herder conflicts and seeks to specifically achieve the following objectives:

i. To identify causes and patterns of the farmer-herder conflicts

ii. To examine the impact of the farmer-herder conflicts on food security

iii. To evaluate the efforts of government at various levels in resolving the conflict

**History of Farmers and Herders Conflict in Nigeria**

Scholars are divided on how they explain and analyze the history of the farmers-herders conflict. The scholarly arguments in the literature have three major perspectives. The first category of scholars looks at the history of the Fulani people, and the second category focuses on the history of the Fulani migration.

The Fulanis are the largest pastoralist group with the population between 25 million to 40 million people across 17 African countries from the Atlantic shores of Senegal and Mauritania to Sudan. Even among scientists and anthropologists there were debates on the identity and migration history because of their complex cultural heritage. In the linguistic literature, there are over 11 dialects of the Fulani spoken in Africa (Schlebusch, Forte-Lima, & Cerny, 2025).

The first category of scholarship argues that the Fulani ethnic origin is the most important approach to the understanding of the conflict. In Africa Fulani have different names

(Hagberg, 2000) In countries where French is the official language, the Wolof term Peul is widely used. In the Gambia and Sierra Leone, the Mande term Fula is normally being used. In Nigeria and Ghana, they are known by the Hausa term Fulani. Kanuri and other peoples of the Chad basin refer to them as Felaata. The term they called themselves is Fulbe (sing. Pullo), which is also the term employed in German writings. In this study, we shall refer to them as Fulani or Fulbe in terms of their identity or origin. In some countries like Cameroon, Niger, and the Central Africa Republic, they are referred to as Mbororo as an ethnolinguistic sub-group of the Fulani (Baidoo, 2014; Azarya, 1996).

Fulani cattle herders moved eastward from Senegal to the Lake Chad region during the eleventh and fourteenth centuries, mostly as a result of migratory drift but also occasionally as a result of Islamic Jihads (Holy wars). Fombina and other Fulani States were established as a result of jihads, allowing Fulani migrants from the North and West to enter Nigeria safely. Up until the British interfered and established the colonial state of Nigeria, these newly formed nations were sustained by centralized governments, military force, taxation, and enslavement (Stenning, 1959; Abubakar, 1977; Frantz, 1980; Harshbarger, 1995). Without mentioning violence between herders and farmers Adebayo (1991) mentioned rivalry between the two factions in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries. The results of the socioeconomic interaction between the two groups indicated symbiotic ties and interdependence.

The African Research Bulletin (2019) claims that Uthman Dan Fodio is the source of the Fulani and later farmers-herders conflict. "A 19th-century Islamic revivalist who declared war on despotic leaders and urged Muslims to practice pristine Islam" was Dan Fodio. He then founded the Islamic Caliphate of Sokoto, which is currently recognized as the Fulani people's and Islam's ancient homeland in Nigeria and West Africa (ARB, 2019).

Tilde (2020), in his view, claimed that the term "Fulani" generally refers to the Fulani with livestock. The categorization is inaccurate and deceptive. He divided Fulani into two more categories. First, West and Central Africa's civilizations have benefited from the contributions of Fula Domesticus, or the cosmopolitan Fulani. Second, there needs to be more interaction between Fula Naturalis, or nomadic Fulani, and civilization. Forests and livestock define and dictate their way of life. The cattle are the masters of nature. They are denied a permanent address and nationality. However, over the centuries, an enduring economy has sustained their republican disposition and kept them free from the political servitude of multiple city-states and empires. They follow the master wherever his interest in pasture and water leads.

The Fulani become sedentary and change into the domestic species when they are lost by a natural calamity, conflict, or religious beliefs or when their master is killed (the cow). Following their assimilation into society, the first generation pursued civilizational endeavours such as trade, academia, politics, and warfare. They learn from their new master the laws they must abide by to live and procreate. The Fulani of the Jihad of the 19th century had to decide between extinction and assimilation. The Fulani adopted assimilation as a

means of preserving their power and transforming themselves, especially in Hausa land following the Jihad by marrying the locals (Tilde, 1999; 2020).

During the colonial period, the Fulani enjoyed power and control of the system through indirect rule. However, immediately after the attainment of independence, the Fulani lost their privileged position with new laws of the Federal Government on indigenization and the Land Use Act of 1978. The Fulani, being transhumance and sedentary, could not claim ownership of land. These developments made Fulani weaker as they were mostly perceived as settlers or non-indigenes by their host communities (Eke, 2018; Adebanwi, 2009; Waters-Bayer & Bayer, 1994; Shettima & Tar, 2008).

The second category of the scholarship focuses on Fulani migration. One of the most populous groups in West Africa, the Fulani live in a nearly continuous zone that roughly corresponds to the Sahelian climate and vegetation, extending from the Atlantic Coast to the Red Sea region as native to numerous states in the Sahelian region, Fulani are also mostly found in Northern Nigeria, Senegal's Futa Toro and Futa Djallon regions, Guinea's Macina regions, and onward through Niger, Chad, and Cameroon to the east. The majority of farmer-herder disputes take place in Sub-Saharan Africa, where recently established African states do not have the necessary frameworks to prevent or reduce the likelihood of these conflicts happening or getting worse (Oppong, 2002).

A sizable portion of the people in the West African sub-region rely on cattle production for their survival and means of subsistence. In West Africa, about 12 million people rely on livestock rearing as their main source of income. In comparison, over 70 million people in the same region make their living from livestock and livestock-related businesses (Shettima & Tar, 2008).

Oruonye et al, (2020) asserted that the majority of pastoralists more than 90% are Fulani. A sizable ethnic group dispersed throughout numerous West and Central African nations is the Fulani. Ninety-five per cent of the estimated 19.5 million cattle, 975,000 donkeys, 28,000 camels, 72.5 million goats, and 41.3 million sheep in the country are thought to be owned by them. Between 20 and 30 per cent of all agricultural production and roughly 6 to 8 per cent of GDP are derived from livestock. Over thirty per cent of the live animals killed in Nigeria are imported by pastoralists from neighbouring nations. The growing number of crop farmers and their migration southward to the wetter Middle Belt region has resulted in ongoing conflicts between the two groups. Although cattle and crop farmers used to be able to resolve conflicts among themselves through customary means, this mechanism has recently failed. The conflict is now seen as having a very dangerous and devastating dimension that involves the use of both complex and sophisticated weapons as well as small and light weapons.

For example, in his article titled ‘This thing called ‘killer herdsman,’ Mahmud Jega notes,

The idea that herdsmen are targeting Christians, Middle Belters, Tivs, or natives of Southern Kaduna is a political fabrication propagated by politicians and the media. The herdsmen barely even recognize the existence of the "North Central geopolitical zone," much less seek to eradicate it. Despite their alleged ethnic allegiance to Sheikh Uthman Dan Fodio, most of today's herdsmen observe Islam only nominally and are obsessed with survival, not religion. The accusation that ranchers have a "Jihadist" objective is unfounded, as the herders themselves require Dan Fodio's second coming to revitalize their religious practices.

Drawing from the above statement on the Fulani herdsmen, Mahmud Jega argued that they are transhumant, not deeply practising Muslims, and are more concerned with the survival of their cattle and livelihood than Jihadism. This does not, however, in a way exonerate the herdsmen of being accused of Fulanization and Islamization agenda propagated in the Nigerian media.

The farmers also have unique and peculiar historical trajectories. However, Wolderhanna and Michael (2005) argued that the two groups intersect and that any attempt to classify them is a difficult task. Nomadic pastoralism, transhumant pastoralism, agro-pastoralism, and sedentary farming are the prevalent categories. In a system known as nomadic pastoralism, farmers who primarily rely on the production of animals for their living need a stable place of residence since they are always on the move, searching for water and pasture for their livestock. They only engage in farming as a means of augmenting cattle grazing.

The Fulani people practice this regularly. Transhumant pastoralism is a method in which farmers raise livestock and cultivate crops simultaneously. They move their herds along specific paths on a fairly regular basis and keep a house or residents who live there for a portion of the year. In agro-pastoralism, farmers who make roughly equal ends meet by raising crops and caring for animals reside in semi-permanent villages and must engage in supplemental farming activities. The final group consists of sedentary farmers who get their living mostly from the cultivation of crops and who maintain permanent settlements. They also have domestic animals that bring in additional revenue. For the two groups, the terms pastoralism and nomadism are interchangeable.

Shettima and Tar (2008) believe that there is multi-resource nomadism, which is when a mobile group may combine cultivation, hunting, gathering, and sale of labour as well as livestock herd. This is what has been happening in the last decade in Northeast and northern Nigeria with the introduction of FADAMA and dry season farming facilitated by the Federal Government and the World Bank to revamp the agricultural sector to achieve food security and boost foreign exchange through comparative advantage.

The third category is the concentric argument which sees the Fulani having intergroup relations with their neighbours. The immediate neighbours are the Hausas with whom they have lived for centuries and shared cultural values, religious affiliation, politics, and inter-

married. The relations pre-date the Sheikh Uthman Dan Fodio Jihad of 1804. The Hausa were known farmers, hunters, and traders while the Fulanis were known to be herders and nomads, and very few of them engaged in trading. However, nowadays Fulani engage in trading and other entrepreneurial investments.

Subsequently, the Fulani herders as transhumance moved around searching for pasture, water, and places free of tsetse flies. The movements brought the Fulani with the indigenous groups or ethnic nationalities in the entire Northern region into close relations. The most endowed areas with grazing reserves and water bodies were found in the Lake Chad Basin, River Benue and Gongola, and Middle Belt areas. These zones are rich in resources needed to rear cattle.

**Literature Review on Farmers-Herders Conflict**

According to Cabot (2017), the disruption of agricultural and pastoral calendars due to climate change has engendered both geographical and occupational overlaps between the endeavors of farmers and herders. The duration of overlap between agricultural activities and livestock migrations during the arid season has intensified as a result of rainfall variability. In response to the harsh conditions imposed by inconsistent precipitation, farmers and herders are increasingly gravitating towards agro-pastoralism as a coping mechanism.

Harshbarger (1995) conducted an empirical study in Cameroon and investigated the intricacies of farmers-herders conflict dynamics using the state-society approach in Africa. The study was conducted through fieldwork for over sixteen months between 1991 and 1992 in the Tugi and Wum villages situated in the Northwest province of Cameroon. It employed ethnographic research methods, participant’s observation survey data, and the study aimed to explore the issues around cattle trespassing and farm destruction, as well as the mediation processes employed to address the conflicts between farmers and herders.

Onuoha and Ochuba (2018) argued that the farmers-herders conflict is an intractable conflict that has engulfed the entire Sub-Saharan Africa and Nigeria's hinterlands. They identified some reasons why the farmers-herders conflict has been persistent based on the rationale of why the herdsmen and farmers clash and will continue to clash. They based their claims on an alleged expansionist desire of Fulani for land, Islamization agenda, and environmental politics conditioned by scarcity. In 2018, the International Crisis Group identified three reasons for the escalation of violence: the growth of ethnic militias who were bearing illegally acquired weapons; the failure of the Federal Government of Nigeria to prosecute perpetrators or heed warnings of attacks; and the introduction of anti-grazing laws in some states, resulting in clashes between farmers and herders in the neighbouring states. Lenshie and Jacob's (2020) argued that poor administration and governance of land resources were responsible for the persistent clashes between farmers and herders in Taraba State. This finding disagreed with Onuoha and Ochuba’s (2018) postulations as earlier stated.

Another study by Jibril, Adamu, and Jirah (2024) in employed a survey method to generate data found that the impact of the conflict was more severe on food security, poverty, and destruction of livelihood of the affected communities bringing fresh insights.

According to Basset (1988), pastoralists and farmers became more intimate due to the ecological issues and drought in the 1970s. The ecological degradation in Northern Nigeria that leads to the seasonal migration of herders and their herds towards Central and Southern Nigeria could be better explained by changes in both push and pull factors happening simultaneously. Climate change is a push factor and the search for greener pasture is a pull factor for the survival of the livestock.

In their study, Ingawa, Ega, and Erhabor (1999) emphasized that the primary underlying causes of conflicts between herdsmen and farmers in Nigeria are shifting resource access rights, whereby arable farmers' tenure-ship is impeding traditional access rights to communal grazing and water resources. This is especially bad along the classic trekking routes, which turn into popular cropping locations due to the higher soil fertility brought about by the concentration of animal excrement from the trekking herds in these places. The amount of cattle feed that is currently accessible has significantly decreased, especially in the Northern States, as a result of inadequate grazing resources, increased crop production (and subsequent increased commercialization of crop leftovers), and poor management of grazing reserves.

Drawing from the preceding arguments of Blench (1996), resource conflicts can be classified into two categories: point resources, including mines, farms, and reserves, and eco-zonal conflicts, including water, grazing, and hunting rights. In this case, the farmers-herders conflict is the former. Ahmadu (2011) the Lake Chad region has been one of the battlefields for farmers-herders conflict in recent years. The basin's economic potential for agro-pastoralism attracted herders from other ecological zones in Chad, Niger, and Cameroun Republics to settle in the hinterlands of the Nigerian lake basin. The complementarity of their relations deteriorates with increased economic hardship caused by environmental factors like the shrinking of the great Lake Chad basin and desert encroachment from the Sahel.

It is crucial to remember that population expansion and climate change do not always lead to these violent confrontations. Instead, changes in the climate and population tend to make resource-related conflicts more common, making it more difficult for the already overburdened traditional institutions to resolve conflicts amicably. These modifications frequently make the breakdown of mutually beneficial agro-pastoral partnerships even worse. Migration patterns have changed, access to agricultural land has been restricted, and the availability of dependable water sources has decreased due to desertification and climate variability. The expected population explosion in West Africa is expected to drive up demand for these resources at the same time (Kwaja & Smith, 2020).

Shettima and Tar (2008), on the other hand, claimed that land disputes could result from a region's shifting demographics. They contended that if Nigeria's 140 million population were to be projected back to pre-colonial times, it would only have been 10 million in the 19th century, negating the need for competing interests in land use. Sambo and Sule (2021) examined the farmers-herders conflict within the context of national security problem, nation-building, and the need for national integration in Nigeria. Employing a descriptive qualitative approach to data collection and analysis, the study drew insights from secondary sources, which were discussed through thematic and analytical presentations focusing on Adamawa State.

Adisa (2012) observed that land tenure system and ownership was regarded as a cause of conflicts. In most areas in Nigeria, farmers are regarded as those who own the land and, therefore, determine how it is used, while the herdsmen are regarded as the landless group who do not own land talk more to use and settle on. The clashes between farmers and herders are often exaggerated. The nature of cohabitation, interdependence, and complementarity is downplayed for political reasons. Identity politics and power relations amplify the politicization of the farmers-herders conflict (Hussein et al., 1999).

Tenuche and Ifatimehin (2009) postulated three basic levels of conflict between Fulani herders and farmers, which influence power relations in Nigeria.

i. The Constitution of Nigeria lacks an explicit explanation of the indigene/settler's mirage;

ii. Uncertainty on grazing area(s) and water detection germane for the survival of herders and farmers;

iii. The Nigerian Land Tenure Act permits ownership and lease of land.

The above statement explains the dynamics and challenges of Nigeria's federalism regarding political rights and conflict resolution. It further buttresses the fact that Nigeria's federalism needs restructuring to address the citizen-settler dichotomy, state police, and resource control.

**Theoretical Framework: Environmental Scarcity Theory**

The study is anchored on the environmental scarcity theory, which serves as the framework for understanding the farmers-herders conflict as the independent variable. This theory posits that there is link between environmental factors, such as scarcity of resources like land, water, and pasture, play a crucial role in exacerbating conflicts between herders and farmers.

The Environmental Scarcity Theory (EST) was pioneered by Homer-Dixon and the University of Toronto Group of academics and seeks to illuminate the linkages between environmental scarcity and various forms of conflict, including violence, ethnic tensions, and insurgencies, particularly in developing countries. Homer-Dixon (1991) posits that within the next 50 years, the global population will likely surpass nine billion, accompanied by a quintupling of global economic output. Consequently, the scarcity of renewable resources is expected to intensify continuously.

The EST provides a comprehensive framework for understanding the complex interplay between environmental dynamics, population pressures, and socio-economic disparities, as well as their role in shaping conflicts over scarce resources. By illuminating these linkages, the theory informs efforts to address the root causes of conflict and promote sustainable resource management practices that mitigate the risk of violence and foster peace and stability in vulnerable communities.

Homer-Dixon's identification of six types of environmental change as potential drivers of violent conflicts underscores the complex relationship between environmental degradation and social unrest. These serve as assumptions of the environmental scarcity: Greenhouse-induced climate change, Deforestation, Stratospheric ozone depletion, Depletion and contamination of freshwater sources, Degradation and loss of fertile agricultural land, and Depletion of fisheries

Homer-Dixon's studies have demonstrated that developing countries predominantly rely on environmental resources crucial for agricultural production, including forests, croplands, and freshwater. His research findings, drawn from projects conducted in countries such as China, Mexico, and numerous nations in sub-Saharan Africa, underscore the vital role of these resources in sustaining livelihoods and economic activities in developing regions.

The concept of environmental change leading to environmental scarcity aligns with Percival and Homer-Dixon's (1998) classification, which identifies three main types of environmental scarcity:

i. Supply-induced scarcity occurs when environmental resources are degraded or depleted, such as through soil erosion, leading to the loss of arable land.

ii. Demand-induced scarcity: Arising from population growth or increased per capita consumption, which escalates the demand for resources.

iii. Structural scarcity: Arising from unequal distribution of resources, whereby a few individuals or groups control a disproportionate share of resources, leaving the rest of the population facing shortages.

These forms of scarcity can exacerbate tensions and conflicts as competition for dwindling resources intensifies. In regions like Nigeria, where environmental degradation is acute, the consequences of environmental scarcity are particularly pronounced, further fueling social and economic instability.

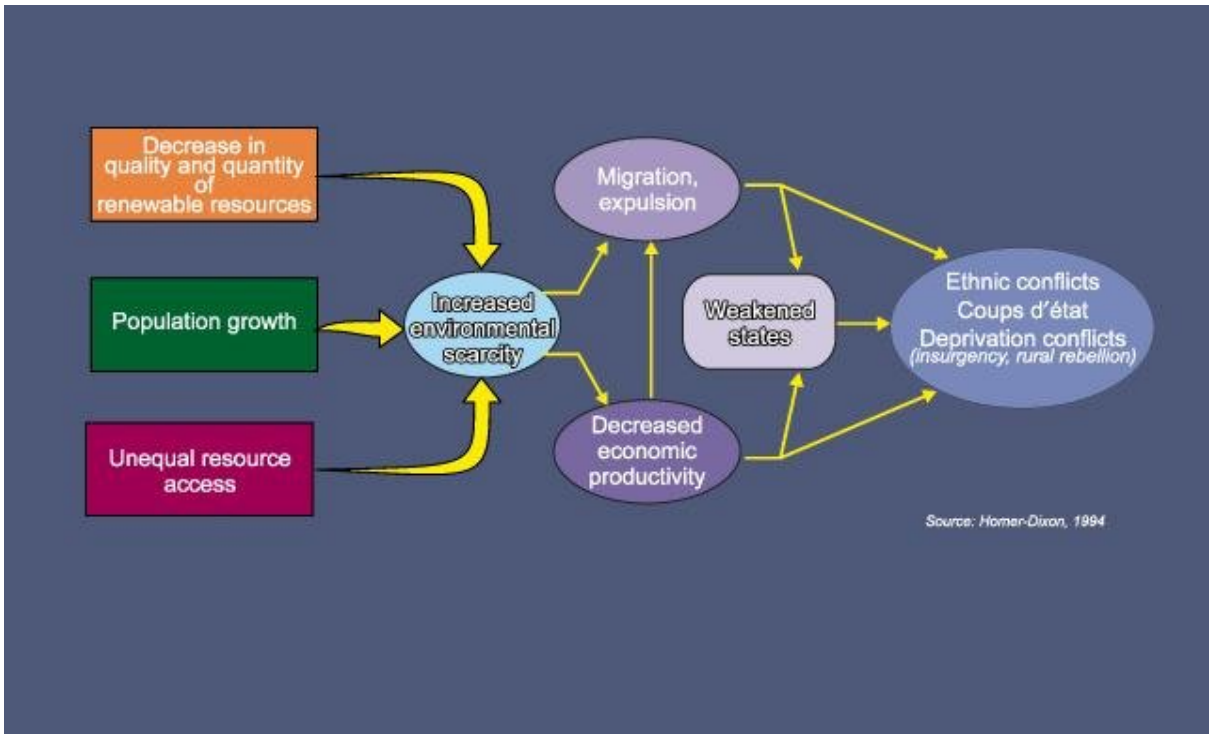



Figure 1: Framework of Analysis of Environmental Scarcity Theory (EST)
Source: Homer-Dixon (1994).

Homer-Dixon's framework, which explores the causal relationship between environmental change and resource conflict (eco-violence), offers valuable insights into the dynamics of the farmers-herders conflict in Northeast Nigeria and beyond. The three key factors identified population growth, environmental change, migration, and unequal resource distribution—align with the evidence and situational analysis of the conflict (Homer-Dixon, 1999).

Inspired by Homer-Dixon's (1994) theoretical postulation a descriptive model of the farmers-herders conflict was designed by Mohammed (2024) in his thesis on the factors, reasons and dynamics of the conflict in Northeast Nigeria as it can be seen illustrated in Figure 2.

Linking and applying the theory involves considering the cause-and-effect nature of environmental changes, population growth and migration patterns. Factors such as climate change in Sub-Saharan Africa, the shrinking of the Lake Chad Basin, and the ethnic politics prevalent in the Northeast and Nigeria at large contribute to the current resource conflicts. Access, ownership, and scarcity of available resources, exacerbated by population growth and environmental degradation, serve as the primary drivers of the farmers-herders conflict in Northeast Nigeria. While this reality poses challenges, it also provides an environment conducive to the adoption of mitigation strategies to address the conflict.

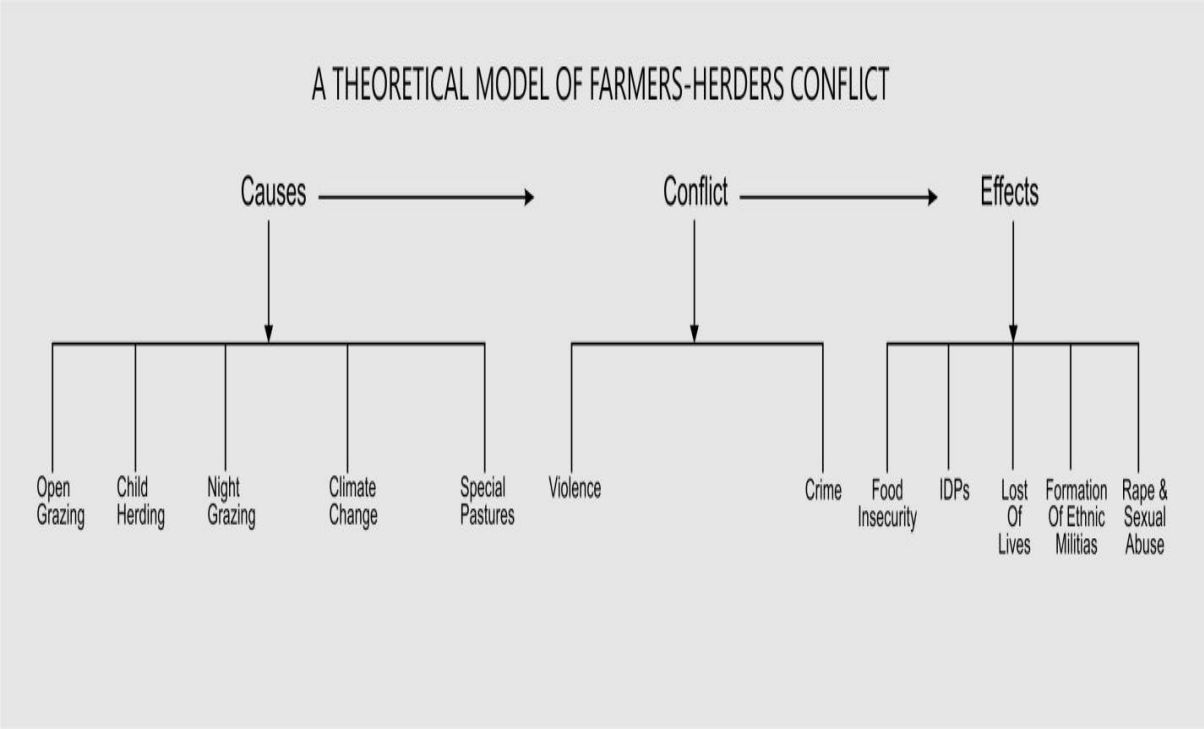



Figure 2: A Theoretical Model of Farmers-Herders Conflict
Source: Mohammed (2024).

**The Nature of the Study Area**

The area that constitutes the North-East zone of Nigeria lies between the vast arid expanse of the Sahara and the dense tropical rainforest along the Guinea Coast. Delimiting the area is Cameroon to the east, the Niger and Chad Republics to the north, North-Central Nigeria to the west, and South-Eastern Nigeria to the south. This geographical area constitutes the largest zone in Nigeria and comprises the present states of Adamawa, Bauchi, Borno, Gombe, Taraba and Yobe, respectively. It has a total of 103,639 square miles, representing 29.1 per cent of the total area of Nigeria (Barbour, 1971; Ibrahim, 2012).

Figure 3 shows the selected 18 LGAs that were most affected by farmers-herders selected. These selected LGAs in Adamawa State are: Michika, Mubi, Song, Demsa, Lamurde, and Numan, while in Gombe State the selected LGAs are: Dukku, Yamaltu-Deba, Balanga,

Billiri, and Kaltungo. Finally, in Taraba State, the selected LGAs are Ardo-Kola, Lau, Gassol, Sardauna, Takum, and Wukari. The selected LGAs were based on Northern, Central, and Southern Senatorial Districts in each of the three states.

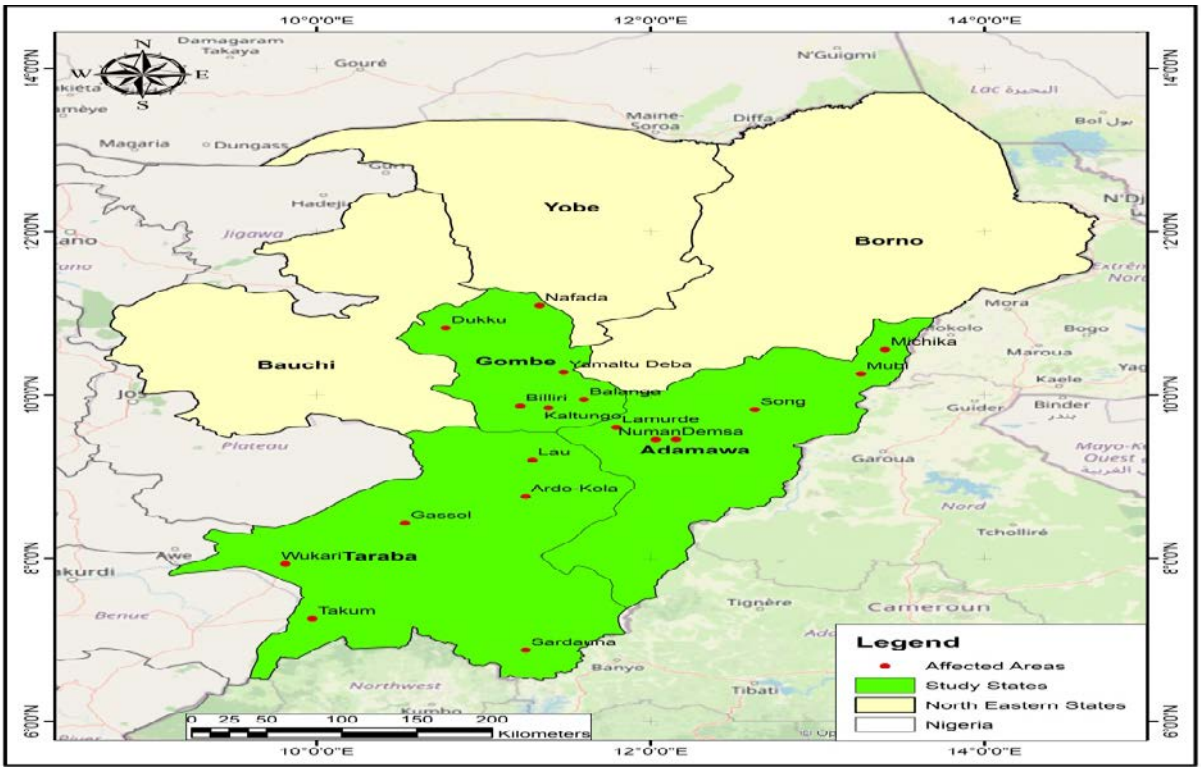


Figure 3: Map Showing the Study Area
Source: Mohammed (2024).

**Methodology**

A survey research approach was used to elicit data through multiple sources, including Focus Group Discussions (FGD), Key Informant Interviews (KII), reports from the State Emergency Management Agencies (SEMA), and supplemented by direct observations. The analytical approach employed in this study aligns with the systematic thematic and narrative analysis methodologies commonly utilized in qualitative research in social sciences as outlined by Krueger (1998a; 1998b; 2002),

The population of this study is heterogeneous. Hence, non-probability sampling will be adopted. The study therefore will use a purposive sampling method in selecting the farmers, herders, traditional rulers, Ardos, AFAN leaders, State Emergency Management Agency staff, staff of the Ministry of Agriculture and Food Security, International Committee of the Red Crescent, security agents and local civil society organizations, and lecturers. From this population, the sampling procedure will be determined and arrived at by quota and clusters.

The quota is derived from the conflicting parties and clusters for the FGD and unstructured interviews. Using purposive sampling two Local Government Areas were selected in each of the three Senatorial Districts of the selected states of Adamawa, Gombe, and Taraba.

Therefore, the FGDs were conducted in various locales, including LGA headquarters, township centres, RUGA settlements campsites, IDP camps, and strategic market days in selected areas. On average, FGDs lasted between 45 minutes to 1 hour, with a total of 18 FGDs conducted in the AGT States, each comprising eight participants, totaling 144 participants. Additionally, 48 KII interviews were conducted, resulting in a cumulative total of 192 interviews. Clusters for grouping were categorized from 1-6 for Adamawa State, 6-12 for Gombe State, and 12-18 for Taraba State.

**Socio-Demographic Characteristics of Participants**

Table 1 below illustrates the categories of participants purposefully selected and interviewed due to their positions, lived experiences, and involvements as actors or victims of the farmers-herders conflict in the study areas. These groups include leaders and representatives of the All Farmers Association (AFAN), State Ardos (Miyatti Allah leaders), community-based organizations and civil society organizations, farmers, National Emergency Management Agency (NEMA), Federal Ministry of Agriculture and Food Security (FMA&FS), herders, International Committee of the Red Cross, lecturers, police personnel, State Emergency Management Agency (SEMA), and traditional rulers. These diverse categories of participants were selected to provide comprehensive insights into various perspectives and experiences related to the farmers-herders conflict, ensuring a well-rounded understanding of the dynamics involved.

**Table 1: Distribution of categories of the participants by state**

| S/N | CATEGORIES | ADAMAWA | GOMBE | TARABA | TOTAL |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | AFAN Leaders | 1 | 1 | 1 | 3 |
| 2 | State Ardos | 1 | 1 | 1 | 3 |
| 3 | CSOs/CBOs | 2 | 2 | 2 | 6 |
| 4 | Farmers | 24 | 24 | 24 | 72 |
| 5 | NEMA Officials | 1 | 1 | 1 | 3 |
| 6 | FMA&NS Officials | 1 | 1 | 1 | 3 |
| 7 | Herders | 24 | 24 | 24 | 72 |
| 8 | ICRC Officials | 2 | 2 | 2 | 6 |
| 9 | Lecturers | 2 | 2 | 2 | 6 |
| 10 | Police Personnel | 2 | 2 | 2 | 6 |
| 11 | SEMA Officials | 1 | 1 | 1 | 3 |
| 12 | Traditional Rulers | 3 | 3 | 3 | 9 |
| | Total | 64 | 64 | 64 | 192 |

Source: Field Survey (2024).

**Presentation of Data and Analysis**

The results presented herein stem from transcribed recordings of FGDs, KIIs, field notes, and direct observations amassed over seven months of fieldwork spanning from May to December 2024. The data collected from the field survey seeks to answer the three research questions that guide the study. 1) the causes and patterns of the farmers-herders conflict, 2) the impact of the farmers-herders conflict on food security, and 3) Efforts of the government in resolving the conflicts. The data generated from the FGD and KII in the 3 selected States of Adamawa, Gombe and Taraba were from responses developed from the research questions. This is presented in Table 2.

**Table 2: The Causes and Patterns of the farmers-herders conflict in the Northeast**

| S/N | Items | Manifestations | Responses (%) |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Traditional open grazing system of cattle and trees passing into farms, causing frequent destruction of crops | Most reported cases of the conflict are attributed to open grazing and cattle tress passing into farms | 68 |
| 2 | Farmers having new farms on cattle routes that are part of normal migratory movement by herders | Due to scarcity/proximity of land, new farms were built on cattle routes | 47 |
| 3 | Search for special pastures by herders to feed their cattle for high productivity | Affected areas notice increasing pressure on specific areas with special pastures | 43 |
| 4 | An increasing prevalence of child herding is found across the affected areas | A practice becoming common among herders where underage children were tasked with grazing animals | 34 |
| | Total | | 192 |

Source: Field Survey (2024).

From Table 2, 68 participants representing 35% believe that the traditional open grazing system was the major cause of farmers-herders clashes in the northeast sub-region, while 47 participants representing 24% agreed that having farms on cattle routes was the cause of the conflict. In ensuing responses, 43 participants representing 22% believed that the search for special species of pasture should be seen to be responsible for the conflict in the areas. Finally, 34 participants representing 17% agreed that the prevalence of underage or child herding was responsible for the incessant clashes. This finding implies that the causes of

farmers-herders conflict are complex, multifaceted, and unevenly distributed across communities.

The data presented in Table 3 indicated that 69 participants representing 35% of the participants agreed that what affected food security was the displacement of the population that directly affected the manpower and talents that were lost due to the conflicts, while 56 participants representing 29% believed that the farmers-herders conflict indirectly affects food security by way of inputs and outputs. Signifying that the conflict does not allow for proper and timely application and use of inputs on the farms which negatively affects output at the end of the farming season. Moreover, 41 participants agreed that the conflict affects infrastructure and supply chains, representing 21% of participants and that lack of access to farms due to insecurity and unavailability of food affects food price and quality, with 26 participants representing 13% of responses. The implications of the conflict on food insecurity are very negative and have an overreaching impact on the nutrition and income level of the affected areas.

Table 3: The impact of the farmers-herders conflict on food security in the Northeast

| S/N | Items | Manifestations | Responses (%) |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | The direct impact of the farmers-herders conflict on food security | Displacement of the population, which affects (talents & manpower) | 69 |
| 2 | Indirect impact of the farmers-herders conflict on food security | The conflict affects inputs and outputs (investments and farm produce) and food supply chains | 56 |
| 3 | The farmers-herders conflict affects infrastructure and supply chains | Destruction of roads, warehouses and silos negatively impacts food security | 41 |
| 4 | Lack of access to farms due to insecurity and unavailability of food affects quality and prices. | The conflict influences the increase in food prices, quality and nutrition levels | 26 |
| | Total | | 192 |

Source: Field Survey (2024).

The data in Table 4 show that 65 participants representing 34% of responses agreed that deployment of security forces to the areas affected by the farmers-herders conflict was the major response and effort of the Federal Government of Nigeria. Moreover, 46 participants representing 24% of the respondents believed that the introduction of the National Livestock Transformation Plan (NLTP) was a key step taken by the Federal Government of Nigeria in

addressing the farmers-herders conflict. Similarly, 43 participants representing 22% of the respondents agreed that the Federal Government of Nigeria responded to the farmers-herders conflict by providing humanitarian assistance through NEMA. Lastly, 38 participants representing 20% of the respondents believe that the "Anti-Open Grazing Law", particularly by the Taraba State government, was the most impactful effort towards resolving the conflict. Nevertheless, the conflict persists due to poor implementation.

Table 4: The efforts of the Federal Government in resolving farmers-herders conflict in the northeast

| S/N | Items | Manifestations | Responses (%) |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Deployment of military and other security forces in conflict areas | The immediate response of the Federal Government has always been the deployment of security forces | 65 |
| 2 | Introduction of the National Livestock Transformation Plan (NLTP 2019) | It is a Federal Government initiative aimed at providing grazing reserves for livestock | 46 |
| 3 | Provision of humanitarian assistance to the affected areas through FEMA | In most cases, humanitarian assistance with food, clothes, and medicines was provided | 43 |
| 4 | Implementation of banned open grazing system by some state governments | Some states implemented anti-open grazing laws to curtail the conflicts | 38 |
| | Total | | 192 |

Source: Field Survey (2024).

**Discussion of Findings**

The farmers-herders conflict has negatively impacted food and human security in the northeast, especially in the selected States of Adamawa, Gombe, and Taraba. Results from the fieldwork indicated that the primary cause of these clashes is the traditional open grazing system, where herders trespass into farmlands and eat and destroy crops. It serves as the precipitating factor of conflict in most rural communities. This finding aligns with previous studies by the International Crisis Group (2018; 2019), Amnesty International (2017, 2018), Shettima and Tar (2008), and Ahmadu (2011).

The implications of the farmers-herders conflict on the political economy of food production and human security were severe and profound. Over 70% of the population of the affected states are farmers who depend on it for food, clothes, and income. The conflict disrupts food production and supply chains, leading to food price inflation and overall food insecurity in the region. The study revealed that conflicts between farmers and herders have drastically reduced food production in the Northeast. The sub-region is the second poorest in Nigeria despite insurgency and desertification challenges (NBS, 2019; 2023). The political economy explanation of food production is affected directly through the loss of talent and manpower and indirectly affected inputs and outputs. Displacement of population and lack of accessibility to farm fields to cultivate or harvest farm produce. This finding corroborates the study of Oruonye, Ahmed, and Fatima (2020), Human Rights Watch (2017), Adamawa State Government (2020), Okolie and Lenshie (2018), and Davidhusser and Luna (2009).

Unfortunately, the search for special species of pasture and night grazing serves as new evidence of the incessant conflict in the study areas. This phenomenon has been seen to be very rampant and has devastating effects on farming activities and communities. Moreover, under-age or child herding is becoming the norm with minors taking charge of cattle in difficult terrain and volatile environments that have suffered insurgency for nearly two decades. The region has a history of insurgency and communal violence where mere disagreement can turn into conflict within and between communities.

The Northern Regional Government in 1965 initiated one of the first attempts to respond to the herder-farmer conflict in the country. The grazing reserves gazetted large portions of land to be exclusively used by herders to rear their livestock. However, the grazing reserve system was not later supported adequately by implementation. The government was still in the process of initiating legislation to legitimise the grazing reserves before natural factors such as population growth and other related consequences like urbanisation and migration encroached on these designated areas, reducing the herders' chances of accessing the reserves. The enactment of the anti-open grazing law in Benue and Taraba State did not yield positive results in stopping the clashes.

## Conclusion

The paper examines the farmers-herders conflict and food security. It is aimed at exploring new evidence on the causes and patterns of the conflict in the Northeast, Nigeria. The conflict was situated within issues of access, competition, and control of resources such as land, water, forests, and pasture. The environmental domain served as the battleground, with different actors asserting their rights through social power and identity, impacting human and food security in the Northeast sub-region and Nigeria at large. Food insecurity is caused by the displacement of farmers and the disruption of supply chains, which ultimately affects food availability, accessibility, and prices. Therefore, the new evidence from the study suggest search for special pasture, destruction of ceremonial grass, child herding and formation ethnic militias as troubling for the security of Nigeria at large.

The findings revealed that the farmers-herders conflict is entirely a resource-based conflict exacerbated by factors such as environmental and climate change, degradation, population pressures, identity politics, and socio-economic dynamics. It identified the conflict as a low-intensity conflict. The study concluded that the farmers-herders conflict in Northeast Nigeria and beyond stemmed from the failure of successive government policies on cattle routes, poor land use, administration and ownership, water, and other agricultural resources. These policies have become sources of competition and conflict due to parochial interests, corruption, and population pressure stemming from both animals and human beings needs.

Therefore, the open grazing system that is traditional and prevalent has to be replaced by grazing reserves; child or underage herding, night grazing, and mercenary herding have become sources of conflict. The impact of the conflict on food security is multidimensional. It directly displaces talents and indirectly affects outputs. The conflict has other consequences on society, like proliferation of weapons, formation of ethnic militias and sexual abuse of women. Successive governments' failure to establish new cattle routes or harmonise existing ones resulted in controversy. The Northern Nigerian Regional Government's National Grazing Reserves Law of 1965, which established 415 cattle routes (141 gazetted in 21 States, mostly in Northern Nigeria except for Ogun and Oyo in the Southwest), needed to be revised. The Land Use Act of 1978 shifted power to the centre and state governors, politicising efforts to establish cattle colonies and the RUGA policy in 2018 and 2019 in Nigeria.

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# GOVERNANCE AND SECURITY SECTOR REFORM IN NIGERIA: TOWARD HUMAN SECURITY AND RESILIENT PEACE

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**Abstract.** The Nigerian security architecture comprises various security agencies, including the Nigerian Police Force, the Nigerian Armed Forces (NAF), the State Security Service (SSS), and the Nigerian Security and Civil Defense Corps (NSCDC). Despite these agencies, the state of security in the country remains poor, throwing the credibility of this security into public scrutiny (Okeke, 2021). Previous governments have made efforts to address this insecurity through increased budgetary allocations and the establishment of new structures like the Livestock Development Ministry, the Special Anti-Robbery Squad (SARS), and the Community Policing Policy; yet, the security situation in Nigeria continues to deteriorate. Considering the above, one keeps pondering the reason for the failure of security agencies in providing the needed security in the country. Can insecurity in Nigeria be attributed to institutional failure? Or is it due to the corrupt nature of the security personnel? What is the political will in fighting insecurity in the state? The objective of this study was to examine the current security structures and their challenges in order to ameliorate them in the state. Content analysis was adopted as the methodology, using secondary sources of data from textbooks, journal articles, documentaries, and the internet. This study concentrated on Nigeria's security challenges and reform efforts with emphasis on Human Security and Resilient Peace. The study utilized Structural Functional Theory, which provided insights into the institutions, functions, and the relationships between them. This study discovered that corruption, insufficient funding, infrastructural deficit, lack of training, politicization of the security sector, mandate overlapping, and lack of intelligence gathering are perceived as worsening conditions of insecurity in Nigeria. This study therefore recommends restructuring the security architecture in the country; increased funding; improved surveillance and intelligence gathering through procurement of internet gadgets and ICT-enabled technology; improved accountability and oversight functions; and inter-agency cooperation among security agencies and the community.

**Keywords:** Governance, security sector reform, human security, resilient peace

## Introduction

The traditional roles of any responsible government in any society are to ensure the peace and well-being of the people because nations and people find meaning in their livelihood only when they are assured of their security (Kupoluyi & Nwogwugwu, 2015). Similarly, Imobighe (2003) avers that, without security, individuals within a state find it difficult to engage in productive activities, and such a state is bound to experience greater difficulties in harnessing human and material resources towards meaningful development and the promotion of the general well-being of their people. The internal security of a nation is important in attracting foreign investments as well as promoting nation-building and national development (Nwogwugwu & Odedina, 2018).

Nigeria's security landscape is complex and multifaceted, with many security challenges that threaten stability and hamper development. Nigeria’s security sector is a critical component of the country's governance structure, and its effectiveness helps address the security challenges the state faces. Nigeria’s security sector includes institutions such as the military, law enforcement agencies, intelligence agencies, correctional institutions, and other entities responsible for ensuring security in the state (OECD, 2007). There are four statutory security intelligence agencies in Nigeria, including the State Security Service (SSS), the Defense Intelligence Agency, the Nigerian Intelligence Agency (NIA), and the Force Intelligence Bureau (FIB), with specified tasks defined by the laws that established them (OECD, 2007). The agencies usually perform coordinated activities that aim to provide adequate security to ensure the safety of lives and property. The existing channels of coordination between these agencies are the Joint Intelligence Board and the Office of the National Security Adviser (Arase, 2013). These security agencies have different responsibilities relating to intelligence generation about internal security, defense, and external subversion, respectively.

The State Security Service is in charge of protecting government officials and property and also gathers vital domestic intelligence. In contrast, the defense intelligence agencies protect Nigeria's territorial sovereignty and cooperate with military allies to foster regional and global security. The Nigeria National Intelligence Agency is in charge of external intelligence, while the Force Intelligence Bureau was established to gather intelligence for the Department of Police on criminal activities (Caleb, 2024).

The lead agency for countering terrorism in Nigeria is the Office of the National Security Adviser, whose roles have been politicized by forces of Religion and ethnicity, which has made it difficult to gather intelligence information in the country. There have been a series of policies on security sector reforms in Nigeria since the Country’s independence. However, insecurity is still not a thing of the past, meaning these problems are still being experienced in the state. The recent policy framework for community and state policing proposes a clear division of responsibilities between federal and state Police Forces; a policy that supposedly devolved more powers and encourages community engagement and a community-based

approach to security matters is yet to generate any positive result, as people can see the worsening security situation in the country.

The Security challenges in Nigeria are multifaceted and complex which include Boko Haram, banditry and insurgency in the Northeast, and the group's ability to launch coordinated assaults, widespread kidnappings, armed robbery and violence act perpetrated by criminal gangs, farmers/herders crisis often resulting to violence and displacements, frequent abduction of students and teachers in both secondary and tertiary institutions in the country as witnessed in Borno, Oyo and many other states in the country highlights the need for increased investment in security personnel and infrastructure for the security of the country (Okeke, 2021). The Nigerian security architecture comprises various security agencies, including the Nigerian Police Force, the Nigerian Armed Forces (NAF), the State Security Service (SSS), and the Nigerian Security and Civil Defense Corps (NSCDC). Despite the presence of these numerous security agencies, the state of security in Nigeria remains poor because politics, ethnicity, and religion have fragmented the security architecture and subjected these outfits to public scrutiny (Okeke, 2021). Insufficient funding and institutionalized corruption in the sector undermined the effectiveness of these agencies, consequently eroding public trust and reducing their capacity to perform their duties.

Previous governments have made efforts to address the security challenges of the state through increased budgetary allocations for the security sector, the establishment of new structures like the Livestock Development Ministry, and the launch of initiatives like the National Commission for Almajiri and Out-of-School Children Education. In 2014, President Goodluck Jonathan signed and launched Nigeria’s first-ever National Security Strategy, which served as the overarching national strategy document in framing the country’s pursuit of its national security. Nigeria’s security service was presented as a framework for a holistic and more coordinated approach and response to security challenges in the country. The development of the 2014 National Security Strategy was to organize, guide, and harmonize national security policies and efforts. The policy identified key security issues and assigned roles and responsibilities to government, civil society organizations, private agencies, and individuals. The 2014 National Security Strategy acknowledged the limitations of time and space and therefore emphasized the issues that were important to the security and existence of Nigeria as a nation. The National Security Strategy documents were to be reviewed after a period of five to ten years to bring them up to date with the realities of the time. Despite all these, the problems of insecurity persist in Nigeria, which calls for scholarly attention.

The previous study on Security Sector Reforms did not give much attention to the use of scientific gadget and surveillance but devoted much time to physical monitoring of the community which considering the large geographical land mass with dominance of ungoverned spaces in the country, the study could not adequately address security issues in the country and one ponders on what is the reason for the failure of security agencies in providing the needed security in the country? Can insecurity in the country be attributed to institutional failure? Or is it due to the corrupt nature of the security personnel? What is the

political will on the part of Nigerian leadership in fighting insecurity in the state? The objective of this study was to draw Nigeria's reform trajectory and examine the current security structures and their challenges in order to ameliorate the security problems in the state.

The methodology adopted in the study was such that secondary sources of data were utilized, which included the review of related literature on policy documents and reports on security sector reform in Nigeria (Ebo & Olukolade, 2022). Secondary data were sourced from textbooks, journal articles, documentaries, and internet sources. This study concentrated on Nigerians' security challenges and reform efforts, with emphasis on human security and resilient peace, and acknowledged potential biases in data collection and analysis, as well as limitations in accessing sensitive security information for this study.

## Conceptual clarification

### Governance

Governance refers to the system of rules, practices, and processes by which an organization or state is directed and controlled. It involves decision-making, accountability, transparency, and the exercise of power to achieve goals and serve the interests of stakeholders (Anifowoso, 1999). Governance is about how things are run, managed, and led to ensure accountability, fairness, and responsiveness to the people or stakeholders involved. It means the administration of security policies and the political will of political leaders in promoting peace and stability in a state.

### Security Sector Reform (SSR)

Security Sector Reform is a process aimed at improving the effectiveness, accountability, and transparency of a country's security institutions, such as the military, police, and intelligence agencies. These activities involve strengthening security agencies to improve their capacity and ensuring professionalism and oversight (OECD, 2007). This also involves increasing openness and transparency in these agencies' actions to build trust so they can act responsibly in decision-making, tackling issues like corruption and human rights abuses in the state (UNDP, 2019). The goal of security sector reforms is to create a more secure, stable, and democratic environment where security institutions and personnel can serve the people diligently without prejudice (Olugbenga, 2022).

### Human Security

Human security is about protecting individuals and communities from threats like violence, poverty, and disease. It is a people-centered approach that focuses on safeguarding people from harm, conflict, and crises; creating an enabling environment for individuals to make

choices and live safely; and ensuring that basic human rights and needs are met (Adamu, 2023). This covers aspects like personal security, economic security, food security, health security, and environmental security. The above conception is in line with the submission of Mbachu & Eze (2017), who posit that holistic security has to go beyond just state or national security but to individual well-being in the state.

**Resilient Peace**

Resilient peace refers to a sustained and lasting peace that can withstand shocks, stresses, and challenges. Resilient peace is said to be when a society is created that is equipped to manage conflicts, prevent violence, and promote stability even in the face of adversities or multi-ethnicities and religious differences, as the case in Nigeria (United Nations, 2018). According to the United Nations report, resilient peace is a lasting peace. It can be achieved through creating a just society that regulates itself for the peace and stability of that society. The key elements of resilient peace include governments' conduct, which ensures that all voices are heard and valued, and the building of robust and accountable institutions that can foster trust, understanding, and unity among communities, promote economic opportunities, and reduce inequality. Resilient peace is not just the absence of violence but a positive and dynamic state of peace that is built to last.

**Theoretical Framework**

This article is anchored in structural-functionalist theory, which was developed from systems theory. According to Almond, the functional approach identified structures and the functions associated with them within the political system, classified into input and output (Almond, 2001). The theory provides a comprehensive analytical tool for understanding the institutions and their roles in a political system. Structural functionalism is a sociological theory that views society as a complex system with interconnected structures and institutions that work together to maintain social order and stability.

In the context of governance and security sector reforms in Nigeria, structural functionalism provides insight into the institutions of governance, their functions, and the relationships between these institutions (Parsons, 1951). Social structure refers to the patterns of social relationships and institutions that shape society. In contrast, functions refer to the roles and purposes that institutions and structures serve in maintaining social order and stability. Dysfunction, as identified with the theory, refers to the negative consequences that occur when institutions or structures fail to perform their functions effectively (Agarwa, 2009).

However, this theory has been criticized over the years by various theorists for being unable to account for social change, such that it attempts to describe social institutions solely through their effects and does not explain the causes of these effects. Despite these criticisms, the theory still has relevance to the understanding of the roles, structures, and functions of

political institutions in political systems. The theory is relevant to this study by virtue of its theoretical construct, which emphasizes the functions of institutions and enables one to understand the positive roles they play in the maintenance of social order and control in the state. The various institutions in Nigeria's governance and security sectors are interdependent, interwoven, and complementary to each other, meaning that the function of one institution affects the others (Anifowose, 1999).

In applying structural-functional theory in this study, the security governance institutions in Nigeria are the Police Force, the Military, the Nigeria Security and Civil Defense Corps, State Intelligence Agencies, and the arms of government responsible for policy formulation, implementation, and adjudication, which are interdependent. The dysfunctional nature of these institutions has plagued Nigeria with serious security weaknesses, which have contributed to the country's security challenges in contemporary Nigeria. Nigeria's governance and security challenges are systemic and deeply ingrained in the country's institutions and structures. The failure of one is directly linked to the failure of the other institutions. To address these challenges, there is a need for a comprehensive approach that involves reforming and strengthening institutions (Anifowose, 1999). By applying a structural functionalist perspective, policymakers can better understand the complex relationships between institutions and structures in Nigeria's governance and security sectors. This can help identify areas for reform and develop effective strategies to address governance and security challenges in the country.

**Nigeria's Current Security Structure and Challenges**

Nigeria's security structure comprises various security agencies, including the Nigerian Police Force, the Nigerian Armed Forces (NAF), the State Security Service (SSS), and the Nigerian Security and Civil Defense Corps (NSCDC). Despite these numerous security agencies in the country, the state of security remains poor because politics, ethnicity, and religion have fragmented the security architecture and thrown the credibility of these outfits into public scrutiny. Insufficient funding and institutionalized corruption in the security sector undermine the effectiveness of these agencies and erode public trust, reducing their capacity to perform their constitutional duties.

In the area of human rights abuses, inadequate security and corruption have led to human rights abuses and impunity, which have caused humanitarian crises in the country. Security personnel also lacked necessary training and equipment to address modern security challenges, which has made it possible for bandits to carry out their attacks on soft targets, including places of worship and business premises. There is a problem of mandate overlaps among security agencies in the country, which caused confusion and power struggles among the agencies. The structural defects have made the Boko Haram sect grow increasingly active and deadly in their attacks against state and civilian targets in Nigeria (Blanchard, 2016). Most terrorism-related attacks in the country are a result of a lack of coordination and cooperation between security agencies.

Corruption, misallocation of resources, limited requisite databases, the slow pace of the judicial system, and insufficient training for prosecutors and judges to implement anti-terrorism laws have promoted insecurity in the country. The criticisms about the slow and reactive responses of internal security agencies to the Boko Haram insurgency and banditry in the country are a result of the failure on the part of the government to muster reasonable effort to protect innocent citizens (Bello, 2012). Lack of coordination among the security agencies is a major problem in the functioning of these agencies. Osumah (2013) maintains that poor coordination between police and intelligence forces across the country has led to a widespread belief that the current internal security institutions are not functioning as expected.

The Nigerian security forces at present do not appear to be in a position to defeat terrorists and kidnappers. This is in line with the submission of Amaraegbu (2013), who avers that the roadblocks, token arrests, and reactive soldiers in Nigeria neither frighten Boko Haram nor kidnappers and armed robbers with superior firepower. Complicating the issue, there is a high degree of politicization of the security sector in the country. Osumah (2013) added that security issues have allegedly been manipulated by the Nigerian ruling elite at various levels of government to allow them to set aside huge sums of money as security votes, often subjected to abuse. Nigeria's effort to defeat Boko Haram has not yielded the expected results despite allocating huge resources to the sector to fight the insurgency in the state.

Corruption is also a major problem in the security sector and has manifested in the country. To shed more light, the Nigerian government has arrested several former senior officials on corruption charges, including former President Jonathan's National Security Advisor, who was charged with fraud over a $2 billion arms deal for equipment that was reportedly never delivered to the government (Amaraegbu, 2013). Jonathan's former chief of defense has also been alleged to have stolen $20 million and an estimated $240 million in fraudulent overpaid defense contracts (Amaraegbu, 2013).

There has been weak intelligence capacity in the country. Confirming this, the former president of Nigeria, Goodluck Jonathan, once maintained that Nigeria's security and intelligence community under his watch lacked the required intelligence capacity to carry out their basic duty of identifying enemies of state because some of the Boko Haram members are in the Executive Arm of Government, some in the Legislative Arm, while some are even in the Judiciary. He stated further that some are also in the Armed Forces, the Police and other security agencies (Amaraegbu, 2013). With the above, Boko Haram operates undetected because the residents do not trust the government to offer intelligence information or to provide information to security operatives about the hideouts and activities of the sect members. After all, mistrust and suspicious relationships characterize security operatives and civilian populations in the volatile states. All of these undermine intelligence and undertakings that would lead to the identification and arrest of these bandits. There is constitutional misalignment between federal command of the police and state-level accountability demands; there is limited civilian oversight capacity, and the security outfit in

Nigeria is fragmented and politicized. Weak disciplinary systems and complaint mechanisms, lack of forensics, and case management gaps undermine prosecution in the country.

**Nigeria's Policies on Security Sector Reforms in Nigeria (ONSA)**

Security policies are documents that spell out the rules, approaches, or strategic stance in building structures and repositioning them for effective performance. Well-designed and implemented security policies are indispensable tools for any security program in a state. Nigeria's policies on security sector reform aim to enhance human security and resilient peace, including key aspects like strengthening the Office of the National Security Adviser to coordinate security agencies effectively with emphasis on human security, institutional building, and accountability to enhance citizens' safety (Adamu, 2023). The policy aims to overhaul deployment systems to prioritize corps members' safety, including risk assessments and improved insurance coverage. These policies aim to address security challenges like insurgency, banditry, and cybercrime. The policies aim to strengthen institutions for accountability and coordination among security agencies (United Nations Development Program 2023).

The focus is on intelligence integration, crisis management, and inter-agency collaboration that can encourage local communities to take ownership of security and integrate ex-offenders into the national social register, and to provide support for vulnerable populations such as surveillance systems and Artificial Intelligence-powered solutions to enhance security operations, strengthen the justice system, improve investigation and prosecution, and address corruption issues in the state (Olugbenga, 2022). The government has also increased budgetary allocations for the security sector and established new structures like the Livestock Development Ministry and launched initiatives like the National Commission for Almajiri and Out-of-School Children Education.

Similarly, President Goodluck Jonathan signed and launched Nigeria's first-ever National Security Strategy in 2014, which served as the overarching national strategy document in framing the country's pursuit of its national security. Nigeria's Security Service was presented as a framework for a holistic and more coordinated approach and response to security challenges in the country. The development of the 2014 National Security Strategy was to organize, guide, and harmonize national security policies and efforts. The policy identified key security issues and assigned roles and responsibilities to government, civil society organizations, private agencies, and individuals. The 2014 National Security Strategy acknowledged the limitations of time and space and therefore emphasized the issues that were important to the security and existence of Nigeria as a nation. The National Security Strategy documents were to be reviewed after a period of five to ten years to bring them up to date with the realities of the time.

**The Security Sector Reform: Building Trust, Ensuring Stability in Nigeria**

Nigeria has been grappling with security challenges which call for reforms in the security sector. Security sector reform is broadly seen as a strategy for strengthening the effectiveness and accountability of security actors under democratic control, enabling them to deliver human security and offer a pathway to durable political and economic stability in the state. The scope of the security sector in Nigeria includes, among others, the Armed Forces, Police, State Security Service, Correctional Services, Border and Maritime Security, Parliamentary and Executive oversight bodies, and non-state actors. The principles that govern the reforms concern democratic governance, effectiveness and efficiency in security administration, accountability and transparency, civil society participation, and community ownership.

**The Police Force and Community Policing**

The Police Force has many functions which include, among others, maintaining public order and preventing breaches of peace in compliance with laws. These institutions handle crowd control, manage public events, and intervene in disputes. They also prevent crimes through patrols, investigations, and intelligence gathering to obtain evidence to apprehend suspects (Akinwumi, 2018). The police also protect citizens' lives, properties, and rights through quick responses to emergencies, provide security, and safeguard vulnerable groups in society. The Police also enforce traffic laws, manage road safety, and regulate traffic flow by handling accidents, and promote road safety awareness to promote an accident-free road. The Police also engage communities to build trust and collaborate on safety measures and initiatives to help prevent crime and address local concerns, especially crimes rooted in the community. The work is done through intelligence gathering and analyzing information to prevent or apprehend those involved in crimes. The Police Force identifies threats, profiles suspects, and takes necessary actions.

The Nigerian Police Force has introduced community policing initiatives to build trust and foster cooperation between law enforcement agencies and the public. Efforts have also been made to improve police training that focuses on modern policing techniques, human rights, and ethics (Buzan et al., 1998). The internal mechanisms to monitor and discipline officers involved in corrupt practices have also been strengthened. There is also a growing consensus on the need for state policing to address unique security challenges in the country, which the state stands to benefit much from. However, police brutality and extortion, and corruption both on the road, in stations, and in the markets remain significant challenges with many Police officers.

Under the Military, their official roles include, among others, territorial defense, internal security, counter-terrorism, peacekeeping, disaster relief, and support to civil authorities. These functions are outlined in Sections 217 to 220 of the 1999 Constitution as amended (Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria1999). The key responsibilities include,

among other things, protecting Nigeria's sovereignty, territorial integrity, and national interests, as well as maintaining law and order.

The Nigeria Air Force protects Nigeria's airspace from external threats like unauthorized aircraft or missiles, using fighter jets, radar systems, and air defense units to secure the skies. They also support ground and naval operations with air power, like providing cover for troops. The NAF also gathers intelligence information through aerial surveillance using planes or drones to monitor borders, identify threats, and support operations. It also airlifts troops, equipment, and supplies to support military operations and humanitarian missions. It also conducts search and rescue missions for personnel in distress. It provides aid during natural disasters like floods, earthquakes, or wildfires to help with evacuation and relief supplies.

The Nigerian military faces challenges in addressing insecurity, particularly in the Northeast, and requires reforms to improve its effectiveness. To this end, the military introduced reforms aimed at improving professionalism and accountability, including monitoring borders, conducting patrols, and responding to security breaches. The Army supports civil authorities like the police in maintaining law and order, especially during emergencies or civil unrest. They help manage protests, contain violence, and restore order in society. They conduct operations to secure communities, rescue hostages, and disrupt militant activities. They also participate in infrastructure projects like building roads, bridges, and schools, especially in remote areas, through community development initiatives.

The Nigeria Security and Civil Defense Corps is responsible for maintaining peace and order and protecting the lives and property of citizens. The agency secures critical infrastructure like oil pipelines, power plants, and public facilities to prevent vandalism and ensure national security (Mbachu & Eze, 2017). They also assist police and other agencies in maintaining law and order, especially in emergencies or large-scale disturbances. Recent reforms in the sector focused on improving the welfare of personnel, training, and equipping them. There is also more community engagement to promote safety awareness, resolve conflicts, and build trust between citizens and security agencies to safeguard economic assets like oil facilities, forests, and wildlife for national development.

## Findings

### Corruption and Lack of Political Will by the Leadership in Nigeria

In the course of this study, it has been revealed that corruption and resource disparities among states are perceived to be challenges to the successful implementation of state policing in Nigeria. Insufficient funding and institutionalized corruption in the security sector undermined the effectiveness of security agencies and eroded public trust, reducing their capacity to perform their duties. In the area of Human Rights abuses, inadequate security and

corruption have led to human rights abuses and impunity, which caused humanitarian crises in the country.

Corruption, misallocation of resources, limited requisite databases, a slow judicial system, and insufficient training for prosecutors and judges have been found to have promoted insecurity in the country. This is in line with the thinking of Bello (2012), who maintains that the criticisms about the slow and reactive responses of internal security agencies to the Boko Haram insurgency and banditry in the country are due mainly to the failure on the part of the government to muster reasonable effort to protect innocent citizens.

**Weakness Of Security Institutions and Shortage of Security Personnel in Nigeria**

The study highlighted the ineffectiveness of traditional security institutions in addressing the country's security challenges. The inadequate security infrastructure and pathetic security situation in Nigeria's police-to-citizen ratio of 1:650, with about 370,000 police officers, is far below the United Nations' recommended standard of 1:450 (Egbetokun, 2025), and is another reason for the non-performance of the police force in the country. The state of security remains poor because there is a shortage of human and material resources. It has also been found that the security personnel also lacked necessary training and equipment to address modern security challenges, softening the ground for bandits to carry out their attacks on soft targets, including places of worship and business centers.

**Politicization of Security Institutions in Nigeria**

Politics, ethnicity, and religion have been found to have fragmented the security architecture and thrown the credibility of these security agencies into public scrutiny. Recruitment in the sector has been politicized, using it for political compensation, thereby compromising the security of the state. To buttress the discoveries further, Osumah (2013) added that security issues have allegedly been manipulated by the Nigerian ruling elite at various levels of government to allow them to set aside huge sums of money as security votes, which are often subject to abuse.

**Lack of Collaboration among Security Agencies and Community Members**

There is a problem of mandate overlap among security agencies in the state, which has caused confusion and power struggle among the agencies. The structural defects and non-collaborative effort have softened the ground for the Boko Haram sect to grow increasingly active and deadly in their attacks against state and civilian targets in Nigeria. This finding agrees with Blanchard (2016), who stated that most terrorist attacks in Nigeria are mainly due to a lack of coordination and cooperation between security agencies. Community members are discovered to be willing to cooperate with the bandits for their immediate safety since the security come and go. The findings show that unhealthy rivalry among security agencies did

not allow a smooth relationship that could have encouraged effective intelligence gathering to combat crimes and fight insecurity in Nigeria.

**Lack of Intelligence Gathering and Sharing in Nigeria**

The findings in the study revealed that the current level of intelligence gathering in Nigeria is not developed and has aggravated insecurity in the country. The present level of intelligence gathering has aided insecurity since there are insufficient human and material resources that could be effectively deployed in the country. Nigeria is obviously yet to fully benefit from intelligence gathering, which can reduce insecurity.

**Conclusion**

In conclusion, it is not erroneous to state that the prevalence of insecurity in Nigeria is worsened by a lack of effective reform measures that could have improved the performance of security personnel in the country. The study highlights the need for civilian oversight and control over the security sector to ensure accountability and effectiveness. This study identified overconcentration and excessive control of security at the center, corruption, and inadequate funding as significant challenges to the security sector in Nigeria. Nigeria's security sector truly requires comprehensive reforms that would enhance the effectiveness of agencies and promote coordination to address security issues in the state. The study strongly aligns with the proposition that effective intelligence gathering can safeguard citizens' lives and property and therefore supports the proposition that a well-designed national security policy would promote and encourage foreign investment in the state.

**Recommendations**

This study therefore recommends restructuring the security sector to enhance coordination, effectiveness, and accountability, and to promote the initiative of community policing. There should be specialized units that promote trust-building. There should be sub-national security outfits known as state-sponsored outfits to fill the gaps in the highly centralized security outfit in Nigeria. Government needs to promote community engagement to enhance trust and cooperation between security agencies and communities, improving intelligence sharing and community engagement.

There should be increased funding in the security sector to support the agencies' operations and capacity building through training and retraining to sustain the capacity of security personnel. The security personnel need to be provided with necessary training and equipment, support, and reinforcement capacity to address modern security challenges. Additional police officers are needed to meet the United Nations' standard.

There should be improved surveillance and a need for human intelligence to monitor the activities and operations of criminal groups in the state. Intelligence gathering and sharing among security operatives would go a long way toward securing the lives and property of citizens. There is a need for a national database and sustained identity management for all and sundry. There should be capacity building of security that focuses on enhancing the skills, knowledge, and capabilities of security personnel through training and professional development to keep them updated with ICT knowledge for effective performance.

To ensure and promote institutional transparency and accountability, there should be budget disclosure and transparency in procurement processes and auditing to allow for accountability in the sector. The unnecessary bureaucratic processes in the procurement of military wares and the training of troops should be deliberately avoided. The anti-corruption measures need to be implemented to enhance transparency and accountability in the activities of security agencies in the state.

Inter-agency cooperation should be encouraged among security agencies. Recruitment of Intelligence personnel must not be politicized but based on merit and technical expertise because of the sensitive nature of the assignments. A new policy framework is needed that can decentralize policing in the country, including legal measures that allow federal agencies to collaborate with state-level security outfits to create a more coordinated and effective security system in the state. Reform is needed to enhance citizen-centered security to improve the effectiveness of security in Nigeria. A complete overhaul of the security agencies in Nigeria is needed to procure ICT-enabled technology that will assist in effective intelligence gathering and usage.

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# WOMEN PEACEBUILDERS IN MEDIATION EFFORTS: CHALLENGES AND PATHWAYS FOR INCLUSION IN TARABA STATE

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**Abstract.** This paper examines women peacebuilders in mediation efforts: challenges and pathways for inclusion in Taraba State, with particular focus on the structural, cultural, and institutional mechanisms that determine the politics of women's inclusion in formal and informal mediation systems. The study adopts Conflict Transformation Theory as its analytical framework, operationalizing Lederach's four dimensions personal, relational, structural, and cultural to examine the specific barriers and enabling mechanisms that govern women's access to, and influence within, mediation structures in the state. Methodologically, the study draws on a systematic review of primary and secondary literature, policy documents, and empirical evidence from conflict-affected communities in Taraba State, triangulated with documented case studies of women's mediation practice in the region. The analysis demonstrates that women's exclusion from formal mediation is not incidental but is structurally reproduced through patriarchal institutional designs, gendered resource asymmetries, security vulnerabilities, and weak policy enforcement, each operating across the personal, relational, structural, and cultural dimensions of conflict systems in the state. Conversely, women's informal peace agency expressed through grassroots dialogue facilitation, cross-ethnic market networks, and faith-based reconciliation reveals how women transform relational and cultural conflict dynamics even in the absence of formal inclusion. The study argues that institutionalizing women's mediation roles is both a gender equity imperative and a strategic requirement for durable peace, as the mechanisms through which women engage in conflict relational trust-building, inclusive agenda-setting, and community embeddedness directly address the relational and cultural transformation deficits that formal male-dominated processes consistently fail to resolve. Recommendations are organized across state, community, and informal mediation levels, providing a context-specific intervention framework linked to identified causal barriers.

**Keywords:** Women peacebuilders, local conflict mediation, politics of inclusion, Conflict Transformation Theory, Taraba State, Nigeria, Women Peace and Security

## Introduction

Taraba State, located in Nigeria's North-Eastern region, has experienced recurring cycles of violent conflicts since its creation in 1991. These conflicts are driven by intersecting structural forces including ethnic competition between indigenous and settler communities, farmer-herder clashes intensified by climate-induced resource scarcity, political contestations over local government autonomy, and the proliferation of small arms that sustains cycles of retaliatory violence (Daura, Ibrahim, & Mohammed, 2024; Adebayo & Olaniyan, 2020). The humanitarian consequences have been severe: displacement, destruction of livelihoods, erosion of inter-communal trust, and the systematic targeting of women through sexual and gender-based violence (Ibrahim & Salihu, 2021). However, the analytical problem this study addresses is not conflict per se, but rather the paradox embedded in Taraba State's mediation architecture: the very actors' women whose relational capital, community embeddedness, and trans-ethnic networks are most directly implicated in the informal prevention and de-escalation of violence, are simultaneously the most systematically excluded from the formal mediation structures in which durable peace agreements are negotiated and institutionalised.

This paradox has a clearly identifiable analytical core: women's exclusion from formal mediation in Taraba State is not simply a cultural residue of patriarchal tradition, but is structurally reproduced through a politics of inclusion that operates across institutional, normative, and security dimensions. The concept of the 'politics of inclusion' as used in this study refers to the organized patterns of gatekeeping, symbolic representation, and structural displacement through which formal mediation systems grant or deny substantive access to women, irrespective of their demonstrated peacebuilding capacity. Understanding how this politics of inclusion operates and under what conditions it can be transformed is the central analytical problem of the study. This framing moves beyond the common descriptive observation that women are underrepresented in peace processes, toward an explanatory account of the mechanisms that produce and sustain that underrepresentation, and the counter-mechanisms through which women's agency challenges it.

The theoretical anchor for this analysis is Conflict Transformation Theory, as developed by Lederach (1995, 2003) and extended by Ramsbotham, Woodhouse, and Miall (2022). The theory provides a multi-dimensional framework for examining conflict not as a discrete event to be managed but as a structural and relational condition to be transformed through simultaneous engagement with its personal, relational, structural, and cultural dimensions. Applied to women's mediation roles in Taraba State, the theory enables the identification of both the specific transformation deficits that women's exclusion produces, particularly at the relational and cultural levels, and the potential transformation contributions that inclusive mediation systems could generate. The paper is organized as follows: a conceptual review of women peacebuilders in conflict-affected societies; a theoretical section that operationalizes Conflict Transformation Theory for the study context; an analytical section examining gendered exclusion mechanisms and women's informal peace agency; and a conclusion with

a context-specific intervention framework organized across state, community, and informal mediation levels.

## Conceptualizing Women Peacebuilders in Conflict-Affected Societies

### Global Foundations: Women, Agency, and Peacebuilding

The conceptual construction of women as peacebuilders has undergone significant evolution in the international peace and security literature, moving from early framings that positioned women primarily as victims of conflict to more agentic perspectives that recognize women as strategic actors in conflict prevention, management, and transformation. Tickner (2019) argues that this shift reflects a broader feminist reconceptualization of security, challenging the androcentric assumptions of mainstream international relations theory and centering the gendered dimensions of both conflict and peace. At the global level, the landmark adoption of United Nations Security Council Resolution 1325 in 2000 institutionalized the normative case for women's participation in all aspects of peace and security, establishing the international legal scaffolding through which subsequent national and regional frameworks have been developed (United Nations, 2023). The global evidence base consistently demonstrates that women's substantive participation in formal peace processes increases the durability of peace agreements, broadens the agenda to include humanitarian, transitional justice, and social reconciliation concerns, and strengthens the local legitimacy of mediated settlements (Council on Foreign Relations, 2024).

Theoretically, the field has moved toward understanding women's peacebuilding through the lens of social capital and relational agency. Putnam (2020) and Varshney (2021) demonstrate that women often maintain cross-cutting social networks that bridge ethnic and religious divides, providing the inter-communal communication infrastructure through which conflict escalation can be interrupted. Women's bridging capital the network ties that span group boundaries represents a structurally significant peacebuilding resource that formal male-dominated mediation systems systematically fail to leverage. Paffenholz (2020) identifies protection, monitoring, socialization, and facilitation as the four key functions that women's civil society actors perform in peacebuilding, arguing that the absence of women from formal processes creates functional deficits in peace architectures that cannot be compensated for by technical diplomatic competence alone. The synthesis of these global conceptual foundations establishes that the question of women's inclusion in mediation is not merely normative but structural: exclusion produces measurable deficits in peacebuilding outcomes.

### African Contexts: Institutional Barriers and Women's Informal Peace Agency

Across conflict-affected societies in Africa, women peacebuilders have operated at the intersection of powerful structural constraints and remarkable informal agency, navigating patriarchal institutional architectures while building the relational foundations of peace

through grassroots engagement. The African Union's (2023) continental framework on women, peace, and security recognizes this dual reality, acknowledging that while African women have played pivotal roles in post-conflict reconstruction and inter-communal reconciliation, they remain systematically excluded from formal peace negotiations, ceasefire agreements, and post-conflict governance structures. Research on women's mediation roles in Kenya, Liberia, South Sudan, and the Democratic Republic of Congo reveals a consistent pattern: women are disproportionately active in the informal and community-based dimensions of peacebuilding, yet their contributions are rarely translated into formal institutional recognition or influence (African Union, 2023; Mercy Corps, 2025).

The Liberian experience, in which women's peace coalitions played a decisive role in pressuring warring factions into the 2003 Accra Peace Agreement, is frequently cited as exemplifying the transformative potential of organized women's peace agency (Adeyemi & Ogundele, 2023). However, subsequent scholarship has cautioned against romanticizing this example, noting that Liberian women's post-agreement political marginalization demonstrates that informal peace influence does not automatically translate into formal institutional inclusion. Chinonso and Ibrahim (2022) argue that for African women peacebuilders, the central challenge is not demonstrating peacebuilding capacity, which is well-evidenced across contexts, but achieving institutional recognition of that capacity within formal mediation architectures that are structurally designed to reproduce male authority. This distinction between demonstrated informal agency and denied formal recognition is analytically central to understanding women's peacebuilding roles in Taraba State.

**Nigerian Context: Gender, Conflict, and Mediation Systems**

In Nigeria, women peacebuilders operate within a complex institutional landscape shaped by the interaction of statutory governance frameworks, customary law systems, traditional governance structures, and faith-based institutions, each carrying distinct and often contradictory implications for gender inclusion in conflict mediation. UN Women (2021) documents that despite Nigeria's adoption of a National Action Plan on UNSCR 1325, women remain severely underrepresented in formal state-level peace institutions, security sector governance, and the traditional emirate and chieftaincy councils that dominate community-level mediation across northern Nigeria. The institutional architecture of Nigerian mediation systems, particularly in the Middle Belt and North-East where Taraba State is situated, reflects the consolidation of male authority across both statutory and customary governance channels, creating compounding layers of exclusion that are difficult to address through single-track interventions.

At the grassroots level, however, Nigerian women have developed sophisticated informal mediation practices that leverage their social capital, cross-ethnic market networks, and maternal authority to interrupt conflict escalation and facilitate reconciliation. Mercy Corps (2025) documents how women's peace groups in Borno, Plateau, and Taraba States have served as early warning networks, inter-ethnic confidence-building platforms, and

psychosocial support systems for conflict-affected communities. These informal mediation roles are not supplementary to formal peace processes. However, they are often their most functionally effective dimension, particularly in rural and peri-urban communities where state mediation institutions are absent or distrusted. The conceptual synthesis across global, African, and Nigerian contexts therefore establishes a clear analytical framework: women peacebuilders in Taraba State are simultaneously constrained by a politics of institutional exclusion and empowered by a politics of informal agency, and the central question for this study is how the mechanisms governing these two dynamics can be identified, analyzed, and transformed.

**Theoretical Framework: Conflict Transformation Theory**

This study is anchored in Conflict Transformation Theory, pioneered by John Paul Lederach (1995, 2003) and subsequently elaborated by Ramsbotham, Woodhouse, and Miall (2022). The theory represents a paradigmatic shift from conflict resolution and management frameworks that prioritize settlement of discrete disputes, toward a transformative orientation that targets the underlying personal, relational, structural, and cultural conditions that generate and sustain violent conflict. Lederach (2003) argues that sustainable peace cannot emerge from negotiated agreements alone but requires the transformation of the social fabric within which conflict is embedded, including the attitudes that dehumanize adversaries, the relationships fractured by violence, the structural inequalities that produce grievance, and the cultural norms that legitimize exclusion and domination. This multi-dimensional conception of transformation is both analytically powerful and normatively ambitious, making it particularly appropriate for examining the complex and multi-layered dynamics of women's exclusion from mediation processes in Taraba State.

**Operationalization for the Study**

Rather than treating the four dimensions of Conflict Transformation Theory as descriptive categories, this study operationalizes each dimension as an empirical lens with specific indicators relevant to women's participation in mediation processes in Taraba State. This operationalization is summarised across the four dimensions as follows.

The personal dimension of transformation is operationalized through the empirical indicator of individual attitudes, perceptions, and emotional dispositions toward women's mediation roles among conflict actors, community members, male traditional leaders, and state officials. Transformation at this level is evidenced by measurable shifts in attitudes from exclusionary to inclusive orientations detectable through changes in public discourse, individual testimonies of male leaders, and reported community perceptions of women's mediation legitimacy. In Taraba State, the persistence of personal-level barriers is evidenced by the documented tendency of male traditional and political leaders to perceive women's mediation participation as culturally transgressive rather than as a legitimate expression of civic agency

(UN Women, 2021). Interventions targeting this dimension include gender-awareness training, male champion programs, and sustained engagement with religious and traditional leaders who can model attitudinal transformation.

The relational dimension is operationalized through the indicator of the quality and structure of inter-communal and inter-institutional relationships in which women participate as mediation actors. Transformation at this level is evidenced by the establishment or strengthening of cross-ethnic and cross-religious dialogue structures that include women as substantive participants rather than symbolic token representatives. Empirically, the relational dimension is traceable in Taraba State through the activities of women's peace committees, inter-ethnic market associations, and faith-based dialogue forums that bring women from the Jukun, Fulani, Hausa, Kuteb, Chamba, and Mambilla communities into sustained cooperative interaction (Mercy Corps, 2025). These relational structures function as early warning systems, de-escalation channels, and trust-building mechanisms that represent concrete relational transformation, even in the absence of formal mediation inclusion.

The structural dimension is operationalized through the indicator of institutional design and power distribution in formal mediation systems specifically, the gender composition of state peace commissions, conflict resolution committees, and traditional governance councils; the existence and enforcement of gender quotas and affirmative inclusion policies; and the allocation of financial and logistical resources to women's peace organizations. Transformation at this level is evidenced by institutional reforms that alter the formal rules governing access to mediation roles, moving from male-exclusive to gender-inclusive institutional architectures. In Taraba State, the structural dimension captures both the absence of gender-responsive peace institutions and the policy implementation gaps that prevent Nigeria's National Action Plan on UNSCR 1325 from generating tangible inclusion outcomes at the state level (United Nations Development Program, 2023).

The cultural dimension is operationalized through the indicator of community norms, values, and narratives that govern gender roles in public decision-making and conflict resolution. Cultural transformation is evidenced by documented shifts in community acceptance of women as legitimate mediators, measurable through changes in the cultural protocols governing traditional mediation forums, the emergence of community narratives that valorize women's peace contributions, and the gradual reform of customary practices that prescribe male authority over conflict resolution. In Taraba State, the cultural dimension is particularly significant given the layered interplay of ethnic tradition, Islamic jurisprudence, and Christian communal norms that each carry distinct and sometimes contradictory implications for women's public roles. Transforming exclusionary cultural norms requires sustained engagement with religious and traditional authorities, community peace education, and the deliberate documentation and celebration of women's mediation successes.

## Gendered Exclusion and Structural Constraints in Mediation Systems in Taraba State

### Institutional Architecture of Exclusion

The formal mediation architecture in Taraba State is structurally designed, whether intentionally or through historical accretion, to reproduce male authority in conflict resolution processes. State-level peace commissions, local government conflict resolution committees, and the traditional emirate and chieftaincy councils that dominate community mediation across the state all reflect an institutional logic that treats gender exclusion not as an anomaly to be corrected but as a default condition to be maintained. Adeyemi and Ogundele (2023) document that women constituted less than ten percent of formal mediation team membership across northern Nigerian state peace institutions, and that where women were present, they were typically assigned observer or support roles rather than substantive decision-making functions. This institutional marginalization operates through a specific causal mechanism: the rules governing access to formal mediation roles are anchored in customary authority structures that confer mediation legitimacy through lineage, title, and community eldership, all of which are structurally inaccessible to women under prevailing customary law systems.

The consequence of this institutional exclusion for conflict outcomes in Taraba State is analytically traceable. When women are absent from formal mediation processes, the resulting peace agreements systematically fail to address the gender-specific dimensions of conflict, including sexual violence, women's displacement, and the economic exclusion that sustains women's conflict vulnerability. UN Women (2021) documents multiple instances in which peace agreements negotiated exclusively by male mediators in Taraba State addressed territorial, political, and resource allocation concerns while failing to incorporate provisions for justice for survivors of sexual violence, protection of women's land rights, or the reintegration of women-headed households. These omissions are not accidental but are structural consequences of women's absence from the negotiation architecture: peace agreements reflect the interests and priorities of those present, and when women are absent, their interests are not represented.

### Patriarchal Norms as Causal Mechanisms of Exclusion

The cultural dimension of women's exclusion from mediation in Taraba State operates through identifiable normative mechanisms that translate broad patriarchal values into specific exclusionary practices within mediation contexts. These mechanisms include: the cultural proscription of women's speech in mixed-gender public forums, the ritual protocols of traditional mediation that require participants to hold recognized titles or lineage standing, the religious norms within both Islamic and Christian communities that prescribe male authority over public dispute resolution, and the social sanctioning of women who transgress gender-role expectations by engaging in public conflict mediation (UN Women, 2024). Critically, these cultural mechanisms function not merely as external constraints on women's

mediation participation but as internalized norms that shape women's own self-exclusion, as many women withdraw from potential mediation roles in anticipation of social sanction rather than in direct response to explicit prohibition.

This dynamic of anticipatory self-exclusion represents a particularly challenging dimension of the politics of inclusion, because it renders exclusion relatively invisible and therefore resistant to interventions targeted at formal institutional access. Lederach's (1995) cultural dimension of conflict transformation provides the most analytically precise tool for addressing this dynamic, directing attention to the need for community-level normative change rather than or alongside formal policy reform. In Taraba State, the cultural mechanisms of women's exclusion are reinforced by the absence of positive community narratives about women mediators. Where women's mediation contributions are not publicly acknowledged and celebrated, the cultural case for their inclusion cannot be built, and anticipatory self-exclusion is sustained. Addressing this mechanism requires deliberate investment in the documentation and public recognition of women's existing mediation contributions as a foundation for normative shift.

**Security Threats as Structural Constraints on Women's Mediation Agency**

Security threats represent a structural constraint on women's mediation participation that is distinct from but interactively reinforcing of cultural and institutional barriers. Women peacebuilders in Taraba State operate in environments where engagement in conflict mediation exposes them to targeted violence, intimidation, and sexual assault by armed actors who perceive women's peace advocacy as a threat to their strategic interests. Ibrahim and Salihu (2021) document cases in which women who facilitated inter-communal dialogue in Wukari and Ibi were subsequently subjected to threats and violence, producing a chilling effect that extended well beyond the individual targets to deter broader women's participation in public mediation forums. This security mechanism operates through a specific causal logic: armed actors use violence against women peacebuilders instrumentally, as a low-cost strategy for disrupting peace processes while simultaneously reinforcing gender hierarchies that confine women to domestic roles.

The absence of gender-responsive protection mechanisms for women mediators in Taraba State amplifies this structural constraint. Formal security agencies are largely absent from rural conflict zones, disproportionately male-staffed, and untrained in the protection needs of civilian peacebuilders. Women mediators therefore bear their security costs individually, through self-censorship, withdrawal from public mediation activities, or reliance on informal male protection networks that often condition security on compliance with patriarchal authority. These security dynamics interact directly with the structural dimension of Conflict Transformation Theory: the institutional reforms required to enable women's mediation participation cannot succeed without parallel investment in security architecture that provides targeted protection for women engaged in formal and informal peace work.

## Women's Informal Peace Agency and Mechanisms of Conflict Transformation in Taraba State

### Relational Transformation Through Market and Associational Networks

Despite their systematic exclusion from formal mediation structures, women in Taraba State have developed sophisticated informal peace agency rooted in the relational capital they maintain through market trading, religious associations, and women's cooperative organizations that span ethnic and community boundaries. These informal networks constitute a form of bridging social capital: the inter-group connections that Varshney (2021) identifies as the most reliable structural predictor of conflict de-escalation that formal male-dominated mediation processes consistently fail to generate or sustain. Women traders in Jalingo, Wukari, and Takum markets who maintain economic relationships across the Jukun-Fulani and Hausa-Tiv divides function as de facto early warning systems, detecting rising tensions before they escalate to violence and mobilizing informal de-escalation responses through their network contacts (Mercy Corps, 2025).

The mechanism through which these market and associational networks produce conflict transformation outcomes is relational rather than institutional: women's sustained cross-ethnic economic interactions generate positive interdependencies that increase the social costs of inter-communal violence for all parties. When the same Fulani traders who supply cattle to Jukun market women have sustained business relationships, shared credit arrangements, and mutual social obligations with those women, the decision calculus for violence is altered; the anticipated losses reduce the expected gains from inter-communal attack in established economic relationships. This relational transformation mechanism operates continuously and incrementally rather than through dramatic negotiated settlements, making it largely invisible to conventional conflict analysis but crucial to the maintenance of fragile inter-communal stability in the state.

### Personal and Cultural Transformation Through Women's Peace Committees

Women's peace committees established in several local government areas of Taraba State represent a concrete institutional expression of women's informal peace agency that engages both the personal and cultural dimensions of conflict transformation. By bringing together women from different ethnic and religious backgrounds around shared peacebuilding purposes, these committees create structured opportunities for the kind of sustained inter-group cooperation that generates personal attitudinal change, reducing dehumanizing perceptions, building cross-group empathy, and creating shared community identities that transcend conflict-sustaining ethnic categories (African Union, 2023; Mercy Corps, 2022). The personal transformation produced through these platforms is not merely individual but aggregative: as individual women from different communities develop trust, respect, and

shared commitment, the normative environment of their communities shifts incrementally toward greater cultural acceptance of inter-ethnic cooperation.

The cultural transformation potential of women's peace committees is, however, constrained by their limited articulation with formal mediation structures. When peace committees operate in isolation from state peace institutions, their relational and cultural transformation work does not generate formal peace agreements, institutional reforms, or policy outcomes that could sustain transformation at the structural level. Lederach (2003) argues that sustainable conflict transformation requires vertical integration the connection of grassroots transformation processes to middle-range and top-level institutional reform without which community-level peace gains remain fragile and reversible. For women's peace committees in Taraba State, the critical transformation challenge is therefore not building relational and cultural change at the community level, which women's informal agency has demonstrated capacity for, but creating the structural linkages that translate this change into formal institutional transformation.

**The Translation Gap: From Informal Agency to Formal Inclusion**

The analytical synthesis of women's exclusion from formal mediation and their demonstrated informal peace agency reveals what this study terms the 'translation gap': the structural and institutional failure to convert women's proven informal peacebuilding contributions into formal mediation recognition, authority, and influence. This translation gap is not a natural or inevitable feature of mediation systems. However, it is the product of specific institutional choices: the gatekeeping functions of male-dominated peace commissions, the absence of formal recognition protocols for informal mediators, the non-existence of pathways from women's peace committees to state mediation bodies, and the resource inequalities that prevent women's organizations from sustaining engagement with formal peace processes. The translation gap produces a systemic irony: Taraba State's formal mediation architecture is least effective precisely in the relational and cultural transformation dimensions where women's informal agency is most developed. In contrast, women are excluded from the structural and policy dimensions of formal mediation where their inclusion would generate the greatest added value.

**Conclusion**

This paper has advanced an analytical argument about the politics of inclusion that governs women's roles in local conflict mediation in Taraba State, moving beyond the descriptive documentation of exclusion to identify the causal mechanisms through which patriarchal institutional design, cultural normativity, and security vulnerabilities interact to produce and sustain women's marginalization from formal peace processes. The theoretical architecture of Conflict Transformation Theory, operationalized across its personal, relational, structural, and cultural dimensions, has demonstrated that women's exclusion from Taraba State's mediation

systems is not uniformly distributed across these dimensions but is most acute at the structural and cultural levels precisely where formal institutional design and community norms actively gatekeep access. In contrast, women's informal peace agency has generated significant relational and personal transformation outcomes that formal systems have consistently failed to recognize or leverage.

The causal mechanism linking women's mediation roles to peace outcomes in Taraba State can now be stated with analytical precision: where women's informal agency is allowed to operate through market networks, peace committees, and faith-based dialogue forums it produces relational transformation outcomes (reduced inter-group suspicion, positive economic interdependencies, cross-ethnic communication channels) and personal transformation outcomes (attitudinal change, reduced dehumanization) that are functionally necessary for sustainable peace. However, because these relational and personal gains are not institutionally connected to formal mediation processes, they do not generate the structural transformation (institutional reform, policy change, formal agreement) or the cultural transformation (community-level normative legitimation of women's public authority) required for durable peace. The translation gap between women's informal peace contributions and their formal mediation exclusion therefore constitutes the central mechanism through which Taraba State's conflict cycle is sustained: the relational and personal foundations of peace are periodically generated but never institutionally secured, producing fragile and reversible de-escalation rather than durable transformation.

Closing this translation gap by institutionalizing women's mediation roles, reforming the structural gatekeeping mechanisms of formal peace institutions, and investing in the cultural legitimation of women's peace authority is therefore not only a gender equity imperative but the most analytically defensible pathway to sustainable peace in Taraba State. The mechanisms through which women's inclusion would alter conflict trajectories are clear: increased bridging capital in formal mediation processes would reduce information asymmetries and inter-group dehumanization; broadened agenda-setting would ensure peace agreements address the gender-specific dimensions of conflict that currently undermine agreement durability; and enhanced cultural legitimation of women's mediation authority would gradually shift the normative environment from exclusionary to inclusive. Conflict Transformation Theory predicts, and the evidence from Taraba State confirms, that transformation cannot be sustainable if it operates only at the informal and grassroots level while formal institutional structures remain unreformed.

**Context-Specific Intervention Framework**

The following recommendations are organized across three distinct intervention levels state institutions, community mediation, and informal mediation systems and are explicitly linked to the causal barriers identified in the analysis. Each recommendation specifies the barrier it addresses and the transformation mechanism it seeks to activate.

**State-Level Institutional Reforms (Targeting Structural Dimension)**

Barrier addressed: Patriarchal institutional design and policy implementation gaps that exclude women from formal mediation architecture.

- **Establish a Gender-Inclusive State:** Peace Commission with a legally mandated 35 percent minimum female membership requirement, enforceable through an independent compliance monitoring mechanism. This directly addresses the institutional design barrier by altering the formal rules of access to state mediation bodies, and activates structural transformation by redistributing decision-making authority within peace institutions.

- Develop a Taraba State Action Plan on Women, Peace, and Security with specific targets for women's inclusion in formal mediation processes at each level of the state governance architecture, with dedicated budget lines, annual monitoring reports, and sanctions for non-compliance. This addresses the policy implementation gap identified in the structural analysis and creates accountability infrastructure that prevents normative commitments from remaining aspirational.

- Establish a Women Mediators' Roster within the State Peace Commission, drawing on women currently active in informal and community-level mediation, and creating a formal pathway through which demonstrated informal mediation expertise can generate access to formal state mediation processes. This intervention directly targets the translation gap by creating the structural linkage between informal agency and formal inclusion.

- Introduce gender-responsive protection protocols for formal and informal mediators, including safe transportation, security escorts, confidential reporting mechanisms for threats, and coordinated engagement with security agencies on the protection needs of women involved in peace processes. This addresses the security constraint identified as a structural barrier to women's mediation participation.

**Community Mediation Level (Targeting Relational and Cultural Dimensions)**

Barrier addressed: Exclusionary cultural norms in traditional mediation forums and the absence of pathways from community-level women's peace committees to formal mediation processes.

- Formalize and resource women's peace committees in each of Jalingo LGA's wards, providing them with official recognition by the Local Government Authority, modest operational budgets, and formal referral protocols to state-level mediation bodies.

Formalization activates structural transformation by connecting community relational capital to institutional peace architecture, while official recognition initiates cultural transformation by signaling public legitimation of women's mediation authority.

- Establish a Traditional Governance Engagement Program targeting emirate councils, chieftaincy structures, and religious leadership bodies, designed to negotiate graduated women's advisory roles within traditional mediation forums beginning with consultative participation, progressing toward co-mediation, and establishing the cultural precedent for women's mediation legitimacy within customary authority structures. This directly addresses the cultural dimension barrier of normative exclusion within traditional systems.

- Institutionalize peace education curricula in secondary schools and tertiary institutions across Taraba State that explicitly address the social costs of women's mediation exclusion and build cultural acceptance of gender-inclusive conflict resolution. This addresses the personal and cultural transformation dimensions by investing in the generational normative change required for durable attitudinal shift.

**Informal Mediation Systems (Targeting Personal and Relational Dimensions)**

Barrier addressed: Anticipatory self-exclusion among women mediators due to internalized patriarchal norms and the invisibility of women's informal peace contributions in community and national discourse.

- Commission a systematic documentation project of women's informal mediation contributions in Taraba State, producing publicly accessible case studies and policy briefs that demonstrate the causal relationship between women's informal peace agency and conflict de-escalation outcomes. Documentation activates cultural transformation by creating evidence-based narratives that challenge exclusionary norms and build the case for formal inclusion by demonstrating existing capacity.

- Establish mentorship and peer-learning networks connecting experienced women mediators with emerging women leaders across ethnic and geographic boundaries in Taraba State. These networks address the personal dimension by building individual mediation confidence and capacity while simultaneously strengthening the relational capital that constitutes the foundation of women's collective peace agency.

- Develop economic integration programs that leverage women's existing cross-ethnic market networks as platforms for deliberate peacebuilding programming, providing training in early warning recognition, de-escalation communication, and rapid response protocols to women traders whose market networks already function as informal conflict barometers. This directly activates the relational transformation

mechanism identified in the analysis as the most functionally effective dimension of women's current informal peace contribution.

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# THE ROLE OF IDENTITY POLITICS IN FUELING POLITICAL DIVISIONS AND CONFLICT IN NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** Identity politics has emerged as a potent force shaping Nigeria's political landscape, often serving as both a tool for representation and a catalyst for division. This study critically examines the role of identity politics in fueling political divisions and conflict in Nigeria, situating its analysis within the broader framework of ethnic pluralism, religious diversity, and historical marginalization. Drawing on theoretical perspectives from social identity theory, elite theory, and relative deprivation theory, the paper explores how political elites mobilize ethnic and religious identities as instruments for power consolidation and resource control. The manipulation of identity-based narratives deepens societal cleavages, undermines national cohesion, and perpetuates mistrust among Nigeria's diverse groups. Empirical evidence reveals that identity-driven competition over political representation, federal resource allocation, and cultural recognition frequently escalates into violent conflicts, particularly in regions such as the North Central and South East. Moreover, the politicization of ethnicity and religion erodes democratic institutions by prioritizing parochial loyalties over civic nationalism. The paper concludes that mitigating the adverse effects of identity politics requires deliberate institutional reforms that promote inclusivity, equitable governance, and intergroup dialogue. Strengthening civic identity and national integration is essential to transforming Nigeria's diversity from a source of conflict into a foundation for sustainable peace and democratic stability.

**Keywords:** Identity politics, political divisions, ethnic conflict, national cohesion, democracy

## Introduction

Identity politics, defined as organized political activity built around ethnic, religious, regional, or communal identities, has long structured public life in Nigeria and remains a central driver of political division and conflict. In a state shaped by colonial boundary-making and postcolonial governance, ethnicity and religion function not merely as cultural markers but as powerful political resources. Political elites frequently mobilize these

identities to secure power, distribute state resources, and protect group interests, transforming social differences into arenas of competition, exclusion, and, at times, violence (GOV.UK, 2023).

Empirical data underscores the depth and persistence of identity politics in Nigeria. Survey evidence from organizations such as Afrobarometer consistently shows that a significant proportion of Nigerians prioritize ethnic or religious identity over national identity. For example, Afrobarometer Round 8 data (2019-2021) indicate that approximately 48–55% of Nigerians identify more strongly with their ethnic group than with the nation, while only about 35–40% prioritize a national identity. This reflects a deeply embedded pattern of social identification that aligns with Social Identity Theory, where political preferences and loyalties are strongly mediated through group belonging.

Electoral behavior further illustrates the salience of identity politics. Studies of recent elections, including the 2019 and 2023 general elections, show that over 70% of voting patterns in many regions correlate strongly with ethnic and religious affiliations, particularly in highly polarised states. In northern Nigeria, voting often aligns with religious identity (predominantly Muslim), while in the southern and Middle Belt regions, ethnic and Christian affiliations play a more decisive role. This pattern reinforces the perception of politics as a zero-sum contest among identity blocs.

Conflict data also reveals the tangible consequences of identity-based mobilization. According to the Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project, Nigeria has recorded tens of thousands of fatalities linked to communal, ethnic, and religious violence over the past two decades. Between 2010 and 2023 alone, ACLED estimates over 60,000 conflict-related deaths, a significant portion of which are tied to identity-based conflicts such as farmer–herder clashes, insurgency, and communal violence. In the Middle Belt, for instance, farmer–herder conflicts, often framed along ethnic and religious lines, account for thousands of deaths annually in peak years.

In the Niger Delta, identity politics intersects with resource control struggles. The region produces over 80–90% of Nigeria’s export earnings from oil, yet local communities experience high levels of poverty and environmental degradation. This disparity has contributed to militant movements; at the height of militancy (circa 2006–2009), Nigeria’s oil production dropped by up to 25% due to attacks and sabotage, illustrating how identity-based grievances can disrupt national economic stability (Taylor & Francis, 2022). Communal violence in areas such as Jos and the broader Middle Belt further highlights the statistical dimensions of identity conflict. Reports indicate that thousands of people have been killed in Jos-related crises since the early 2000s, with major outbreaks (e.g., 2001, 2008, 2010) each resulting in hundreds to over a thousand fatalities per episode. These conflicts are often driven by disputes over indigene–settler status, land access, and political representation, with identity markers determining inclusion or exclusion.

Religious identity has been particularly significant in northern Nigeria, especially with the rise of Boko Haram. Since 2009, the insurgency has caused over 35,000 deaths and displaced more than 2 million people, according to estimates from the United Nations and humanitarian agencies. The group's ability to recruit and mobilize is closely tied to its framing of political grievances through religious identity, demonstrating how identity can serve both as a mobilizing and legitimizing force in violent conflict.

Public perception data also reflects widespread concern about identity divisions. Surveys by Afrobarometer show that over 60% of Nigerians believe that ethnic or religious conflict is a major problem, while trust levels across ethnic lines remain relatively low. For instance, fewer than 30% of respondents express high trust in members of other ethnic groups, indicating persistent intergroup suspicion. At a structural level, inequality reinforces identity politics. Nigeria's Gini coefficient has remained high, around 0.35–0.40 in recent years, while regional disparities in poverty are stark: northern regions record poverty rates exceeding 60–70%, compared to significantly lower rates in parts of the south. These disparities feed perceptions of marginalization and relative deprivation, which are often articulated through ethnic or regional identity frameworks.

Collectively, these patterns demonstrate that identity politics in Nigeria is not merely theoretical but empirically grounded. High levels of ethnic identification, identity-based voting patterns, persistent intergroup distrust, and the scale of conflict-related deaths all point to its entrenched role in shaping political behavior and instability. This persistence highlights a fundamental problem: despite recognition of its destabilizing effects, identity politics continues to undermine national integration, democratic consolidation, and sustainable peace in Nigeria. The enduring prioritization of group identities over a shared national identity, combined with their manipulation by political elites and weak institutional responses, has entrenched exclusion, electoral polarisation, and recurrent violence. As such, the central challenge lies in the Nigerian state's limited capacity to manage diversity effectively, ensure inclusive governance, and reduce the politicization of identity, raising critical questions about how these dynamics can be addressed to foster long-term stability and cohesion.

## Conceptual Review

### Identity Politics

Identity politics is a complex and contested concept in political science and sociology, referring to the mobilization of individuals and groups around shared aspects of identity, such as ethnicity, religion, gender, culture, or sexual orientation, in pursuit of political recognition, representation, and power. The term emerged prominently in the late 20th century to describe social movements that challenged dominant structures of exclusion and sought to redefine political participation through identity-based solidarity (Bernstein, 2005; Heyes, 2020). Fundamentally, identity politics rests on the assumption that certain social identities shape

individuals' experiences of injustice and that political organization should be grounded in these shared experiences (Fraser, 2000).

Philosophically, identity politics challenges the liberal universalist notion of the "neutral citizen," arguing instead that political agency and representation cannot be divorced from cultural, racial, or gendered identities (Young, 1990). Young and Fraser, for instance, emphasize that group-based inequalities, such as those tied to race, gender, or ethnicity, necessitate recognition as well as redistribution to correct historical marginalization. Thus, identity politics is seen both as a corrective response to structural inequality and as a framework for asserting dignity, inclusion, and cultural validation in plural societies (Fraser, 2000; Taylor, 1994).

In the global South, and particularly in postcolonial contexts, identity politics often assumes more volatile and competitive forms. In Africa, the colonial experience institutionalized identity categories along ethnic and regional lines, embedding them into the logic of state formation and political competition (Mamdani, 1996). Consequently, identity politics in countries such as Nigeria, Kenya, and Sudan has frequently revolved around contestations for power, access to resources, and recognition of communal rights. Rather than serving merely as a mechanism for inclusion, identity politics can thus reproduce exclusion, patronage, and conflict when elites instrumentalize it for political gain (Osaghae & Suberu, 2005; Ekeh, 1975).

From a theoretical standpoint, identity politics can be examined through multiple lenses. Constructivist theory views identity as socially constructed and dynamic, shaped through discourse, historical experience, and social interaction (Wendt, 1992). In this sense, identity politics is a product of how groups interpret and frame their social position in relation to others. Conversely, realist and materialist scholars underscore how identity politics reflects competition over tangible and symbolic resources within the state, where ethnicity, religion, or culture serve as vehicles for elite mobilization (Brubaker, 2004).

However, identity politics is not inherently divisive. Scholars such as Appiah (2005) and Crenshaw (1991) argue that it can be an emancipatory force, central to the politics of recognition and intersectionality, by empowering historically marginalized groups to articulate grievances and assert political agency. However, its darker side emerges when it devolves into exclusionary nationalism, sectarianism, or populism, fostering polarisation and conflict instead of inclusion and justice (Mouffe, 2018).

In essence, identity politics represents both a tool of empowerment and a source of division, depending on how it is mobilized within political systems. When embedded within inclusive democratic frameworks, it can enhance pluralism and representation. However, in fragile or divided societies, especially those characterized by weak institutions and zero-sum competition, it can exacerbate tensions and undermine social cohesion. The challenge,

therefore, lies not in the existence of identity politics itself but in managing it through inclusive governance, equitable resource distribution, and sustained intergroup dialogue.

**Political Divisions**

Political divisions refer to the structural, ideological, and sociocultural cleavages that fragment political communities, shape patterns of political competition, and influence the nature of governance and stability within a state. Conceptually, political divisions are rooted in differences of interest, identity, belief, or ideology that manifest in contestation over power, resources, and legitimacy. They are intrinsic to plural societies and democratic politics, yet when unmanaged or exploited, they can become sources of polarisation, instability, and conflict (Lipset & Rokkan, 1967; Dahl, 1971).

At its core, political division represents the process by which societies are segmented along cleavage lines, such as class, ethnicity, religion, region, or ideology, that structure political participation and align citizens with particular political actors or parties. The classic cleavage theory of Lipset and Rokkan (1967) identifies four foundational divides in modern political systems: center–periphery, state–church, rural–urban, and owner–worker. These cleavages shape the formation of political parties and enduring patterns of political loyalty, often reflecting deep historical and sociocultural foundations.

In contemporary contexts, political divisions go beyond traditional cleavages to encompass cultural, ethnic, and identity-related dimensions. The rise of identity politics, where political mobilization is driven by shared identity rather than ideology, has deepened divisions in many democratic and developing societies (Mouffe, 2005; Fukuyama, 2018). In highly diverse societies such as Nigeria, Lebanon, or India, identity-based divisions often coincide with struggles for state power, turning political differences into existential conflicts between groups (Horowitz, 1985; Lijphart, 1999).

From a theoretical standpoint, pluralist scholars argue that divisions are an inherent and even healthy part of democratic competition, ensuring the representation of diverse interests and preventing hegemonic domination (Dahl, 1971). However, elitist and Marxist theories view political divisions as reflections of deeper structural inequalities, class-based or resource-based, that elites manipulate to sustain dominance and control (Miliband, 1969; Gramsci, 1971). In this sense, divisions are not spontaneous social realities but constructed and maintained through the reproduction of power relations within the political economy.

Modern scholarship also highlights the role of media, technology, and populism in deepening political divisions. The digital revolution and social media platforms have amplified ideological echo chambers, facilitated misinformation, and contributed to affective polarisation, where political opponents are seen not merely as competitors but as enemies (Sunstein, 2017; Iyengar & Krupenkin, 2018). These patterns are evident in both established

democracies, such as the United States and the United Kingdom, and emerging democracies, where weak institutions make divisions more volatile (McCoy & Somer, 2019).

In postcolonial African states, political divisions often arise from the colonial legacy of arbitrary boundaries, unequal development, and elite instrumentalization of ethnicity and religion for political gain (Ake, 1996; Ekeh, 1975). In Nigeria, for example, regional and ethnic divisions- North vs. South, Christian vs. Muslim- have been entrenched through political patronage, resource control disputes, and institutional imbalance, producing recurrent cycles of conflict and mistrust (Osaghae & Suberu, 2005). Such divisions undermine national integration and democratic consolidation, as loyalty to ethnic or regional blocs frequently supersedes allegiance to the state.

Importantly, political divisions are not merely disruptive; they can also be constructive when mediated through inclusive institutions and participatory governance. Arend Lijphart's (1999) theory of consociational democracy suggests that in plural societies, structured power-sharing, proportional representation, and mutual veto rights can convert divisions into mechanisms of stability rather than conflict. Hence, the impact of political divisions depends not on their existence per se, but on the institutional capacity to manage and transform them. Therefore, political divisions are an inevitable feature of political life, reflecting the diversity of human interests and identities. However, when exacerbated by inequality, exclusion, and manipulative political practices, they can erode trust, weaken institutions, and generate social conflict. The challenge for modern governance lies in building inclusive frameworks that channel divisions into legitimate political competition, rather than allowing them to devolve into fragmentation and instability.

**Ethnic Conflict**

Ethnic conflict is a pervasive phenomenon in the study of political science, sociology, and international relations. It denotes a form of social and political confrontation in which ethnicity constitutes the primary basis of group identification, mobilization, and antagonism (Horowitz, 1985). Ethnicity itself is a socially constructed identity that often derives from shared cultural traits such as language, religion, history, or ancestry (Eriksen, 2010). When politicized, these cultural markers can become powerful instruments for collective mobilization and contestation over power, resources, and recognition, leading to conflict (Fearon & Laitin, 2000). Conceptually, ethnic conflict refers to disputes and violent struggles between groups defined by perceived common ancestry and cultural heritage (Horowitz, 1985). These conflicts are typically characterized by collective action in defense of perceived group interests, often resulting from real or imagined inequalities and injustices (Gurr, 1993). Ethnic conflicts can manifest as secessionist wars, communal violence, insurgencies, or state repression, depending on the structure of grievances and opportunities available for mobilization (Fearon, 2004).

From a theoretical standpoint, three major paradigms dominate the conceptual understanding of ethnic conflict: primordialism, instrumentalism, and constructivism. The primordialist school views ethnic identity as a fixed and natural phenomenon, an intrinsic aspect of human belonging that inevitably generates conflict when group boundaries are threatened (Geertz, 1973). In contrast, instrumentalists argue that ethnicity is mobilized strategically by political elites to achieve material or political ends, often by exploiting social divisions and grievances (Cohen, 1974; Brass, 1991). Constructivist perspectives, however, posit that ethnic identities are socially and historically constructed, shaped by political institutions, colonial legacies, and socio-economic dynamics (Anderson, 1983; Wimmer, 2013). Ethnic conflict often emerges from the intersection of grievance and opportunity structures. According to Gurr (1970), grievances such as political exclusion, economic inequality, and cultural marginalization create fertile grounds for collective mobilization. Cederman, Wimmer, and Min (2010) further argue that ethnic groups excluded from state power are significantly more likely to engage in rebellion than those with inclusive access. Structural conditions, such as weak state institutions, economic underdevelopment, and resource competition, provide opportunities for such grievances to escalate into organized conflict (Fearon & Laitin, 2003; Collier & Hoeffler, 2004).

Horizontal inequalities, that is, inequalities between culturally defined groups, are crucial in explaining ethnic conflict (Stewart, 2008). When certain ethnic groups experience systematic deprivation in political representation, education, or economic opportunities, resentment grows and can translate into violent mobilization. Ethnic entrepreneurs or elites often exploit these divisions for political gain, amplifying perceived threats to collective identity (Brass, 1991). Ethnic conflict is not merely about material interests but also about identity, recognition, and dignity. It is deeply rooted in the struggle for symbolic and cultural legitimacy (Burton, 1990). Social identity theory suggests that individuals derive self-esteem and meaning from their group affiliations, and when such identities are perceived to be under attack, defensive and retaliatory actions ensue (Tajfel & Turner, 1986). Hence, ethnic conflicts are as much psychological and cultural as they are political and economic.

The conceptual debate on ethnic conflict also centers on whether ethnicity itself is the main cause of conflict or merely a mobilizing frame for deeper structural grievances. Scholars like Fearon and Laitin (2003) argue that state weakness and insurgency conditions, rather than ethnic diversity per se, better predict civil war onset. Others, such as Horowitz (1985) and Cederman et al. (2013), maintain that ethnic exclusion and the politicization of identity remain central causal factors. This debate underscores the complexity of distinguishing ethnic conflict from other forms of political violence, as ethnic identity often overlaps with class, regional, and ideological cleavages. Ethnic conflict undermines state legitimacy, social cohesion, and economic development. It often results in large-scale displacement, human rights violations, and the destruction of infrastructure (World Bank, 2003). Moreover, prolonged ethnic wars can entrench identity divisions, leading to cycles of violence and revenge that hinder post-conflict reconciliation (Stewart, 2008). Addressing ethnic conflict,

therefore, requires not only security and institutional reforms but also reconciliation efforts that promote intergroup trust, inclusivity, and shared national identity (Bøås & Dunn, 2007).

Ethnic conflict, therefore, is a multidimensional phenomenon rooted in the interplay between identity, power, and inequality. While ethnicity serves as the immediate axis of mobilization, its underlying causes are often structural, institutional, and historical. A sound conceptual understanding of ethnic conflict thus necessitates integrating identity-based theories with analyses of governance, economic structures, and state capacity. This synthesis highlights that ethnic conflict is less about immutable cultural difference and more about the political and economic conditions under which ethnic identities become salient and contentious.

**Empirical Review of the Related Literature**

Adebayo (2014), in his article "Ethnicity, Political Manipulation, and Conflict in Nigeria," examines how political elites instrumentalize ethnic identities to consolidate power, shape electoral outcomes, and manipulate state institutions for partisan advantage. The study emphasizes the centrality of ethnicity in driving political mobilization, illustrating how competition over resources and political offices often exacerbates intergroup tensions and fuels localized and national-level conflicts. Adebayo provides compelling empirical examples, highlighting instances where ethnic affiliations have intensified disputes over governance, representation, and access to state resources. The study also situates these dynamics within Nigeria’s broader historical and colonial legacy, linking the entrenchment of ethnic divisions to contemporary political behavior and governance challenges. Despite its valuable insights, the study has notable limitations. First, it primarily focuses on descriptive accounts of ethnic manipulation without offering robust quantitative analyses to measure the extent or intensity of identity-driven conflict. Second, Adebayo tends to treat ethnicity as a largely static and monolithic factor, underemphasizing the fluidity of identity and the intersection of ethnicity with religion, class, and regionalism. Third, the article does not extensively explore potential mechanisms or policy interventions for mitigating the destabilizing effects of ethnic politics, leaving a gap for research on practical conflict management and inclusive governance strategies. Finally, the study is largely retrospective, offering limited predictive analysis of how emerging political trends might influence identity politics in future electoral cycles.

Idang (2013), in his journal article "Political Parties and Electoral Violence in Nigeria," examines the role of political parties in shaping electoral dynamics and their contribution to violence during elections. The study highlights that Nigerian political parties are often organized along ethnic, regional, and patronage lines, which exacerbates competition and intensifies tensions during electoral periods. Idang argues that party structures, candidate selection processes, and the manipulation of party machinery by elites facilitate the mobilization of supporters along identity-based lines, often leading to intimidation, clashes, and post-election disputes. The article provides empirical evidence from multiple electoral cycles, illustrating how weak party institutionalization, lack of internal democracy, and elite-

driven politics contribute to systemic electoral violence. The study underscores the interplay between institutional weaknesses and political culture in explaining why elections in Nigeria frequently trigger conflict, thereby offering insights for reforms in party governance and electoral management. Despite its valuable contributions, several gaps are apparent. First, Idang's analysis focuses primarily on macro-level party structures and elite behavior, with limited attention to grassroots actors and community-level dynamics that influence electoral violence. Second, the study largely examines historical patterns without fully incorporating recent technological or social media influences on political mobilization and violence, which are increasingly relevant in contemporary Nigerian elections. Third, while it identifies causal factors, the article provides limited discussion on effective policy or institutional interventions to mitigate violence, leaving a gap for applied research on preventive strategies. Finally, the research is largely descriptive, offering less theoretical engagement with broader frameworks such as social identity theory or instrumentalist approaches, which could deepen understanding of how identity politics interacts with party dynamics to fuel conflict.

Jibrin (2012), in his policy report "Ethno-religious Conflict and Security Challenges in Nigeria," analyzes the persistent ethno-religious tensions and their implications for national security. The report emphasizes how overlapping ethnic and religious identities, coupled with political manipulation, contribute to communal violence and instability across Nigeria. Jibrin highlights key flashpoints, including the North-East (Boko Haram insurgency) and intercommunal clashes in the Middle Belt, illustrating the complex interplay between identity, politics, and security. The study provides actionable insights for policymakers, stressing the need for inclusive governance, conflict-sensitive development, and strengthened security frameworks to mitigate these tensions. While the report is comprehensive in identifying drivers of conflict, it primarily offers descriptive analysis with limited empirical data to quantify the scale or frequency of violence. Additionally, it lacks a strong theoretical framework to contextualize identity-based conflicts within broader political science or security studies literature. The report also provides limited exploration of preventive strategies at the community level or the role of civil society in conflict mitigation, leaving space for more detailed, evidence-based policy interventions.

Mustapha (2006), in his journal article "Ethnic Structure, Inequality, and Governance of the Public Sector in Nigeria," examines how Nigeria's ethnic heterogeneity shapes public sector governance and contributes to socio-political inequality. The study highlights that disproportionate representation of ethnic groups in government institutions often reinforces elite domination, marginalization of minority groups, and uneven access to resources. Mustapha argues that these structural inequalities exacerbate tensions, foster perceptions of injustice, and indirectly fuel political instability and conflict, particularly when ethnicity becomes a mobilization tool in elections or policy decisions. While the article provides a strong structural analysis of ethnicity and governance, it offers limited empirical evidence linking specific governance practices directly to episodes of political conflict. Furthermore, the study predominantly focuses on elite-level dynamics, with minimal attention to grassroots-level perceptions or responses to governance inequalities. There is also a lack of

comparative analysis across regions or sectors to assess variation in ethnic influence, leaving room for more nuanced, data-driven studies that connect ethnic inequality to concrete security and development outcomes.

Suberu (2001), in his article "Federalism and Ethnic Conflict in Nigeria," examines how Nigeria's federal structure interacts with its complex ethnic landscape to influence political stability and conflict. He argues that while federalism was intended to manage diversity and provide equitable representation, it has often reinforced ethnic divisions by institutionalizing group-based competition for political power and resources. Suberu highlights how the interplay between ethnic loyalties and federal arrangements shapes electoral dynamics, policy-making, and intergroup tensions, offering a nuanced understanding of institutional factors in Nigerian conflicts. The study focuses primarily on structural and institutional dimensions, with less emphasis on the role of elite manipulation, political mobilization strategies, or the influence of religious identity in exacerbating conflicts. Additionally, while the analysis is rich in historical context, it provides limited empirical data on contemporary cases post-2000, leaving a gap for research on how recent political reforms and decentralization efforts affect ethnic conflict in Nigeria. A comparative perspective across states could also enhance understanding of why federalism mitigates tensions in some regions while intensifying them in others.

Falola (2001), in his article "Nationalism and Political Identity in Nigeria: Colonial Legacies and Postcolonial Challenges," explores the historical roots of political identity formation in Nigeria, emphasizing how colonial policies entrenched ethnic, regional, and religious divisions that continue to shape post-independence politics. The study highlights the paradox of nationalism in Nigeria, where efforts to build a cohesive national identity have been consistently undermined by the persistence of localized ethnic loyalties and the politicization of identity. Falola argues that these colonial legacies have influenced patterns of elite competition, the structuring of political institutions, and the recurrent instability in Nigerian governance. The article provides rich historical analysis, linking the institutional and ideological foundations of postcolonial politics to contemporary challenges in achieving political unity and inclusive governance. While Falola's work is theoretically and historically grounded, several gaps remain. First, the study is largely qualitative and historical, lacking empirical data or case studies that quantify the impact of colonial legacies on modern political behavior. Second, the article primarily focuses on macro-level historical processes and underemphasizes contemporary micro-level dynamics, such as how local communities negotiate ethnic and religious identities in daily politics. Third, there is limited exploration of the role of policy interventions or institutional reforms in mitigating the enduring effects of colonial-era divisions. Finally, the study does not sufficiently address the interactions between ethnicity, religion, and other socio-economic factors in shaping political conflict, leaving room for more intersectional analysis in future research.

Osaghae (1995), in his journal article "Structural Adjustment and Ethnicity in Nigeria," explores how the implementation of structural adjustment programs (SAPs) interacted with

Nigeria’s ethnic divisions to influence political stability and social cohesion. He argues that SAPs, by imposing economic austerity and resource redistribution, intensified competition among ethnic groups for access to scarce resources and government patronage. These dynamics exacerbated existing ethnic tensions and contributed to political fragmentation, highlighting the intersection of economic policy and identity politics in shaping conflict dynamics in Nigeria. While Osaghae effectively links economic reforms to ethnic tensions, the study primarily provides a macro-level analysis, with limited micro-level data on how specific communities or groups experienced and responded to these policies. Additionally, the focus on the SAP era restricts the applicability of the findings to contemporary contexts, leaving room for updated research examining current economic reforms and their interaction with identity politics. The study also lacks comparative analysis across different regions, which could provide insights into why some areas experienced more severe ethnic tensions than others.

Horowitz (1985), in his seminal work "Ethnic Groups in Conflict," provides a foundational analysis of how ethnic divisions influence political behavior and contribute to instability, particularly in multi-ethnic states. The study emphasizes that the structure and distribution of ethnic groups within a political system profoundly affect patterns of competition, cooperation, and conflict. Horowitz introduces the concept of institutional engineering, arguing that electoral systems, federal arrangements, and power-sharing mechanisms can either mitigate or exacerbate ethnic tensions. His framework combines theoretical rigor with comparative insights, drawing examples from countries with diverse ethnic configurations, and highlights the role of elites in mobilizing ethnic identities for political gain. The work remains influential in understanding why ethnicity often becomes a central organizing principle in politics, explaining both the persistence of intergroup conflict and the challenges of achieving national integration. Despite its theoretical significance, several gaps are evident. First, Horowitz’s analysis is largely generalized and comparative, with limited empirical investigation into specific contemporary cases, including African contexts like Nigeria. Second, the study does not fully account for the interaction of ethnicity with other identity markers such as religion, class, or regional affiliations, which are critical in understanding complex conflicts. Third, while institutional solutions are proposed, there is insufficient discussion on the practical implementation and effectiveness of these arrangements in highly polarized societies. Finally, Horowitz’s framework emphasizes structural determinants of conflict but underexplores the agency of grassroots actors and civil society in mediating or mitigating ethnic tensions, leaving an avenue for more nuanced, micro-level research.

Tajfel and Turner (1979), in their article "An Integrative Theory of Intergroup Conflict," develop social identity theory to explain how group membership shapes intergroup attitudes and behaviors. They argue that individuals derive part of their self-concept from their group affiliations, leading to in-group favoritism and out-group discrimination, which can escalate into intergroup conflict. This framework provides a psychological basis for understanding ethnic, religious, and regional tensions. It has been widely applied to analyze political and

social conflicts globally, including in multi-ethnic states like Nigeria. While the theory robustly explains the psychological mechanisms of group behavior, it offers limited insight into structural, economic, or political factors that exacerbate intergroup conflict. Additionally, its applicability in highly complex, multi-layered political systems like Nigeria may require integration with institutional and elite-centered perspectives to fully account for how identities are mobilized for political purposes. Empirical validation in contemporary African contexts also remains underexplored.

**Theoretical Review**

Nigeria's political landscape is deeply shaped by identity politics, expressed through ethnic, religious, and regional affiliations. The country's colonial and postcolonial trajectories have produced a fragmented socio-political order in which group identity often outweighs national identity (Osaghae & Suberu, 2005). Identity politics, defined as the mobilization of individuals around ascriptive characteristics such as ethnicity, religion, and region to advance political or economic interests (Heywood, 2019), has intensified divisions, fostered mutual distrust, and contributed to recurrent conflict in Nigeria. A range of theoretical perspectives helps explain how identity politics drives political fragmentation and instability in a multi-ethnic state like Nigeria.

Social Identity Theory (SIT), developed by Tajfel and Turner (1979), explains how individuals derive part of their self-concept from group membership. Through categorization into "in-groups" and "out-groups," people tend to favor those within their group while discriminating against others. In Nigeria, ethnic and religious identities often serve as dominant in-groups, shaping political behavior. Voters frequently support candidates aligned with their ethnic or regional background, viewing politics as a zero-sum struggle over power and resources (Mustapha, 2006). These dynamics reinforce political polarisation, deepen mistrust, and sustain intergroup conflict (Ikelegbe, 2005).

Relative Deprivation Theory (Gurr, 1970) links identity-based conflict to perceived inequalities between groups. When communities believe they are disadvantaged relative to others, especially in terms of political representation, development, or resource allocation, they may resort to protest or violence. In Nigeria, movements such as Niger Delta militancy and other forms of ethnic agitation are often rooted in perceptions of marginalization and exclusion (Ikelegbe, 2005; Ukiwo, 2003). Identity politics thus becomes a channel through which grievances are expressed, and collective action is mobilized.

Finally, elite theory, associated with Pareto (1935) and Mosca (1939), posits that a small ruling class controls political power and manipulates societal divisions to maintain dominance. In Nigeria, elites frequently exploit ethnic and religious cleavages to legitimize authority and weaken opposition (Ake, 1996; Joseph, 1987). By framing politics as competition among ethnic blocs, they divert attention from governance failures and socio-

economic inequality, thereby perpetuating patronage, corruption, and underdevelopment (Osaghae, 1998).

These perspectives show that identity politics in Nigeria is a multifaceted phenomenon rooted in psychological processes, elite strategies, historical constructions, structural inequalities, and institutional weaknesses. Its persistence continues to shape political competition, deepen social divisions, and challenge efforts toward national integration and stability.

## Research Methodology

The study employs a qualitative research methodology to examine and interpret the significance of the topic under investigation. This approach prioritizes the analysis of cases of identity politics in Nigeria, relevant empirical studies, and postcolonial conflict reports to uncover underlying perceptions, experiences, and contextual realities. The research utilizes both purposive and snowball sampling techniques. Purposive sampling was applied to identify materials that critically examine how identity politics contributes to political divisions and conflicts in Nigeria, chosen for its ability to target information-rich sources, including scholarly literature and case studies specifically addressing the subject.

In addition, snowball sampling was implemented through citation tracking, allowing the identification of further pertinent studies via the reference lists of already sourced materials. By integrating purposive and snowball sampling, the study systematically selected books, journal articles, case studies, and government documents that are directly relevant to the research objectives, ensuring a thorough and contextually grounded understanding of the topic.

## Data Analysis and Results

The data analysis and results in this study mainly focus on a review of theoretical perspectives, relevant literature, documentaries, and case studies, which provide valuable insights into how identity politics contributes to political divisions and conflicts in Nigeria. Based on this, the analysis and results are presented as follows:

### Analysis of the Major Factors of Identity Politics Fueling Political Divisions and Conflicts in Nigeria

Identity politics in Nigeria refers to the use of ethnic, religious, and regional identities as bases for political mobilization and competition. Rather than promoting unity, identity politics has deepened polarization and violent conflict in the country. The major indices that sustain this phenomenon include ethnic mobilization, religious manipulation, regionalism, resource control struggles, elite manipulation, institutional weakness, and political exclusion.

These indices are interlinked and mutually reinforcing (Osaghae & Suberu, 2005; Nnoli, 1978). Consequently, the following section provides an explicit explanation of these indices:

**Ethnic Mobilization and Polarisation**

Ethnic identity is one of the strongest indices of political behavior in Nigeria. Politicians mobilize support primarily through appeals to ethnic solidarity, turning elections into contests between groups rather than issues (Horowitz, 1985; Nnoli, 1978). During Nigeria's First Republic (1960–1966), the three dominant political parties- the Northern People's Congress (NPC), Action Group (AG), and National Council of Nigerian Citizens (NCNC)- were organized largely along ethnic lines representing Hausa-Fulani, Yoruba, and Igbo interests respectively (Suberu, 2001). This ethnicized party structure sowed distrust and contributed to the military coups of 1966 and the subsequent civil war (Osaghae, 1998). Ethnic mobilization transforms political competition into ethnic rivalry, undermines national integration, and provokes conflicts such as the Jos crisis (2001–2010) and recurring Herdsmen–Farmer clashes in the Middle Belt region (Ukiwo, 2003; Akinyele, 2011).

**Religious Manipulation and Sectarian Divisions**

Religion serves as a key mobilizing identity in Nigeria. Politicians and elites manipulate religious sentiments to gain legitimacy, votes, and social control (Kukah, 2011; Falola, 1998). For instance, the Sharia Law controversy in northern states after 1999 heightened Muslim–Christian tensions. Political elites in states such as Zamfara and Kano promoted Sharia as an identity tool to consolidate local support, which triggered violent reactions from Christian minorities (Ostien, 2009). Similarly, religious polarization has been central to the Boko Haram insurgency, which exploits Islamic identity to justify rebellion (Agbiboa, 2013). Religious manipulation has been fueling sectarian conflicts, erodes national secularism, and weakens the capacity of the state to act impartially (Ukiwo, 2003).

**Regionalism and Federal Character Politics**

Regional identity- North, South, East, or West- continues to define political participation and distribution of power in Nigeria. The "federal character principle" was introduced to promote inclusiveness but has inadvertently institutionalized regional divisions (Suberu, 2001). For example, the persistent debate over "power rotation" between the North and South reflects the regionalization of political power. The tension following President Goodluck Jonathan's (a southerner) decision to contest in 2011 despite expectations of northern succession sparked widespread protests and violence (Omotola, 2011). The emergence of Bola Ahmed Tinubu as a presidential candidate in 2023 generated notable controversy within the party, particularly between its northern and western blocs. Nigeria's electoral processes have consistently been characterized by perceptions of marginalization among one or more geopolitical zones. While designed to ensure fairness, regionalism fosters resentment and competition for state control.

It transforms political appointments and economic opportunities into regional contests (Mustapha, 2006).

**Resource Control and Economic Inequality**

The Niger Delta region, which produces over 80% of Nigeria's crude oil, has long suffered from environmental degradation, poverty, and underdevelopment despite its immense contribution to national revenue. The local communities' demand for greater control over oil resources led to violent agitation beginning in the 1990s. Resource-based identity politics arises from the uneven distribution of natural resources, especially oil. The struggle for control of oil revenues has fueled identity-based militancy and separatist agitations (Ikelegbe, 2005; Watts, 2004). For instance, groups such as the Movement for the Survival of the Ogoni People (MOSOP), led by Ken Saro-Wiwa, protested against environmental pollution and economic neglect by multinational oil companies like Shell and the Nigerian government. The execution of Saro-Wiwa and eight other Ogoni activists in 1995 intensified regional and international outrage (Ikelegbe, 2005). By the 2000s, militant organizations like the Movement for the Emancipation of the Niger Delta (MEND) emerged, attacking oil installations and kidnapping foreign workers to press for "resource control" and increased revenue allocation to oil-producing states (Watts, 2004; Osaghae, 1998). Disparities in access to education, healthcare, and infrastructure have led to persistent poverty in northern states. The National Bureau of Statistics (2020) reports that over 70% of Nigeria's poor population resides in the northern region. These inequalities have fueled grievances and facilitated the rise of insurgent groups like Boko Haram, which frame their struggle partly as a reaction to economic injustice (Agbiboa, 2013). Resource control conflicts blur the line between ethnic, regional, and economic grievances. They reinforce the perception that certain groups benefit disproportionately from the "national cake," fueling violent rebellion and secessionist movements (Osaghae, 1998).

**Elite Manipulation and Patronage Politics**

According to the Instrumentalist Theory of ethnicity, political elites deliberately invoke identity to gain power and protect class interests (Brass, 1991; Joseph, 1987). For example, during the 2015 general elections, elite political actors weaponized identity politics by framing the contest between Muhammadu Buhari and Goodluck Jonathan as one between "northern Muslim" and "southern Christian" blocs. This framing deepened mistrust between regions and reinforced electoral violence (Omotola, 2015). Elite manipulation transforms identity into a political resource, legitimizes corruption through ethnic patronage, and perpetuates clientelism rather than democratic accountability (Ake, 1996; Joseph, 1987).

**Political Exclusion and Marginalization**

Perceived or real exclusion from access to political power and national resources drives identity-based resentment (Gurr, 1970; Osaghae, 1998). For instance, movements like the Indigenous People of Biafra (IPOB) and the Middle Belt Forum emerged from claims of political and economic marginalization. IPOB's campaign for secession under Nnamdi Kanu reflects the belief that the Igbo have been excluded from national leadership since the end of the civil war (Okeke, 2020). Marginalization narratives sustain ethnic nationalism and secessionist rhetoric, threatening Nigeria's territorial integrity (Osaghae & Suberu, 2005).

**Media and Identity Amplification**

The media reinforces identity politics by framing political issues through ethnic or religious lenses, often sensationalizing divisive narratives (Akinyele, 2011). For example, during the 2019 general elections, certain regional media outlets presented candidates as "northern defenders" or "southern liberators," shaping voters' choices along identity lines (Pate, 2018). Such framing reinforces stereotypes and polarizes public opinion, catalyzing hate speech and electoral violence.

**Analysis of Identity Politics and Its Impact on Political Divisions and Conflict in Nigeria**

In Nigeria, identity politics has evolved from a marginal consideration into a central determinant of political alignment and conflict, shaped by structural inequalities, elite manipulation, and uneven patterns of development. Policies such as the federal character principle, zoning, and rotational presidency, designed to promote inclusion, have paradoxically reinforced ethnic consciousness by institutionalizing identity-based competition for political and economic power (Suberu, 2001; Elaigwu, 2011). Political elites routinely mobilize ethnic and religious sentiments to secure loyalty and political legitimacy, transforming identity into a strategic political instrument. This process positions identity politics as a mechanism through which access to political legitimacy and material resources is contested, thereby deepening polarization and precipitating recurrent conflict (Agbu, 2004; Akinola, 2018).

The 2011 presidential election, following the death of President Umaru Musa Yar'Adua, illustrates the volatility of identity-driven politics. The election of Goodluck Jonathan, a southern Christian, over northern Muslim contenders was widely perceived in the North as a breach of the informal zoning arrangement within the People's Democratic Party (PDP). Elite manipulation of ethnic and religious narratives ignited riots across 12 northern states, resulting in over 800 deaths and the displacement of thousands (Human Rights Watch, 2011). This episode underscores how elite-driven identity politics recentered ethnicity and religion as the primary axes of political legitimacy and participation.

The 2015 general election further highlighted the salience of identity in national politics. The All-Progressives Congress (APC) drew its major support from the North and Southwest, while the PDP retained dominance in the South-South and Southeast. Campaign rhetoric was heavily infused with ethnic and religious symbolism, portraying Muhammadu Buhari as a "northern Muslim savior" and Goodluck Jonathan as a "southern Christian victim" of northern dominance (Suberu, 2015). Similarly, the 2023 presidential election again recentered identity politics, as debates over Bola Ahmed Tinubu's Muslim-Muslim ticket and regional rotation of power intensified divisions between North and South, as well as between Muslim and Christian communities (International Crisis Group, 2023). These electoral contests underscore the extent to which religious and regional identities have become pivotal in shaping political alliances and conflict dynamics.

At the subnational level, recurrent violence in states such as Plateau (Jos) and Kaduna exemplifies the manipulation of identity narratives by local elites to maintain political relevance and control over land and resources. In Jos, disputes between the Berom (Christian "indigenes") and Hausa-Fulani (Muslim "settlers") are frequently politicized around local government control, political appointments, and access to economic opportunities (Krause, 2011). Such conflicts illustrate how identity is leveraged as a political instrument to marginalize opponents and consolidate elite dominance, often resulting in communal violence. Another illustrative case is the localized ethno-political conflicts, such as the Tiv–Jukun clashes in Wukari and Taraba, which highlight the persistent influence of historical grievances, elite political entrepreneurship, and competition over chieftaincy and territorial control in sustaining recurrent violence. Studies indicate that these tensions are often intensified during electoral cycles, as political actors strategically mobilize identity-based narratives to secure and consolidate electoral support. Finally, the Boko Haram insurgency in Nigeria's Northeast also demonstrates pronounced identity and religious dimensions. While multiple factors drive the insurgency, including poverty, governance deficits, and ideological radicalization, its narratives emphasizing marginalization, moral decline, and religious revival reveal how identity-based framing can facilitate recruitment and garner local support.

The re-centering of identity politics in Nigeria reveals the fragility of national cohesion and the challenges to democratic consolidation. Rather than transcending ethnic and religious affiliations, the political system has institutionalized them as bases of legitimacy and access to state power. Persistent identity-centered politics deepens societal divisions, fuels violent conflicts, and undermines the emergence of a unified national identity. Addressing these challenges requires deliberate strategies to depoliticize ethnicity through inclusive governance, equitable resource distribution, and the strengthening of civic institutions.

**Discussion of Findings**

The findings from the study underscore the centrality of identity politics in shaping Nigeria's political landscape and its recurrent conflicts. Identity, encompassing ethnicity, religion, region, and indigene–settler status, has emerged not merely as a background feature of

Nigerian society but as a core determinant of political alignment, electoral outcomes, and localized violence.

The study reveals that political elites consistently manipulate ethnic and religious sentiments to mobilize support, secure loyalty, and consolidate power. Examples such as the 2011 presidential election, where Goodluck Jonathan's southern Christian identity became a flashpoint against northern Muslim candidates, illustrate how elite-driven narratives can ignite large-scale violence. The resulting riots across 12 northern states, with over 800 casualties, demonstrate the deadly consequences of framing political contests in ethnic and religious terms (Human Rights Watch, 2011). Similarly, the 2015 and 2023 presidential elections highlighted the role of identity in shaping voting blocs and political discourse, with campaigns emphasizing regional and religious affiliations (Suberu, 2015; International Crisis Group, 2023).

The findings show that electoral cycles often exacerbate identity-based divisions. Zoning, rotational presidency, and informal power-sharing arrangements, while intended to promote inclusivity, paradoxically heighten ethnic and regional consciousness. For instance, the debate over Bola Ahmed Tinubu's Muslim–Muslim ticket in 2023 sparked tensions between North and South, and between Christian and Muslim communities, demonstrating how formal and informal institutional mechanisms can be politicized to deepen societal fault lines.

Beyond national politics, local disputes reveal the enduring impact of historical grievances and competition over resources. The Tiv–Jukun clashes in Wukari and Taraba exemplify how identity is weaponized in struggles over chieftaincy, land, and local political dominance. These conflicts are often exacerbated during electoral periods, as local actors exploit ethnic narratives to consolidate influence and political advantage (Paul & Victor, 2022). Similarly, the Jos crises in Plateau State show how disputes between Berom "indigenes" and Hausa-Fulani "settlers" over land and political representation become politicized along ethnic and religious lines, resulting in recurrent communal violence (Krause, 2011).

The Boko Haram insurgency in the Northeast highlights the intersection of identity and religious mobilization in violent conflict. While the insurgency has structural roots in poverty, weak governance, and ideological radicalization, its narratives of marginalization, moral decay, and religious revival illustrate how identity frames facilitate recruitment and local sympathy. This demonstrates that both local and insurgent actors leverage identity to achieve strategic political and social objectives.

The study's findings suggest that the persistent recentering of identity in political and social discourse undermines national cohesion and democratic consolidation. Institutional mechanisms intended to manage diversity, such as federal character, zoning, and rotational presidency, can be hijacked to reinforce exclusionary politics. Consequently, identity politics

not only fuels electoral and communal conflict but also institutionalizes divisions, making governance and conflict resolution more challenging.

Conclusively, the findings indicate that identity politics operates as both a strategic tool for elites and a social lens through which communities interpret political competition and resource allocation. From national elections to local disputes, identity frames exacerbate political divisions, perpetuate cycles of violence, and shape access to power and resources. Effective mitigation requires depoliticizing ethnic and religious identities, strengthening inclusive governance mechanisms, promoting equitable resource distribution, and investing in civic education that fosters cross-cutting social cohesion.

## Conclusion

The analysis of identity politics in Nigeria demonstrates that ethnicity, religion, region, and indigene-settler status have become central factors in shaping political behavior, electoral outcomes, and localized conflicts. Far from being a peripheral influence, identity has been strategically mobilized by political elites to secure loyalty, consolidate power, and control access to resources, often at the expense of national cohesion and social stability. Electoral contests, informal arrangements such as zoning, and disputes over political representation illustrate how identity frames are used to deepen polarization and exacerbate divisions, as seen in the 2011, 2015, and 2023 presidential elections.

At the local level, conflicts such as the Tiv–Jukun clashes in Taraba and Wukari, as well as the Berom–Hausa-Fulani disputes in Jos, demonstrate how historical grievances and competition over land, chieftaincy, and political office are politicized along ethnic and religious lines. Moreover, insurgencies like Boko Haram in the Northeast reveal how religious identity can be leveraged to recruit followers and mobilize support, compounding insecurity and undermining governance.

The role of identity politics in Nigeria underscores the fragility of its democratic institutions and the challenges of nation-building in a highly diverse society. It fosters recurrent communal violence, entrenches regional and religious cleavages, and undermines efforts toward equitable governance. Addressing these challenges requires deliberate strategies to depoliticize identity, strengthen inclusive institutions, promote equitable resource distribution, and foster civic engagement that transcends ethnic and religious divides. Without such interventions, identity politics will continue to serve as a powerful driver of political divisions and conflict in Nigeria.

## Recommendations

The following recommendations were made to add more value to the role of identity politics in fueling political divisions and conflict in Nigeria:

i. The government should develop mechanisms to strengthen equitable representation of all ethnic and religious groups through transparent appointments and enforcement of federal character principles to reduce exclusion and political tension in Nigeria.

ii. The government should regulate political parties and enforce strict electoral rules against hate speech and identity-based campaigning through the Independent National Electoral Commission to promote issue-based politics.

iii. The government should establish strong early-warning and mediation systems involving state and community actors to address grievances before they escalate into violence.

iv. The government should promote civic education, intergroup dialogue, and expand programs like the National Youth Service Corps to strengthen national identity and reduce ethnic and religious divisions.

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# AN ASSESSMENT OF YOUTH CONTRIBUTIONS AND CHALLENGES IN PEACEBUILDING IN TARABA STATE, NIGERIA (1991–2025)

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**Abstract.** One of the challenges that has confronted Taraba State, since its creation, has been the issue of violent conflicts among its diverse ethno-religious people. These violent conflicts, either resulting from economic, political, religious, or socio-cultural grounds, have led to negative consequences, ranging from destruction of lives and properties, destabilizing the developmental plans of the people and the government of the State at large. However, in the course of this violence, many actors have contributed in one way or the other, either intensifying the violence or resolving it and building peace thereafter for the growth of the people and the State. This study adopts a qualitative-dominant methodology, utilizing primary data from oral interviews and key informants, alongside secondary sources such as journals, reports, and policy documents. Through a multidisciplinary approach, the study examines the role of youth in peacebuilding in Taraba State. The paper posits that the youth in Taraba State are not inherently inclined to violent behavior; rather, they are products of their societies. It is argued, therefore, that integrating youth into peacebuilding processes in Taraba State is bound to facilitate the realization of sustainable peace in the State. It concludes that the involvement of youth in peacebuilding processes would facilitate their transformation from agents of violence to agents of peace in Taraba State and the nation at large.

**Keywords:** Youth, contributions, challenges, peacebuilding, conflict transformation theory.

## Introduction

Conflict has remained one of the most persistent challenges to human societies across history. From global wars to localized communal clashes, societies have struggled with how to prevent, manage, and resolve disputes that arise from competing interests, identities, and resources. The wars in the Western Balkans following the dissolution of Yugoslavia in 1991, for example, left deep scars of political, ethnic, and social divisions that continue to shape the region's present realities. Despite large investments in transitional justice, reconciliation, and international interventions, inter-ethnic tensions, polarized media, and nationalist ideologies persist, raising doubts about the long-term effectiveness of external peacebuilding strategies (Fairey & Kerr, 2020). Importantly, youth have often been alienated from these peacebuilding

processes, fuelling feelings of disappointment and disillusionment (Greenberg, 2014). Scholars such as McEvoy-Levy (2001) argue that this neglect of youth in peace processes is short-sighted and undermines the sustainability of peace, as young people are not only victims of violence but also hold untapped potential as transformative agents of reconciliation and peacebuilding.

In Africa, violent conflicts remain a major impediment to peace, security, and development. From protracted civil wars in Liberia and Sierra Leone to ethnic-based conflicts in Sudan and Ethiopia, African states continue to grapple with the challenge of sustaining peace in multi-ethnic and multi-religious societies. In Nigeria, Africa's most populous country, violent conflicts are deeply rooted in political, religious, ethnic, and socio-economic fault lines. The rise of insurgent groups such as Boko Haram in the North-east, farmer–herder clashes in the Middle Belt, militancy in the Niger Delta, and banditry in the North-west region are all evidence of how insecurity has become both widespread and multidimensional (World Bank, 2017). These conflicts have destroyed livelihoods, displaced millions, and undermined the country's democratic and developmental aspirations.

Within this national context, Taraba State offers a microcosm of Nigeria's wider conflict dynamics. Since its creation in 1991, the state has experienced recurrent violent conflicts, particularly along ethnic and religious lines. Its diverse population, comprising different ethnic groups, faiths, and communities, has frequently clashed over land ownership, political representation, resource distribution, and cultural differences. These conflicts have often escalated into large-scale violence, leading to destruction of lives and property, mass displacement, and destabilization of social and economic life in the state (Best, 2006). Weak institutions have exacerbated the violence in Taraba State, the manipulation of identities by elites, and the marginalization of certain groups, particularly young people. Youth are not inherently violent; they are products of their socio-political environment (Obaje & Okeke-Uzodike, 2013).

The role of youth in these conflicts has been complex and multifaceted. On one hand, youth have often been mobilized as foot soldiers of violence by politicians, religious leaders, and ethnic entrepreneurs who exploit their energy, vulnerabilities, and limited opportunities (Ikelegbe, 2013). On the other hand, youth are also among the most affected victims of violent conflicts, losing lives, opportunities for education, and prospects for meaningful livelihoods. However, youth also hold significant potential as peacebuilders, particularly when engaged through community-based initiatives, grassroots organizations, and state-led peacebuilding efforts (Ugiomoh & Ajayi, 2019). Their creativity, energy, and ability to mobilize peers position them as critical actors for promoting dialogue, reconciliation, and social transformation. The involvement of youths in post-conflict resolution is crucial for peacebuilding and national development. (Jonathan & Mohammed, 2021).

It is therefore important to examine youth, not merely as passive victims or perpetrators, but as critical stakeholders in the peacebuilding process. This paper argues that youth in Taraba

State are not inherently violent; rather, they are products of their socio-political environment. When meaningfully engaged, they can become key drivers of sustainable peace. This article therefore fills an important gap by assessing the contributions and challenges of youths to peace-building in Taraba State between 1991 and 2025. It critically examines the forms of youth participation, evaluates their impact on conflict mitigation, and identifies the constraints limiting their effectiveness. The study is guided by the recognition that empowering young people as peace actors is central to sustainable development and social stability in Nigeria.

**The problem**

Since its creation in 1991, Taraba State has been plagued by recurrent violent conflicts driven by ethnic rivalries, religious tensions, political competition, and struggles over land and resources. These conflicts have left devastating consequences: mass killings, destruction of property, displacement of thousands, and deep fractures in inter-communal trust. Such instability has undermined socio-economic development and weakened state institutions (Albert, 2001; Okoli & Iortyer, 2014). Amid these recurring crises, youth have often been stereotyped primarily as perpetrators of violence, manipulated by political elites, religious leaders, and ethnic entrepreneurs who exploit their energy and vulnerability for destructive purposes (Umar, 2019; Akinwale, 2010). Youths have been used as political tools to perpetrate violence; yet they remain the most affected by conflict. This narrative, however, oversimplifies their role and disregards their potential as constructive agents in peace processes. Studies in other regions demonstrate that youth, when positively engaged, have contributed meaningfully to reconciliation, grassroots peacebuilding, and social transformation (Snyder & Norton, 2015; Paffenholz, 2014). The dominant perception of youths as violent actors has led to their exclusion from formal peace processes. The instability has significantly undermined socio-economic development and weakened state institutions (Nagombe & Umar, 2025; Mercy Corps, 2024).

Despite this global evidence, there is limited scholarly work examining the actual contributions of youth in peacebuilding within Taraba State. Most analyses of conflict dynamics in the region focus on ethno-religious divisions or political manipulation while neglecting how youth themselves navigate, resist, or transform these conditions (Brock & Caryl, 2020). This knowledge gap raises an urgent question: should Taraba's youth continue to be viewed merely as agents of violence, or can they be recognized and empowered as partners in building lasting peace? Addressing this problem is vital not only for the future of Taraba State but also for Nigeria, where young people represent the largest demographic group and an untapped resource for sustainable peace.

## Conceptual Clarifications

In any academic discourse, clarity of key concepts is essential to avoid ambiguity and misinterpretation (Babbie, 2010).

### Conflict

Jeong (2008) describes conflict as "a relationship between two or more parties who believe they have incompatible goals." Similarly, Kriesberg (2007) explains conflict as a social situation in which actors pursue goals that appear mutually exclusive, thereby creating tension and confrontation. It is an integral aspect of social interaction and a fundamental feature of human existence. Conflict occurs because individuals and groups have different needs, interests, perceptions, and aspirations (Coser, 1956). As such, it can manifest in various settings within a person, between people, among groups, or even between nations. While some conflicts lead to destruction and hostility, others serve as agents of change, stimulating growth, reform, and adaptation within societies (Folger, Poole & Stutman, 2017).

Conflict is a dynamic struggle that arises when individuals or groups perceive that those essential human needs, such as security, identity, recognition, participation, and self-actualization, are being denied, threatened, or compromised by others (Maslow, 1943; Burton, 1990; Azar, 1990). In such situations, affected actors seek to protect or realize those non-negotiable needs. They may resort to measures intended to neutralize, injure, or eliminate perceived rivals if peaceful redress is unavailable. Thus, conflict is both a response to deprivation and an assertion of human dignity and survival, and its escalation depends on the intensity of unmet needs and the absence of legitimate avenues for their satisfaction (Burton, 1990; Maslow, 1943).

### Violence

Violence is typically understood as the use of physical force to harm, damage, or kill. However, Galtung (1996) expands the concept to include structural violence, which refers to social structures or institutions that harm individuals by preventing them from meeting their basic needs. In Taraba State, violence has taken both direct forms such as communal clashes, armed attacks, and political thuggery and indirect forms, including marginalization, poverty, and exclusion of youth from decision-making processes. In this context, violence is defined as both the physical manifestations of conflict (clashes, displacement, property destruction) and the structural conditions (unemployment, political exclusion) that sustain instability.

### Peacebuilding

Peacebuilding involves reconciliation, dialogue, and social transformation to address root causes of conflict. Peacebuilding is broadly defined as a long-term process aimed at

preventing the outbreak, escalation, and recurrence of violent conflict while fostering social, economic, and political transformation to achieve sustainable peace (Bachir, 2021; Olaniyi, 2021). According to Olaniyi (2021), peacebuilding encompasses a variety of strategies and initiatives such as conflict prevention, conflict resolution, peace education, community dialogue, reconciliation, and social integration. These processes are crucial in fostering stability and social harmony, particularly in societies emerging from conflict or facing persistent insecurity.

In the context of Nigeria, peacebuilding is especially significant due to the country's long-standing experiences with intercommunal conflict, political instability, and insecurity (Awodiya, 2021; Eze, 2020). Awodiya (2021) emphasizes that youth engagement and participation should be central to peacebuilding efforts, given their potential to drive positive social change and support sustainable peace. The involvement of young people not only promotes inclusivity but also strengthens local ownership of peace initiatives.

**Youth**

The concept of youth is context-dependent. The United Nations (2018) defines youth as individuals between the ages of 18 and 24, while in the African context, the African Union (2006) extends the definition to include persons aged 15 to 35. Beyond age, Honwana (2012) views youth as a social category shaped by marginalization, aspirations, and the struggle for inclusion in political and economic life. In conflict settings, youth are frequently perceived as both vulnerable actors susceptible to manipulation and as potential agents of positive social transformation (Ugiomoh & Ajayi, 2019).

**Youth Contribution**

Okeke (2021) argues that youth contributions should also be assessed not only by immediate outcomes but also by long-term impacts on community resilience, tolerance, and intergroup collaboration.

**Theoretical Framework**

The theoretical foundation for this study is Conflict Transformation Theory, developed by John Paul Lederach in the mid-1990s. Unlike conflict management or conflict resolution, which focus mainly on suppressing violence or negotiating settlements, conflict transformation emphasizes changing the underlying social relationships, structures, and attitudes that generate and sustain violent conflict (Lederach, 1997). The theory posits that sustainable peace can only be achieved when societies move beyond short-term ceasefires and address the deeper roots of grievances such as exclusion, inequality, and lack of dialogue (Lederach, 2003).

A central proposition of the theory is that peace-building is not a one-time intervention but a long-term process involving multiple actors at different levels of society. Lederach (1995) highlights three levels of peace-building: top-level leaders (political and military elites), middle-range leaders (community leaders, academics, religious leaders), and grassroots actors (ordinary citizens and youth groups). Youths, because of their numbers, energy, and direct presence in communities, occupy a critical position in the grassroots and middle-range levels of this peace architecture, their involvement in mediation, civic education, and interfaith initiatives in Taraba State.

**State Reflects Precisely the Type of Bottom-Up Peace-Building Envisaged in the Theory**

Applying this theory to Taraba State, youth engagement in early-warning mechanisms, interfaith dialogues, and digital activism can be understood as transformative actions that go beyond suppressing violence. These initiatives aim to reshape hostile attitudes, build trust across ethnic and religious divides, and strengthen local resilience. For example, when youth peace clubs organize inter-community sports competitions or awareness campaigns against electoral violence, they are not merely preventing immediate violence. However, they are transforming intergroup perceptions and laying the groundwork for future cooperation (Ibrahim & Alemika, 2020).

The theory also explains why youth contributions are sometimes limited. Structural constraints such as unemployment, poverty, and political manipulation represent forms of "structural violence" that hinder youths from realizing their full peace-building potential (Galtung, 1969). Conflict Transformation Theory therefore underscores the importance of empowering youth through training, recognition, and institutional support, so that they can actively transform conflict systems rather than being trapped as tools in them.

Conflict Transformation Theory provides a robust analytical lens for assessing the contribution of youths to peace-building in Taraba State. It emphasizes long-term engagement, local ownership of peace processes, and the transformation of hostile relationships into constructive ones. By situating youths as central grassroots actors, the theory highlights both their agency and the structural challenges that shape their peace-building efforts between 1991 and 2025.

**Methodology**

This study adopts a qualitative-dominant research design in examining the contributions and challenges of youth to peacebuilding in Taraba State between 1991 and 2025. Given the historical and socio-political nature of the subject, data were generated from both primary and secondary sources to ensure depth and contextual richness.

## Primary Data

Primary data were collected through oral interviews and key informant engagements. Purposive sampling was used to identify individuals with direct knowledge of youth involvement in peacebuilding. Three youth leaders were central to this process: Comrade Udi Pastore, who mediated between youth and government during the #EndSARS protests in 2020. Comrade Nafinji Abokki, who organized grassroots mediation and community watch groups in Wukari between 2019 and 2023. Franklin Cosmos, who has led annual International Peace Day campaigns in Jalingo since 2019. These interviews provided firsthand narratives of youth participation in mediation, advocacy, and civic education. Field observations during peace sensitization programs and youth dialogue forums further enriched the data, offering insights into how young people engage beyond written documentation.

## Secondary Data

Secondary data were drawn from academic journals, government policy documents, NGO reports, media publications, and digital sources. Materials from organizations such as the United Nations, IOM Nigeria, and the Para-Mallam Peace Foundation were particularly useful in contextualizing youth-led initiatives. Social media campaigns and online broadcasts also provided contemporary evidence of youth activism and peace advocacy in Taraba State. The combination of primary and secondary sources ensured triangulation and strengthened the reliability of the study's findings.

## Data Analysis

Data analysis employed qualitative thematic methods supported by historical interpretation. This approach allowed the study to capture both the immediate and long-term contributions of youth to peacebuilding.

## Thematic Analysis

Evidence from interviews and documents was organized into key themes: Mediation and conflict resolution, advocacy and awareness campaigns, interfaith and interethnic dialogue, peace education and leadership training, youth-led development initiatives, monitoring and reporting of violence, and challenges limiting youth effectiveness. This thematic categorization highlighted the diverse ways in which youth have contributed to reconciliation and community cohesion.

**Taraba State and Violence (1991-2025).**

Taraba State, created in 1991 out of the former Gongola State, is located in Nigeria's North-East geopolitical zone. It shares international borders with Cameroon to the east and inter-state boundaries with Benue, Plateau, Adamawa, Nasarawa, and Gombe. Known as "Nature's Gift to the Nation", Taraba is endowed with fertile land, rich cultural diversity, and mineral resources. However, this same diversity of over 80 ethnic groups with distinct cultural, linguistic, and religious identities has made the state highly susceptible to violent conflicts (Best, 2007).

Since 1991, Taraba State has been marked by recurrent episodes of communal, ethno-religious, and farmer-herder violence. Conflicts between the Jukun and Tiv in Wukari, Ibi, Gassol and Donga Local Government Areas, Kuteb-Chamba disputes in Takum, and Fulani-Mambilla clashes in Sardauna have left deep scars on inter-communal relations (Blench, 2017). These violent encounters are often triggered by contestations over land ownership, chieftaincy succession, political representation, and access to scarce economic resources (Egwu, 2016). The state's strategic border with Cameroon has further facilitated the inflow of small arms and light weapons, exacerbating the intensity and frequency of clashes (Onuoha, 2011).

The democratization process in Nigeria since 1999 has also had paradoxical effects on peace in Taraba. While democracy opened spaces for political participation, it also heightened ethnic competition and elite manipulation of communal identities. Youths, due to unemployment and poverty, were frequently mobilized as foot soldiers during political crises and communal disputes (Adebanwi, 2004). In particular, the violent clashes in Wukari between Jukun and Tiv communities in 2001 and the violent outbreaks in Takum and Bali have demonstrated the vulnerability of youth to political manipulation but also their centrality in local peace negotiations when violence subsides (Akinwale, 2019).

More recent conflicts have taken new forms. Farmer-herder clashes, driven by climate change, population pressure, and grazing disputes, have become more frequent since the mid-2000s. In the Mambilla Plateau, violent confrontations between indigenous groups and Fulani pastoralists have led to significant casualties and displacement (International Crisis Group, 2017). The spread of kidnapping, banditry, and armed robbery in the 2010s further compounded insecurity, creating complex security threats that overstretched government responses.

Despite these challenges, Taraba State has also been a hub of peace-building initiatives. Traditional institutions, such as the Muri Emirate Council, and faith-based organizations have initiated dialogues aimed at fostering coexistence. In many of these processes, youth groups have been mobilized as peace volunteers, interfaith advocates, and community watchdogs. Their grassroots presence has enabled them to act as mediators in local disputes, conduct

civic education, and participate in security partnerships with vigilante groups and formal security agencies (Ibrahim & Alemika, 2020). Thus, while Taraba is often portrayed in terms of its violent conflicts, it is also a fertile ground for studying the transformative role of youth in peace-building.

**Youth involvement in peace-building in Taraba State, 1991–2025**

Following the Second World War, the international community was left both shocked and exhausted. In response to the devastation, the Marshall Plan was introduced to rebuild war-torn Europe. Proponents viewed it as a model for peacebuilding and recovery (Wilson, 1977), while critics regarded it as a means for the United States to exert control over Western Europe through aid programs designed to counter Soviet influence (O'Brien, 2014). According to the World Bank, early peacebuilding efforts focused on "economic recovery and normalization," whereas the United Nations placed greater emphasis on political processes (Barakat, 2005). Given its highly contextual nature, peacebuilding should not be defined from a single perspective. The UN also stresses that sustainable peace requires "extensive human, knowledge and financial investments" (Zyck, 2016).

As McEvoy-Levy (2014) observes, youth should be represented in political negotiations, peace processes, and reconstruction efforts for at least four reasons: because they participated in preceding conflicts; because they possess rights to participation; because they bring valuable knowledge and ideas; and because sustainable peace requires intergenerational healing. Building capacity among both elites and youth is essential, particularly the ability to share power with young people at the highest levels. Therefore, youth inclusion in peacebuilding processes is vital to ensure political, social, and economic participation, especially for the young people of Taraba State, who have lived within a conflict-prone environment since 1991.

Youth constitute a significant proportion of Taraba State's population and play a vital role in maintaining peace, security, and community cohesion. Given their demographic strength, creativity, and social influence, young people have become essential agents in promoting dialogue, reconciliation, and sustainable peace. Since the creation of Taraba State in 1991, youth involvement in peacebuilding has evolved from informal participation in community mediation to organized and technology-driven initiatives.

During the 1990s and early 2000s, youth participation in peacebuilding primarily occurred through traditional community forums and local vigilante groups, which sought to prevent violence and protect lives and property during communal conflicts. Many youths served as mediators, message carriers, and peace advocates within their localities, working under the guidance of traditional and religious leaders. Although it seems informal, these roles were critical in fostering trust, encouraging reconciliation, and reducing the intensity of local

disputes. Taraba State youth have contributed to the rate and pace of peacebuilding directly and indirectly in various ways as follows;

Mediation and Conflict Resolution: Youth often act as mediators and peace brokers in conflicts, facilitating dialogue between opposing parties and helping to negotiate compromises. They can organize youth-led mediation forums or act as neutral interlocutors, bridging trust gaps and reducing tensions (Abdulraheem, 2018). Youth groups have mediated local disputes in post-crisis communities, reducing tensions among ethnic groups in Taraba State. (Jonathan & Mohammed, 2021). A recent example is the Tiv–Fulani peace accord in Gassol Local Government Area, where leaders from both sides signed a peace pact to end recurring clashes (Guardian, June 2025). In that process, youth representatives were included among the stakeholders invited by military and local authorities to deliberate on sustainable peace. Also, in Southern Taraba, youth groups like Southern Taraba Youths Coalition for Peace (STYCOP) have issued press statements and engaged in local dialogue efforts to foster cohesion and discourage violence. However, mediation is not always smooth because in Bandawa (a community in Taraba), some youth reportedly violated a prior peace accord by launching attacks on herders, triggering reprisals. This shows that youth roles and efforts can lead both toward mediation and escalation if their buy-in is not sustained.

**Project**

Zamman Lafiya Taraba (2024–2025), led by the Para-Mallam Peace Foundation, actively mobilized thousands of youths across Wukari, Ussa, and Takum after years of ethnic clashes. Youth facilitated community forums, cross-cultural visits, and peace walks that directly contributed to reducing tensions between Tiv, Jukun, and Fulani communities.

Advocacy and Awareness-Raising: Youth can raise awareness about the impacts of conflict and promote peace values by using their voices and platforms. This includes running social media campaigns, holding community outreach events, and leveraging youth networks to spread messages of tolerance and nonviolence (Nyeneokpon, 2018).

Youth advocacy is evident in Taraba State. For example, the Ajadi Rescue Movement (Taraba State chapter) has publicly reaffirmed its commitment to youth empowerment, unity, and peace, leveraging media statements and public engagements. The state government has also directly targeted youth with peace messages: a recent video shows that the Taraba government sensitizes youths on peacebuilding, broadcast through media channels. Youth groups in Taraba have also expressed strong opinions on traditional governance and community affairs. Similarly, #PeaceInWukariNowCampaign (2021), initiated by young activists from Federal University Wukari, went viral across social media, garnering thousands of engagements and drawing the attention of mediators to disputes.

Comrade Udi Pastore, the former NYCN Taraba State chapter president who mediated during the #ENDSars protests in Taraba (2020), used social media livestreams, Facebook, town halls, and WhatsApp broadcast networks to calm young protesters and disseminate accurate information from his meeting with the Deputy Governor. His digital advocacy helped prevent violence in Jalingo.

The October 2025 Taraba youth media for peace workshop, organized by the Taraba State Bureau for Peace and Conflict Management and GIZ, trained over 150 youth on using digital tools to counter hate speech, report violence, and create peace content. This training increased youth participation in digital peace advocacy across the state. These examples show youth using media, public statements, and advocacy to influence discourse and governance in Taraba State.

Education and Skills-Building: Peace education programs targeting youth have been implemented to build conflict resolution skills (Obaje & Okeke-Uzodike, 2013). By providing training, formal education, vocational skills, and leadership development, youth become better equipped to engage in dialogue, manage conflicts, and foster peace (Achebe, 2020). In Taraba State, there is evidence of institutional efforts to empower youth with skills. Recently, the government signed two bills to empower youth, including via a Youth Development Agency and structures to support youth initiatives (Leadership NG). Additionally, youth training workshops are organized in local government areas such as Wukari, Takum, Ussa, etc., often in partnership with NGOs or external bodies to teach conflict resolution, leadership, and civic skills (reports in Guardian and other media). Comrade Nafinji Aboki, former Jukun Youth President in Wukari LGA, trained youth as early warning agents and information gatherers between 2019 and 2023. His model was later adopted by local security committees in Wukari and Takum LGAs.

Community Mobilization and Volunteering: Youth can mobilize their peers and communities for peace actions such as peace walks, clean-ups, volunteer relief activities, and local peace campaigns, thus harnessing social energy toward reconciliation (Okeke, 2020). Youth coalitions are active in mobilizing for peace. The Southern Taraba Youths Coalition for Peace (STYCOP) campaigns against violence in the southern zone of the state, promoting dialogue, togetherness, and peaceful coexistence. Also, the Taraba State Government has engaged youth directly through sensitization programs. Videos showed government-led efforts where youth are educated about peace-building principles and volunteer action. Furthermore, the signing of peace pacts (e.g., Tiv-Fulani in Gassol) was preceded by community mobilization, and youth groups played roles in rallying people, supporting logistics, and building grassroots acceptance of the peace agreement. Mr. Franklin Cosmos, a prominent Taraba youth activist, has led annual International Peace Day walk-a-thons in Jalingo since 2019. In 2025, he partnered with the Taraba State Bureau for Peace and Conflict Management to launch a youth-led civic education series on peace and democratic participation

Youth-led Peacebuilding Initiatives: Youth are critical actors in promoting peace, as they possess the creativity, energy, and understanding needed to tackle the root causes of conflict. Through youth-led initiatives, young people have been able to develop programs that address issues such as marginalization, political exclusion, and social inequality. For instance, the Young African Leaders Initiative (YALI) Network in Nigeria has spearheaded several peace-oriented projects, such as the "YALI RLC Nigeria Emerging Leaders Peace Camp," which equips young individuals with negotiation, mediation, and leadership skills essential for conflict transformation (Ayorinde, 2020). Initiatives such as 'Youth for Peace Taraba' have emerged to address local conflicts. (Jonathan & Mohammed, 2021). Taraba State youth have also taken the lead in various peacebuilding efforts. Organizations such as the Taraba Youth Peace Initiative (TYPI) and the Young Ambassadors for Community Peace and Interfaith Foundation (YACPIF) have mobilized young people across Jalingo, Wukari, and Takum to promote peaceful coexistence among ethnic and religious groups. These groups organize peace walks, dialogue forums, and social media campaigns that advocate for unity and tolerance among the Tiv, Jukun, and Fulani communities.

Interfaith and Interethnic Dialogue: Promoting interfaith and interethnic dialogue is another vital avenue through which youth can contribute to sustainable peace. By engaging people from diverse religious and ethnic backgrounds, youth-led programs can foster trust, mutual respect, and reconciliation. For instance, the Interfaith Mediation Center (IMC) in Kaduna has successfully brought together Christian and Muslim youth to promote understanding and tolerance (Onyegbula, 2019).

Similarly, in Taraba State, where diversity often fuels misunderstanding, youth have organized dialogue sessions to bridge religious and ethnic-group divides between Jukun, Tiv, Hausa, and Fulani groups. The Taraba State Youth Council and local NGOs such as Hope Afresh Foundation Taraba have been instrumental in facilitating community dialogues and peace advocacy programs. These initiatives have been crucial in promoting religious tolerance and resolving farmer-herder disputes, particularly in Wukari and Bali Local Government Areas. The COMITAS project by IOM Nigeria actively engaged Taraba youth in farmer–herder mediation in Zing and Lau LGAs. Through peace committees and dialogue sessions, young people helped restore trust in affected communities.

**Monitoring and Reporting Human Rights Abuses:** Youth play a vital role in observing and documenting human rights abuses, especially in conflict-affected communities. By monitoring incidents of violence and reporting them to relevant authorities, they help ensure accountability and prevent recurrence. The Network of Young Female Leaders in Nigeria has been a notable example, championing the defense of women and children in fragile contexts (Achimugu, 2021). Taraba State youth-led groups like Women and Youth Peace Network (WYPN) and Community Youth Observers of Taraba (CYOT) have reported instances of displacement, land conflicts, and gender-based violence to local authorities and NGOs. Their

collaboration with media outlets and digital platforms has amplified the voices of marginalized victims and pressured community leaders to act on issues of injustice and violence. The 2025 Taraba youth media for peace workshop (as mentioned above) greatly enhanced youth capacity to report human rights abuses using mobile journalism and community reporting networks

**Youth-led Initiatives for Sustainable Development:** Sustainable development initiatives are central to peacebuilding, as they address the underlying socio-economic causes of conflict, such as poverty, inequality, and unemployment. Youth organizations such as the Nigerian Youth Climate Coalition have promoted environmental sustainability, renewable energy, and food security as pathways to peace (Bamidele, 2018). Taraba State youth have engaged in similar sustainability-driven peace efforts. The Taraba Green Youth Movement and Jalingo Agro Peace Project have empowered young farmers with training on sustainable agriculture, conflict-sensitive resource management, and eco-friendly practices. The August, 2024 AFRICOSUD youth governance forum in Jalingo brought together over 200 youth and government officials to discuss SDGs, good governance, and peacebuilding, strengthening youth-state collaboration. These projects not only reduce poverty and unemployment but also discourage youth involvement in violence by offering economic alternatives.

**Challenges faced by the youth in contributing to peacebuilding in Taraba State**

Despite the critical role of young people in peacebuilding and conflict prevention, numerous challenges continue to hinder their effective participation in Nigeria's peace processes. These challenges are structural, institutional, economic, and security-related in nature, collectively limiting the youth's potential to serve as effective agents of peace and social transformation.

Limited Opportunities and Exclusion from Decision-Making: One of the most significant obstacles facing youths in peacebuilding is their exclusion from policy formulation and decision-making platforms. According to Irobi (2019), youth are often perceived as inexperienced or incapable of handling critical governance and peace-related responsibilities, thereby reducing their inclusion in national and community-level peace dialogues. This generational bias marginalizes them from participating meaningfully in peace and security decision-making processes. The absence of youth representation in peace committees and government structures further weakens the long-term sustainability of peace efforts.

Similar patterns of exclusion exist, particularly in local peace committees and traditional institutions in Taraba State where older elites dominate discussions on communal conflicts. Although the Taraba Youth Peace Initiative (TYPI) and Young Ambassadors for Community Peace and Interfaith Foundation (YACPIF) have advocated for youth inclusion in peace platforms, their influence remains limited due to a lack of institutional recognition and government engagement.

**Inadequate Funding and Institutional Support**

Another major challenge is the shortage of financial resources and institutional backing. Youth-led organizations often depend on donor assistance or voluntary contributions to fund their activities, which limits the continuity of their programs (Ejimeke, 2019). The lack of structured government funding mechanisms for youth peace initiatives restricts their ability to organize large-scale projects or engage in long-term interventions such as capacity building, community mediation, and post-conflict recovery. Just as in Taraba State, most youth-led groups, such as the Women and Youth Peace Network (WYPN) and Community Youth Observers of Taraba (CYOT), operate with minimal financial support. The absence of steady funding has led to project discontinuity, low outreach capacity, and the inability to reach conflict-prone areas such as Wukari, Takum, and Lau. Consequently, many youth organizations struggle to maintain their operations beyond donor-driven phases.

**Insecurity and Threats to Peacebuilders**

The volatile security situation in many parts of Nigeria exposes youth peacebuilders to significant risks. According to Okeke (2020), young peace advocates working in conflict-affected zones often face intimidation, physical attacks, and abductions by violent groups who perceive them as threats to their influence. This constant danger discourages many from engaging in community peace work, particularly in rural areas where state security presence is weak. Youth in Taraba State who are mediators involved in inter-ethnic peacebuilding, especially in Jukun-Tiv and Fulani-farmer conflict zones, have experienced harassment and targeted violence. The persistent clashes in Wukari, Bali, and Donga Local Government Areas have made peace volunteers vulnerable, limiting their ability to conduct dialogues or monitor violence effectively. Some organizations have resorted to digital advocacy as a safer alternative to physical interventions.

**Distrust Between Youths and Government Authorities:**

A further limitation to youth peace efforts is the mutual distrust between young people and government institutions. Ayodele and Azeez (2019) assert that many government officials view youth-led initiatives with skepticism, suspecting them of political motives. This perception has discouraged collaboration and resource-sharing between youth networks and official peacebuilding agencies. Furthermore, the bureaucratic rigidity of government institutions slows the implementation of youth-driven proposals, leading to frustration among active young peace advocates. In Taraba State, this tension is evident in the relationship between youth organizations and state authorities. Despite the establishment of state-level youth offices, cooperation on peacebuilding projects remains minimal. Many youth groups complain of being sidelined during policy discussions or community peace summits organized by the Ministry of Youth and Sports or the Peacebuilding Agency. This has fostered

a sense of exclusion and reduced trust in government sincerity toward youth empowerment and peace promotion.

**Socio-Economic Challenges**

Poverty, Unemployment, and Inequality: Socio-economic deprivation remains a root cause limiting youth participation in peacebuilding. Agbese (2018) emphasizes that poverty and unemployment drive frustration, making young people more susceptible to manipulation by political elites or violent groups. Youth who struggle for daily survival often prioritize economic gain over volunteer peace work, thereby reducing the sustainability of peace initiatives. Inequality in access to education and livelihood opportunities also deepens grievances that fuel conflict, particularly among marginalized youth populations. The challenge is no different in Taraba State; high youth unemployment rates, especially in rural communities, have contributed to cycles of violence and restiveness. Many young people have been recruited into communal militias or political thuggery due to economic hardship. However, some programs, such as the Taraba Green Youth Empowerment Scheme and Hope Afresh Foundation vocational projects, have attempted to reduce these risks by offering alternative livelihood and training opportunities that promote peaceful coexistence.

**Weak Institutional Coordination and Sustainability**

The lack of coordination among peacebuilding stakeholders undermines youth efforts. Multiple youth organizations operate in isolation without strategic alignment or knowledge-sharing platforms. According to Eniola (2020), this fragmentation results in duplication of efforts, competition for limited resources, and limited impact on the ground. Without institutional frameworks that connect local, national, and international youth initiatives, peacebuilding efforts remain disjointed. Taraba State, several youth-led initiatives function independently without collaboration with other stakeholders like the Peacebuilding Agency, traditional rulers, or religious councils. This weak coordination reduces the efficiency and visibility of youth efforts and hampers long-term sustainability. Strengthening inter-agency networks, mentorship structures, and policy integration would significantly improve the effectiveness of youth-led peace interventions in the state.

**Conclusion**

Nigerian youths, particularly those in Taraba State, play an indispensable role in peacebuilding; their impact remains constrained by multiple structural and socio-economic barriers. Exclusion from decision-making, lack of institutional and financial support, insecurity, distrust between government and youth groups, and widespread poverty continue to limit their effectiveness in sustaining peace initiatives. In Taraba, these challenges are

compounded by the state's history of inter-ethnic and communal violence, which often discourages young people from taking active roles in reconciliation efforts. Nevertheless, the resilience and creativity of Taraba's youth, demonstrated through organizations such as the Taraba Youth Peace Initiative, Young Ambassadors for Community Peace and Interfaith Foundation, and Women and Youth Peace Network, show that meaningful progress is achievable. Addressing these challenges through improved funding, inclusive governance, and socio-economic empowerment will not only strengthen youth participation but also lay the foundation for lasting peace and security in Taraba State and Nigeria as a whole.

**Recommendations**

i. To coordinate youth-led peace efforts and offer financial and technical support, the Taraba State government should create a Youth Peace and Security Desk within the Agency of Youth and Sports.

ii. In order to foster early understanding of tolerance and communication, peace education should be incorporated into secondary and postsecondary curricula, especially in local government regions that are prone to conflict in Taraba State, Nigeria.

iii. In order to combat false information and advance peace narratives online, stakeholders in Taraba State, including NGOs and development partners, should make investments in teaching young people digital skills.

iv. Annual young Peace Conferences and community service initiatives should promote ongoing interaction between young groups of all religious and ethnic origins across all conflict-prone local government areas in Taraba State within the period 1991–2025

v. In order to facilitate evidence-based policymaking and better actor coordination, a state-led data system should be established to monitor youth involvement in peacebuilding initiatives.

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# AN INVESTIGATION OF THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN COMMUNAL VIOLENCE AND RURAL-URBAN MIGRATION IN WUKARI LOCAL GOVERNMENT AREA OF TARABA STATE, 1991-2021

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**Abstract.** This study explores the relationship between communal conflict and rural–urban migration in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State, from 1991 to 2021. Over the past three decades, recurrent communal violence has disrupted livelihoods, displaced populations, and reshaped settlement patterns in Wukari Local Government Area. Guided by the push–pull theory of migration, the research examines how violent conflict functions as a "push" factor, compelling rural dwellers to migrate, while the relative safety, economic opportunities, and social networks in urban centers act as "pull" factors, attracting them. To further interpret the wider dynamic, the study draws on modernization theory, which provides a framework for understanding how conflict-induced migration contributes to urbanization, social change, and governance challenges. Methodologically, the study adopts the qualitative survey approach, relying on primary information from selected (5) persons through the use of key informant interviews (KII) and focus group discussions (FGD). More so, secondary information from published and unpublished documents was used in the research process to arrive at the expected conclusion. This study revealed a strong connection between communal violence and rural–urban migration, with implications for rural depopulation, urban growth, and sustainable development planning in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State, Nigeria.

**Keywords:** Conflict, communal violence, migration, rural-urban migration, push and pull factors, economic opportunities.

## Introduction

Communal violence has remained a recurring challenge in Nigeria, particularly in the Middle Belt region where ethnic, religious, and cultural diversity often intersects with competition over land, political power, and access to resources. Wukari Local Government Area (LGA) in Taraba State represents one of the most volatile conflict zones in this region, having experienced numerous violent clashes between different ethnic and religious groups, notably

between the Jukun, Tiv, and Hausa/Fulani communities, since the early 1990s (Egwu, 2016; Audu, 2020).

The roots of communal conflict in Wukari are deep and multifaceted. They stem from historical contestations over land ownership, political exclusion, identity politics, and resource control, among others. Recurrent clashes, such as those recorded in 1992, 2001, 2013, and 2019, have resulted in widespread destruction of lives and property, the burning of settlements, and forced displacement of thousands of people (Okoli & Atelhe, 2014). The prolonged nature of these conflicts has eroded social cohesion and triggered waves of rural–urban migration as residents flee insecurity and deteriorating living conditions.

Communal violence in Wukari has produced far-reaching impacts across several dimensions. Agriculturally, large expanses of farmland have been abandoned due to insecurity, leading to food shortages and loss of income among rural dwellers. Institutionally, the violence has disrupted essential public services: schools have been closed, health facilities vandalized, and local governance paralyzed. Economically, the frequent destruction of markets, transport networks, and business premises has led to unemployment, reduced investment, and capital flight from rural communities. Socially, inter-group mistrust, family separation, and displacement have become widespread, undermining traditional social networks and collective resilience.

Environmental and security conditions have equally worsened. Deforestation and overgrazing, compounded by human displacement, have intensified resource scarcity and environmental degradation, further fueling competition and migration. At the same time, insecurity has become endemic, with residents facing constant threats from armed groups, reprisal attacks, and banditry. This combination of agricultural decline, institutional collapse, economic hardship, environmental stress, and insecurity has compelled many individuals and families to migrate from rural communities to urban centers such as Wukari, Jalingo, Makurdi, and even Abuja in search of peace, safety, and livelihood opportunities (International Organization for Migration [IOM], 2022).

The relationship between communal violence and rural–urban migration in Wukari therefore presents a complex socio-economic and institutional challenge. Understanding this relationship is crucial for developing evidence-based interventions that promote peacebuilding, rural stability, and balanced regional development in Taraba State and Nigeria at large.

**Methodology**

This study adopted a qualitative research design to examine the influence of communal violence on rural–urban migration in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State between 1991 and 2021. The qualitative approach was considered appropriate because it

facilitates an in-depth understanding of participants' experiences, perceptions, and interpretations regarding communal conflict and migration. Given the complex social and cultural dimensions of conflict-induced migration, qualitative methods provided rich and contextualized data that could not be adequately captured through quantitative techniques.

The study was conducted in Wukari Local Government Area, a conflict-prone region that has experienced recurrent communal clashes involving the Jukun, Tiv, and Hausa/Fulani ethnic groups. The area was purposively selected because of its history of violent conflicts and the resulting migration patterns observed over the study period.

The target population comprised individuals and groups with direct knowledge and experience of communal violence and migration. These included displaced persons, traditional rulers, government officials, community leaders, youth leaders, women leaders, and representatives of non-governmental organizations involved in peacebuilding and humanitarian activities.

A purposive sampling technique was employed to select participants who possessed relevant information concerning the phenomenon under investigation. A total of 15 participants were selected for the study. Data were collected through 5 Key Informant Interviews (KIIs) and three Focus Group Discussions (FGDs) consisting of five participants each. The key informants included traditional rulers, government officials, community leaders, and NGO representatives, while the FGDs involved displaced persons, youth leaders, and women leaders. Participants were selected based on their involvement in or experience of communal conflicts and migration-related issues within the study area.

Fieldwork was conducted over a period of six weeks, during which interviews, focus group discussions, and field observations were carried out. Semi-structured interview guides and discussion protocols were used to facilitate data collection while allowing participants the flexibility to express their views and experiences comprehensively.

Data generated from the interviews and focus group discussions were audio-recorded, transcribed verbatim, and analyzed using thematic analysis. The analysis followed a systematic process involving familiarisation with the data, generation of initial codes, identification of recurring patterns, categorization of codes into themes, and interpretation of findings. Both inductive and deductive coding procedures were employed to ensure that emerging themes reflected participants' perspectives while addressing the study objectives.

To ensure the trustworthiness of the findings, several strategies were adopted. Credibility was enhanced through triangulation of data sources, including interviews, focus group discussions, observations, and documentary evidence. Member checking was conducted by presenting summaries of findings to selected participants for verification. Transferability was strengthened through detailed descriptions of the study context and participants.

Dependability and confirmability were ensured through proper documentation of research procedures, maintenance of field notes, and preservation of interview transcripts for audit purposes.

Ethical considerations were strictly observed throughout the study. Ethical approval was obtained from the Departmental Postgraduate Research Ethics Committee of Taraba State University, Jalingo, before the commencement of fieldwork. Participants were adequately informed about the purpose of the study and their rights as research participants. Informed consent was obtained from all participants before data collection. Confidentiality and anonymity were maintained through the use of pseudonyms, while participation remained voluntary, with participants free to withdraw from the study at any stage without consequence.

**Concept of Communal Violence**

Communal violence refers to violent conflicts between groups within the same geographical area, often along ethnic, religious, political, or resource-based lines. It is a form of collective violence that arises when different communities perceive one another as threats to their interests, identity, or survival (Horowitz, 2014). In Nigeria, communal violence has remained a persistent phenomenon, particularly in the Middle Belt region, where diverse ethnic and religious communities coexist within fragile political and economic structures (Egwu, 2016).

Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State typifies this condition. The area has witnessed numerous violent clashes between the Jukun, Tiv, and Hausa/Fulani since the early 1990s. These conflicts have resulted in widespread displacement, loss of lives, and the destruction of livelihoods and infrastructure. Communal violence in this region often arises from disputes over land ownership, political representation, and competition for scarce natural resources (Audu, 2020).

**Causes of Communal Violence.**

Scholars have identified several interrelated causes of communal violence. Egwu (2016) attributes it to a combination of historical grievances, identity politics, and weak governance structures. Okoli and Atelhe (2014) point to the struggle over land and access to agricultural resources as major triggers of violent confrontation between sedentary farmers and migrant herders. Other factors include poverty, unemployment, political manipulation, and the proliferation of small arms (Audu, 2020).

In Wukari, these causes are often compounded by external pressures such as climate change, population growth, and poor institutional responses. The absence of effective conflict resolution mechanisms, coupled with the decline in traditional authority systems, has made disputes more likely to escalate into violence. As violence persists, communities are

displaced, leading to waves of rural–urban migration as individuals seek security and better livelihoods elsewhere.

## Concept of Migration

Migration is the movement of people from one geographical location to another, either temporarily or permanently, for various reasons such as economic opportunity, security, education, or environmental conditions (Todaro, 2015). Migration can be internal or international; internal migration involves movement within the same country, while international migration involves crossing national borders.

Rural–urban migration, which is the focus of this paper, refers to the movement of people from rural areas to urban centers in search of improved living conditions. According to the International Organization for Migration (IOM, 2022), rural–urban migration in Nigeria is often driven by structural inequalities, insecurity, and lack of social amenities in rural areas. In the case of Wukari LGA, prolonged communal violence has become a significant "push factor," compelling many rural dwellers to relocate to urban areas such as Wukari town, Jalingo, and beyond.

## Impact of Communal Violence

The effects of communal violence extend across multiple dimensions, shaping both the rural and urban landscapes of Wukari and other affected regions.

i. Agricultural Impact: Violence disrupts farming activities, destroys crops and livestock, and leads to abandonment of farmlands. This results in food insecurity and reduced income among rural households (Audu, 2020).

ii. Institutional Impact: Educational and healthcare institutions often shut down due to insecurity. Government offices and public services become dysfunctional, weakening governance (North, 1990).

iii. Economic Impact: Markets and local businesses are destroyed during clashes. Investors withdraw, employment opportunities decline, and rural economies collapse (Okoli & Atelhe, 2014).

iv. Social Impact: Displacement of people erodes social cohesion and trust. Families are separated, and traditional authority systems lose influence (Eweka & Olusegun, 2016).

v. Environmental Impact: Conflicts lead to environmental degradation as displaced persons exploit forests, water sources, and land for survival, worsening ecological stress (Audu, 2020).

vi. Security Impact: The proliferation of small arms, reprisal attacks, and militarization of communities heighten insecurity and further displace populations (Egwu, 2016).

The interplay of these dimensions contributes to a vicious cycle of violence, underdevelopment, and migration. Understanding these relationships is essential to developing sustainable conflict prevention and migration management strategies in Wukari and similar contexts.

**Empirical Review**

Empirical studies across Nigeria and Africa consistently demonstrate that communal violence, insecurity, and socio-economic instability are significant drivers of migration, particularly from rural communities to urban centers. Existing literature generally agrees that persistent conflicts disrupt livelihoods, weaken local institutions, and compel affected populations to seek safety and economic opportunities elsewhere.

Studies conducted in Nigeria's Middle Belt region reveal a strong relationship between communal conflicts and population displacement. For instance, Egwu (2016) found that ethnic and religious violence has resulted in widespread displacement, destruction of agricultural activities, and weakened local governance structures. Similarly, Okoli and Atelhe (2014) observed that herder-farmer conflicts, driven by resource competition and ineffective institutional responses, have significantly contributed to migration from conflict-affected rural communities. These findings suggest that communal violence not only threatens physical security but also undermines the socio-economic foundations that sustain rural populations.

Research on internal displacement further reinforces the link between insecurity and migration. Audu (2020) reported that victims of ethnic conflicts in the Middle Belt often relocate to urban centers in search of safety and stability. This finding is consistent with the report of the International Organization for Migration (IOM, 2022), which identifies insecurity and environmental stress as major factors responsible for internal displacement in Nigeria. Together, these studies indicate that migration is frequently a survival strategy adopted by individuals and households confronted with violent conflict and deteriorating living conditions.

Scholars have also highlighted the challenges faced by displaced populations after migration. Eweka and Olusegun (2016) noted that inadequate institutional frameworks for rehabilitation and reintegration often leave internally displaced persons in prolonged conditions of

vulnerability. In a related study, Ajaero and Onokala (2013) found that insecurity, poor access to social services, and economic hardship are important determinants of rural–urban migration. These studies collectively suggest that migration outcomes are influenced not only by conflict itself but also by the capacity of institutions to provide support and opportunities for affected populations.

Beyond Nigeria, evidence from other African countries demonstrates similar patterns. Adepoju (2010) argued that conflict-induced migration across Africa is closely associated with governance failures, resource scarcity, and environmental degradation. Likewise, the Internal Displacement Monitoring Center (IDMC, 2020) reported that Africa records some of the highest levels of internal displacement globally due to communal, ethnic, and political violence. These continental findings reinforce the argument that migration is often the outcome of multiple interacting factors rather than a single cause.

Although previous studies have established important connections between conflict, insecurity, displacement, and migration, most have focused on broad national or regional patterns. Limited attention has been given to how communal violence interacts with institutional breakdown, economic decline, environmental degradation, and security challenges to influence rural–urban migration within specific local contexts. Consequently, there remains a gap in the literature regarding the dynamics of communal violence and migration in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State. This study seeks to fill this gap by providing an in-depth examination of how communal violence shapes rural–urban migration within the study area.

**Theoretical Framework**

Theoretical frameworks provide the intellectual basis for explaining social phenomena and guiding empirical inquiry (Creswell, 2014). This study adopts the Push-Pull Theory of Migration and Modernization Theory to explain how communal violence influences rural-urban migration in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State between 1991 and 2021.

Their complementary explanatory power informs the choice of these theories. While the Push-Pull Theory explains the factors that compel individuals to migrate, the Modernization Theory helps to explain the broader socio-economic changes associated with migration and urbanization.

**Push-Pull Theory of Migration**

The Push-Pull Theory was developed by Lee (1966), who argued that migration occurs because individuals are pushed away from their places of origin by unfavorable conditions and attracted to other locations by perceived opportunities. The relative advantages and disadvantages of origin and destination areas therefore shape migration decisions.

In Wukari LGA, communal violence constitutes a major push factor. Recurrent conflicts have resulted in loss of lives, destruction of property, displacement of populations, and disruption of livelihoods, particularly agriculture, which remains the dominant economic activity in the area (Akinwale, 2021). These conditions encourage residents to relocate to safer urban centers.

Conversely, urban areas such as Wukari town, Jalingo, Jos, and Takum serve as pull destinations because they offer relatively better security, access to social services, employment opportunities, and social support networks (Adepoju, 2018; Oyeniyi, 2013). The theory therefore explains how insecurity and violence in rural communities stimulate migration to urban centers.

**Modernization Theory**

Modernization Theory, associated with Rostow (1960) and Parsons (1964), explains societal transformation from traditional to modern forms through economic development, urbanization, technological advancement, and institutional change. The theory views migration as an important mechanism through which modernization occurs.

Applied to this study, rural–urban migration resulting from communal violence contributes to demographic and socio-economic changes in urban centers. The influx of migrants increases demand for housing, education, healthcare, and employment while also encouraging economic diversification and infrastructural expansion (Todaro & Smith, 2015). At the same time, rural communities may experience population decline and reduced agricultural productivity.

**Relevance of the Theories to the Study**

The integration of the Push-Pull and Modernization theories provides a comprehensive understanding of communal violence and migration in Wukari LGA. The Push–Pull Theory explains the immediate causes of migration, particularly insecurity, displacement, and livelihood loss. In contrast, the Modernization Theory explains the broader consequences of migration for urban growth, institutional development, and socio-economic transformation. The theories demonstrate that communal violence is not only a driver of population

displacement but also a factor that shapes patterns of urbanization and social change in the study area.

**Theoretical Assumptions**

This study is premised on the assumption that communal violence constitutes a major push factor driving rural–urban migration in Wukari Local Government Area by creating conditions of insecurity that compel individuals and households to relocate in search of safer environments. It further assumes that urban centers attract migrants because they offer relatively greater security, wider economic opportunities, and better access to essential social services such as education, healthcare, and public infrastructure. The study also assumes that migration is not merely a consequence of communal violence but a process that contributes to social and economic transformation in destination areas through changes in labor supply, economic activities, population dynamics, and social interactions. However, it recognizes that the modernization associated with migration produces uneven outcomes, creating opportunities for economic advancement and improved access to services while simultaneously generating challenges such as urban congestion, unemployment, pressure on public infrastructure, and social inequalities. Overall, the study assumes that rural–urban migration in Wukari is both an adaptive response to communal violence and a catalyst for broader structural changes in both the communities of origin and destination. Consequently, the combined application of the selected theoretical perspectives provides a suitable framework for explaining the complex relationship between communal violence and rural–urban migration in Wukari Local Government Area.

**Discussion of Findings**

The findings of this study reveal a strong and direct relationship between communal violence and rural–urban migration in Wukari Local Government Area from 1991 to 2021. The recurring violent clashes between ethnic groups, particularly between the Jukun and Tiv communities, have consistently displaced large segments of the population, forcing them to seek refuge in urban centers such as Wukari town, Jalingo, Lafia, Makurdi, and Abuja. The data derived from interviews and focus group discussions indicate that insecurity and fear of renewed attacks were the most frequently cited reasons for migration. This confirms the Push–Pull Theory of Migration, which explains how violent conflict functions as a major “push” factor that drives people away from rural settlements.

The study finds that urban centers act as “Pull” destinations due to perceived safety, improved social services, and alternative livelihood opportunities. Migrants often rely on pre-existing social networks of family and ethnic associations for accommodation and employment support. However, while migration offered temporary relief, it also contributed to urban overcrowding, increased competition for jobs, and pressure on housing and

infrastructure. These changes align with the Modernization Theory, which posits that migration contributes to structural transformation and urbanization, though often unevenly.

These findings are consistent with those of Abaji et al. (2024), who in their study "Insecurity, Rural–Urban Migration and Food Security in North Central Nigeria: Implications for National Security and Social Stability," examined rural communities across Benue, Nasarawa, and Plateau States. Their research revealed that rising insecurity has triggered widespread displacement from rural settlements, weakened agricultural productivity, and intensified pressure on urban infrastructure such as housing, sanitation, and employment. These outcomes mirror the present study's observation that violence acts as a powerful "push" factor, forcing people to abandon vulnerable rural areas. At the same time, urban centers attract them as "pull" destinations promising safety and stability. The study also identified the dual outcome of rural decline characterized by abandoned settlements and reduced productivity and urban stress, including overcrowding and competition for limited resources. This aligns closely with the conclusions drawn in this research regarding the rural–urban divide in Wukari.

Similarly, Adebayo and Oriola (2016), in their paper "Nexus of Land Conflicts and Rural–Urban Migration in South West Nigeria: Implications for National Development," explored how disputes over land ownership and access have contributed to the movement of people from rural to urban areas. Although their focus was primarily on land-related conflicts rather than ethnic violence, their findings highlight a similar mechanism: rural conflict acts as a push factor, propelling individuals toward urban centers in search of security and better opportunities. This further reinforces the application of the Push–Pull Theory of Migration in explaining conflict-induced population movement in Wukari.

The study further shows that the impacts of communal violence extend beyond human displacement. Farmlands were abandoned, agricultural productivity declined, and many rural institutions such as schools and health centers became dysfunctional. As a result, rural communities experienced depopulation, economic stagnation, and weakened governance structures, while urban centers witnessed rapid expansion and economic diversification. The findings therefore highlight a dual process of rural decline and urban growth, driven largely by conflict-induced migration. Consequently, the study demonstrates that communal violence is not only a security issue but also a major development challenge affecting socio-economic stability and long-term regional planning in Wukari.

## Conclusion

This study examined the relationship between communal violence and rural–urban migration in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State from 1991 to 2021. The findings establish that communal violence has been a significant driver of population displacement and migration from rural communities to urban centers. Persistent conflicts, particularly between

the Jukun and Tiv ethnic groups, created insecurity, fear, and uncertainty, compelling many residents to abandon their homes and livelihoods in search of safety and stability in urban areas.

The study further revealed that while urban centers provided temporary refuge and economic opportunities for displaced persons, the influx of migrants contributed to increased pressure on housing, employment, and social infrastructure. At the same time, the departure of residents from rural communities resulted in declining agricultural productivity, abandonment of farmlands, weakening of local institutions, and reduced socio-economic development. These findings confirm the relevance of the Push–Pull Theory of Migration in explaining conflict-induced migration and demonstrate how communal violence functions as a major push factor. At the same time, urban centers serve as pull destinations.

The study concludes that communal violence in Wukari is not merely a security challenge but also a critical development issue with far-reaching consequences for population distribution, economic growth, rural development, and urban planning. Addressing the root causes of communal conflicts is therefore essential for promoting sustainable peace, reducing forced migration, and fostering balanced socio-economic development in Wukari Local Government Area and beyond.

**Recommendations**

Based on the findings of this study, the following recommendations are proposed:

i. Government, traditional rulers, religious leaders, and civil society organizations should collaborate to establish and strengthen local peacebuilding structures in Wukari Local Government Area. Regular dialogue forums, mediation committees, and early warning systems should be developed to address grievances before they escalate into violent conflicts. This would help reduce communal violence and minimize forced migration from rural communities.

ii. The government should prioritize the reconstruction of damaged infrastructure, including schools, health centers, roads, and water facilities in conflict-affected rural areas. In addition, agricultural support programs such as the provision of farm inputs, credit facilities, and security for farming activities should be implemented to encourage displaced persons to return and rebuild their livelihoods. This would help reverse rural decline and restore economic productivity.

iii. Since communal violence has contributed to increased migration into urban centers, state and local governments should strengthen urban planning policies to accommodate the growing population. This should include the provision of affordable housing, employment opportunities, healthcare services, and social welfare programs

for displaced persons. Such measures would reduce the pressure on urban infrastructure and promote the successful integration of migrants into their host communities.

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# CLIMATE VARIABILITY AND IRREGULAR INTERNAL MIGRATION IN TARABA STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** Climate variability has emerged as one of the most pressing environmental challenges confronting many regions in Nigeria, with significant implications for human mobility and settlement patterns. In Taraba State, a region characterized by agrarian livelihoods and ecological diversity, irregular internal migration has become increasingly linked to climatic shifts such as unpredictable rainfall, prolonged droughts, and flooding. This study investigates the nexus between climate variability and irregular internal migration in Taraba State, focusing on the underlying drivers, socio-economic consequences, and coping mechanisms employed by affected populations. This research adopts a mixed-methods approach, integrating quantitative surveys with qualitative interviews to capture both statistical trends and lived experiences of migrants and non-migrants. Findings reveal that climate-induced disruptions to agricultural productivity, livelihood insecurity, and resource competition serve as major catalysts for irregular movements within the state. The study further highlights the strain such movements place on receiving communities, manifesting in increased pressure on infrastructure, social services, and communal harmony. By critically examining the interconnections between climate variability and irregular internal migration, the research underscores the urgent need for proactive policy frameworks that address climate resilience, sustainable livelihood strategies, and conflict mitigation. Ultimately, the study contributes to broader discourses on environmental migration in Nigeria and offers evidence-based insights for policymakers, development practitioners, and scholars.

**Keywords:** Climate, climate variability, and irregular internal migration

## Introduction

Climate variability has emerged as one of the most pressing global challenges, profoundly influencing human livelihoods, settlement patterns, and socio-economic stability. Recent studies highlight that shifts in rainfall, temperature extremes, and extreme weather events have become more frequent in Sub-Saharan Africa, disproportionately affecting agrarian communities that depend on natural resources for survival (Adeyemi & Oladipo, 2019; IPCC, 2021). Taraba State, located in Nigeria's North-East geopolitical zone, exemplifies this vulnerability. Over the past two decades, fluctuations in rainfall distribution, rising temperatures, and recurring climate-related hazards have contributed to declining agricultural

productivity, food insecurity, and livelihood instability, worsening community exposure to socio-economic shocks (Amare et al., 2018; Holleman et al., 2019)

Taraba State, popularly described as “Nature’s Gift to the Nation,” spans diverse ecological zones including mountainous regions, valleys, and savannah plains. Though these landscapes support rich agricultural activities, they also heighten exposure to climatic disturbances due to reliance on rain-fed farming. Empirical assessments show that erratic rainfall, dry-season lengthening, and episodic flooding have altered planting cycles, reduced crop yields, and strained livestock production (Awosika & Ibe, 2020; Olanrewaju & Adebayo, 2021). As these pressures accumulate, many rural households, particularly smallholder farmers lacking adaptive capacity, resort to internal migration, sometimes irregularly, as a coping strategy to secure alternative livelihoods in urban centers or ecologically stable parts of the state.

**Problem Statement**

Despite Nigeria’s economic potential, many rural communities remain extremely vulnerable to the impacts of climate variability. In Taraba State, environmental stressors, including irregular rainfall, prolonged dry spells, and periodic flooding, have increasingly been linked to irregular internal migration. However, state-level empirical evidence remains limited, creating a gap in localized understanding. Studies conducted in Nigeria indicate that climate-related livelihood losses significantly influence population movement. Ayinde and Akande (2019) found that environmental stress accounted for over 40% of rural–urban migration triggers, while Yusuf and Jimoh (2020) reported a strong association between drought episodes and temporary migration in Taraba communities.

Similarly, Olanrewaju and Adebayo (2021) observed that declining agricultural productivity due to climate variability contributed to increased internal displacement in North-East Nigeria. These findings suggest that environmental pressures are central to migration decisions. However, Taraba State lacks comprehensive, context-specific studies explaining how climate variability shapes irregular migration patterns. Without such evidence, policymakers struggle to design targeted interventions, leaving communities exposed to worsening socio-economic and environmental risks.

**Objectives of the Study**

i. To examine the patterns and trends of climate variability in Taraba State over the past two decades.

ii. To analyze socio-economic factors that interact with climate variability to influence irregular internal migration.

iii. To evaluate existing policies and programs addressing climate-induced migration in the state.

**Conceptual Framework**

Climate variability is defined as the irregularity or fluctuations in climate parameters, including rainfall, temperature, and the occurrence of extreme weather events (IPCC, 2021). Irregular internal migration refers to unplanned or undocumented movement of people within national borders, typically in response to environmental or socio-economic stressors (Adepoju, 2018).

The conceptual framework for this study links climatic stressors to household vulnerability, which subsequently influences migration decisions. Push factors, such as prolonged drought, flooding, and crop failure, compel households to leave their origin communities. At the same time, pull factors, such as perceived economic opportunities, urban employment, and access to better social services, attract migrants to new destinations (Black et al., 2015). Household adaptive capacity, including access to resources, social networks, and livelihood diversification, mediates the decision to migrate. This framework helps to understand migration as a complex response to environmental, economic, and social pressures in Taraba State.

**Theoretical Perspectives**

The relationship between climate variability and irregular internal migration in Taraba State can be comprehensively understood through an interdisciplinary theoretical lens. Migration is a complex phenomenon influenced by environmental stressors, socio-economic conditions, and adaptive household strategies. Therefore, this study is anchored on three interrelated theories: the Push–Pull Theory of Migration, the Human Security Approach, and the Climate Change Adaptation Theory. These theories collectively provide a robust explanatory framework for understanding how climate variability shapes human mobility patterns in agrarian communities such as those in Taraba State.

**Push-Pull Theory of Migration**

The Push-Pull Theory, originally developed by Lee (1966), remains one of the most widely applied theoretical frameworks in migration studies. The theory explains migration as the outcome of interacting forces that either push individuals away from their place of origin or pull them toward a destination.

Push factors are negative conditions that compel individuals or households to leave their environment. These include unemployment, poverty, environmental degradation, conflict, and, in the context of this study, climate variability-related stressors such as prolonged

drought, flooding, and declining agricultural productivity. In agrarian societies like Taraba State, where livelihoods are heavily dependent on rain-fed agriculture, climate variability directly undermines food security and household income, thereby increasing the pressure to migrate (Black et al., 2015; Adeyemi & Oladipo, 2019).

On the other hand, pull factors are attractive conditions that draw migrants to new locations. These include better employment opportunities, improved infrastructure, access to education and healthcare, and perceived safety. In the context of internal migration within Taraba State, urban centers such as Jalingo often serve as pull destinations due to relatively better economic opportunities and access to services compared to rural communities (Olanrewaju & Adebayo, 2021).

However, while the Push–Pull Theory provides a useful descriptive framework, it has been criticized for being overly simplistic, as it tends to treat migration as a rational response to clearly defined factors without adequately considering structural inequalities, policy environments, or household decision-making dynamics (de Haas, 2010). Despite this limitation, the theory remains highly relevant in this study as it helps to explain the immediate environmental and economic triggers of irregular migration in Taraba State. In this study, climate variability acts as a dominant push factor, while urban livelihood opportunities and social networks act as pull factors influencing migration decisions among rural households.

**Human Security Approach**

The Human Security Approach, popularized by the United Nations Development Program (UNDP, 1994), shifts the focus of security from the state to the individual. It emphasizes protecting individuals from chronic threats such as hunger, disease, and environmental degradation, as well as from sudden disruptions in daily life. Human security is multidimensional and includes economic security, food security, health security, environmental security, personal security, community security, and political security. Climate variability directly threatens several of these dimensions, particularly in rural agrarian settings. For instance, irregular rainfall patterns and prolonged droughts reduce agricultural yields, thereby undermining food and economic security. Similarly, flooding and extreme weather events can destroy homes, infrastructure, and community livelihoods, further increasing vulnerability (IPCC, 2021).

In Taraba State, where a significant proportion of the population depends on subsistence farming, climate-induced disruptions significantly weaken household resilience. As a result, migration becomes a survival strategy rather than a purely economic choice. Individuals and households move in search of safety, food, and livelihood opportunities, reflecting a direct response to human insecurity (Awosika & Ibe, 2020). The Human Security Approach is particularly relevant in explaining why migration in climate-affected regions is often irregular

and unplanned. It highlights that migration is not always voluntary in the classical sense but may be a forced response to deteriorating living conditions. This perspective aligns with findings by Eze and Okeke (2017), who argue that environmental stress significantly increases vulnerability and compels households to adopt mobility as a coping mechanism.

However, one limitation of this approach is that it is broad and sometimes lacks specificity in explaining the exact mechanisms of migration decision-making. Despite this, it provides a strong normative and policy-oriented framework that emphasizes the need for protective interventions and resilience-building in climate-vulnerable communities.

**Climate Change Adaptation Theory**

The Climate Change Adaptation Theory, as articulated by Smit and Wandel (2006), focuses on how individuals, households, and communities respond to environmental stressors by adjusting their behavior, livelihood strategies, and spatial location. Adaptation refers to the process of adjusting to actual or expected climate impacts to reduce harm or exploit beneficial opportunities.

Within this theoretical framework, migration is conceptualized as one of several adaptation strategies employed by households facing climate variability. Other adaptation strategies include livelihood diversification, adoption of climate-resilient crops, irrigation practices, and changes in farming techniques. However, when local adaptive capacity is exceeded, migration becomes a necessary response (Foresight, 2011).

In the context of Taraba State, climate variability such as unpredictable rainfall patterns, rising temperatures, and recurrent flooding disrupts agricultural activities and reduces productivity. Households with limited access to financial resources, modern technology, or institutional support often struggle to adjust effectively to these changing environmental conditions. Consequently, they resort to migration as an adaptive response to environmental stress (Nwoko et al., 2020). The adaptation framework is particularly useful in understanding the variability of migration responses. While some households migrate permanently, others engage in seasonal or circular migration depending on the severity of environmental stress and their adaptive capacity.

Nevertheless, critics argue that adaptation theory sometimes normalizes migration without fully addressing the structural inequalities that force vulnerable populations into mobility. Despite this limitation, the theory remains highly valuable for explaining migration as a dynamic and adaptive response to environmental change rather than a purely economic phenomenon.

## Integrative Theoretical Synthesis

Individually, each of the three theories provides valuable insight into the relationship between climate variability and irregular internal migration. However, when integrated, they offer a more comprehensive understanding of the phenomenon.

The Push-Pull Theory explains the immediate drivers of migration, particularly environmental degradation and economic opportunities. The Human Security Approach highlights the deeper vulnerability and insecurity experienced by affected populations, framing migration as a survival strategy. The Climate Change Adaptation Theory further explains migration as a coping mechanism adopted when local adaptive capacity is exceeded.

These theories illustrate that a single factor does not drive migration in Taraba State but is the outcome of interacting environmental, socio-economic, and institutional pressures. Climate variability acts as a trigger, while socio-economic vulnerability determines the intensity and nature of migration responses. Household adaptive capacity ultimately shapes whether individuals remain in place or migrate. This integrated framework therefore provides a strong analytical foundation for understanding irregular internal migration in the study area. It supports the empirical investigation of climate-induced mobility patterns in Taraba State.

## Empirical Studies on Climate Variability

Globally, climate variability is recognized as a key driver of human mobility. Black et al. (2015) emphasize that environmental stress exacerbates pre-existing socio-economic vulnerabilities, compelling migration. In Sub-Saharan Africa, erratic rainfall and recurrent droughts disrupt agricultural productivity, compelling rural households to migrate to urban centers or more fertile areas (Adepoju, 2018).

In Nigeria, particularly the North-East, rainfall variability, flooding, and prolonged dry seasons have been linked to temporary and permanent migration (Ayinde & Akande, 2019). Communities affected by environmental stressors experience food insecurity, income loss, and social disruption. Empirical evidence underscores that households often resort to irregular migration as a survival strategy, highlighting the need for localized research in regions like Taraba State.

## Climate-Induced Migration in Sub-Saharan Africa

Sub-Saharan Africa is highly vulnerable to climate variability due to its dependence on rain-fed agriculture and limited adaptive capacity. Droughts, desertification, and flooding frequently displace rural populations, often leading to irregular internal migration (Foresight, 2011). For instance, studies in Ethiopia and Sudan reveal that drought-induced displacement affects thousands annually, leading to urban overcrowding and increased socio-economic

pressures (Gebre, 2017). These regional experiences offer valuable insights for understanding Taraba State, where similar climatic hazards affect rural livelihoods but localized data are limited.

Socio-economic, political, and environmental factors influence Internal Migration in Nigeria and Taraba State. In North-East Nigeria, including Taraba, climate variability has become a significant driver. Erratic rainfall and flooding disrupt agricultural production, forcing households to migrate internally, often irregularly (Nwoko et al., 2020). Migration patterns vary seasonally and spatially, influenced by household resources, social networks, and community infrastructure.

**Socio-Economic Impacts of Irregular Migration**

Irregular migration resulting from climate variability has far-reaching socio-economic consequences for both communities of origin and destination. One of the most significant impacts is the loss of economically active labor in rural communities, as the migration of working-age adults reduces the agricultural workforce, lowers farm productivity, and diminishes household income and food production. At the same time, the increasing influx of migrants into urban centers places considerable pressure on existing infrastructure and public services, including housing, healthcare, education, water supply, sanitation, and transportation. Beyond its economic implications, irregular migration also disrupts family structures, weakens community cohesion, and alters traditional social norms as prolonged separation and population movements affect established social relationships and support systems. Furthermore, many migrants face persistent economic vulnerability in destination areas due to limited access to secure employment, forcing them into low-paying informal occupations that often expose them to poverty, exploitation, precarious living conditions, and social marginalization (Adepoju, 2018; Ayinde & Akande, 2019).

**Methodology**

This study adopts a descriptive and analytical research design. The descriptive component seeks to provide an in-depth understanding of climate variability patterns and migration trends in Taraba State. The analytical aspect investigates the relationships between climatic stressors, socio-economic factors, and irregular migration patterns.

A mixed-methods approach is employed, integrating quantitative and qualitative techniques. Quantitative data, including rainfall records, temperature fluctuations, and migration statistics, allow for trend analysis and correlation assessment. Qualitative data, collected through interviews and focus group discussions, provide insights into household perceptions, migration decision-making, and adaptation strategies.

## Study Area

Taraba State, located in Nigeria's North-East geopolitical zone, occupies approximately 54,473 square kilometers. It shares borders with Bauchi, Gombe, Adamawa, Benue, Nasarawa, and Plateau States, as well as Cameroon to the east. The state has a diverse landscape, including the Mambilla Plateau, savannah plains, and several river valleys, making it ecologically rich but environmentally vulnerable.

The state has a predominantly agrarian population, with farming and livestock rearing as primary economic activities. Communities rely heavily on rainfall for crop production, making them highly susceptible to climate variability. The study focuses on multiple local government areas (LGAs) in Taraba State to capture diverse climatic and socio-economic conditions influencing migration patterns.

## Population of the Study

The population of this study comprises rural households in Taraba State whose livelihoods depend mainly on agriculture, alongside community leaders, local government officials, and non-governmental organizations involved in climate adaptation and migration management. According to the 2006 National Population Census conducted by the National Population Commission, Taraba State has an estimated population of about 2.3 million people, with a significant proportion residing in rural farming communities. The target population for this study will specifically focus on adult household heads and residents in selected rural communities that are highly affected by climate variability and migration-related challenges. These groups are considered appropriate because they provide both quantitative information and practical experiences relating to climate change impacts, livelihood instability, and irregular migration patterns within the state.

## Sample Size and Sampling Technique

The sample size for this study consists of 150 respondents drawn from selected rural communities in Taraba State that are highly vulnerable to climate variability and migration-related challenges. The sample includes 110 households directly affected by climate variability, particularly households experiencing livelihood disruption, displacement, or migration of family members due to irregular rainfall, flooding, drought, and declining agricultural productivity. In addition, 40 households that are less affected or have not experienced migration were included to provide a basis for comparison.

The choice of 150 respondents was considered appropriate because it provides adequate representation of the study population while remaining manageable for data collection and analysis within the scope of the research. Since the study focuses primarily on the effects of

climate variability on migration, the number of affected households was intentionally higher than the non-affected households to reflect the realities within the study area.

Purposive sampling technique was used to select respondents with relevant knowledge and direct experience relating to climate variability and migration. The study also employed snowball sampling, particularly in identifying migrant households and individuals who may not be easily accessible through conventional sampling procedures. This approach enabled the researcher to obtain detailed information and reliable experiences from participants directly connected to the phenomenon under investigation.

**Data Collection Methods**

Data for this study were obtained from both primary and secondary sources to provide a comprehensive understanding of the relationship between climate variability and irregular internal migration in Taraba State. Primary data were collected using structured questionnaires, semi-structured interviews, and focus group discussions (FGDs). The structured questionnaire was administered to selected household heads to generate quantitative information on respondents' socio-economic characteristics, exposure to climate variability, migration experiences, livelihood conditions, and adaptation strategies. Semi-structured interviews were conducted with key informants, including community leaders, local government officials, agricultural extension officers, and representatives of relevant non-governmental organizations (NGOs), to obtain in-depth qualitative information on the drivers of migration, existing policy interventions, and community resilience strategies. In addition, focus group discussions were organized across selected communities to capture collective experiences, perceptions, and local knowledge regarding climate variability, migration patterns, and household adaptation responses.

Secondary data complemented the primary data and were obtained from a variety of credible sources. These included meteorological records on rainfall patterns, temperature variations, and flooding incidents; reports from the National Population Commission; government publications; peer-reviewed journal articles; reports from non-governmental organizations; and climate- and migration-related databases maintained by international organizations such as the World Bank and the United Nations Development Program (UNDP). These secondary sources provided historical and contextual information that supported the interpretation of the primary data and strengthened the overall analysis.

**Data Analysis**

The study employed both quantitative and qualitative techniques in analyzing the data collected. Quantitative data obtained through the structured questionnaires were analyzed using descriptive and inferential statistics. Descriptive statistical tools, including frequencies, percentages, means, and tables, were used to summarize respondents' socio-economic

characteristics, climate variability trends, migration patterns, and adaptation strategies. Inferential statistical techniques, particularly chi-square tests and correlation analysis, were employed to examine the relationships between climate variability, socio-economic factors, and irregular internal migration. Qualitative data generated from the semi-structured interviews and focus group discussions were analyzed using content analysis. Responses were carefully transcribed, coded, and organized into recurring themes and categories to identify patterns, explain respondents' experiences, and provide deeper insights into household adaptation strategies, migration decisions, and institutional responses.

### Validity and Reliability of Research Instruments

The validity and reliability of the research instruments were carefully established to ensure the credibility and consistency of the findings. To ensure content and face validity, the questionnaire and interview guides were subjected to expert review by specialists in environmental studies, migration studies, and the social sciences. Their observations and recommendations were incorporated to improve the clarity, relevance, and appropriateness of the research instruments. Furthermore, the instruments were pre-tested through a pilot study conducted in communities outside the selected study areas with similar socio-economic and environmental characteristics. Feedback from the pilot exercise was used to refine ambiguous questions and improve the overall quality of the instruments. The reliability of the structured questionnaire was assessed using Cronbach's Alpha coefficient to determine the internal consistency of the measurement items. A Cronbach's Alpha value of 0.70 or higher was considered acceptable, indicating that the questionnaire items consistently measured the variables under investigation and were sufficiently reliable for data collection.

## Results

### Socio-Demographic Characteristics of Respondents

The study surveyed 100 respondents, divided into 50 households directly affected by climate variability (migrants) and 50 minimally affected (non-migrants). Key characteristics include:

**Table 4.1: Demographic Characteristics of Respondents**

| Characteristic | Frequency | Percentage |
|---|---|---|
| Gender (Male) | 60 | 60% |
| Gender (Female) | 40 | 40% |
| Age 18–30 | 25 | 25% |
| Age 31–50 | 45 | 45% |
| Age 51+ | 30 | 30% |
| Primary Education | 35 | 35% |
| Secondary Education | 45 | 45% |
| Tertiary Education | 20 | 20% |
| Occupation – Farming | 60 | 60% |
| Occupation – Trading | 25 | 25% |
| Occupation – Other | 15 | 15% |

Source: Field Survey, 2026.

The data indicate that most respondents are male, aged between 31–50, with primary and secondary education. Farming is the dominant occupation, confirming the state's agrarian nature and high vulnerability to climate variability.

**Patterns and Trends of Climate Variability in Taraba State**

Meteorological data obtained from the Nigerian Meteorological Agency and related climate reports covering the period between 2000 and 2023 indicate noticeable changes in climatic conditions across Taraba State. The analysis shows significant fluctuations in annual rainfall distribution, rising temperature patterns, and increasing occurrences of extreme weather events, all of which have negatively affected agricultural productivity and rural livelihoods within the state.

**Table 4.2: Meteorological Trends in Taraba State (2000-2023)**

| Climate Variable | 2000–2005 | 2006–2011 | 2012–2017 | 2018–2023 | Observed Trend |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Average Annual Rainfall (mm) | 1,450 mm | 1,320 mm | 1,280 mm | 1,190 mm | Declining and irregular rainfall |
| Average Temperature (°C) | 26.1°C | 26.8°C | 27.4°C | 27.9°C | Gradual temperature increase |
| Flood Incidence (Reported Cases) | 3 | 5 | 8 | 11 | Increasing flooding events |
| Dry Spell Duration (Weeks) | 2–3 Weeks | 3–4 Weeks | 4–5 Weeks | 5–6 Weeks | Longer dry seasons |

Source: Adapted from Nigerian Meteorological Agency climate records and field survey data, 2026.

The rainfall data indicate increasing irregularity in the onset and cessation of rainy seasons, with shorter periods of effective rainfall being experienced in many farming communities. This situation has disrupted planting calendars and reduced crop productivity among rural households. Similarly, temperature records reveal a steady increase of approximately 0.5–1.8°C between 2000 and 2023, contributing to increased evapotranspiration, soil moisture loss, and heat stress on crops and livestock.

The data further show a growing frequency of extreme climatic events, particularly flooding along river valleys such as areas surrounding the Benue River basin and prolonged dry spells within savannah regions of the state. These environmental changes have increased vulnerability among farming households and contributed to livelihood instability, food insecurity, and migration pressures in several rural communities.

**Socio-Economic Factors Influencing Irregular Migration**

Qualitative and quantitative data highlight key socio-economic drivers:

| Socio-Economic Factor | Migrants (%) | Non-Migrants (%) |
|---|---|---|
| Crop Failure | 70 | 30 |
| Livestock Loss | 60 | 40 |
| Income Loss | 75 | 25 |
| Access to Social Service | 40 | 60 |
| Household Size (>6 members) | 65 | 35 |

**Source:** Field Survey Data, 2026

Crop failure, income loss, and large household size are major push factors for irregular migration. Non-migrant households often have better access to social networks and diversified livelihoods, enabling them to withstand climatic shocks.

**Discussion of Findings**

The findings of this study show a very clear relationship between climate variability and irregular internal migration in Taraba State. This means that changes in weather patterns, such as heavy rain, low rainfall, and increasing heat, strongly influence why people move from one place to another within the state. Over the years, farming communities in Taraba State have become more vulnerable because they depend heavily on rainfall for their crops. When the rain does not come at the right time or when floods destroy farmlands, many families lose their source of income and food. This agrees with the view of Adeyemi and Oladipo (2019), who explained that climate change reduces agricultural productivity in Nigeria and makes rural life more difficult.

From the study, it was also discovered that rainfall patterns in Taraba State are no longer stable. In the past, farmers could predict when the rainy season would start and end, but now this is no longer the case. Sometimes rain comes late, sometimes it stops early, and at other times it is too heavy and causes flooding. This has made farming very difficult and unpredictable. The meteorological data collected between 2000 and 2023 clearly shows this change, with rainfall decreasing gradually and dry seasons becoming longer. This supports the findings of Holleman et al. (2019), who noted that climate instability directly affects food production and rural livelihoods in Africa.

Another important finding is the steady increase in temperature over the years. Even though the increase may look small (about 0.5–1.2°C), it has a big effect on farming. Higher temperatures dry the soil faster, reduce water availability, and make crops grow poorly. Livestock also suffer from heat stress and a lack of pasture. According to the IPCC (2021), even small temperature changes can have serious impacts on agriculture, especially in developing regions where people depend on natural weather conditions.

The study also found that migration in Taraba State is not random but is strongly influenced by these environmental problems. Many households move either temporarily or permanently when farming becomes too difficult. Some people move during dry seasons and return when conditions improve, while others move permanently to urban areas like Jalingo in search of better living conditions. This supports Black et al. (2015), who explained that environmental stress often pushes people to migrate as a survival strategy.

One very important finding is that not all households are affected in the same way. Poor households are more likely to migrate because they do not have savings, land security, or alternative jobs. On the other hand, richer households or those with strong social networks are better able to cope. For example, families with relatives in towns may receive help or job opportunities, while others without such support are forced to move without planning. This agrees with Eze and Okeke (2017), who stated that household strength and resources determine how people respond to environmental stress.

The study also shows that migration has both good and bad effects. On the positive side, migration helps some families survive when farming fails. People who move to towns sometimes find jobs or send money back home. However, the negative effects are also very serious. Rural communities lose young and active workers, which reduces farming output. Urban areas also become overcrowded, leading to pressure on housing, schools, and healthcare services. This supports the findings of Adepoju (2018), who noted that migration can create both opportunities and challenges depending on the situation.

Furthermore, the study discovered that existing government and community responses are not strong enough to handle these problems. Most of the support systems are small and local, such as small irrigation projects, tree planting, and community savings groups. While these

efforts help a little, they are not enough to solve the bigger problem of climate-induced migration. There is also a lack of strong government policies that directly address the link between climate change and migration in the state. This agrees with Nwoko et al. (2020), who observed that policy responses in North-East Nigeria are still weak and reactive rather than proactive.

The findings show that migration in Taraba State is not caused by only one factor. Instead, it is a combination of environmental problems (like drought and flooding), economic challenges (like poverty and job loss), and social factors (like family size and support networks). This supports the Push-Pull Theory, which explains that people move because of both negative pressures that push them away and positive opportunities that pull them to new places (Lee, 1966). It also supports the Human Security Approach, which explains that when people cannot secure basic needs like food and safety, they are forced to move (UNDP, 1994). The Climate Change Adaptation Theory explains that migration is one way people try to cope when their environment becomes too difficult to survive in (Smit & Wandel, 2006). In simple terms, the findings show that climate change is not just an environmental issue in Taraba State; it is also a social and economic problem that affects how people live, work, and move. When the weather becomes unpredictable and farming becomes difficult, people are forced to look for survival elsewhere. This makes climate variability one of the strongest hidden drivers of irregular migration in the state today.

**Patterns and Drivers of Climate-Induced Migration in Taraba State**

The findings reveal that climate-induced migration in Taraba State follows distinct spatial and temporal patterns shaped by environmental pressures, livelihood vulnerabilities, and socio-economic opportunities. Three major migration patterns emerged from the study: seasonal migration, permanent migration, and inter-local government area (LGA) migration. These patterns demonstrate that migration is not a random phenomenon but rather a strategic adaptation adopted by households to cope with recurring environmental and economic challenges.

Seasonal migration is one of the most common patterns observed among rural households. This form of migration involves the temporary movement of individuals, particularly economically active members of households, during periods of peak agricultural stress. Such movements are often associated with prolonged dry seasons, delayed rainfall, flooding, or crop failures that reduce agricultural productivity and household incomes. Migrants typically relocate temporarily to urban centers or areas with greater economic opportunities, engaging in activities such as petty trading, casual labor, transportation, construction, or seasonal farming before returning to their communities when environmental conditions improve. Seasonal migration therefore serves as a livelihood diversification strategy that enables households to supplement income while maintaining social and economic ties with their communities of origin.

A second pattern identified is permanent migration, involving households that relocate entirely from environmentally vulnerable communities to urban centers or more agriculturally productive locations within Taraba State. Unlike seasonal migration, permanent migration reflects a long-term adaptation strategy in response to repeated climate shocks that make continued residence economically and environmentally unsustainable. Persistent flooding, declining soil fertility, recurrent droughts, and diminishing agricultural yields have weakened household resilience, compelling families to seek more stable living conditions elsewhere. Permanent migrants are often motivated by the prospect of improved employment opportunities, better access to education, healthcare, infrastructure, and more reliable sources of livelihood.

The study also identified inter-LGA migration, characterized by movements from highly climate-vulnerable Local Government Areas such as Bali and Lau to relatively less affected areas within the state. This pattern indicates that migration is not exclusively rural-to-urban but also occurs within rural regions where differences in environmental conditions and agricultural potential exist. Households relocate to communities with more favorable rainfall patterns, fertile land, or lower exposure to flooding, allowing them to continue agricultural production while remaining within familiar cultural and social environments. Inter-LGA migration highlights the uneven geographical impacts of climate change across Taraba State and the role of environmental variability in shaping internal population movements.

Several factors drive these migration patterns. The most significant are environmental push factors, including drought, flooding, and soil degradation. These environmental hazards undermine agricultural productivity, reduce food availability, destroy livelihoods, and increase household vulnerability. As agriculture remains the principal source of income for most rural households in Taraba State, declining environmental conditions directly threaten economic survival. Consequently, migration becomes an adaptive response to environmental stress rather than merely a demographic process.

Alongside environmental pressures, economic pull factors strongly influence migration decisions. Urban centers and relatively prosperous agricultural communities offer greater employment opportunities, higher income prospects, improved markets, and better access to public services. The expectation of improved livelihoods encourages individuals and households to relocate, particularly when agricultural incomes become increasingly unreliable. Migration is therefore driven not only by the necessity to escape environmental hardship but also by the aspiration to improve economic well-being.

Another important driver is the presence of social networks. Existing relationships with relatives, friends, or members of the same community living in destination areas significantly reduce the risks associated with migration. These networks provide information about employment opportunities, temporary accommodation, financial assistance, and emotional support, making migration more accessible and less costly. Social capital thus facilitates both

seasonal and permanent migration by lowering barriers to mobility and increasing migrants' chances of successful settlement and integration.

The findings point to policy gaps as an underlying structural driver of migration. Limited government interventions in climate adaptation, inadequate rural infrastructure, weak agricultural support services, insufficient disaster preparedness, and the absence of effective livelihood protection programs leave vulnerable households with few alternatives to migration. In many affected communities, inadequate investment in irrigation, flood control, climate-smart agriculture, and social protection has reduced local adaptive capacity. As a result, migration increasingly functions as a coping mechanism rather than a voluntary choice.

The observed migration patterns demonstrate that climate-induced migration in Taraba State is a multidimensional adaptation strategy shaped by the interaction of environmental degradation, economic opportunities, social support systems, and institutional weaknesses. While migration enables households to reduce immediate livelihood risks, persistent reliance on mobility also reflects broader deficiencies in climate adaptation and rural development policies. Addressing the root causes of migration therefore requires integrated interventions that strengthen environmental resilience, expand livelihood opportunities, enhance social protection, and improve local governance to reduce forced displacement and promote sustainable community adaptation.

**Policy Responses and Community Adaptation Strategies**

The findings from the interviews and focus group discussions (FGDs) indicate that communities in Taraba State have developed several indigenous adaptation strategies to mitigate the adverse effects of climate variability. However, these responses remain largely localized, informal, and insufficient to address the increasing scale and intensity of climate-related challenges. The limited scope and coverage of these adaptation measures suggest that while local communities possess considerable adaptive capacity, they lack the institutional, financial, and technological support required to sustain resilience in the face of accelerating environmental change.

One of the most common adaptation strategies identified is the adoption of small-scale irrigation practices. Households situated near rivers, streams, and wetlands increasingly engage in dry-season farming using simple irrigation technologies to reduce dependence on increasingly unreliable rainfall. Small-scale irrigation enables farmers to diversify cropping seasons, stabilize food production, and generate additional income during periods of rainfall deficit. Nevertheless, these initiatives are constrained by inadequate irrigation infrastructure, limited access to water management technologies, poor extension services, and insufficient financial resources, thereby restricting their effectiveness and scalability.

The study also found that tree planting initiatives have emerged as an important community-based environmental conservation strategy. Local communities, often with the support of civil society organizations and faith-based groups, undertake tree planting to combat deforestation, reduce soil erosion, improve soil fertility, and mitigate the impacts of rising temperatures. Besides contributing to environmental restoration, these initiatives help improve biodiversity and strengthen ecosystem resilience. However, the absence of coordinated state support, weak enforcement of environmental regulations, and limited public awareness have prevented these initiatives from achieving broader landscape-level impacts.

Another important coping mechanism is the establishment of informal community-based savings groups. These locally organized financial arrangements enable members to pool savings and provide loans or emergency financial assistance during periods of crop failure, flooding, drought, or other climate-related shocks. Such groups enhance household resilience by providing temporary financial security, supporting livelihood diversification, and reducing dependence on external assistance. Nevertheless, their limited capital base and informal structure constrain their ability to respond effectively to prolonged or widespread climate crises.

Despite these community initiatives, the study reveals significant policy and institutional gaps that undermine effective climate adaptation and migration governance. Existing government interventions are largely reactive, focusing primarily on emergency relief following disasters rather than addressing the underlying drivers of climate vulnerability. Relief materials and humanitarian assistance often arrive after households have already experienced substantial livelihood losses, making these interventions inadequate to prevent displacement or support long-term recovery. Furthermore, the study found no comprehensive state-level policy framework that explicitly integrates climate change adaptation with migration management. As a result, climate-induced migration remains largely absent from development planning, disaster risk reduction strategies, and social protection programs.

To strengthen resilience, respondents consistently recommended several policy improvements. First, establishing effective early warning systems would enable communities to anticipate droughts, floods, and other extreme weather events, thereby improving preparedness and reducing disaster-related losses. Second, expanding social protection programs, including cash transfers, agricultural insurance, input subsidies, and livelihood support schemes, would enhance household resilience and reduce the economic pressures that compel migration. Third, promoting climate-smart agriculture through improved irrigation systems, drought-resistant crop varieties, conservation agriculture, climate information services, and strengthened agricultural extension services would improve productivity while enhancing farmers' capacity to adapt to changing climatic conditions. Increased investments in rural infrastructure, environmental restoration, and institutional coordination across relevant government agencies should support these interventions.

## Conclusion

This study concludes that climate variability is a major driver of irregular internal migration in Taraba State, primarily through its adverse effects on agricultural productivity, household livelihoods, food security, and socio-economic stability. The increasing frequency of erratic rainfall, rising temperatures, drought, and flooding has heightened the vulnerability of rural households, particularly those dependent on rain-fed agriculture. However, migration decisions are influenced not only by environmental stressors but also by socio-economic factors such as low household income, large family size, limited livelihood opportunities, and inadequate access to social support and essential public services. Consequently, irregular migration has become an important coping and adaptation strategy for households seeking to diversify income sources and reduce exposure to climate-related risks. Although migration provides temporary economic relief, it also creates significant development challenges, including increased pressure on urban infrastructure and public services, labor shortages in rural communities, declining agricultural productivity, and the erosion of traditional social support systems and community cohesion. These findings underscore that climate-induced migration reflects broader structural vulnerabilities rather than merely population movement.

The study further finds that existing adaptation initiatives and policy responses remain fragmented, reactive, and inadequate to address the complex relationship between climate variability and internal migration. Community-based measures such as small-scale irrigation, tree planting, and informal savings groups have strengthened local resilience but remain constrained by weak institutional support, inadequate funding, and poor policy coordination. Therefore, there is an urgent need for an integrated policy framework that combines climate adaptation, disaster risk reduction, migration management, and rural development while strengthening coordination among relevant government institutions. Investment in effective early warning systems, expanded social protection programs, climate-smart agriculture, and rural livelihood diversification should be prioritized to reduce household vulnerability and build long-term resilience. At the community level, support for cooperative societies, migration support networks, skills development, and continuous climate awareness programs will enhance adaptive capacity and reduce distress migration. By adopting these integrated policy and community-based interventions, Taraba State can transform climate-induced migration from a survival response into a planned adaptation strategy that promotes resilience, sustainable livelihoods, and inclusive socio-economic development.

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# COMMUNAL CONFLICT AND SOCIAL COHESION AMONG SELECTED COMMUNITIES IN WUKARI LOCAL GOVERNMENT AREA OF TARABA STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** This study explored Communal Conflict and Social Cohesion among Selected Communities in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State, Nigeria. Thus, the specific objectives of the study are to: (i) identify the major causes of communal conflict among Selected Communities in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State, (ii) examine the extent to which communal conflict affects social cohesion among Selected Communities in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State. A systematic literature review (SLR) approach was adopted using the PRISMA (Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses) framework to ensure rigor, transparency, and replicability. Initial search across databases yielded 320 studies. Following a PRISMA-inspired screening process, the study used inclusion and exclusion criteria to identify 6 studies, which were included in the final review. Thematic analysis was employed to examine the studies critically. Findings revealed that land disputes, cultural differences, and historical grievances are the most cited causes of communal conflict among the selected communities in Wukari Local Government Area. The study further found that communal conflict affects personal and communal trust among the selected communities in Wukari Local Government. The study concluded that recurring communal conflicts can deeply erode intergroup trust and cooperation, perpetuating cycles of division and instability. It recommends establishing community-based peacebuilding structures, inclusive governance, equitable land administration, and sustained intergroup dialogue to strengthen social cohesion and foster lasting peace.

**Keywords:** Communal conflict, social cohesion, peacebuilding, intergroup trust, shared identity.

## Introduction

Communal conflicts are a recurring phenomenon across the globe. They manifest in diverse forms and are often driven by identity politics, structural inequality, resource scarcity, and political manipulation. From South Asia to Sub-Saharan Africa and parts of the Middle East, communal violence has caused severe humanitarian crises, undermined development, and threatened social cohesion. For example, India continues to experience recurrent communal violence, particularly between its Hindu majority and Muslim minority. A notable recent

example is the 2020 Delhi riots, triggered by protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA), which was perceived as discriminatory against Muslims. Over 50 people died, and hundreds were injured during the violence. Human Rights Watch (2020) documented police complicity and the targeted nature of attacks.

While communal conflicts are recorded globally, Nigeria is not an exception; for example, the popularly known case of Farmer-Herder Conflicts in Nigeria. Although discussed in the national context, Nigeria's farmer-herder conflicts also fit into a broader global pattern of communal violence driven by competition for land and identity politics. The conflicts, particularly in the Middle Belt region, have led to thousands of deaths and have intensified religious and ethnic divisions (International Crisis Group, 2021).

Key drivers of communal conflict globally include Ethno-Religious Intolerance, Competition for Resources, Historical Injustices, Political Manipulation, Weak Institutions, etc. For example, Ethno-Religious Intolerance relates to deep-seated religious or ethnic animosities that contribute to mistrust and hostility. At the same time, Competition for Resources in communities involves people competing for land, water, employment, and political representation, all of which are often sources of tension or conflict among community members. Moreover, on one hand, Historical Injustices encompasses long-standing unresolved issues relating to colonial boundaries and systemic discrimination that have left legacies of resentment among communities. On the other hand, Political Manipulations involves the Elites sometimes exploiting identity divisions for political advantage, thereby creating a fertile ground for breeding communal conflicts. Additionally, weak institutions, as one of the drivers of communal conflicts, relate to a lack of strong will to enforce the law and a lack of access to justice by members of the communities, which can escalate minor disputes into full-blown violence.

Social cohesion refers to the degree of social integration and unity among groups in a society. It encompasses trust, sense of belonging, shared values, and the willingness of individuals to cooperate and work for the common good. Globally, social cohesion is increasingly recognized as a cornerstone of peace, stability, and sustainable development. At the global level, countries with strong institutions, inclusive governance, and equitable resource distribution tend to exhibit higher levels of social cohesion. Conversely, societies with entrenched inequalities, discrimination, and exclusion are more prone to divisions and conflict. For instance, Scandinavian countries rank high in social cohesion indices due to robust welfare systems, civic participation, and equitable policies. In contrast, multi-ethnic nations facing governance deficits such as South Sudan, Myanmar, or parts of Nigeria struggle with low social cohesion.

The relationship between communal conflict and social cohesion is both reciprocal and antagonistic. On one hand, the presence of communal conflict weakens social cohesion by eroding trust between communities, disrupting communication channels, and reinforcing stereotypes and divisions. When communities experience sustained violence or

marginalization, their willingness to cooperate or see themselves as part of a shared national identity diminishes significantly. On the other hand, weak social cohesion creates fertile ground for communal conflict to emerge. In environments where intergroup relationships are characterized by mistrust, exclusion, and competition, even minor disputes can escalate into large-scale violence. In this way, social cohesion acts as both a buffer against and a casualty of communal conflict. This dynamic is evident in many conflict-prone societies. For instance, in Nigeria, repeated clashes between Fulani herders and sedentary farmers have hardened ethnic lines and deepened mutual animosities, undermining national unity. Similarly, the ethnic violence in Ethiopia and the Rohingya crisis in Myanmar illustrate how communal conflict can fracture social cohesion and entrench divisions for generations. Therefore, any strategy aimed at mitigating communal conflict must incorporate deliberate efforts to strengthen social cohesion through inclusive governance, equitable resource sharing, conflict resolution mechanisms, and civic engagement.

Social cohesion, the glue that binds societies together through shared values, mutual trust, and collective belonging, is a fundamental condition for peace, development, and nation-building. Ideally, in a socially cohesive society, individuals and groups, regardless of ethnic, religious, or political affiliations, coexist harmoniously, participate in collective decision-making, trust one another, and collaborate toward common goals. Social cohesion fosters resilience against divisiveness and enables communities to manage differences constructively through dialogue and inclusive governance. In contrast to this ideal, Wukari Local Government Area (LGA) of Taraba State has experienced persistent disruptions to social cohesion, largely due to recurring communal conflicts between ethnic groups, particularly the Tiv and Jukun communities. These conflicts, often driven by disputes over land ownership, political exclusion, cultural differences, and historical grievances, have eroded trust and deepened suspicion among residents; mistrust prevails, and rather than a shared identity, ethno-political fragmentation dominates.

In consequence, social cohesion in Wukari has become fragile, with low levels of inter-group interaction, weakened institutions of reconciliation, and diminished willingness to collaborate across group lines (Abuh, Amayll & Ogwuche, 2017; Francis et al., 2024). The government and civil society have made several efforts to address these divisions. These include the establishment of peace committees, security interventions, the formation of interfaith dialogue groups, and the convening of reconciliation forums (Yahaya, Haruna & Francis, 2021). Despite these efforts, episodes of violence continue to erupt, and signs of deep-seated animosity persist. The reappearance of communal conflicts despite these initiatives points to unresolved structural and relational problems that continue to hinder the attainment of meaningful social cohesion in the region.

Given the persistent fragmentation and mutual suspicion among the diverse ethnic communities in Wukari LGA, there is an urgent need to conduct a comprehensive empirical investigation into the link between communal conflict and social cohesion. Such a study deepens understanding of the underlying issues. It provides evidence-based recommendations

to policymakers, community leaders, and peacebuilding practitioners to develop sustainable strategies for fostering inclusive and lasting peace in the region. Hence, the broad objective of this study is to investigate communal conflict and social cohesion among selected communities in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State, while the specific objectives are to (i) identify the major causes of communal conflict in selected communities within Wukari LGA and (ii) examine the extent to which communal conflict affects social cohesion among ethnic groups in Wukari LGA.

In terms of significance, this study holds significant practical, policy, and academic value for advancing peacebuilding and social cohesion. Practically, it equips grassroots stakeholders, including community, traditional, and religious leaders, NGOs, social workers, and youth groups, with empirical data and localized strategies to mediate disputes, design targeted interventions, and promote long-term reconciliation. At the policy level, the research provides actionable evidence for local, state, and federal government agencies (such as the Ministries of Internal Affairs, Women Affairs, and Youth Development) to institutionalize inclusive peace frameworks, implement conflict-sensitive resource allocation, and integrate community-based peace mechanisms into formal governance. Academically, the study enriches literature in conflict, sociology, and political science within the African context, filling a critical geographical research gap in the under-researched Wukari LGA while offering a multidimensional model and reference point for future scholars analyzing post-conflict recovery dynamics.

In terms of the scope of the study, geographically, it is delimited to conflict-affected communities within Wukari Local Government Area (LGA) of Taraba State, Nigeria, specifically targeting Kente Ward, Tsokundi, Bantaje, Jibu, Avyi, Rafin-Kada, Puje, Chonku, Wapan Nyaku, and Ikyaior, focusing on areas with a history of ethnic, religious, or political disputes involving the Jukun, Tiv, Hausa, and other resident groups. Thematically, the research explores the causes, patterns, and effects of communal conflict on social cohesion, specifically evaluating dimensions like inter-group trust, cooperation, and shared values. Furthermore, the study examines the lived experiences and perceptions of diverse local stakeholders, including community leaders, youth, women, and religious figures, while assessing the effectiveness of existing peace interventions to propose strategic, community-based approaches for sustainable reconciliation.

## Literature Review and Conceptual Framework

### Communal Conflict

Communal conflict is generally defined as violent confrontation or hostility between groups differentiated by ethnic, religious, cultural, or linguistic identities. Such conflicts often arise from a combination of historical grievances, competition for limited resources, marginalization, and socio-political exclusion. Communal conflicts differ from political or

criminal violence in that they are rooted in group identity and often persist over generations. Communal conflicts refer to violent confrontations between groups within a community, often rooted in disputes over land, political representation, identity, or access to scarce resources (Khan, 2021; Okereke & Lawal, 2023). In many developing countries, particularly in sub-Saharan Africa, such conflicts are exacerbated by weak governance, historical grievances, and ethnic or religious divisions (Arowosegbe, 2020; Mohammed & Yusuf, 2022). In Nigeria, communal conflicts have become increasingly frequent and deadly, especially in regions like the Middle Belt and North-East, where contestations over land ownership, traditional leadership, and indigene-settler dichotomies prevail (Omede & Bakut, 2023; Abubakar & Onyegbulem, 2024). These conflicts often result in loss of lives, displacement, destruction of livelihoods, and the breakdown of intergroup relations, thereby undermining social cohesion and community development (Liman et al., 2021). Recent scholarship emphasizes the role of inclusive governance, equitable resource allocation, and traditional conflict resolution mechanisms as critical to mitigating communal violence and promoting long-term peace (Aliyu & Haruna, 2023; Obasi & Adekeye, 2023). Therefore, understanding the complex drivers and patterns of communal conflicts is essential for designing targeted peacebuilding interventions.

**Social Cohesion**

Social cohesion refers to the strength of relationships and the sense of solidarity among members of a community or society, which enables cooperation for mutual benefit (Fonseca, Lukosch, & Brazier, 2019). It is characterized by shared values, trust, inclusion, and willingness to participate in communal life (Chan, To, & Chan, 2006; UNDP, 2022). Recent studies emphasize that social cohesion is vital for peacebuilding and sustainable development, especially in multi-ethnic and conflict-prone societies (Schiefer & van der Noll, 2017; Obasi & Adekeye, 2023). In Nigeria, particularly in regions affected by communal conflicts, social cohesion has been weakened by distrust, marginalization, and identity-based violence, leading to fragmented communities (Edeh & Eme, 2020; Aliyu & Haruna, 2023). Scholars have also noted that the erosion of cohesion often results in lower levels of community engagement, reduced social capital, and a decline in collective problem-solving (Adewale & Omotola, 2021; Yusuf, 2024). Thus, strengthening social cohesion through inclusive governance, equitable resource distribution, and intergroup dialogue is increasingly viewed as essential for conflict resolution and societal resilience.

**Link between Conflicts and Social Cohesion**

There is a growing body of literature emphasizing that communal conflicts significantly undermine social cohesion by eroding trust, weakening shared values, and disrupting intergroup relations (Fonseca, Lukosch, & Brazier, 2019; Obasi & Adekeye, 2023). In conflict-affected societies, frequent communal violence often results in long-term fragmentation, mutual suspicion, and social withdrawal, which in turn reduces participation in collective community activities (Aliyu & Haruna, 2023; Yusuf, 2024). Empirical studies in

Nigeria's Middle Belt and North East regions show that repeated communal clashes not only cause physical destruction and displacement but also foster deep-seated resentment, weakening the social glue that binds communities together (Edeh & Eme, 2020; Abubakar & Onyegbulem, 2024). According to Mohammed and Yusuf (2022), communal conflict disrupts both vertical (state-society) and horizontal (intergroup) trust, making reconciliation and peacebuilding difficult. Adewale and Omotola (2021) further argue that unresolved grievances and continued marginalization create an environment of social disintegration, where individuals no longer feel a sense of belonging or shared identity. Thus, the relationship between communal conflict and social cohesion is largely inverse, where persistent conflict weakens the capacity of communities to coexist peacefully and pursue collective goals.

## Theoretical Framework

The theoretical framework provides the foundation for understanding the relationship between communal conflict and social cohesion. It guides the research by explaining the underlying mechanisms, causes, and dynamics. The Social Identity Theory (SIT), developed by Tajfel and Turner (1979), was adopted to underpin the study as it better explains how individuals derive a sense of identity and belonging from their membership in social groups, often leading to in-group favoritism and out-group discrimination. Its key assumptions are that people categorize themselves and others into social groups to enhance self-esteem and that intergroup conflict often arises when group identities are threatened or perceived as unequal. The theory also assumes that the mere perception of belonging to distinct social groups is sufficient to trigger competition and hostility. However, SIT has been criticized for overemphasizing identity-based explanations while neglecting the role of structural, political, and economic factors in conflicts. Another criticism is its limited attention to how individuals navigate multiple and overlapping identities in complex societies. Despite these limitations, the theory is highly relevant to the current study as it helps explain how ethnic affiliations and identity politics fuel communal tensions in Wukari. Moreover, it provides a useful framework for understanding how identity-based divisions undermine social cohesion in conflict-prone communities.

## Methodology

This study adopted a systematic literature review (SLR) guided by the PRISMA (Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses) framework to examine the causes of communal conflict and its effects on social cohesion in Wukari LGA. The review followed the stages of identification, screening, eligibility, and inclusion, with the quality of selected studies assessed using the Critical Appraisal Skills Program (CASP) checklist. Literature was sourced from Google Scholar, Scopus, Web of Science, ResearchGate, and Academia.edu using keywords and Boolean operators such as "communal conflict" AND "social cohesion." Only peer-reviewed, English-language, full-text journal articles conducted in Wukari were included, while non-peer-reviewed, non-English, inaccessible, irrelevant, and

out-of-area studies were excluded. The PRISMA screening process identified 320 records, of which 180 duplicates were removed, leaving 140 studies for title and abstract screening. After excluding 60 irrelevant studies, 80 full-text articles were assessed, with 74 excluded because of outdated publication (n = 20), lack of full-text access (n = 10), methodological weaknesses (n = 25), or insufficient relevance (n = 19). Consequently, 6 studies were included in the final review.

**Screening Process for the Selection of Studies for Analysis**

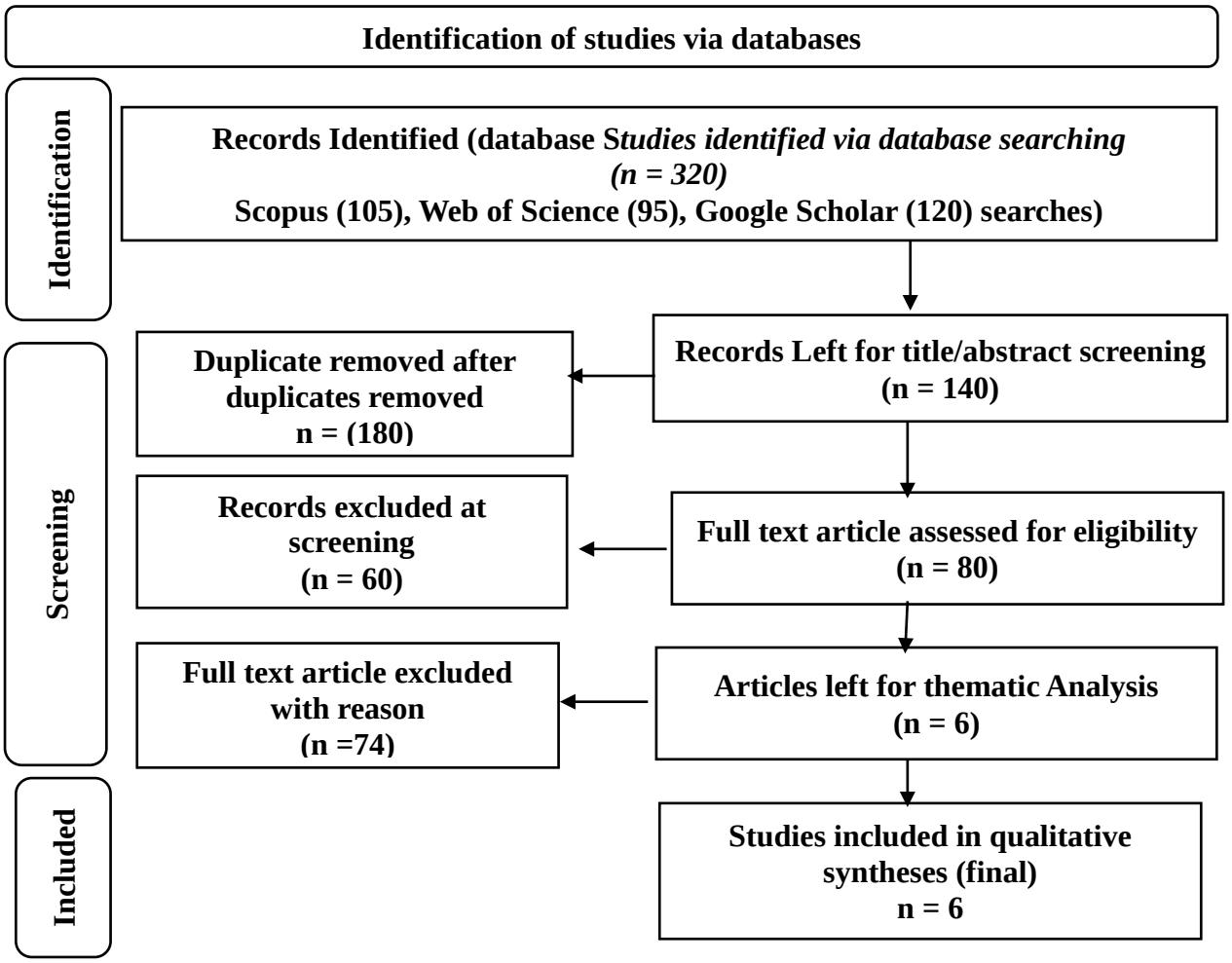



Figure 1: PRISMA flow chart showing the summary of the selection process

**Thematic Analysis**

**Causes of Communal Conflicts**

The study by Amakoromo, Agwadu and Namo (2024) examined the root of the Tiv–Jukun communal violence in Wukari LGA. Drawing on field data and documentary evidences, they identified a clustered causes of communal violence that interact to produce recurrent clashes

which include: (1) conflict entrepreneurs and elite manipulation i.e., local actors who mobilise youth, inflame identity narratives and profit from disorder; (2) economic motivators such as poverty, inequality and the desire for material gain that make violence rewarding for some actors; (3) land and resource competition, including disputed ownership, boundary claims and struggles over fertile farmland and grazing routes; (4) political and chieftaincy disputes, where contests for local offices, recognition of traditional rulers and access to patronage turn local tensions into violent confrontations; (5) unresolved historical grievances that keep old disputes alive and ready to be re-ignited; and (6) weak institutional responses in terms of partial security intervention, impunity and slow dispute-resolution mechanisms that fail to deter repetition. The authors argue these causes are mutually reinforcing (for example, elites exploit land disputes and political contests for economic gain), which helps explain the persistence of violence and the difficulty of achieving durable peace in Wukari.

Another important empirical study is by Agbu, Zhema, and Agbu (2020) titled “An Investigative Study into the Causes and Effects of Ethno-Religious Conflicts on Women and Children in Wukari and Ibi Local Government Areas of Taraba State, Nigeria (1991-2020)”. This study employed a mixed-methods approach, i.e., combining interviews, questionnaires, and documentary analysis to investigate the root causes of communal conflicts in Wukari. The researchers identified several interrelated factors fueling persistent hostilities. Chief among them is land ownership and boundary disputes between the Tiv and Jukun ethnic groups, which have intensified due to population growth, migration, and the absence of clear demarcation of farmlands. The study also highlights political exclusion and chieftaincy rivalries, where one ethnic group feels marginalized in local leadership and resource allocation, creating resentment and mistrust. Another major cause is religious intolerance, as Christianity and traditional belief systems are often used to draw identity lines that amplify existing ethnic divisions. Furthermore, economic hardship and youth unemployment make young men vulnerable to recruitment by conflict entrepreneurs and militia groups. Finally, the authors note that weak government intervention, biased security responses, and a culture of impunity have allowed violence to persist. Agbu et al. (2020) conclude that without addressing these root causes, especially land reform, inclusive governance, and equitable development, communal peace in Wukari will remain fragile.

Another relevant empirical study is by Odigbo (2018) titled “Two Neighbors, Too Many Crises: Re-thinking Measures to Ending the Tide of Jukun/Tiv Violent Conflict in Wukari”, published in the Nigerian Journal of Political Science (NAJOPS). Adopting a qualitative research approach to collect primary data from community leaders, victims of communal conflicts, and security agents using interviews, Odigbo (2018) examined the recurring communal clashes between the Jukun and Tiv ethnic groups in Wukari Local Government Area. The study identified land ownership and territorial claims as the most persistent cause of the conflict, tracing these disputes to pre-colonial settlement patterns and the lack of clearly defined boundaries between Tiv farmlands and Jukun territories. Odigbo further points to ethnic identity and cultural domination, arguing that mutual distrust and perceptions of superiority or marginalization reinforce hostility between both groups. Additionally,

political manipulation and elite interests were found to play a central role: politicians and traditional elites allegedly exploit ethnic sentiments to mobilize support, particularly during elections, thereby deepening divisions. The research also underscores religious intolerance, where faith-based differences overlap with ethnic tensions, making disputes more volatile. Finally, poor governance and weak conflict management institutions, including biased security responses and the absence of effective justice mechanisms, were cited as enabling factors that allow the cycle of violence to continue. Odigbo (2018) concludes that sustainable peace in Wukari requires inclusive governance, fair land administration, and genuine reconciliation processes led by credible local institutions.

**Effect of Communal Conflict**

The study by Momodu, Matudi & Momodu (2013) titled "Exploring the Dynamics of Identity-Based Conflict and the Possibility for its Sustainable Management: A Study of the Persistent Ethno-Religious Conflict in Wukari Area of Taraba State, Nigeria," finds that communal violence in Wukari has profoundly undermined social cohesion in multiple, mutually reinforcing ways. First, the authors document a severe erosion of interpersonal trust between formerly co-existing groups, with mutual suspicion replacing routine neighbourliness; second, violence produced spatial segregation (divided settlement patterns) so that communities now live apart and avoid crossing into each other's areas; third, the conflict caused breakdown of social networks and intergroup institutions (markets, religious and cultural associations, and joint labour arrangements) that previously knit the town together; fourth, there is marked psychological separation and intergroup hatred, trauma, fear and stereotyping that are transmitted across generations; fifth, political life became polarised along identity lines, reducing chances for cross-cutting alliances and cooperative governance; sixth, customary mechanisms for dispute resolution and traditional leadership legitimacy were weakened or contested, removing local channels that once managed tensions non-violently; and finally, mass displacement and population flight disrupted inter-household ties (intermarriage, reciprocal labour, credit relationships), further degrading shared social capital. The paper emphasizes that these social-cohesion effects are not short-lived: they feed back into economic and political grievances and thus make peacebuilding more difficult unless reconciliation, trust-building and inclusive local institutions are deliberately restored.

Another insightful study is by Bawa, Haruna, and Emmanuel (2021) titled "State Intervention in Communal Conflict: A Study of Tiv–Jukun Crisis in Takum and Wukari Local Government Areas of Taraba State (2001–2019)", published in the Lapai International Journal of Administration. This study explored the long-term implications of communal conflicts on social cohesion and intergroup relations in Wukari. Drawing on interviews, focus group discussions, and official records, the authors found that persistent conflict has deeply fragmented social relationships among ethnic and religious groups that once coexisted peacefully. One major effect identified is the breakdown of communal trust, as repeated cycles of violence have created suspicion and fear between the Tiv and Jukun peoples. The study further reports declining inter-ethnic cooperation, particularly in farming, trade, and

local governance, activities that previously depended on mutual reliance and shared community norms. Another effect is social polarization, where identity lines (ethnic and religious) have hardened, leading to exclusive social networks and the erosion of cross-cutting ties such as intermarriage and mixed neighborhood settlements. The authors also note that the conflict caused the collapse of traditional conflict-resolution mechanisms and local institutions, thereby weakening the social fabric that once mediated disputes. Lastly, youth radicalization and the militarization of community identity have replaced older traditions of communal solidarity with factional loyalty and mistrust. Bawa et al. (2021) conclude that sustainable peace in Wukari requires deliberate policies that promote reconciliation, rebuild trust, and re-establish inclusive institutions capable of transcending ethnic divisions.

Another relevant empirical study is by Adagba, Ugwuja, and Ede (2020) titled “Ethno-Religious Conflicts and Social Disintegration in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State, Nigeria”, published in the Journal of Peace, Security and Development Studies. Using field interviews, focus group discussions, and questionnaires, the authors investigated how recurring communal violence, particularly the Tiv–Jukun conflict, has weakened the bonds of social cohesion in Wukari.

The study found that the repeated cycles of communal clashes have eroded mutual trust and intergroup tolerance, replacing them with suspicion, fear, and resentment between communities. Traditional social ties, such as intermarriages, shared markets, and cooperative farming arrangements, have been disrupted or completely severed, leading to increasing ethnic segregation. The conflict has also led to the breakdown of community institutions and leadership structures that previously maintained harmony, as both traditional rulers and religious leaders lost credibility for being perceived as biased. Another key finding is the loss of collective identity and sense of belonging, where residents increasingly identify with ethnic or religious groups rather than as members of a unified Wukari community. The authors further note that youth radicalization and social isolation have increased as young people, traumatized by violence and displacement, turn to militant or vigilante groups instead of community-building initiatives. Adagba et al. (2020) conclude that communal conflict in Wukari has profoundly fractured social cohesion, turning a once interdependent community into one defined by division and distrust. They recommend that peacebuilding efforts should focus on restoring intergroup trust, strengthening local conflict-resolution institutions, and encouraging joint economic ventures that rebuild interdependence.

**Social Cohesion among Selected Communities in Wukari LGA**

Social cohesion across the selected communities of Wukari LGA Stokundi, Bantaji, Jibu, Avyi, Rafin-Kada, Puji, and Chonku has been significantly shaped by the recurring patterns of communal conflict that characterize the area. These communities have historically relied on inter-ethnic trade, farming cooperation, shared markets, and communal institutions to sustain everyday social interaction. However, episodes of violence linked to indigene-settler tensions, land disputes, chieftaincy rivalries, and religious or political grievances have

weakened these traditional bonds. In Tsokundi and Rafin-Kada, repeated disruptions to farming and market activities have reduced interdependence among groups, while in Baantaji, Avyi and Jibu, contestations over identity, territorial claims and local leadership structures have deepened mistrust and limited opportunities for constructive engagement. Similarly, communities such as Puje and Chonku have experienced displacement, fear of movement, and fragmentation of shared social spaces, which undermine collective resilience. Overall, the combined effect of these pressures is a decline in trust, cooperation, and shared community life, leading to a fragile social fabric that struggles to support meaningful cohesion across ethnic and social boundaries in Wukari LGA.

**Findings and Discussion of Findings**

The systematic review identified several interrelated factors responsible for the persistence of communal conflicts in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State. Across the reviewed studies, land ownership and boundary disputes emerged as the most consistent driver of conflict, reflecting the centrality of land as a source of livelihood, identity, and political influence among the Tiv and Jukun communities. Competition over access to land and natural resources has been exacerbated by weak land administration systems and the absence of effective dispute resolution mechanisms, thereby sustaining recurring cycles of violence (Amakoromo et al., 2024; Agbu et al., 2020; Odigbo, 2018).

The review further revealed that political exclusion, chieftaincy disputes, and elite manipulation significantly contribute to communal tensions. Political actors and influential elites have frequently exploited ethnic identities and traditional institutions to advance personal and group interests, thereby deepening mistrust and reinforcing divisions. Closely linked to these are unresolved historical grievances, which continue to shape perceptions of injustice and fuel retaliatory violence. These findings indicate that the recurrence of communal conflicts in Wukari is rooted not only in contemporary political competition but also in longstanding historical and institutional challenges.

Economic hardship, poverty, youth unemployment, and competition for scarce resources were also identified as important drivers of communal conflict. These socio-economic conditions increase the vulnerability of young people to mobilization by conflict entrepreneurs, who exploit grievances for material and political gain. In addition, religious intolerance and cultural differences reinforce existing ethnic divisions, particularly where governance structures fail to promote inclusion, accountability, and equitable access to resources. Weak government intervention, poor conflict management institutions, and a culture of impunity further perpetuate violence by limiting effective prevention, mediation, and post-conflict reconciliation.

These findings have important implications for peacebuilding and local governance in Wukari LGA. Addressing communal conflicts requires comprehensive interventions that

strengthen land governance, improve boundary demarcation and dispute resolution systems, promote inclusive political participation, and reform traditional governance institutions. Equally important are initiatives that address poverty and youth unemployment while fostering inter-ethnic dialogue, cultural understanding, and reconciliation to heal historical grievances. Strengthening state institutions and enhancing collaboration among government agencies, traditional rulers, religious leaders, and civil society organizations are also essential for preventing future conflicts and promoting sustainable social cohesion.

The findings corroborate those of Amakoromo, Agwadu, and Namo (2024), who identified land disputes, conflict entrepreneurship, political manipulation, and weak institutional responses as major drivers of the Tiv–Jukun conflict in Wukari. Similarly, Agbu, Zhema, and Agbu (2020) found that land ownership disputes, political exclusion, chieftaincy rivalries, religious intolerance, and economic hardship were central to ethno-religious conflicts in Wukari and Ibi. Odigbo (2018) likewise emphasized land ownership, ethnic identity, political interests, and weak governance as the underlying causes of recurring violence. Collectively, these studies demonstrate that communal conflict in Wukari is multidimensional, requiring integrated policy responses that address structural, political, economic, and socio-cultural factors simultaneously.

Nevertheless, a recurring finding across the reviewed studies is the erosion of interpersonal and communal trust, which weakens relationships among individuals and ethnic groups. As trust declines, communities become increasingly divided, resulting in social fragmentation, spatial segregation, and the breakdown of intergroup cooperation in economic, political, and social activities (Momodu et al., 2013; Bawa et al., 2021). These conditions undermine peaceful coexistence and reduce the capacity of communities to address shared challenges collectively.

The review also showed that communal conflicts have severe socio-economic consequences that further weaken social cohesion. These include loss of lives and property, destruction of public infrastructure, displacement of populations, declining agricultural productivity and household incomes, loss of crops and livestock, deterioration in children's education, and the diversion of public resources from development to security operations (Igbadoo & Gbenga, 2023). The proliferation of small arms and the creation of an insecure environment further discourage economic activities and social interactions, thereby deepening divisions within affected communities.

Beyond the socio-economic impacts, communal conflicts were found to disrupt traditional and informal mechanisms that sustain social cohesion. The studies highlighted the breakdown of customary dispute-resolution institutions, the weakening of inter-household relationships such as intermarriage, reciprocal labor, and informal credit arrangements, and increasing political and social polarization along ethnic and religious lines (Momodu et al., 2013; Bawa et al., 2021). The review further identified youth radicalization and the militarization of

community identities as emerging consequences that perpetuate cycles of violence and reduce opportunities for reconciliation and sustainable peace.

These findings suggest that restoring social cohesion in Wukari requires interventions that extend beyond the cessation of violence. Effective peacebuilding should prioritize rebuilding trust through inter-ethnic dialogue, reconciliation programs, and inclusive community development initiatives that encourage cooperation across ethnic and religious divides. Strengthening customary conflict-resolution institutions, promoting social integration, supporting displaced populations, and creating sustainable livelihood opportunities, particularly for young people, are equally important for preventing renewed conflict and fostering long-term peace.

The findings are consistent with those of Igbadoo and Gbenga (2023), who reported that the Tiv–Jukun conflict resulted in widespread socio-economic disruption, displacement, and insecurity in Wukari. They also corroborate the work of Momodu, Matudi, and Momodu (2013), who found that identity-based conflicts undermine interpersonal trust, weaken social institutions, and intensify political polarization. Similarly, Bawa, Haruna, and Emmanuel (2021) observed that communal violence fragments social relationships, reduces inter-ethnic cooperation, and weakens traditional mechanisms for conflict resolution. Collectively, these studies demonstrate that communal conflict significantly undermines social cohesion by disrupting the social, economic, and institutional foundations necessary for peaceful coexistence and sustainable development in Wukari LGA.

## Conclusion

This study examined the causes of communal conflicts and their effects on social cohesion in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State through a systematic review of the literature. The findings indicate that persistent land disputes, political exclusion, chieftaincy rivalries, religious intolerance, unresolved historical grievances, economic hardship, and youth unemployment are the principal drivers of communal conflicts in the area. These interconnected factors have weakened interpersonal and communal trust, disrupted intergroup cooperation, fragmented social relationships, and undermined sustainable community development. The study therefore concludes that communal conflicts significantly erode social cohesion by weakening the social, economic, and institutional foundations necessary for peaceful coexistence.

Addressing these challenges requires coordinated and sustained interventions by government, traditional institutions, civil society organizations, and community stakeholders. The Taraba State Government, in collaboration with the Wukari Local Government Council and traditional authorities, should establish a Conflict Resolution and Peacebuilding Committee to address the structural drivers of conflict through inclusive dialogue, transparent land administration, equitable boundary demarcation, and effective mechanisms for resolving

chieftaincy and political disputes. The committee should comprise traditional rulers, community leaders, youth representatives, civil society organizations, women's groups, and legal experts. It should facilitate regular community peace forums, mediation initiatives, and cultural integration programs across conflict-prone communities.

Furthermore, the Wukari Local Government Council, in partnership with religious institutions, development partners, and community-based organizations, should implement structured peacebuilding initiatives aimed at rebuilding trust and strengthening social cohesion. These initiatives should include inter-ethnic dialogue, joint cultural festivals, conflict-sensitivity training, youth empowerment and employment programs, and community reconciliation activities designed to reduce ethnic polarization and promote inclusive participation in local governance. Strengthening customary conflict-resolution institutions alongside formal governance mechanisms will further enhance the sustainability of these interventions. Collectively, these measures will contribute to rebuilding trust, fostering peaceful coexistence, and creating the social conditions necessary for sustainable development in Wukari Local Government Area.

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# GENDER AND PEACE BUILDING IN NIGERIA: A STUDY OF PARTICIPATION IN CONFLICT RESOLUTION AND SUSTAINABLE PEACE

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**Abstract.** Gender equality and shared responsibility in the peace process played by both men and women have a significant role in the field of peacebuilding, with recognised importance in promoting sustainable and inclusive peace. This paper examines the complex relationship between gender and peacebuilding, revealing the diverse ways in which gender inequalities and power dynamics influence the peace process, with a focus on areas like the North-east, Middle-belt, Niger-Delta, Plateau and Kaduna states region. The study further investigates the role of gender in peace building in Nigeria, focusing on the exclusion of women from formal peace processes, shaped conflict dynamics. The study analyses the positive contribution of gender equality and women's participation in peacebuilding initiatives as well as the challenges that hinder their full inclusion. The study demonstrates that addressing the power dynamics will enable policymakers, practitioners and researchers to foster effective transformative approaches to peacebuilding that promote gender equality and social justice. Agency theory provides a picture of understanding how women's marginalisation from peacebuilding reinforces. The study employs a qualitative research design drawing on empirical literature, policy documents, and scholarly studies to analysis pattern to gender-based violence and peacebuilding practices across conflict-affected areas in Nigeria. Findings show that women play vital roles in peacebuilding and are involved in resolution mechanisms with stigma and economic exclusion, while weak institutions and poor justice responses contributed to cultural impunity. The research reveals that women's exclusion from peace negotiations undermines the sustainability and inclusiveness of peace initiatives, as their experiences and needs remain unaddressed in most peace agreements. The study concluded that gender is grounded in Agency theory. The researcher recommends the United Nations UNSCR 1325 and Nigeria Action Plan to be implemented for sustainable peace.

**Keywords:** Gender, Conflict, Peace building, Agency Theory, Nigeria

## Introduction

Peace building has become one of the most significant issues in contemporary Nigeria due to the persistent occurrence of violent conflicts across different regions of the country. Gender thus refers to a strategy that seeks to integrate gender perspective in to all stages of policy development, advocacy, and resource allocation to ensure that men and women benefit

equally. It has become a central pillar of global peace and development policy, particularly since the adoption of the Beijing Platform for Action in 1995. It urges governments to integrate gender considerations across all sectors as a strategy for achieving equality (UN Women, 2020). This global commitment was reinforced by the landmark United Nations Security Council Resolution (UNSCR) 1325 on Women, Peace and Security (WPS) in 2000.The emphasis is on the need to recognize women not only as victims of conflict but also as important actors in peacebuilding, conflict prevention, and post-conflict reconstruction (UNDP, 2021). According to Enloe (2019), gender essentially seeks to transform institutional norms and ensure that gendered power relations are acknowledged and addressed in all peace and security processes. Nigeria provides a rich context for interrogating gender within peacebuilding because of its prolonged and multifaceted security challenges.

The country has experienced diverse conflicts, including the Boko Haram insurgency in the Northeast, armed banditry in the Northwest, farmer–herder conflicts in the North-Central, militancy in the Niger-Delta, and separatist agitations in the Southeast. These conflicts have collectively produced substantial humanitarian crises, massive internal displacement, economic instability, and widespread human rights abuses (Danjibo et al., 2023). Women and girls often bear the brunt of these crises through abductions, forced marriages, sexual and gender-based violence, loss of livelihoods, and disruption of social support systems (Obi & Hassan, 2020). Despite this vulnerability, women have consistently demonstrated resilience by engaging in informal peace negotiations, early-warning mechanisms, community mediation, and support for displaced persons (Okpara & Adeleye, 2021).

Recognising these realities, Nigeria has developed several frameworks aimed at integrating gender into peace and security governance. These include the National Gender Policy (2006), the National Action Plan (NAP) for implementing UNSCR 1325 first adopted in 2013 and revised in 2017andinstitutional initiatives championed by the Federal Ministry of Women Affairs and civil society organizations such as WACOL and WRAPA. These frameworks aim to increase women's meaningful participation in peace building, enhance protection mechanisms, and improve gender-responsive decision-making. International development partners such as UN Women, ECOWAS, and UNDP have supported these efforts through training, advocacy, and capacity-building programmes (UN Women, 2020; UNDP, 2021). However, the implementation of gender in Nigeria remains limited and inconsistent. Research shows that women continue to occupy marginal positions informal peace and security institutions, representing less than there commended threshold for effective gender representation (Adebajo & Omotola, 2021).

Barriers such as patriarchal norms, weak institutional capacity, insufficient funding, absence of gender-disaggregated data, and limited political will continue to undermine progress (Danjibo et al., 2023). Furthermore, peace negotiation processes at federal, state, and local government levels rarely include women, despite evidence that women's participation leads to more durable peace outcomes (Okenwa, 2022). The persistence of these challenges underscores the need for a deeper examination of gender in Nigeria's peace building architecture. Understanding how gender perspectives are currently integrated and the obstacles that impede their effective implementation offers critical insights into enhancing the country's peace building strategies. As Galtung (2019) argues, sustainable peace requires inclusive processes that address the structural and cultural causes of conflict. Therefore,

strengthening gender in Nigeria is not only a policy imperative but also a pathway toward achieving lasting stability and development.

Nigeria has experienced various forms of conflict including insurgency in the North-East, farmer-herder clashes in the Middle Belt, and militancy in the Niger Delta, ethno religious violence in Plateau and Kaduna States, secessionist agitations in the South-East, banditry in the North-West, and electoral violence across the federation. These conflicts effects include displacement, poverty, insecurity, destruction of infrastructure, and loss of lives and properties. Peace building ultimate purpose is geared towards preventing the outbreak, continuation, and recurrence of violent conflict in pursuit to promoting reconciliation, justice, and sustainable peace. The resolution mechanisms employed for success in peace building includes conflict prevention, mediation, dialogue, post-conflict reconstruction, and institutional strengthening. In Nigeria, peace building has increasingly become a national priority due to the need for long-term conflict management, national integration and national stability.

Gender has been considered as a significant instrument which play a critical role in peace building because conflict affects men and women differently. Women and girls often suffer disproportionately during conflicts through sexual violence, displacement, loss of livelihoods, and social exclusion. Despite these challenges, women remain active informal agents of peace building through community mediation, humanitarian interventions, advocacy, reconciliation efforts, and grassroots mobilization. It has being on record that, peace processes in Nigeria have been dominated by men, while women are often excluded from formal negotiations and leadership structures. This exclusion limits the effectiveness of peace building because it ignores the perspectives and contributions of half of the population. The United Nations Security Council Resolution 1325 on Women, Peace and Security emphasizes the importance of women's participation in conflict prevention, conflict resolution, and post-conflict reconstruction.

Fundamentally, Nigeria had adopted a National Action Plan for the implementation of Resolution 1325 to improve women's inclusion in peace and security matters. However, practical implementation remains weak due to men's domination and monopolistic cultural barriers, patriarchy, poor political representation, weak institutional support, and limited funding for women-led peace initiatives and laudable developmental efforts in conflict affected areas. This study therefore examines gender and peace building in Nigeria with emphasis on women's participation in conflict resolution and sustainable peace. It seeks to explore the extent of women's involvement, balance gender inequality that continually prevailed, the challenges they face, and the strategies required to strengthen inclusive peace building in Nigeria.

**Statement of the Problem**

There is no controversy that despite the increasing recognition of women's importance in peacebuilding, their participation in formal peace processes in Nigeria remains significantly low. Most conflict resolution mechanisms are still monopolized by men, while women are largely confined to informal and community-based roles that are often unrecognized and undervalued.

Despite increasing global recognition of the importance of gender in peacebuilding, Nigeria continues to struggle with effectively integrating gender perspectives into its peace and security architecture. Although frameworks such as the National Gender Policy (2006) and the National Action Plan (NAP) for implementing UNSCR 1325 (2013; revised in 2017) were established to promote women's participation in peace processes, significant gaps remain between policy commitments and actual practice. These frameworks largely exist on paper and have not translated into meaningful structural changes within institutions responsible for conflict management and security governance (Danjibo et al., 2023). A major problem is the persistent marginalization of women in formal peacebuilding mechanisms. Women are routinely excluded from high-level peace negotiations, security decision-making bodies, conflict-resolution committees, and early-warning systems. Existing studies show that women make up less than 10% of Nigeria's peace and security institutions, far below international recommendations (Adebajo & Omotola, 2021).

This exclusion limits the diversity of perspectives needed to understand the gendered dimensions of conflict and undermines the effectiveness of peace interventions. Furthermore, gender-based violence remains widespread in conflict-affected regions. Women and girls continue to experience abduction, sexual violence, forced marriages and displacement. Also, in all-around conflict-affected areas, women informally serve as mediators, caregivers, and advocates for peace, yet they are excluded from formal negotiation tables where major decisions are made. Thus, gender imbalance weakens the effectiveness and sustainability of peace agreements because the experiences and needs of women are not adequately represented.

Furthermore, persistent patriarchal norms, low access to education, economic dependency, insecurity, and limited political opportunities continue to hinder women's participation in peace building. Although Nigeria has adopted policies aimed at promoting gender inclusion, implementation remains poor and institutional commitment is often weak. The problem therefore lies in the gap between policy recognition and practical inclusion of women in peace building processes.

**Objective of the Study**

i. To examine the role of women in peacebuilding processes.

ii. To identify challenges affecting women's participation in conflict resolution.

iii. To assess policy on women's inclusion in peacebuilding.

## Research Questions

Two research questions guided the study:

i. What role do women play in peacebuilding in Nigeria?

ii. What are the major barriers hindering women's participation in conflict resolution?

iii. How effective are gender policies in promoting their inclusion in peace building?

## Conceptual Clarification

### Gender and Gender Participation

Gender refers to the socially constructed roles, expectations, behaviours, and power relations associated with being male or female within a given society, distinguishing it from biological sex (Connell & Pearse, 2015). These constructions shape access to resources, opportunities, and authority, often producing structural inequalities that limit women's participation in governance, conflict resolution, and development processes (World Bank, 2019). Gender emerged as a global strategy to address these gaps by ensuring that gender perspectives are integrated into policies, institutions, and programme cycles at all levels (UN-Women, 2020).

It promotes the systematic assessment of how proposed actions may affect women and men differently to prevent reinforcing inequalities. In peacebuilding, gender participation strengthens inclusivity, enhances conflict-sensitivity, and ensures that interventions respond adequately to the needs of diverse groups affected by violence (True, 2016). Incorporating women's voices and experiences contributes to more durable peace outcomes, as societies that adopt gender-responsive approaches tend to implement more equitable, legitimate, and sustainable post-conflict reforms (O'Reilly, ÓSúilleabháin, & Paffenholz, 2015). Thus, gender participation is both a normative commitment and a practical framework for improving peacebuilding effectiveness.

### Peacebuilding

Peace building refers to deliberate efforts aimed at preventing the outbreak, escalation, continuation, or recurrence of violent conflict and fostering sustainable peace within societies (Galtung, 2019). It encompasses a wide range of activities, including conflict prevention, negotiation, mediation, reconciliation, post-conflict reconstruction, institution building, and promoting social cohesion. Peacebuilding is multidimensional, addressing not only immediate security concerns but also structural causes of conflict such as inequality, exclusion, weak governance, and socio-economic marginalization (Lund, 2020). Effective peace building requires inclusivity, participation, and legitimacy, with actors ranging from state institutions and international organizations to local communities and civil society groups. The success of peacebuilding efforts is often contingent on integrating diverse perspectives, including those of marginalized groups, to ensure that the root causes of conflict

are addressed. Without comprehensive approaches, peacebuilding interventions risk being superficial, unsustainable, or inadvertently exacerbating existing tensions (Paris & Sisk, 2009). Thus, peacebuilding is not only a security-oriented strategy but also a social, political, and economic endeavour that requires long-term commitment.

## Gender in Peacebuilding

Gender in peacebuilding involves the systematic integration of gender perspectives into all stages of conflict management, peace negotiations, and post-conflict reconstruction (Okenwa, 2022). It recognises that men and women experience conflict differently, with women often facing sexual violence, displacement, and economic marginalization, while also contributing uniquely to peace and reconciliation efforts. By incorporating gender considerations, peace building processes become more inclusive, equitable, and effective, enhancing the legitimacy and sustainability of interventions (True, 2016). Research indicates that women's participation in peace processes leads to more durable peace agreements, stronger community cohesion, and improved monitoring of ceasefires and human rights protections (O'Reilly, Ó Súilleabháin, & Paffenholz, 2015). Gender participation requires legal frameworks, institutional reforms, and capacity-building measures to ensure that women are actively involved in decision making and those policies are sensitive to gender-specific vulnerabilities. In practice, this includes designing programmmes that address women's security needs, promoting equal representation in peace committees, and implementing mechanisms to monitor gender outcomes. Hence, gender mainstreaming is both a normative and practical approach that enhances the effectiveness of peace building.

## Nigeria's Peace and Security Context

Nigeria's peace and security landscape is complex, characterized by multidimensional conflicts with political, economic, religious, ethnic, and resource-driven dimensions. The Boko Haram insurgency in the Northeast has resulted in tens of thousands of deaths, mass displacement, and widespread disruption of social and economic life (Danjibo et al., 2023). In the North Central region, clashes between pastoralists and farmers over land and water resources have caused recurring communal violence, while armed banditry in the Northwest threatens public safety and economic activities. In the Niger Delta, resource-related militancy has historically undermined regional stability, affecting both local livelihoods and national development (Adebajo & Omotola, 2021). Women are disproportionately affected, facing abductions, sexual violence, forced marriages, and loss of access to education and livelihoods. Despite these vulnerabilities, women actively participate in informal conflict resolution, community mediation, and humanitarian support, demonstrating resilience and leadership (Okpara & Adeleye, 2021). Addressing Nigeria's conflicts effectively requires peacebuilding approaches that incorporate gender perspectives, ensuring both the protection of women and their meaningful participation in decision-making processes to foster inclusive and sustainable peace.

## Empirical Review

Gender participation for peacebuilding is a widely trending issue. It covers several viewpoints, including how women are excluded in peace building mechanism in Nigeria. For instance, Obi and Hassan (2020) examined the extent to which gender perspectives have been integrated into formal peacebuilding processes in Nigeria. The study highlights that women remain significantly underrepresented in peace and security decision-making bodies, including mediation committees, local peace councils, and government task forces addressing conflict. Using qualitative analysis of government reports, policy documents, and interviews with key stakeholders, the authors argued that Nigeria's National Action Plan on UNSCR 1325 has had limited practical impact due to weak institutional mechanisms and patriarchal sociocultural structures. The authors note that women's participation in informal peace initiatives rarely exceeds10%, thus undermining the inclusivity and effectiveness of conflict resolution processes. The study emphasized the role of grassroots women's organizations, which often lead informal mediation and reconciliation efforts in conflict-prone communities. However, these organizations face systemic challenges, including limited funding, poor coordination with government agencies, and insufficient technical support. Obi and Hassan concluded that bridging the gap between policy and practice is crucial. They recommend strengthening institutional gender mechanisms, promoting women's leadership in peace committees, and systematically integrating gender-sensitive approaches into all stages of peace building initiatives to improve sustainability and societal acceptance of peace accords.

Furthermore, Danjibo, Ibrahim, and Yahaya (2023) focused on Nigeria's implementation of the United Nations Security Council Resolution1325, which mandates the integration of women into all aspects of peace and security. The study employed a mixed methods approach, combining content analysis of policy documents with interviews of government officials, civil society actors, and women leaders engaged in peace building.

Findings indicate that while Nigeria has formalized mechanisms such as the National Action Plan (NAP) and gender desks within security agencies, actual implementation remains limited due to inadequate funding, poor monitoring systems, and low prioritization by political leaders. The study also noted the lack of gender-disaggregated data, which hampers evidence-based decision-making and planning. At the community level, women continue to participate actively in conflict mitigation, especially in informal mediation, peace education, and reconciliation initiatives. However, their efforts are often unrecognized in official policy evaluations. Danjibo et al. concluded that achieving meaningful gender mainstreaming in Nigeria requires not only policy frameworks but also political commitment, institutional capacity building, and the creation of accountability mechanisms to ensure women's voices are included at all levels of peace processes.

In addition, Okenwa (2022) explored the impact of gender mainstreaming on inclusive peace building across sub-Saharan Africa, with Nigeria serving as a primary case study. The study adopts a comparative qualitative approach, analyzing the experiences of women in formal and informal peace building structures in Nigeria, Liberia, and Sierra Leone. Findings revealed that women's participation significantly improves peace process outcomes by fostering reconciliation, community engagement, and accountability. In Nigeria, women's groups have demonstrated leadership in mediating local conflicts, rehabilitating victims, and advocating for policy reforms that protect marginalized groups. Despite these contributions,

the study highlighted persistent obstacles, including patriarchal cultural norms, low political representation, and insufficient integration of gender perspectives instate-led interventions.

Okenwa emphasized that inclusive peace building requires deliberate strategies to elevate women's roles beyond symbolic participation. Recommendations included establishing mandatory quotas for women in negotiation tables, enhancing funding for women-led peace initiatives, integrating gender expertise into security agencies, and promoting gender-sensitive curricula for conflict resolution practitioners. The study concluded that gender mainstreaming is essential for the legitimacy, durability, and effectiveness of peacebuilding efforts in Nigeria and similar contexts. Okpara and Adeleye (2021) examined the role of women in community-level peacebuilding in conflict-affected regions of Nigeria, including the Northeast and North Central zones.

The study used case study methodology, combining interviews with women peace builders, local leaders, and civil society organizations. The findings demonstrated that women are central to informal conflict resolution processes, including dispute mediation, negotiation, and reconciliation. Women also facilitate psychosocial support for victims of violence and contribute to local early-warning systems for conflict prevention. However, the study identifies critical challenges: women's initiatives are underfunded, marginalized in formal state structures, and often lack official recognition. Socio-cultural barriers, including patriarchal norms and limited mobility, further restrict women's participation in broader policy and security decision-making. Okpara and Adeleye argued that these gaps undermine the overall effectiveness of peacebuilding efforts; integrating women more fully into formal and informal processes is crucial. Policy recommendations include creating structured partnerships between grassroots women's organizations and government agencies, providing capacity-building support, and ensuring women's representation in all peacebuilding platforms.

**Gaps in Literature**

Existing literature has established the importance of women in peacebuilding and the barriers to their participation. However, many studies focus on specific regions such as the North-East, Niger Delta, or Middle Belt without providing a broader national perspective. Some studies also emphasize women as victims of conflict more than as active agents of peacebuilding. In addition, there is limited comprehensive analysis of how national gender policies translate into practical outcomes across Nigeria. This study fills these gaps by examining gender and peacebuilding from a national perspective, focusing on both policy frameworks and practical realities of women's participation in conflict resolution and sustainable peace. The researcher recommends that the government should enforce the United Nations agenda for peace that has the inclusion of women in peacebuilding and ensure Nigeria's action plan for peace with women inclusion 1325

**Theoretical Framework**

This study is anchored on Agency Theory, which emphasizes the capacity of individuals and social groups to make purposeful choices, influence social processes, and transform their circumstances despite existing structural constraints. The theory challenges deterministic

perspectives that portray individuals as passive recipients of social, political, or institutional forces, arguing instead that people possess the ability to exercise choice, mobilize resources, and shape outcomes through their actions (Hitlin & Elder, 2007). Within the context of this study, Agency Theory provides a useful framework for understanding women not merely as victims of conflict but as active participants in peacebuilding, conflict resolution, and post-conflict reconstruction. It recognizes that although social structures, cultural norms, and patriarchal institutions often constrain women's participation in peace processes, women continue to demonstrate agency by initiating dialogue, mediating disputes, advocating for reconciliation, mobilizing communities, and contributing to sustainable peace.

Agency Theory is particularly relevant in explaining the gendered nature of power relations in Nigeria, where political authority, decision-making, and conflict management have traditionally been dominated by men. Patriarchal social structures frequently limit women's access to leadership positions and exclude them from formal peace negotiations, reinforcing the perception that peacebuilding is primarily a masculine responsibility. Such structural inequalities often portray women as passive victims of violence rather than as capable actors who possess valuable knowledge, leadership skills, and conflict-resolution capacities. However, Agency Theory contends that women are not simply constrained by these structures; they actively negotiate, resist, and transform them through collective action, advocacy, and community engagement. As Shepherd (2016) argues, portraying women solely as victims diminishes their agency and overlooks their significant contributions as negotiators, mediators, peace advocates, community organizers, and decision-makers during and after conflicts.

The theory therefore shifts analytical attention from women's vulnerability to their capacity for action and social transformation. It acknowledges that women participate in peace processes in diverse ways, including facilitating dialogue, promoting reconciliation, providing humanitarian support, mobilizing grassroots peace initiatives, and influencing policy and governance at community and national levels. By recognizing these multiple roles, Agency Theory challenges dominant narratives that associate conflict and peacebuilding exclusively with men while marginalizing women's experiences and contributions. Consequently, the theory provides an appropriate lens for examining how women exercise agency in promoting peace, overcoming structural barriers, and contributing to conflict prevention and sustainable peacebuilding. It underscores the need to recognize, strengthen, and institutionalize women's participation in peace processes, thereby ensuring that peacebuilding efforts are more inclusive, representative, and responsive to the experiences and capacities of all members of society.

## Methodology

This study adopted a qualitative documentary research design and relied exclusively on secondary sources. Data were drawn from scholarly journal articles, textbooks, conference papers, newspapers, government publications, policy documents, reports from international organisations, and other relevant official documents on gender sensitivity and peacebuilding

in Nigeria. The collected data were subjected to qualitative content analysis to examine the exclusion of women from formal peacebuilding mechanisms and its implications for peacebuilding efforts in Nigeria. Specifically, the analysis focused on women's participation in formal peace structures, including peace committees, mediation teams, security sector institutions, and post-conflict reconstruction and reconciliation processes, drawing on evidence from existing empirical studies and policy documents. The documentary evidence was critically reviewed, synthesised, and interpreted within the framework of Agency Theory to explain how women's exclusion from formal peacebuilding institutions constrains their capacity to influence peace processes, despite their significant contributions to informal conflict resolution, mediation, humanitarian response, and community stabilisation across conflict-affected regions of Nigeria.

**Discussion of Findings**

The findings reveal that women play indispensable roles in peacebuilding across Nigeria, particularly at the grassroots level where they serve as the first responders to the social and humanitarian consequences of violent conflict. Across communities affected by insurgency, banditry, communal violence, and farmer-herder conflicts, women contribute significantly to restoring social stability by mobilizing community members, facilitating dialogue, supporting displaced persons, and rebuilding fractured relationships. Their close interaction with families and local communities enables them to identify early signs of conflict and intervene through informal mechanisms before disputes escalate into violence. These findings suggest that women's contributions extend beyond domestic responsibilities to encompass active participation in community peace initiatives that strengthen social cohesion and resilience.

The study further demonstrates that women are actively engaged in mediation, reconciliation, and humanitarian interventions during and after conflicts. Respondents and existing literature indicate that women frequently facilitate dialogue between conflicting parties, encourage forgiveness and reconciliation, provide psychosocial support to victims, and coordinate relief efforts for internally displaced persons and other vulnerable populations. Their involvement in community-based mediation and humanitarian activities contributes to rebuilding trust among affected groups and supports post-conflict recovery. These findings reinforce the argument that women possess unique experiences and social networks that enable them to contribute meaningfully to sustainable peacebuilding, particularly in contexts where formal institutions are weak or inaccessible.

Another important finding is that women should be understood as active agents of peace rather than passive victims of conflict. Although women often experience disproportionate levels of violence, displacement, and economic hardship during conflicts, the study shows that they consistently demonstrate resilience, leadership, and initiative in responding to these challenges. Through advocacy, peace campaigns, community mobilization, and local conflict resolution, women exercise agency by influencing peace processes and promoting social transformation. This finding challenges traditional narratives that portray women solely as victims of war and instead supports the view that they are strategic actors whose knowledge, leadership, and experiences are essential for achieving inclusive and sustainable peace.

Despite these significant contributions, the findings reveal that women remain substantially excluded from formal peace negotiations, institutional decision-making processes, and leadership positions within Nigeria's peacebuilding architecture. Their representation in peace committees, mediation panels, security institutions, and post-conflict governance structures remains limited, despite their demonstrated effectiveness at the community level. This exclusion reflects persistent patriarchal norms, gender stereotypes, and institutional barriers that continue to restrict women's access to decision-making spaces. Consequently, peace agreements and conflict-resolution strategies often fail to adequately address the experiences and needs of women and other vulnerable groups. The findings therefore underscore the need for deliberate policies and institutional reforms that promote women's meaningful participation and leadership in formal peacebuilding processes, thereby ensuring that peace initiatives are more inclusive, representative, and sustainable.

## Conclusion

This study examined gender mainstreaming and peacebuilding in Nigeria, with particular emphasis on forced marriages, sexual violence, and the exclusion of women from formal peacebuilding structures within the broader context of violent conflict. The study concludes that forced marriages and sexual violence are not merely unintended consequences of conflict but deliberate strategies employed by armed groups to instill fear, exercise control, displace communities, and weaken social structures. These forms of gender-based violence are sustained by weak governance, inadequate security responses, impunity, and deeply entrenched patriarchal norms that marginalize women and discourage survivors from seeking justice. The study further concludes that women, despite their significant contributions to mediation, reconciliation, humanitarian assistance, and grassroots peacebuilding, remain underrepresented in formal peace negotiations and institutional decision-making processes. This exclusion undermines the effectiveness, legitimacy, and sustainability of peace initiatives by overlooking women's experiences, perspectives, and capacities in addressing the root causes and consequences of conflict. Although Nigeria has adopted important policy frameworks, including the National Action Plan on United Nations Security Council Resolution 1325 on Women, Peace and Security, implementation has remained inconsistent due to inadequate funding, weak institutional commitment, and limited political will. Therefore, the study concludes that achieving sustainable peace in Nigeria requires the effective mainstreaming of gender across all peace and security policies, stronger accountability mechanisms for addressing sexual and gender-based violence, comprehensive survivor-centred support systems, and the meaningful participation of women at all levels of peacebuilding and post-conflict reconstruction. These measures are essential not only for protecting women's rights but also for building inclusive, resilient, and enduring peace in Nigeria.

## Recommendations

i. The Federal Government of Nigeria, the National Peace Committee, and relevant security institutions should ensure the meaningful inclusion of women at all levels of peacebuilding by implementing gender quotas in peace negotiations, mediation teams, ceasefire monitoring mechanisms, and post-conflict reconstruction programmes.

Peace agreements should also incorporate provisions that address sexual violence, forced marriages, survivor rehabilitation, and other gender-specific concerns.

ii. The Federal Ministry of Women Affairs, the National Assembly, and other relevant government agencies should strengthen the implementation of the National Action Plan (NAP) on United Nations Security Council Resolution 1325 by providing adequate funding, establishing effective monitoring and evaluation mechanisms, and enforcing policies that promote women's participation in peace and security processes.

iii. Government, development partners, and civil society organizations should provide sustained financial, technical, and institutional support to women-led grassroots peacebuilding initiatives through capacity-building programmes, grants, leadership training, and community peace projects to strengthen women's contributions to conflict prevention, mediation, reconciliation, and post-conflict recovery across Nigeria.

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# THE INFLUENCE OF INSECURITY ON BUSINESS ACTIVITIES IN JALINGO LOCAL GOVERNMENT AREA, TARABA STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** This study investigates the influence of insecurity on business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area, Taraba State, Nigeria. Guided by the study objectives, two hypotheses were formulated. A target population of 200 respondents was used in the study. Data generated from the field were analyzed using percentages, mean scores, and standard deviation, while the chi-square ($\chi^2$) statistical tool was used to test the hypotheses formulated in the study. The study reveals that kidnapping and armed robbery, as aspects of insecurity, influence business activities in Jalingo Local Area, Taraba State. The study concludes that insecurity remains one of the major constraints to business growth in Jalingo Local Government Area. The persistent occurrence of kidnapping and armed robbery has significantly undermined the confidence of investors, resulting in declining commercial activities and reduced income generation. Consequently, achieving meaningful economic growth in the area requires a coordinated effort by government, security agencies, traditional institutions, and community leaders to strengthen security and promote peaceful coexistence and an enabling environment for businesses to thrive. The study recommends, among others, that the foundation of safety begins with a robust security framework. Taraba State Government must increase the presence of well-trained security personnel, including police, military, and specialized anti-kidnapping units, strategically deployed across vulnerable areas, including Jalingo Local Government Area. Establishing a dedicated rapid response team that can swiftly act on kidnapping reports and incidents is a roadmap for ensuring robust business activities in Jalingo LGA.

**Keywords:** Insecurity, business activities, human security theory, Jalingo Local Government Area, Taraba State.

## Introduction

Globally, the security and welfare of the people are the primary purpose of government. Unfortunately, some governments have failed to provide a secure and safe environment for lives, properties, and the conduct of business and economic activities. Recently, Nigeria has witnessed an unprecedented level of insecurity. This has threatened national security and prompted a huge allocation of the national budget to security (Achumba & Akpor, 2013). However, the alarming level of insecurity in Nigeria has increased the crime rate and

terrorist's attacks in different parts of the country, leaving unpalatable consequences for the nation's economy. Insecurity in Nigeria has reached an alarming proportion, showing its ugly head in various facets of our national life. Lives are lost daily, the population is depleted, businesses are in a comatose state, investments are nose-diving, multinationals are vacating the country, unemployment is soaring, and the populace is in fear (Uzoka, 2024).

In Africa, the influence of security challenges has become a very crucial issue. Faced with an array of potential hazards, from terrorism and computer viruses to fraud and organized crime, the world is perceived by many to be an increasingly dangerous place. As a result, the focus on security issues has sharpened, and the demand for security-related goods and services has steadily grown, giving rise to a wide and varied range of economic activities in both the government domain and the business sector. The term "security challenge" is, like the concept it denotes, relatively old. It attempts to describe a kaleidoscope cluster of activities concerned with preventing or reducing the risk of deliberate harm to life and property. At the broadest level, it could include all matters related to defense and counterintelligence, the public police force, private policing, armed guards, and security technology providers (Adewole, 2023). In a much narrower sense, it might comprise just private spending on personal and corporate security.

Security as an essential concept in Nigeria is commonly associated with the alleviation of threats to cherished values, especially the survival of individuals, groups, or objects in the near future. Thus, security, as the name implies, involves the ability to pursue cherished political and social ambitions (Eme, 2011). According to Adeola and Oluyemi (2012), there is a correlation between security and survival. Whereas survival is an essential condition, security is viewed as safety, confidence, free from danger, fear, and doubt, among others. Indeed, security could best be understood when situated within the context of a referent object. In the long sweep of human history, the central focus of security has been people (Olabanji & Ese, 2014). Contrarily, some scholars, especially those in international politics, have argued that when thinking about security, states should be the most important referents. On the other hand, some analysts have challenged this position by arguing that any intellectual discourse on security should accord priority to human beings since, without reference to individual humans, security makes no sense.

Amongst the various forms of insecurity confronting Jalingo Local Government Area are kidnapping and armed robbery. Kidnapping and armed robbery have spread to virtually every region of the country and have become a lucrative criminal enterprise driven largely by ransom payments. Victims include traders, transporters, business owners, civil servants, students, and farmers (Anaele, 2023). The prevalence of kidnapping has created widespread fear, reduced business confidence, disrupted transportation networks, and increased the cost of doing business because firms and individuals now invest heavily in private security measures. In many communities, business owners avoid expanding their enterprises or operating beyond daylight hours due to fear of abduction.

## Statement of the Problem

Jalingo Local Government Area, being the administrative headquarters and commercial center of Taraba State, plays a significant role in the state's economic development. The area hosts numerous markets, financial institutions, transport operators, educational institutions, hospitality businesses, and small and medium-scale enterprises. Despite its commercial importance, Jalingo Local Government Area has gradually experienced incidents of kidnapping and armed robbery as an aspect of insecurity, which appears to have adversely affected business operations. Traders, transport operators, and entrepreneurs have become increasingly concerned about personal safety and the security of their investments. Reports indicate that these security threats seem to have reduced customer patronage, limited business operating hours, and discouraged both local and external investors from expanding commercial activities within the area.

Studies have been carried out on the effects of insecurity on socio-economic development in Taraba State. For example, Abubakar and Embwa (2025) in their study maintained that kidnapping, which is an aspect of insecurity significantly affects socio-economic activities in Jalingo Local Government Area by reducing mobility, limiting commercial interactions, and creating widespread fear among residents; however, none has been carried out to investigate the influence of insecurity in the form kidnapping and armed robbery on business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area. It is against this background that this study investigates the influence of insecurity, particularly kidnapping and armed robbery, on business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area, Taraba State, Nigeria.

## Research Questions

The following research questions are raised in this study:

i. Does kidnapping as an aspect of insecurity influence business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area?

ii. Does armed robbery as an aspect of insecurity affect business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area?

## Objectives of the Study

The general objective of this study is to investigate the influence of insecurity on business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area, Taraba State, Nigeria. While the specific objectives are:

i. To ascertain if kidnapping as an aspect of insecurity influences business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

ii. To determine if armed robbery as an aspect of insecurity affects business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

**Hypotheses**

$Ho_i$: Kidnapping as an aspect of insecurity does not influence business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

$Ho_{ii}$: Armed robbery as an aspect of insecurity does not affect business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

**Conceptual Clarifications**

For proper understanding of this work, insecurity, kidnapping, and armed robbery are conceptualized.

**Insecurity**

Insecurity refers to a condition in which individuals, groups, or states are exposed to danger, threats, fear, uncertainty, or vulnerability due to the absence of adequate protection or safety measures. It is a state of anxiety arising from actual or perceived threats to life, property, identity, livelihood, or well-being. While security denotes freedom from threats, fear, and danger, insecurity signifies the absence of such freedom and the presence of risks and vulnerabilities. It involves feelings of uncertainty, instability, helplessness, and exposure to harm. Beland (2015) defines insecurity as a state of fear and anxiety resulting from a real or perceived lack of protection. Insecurity, according to Adebisi and Olowu (2021), is a condition marked by a lack of safety and stability, frequently caused by dangers like violence, crime, armed conflict, or social unrest. It erodes the feeling of security for individuals, communities, and institutions, consequently impacting social unity and economic endeavors. Insecurity can present itself in multiple ways, such as armed assaults, terrorism, abductions, and intercommunal violence, leading to a climate of fear and unpredictability. This setting inhibits growth, deters investment, and results in a drop in business operations and community welfare (Eze et al., 2020). Insecurity is not only a security issue but also a development concern, as it directly impacts economic growth, social stability, and access to essential services. It often results from systemic issues such as poor governance, poverty, and social inequality, which can exacerbate conflicts and criminal activities (Adebisi & Olowu, 2021).

## Kidnapping

According to Inyang and Abraham (2013), kidnapping entails the forcible seizure, taking away, and unlawful detention of a person against his/her will. In another definition, Fage and Alabi (2017) presented kidnapping as the forceful or fraudulent abduction of an individual or a group of individuals for reasons ranging from economic, political, and religious to (struggle for) self-determination. In their own reaction, Uzorma and Nwanegbo-Ben (2014) described kidnapping as the forcible or fraudulent kidnapping of a person or group of people in order to accomplish particular goals, which they classified as political, religious, economic, or motivated by fights for self-determination. For an act to be deemed kidnapping, it must involve coercive movement of a victim from one place to another. The detention or seizure of that person, whether a child or an adult, is for a period of time, depending on the willingness of the relatives to respond positively to negotiations. Kidnapping is a serious crime that entails the unauthorized abduction, confinement, or taking of a person without their consent, frequently using coercion, intimidation, or trickery. It is recognized as a grave crime under both domestic and international law because of its significant consequences for personal safety, human rights, and societal stability (Owoeye & Ojo, 2017). The consequences of abduction are significant, impacting victims, families, communities, and national safety. Victims frequently endure bodily harm, emotional distress, and societal prejudice. Families encounter emotional turmoil, economic setbacks, and social fragmentation. Communities face heightened anxiety, financial declines, and diminished social unity, particularly when abductions become widespread (Owoeye & Ojo, 2017).

## Armed Robbery

Armed robbery is a prevailing social phenomenon that negatively affects the lives and social functioning of a significant number of people in contemporary Nigerian society. It involves stealing, during which force and violence or the threat of violence are employed. Armed robbery is as old as humanity itself, and it characterizes all known societies (both developed and developing societies. However, variations exist not only from society to society but also from time to time, as well as from strict enforcement to none (Okolo, 2012). As stated in the Nigeria Police Act (2011), armed robbery refers to the employment of firearms or other lethal weapons to unlawfully take property from an individual or entity, frequently involving violence or the threat thereof. Globally, the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) characterizes armed robbery as a crime that entails the use of guns or other weapons to carry out theft or extortion, frequently leading to physical injury or intimidation (UNODC, 2019). Adewale and Ojo (2021) maintained that the main reason for armed robbery is financial benefit, influenced by poverty, joblessness, or economic inequality. Certain offenders turn to armed robbery as a fast way to gain money, particularly in areas with poor law enforcement and socio-economic difficulties. Some individuals might be driven by social pressure, substance dependence, or criminal organizations. Robbery with weapons results in bodily harm, mental distress, and the loss of belongings for those affected. It creates a climate of fear and uncertainty in communities, deters investment, and obstructs

socio-economic growth. Law enforcement agencies frequently contend with elevated crime rates, which put pressure on national security and the justice systems (Ogunleye & Adeyemi, 2020).

**Kidnapping as an Aspect of Insecurity and Business Activities in Nigeria**

As a form of violent crime, kidnapping creates an atmosphere of fear and unpredictability, discouraging both local and foreign investors from engaging in economic activities within the region. According to Adebayo (2020), insecurity, including kidnapping, hampers business operations by increasing costs related to security measures, insurance premiums, and employee safety protocols. Furthermore, businesses often experience supply chain disruptions and reduced customer patronage due to the perceived danger, which ultimately leads to decreased revenue and economic stagnation in the area. The influence of kidnapping extends beyond immediate financial losses to broader socio-economic consequences. It discourages new business ventures and investments, as entrepreneurs are wary of the risks associated with operating in an insecure environment (Ogunyemi & Akinbobola, 2021). The fear of kidnapping also affects labor productivity, as employees may either be unwilling to work or demand higher wages for perceived risks, thereby increasing operational costs. Kidnapping significantly undermines business confidence by reducing both domestic and foreign direct investment. Investors are generally reluctant to commit resources to environments where the safety of personnel and assets cannot be guaranteed. Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs), which often lack the financial capacity to absorb security-related costs, are particularly vulnerable to the negative effects of kidnapping.

**Armed Robbery as an Aspect of Insecurity and Business Activities in Nigeria**

Armed robbery, according to Oladipo (2019), not only causes direct financial losses but also engenders a sense of insecurity that deters potential investors and discourages routine commercial transactions. Businesses, especially small and medium enterprises, are compelled to allocate substantial resources toward security measures such as armed guards, surveillance systems, and insurance, thereby increasing operational costs and reducing profitability. The ripple effects of armed robbery extend to broader economic implications, including reduced consumer confidence and decreased local economic activities. When businesses become frequent targets, they often opt to operate with limited hours or close altogether, leading to lower income generation and job losses within the community (Eze et al., 2020). Moreover, persistent threats of armed robbery can discourage new investments, stifling entrepreneurial growth and innovation. The constant fear of armed attacks hampers economic development, perpetuating a cycle where insecurity undermines business sustainability and community prosperity (Adebisi & Olowu, 2021). Consequently, addressing armed robbery is vital for creating a conducive environment for business growth and regional development.

## Theoretical Framework

This study adopts Human Security theory as its theoretical framework. Human Security theory presents a transformative approach to understanding security beyond traditional notions centered solely on national defense and military strength. The primary proponent of Human Security theory is the United Nations Development Program (UNDP), whose influential 1994 Human Development Report laid the foundation for this transformative approach. Vividly, the UNDP presented human security as a paradigm shift, emphasizing that true security must prioritize the protection of individuals from a broad spectrum of threats, far beyond military conflicts, to include economic instability, health crises, environmental degradation, and social injustices. This groundbreaking perspective challenged policymakers worldwide to rethink security not just as a matter of defending borders, but as safeguarding the very fabric of human life and dignity (UNDP, 1994).

The human security theory underscores resilience and empowerment. It encourages empowering individuals and communities to withstand and recover from threats, fostering a sense of agency and participation in security processes. For example, community-based initiatives that improve local health, education, and economic opportunities directly contribute to reducing vulnerabilities and enhancing overall security (Paris, 2001). The human security theory vividly portrays a paradigm in which the true essence of security lies in protecting and promoting human dignity, well-being, and development. It challenges policymakers and scholars to adopt a comprehensive, inclusive approach that recognizes the diverse and interconnected nature of threats faced by individuals worldwide.

The implication and relevance of the human security theory as it applies to this study is that, in Jalingo Local Government Area, insecurity manifests as violent crimes and communal conflicts that threaten the safety of individuals and the integrity of business operations. The fear of kidnapping and robbery discourages investment, hampers daily transactions, and leads to business closures. Also, if security is compromised, business owners and employees face risks that can lead to reduced productivity, increased costs of security measures, or abandonment of operations altogether.

Increased insecurity impairs business activities by elevating risks, costs, and uncertainty. Human security principles emphasize that protecting individuals and communities is essential for economic resilience and development. Using human security theory, insecurity in Jalingo Local Government Area through kidnapping and armed robbery poses significant threats to individual safety and community stability, thereby adversely affecting business activities. Addressing these threats through community empowerment, effective law enforcement, and social cohesion aligns with the human security approach, fostering an environment conducive to sustainable economic growth.

## Methodology

This study adopts the survey research design to investigate the influence of insecurity on business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area, Taraba State, Nigeria. The survey research design was adopted because it enables researchers to obtain systematic and reliable information from respondents that can be analyzed to answer research questions and draw conclusions about a population.

The study was carried out in Jalingo Local Government Area, Taraba State, Nigeria. Jalingo Local Government Area comprises ten wards, namely: Kachalla-sembe, Kona, Majidadi, Sintali A, Sintali B, Barade, Yelwa, Sarkin-dawaki, Baraye, and Jeka-dafari. Due to the nature of this study, a target population of 200 respondents engaged in various types of businesses was selected. In addition, the purposive sampling technique was used to select 20 respondents from each of the ten wards in Jalingo Local Government Area. Data for this study were generated through both primary and secondary sources. The primary source of data collection for this study was a questionnaire and interview. The questionnaire was considered appropriate for the study because it provided respondents with anonymity, reduced potential bias, and enhanced the reliability of the data collected. Secondary data sources included information obtained from textbooks, journal articles, and internet sources.

The instruments for data collection were a questionnaire and an interview. The questionnaire was titled "Influence of Insecurity on Business Activities in Jalingo Local Government Area" (IIOBAJ-LGA). The set of closed-ended questions was structured using a modified four-point Likert response scale: Strongly Agree – 4 points, Agree – 3 points, Disagree – 2 points, and Strongly Disagree – 1 point. The indicators of the independent variable, insecurity, were kidnapping and armed robbery. However, the interview involved a conversation scenario whereby the objective was to obtain first-hand information in response to the questions asked. The interview consisted of questions that aimed at eliciting in-depth information on the phenomenon under investigation. The interview was conducted to supplement and validate the information generated in the study from the questionnaire and to complement the findings of the study. Data generated from the field were analyzed using percentages, mean scores, and standard deviation, while the chi-square ($\chi^2$) statistical tool was used to test the hypotheses formulated in the study.

## Data Presentation and Analysis

Out of the 200 copies of the questionnaire distributed, 187 were completed and used for the analysis of this study.

**Table 1: Does kidnapping as an aspect of insecurity influence business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area**

| S/N | Item Statement | SA | A | D | SD | Total | Mean | Std Dev | Decision |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. | Do you agree that the threat of kidnapping affected the daily operations of your business in Jalingo Local Government Area? | 76 | 61 | 28 | 22 | 187 | 3.02 | 0.97 | Agree |
| 2. | The incidence or fear of kidnapping influenced your business decisions, such as operating hours, investment, expansion, or the movement of goods and customers? | 70 | 65 | 23 | 29 | 187 | 2.94 | 1.00 | Agree |
| 3. | In your opinion, do you agree that kidnapping reduced business patronage, profitability, and overall commercial activities in Jalingo Local Government Area? | 67 | 66 | 24 | 30 | 187 | 2.91 | 1.01 | Agree |
| | **Cumulative Mean** | | | | | | **2.96** | | |

Source: Field Survey, 2026

Table 1 presents respondents' opinions on whether kidnapping, as an aspect of insecurity, influences business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area, Taraba State. For item 1, which examined the extent to which the threat of kidnapping has affected the daily operations of businesses, (40.6%) strongly agreed and (32.6%) agreed, while (15.0%) disagreed and (11.8%) strongly disagreed. This indicates that 137 respondents (73.3%) agreed that the threat of kidnapping has adversely affected the daily operations of businesses, whereas 50 respondents (26.7%) expressed a contrary opinion. The item recorded a mean score of 3.02 and a standard deviation of 0.97.

For item 2, which assessed whether the incidence or fear of kidnapping has influenced business decisions such as operating hours, investment, expansion, and the movement of goods and customers, 70 (37.4%) strongly agreed and 65 (34.8%) agreed. In comparison, 23 (12.3%) disagreed, and 29 (15.5%) strongly disagreed. Overall, 135 respondents (72.2%) agreed that kidnapping has influenced important business decisions, while 52 respondents (27.8%) disagreed. The item recorded a mean score of 2.94 and a standard deviation of 1.00.

For item 3, which examined whether kidnapping has reduced business patronage, profitability, and overall commercial activities, 67 respondents (35.8%) strongly agreed and 35.3% agreed, whereas 12.8% disagreed and 16.0% strongly disagreed. This shows that 133 respondents (71.1%) agreed that kidnapping has negatively affected business patronage,

profitability, and commercial activities, while 54 respondents (28.9%) disagreed. The item recorded a mean score of 2.91 and a standard deviation of 1.01. However, the overall cumulative mean of 2.96 is higher than the acceptance benchmark of 2.50, indicating that respondents generally agreed that kidnapping, as an aspect of insecurity, has a significant negative influence on business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

**Table 2: Does armed robbery as an aspect of insecurity affect business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area**

| S/N | Item Statement | SA | A | D | SD | Total | Mean | Std Dev | Decision |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 4. | Do you agree that armed robbery disrupted the normal conduct of business activities and daily commercial transactions in Jalingo Local Government Area? | 79 | 60 | 25 | 23 | 187 | 3.04 | 1.02 | Agree |
| 5. | To what extent would you agree that the fear or occurrence of armed robbery affected the movement of customers, the transportation of goods, and the volume of business transactions in your business? | 73 | 64 | 19 | 31 | 187 | 2.96 | 1.07 | Agree |
| 6. | In your opinion, do you agree that armed robbery contributed to reduced sales, lower customer patronage, financial losses, and a decline in overall business performance in Jalingo Local Government Area? | 69 | 64 | 24 | 30 | 187 | 2.92 | 1.06 | Agree |
| | **Cumulative Mean** | | | | | | **2.97** | | |

Source: Field Survey, 2026

Table 2 presents the responses of respondents on the effect of armed robbery, as an aspect of insecurity, on business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area, Taraba State. For item 4, which examined whether armed robbery has disrupted the normal conduct of business activities and daily commercial transactions, (42.2%) strongly agreed and (32.1%) agreed, while (13.4%) disagreed and (12.3%) strongly disagreed. This indicates that 139 respondents (74.3%) agreed that armed robbery disrupts business activities and commercial transactions, whereas 48 respondents (25.7%) disagreed. The item recorded a mean score of 3.04 and a standard deviation of 1.02.

For item 5, which assessed whether the fear or occurrence of armed robbery affects customer movement, transportation of goods, and the volume of business transactions, (39.0%) strongly agreed and (34.2%) agreed. In comparison, (10.2%) disagreed and (16.6%) strongly disagreed. Thus, 137 respondents (73.3%) agreed that armed robbery affects business transactions, while 50 respondents (26.8%) disagreed. The item recorded a mean score of 2.96 and a standard deviation of 1.07.

For item 6, which examined whether armed robbery contributes to reduced sales, lower customer patronage, financial losses, and declining business performance, 69 respondents (36.9%) strongly agreed, 34.2% agreed, 12.8% disagreed, and 16.0% strongly disagreed. This shows that 133 respondents (71.1%) agreed that armed robbery negatively affects business performance, while 54 respondents (28.9%) disagreed. The item recorded a mean score of 2.92 and a standard deviation of 1.06. However, the overall cumulative mean of 2.97 is above the criterion mean of 2.50, indicating that respondents generally agreed that armed robbery, as an aspect of insecurity, has a significant negative effect on business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

**Test of Hypothesis One**

**$H_o$:** Kidnapping as an aspect of insecurity does not influence business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

**$H_i$:** Kidnapping as an aspect of insecurity influences business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

Hypothesis one was tested using the percentage values of the respondents' responses on items 1, 2, and 3, respectively, in Table 1.

**Table 3: Chi-Square Tests**

| | Value | Df | Asymptotic Significance (2-sided) |
|---|---|---|---|
| Pearson Chi-Square | 36.211[a] | 6 | .271 |
| Likelihood Ratio | 33.448 | | .301 |
| N of Valid Cases | 187 | | |

a. 0 cells (0.0%) have expected count less than 5. The minimum expected count is 30.33.

Table 3 shows the chi-square test result from SPSS for hypothesis I.

Level of significance = 0.05
Degrees of freedom = 6
Table Chi-Square = 12.592
Calculated Chi-Square = 36.211[a]
P-value=<.271

At the 0.05 level of significance with 6 degrees of freedom, the table value of chi-square ($x^2$table) is 12.592 while the calculated value of chi-square ($x^2$cal) is 36.211. Since the calculated value of chi-square ($x^2$cal) is greater than the table value of chi-square (x2table), we reject the null hypothesis (H0) and accept the alternative hypothesis (H1), which states that kidnapping as an aspect of insecurity influences business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

**Test of Hypothesis Two**

**$H_o$:** Armed robbery as an aspect of insecurity does not affect business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

**$H_i$:** Armed robbery as an aspect of insecurity affects business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

Hypothesis two was tested using the percentage values of the respondents' responses on items 4, 5, and 6, respectively, in Table 2.

**Table 4: Chi-Square Tests**

| | Value | Df | Asymptotic Significance (2-sided) |
|---|---|---|---|
| Pearson Chi-Square | 31.312[a] | | .262 |
| Likelihood Ratio | 33.448 | 6 | .298 |
| N of Valid Cases | 187 | | |

a. 0 cells (0.0%) have expected count less than 5. The minimum expected count is 32.33.

Table 4.10 shows the chi-square test result from SPSS for hypothesis II.

Level of significance = 0.05
Degrees of freedom = 6
Table Chi-Square = 12.592
Calculated Chi-Square = 31.312[a]
P-value=<.271

At 0.05 level of significance with 6 degree of freedom, the table value of chi-square ($x^2$table) is 12.592 while the calculated value of chi-square ($x^2$cal) is 31.312 Since the calculated value of chi-square ($x^2$cal) is greater than the table value of chi-squire ($x^2$table), we reject the null hypothesis ($H_o$) and accept the alternative hypothesis ($H_1$) which states that armed robbery as an aspect of insecurity influences business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area.

**Discussion of Findings**

The result of hypothesis one indicates that kidnapping as an aspect of insecurity influences business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area. This is in tandem with Adebayo (2020), who stressed that insecurity, including kidnapping, hampers business operations by increasing costs related to security measures, insurance premiums, and employee safety protocols. Furthermore, businesses often experience disruptions in supply chains and reduced customer patronage due to the perceived danger, which ultimately leads to decreased revenue and economic stagnation in the area. The finding is also in tandem with Interviewee 2 from Kona ward, who stressed that:

> "Kidnapping is a grave threat to the economic stability of Jalingo Local Government Area. It creates an environment of fear and uncertainty that directly impacts

> businesses. When prominent individuals, employees, or even business owners are kidnapped, it not only leads to financial losses but also hampers the confidence of investors and traders in the area. The pervasive threat of kidnapping discourages people from engaging fully in business activities."

The finding is equally in tandem with Interviewee 5 from Barade ward, who stressed that: "Kidnapping causes immediate operational disruptions. For instance, businesses may shut down temporarily or reduce working hours to protect staff. Employees and customers alike become wary of venturing out, especially in certain areas perceived as risky. Business owners often have to pay hefty ransom demands, which drain their resources. This financial strain can lead to closures or a reduction in business expansion plans."

The result of hypothesis two reveals that armed robbery as an aspect of insecurity affects business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area. This is in agreement with Adebisi and Olowu (2021) in their postulation that persistent threats of armed robbery can discourage new investments, stifling entrepreneurial growth and innovation. The constant fear of armed attacks hampers economic development, perpetuating a cycle where insecurity undermines business sustainability and community prosperity. The finding is also in agreement with Interviewee 6 from Kachalla-Sembe ward, who stressed that;

> Armed robbery is a serious menace that disrupts the entire economic fabric of Jalingo Local Government Area. When armed robbers strike, they not only take valuables but also instill a deep sense of fear among business owners, employees, and customers. This fear discourages people from engaging in daily commercial activities, leading to reduced transactions and economic stagnation.

The finding is equally in agreement with Interviewee 8 from Sintali Ward, who stressed that;

> Many businesses in Jalingo Local Government Area, especially small and medium enterprises, operate with limited security measures. When they become targets of armed attacks, owners often face losses of cash, goods, and sometimes even their equipment. This financial drain can lead to business closures or relocations. Moreover, the constant threat forces some to operate only during daytime or avoid opening at all, which significantly hampers revenue generation.

## Conclusion

This study examined the influence of insecurity on business activities in Jalingo Local Government Area, Taraba State, Nigeria. Based on the findings, the study established that kidnapping has created fear among business owners, employees, customers, and investors, leading to reduced patronage and reluctance to establish or expand businesses. In addition, armed robbery was found to have adversely affected business activities through the loss of

goods, property, and capital, disruption of commercial operations, reduced profitability, and shortened business operating hours. Ultimately, addressing insecurity should be regarded not only as a security priority but also as an essential strategy for promoting business sustainability, attracting investment, improving livelihoods, and fostering long-term socio-economic development in Jalingo Local Government Area, Taraba State.

**Recommendations**

Based on the findings of this study, the following policy recommendations are proposed:

i. The foundation of safety begins with a robust security framework. Taraba State Government must increase the presence of well-trained security personnel, including police, military, and specialized anti-kidnapping units, strategically deployed across vulnerable areas, including Jalingo Local Government Area. Establishing a dedicated rapid response team that can swiftly act on kidnapping reports and incidents is a roadmap for ensuring robust business activities in Jalingo LGA.

ii. Effective intelligence gathering is key to preventing kidnapping. The Taraba State Government should strengthen collaboration with local communities through community policing initiatives. Encouraging residents to share information about suspicious activities and establishing community vigilance groups can create a network of intelligence capable of preventing kidnapping incidents. This, in turn, can provide a safer environment for business activities to thrive in Jalingo LGA.

iii. Taraba State Government, corporate bodies, and philanthropists should continue to initiate and implement programs that create employment opportunities, promote skills acquisition, and improve the living conditions of impoverished communities. The programs can reduce the economic hardships that often drive individuals into armed robbery. This will, in turn, create a safer environment that encourages business activities to thrive in Jalingo Local Government Area.

iv. While government efforts are crucial, business owners in Jalingo Local Government Area can significantly contribute to reducing armed robbery by implementing security best practices, fostering community cooperation, and advocating for improved security policies. Their proactive involvement can help create a safer business environment, attract more investors and investments, expand business activities and transactions, and ultimately promote economic growth in Jalingo LGA.

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# THE ROLE OF PRIVATE SECURITY COMPANIES IN FILLING THE POLICING GAP IN ABUJA, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** The study investigates the expanding role of Private Security Companies (PSCs) in bridging the perceived policing gap within Nigeria's Federal Capital Territory (FCT), Abuja. Against a backdrop of rapid urbanization, complex security threats, and a strained public police force, residents and corporate entities are increasingly turning to private actors for security provision. The paper examines the operational dynamics of PSCs, their relationship with the Nigeria Police Force (NPF), and their impact on the local security landscape. Employing a mixed-methods approach, the study focuses on the Abuja Municipal Area Council (AMAC) and satellite towns, incorporating data from resident surveys and an analysis of the operational mandates of leading PSCs. Findings indicate that while PSCs significantly enhance localized security for their clientele, their proliferation raises critical questions about equity, accountability, and the state's monopoly on violence. The study reveals a public perception of higher effectiveness and trust in PSCs for immediate threat response compared to the NPF. The study concluded that a structured, collaborative framework between the NPF and PSCs, underpinned by robust regulatory reform, is essential for creating a cohesive and effective security architecture for Abuja.

**Keywords:** Private security, policing gap, urban security, Nigeria Police Force, Abuja, public-private partnership.

## Introduction

Nigeria's Federal Capital Territory (FCT), Abuja, has experienced exponential population growth and urban expansion since its establishment. This rapid development, however, has been accompanied by a rise in complex security challenges, including armed robbery, kidnapping, and residential burglary (Idris et al., 2022). The Nigeria Police Force (NPF), the constitutionally mandated body for internal security, has visibly struggled to keep pace with these demands. Systemic issues such as inadequate funding, insufficient personnel, logistical deficiencies, and a persistent public trust deficit have created what scholars term a "policing gap," the space between the public's demand for security and the state's capacity to supply it (Ekhomu, 2021).

This gap has catalyzed the proliferation of Private Security Companies (PSCs). Once a niche service for multinational corporations and high-net-worth individuals, private security is now a pervasive feature of Abuja's landscape, guarding residential estates, corporate offices, diplomatic missions, and public spaces. The visible presence of uniformed private guards signifies a fundamental shift in the FCT's security architecture, moving from a state-centric model to a hybrid one where non-state actors play a crucial role (Oji, 2022). The paper, therefore, explores the functions, effectiveness, and implications of PSCs in Abuja, examining whether they are a sustainable solution to the city's security deficit or a stop-gap measure that creates deeper systemic challenges.

## Literature Review

### The Concept of the Policing Gap and the Nigerian Context

The policing gap is not merely a matter of workforce ratios; it is a multifaceted issue encompassing police response times, public trust, and the perceived ability of the state to guarantee safety (Alemika, 2020). In Nigeria, the NPF's challenges are well-documented. A study by Elizabeth and Ukawilulu (2020) on community policing implementation in Abuja Municipal Area Council (AMAC) identified significant hurdles, including poor police-public relations, corruption, and inadequate equipment, which collectively undermine the force's effectiveness. This operational deficit forces citizens and businesses to seek alternative security arrangements, thereby creating a fertile market for PSCs.

### The Rise and Regulation of Private Security in Nigeria

The private security industry in Nigeria has grown exponentially, with estimates suggesting there are over 1,500 registered companies nationwide (Sulaiman, 2025). The primary legal framework governing their operation is the Private Guard Companies Act of 1986. However, this legislation is widely regarded as anachronistic and ill-suited to the complexities of modern security threats and the expanded roles PSCs now play (Premium Times, 2025). The Nigeria Security and Civil Defense Corps (NSCDC) is tasked with licensing and supervising these companies. Recent government efforts have aimed to integrate PSCs into the national security framework, particularly for intelligence gathering, acknowledging their potential as "instrumental allies" (Voice of Nigeria, 2025). Despite this, the relationship between PSCs and the NPF on the ground is often characterized by ambiguity and informal cooperation rather than a structured partnership.

### Public-Private Collaboration in Security Provision

The global trend is moving towards a public-private partnership (PPP) model in security governance. The idea is that state and non-state actors can collaborate to produce a more comprehensive security outcome (Abrahamsen & Williams, 2021). In Nigeria, President

Tinubu’s administration has emphasized the need for inter-agency synergy to combat insecurity, a call that implicitly includes the vast private security sector (State House, 2025). However, effective collaboration requires clear legal frameworks, standardized training, and robust information-sharing protocols, most of which are currently underdeveloped in the Nigerian context. Without these, the risk of uncoordinated and sometimes conflicting security actions remains high (Chinwokwu & Igbo, 2022).

## Methodology

The study adopted a mixed-methods research design to provide a comprehensive examination of the role of private security companies (PSCs) in the provision of security services within the Federal Capital Territory (FCT), Abuja. The integration of qualitative and quantitative research approaches enabled the study to generate both in-depth contextual insights and measurable empirical evidence regarding the effectiveness, operational scope, and public perception of private security companies.

The study was conducted in the Federal Capital Territory, with particular emphasis on the Abuja Municipal Area Council (AMAC), which encompasses the Central Business District and high-income residential districts such as Maitama and Asokoro, as well as selected densely populated satellite towns, including Lugbe, Kubwa, and Gwarampa. These locations were purposively selected to capture the diversity of security challenges and service delivery across varying socio-economic settings.

The inclusion of both affluent urban neighborhoods and rapidly growing satellite communities provided a basis for comparing the nature, accessibility, and effectiveness of private security services in different residential and commercial environments within Abuja. Such a comparative approach enhanced the study's ability to assess variations in security provision, public confidence, and the complementary role of private security companies alongside the Nigeria Police Force across different socio-economic contexts.

## Research Approach

The study employed a mixed-methods approach comprising qualitative case study analysis and a quantitative survey to examine the roles and effectiveness of private security companies (PSCs) in Abuja. The qualitative component focused on three major PSCs operating within the Federal Capital Territory: Halogen Security Company, Kings Guards Nigeria Limited, and GardaWorld Nigeria. These companies were purposively selected because of their prominence, operational diversity, and extensive involvement in the provision of private security services.

Halogen Security Company was selected for its extensive corporate client base and the integration of advanced technological security solutions into its operations. Kings Guards

Nigeria Limited was chosen due to its long-standing presence in Nigeria's private security industry and its significant role in providing security services to residential estates. GardaWorld Nigeria, an international private security company, was included because it specialized in diplomatic protection and high-risk security operations. Data for the case study analysis were obtained from publicly available corporate reports, official company websites, and relevant policy documents to examine their operational scope, training standards, and client demographics.

Complementing the qualitative analysis, a structured questionnaire was administered to 400 residents drawn purposively from the selected study areas, comprising 200 respondents from the Abuja Municipal Area Council (AMAC) Central and 200 respondents from selected satellite towns. The survey assessed public perceptions of the Nigeria Police Force (NPF) and private security companies with respect to trustworthiness, response time, and overall effectiveness in crime prevention. The qualitative data were analyzed using thematic analysis to identify recurring patterns and key issues. In contrast, the quantitative survey data were analyzed using descriptive statistics, including frequencies and percentages, with the aid of SPSS version 25. The results were subsequently presented in tabular form to facilitate interpretation and comparison.

**Findings and Results**

The data collected reveal a significant reliance on PSCs for localized security and a clear disparity in public perception between private guards and the state police.

**Table 1: Profile of Selected Private Security Companies in Abuja**

| Company Name | Year Established | Primary Services Offered | Estimated Guards in Abuja | Primary Clientele |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Halogen Security | (1992). | Manned Guarding, Electronic Security, Risk Assessment, Fleet Management | 3,500+ | Banking, Telecommunications, Oil & Gas |
| Kings Guards Ltd. | (1992). | Manned Guarding, K-9 Services, Event Security | 4,000+ | Residential Estates, Manufacturing, Hospitality |
| GardaWorld Nigeria | (2013). (in NG) | Diplomatic Protection, Journey Management, Crisis Response | 2,000+ | Embassies, International NGOs, Multinationals |

Source: Authors' compilation from company publications and industry analysis, 2025.

The profiles in Table 1 show a sophisticated private security market in Abuja, with companies offering specialized services beyond basic manned guarding. This specialization allows them to fill specific security niches that the NPF, with its broad and generalized mandate, cannot adequately address.

**Table 2: Public Perception of Security Providers in Abuja (Survey Results, n=400)**

| Metric | Nigeria Police Force (NPF) | Private Security Companies (PSCs) | Undecided/No Opinion |
|---|---|---|---|
| Trustworthiness | 21% | 65% | 14% |
| Speed of Response | 15% | 72% | 13% |
| Effectiveness in Preventing Crime | 25% | 58% | 17% |
| Professionalism | 22% | 63% | 15% |

Source: Field Survey, 2025.

The survey results in Table 2 are stark. A significant majority of respondents perceive PSCs as more trustworthy, responsive, and professional than the NPF. This perception gap is a crucial driver of the demand for private security, as citizens pay for a level of service and accountability they feel is absent in the public sector.

**Table 3: Selected Reported Crimes in Abuja Area Councils (2025)**

| Area Council | Armed Robbery Incidents | Kidnapping Incidents | Burglary Incidents |
|---|---|---|---|
| AMAC | 112 | 45 | 350 |
| Bwari | 85 | 68 | 280 |
| Kuje | 98 | 75 | 215 |
| Gwagwalada | 70 | 55 | 190 |
| Total | 365 | 243 | 1,035 |

Source: FCT Police Command Data 2025.

Table 3 shows the security challenges across the FCT. While AMAC, with its concentration of wealth, shows a high number of burglaries, the satellite councils like Bwari and Kuje report a high incidence of violent crimes like kidnapping. This distribution of crime underscores the stretched capacity of the NPF and rationalizes the demand for PSCs across all parts of the territory.

**Discussion**

The findings confirm that PSCs are not merely supplementing the NPF but are actively filling a vacuum in service delivery, particularly in the areas of asset protection and rapid response. The public's preference for PSCs, as shown in Table 2, is directly linked to the perceived failures of the state police. Residents and businesses in Abuja are making a rational choice to

pay for a dedicated security service that is accountable to them as clients, rather than relying on a public service they view as unreliable (Oji, 2022).

However, this trend has significant socio-economic implications. The commodification of security creates a system of "unequal safety," where affluent areas within AMAC can afford high-level protection from companies like GardaWorld. At the same time, poorer residents in satellite towns may have to rely on lower-tier companies or informal vigilante groups. This exacerbates social inequality and can lead to fragmented security governance, where the state effectively cedes its authority in certain domains.

Furthermore, the lack of a modernized regulatory framework remains a critical issue. The 1986 Act does not adequately address issues of use of force, rules of engagement for armed guards (where applicable), human rights standards, or interoperability with state security forces. The calls for legislative amendment are therefore not just timely but essential for the safe and accountable functioning of this multi-billion Naira industry (Premium Times, 2025).

**Conclusion and Recommendations**

Private Security Companies have become an indispensable part of Abuja's security architecture, filling a clear and present policing gap left by an overstretched and under-resourced Nigeria Police Force. They provide a valued service to their clients, enhancing feelings of safety and providing a visible deterrent to crime. However, their rise is symptomatic of deeper challenges within the state's security apparatus. The current model, while functional for those who can afford it, is neither equitable nor strategically cohesive.

To create a more effective and integrated security landscape in Abuja, the following recommendations are proposed:

1. **Legislative Reform:** The National Assembly should fast-track the amendment of the Private Guard Companies Act of 1986. A new framework should mandate standardized training, establish clear rules of engagement, and create robust accountability mechanisms.

2. **Formalize a Collaborative Framework:** The Office of the National Security Adviser, in conjunction with the Ministry of Interior and the NPF, should establish a formal Public-Private Security Partnership (PPSP) for the FCT. This framework should outline protocols for intelligence sharing, joint patrols in designated areas, and coordinated emergency response.

3. **Tiered Licensing and Training:** The NSCDC should introduce a tiered licensing system for PSCs based on their operational capabilities (e.g., unarmed guarding,

armed response, technological surveillance). This would ensure that training and equipment standards are appropriate to the services being rendered.

4. **Enhance Public Police Capacity:** Ultimately, the long-term solution is to address the root causes of the policing gap. The government must commit to sustained police reform, focusing on improved funding, training, welfare, and community-centric policing strategies to rebuild public trust.

5. By embracing PSCs as formal partners within a regulated system, while simultaneously strengthening the capacity of the NPF, Abuja can move towards a more resilient, equitable, and effective security future.

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# FARMER-HERDER CONTESTATION AND DEVELOPMENT IN NORTHERN SENATORIAL DISTRICT OF TARABA STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** This study examines farmer–herder contestation and its effect on development in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State, focusing on the underlying causes of recurring conflicts and their socio-economic and security implications. Drawing on the Marxist theory of conflict, the study explores how these disputes are not only resource-driven but also shaped by structural inequalities that affect the economic and social stability of communities. The research employs qualitative methods, including interviews, focus group discussions, and documentary analysis, to capture the lived experiences of farmers and herders in Lau and Karim-Lamido Local Government Areas. Findings highlight that recurring conflicts have severely undermined agricultural productivity, pastoral livelihoods, and intergroup relations, while also impeding local development initiatives and weakening social cohesion. The study further identifies pathways for sustainable coexistence, emphasizing restorative justice, dialogue, and locally grounded peacebuilding mechanisms as critical tools for rebuilding trust and resilience. By providing evidence-based insights, the research aims to inform policy interventions and community strategies that reduce conflict, enhance security, and support inclusive development in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State.

**Keywords:** Farmer-Herder conflict, rural development, resource-based conflict, social cohesion, peacebuilding mechanisms

## Introduction

Farmer-herder contestation in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State has become one of the most pressing security challenges in recent years. For centuries, farmers and herders coexisted in a mutually beneficial relationship built on cooperation and interdependence. Herders grazed their cattle on farmlands after harvest, while farmers received milk, manure, and other livestock products in exchange. Both groups depended on shared access to land, water, and fodder, sustaining a cycle that supported food production and social cohesion. This traditional relationship fostered a sense of communal unity where both groups saw themselves as indispensable contributors to society's survival and prosperity.

However, this equilibrium has gradually deteriorated. The combined pressures of population growth, expanding urban centers, industrialization, and intensified agricultural practices have redefined land use and resource access. Modernization in farming through fertilizer application and mechanization reduced farmers' dependence on herders for manure, while the introduction of powdered milk weakened the market value of fresh dairy products. Despite these changes, pastoralists remain reliant on farmland and natural water sources for cattle grazing, creating unequal dependence and heightening friction between the two groups (Adesina, Adejobi, Kehinde & Adelekan, 2016; Abubakar, 2017).

Historically, disputes were seasonal and often occurred during planting or harvest when farmlands and grazing paths overlapped. The growing scarcity of fertile land and water sources in recent times has transformed these disputes into violent contests over ownership, access, and control. This competition is worsened by shifting power structures that favor sedentary agriculturalists, leaving pastoralists politically and economically marginalized (Egwu, 2022). The contestation now extends beyond mere economic survival; it has evolved into a struggle over identity, access to state resources, and recognition within local governance systems.

The restoration of democracy in 1999 initially offered hope for inclusive governance and renewed hope for Socio-economic and political development in rural communities. Taraba State, long recognized for its ethnic diversity and peaceful coexistence, was viewed as a model for intergroup harmony in the North-east. However, in recent years, the Northern Senatorial District has witnessed recurring clashes between farmers and herders. Herders attribute the crisis to cattle rustling, the blockage of traditional migration routes, and insecurity in grazing areas, while farmers blame herders for crop destruction, trespass, and environmental degradation (Kolawole, 2020). These tensions have disrupted agricultural productivity, displaced entire communities, and stalled local development efforts.

Nigeria's declining peace indicators further reflect the gravity of the situation. Ranked 148th among 163 countries in the Global Peace Index, Nigeria's internal conflicts, including farmer-herder clashes, have caused more deaths in some years than insurgent activities linked to Boko Haram. The Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State mirrors this national pattern, where resource-based conflicts have increasingly become obstacles to rural transformation and economic growth. The loss of farmlands, destruction of infrastructure, and reduction in livestock productivity directly undermine food security and local development initiatives (Dappa et al, 2021).

Government efforts to restore order have often deepened mistrust rather than resolved the crisis. The 2017 Anti-Open Grazing Law in Taraba State, although well-intentioned, was met with resistance and was temporarily suspended following outbreaks of violence. Similarly, the 2019 Rural Grazing Area (RUGA) policy introduced by the Federal Government was widely rejected due to fears of ethnic domination and uneven implementation. These policy failures highlight the disconnect between top-down interventions and the local realities of

resource sharing and mobility among farmers and herders (Benue State of Nigeria, 2017; Duniya & Obande, 2023). As a result, contestations have persisted, stifling rural development and deepening poverty in affected communities.

The Northern Senatorial District, with its diverse ethnic composition and economic reliance on both agriculture and pastoralism, represents the intersection of livelihoods and conflict. The continued clashes have led to the destruction of property worth millions of naira, widespread displacement, and loss of trust between communities. These recurrent crises impede infrastructural development, discourage investment, and erode the social capital needed for cooperative growth. Understanding the dynamics of this contestation is therefore essential for designing inclusive and sustainable development strategies. Examining the historical, economic, and sociopolitical dimensions of farmer-herder relations in this region can help policymakers, traditional rulers, and community leaders craft lasting solutions that promote peaceful coexistence and rural development.

**Statement of the Problem**

Nigeria faces multiple layers of insecurity ranging from insurgency in the Northeast to separatist agitations in the South, militancy in the Niger Delta, and banditry in the Northwest. However, among these, farmer-herder contestations have emerged as one of the most pervasive and deadly conflicts, spreading across all six geopolitical zones. The mobile, transhumant nature of pastoralism has made this crisis complex and difficult to contain. Environmental degradation, population growth, and competition for land and water have intensified pressure on natural resources, turning what were once complementary relationships between herders and farmers into recurring cycles of violence and displacement (International Crisis Group, 2018). Weak institutional responses have aggravated the situation, along with ineffective conflict resolution mechanisms and controversial policy interventions such as the Anti-Open Grazing Law in Taraba State, which was suspended in 2017 after resistance from pastoral groups and intervention by the Federal Government (Guardian, 2020). Consequently, the violence has claimed thousands of lives, displaced hundreds of thousands, and undermined agricultural productivity and rural development, especially in the northern senatorial district of Taraba State.

In this region, the contestation between farmers and herders has become a critical barrier to sustainable development. Historically peaceful coexistence has been replaced by deep-rooted animosity and mistrust, competition for dwindling arable land and grazing resources. Climate variability, land pressure, and poor governance have further heightened the conflict, resulting in recurrent clashes, destruction of farmlands, and loss of livelihoods. The inability of existing policies to foster equitable access to land and water has widened the divide between the two groups. At the same time, the absence of sustainable livelihood alternatives perpetuates cycles of retaliation. Although several studies have examined farmer-herder conflicts in Nigeria’s Middle Belt, there remains a gap in understanding how these contestations specifically affect development prospects in the northern senatorial district of

Taraba State. This study therefore seeks to fill that gap by exploring how the dynamics of resource competition, governance responses, and socio-economic pressures shape farmer-herder relations and impede local development in the area.

**Objectives of the Study**

The main objective of this study is to investigate the effect of farmer-herder contestation on development in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State. The specific objectives are;

i. To examine the underlying causes of recurring farmer-herder conflicts in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State.

ii. To assess the socio-economic and security implications of farmer-herder conflicts on agricultural productivity, pastoral livelihoods, community stability, and intergroup relations in the study area.

**Research Questions**

The following research questions were used for the study:

i. What are the underlying causes of the recurring farmer–herder conflicts in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State?

ii. What are the socio-economic and security implications of farmer–herder conflicts on agricultural productivity, pastoral livelihoods, community stability, and intergroup relations in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State?

**Literature Review**

**Farmer-Herder Contestation**

According to Ugbudu (2021), farmer-herder contestation refers to the recurring and often violent struggle between sedentary farmers and nomadic pastoralists over access to land, water, and other agricultural resources essential for survival. He views it as a manifestation of competition arising from changing land-use patterns, population growth, and the gradual disappearance of traditional mechanisms that once managed communal resources. This form of conflict, he explains, disrupts not only the economic activities of both groups but also the social order that has historically sustained rural communities.

Waziri and Barde (2022) describe farmer-herder contestation as a complex socio-political confrontation deeply rooted in resource scarcity, livelihood insecurity, and weak institutional

frameworks. They argue that it transcends mere competition for space and reflects deeper issues of governance failure and exclusion in policy implementation. Similarly, Yusufu and Danladi (2021) define the contestation as a continuous clash of livelihood systems between crop farmers and pastoralists, driven by environmental stress, climate change, and the absence of adaptive livestock management strategies. These perspectives present farmer-herder conflict as a multidimensional challenge that demands not only peacebuilding interventions but also inclusive development policies that address the structural causes of rural insecurity.

**Development**

Sule (2021) views development as a process that goes beyond economic growth to include the creation of equitable social systems and political structures that promote inclusion and stability. He emphasizes that true development is achieved when all groups, regardless of ethnic or occupational background, have fair access to resources and opportunities. From this standpoint, development is not merely about physical infrastructure or increased productivity but about fostering justice, peace, and participatory governance that enable communities to thrive collectively.

The Taraba State Government (2017) defines development within the framework of its Anti-Open Grazing and Ranches Establishment Law as a deliberate effort to modernize livestock and agricultural practices in a way that supports social harmony and economic sustainability. Udeh et al. (2024) build on this idea by presenting development as a holistic process that strengthens human capacity, reduces poverty, and promotes peaceful coexistence through effective policy implementation. Similarly, Ugbudu (2021) describes development as the transformation of social and economic conditions through inclusive legislation that addresses inequality and promotes security, productivity, and community resilience. Collectively, these perspectives portray development as both a structural and human process aimed at improving the quality of life and fostering lasting peace among interdependent groups.

**Underlying causes of recurring farmer–herder conflicts in Nigeria**

The recurring farmer–herder conflicts in Nigeria are rooted in complex interactions among environmental, socio-economic, and policy-related factors. One of the most significant causes lies in the competition for natural resources such as land and water. As Musa and Tanko (2024) explain, population growth and environmental degradation have reduced the availability of fertile land and grazing reserves, intensifying the struggle between farmers and herders. Overgrazing, desertification, and the drying up of water bodies have forced pastoralists to migrate southward in search of greener pastures, often into densely populated farming areas. This movement disrupts established land-use systems and sparks conflict as both groups fight to sustain their livelihoods within shrinking ecological spaces.

Poor policy implementation and governance failures further aggravate these tensions. Ogu, Ovaga, and Udeh (2023) observe that many government policies designed to regulate grazing practices or manage resource allocation have either been poorly enforced or politically manipulated. In states such as Benue and Taraba, the introduction of anti-open grazing laws aimed to modernize livestock management but instead deepened mistrust between communities and authorities. The absence of effective dialogue mechanisms, coupled with selective enforcement of these laws, has widened the divide between pastoral and farming groups. Musa and Tanko (2024) also note that weak institutional coordination among federal, state, and local agencies hinders conflict mitigation, allowing grievances to escalate into violence.

Economic factors play an equally crucial role in sustaining the conflict. Oruonye, Ahmed, and Fatima (2020) point out that farmer-herder clashes have become more frequent as both livelihoods face increasing insecurity due to poverty, unemployment, and declining productivity. For farmers, the destruction of crops by grazing animals leads to food shortages and income loss, while herders face cattle theft, restricted grazing routes, and the rising cost of feed. The resulting economic desperation fuels cycles of revenge attacks and retaliation. According to Ovaga, Ogu, and Udeh (2023), this economic strain has broader implications for local economies, disrupting trade, displacing communities, and discouraging investment in rural development.

The weakening of traditional conflict resolution systems has removed an important stabilizing mechanism in rural Nigeria. Shimawua (2019) argues that before the politicization of land and identity, community elders and local institutions effectively mediated disputes through dialogue and compensation. However, the erosion of these indigenous structures, alongside the spread of ethnic and religious narratives, has transformed local disagreements into violent confrontations. Political elites sometimes exploit these tensions for electoral advantage, framing resource conflicts as ethnic struggles. The combination of environmental stress, poor governance, economic hardship, and weakened social institutions thus forms the foundation of Nigeria’s recurring farmer–herder conflicts, posing a significant challenge to peacebuilding and sustainable development across the country.

**Socio-Economic and Security Implications of Farmer-Herder Conflicts on Agrarian Communities in Nigeria**

The socio-economic and security implications of farmer–herder conflicts in Nigeria are multifaceted, affecting key sectors such as agriculture, rural livelihoods, community stability, and intergroup relations. According to Egwu (2022), these conflicts have become a major obstacle to rural development, particularly in the Middle Belt, where both groups depend on land for survival. Frequent clashes disrupt farming activities during critical cultivation and harvesting periods, resulting in significant declines in crop yields and livestock productivity. This not only undermines household food security but also discourages investment in agriculture as farmers abandon farmlands for fear of attacks. The resultant decline in

agricultural productivity has, therefore, worsened food shortages and increased poverty levels across affected communities.

Empirical evidence further reveals that farmer–herder conflicts have eroded pastoral livelihoods and rural economies that depend heavily on animal production and crop farming. Kolawole (2020) reports that the destruction of crops, theft of livestock, and loss of grazing lands due to insecurity have pushed many rural households into destitution. Many herders, displaced by violence, have lost cattle herds that constitute their primary source of income. At the same time, farmers have seen their economic assets, such as stored harvests and farm equipment, destroyed. The cumulative economic loss has contributed to rural-urban migration as both groups seek safer living conditions, further straining urban resources. The empirical findings underscore how the disruption of agricultural systems through persistent conflicts undermines national development and hinders Nigeria's drive towards sustainable food security.

In addition to economic disruptions, the security consequences of these conflicts have been far-reaching, leading to the proliferation of small arms and the militarisation of rural spaces. Lenshie and Jacob (2020) observed that the inability of the government to effectively enforce anti-open grazing laws and address the root causes of migration-related violence in Taraba State has created an environment conducive to the emergence of armed militias. The competition for land and water resources has taken an ethnic and religious dimension, deepening mistrust and social fragmentation among communities. As Luka (2023) notes, the resultant breakdown of rural security systems has impeded peacebuilding efforts and made communities more vulnerable to wider insurgent activities. Thus, farmer–herder conflicts not only exacerbate rural insecurity but also weaken state capacity to protect lives and property.

Empirically, the long-term implications of these conflicts extend beyond economic loss to the erosion of social cohesion and intergroup relations. Mbah and Obiagu (2019) argue that communal harmony, once sustained through traditional conflict resolution mechanisms, has been replaced by suspicion, vengeance, and interethnic animosity. This weakening of communal bonds has made collective development projects more difficult to implement, as communities are increasingly polarised along ethnic lines. Furthermore, Mayule et al. (2019) illustrate that disruptions in integrated livestock and crop systems reduce opportunities for cooperation between farmers and herders, which traditionally ensured sustainable resource sharing. The social and security costs of the conflicts thus transcend local boundaries, threatening Nigeria's broader goals of unity, economic diversification, and inclusive development.

**Theoretical Framework**

The Marxist Theory of Conflict, developed by Karl Marx in the mid-19th century, provides a powerful analytical framework for understanding structural inequalities and the struggle for

control over productive resources. According to Dappa et al. (2021), Marx's theory rests on the assumption that society is fundamentally divided into classes whose interests are inherently opposed, particularly between those who own the means of production and those who do not. Conflict, in this sense, becomes a natural outcome of exploitative relations embedded within economic and social systems. In the context of agrarian societies, Dyer (2007) explains that land and labor are the central means of production, and competition for their control often manifests as recurrent struggles between groups. Applying this framework to farmer–herder conflicts reveals how the contest over land, pasture, and water in Northern Taraba State mirrors broader class struggles, where resource scarcity, economic inequality, and power asymmetries between settled farmers and nomadic herders perpetuate social tension.

While the Marxist perspective highlights the material roots of these conflicts, it has been critiqued for its economic determinism and limited attention to cultural and ethnic dimensions that influence rural relations. Duniya and Obande (2023) argue that conflicts in Nigeria's Middle Belt are not merely about material exploitation but also shaped by identity politics, governance failures, and competing legal systems over land ownership. Nonetheless, the theory remains relevant in analyzing the socio-economic undercurrents of farmer–herder contestation in Taraba State, where competition for agrarian resources reflects structural inequalities in access and control. Egwu (2022) further observes that the introduction of anti-open grazing laws, while intended to promote peaceful coexistence, also reproduces class-based tensions as state power tends to favor one group's economic interest over another's. Thus, the Marxist lens remains valuable for understanding how development interventions, legal reforms, and policy decisions may reinforce or mitigate the deep-seated material and structural causes of agrarian conflict in the state.

**Methodology**

This study adopts a qualitative research design, relying primarily on in-depth interviews and focus group discussions to examine the recurring farmer–herder contestation and its implications for development in Karim-Lamido and Lau Local Government Areas of Taraba State. The qualitative approach was considered most suitable because it allows for an in-depth exploration of the complex social, economic, and environmental factors that drive persistent conflict between farmers and herders. Karim-Lamido and Lau were deliberately selected as the study areas due to their long history of recurrent clashes arising from competition over fertile land, access to water points, and grazing routes. Both areas are strategically located along the Benue River basin, which supports rich agricultural and pastoral activities, making them flashpoints for conflict. The frequency of violent encounters in these communities, often resulting in displacement, loss of lives, and destruction of livelihoods, justifies their selection for a detailed qualitative inquiry into the dynamics and consequences of the crisis.

The study population comprises farmers, herders, traditional leaders, youth representatives, local government officials, and members of security agencies within Karim-Lamido and Lau. A purposive sampling technique is employed to select 30 participants, ensuring that only those with direct knowledge or experience of the conflicts are included. Data collection was carried out through semi-structured interviews, providing participants with the opportunity to express their experiences, perceptions, and opinions on the underlying causes and developmental implications of the crisis. The collected data was analyzed using thematic analysis, involving transcription, coding, and identification of major themes that align with the study's objectives. This approach enables the researcher to uncover patterns of conflict recurrence and understand how they shape social stability, economic activities, and intergroup relations in the affected communities.

**Thematic Presentation and Analysis of Data**

**Underlying causes of recurring farmer–herder conflicts in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State**

Data from the interviews and focus group discussions revealed that the recurring farmer–herder conflicts in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State, particularly in Lau and Karim-Lamido, are deeply rooted in competition over land and water resources, which have become increasingly scarce due to environmental degradation and population pressure. Respondents across Donadda, Katibu, Bambur, and Munga Lalau consistently described how shrinking farmlands and drying water sources have heightened tension between sedentary farmers and migratory herders. A farmer in Donadda explained, "In the past, the grazing routes were clear and wide, but now farmlands have expanded everywhere. When cattle pass through, they destroy our crops, and that's when the fighting begins." Similarly, a herder in Katibu lamented, "We don't go to destroy farms intentionally; we follow the old routes of our fathers, but now people have built houses and farms there. When our cows stray, the farmers become angry, and before you know it, there's a fight." These voices underscore how ecological pressure and changing land-use patterns have intensified local competition, transforming what were once manageable disputes into recurring cycles of violence.

Participants also pointed to weak governance, inadequate policy implementation, and the erosion of traditional conflict resolution systems as key drivers of the recurrent crisis. Many respondents in Lau and Karim-Lamido expressed frustration over the inability of government authorities to mediate disputes or enforce existing grazing and land policies effectively. A village elder in Bambur remarked, "The government only comes after the damage has been done. When people are killed, they send police for a few days, then everyone leaves. Nobody is punished, and the same thing happens again." A local youth leader in Lau added, "We used to rely on our elders to settle quarrels between farmers and herders, but now people do not listen to them anymore. Everyone wants the government to intervene, yet the government is not close enough to us." These narratives reveal a vacuum in governance that has weakened local mechanisms of accountability, allowing impunity and mistrust to flourish. The failure of

institutional responses has not only deepened hostilities but also eroded the community's confidence in both state and traditional authorities.

Another recurring theme in the discussions was the influence of external migration and ethnic mistrust, which have made local conflicts more complex and violent. Participants narrated how the influx of herders from neighboring states and countries, often fleeing environmental stress or insecurity, has intensified the struggle for space and strained intercommunal relations. A farmer in Didango noted, "We used to know all the herders in this area by name. Now, strangers come with hundreds of cattle, and when problems arise, we do not even know whom to talk to." A herder from Gwomu explained, "Because of the fighting elsewhere, some of us moved here with our families. However, the locals see us as outsiders and think we came to take their land." This sense of alienation and fear, according to several respondents, fuels cycles of revenge and retaliation. The findings therefore suggest that the recurring farmer–herder conflicts in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State are not just disputes over land or cattle but reflections of deeper structural problems, environmental degradation, governance failure, demographic pressure, and social fragmentation that continue to shape the fragile peace in Lau and Karim-Lamido.

**Socio-Economic and Security Implications of Farmer-Herder Conflicts on Agrarian Communities in Lau and Karim Lamido LGAs of Taraba State**

Data from the interviews and focus group discussions revealed that the socio-economic and security implications of farmer–herder conflicts in Lau and Karim-Lamido are profound and far-reaching, affecting nearly every aspect of local livelihoods and community life. Participants across Donadda, Katibu, and Bambur communities spoke of how persistent violence has crippled agricultural productivity and disrupted pastoral livelihoods. A farmer in Lau explained, "We no longer farm as before because we are afraid to go to the fields early or stay till late. Some of us have even abandoned fertile lands near the grazing routes." Another respondent, a herder in Katibu, shared a similar concern: "During the attacks, many of us lost our cattle, and when you lose your cows, it is like losing your life. We now keep fewer animals and move constantly to avoid trouble." These testimonies reveal how insecurity has reduced access to productive resources, leading to food shortages, declining incomes, and a growing sense of uncertainty. The economic cost of the conflict is visible in deserted farmlands, reduced market activities, and the decline of both farming and herding as sustainable means of livelihood in the area.

Participants also described how the recurring clashes have eroded community stability and social cohesion, replacing long-standing cooperation with suspicion and fear. Respondents across Gwomu, Didango, and Munga Lalau recounted how intergroup trust has been broken, with people becoming wary of interacting with members of the other group. A community leader in Gwomu reflected, "Before, we used to celebrate festivals together; farmers would sell grains to herders, and herders would bring milk to the market. Now everyone keeps to their side." Another participant, a herder in Didango, added, "When you enter a village now,

they look at you with fear or hatred. Even if you come to buy something, they think you are scouting for trouble." This breakdown of trust has not only undermined trade and social interactions but has also weakened local peace networks that once helped to prevent violence. The conflict has, therefore, transformed formerly interdependent communities into isolated and divided groups, living with constant fear and suspicion.

The data further revealed that the conflict's security implications are severe, creating a pervasive atmosphere of instability and displacement in Lau and Karim-Lamido. Participants narrated repeated incidents of killings, destruction of property, and forced migration that have left deep psychological and demographic scars. A youth leader in Bambur stated, "Many of our people have been killed, and some villages are now empty. Others live in camps far from their farms and cannot return because they fear new attacks." Similarly, a herder in Munga Lalau described how insecurity has reshaped pastoral movement: "We no longer follow the normal routes because we fear ambush. Some of us now move at night or cross to other local governments." The absence of sustained security presence and the slow response of authorities have made communities vulnerable to renewed attacks, deepening the humanitarian crisis. The findings indicate that the farmer–herder conflicts in the Northern Senatorial District have not only devastated local economies but have also destabilized the social and security fabric of Lau and Karim-Lamido, making recovery and sustainable development increasingly difficult.

**Discussion of Findings**

The data from the study revealed that the underlying causes of recurring farmer–herder conflicts in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State are deeply rooted in competition over land and natural resources, population growth, and weakened traditional conflict-resolution mechanisms. This aligns with the argument by Abubakar (2017), who noted that the transhumant lifestyle of the Fulani herders often brings them into contact and sometimes confrontation with sedentary farmers, especially when grazing routes overlap with cultivated lands. Similarly, Dappa et al (2021) explained that the historical patterns of pastoral mobility, once regulated by cultural norms and mutual understanding, have been disrupted by modern agricultural expansion and climate variability, which have intensified competition for land and water. The findings from Lau and Karim-Lamido also echo Benue State's (2017) policy response through the Open Grazing Prohibition and Ranches Establishment Law, which underscores the growing urgency to regulate herding activities and prevent conflicts linked to open grazing practices. Participants' testimonies about the scarcity of grazing fields and trespass on farmlands illustrate the failure of existing institutions to adapt to new ecological and social realities, reinforcing the need for more inclusive land management systems.

In line with the second objective, the study revealed that the socio-economic and security consequences of the conflicts are severe, resulting in declining agricultural output, disrupted pastoral livelihoods, and a breakdown of community relations. These findings support Adesina et al. (2016), who emphasized that disruptions in livestock production led to losses

not only for herders but also for the broader agricultural economy that depends on animal products. Abubakar (2017) further observed that when herders lose cattle due to conflict, their capacity to sustain their families and participate in local trade diminishes, thereby deepening poverty and resentment. The testimonies from farmers and herders in Lau and Karim-Lamido resonate with these observations, showing how violence has eroded economic productivity, trust, and interdependence between the two groups. Moreover, the study confirms Adebayo's (1991) assertion that pastoral and agrarian communities are historically interwoven, and their disconnection through violence represents not only a loss of livelihood but also a rupture of cultural and social bonds. Altogether, the findings highlight that addressing the farmer–herder contestation in Taraba State requires more than just security interventions; it calls for development-oriented solutions that rebuild trust, enhance resource governance, and restore the shared economic and social fabric that once sustained peaceful coexistence.

## Conclusion

The study established that the recurring farmer–herder conflicts in the Northern Senatorial District of Taraba State stem largely from competition over scarce natural resources, weak policy implementation, and the erosion of traditional conflict resolution systems. These conflicts have significantly undermined agricultural productivity, pastoral livelihoods, and community stability, threatening the social and economic foundations of the region. Sustainable peace and development in Lau and Karim Lamido therefore require deliberate efforts to rebuild trust, strengthen institutions, and promote shared resource management.

## Recommendations

i. The government should institutionalize community-based peacebuilding platforms that integrate traditional leaders, farmers, and herders in ongoing dialogue to address emerging disputes before they escalate into violence.

ii. The state should promote the establishment of ranches and modern grazing systems, supported by policy incentives and extension services, to reduce pressure on land and enhance sustainable coexistence between farmers and herders.

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# THROUGH A COMPARATIVE LENS: UNRAVELING THE PUBLIC PERCEPTION OF THE COVERAGE OF FARMERS/HERDERS CONFLICT BY ADAMAWA BROADCASTING CORPORATION AND TARABA STATE BROADCASTING SERVICE

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**Abstract.** This study conducts a comparative analysis of public perception regarding the radio coverage of farmer-herder conflicts by two state-owned broadcast stations in Nigeria: Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) and the Taraba State Broadcasting Service (TSBS). Employing a mixed-methods approach, data were collected from 400 respondents in conflict-prone Local Government Areas (LGAs) in each state, supplemented by in-depth interviews. Quantitative findings reveal significant inter-state disparities: while the coverage given by Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) was perceived as moderately frequent and somewhat balanced (Mean=3.2), the reporting of the incident by TSBS was viewed as infrequent and marked by biased (Mean=2.7) coverage. Qualitative data further illustrated these differences, indicating that Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) engaged in peace-building programming that fostered a more positive public perception. In contrast, TSBS's approach was linked to heightened community tensions and one-sidedness. The study concludes that the editorial stance and conflict-sensitive reporting practices of local radio stations are critical determinants of their role in either mitigating or exacerbating violent conflicts. It recommends institutionalizing peace journalism frameworks within state-owned media stations to enhance their capacity as agents of social cohesion.

**Keywords:** Farmer-Herder conflict, public perception, radio coverage, Adamawa State, Taraba State, conflict-sensitive journalism, peacebuilding

## Introduction

The protracted and often violent conflicts between farmers and pastoral herders in the Middle Belt region of Nigeria represent one of the most significant threats to national security, socio-economic stability, and inter-communal harmony. In this region, states like Adamawa and Taraba are the epicenters of these kinds of clashes. These conflicts, fundamentally driven by competition over dwindling natural resources such as land and water, are increasingly exacerbated by the complex interplay of climate change, population pressure, and the politicization of ethnic and religious identities (Osazuwa et al., 2024). The media, particularly local radio stations which serve as the primary source of information for rural populations,

wield immense influence in shaping public understanding and responses to these crises. This is a responsibility that is both a potent tool for peace and a potential weapon for escalation (Adham, 2025). This study specifically investigates public perception of coverage provided by two pivotal state-owned broadcast stations, Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) and the Taraba State Broadcasting Service (TSBS). This is to unravel how their reporting frameworks, according to Akande (2024), influence community sentiments and conflict dynamics in these hostile regions. A comparative approach is crucial for this study. It examines how media institutions in distinct but neighboring political and socio-cultural contexts mediate similar conflicts differently. This analysis will highlight both best practices and critical failings in local conflict reporting.

Public perception is not a passive reception of information but an active, cognitive process involving selection, organization, and interpretation of sensory inputs to construct a meaningful understanding of events (Lucas et al., 2023). In the context of media effects, perception determines how audiences decode messages about conflicts, which in turn shapes their attitudes, emotional responses, and behavioral intentions towards the involved parties. As posited by Ezeh (2021), perception is the lens through which reality is filtered, and in conflict zones, this lens is often coloured by pre-existing trauma, prejudice, and collective memory. Furthermore, Ojukwu and Nwabueze (2022) emphasize that media credibility, a function of perceived objectivity, accuracy, and fairness, is a cornerstone of effective communication, especially during crises. When a media outlet is perceived as biased, its messages are likely to be discounted or rejected, undermining its potential to facilitate dialogue or de-escalate tensions. Therefore, assessing public perception of Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) and TSBS is not merely an academic exercise but a critical evaluation of their credibility and effectiveness as public service providers in a context where information can mean the difference between life and death.

The choice of Adamawa and Taraba States for this comparative study is strategically significant. Both states are characterized by a diverse mix of ethnic groups and a heavy reliance on agriculture and pastoralism, making them hotspots for farmer-herder conflicts. However, according to Braun et al (2025), preliminary observations suggest significant differences in the nature and management of these conflicts, which may be reflected in local media coverage. For instance, a study by Modibo (2024) stresses that Adamawa State has witnessed several government-led and community-based peace initiatives, potentially creating a different operational environment for Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC). In contrast, the Taraba State conflicts have often been reported as more intractable and violent (Lucas et al., 2023). As noted by Bashir (2023), the political economy of media in each state, including ownership influence and editorial policies, inevitably shapes news agendas and framing techniques. This study posits that these contextual differences will manifest in discernible variations in public perception towards the two radio stations, offering valuable insights into the relationship between media governance and conflict communication.

The theoretical foundations of this research are anchored in the Agenda-Setting and Social Responsibility theories of mass communication. The Agenda-Setting theory, as advanced by McCombs and Shaw (1972) and refined in contemporary studies like those of Kwashi (2024), posits that the media may not tell people what to think, but are impressively successful in telling them what to think about. In the context of Adamawa and Taraba, the frequency and prominence given to farmer-herder conflicts by Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) and TSBS may directly influence the public perception of the issue, whether positive or negative. However, the Social Responsibility theory, as discussed in relation to African media by Adebayo (2023), mandates that media institutions have an obligation to act as stewards of public trust by prioritizing social harmony, accuracy, and fairness over commercial or political interests. This study investigates the extent to which these two broadcast stations fulfill this social contract amidst a prevalent conflict, by determining whether they function as fire extinguishers or arsonists in the volatile settings of Adamawa and Taraba States.

However, the study comparatively examined public perception of the frequency of radio coverage of farmer-herder conflict in Adamawa and Taraba States, and it also investigated public perception of radio objectivity and fair coverage of the farmer-herder conflict in Adamawa and Taraba States.

## Literature Review

### Farmer-Herder Conflict Reportage

The farmer-herder conflict in Nigeria has been extensively analyzed through various academic prisms, with recent scholarship increasingly focusing on its localized dimensions and the mediating role of information ecosystems. Earlier works, such as Blench (2010), established the historical and ecological roots of the conflict, linking it to the degradation of grazing reserves in the north and the subsequent southward migration of herders. However, contemporary researchers like Idris (2024) and Okolo (2023) have deepened this analysis by highlighting how climate change-induced desertification and erratic rainfall patterns have intensified resource competition, making states like Adamawa and Taraba critical flashpoints. This body of literature confirms that the conflict is not a monolithic national issue but a series of localized crises shaped by unique geographical, demographic, and governance structures. Assessing media coverage therefore requires a context-specific approach that acknowledges localized dynamics. A generic, one-size-fits-all analysis is insufficient. Such an approach would obscure the critical distinctions in how ABC and TSBS interpret and report on conflicts within their respective jurisdictions.

The role of the media in conflict situations is profoundly ambivalent, a duality extensively documented in communication studies. On one hand, the media can act as an agent of peacebuilding by providing balanced information, countering hate speech, and creating platforms for dialogue. Studies from Kenya, following the 2007/2008 post-election violence,

demonstrate how radio programs dedicated to peace messaging significantly contributed to reconciliation efforts. This finding was reinforced by Mwangi's (2024) analysis of community radio in East Africa. On the other hand, as tragically evidenced in the Rwandan genocide, media can be weaponized to dehumanize the other and incite violence. In the Nigerian context, recent research by Nwankwo (2023) and Sani (2024) reveals that media coverage of the farmer-herder conflict often suffers from sensationalism, ethnic stereotyping, and a lack of investigative depth. This literature suggests that the performance of Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) and TSBS likely falls somewhere on this spectrum between peace promotion and conflict escalation. This study aims to pinpoint their exact positioning based on empirical evidence from their audiences.

**Concept of Public Perception**

Public perception as a variable in media studies is crucial for understanding the real-world impact of communication. Perception is not merely about receiving information but about interpreting it through individual and collective filters, including past experiences, cultural beliefs, and group affiliations (Lucas et al., 2023). As elaborated in cognitive psychology models by Ezeh (2021) and applied to media by Abdullahi (2024), audiences in conflict zones are highly sensitive to media bias. A single instance of unbalanced reporting can irrevocably damage the credibility of a media outlet. Furthermore, Musa (2023) argues that in ethnically charged environments like those in Adamawa and Taraba States, audiences often engage in selective perception, interpreting media messages in ways that reinforce their pre-existing beliefs and group identities. This theoretical understanding is vital for this study. It shows that how audiences perceive ABC and TSBS is not just based on the broadcast content itself, but is also shaped by their own social and psychological backgrounds. Consequently, the research design must be able to separate these interwoven factors.

A significant gap in the existing literature is the scarcity of comparative studies on media coverage of the farmer-herder conflict, particularly focusing on state-owned radio stations in neighboring states. Most studies, such as the work of Gever and Essien (2023) on newspapers, tend to have a national focus, thereby glossing over critical sub-national variations. Others, like the study by Apuke (2024) on social media, explore newer platforms but neglect the enduring dominance of radio in rural areas. A few works have examined radio in isolation, for example, Lucas et al. (2023) on Taraba State, but without a comparative framework. This makes it difficult to identify whether the challenges observed are unique to a specific station or endemic to state-owned broadcast media in general. This study fills this gap by directly comparing public perception of Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) and Taraba State Broadcasting Service (TSBS). This comparative approach, as advocated by comparative media systems scholars like Dare (2024), allows for a more robust analysis by controlling for national-level variables and isolating the impact of local editorial policies and practices on audience perception.

Therefore, the theoretical frameworks guiding this research provide a lens for interpreting the findings. Agenda-Setting theory, as quantitatively validated in Nigerian media studies by Kwashi (2024), suggests that consistent and prominent coverage of peace initiatives by media stations, for instance, could elevate the importance of reconciliation in the public mind. Meanwhile, Social Responsibility theory, as critiqued by Adebayo (2023) in the Nigerian context, sets a normative standard against which the performance of both broadcast stations can be judged. It is thus imperative to ask these questions: Were the stations prioritizing the public good by avoiding inflammatory language and providing a platform for all sides? Or were they neglecting this duty in favor of political or commercial interests? By combining these theories with empirical data on public perception, this study moves beyond mere description. It offers a theoretically grounded explanation for what determines whether a local radio station becomes a voice of reason or a vessel of discord in a conflict setting.

**Methodology**

This research employed a comparative cross-sectional survey design. Qualitative data strategically augmented it. This approach was used to meticulously investigate and contrast public perceptions of radio coverage within the conflict-affected contexts of Adamawa and Taraba States. The comparative framework was fundamental for defining both parallels and divergences in perception across the two states. To engage a population with direct experience and knowledge, the study focused on adult residents in selected Local Government Areas (LGAs) with a documented history of severe farmer-herder clashes. Through purposive sampling, Demsa and Numan LGAs were selected in Adamawa State, while Lau and Sardauna were chosen in Taraba State. This is a methodological strength in conflict zone research, as it ensures data are gathered from knowledgeable consumers of media coverage (Okeke, 2024). For the quantitative component, a target sample size of 400 respondents from each state was determined using the Taro Yamane formula. This enabled robust comparative analysis. A multi-stage sampling technique was then deployed. It began with the purposive selection of LGAs. This was followed by the random selection of respondents within each LGA to ensure geographical spread. The process culminated in systematic random sampling of households, with one eligible adult interviewed per household to enhance representativeness. Data collection was achieved via a structured questionnaire. It probed demographics, media exposure, and perceptions of coverage frequency, objectivity, and influence on conflict management. The instrument utilized a 5-point Likert scale. The subsequent analysis used SPSS version 27 and relied on descriptive statistics. The theoretical mean of 3.0 served as the benchmark for interpretation, a standard practice in social science research noted by Bello (2023).

To complement the quantitative findings, a qualitative component was integrated. It comprised sixteen in-depth interviews, eight per state. These interviews were held with a diverse array of stakeholders, including community leaders, farmers, herders, and civil society activists. The interview guide explored significant themes such as specific examples of impactful reporting and perceptions of bias. Conversations were conducted in local

languages, then transcribed and translated. Thematic analysis of this qualitative data was conducted following the established six-phase framework of Braun and Clarke (2006). This method has been authoritatively applied in contemporary media studies (Chukwu, 2024). Yemi (2023) posits that this rigorous mixed-methods approach triangulates quantitative trends with qualitative narratives. It is highly recommended for complex socio-media phenomena. This strategy ensured a comprehensive and valid understanding of the research problem. Throughout the process, ethical considerations were paramount. Informed consent was obtained from all participants. Anonymity and confidentiality were strictly guaranteed due to the sensitive context. The research instruments were validated by experts and refined through a pilot test. The reliability of the quantitative instrument was confirmed by a Cronbach's Alpha coefficient of 0.79, indicating high internal consistency. This meticulous adherence to ethical and methodological standards is outlined by the National Health Research Ethics Committee of Nigeria (NHREC, 2021). It underpins the credibility and ethical soundness of the study's findings.

**Data Presentation, Analysis, and Discussion of Findings**

Quantitative Data Presentation and Analysis

**Table 1: Demographic Profile of Respondents**

| Variable | Category | Adamawa (n=400) | % | Taraba (n=400) | % |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Gender | Male | 220 | 55.0% | 215 | 53.8% |
| | Female | 180 | 45.0% | 185 | 46.2% |
| Age Group | 20-35 years | 125 | 31.3% | 110 | 27.5% |
| | 36-45 years | 150 | 37.5% | 145 | 36.3% |
| | 46-55 years | 85 | 21.3% | 95 | 23.8% |
| | 56+ years | 40 | 10.0% | 50 | 12.5% |
| Education | Primary | 130 | 32.5% | 127 | 31.8% |
| | Secondary | 175 | 43.8% | 174 | 43.5% |
| | Tertiary | 95 | 23.8% | 99 | 24.8% |

Source: Survey, 2025

The demographic profiles of respondents from both states are remarkably similar, indicating comparable samples. This strengthens the validity of subsequent perceptual comparisons, as differences are less likely to be attributable to major demographic variations. The majority in both states have secondary education (Adamawa 43.8% and Taraba 43.5%), suggesting a baseline capacity to engage with media content critically.

**Table 2: Perception of Coverage Frequency**

| The radio station covers the farmer-herder conflict frequently. | Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) | Taraba Broadcasting Service (TSBS) |
|---|---|---|
| Strongly Agree | 22.0% (88) | 15.1% (60) |
| Agree | 25.0% (100) | 4.4% (18) |
| Neutral | 10.0% (40) | 2.8% (11) |
| Disagree | 30.0% (120) | 27.2% (109) |
| Strongly Disagree | 13.0% (52) | 35.1% (140) |
| Mean Score | **3.2** | **2.7** |

*Source: Survey, 2025*

There is a statistically significant difference in the perception of frequency of coverage. The Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) mean score of 3.2, though just above the theoretical mean (3.0), indicates a moderate level of perceived frequency. In contrast, the TSBS mean of 2.7 falls below the benchmark, pointing to a prevailing perception of infrequent coverage. This aligns with the Agenda-Setting theory (Kwashi, 2024); the lower frequency of coverage by TSBS will likely diminish the perceived salience of the conflict in the public consciousness in Taraba compared to Adamawa.

**Table 3: Perception of Objectivity and Fairness**

| The radio station's coverage is objective and fair. | Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) | Taraba State Broadcasting Service (TSBS) |
|---|---|---|
| Strongly Agree | 18.0% (72) | 11.5% (46) |
| Agree | 20.5% (82) | 13.1% (52) |
| Neutral | 15.0% (60) | 3.3% (13) |
| Disagree | 35.0% (140) | 27.9% (111) |
| Strongly Disagree | 11.5% (46) | 44.4% (178) |
| Mean Score | **3.1** | **2.4** |

*Source: Survey, 2025*

The disparity in perceived objectivity is glaring. While perception of Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) is again moderate (Mean=3.1), the perception of TSBS is overwhelmingly negative (Mean=2.4). The high percentage of Strongly Disagree responses for TSBS (44.4%) suggests a deep-seated credibility crisis. This finding resonates with the arguments of Abdullahi (2024) and Musa (2023) on selective perception and the erosion of trust in media perceived as biased. The significantly lower score for TSBS indicates that its reporting is viewed as heavily partial, which fundamentally undermines its social responsibility mandate (Adebayo, 2023).

**Thematic Analysis**

**Theme 1: Divergent Editorial Approaches to Conflict Reporting**

The interviews revealed a clear distinction in the editorial stance of the two stations. In Adamawa State, respondents frequently mentioned programmes like Shanu a Zaman Lafiya (Peaceful Coexistence Talks) on Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC). A community leader in Demsa noted:

> Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) does not just report the killings; they often invite both farmers and herders to speak the following week. You hear their grievances directly.

This approach of creating a platform for dialogue was consistently praised. In contrast, narratives from Taraba were critical. A respondent from Lau stated:

> TSBS news is like a government bulletin. When herders attack, they are slow to report. When there is a response from farmers, it is quickly called an unlawful attack. We don't trust their balance.

This suggests TSBS is perceived as aligning closely with the narrative of the state government, a finding that echoes Nwankwo's (2023) analysis of state media capture in Nigeria.

**Theme 2: Impact of Coverage on Community Sentiments and Tensions**

The perceived impact of the radio coverage on the ground was also evidently different. In Adamawa, several interviewees felt the radio played a calming role. According to a female respondent from Numan:

> After a clash, hearing a balanced report on Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) helps to reduce the anger and tension. It stops rumours from spreading like wildfire. Doing this, help us to understand each other.

This aligns with the peace building potential of media described by Mwangi (2024). In Taraba State, the effect was described as inflammatory. An interviewee from Sardauna explained:

> The way TSBS reports things causes more trouble. If they say only five people were killed when we know it is fifteen, it makes people angrier. It is as if they are trying to hide the truth.

This perception of downplaying atrocities was linked to increased suspicion and a higher likelihood of reprisal attacks, demonstrating the escalatory role media can play, as feared in the case of Rwandan.

**Discussion of Findings**

The comparative data explicitly demonstrates that the public perception of Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) is significantly more positive than that of the Taraba State Broadcasting Service (TSBS) concerning the coverage of the farmer-herder conflict. The higher mean scores for Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) on both frequency and objectivity indicate that it is perceived as a more active and balanced source of information. This finding can be interpreted through the lens of the Social Responsibility theory. The Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) practice of hosting dialogue programmes, as revealed in the qualitative data, reflects an attempt to fulfil its obligation to the public good by fostering understanding, a practice lauded by peace journalism scholars like Adebayo (2023). However, the TSBS perceived bias and infrequency suggest a failure to meet these social responsibility tenets, potentially due to tighter governmental control or a different editorial policy, as hypothesized by Bashir (2023) in his work on the political economy of state media.

The glaring difference in perceived objectivity is the most critical finding of this study. The credibility deficit faced by TSBS has profound implications. As established by Ezeh (2021), when a media outlet loses credibility, its capacity to influence public opinion constructively diminishes. In a conflict setting, this vacuum is often filled by rumours and hate speech on informal channels, which can be more damaging. The qualitative data from Taraba State, where respondents suspect TSBS of misrepresenting casualty figures, is a classic example of how loss of trust can directly fuel resentment and violence. This supports claim by Musa (2023), that concept of selective perception, where audiences who already distrust an outlet are predisposed to interpret its messages negatively, thus creating a vicious cycle of disbelief and escalation. Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC), by maintaining a degree of perceived balance, seems to have retained a moderating influence, able to assuage rather than inflame passions after violent incidents.

Furthermore, the findings related to frequency of coverage have important agenda-setting implications. The lower frequency of coverage by TSBS, as perceived by its audience, means that the farmer-herder conflict may not be maintained as a high-priority issue on the public agenda in Taraba State to the same extent as in Adamawa. According to Kwashi (2024), low salience can lead to public apathy and reduce pressure on the government to seek durable solutions. The Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) gives more frequent reporting to keep the issue in the public eye, potentially fostering a sustained demand for peace and accountability. This demonstrates that the amount of coverage given is as important as the tone in shaping the public and political response to a lingering crisis like the farmer-herder conflict.

## Conclusion

This study has successfully unraveled the distinct public perceptions of radio coverage of the farmer-herder conflict in Adamawa and Taraba States. The evidence leads to an explicit conclusion that Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC) is perceived as a more frequent, slightly more objective, and potentially peace-oriented broadcast station. On the other hand, Taraba State Broadcasting Service is viewed as infrequent, evidently biased, and contributory to community tensions. These differences have real-world consequences for conflict dynamics, social cohesion, and public trust in institutional media. The study underscores that state-owned broadcast stations are not monolithic entities and that their editorial choices, shaped by local politics and institutional cultures, critically determine their impact as either agents of peace or accessories to conflict.

## Recommendations

i. The study recommends that there be frequent and credible coverage of farmer-herder conflicts from both media houses to enable the public to perceive them in a good light.

ii. The study also recommends the need for constant objective and fair coverage of farmer-herder conflicts by TSBS and Adamawa Broadcasting Corporation (ABC).

iii. However, the study suggested the need for future research. Subsequently, studies should employ longitudinal designs to track changes in perception over time. Research could also explore the specific content of news bulletins from both stations and additional stations through content analysis to objectively correlate editorial content with public perception.

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# INDIGENOUS CONFLICT RESOLUTION MECHANISMS AND TRADITIONAL AUTHORITY IN TARABA STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** This study explores the indigenous conflict resolution mechanisms and traditional authority. Taraba State is an epicentre for violent conflict from the 1900s till date; many communities have resorted to traditional mechanisms to resolve some of these violent conflicts. The study takes Tigun in Kurmi communities as a case study to demonstrate the efficacy or otherwise of these traditional mechanisms in conflict resolution. The researcher has used qualitative research approaches, leveraging focus group discussions and in-depth interviews to collect data with Perspectives and illustrations in Tigun Kurmi Local Government Area. The study found that diverse resolution mechanisms by the Tigun ethnic group were of both physical and spiritual methods, where the spiritual God made instant results due to the system employed of deterrence measures. The paper found that traditional indigenous resolution mechanisms are faster in ending conflicts among disputants than the contemporary legal methods. The researcher hereby recommend government integrate indigenous resolution mechanisms with the modern legal resolution process and strengthen the process of the mechanisms. Cultural theory is the pathway to acquainting oneself with this study, as it is guided by the structural or frustration conflict theories for indigenous conflict to be ended.

**Keywords:** Indigenous conflict resolution mechanism, deterrence measures, legal resolution process, Taraba State.

## Introduction

Conflict is neither new nor alien to African societies; rather, it has historically been a managed social reality embedded within communal life. Conflict resolution mechanisms and systems are developed for preventing, managing, and resolving conflicts using indigenous norms, values, and institutions. Long before the emergence of modern resolution mechanisms, African societies developed indigenous conflict resolution mechanisms rooted in communal values, restorative justice, consensus-building, and moral authority. These traditional mechanisms, such as councils of elders, mediation by traditional rulers, age-grade systems, and customary courts, continue to operate informally alongside formal state institutions.

The violence conflict that was wide spread were those of land claims, communal clashes, intermittent grievances and tension over farm land trespasses, family disputes, social disagreement that has created tensions among communities, chieftaincy lineage over non-

lineage enthronements, resource-based claims such as the farm lands. These conflicts at this period never caused destruction of properties nor displacement of population.

Fundamentally, indigenous violent conflict resolution is a community-based, culturally grounded informal dispute settlement processes that prioritize restoration of relationships and social harmony over retributive justice. These methods are rooted in society's long-established norms and traditions. Restoration and reconciliation in indigenous methods aim to heal wounds, restore broken relationships and reintegrate parties into the community. Similarly, communal focus conflicts are viewed as a community concern, not just a problem between individuals. The entire community has a stake in the resolution process and it outcome. Elders have a critical role because they are respected figures who ensure disputes are typically mediated or arbitrated by a council of Elders, knowledge keepers, and religious leaders who are respected for their wisdom, impartiality, and knowledge of customary law.

The other authorities for resolutions are the ancestral spiritual forces, whose resolutions stood on oath-taking, truth and trust as their tools for arbitration or adjudication. These methods yielded speedy resolution results due to their elements of sanctions, threats and instant actions against guilty parties. These systems are often more accessible, quicker and less expense that make them the primary choice for many people, especially the community societies. Other methods were those that involve symbolic acts, rituals, spiritual or religious elements of shared meals, sacrifices, too much forgiveness, ensuring truthfulness and signifying commitment to peace. Indigenous conflict mechanisms (March, 2025). All these practising processes were implored in Tigun Community with different agendas with diverse communities in Tigun. They have multiple ethnic dialects and practised a common cultural heritage, so that adjudication and resolutions were commonly practised in the Tigun land.

**Statement of the Problem**

Violent conflicts that have enveloped Nigeria with so many different forms of operation, including raiding conflicts, have caused so many effects and impacts on the lives of the societies in Nigeria and especially northeast Nigeria, which authorities have found it difficult to end these conflicts by diverse resolution mechanisms. Taraba State Indeed is an epicentre of violent conflicts such as Boko Haram, banditry, farmer-herder cases, resource-based conflicts, land claims and many others, which have become common in Taraba State communities, thereby making the methods of resolution mechanisms difficult.

These scenarios of difficult ways to resolve conflict in formal methods have led to the continuous widespread of violent conflict in Taraba State communities, which become necessary to proffer the indigenous conflict resolution mechanisms that has promote resolutions result which are no long-terms resolution compared to the contemporary methods. The indigenous methods who are employed truth stand on trust and other uncommonly used spiritual methods that are full of sanction threats and instant disciplinary actions that work. Indigenous traditional methods and traditional authority processes are engaged for promptly resolving violent conflict in Taraba State.

**Objectives of the Study**

i. To explore the role of traditional authority in conflict intervention in Tigun society.

ii. To identify mechanisms used for dispute settlement in Tigun society.

iii. To assess the efficacy and limitations of these indigenous systems in managing conflicts in Tigun society.

**Research Questions**

i. What roles do traditional authorities play in conflict intervention in Tigun society?

ii. What indigenous mechanisms are used for dispute settlement in Tigun society?

iii. How effective are the indigenous conflict management systems in Tigun society, and what are their major limitations?

**Conceptual Clarifications and Theoretical Framework**

Conflict refers to a situation in which individuals or groups pursue incompatible interests, values, or goals, often resulting in social tension or violence. In the African context, conflict is commonly linked to land ownership, political authority, identity, and access to resources, and is often embedded within social relationships rather than isolated events (Best, 2006).

Traditional conflict resolution mechanisms denote indigenous, community-based processes developed over time to manage and resolve disputes using customary norms, values, and institutions. These mechanisms typically involve mediation, negotiation, reconciliation, and restitution facilitated by elders, traditional rulers, lineage heads, or community councils. Their primary objective is the restoration of social harmony rather than the determination of legal guilt or punishment (Zartman, 2000; Murithi, 2009).

In addition, the article draws on restorative justice theory, which emphasizes healing, accountability, and the repair of social relationships rather than retribution. Traditional African conflict resolution mechanisms align closely with restorative justice principles, as they prioritize reconciliation, compensation, apology, and reintegration of offenders into the community (Gyekye, 1997; Zehr, 2002). This theoretical lens helps explain the continued relevance of indigenous mechanisms in fostering long-term peace and social cohesion.

The study also engages communitarian social theory, which underscores the primacy of community values, collective responsibility, and shared moral obligations. African societies are often organized around communal identities in which individual actions are evaluated based on their impact on group harmony. Traditional conflict resolution mechanisms derive

their authority from these communitarian norms, reinforcing social order through moral persuasion rather than coercion (Gyekye, 1997; Etzioni, 1993).

These theoretical perspectives provide a comprehensive framework for analyzing how traditional conflict resolution mechanisms operate, adapt, and interact with modern state institutions. They also offer analytical tools for assessing the strengths and limitations of indigenous approaches within contemporary African governance and justice systems.

**Historical Evolution of Traditional Conflict Resolution Mechanisms in Africa**

Traditional conflict resolution mechanisms in African societies evolved long before the emergence of colonial and postcolonial state structures. These mechanisms were integral to indigenous systems of governance, social regulation, and moral education, serving as tools for maintaining order and cohesion within largely kinshipbased communities. Conflict was understood as a disruption of social equilibrium, and its resolution was embedded in cultural norms, rituals, and shared values that emphasized collective survival and continuity (Gyekye, 1997; Falola, 2004).

Pre-colonial African societies developed diverse yet functionally similar approaches to conflict management. Institutions such as councils of elders among the Yoruba, palaver systems in West and Central Africa, the Gacaca courts among the Igbo and later institutionalized in Rwanda, and lineage-based mediation structures among the Akan and Zulu exemplify indigenous systems designed to address disputes through dialogue, consensus, and moral persuasion (Zartman, 2000; Murithi, 2009). These mechanisms relied heavily on oral traditions, customary law, and the authority of respected community figures whose legitimacy stemmed from age, wisdom, and moral integrity.

Colonial intervention marked a major turning point in the evolution of traditional conflict resolution mechanisms. European colonial administrations introduced formal legal systems based on Western jurisprudence, often dismissing indigenous institutions as primitive or incompatible with modern governance. Customary law was either subordinated to colonial courts or selectively codified to serve colonial interests, thereby distorting its original restorative and communal orientation (Mamdani, 1996; Chanock, 1985). This process weakened traditional authorities and disrupted the organic relationship between indigenous institutions and community life.

Despite colonial marginalization, traditional conflict resolution mechanisms did not disappear. Instead, they adapted to changing political realities and continued to operate informally at the grassroots level. In many rural and peri-urban areas, communities retained reliance on elders, traditional rulers, and customary forums to resolve disputes related to land, marriage, inheritance, and local leadership, often preferring these mechanisms to formal courts due to their accessibility, affordability, and cultural legitimacy (Boege et al., 2009; Osaghae, 2015).

The post-independence period further reshaped traditional conflict resolution mechanisms as African states sought to consolidate authority and modernize governance structures. While some governments attempted to abolish or restrict customary institutions in favor of centralized state control, others adopted more accommodative approaches by recognizing customary courts or incorporating traditional leaders into local governance systems (Sklar, 2004). However, the relationship between traditional mechanisms and the modern state has remained ambivalent, characterized by coexistence, competition, and occasional collaboration.

In contemporary African societies, traditional conflict resolution mechanisms reflect a hybrid evolution shaped by historical continuity and institutional transformation. They operate within plural legal environments where customary norms intersect with statutory law, religious law, and international human rights frameworks. This historical trajectory underscores the resilience of indigenous conflict resolution practices and highlights their capacity to adapt to modern contexts while retaining core principles of restorative justice and communal harmony (Zartman, 2000; Murithi, 2009).

**Structures and Processes of Traditional Conflict Resolution Mechanisms**

Traditional conflict resolution mechanisms in African societies are organized around well-defined social structures and procedural norms that reflect communal values, moral authority, and participatory governance. These structures and processes vary across regions and cultures, yet they share common features centered on dialogue, consensus-building, and the restoration of social harmony rather than punitive justice (Gyekye, 1997; Zartman, 2000).

At the structural level, traditional conflict resolution is typically facilitated by recognized community institutions such as councils of elders, traditional rulers, lineage heads, age-grade associations, and religious or spiritual leaders. These actors are selected based on age, wisdom, experience, moral standing, or hereditary legitimacy, and they command respect within their communities. Their authority is socially constructed and sustained through trust, cultural norms, and collective acceptance rather than coercive power (Osaghae, 2015; Sklar, 2004).

The processes of traditional conflict resolution are largely informal and flexible, allowing procedures to adapt to the nature of the dispute and the social context in which it occurs. Dispute resolution often begins with mediation, where neutral community representatives facilitate dialogue between conflicting parties. Emphasis is placed on storytelling, confession, and collective deliberation, enabling all parties to express grievances and perspectives in an open forum (Murithi, 2009). This participatory process fosters mutual understanding and reduces the likelihood of escalation.

Consensus-building is a central feature of traditional conflict resolution mechanisms. Decisions are rarely imposed unilaterally; instead, resolutions emerge through prolonged discussion aimed at achieving communal agreement. The goal is not to declare a winner or

loser but to reach outcomes that are socially acceptable and morally justified, thereby ensuring compliance and long-term peace (Zartman, 2000; Gyekye, 1997).

Rituals and symbolic acts often accompany the resolution process, serving to reinforce reconciliation and restore broken relationships. These may include public apologies, compensation in the form of livestock or labor, communal feasts, libation ceremonies, or cleansing rituals. Such symbolic practices carry deep cultural significance and function as moral closure, reaffirming shared values and reintegrating disputants into the community (Falola, 2004; Murithi, 2009).

Enforcement of decisions relies primarily on social pressure, moral obligation, and communal sanctions rather than formal legal coercion. Compliance is encouraged through respect for tradition, fear of social ostracism, and concern for communal reputation. This form of enforcement is particularly effective in tightly knit communities where social relationships are enduring and interdependent (Bennett, 2017; Merry, 1988).

The structures and processes of traditional conflict resolution mechanisms demonstrate an indigenous governance logic that prioritizes social cohesion, legitimacy, and sustainability. Their emphasis on inclusivity, moral reasoning, and restorative outcomes distinguishes them from adversarial legal systems and explains their continued relevance in managing conflicts within modern African states.

**Challenges and Limitations of Traditional Conflict Resolution Mechanisms**

While traditional conflict resolution mechanisms play an important role in contemporary African societies, they are constrained by several structural, normative, and contextual challenges. These limitations affect their legitimacy, effectiveness, and potential for integration into modern state systems

**Human Rights and Gender Concerns**

One of the most prominent challenges confronting traditional conflict resolution mechanisms is their perceived incompatibility with modern human rights standards. Many indigenous systems are patriarchal in structure, often excluding women, youths, and marginalized groups from meaningful participation in decision-making processes. Dispute resolution forums are frequently dominated by male elders, which can result in biased outcomes, particularly in cases involving marriage, inheritance, or sexual violence (Merry, 1988; Bennett, 2017). Such practices conflict with constitutional guarantees of equality and international human rights instruments to which most African states are signatories. As a result, traditional mechanisms are often criticized for reinforcing social hierarchies and limiting access to justice for vulnerable groups.

### Lack of Formal Recognition and Legal Authority

Another major limitation is the absence of clear legal and constitutional recognition of traditional conflict resolution mechanisms in many African states. Although customary law may be acknowledged in principle, traditional institutions often operate without formal statutory backing or defined jurisdiction. This lack of recognition weakens their authority and creates uncertainty regarding the enforceability of their decisions. In plural legal systems, disputants may comply with traditional rulings only when it suits their interests, resorting to formal courts when outcomes are unfavorable (Boege et al., 2009; Sklar, 2004). This situation undermines the consistency and credibility of indigenous mechanisms within the broader justice system.

### Susceptibility to Abuse and Politicization

Traditional conflict resolution mechanisms are also vulnerable to manipulation, corruption, and politicization, particularly in contexts where traditional authorities are co-opted by political actors or state elites. The erosion of moral authority among some traditional leaders, driven by partisan affiliations or material incentives, compromises the neutrality required for effective mediation. In addition, the absence of standardized procedures and accountability frameworks can lead to arbitrary decisions and abuse of power (Osaghae, 2015; Mamdani, 1996). These challenges raise concerns about transparency and fairness, limiting public confidence in traditional systems. These challenges highlight the need for critical reform and contextual adaptation of traditional conflict resolution mechanisms if they are to function effectively within modern African states.

### Integration of Traditional and Modern Conflict Resolution Systems

The coexistence of traditional conflict resolution mechanisms (TCRMs) and modern state judicial systems in African societies presents both opportunities and challenges. Effective integration can enhance access to justice, improve social cohesion, and strengthen governance, while misalignment may lead to duplication, conflict of authority, and reduced legitimacy of either system (Boege et al., 2009; Zartman, 2000).

### Policy and Institutional Strategies

For integration to be effective, state policies must formally recognize the role of traditional mechanisms within the broader justice framework. This can include codifying the scope of customary courts, establishing guidelines for procedural fairness, and providing training for traditional leaders on human rights, gender inclusion, and conflict management (Boege et al., 2009). Institutional strategies may involve creating liaison offices within ministries of justice, encouraging documentation of customary practices, and promoting participatory governance models that incorporate both traditional and modern authorities (Sklar, 2004).

By implementing these measures, African states can foster a legal ecosystem where traditional and modern systems coexist productively. This hybrid model not only strengthens access to justice but also ensures that conflict resolution practices remain culturally relevant while upholding universal standards of fairness, equity, and human rights (Murithi, 2009; Zartman, 2000).

**Implications for Peacebuilding and Governance**

The continued relevance and potential integration of traditional conflict resolution mechanisms (TCRMs) within modern African states have significant implications for peacebuilding, governance, and social stability. Recognizing and strategically leveraging these indigenous mechanisms can enhance community resilience, strengthen local governance, and reduce pressure on formal judicial institutions (Boege et al., 2009; Murithi, 2009).

**Enhancing Community-Based Peacebuilding**

Traditional mechanisms contribute directly to grassroots peacebuilding by addressing disputes before they escalate into broader conflicts. Their restorative and reconciliatory nature prioritizes repairing social relationships, fostering dialogue, and promoting forgiveness, which are critical for sustaining long-term peace in closely knit communities (Zehr, 2002). By integrating TCRMs into formal peacebuilding frameworks, policymakers can strengthen early conflict intervention strategies and ensure culturally sensitive approaches that are more likely to gain community acceptance (Murithi, 2009).

**Strengthening Governance and Social Trust**

The involvement of traditional authorities in dispute resolution enhances local governance by providing accessible and trusted channels for conflict management. Communities often view traditional leaders as morally accountable and culturally legitimate, which can improve compliance with decisions and reinforce social order (Osaghae, 2015; Gyekye, 1997). Integrating TCRMs into governance structures can also increase public trust in state institutions, particularly in regions where formal courts are perceived as distant, slow, or biased.

**Reducing Judicial Backlogs and Increasing Efficiency**

Formal judicial systems in many African countries are overburdened, under-resourced, and slow, leading to delays in conflict resolution and limited access to justice for marginalized populations (Boege et al., 2009). Leveraging traditional mechanisms for local dispute resolution can reduce the caseload of formal courts, streamline the justice process, and provide timely solutions. This complementary relationship ensures that both systems operate efficiently while preserving the legitimacy and authority of indigenous practices.

Traditional conflict resolution mechanisms provide not only tools for managing disputes but also critical pathways for enhancing peacebuilding, governance, and social cohesion in modern African states. Strategic recognition and integration of these mechanisms can bridge gaps between formal institutions and communities, ensuring that conflict management is both effective and culturally resonant (Zartman, 2000; Murithi, 2009).

## Methodology

This study adopted a qualitative research design using Focus Group Discussions (FGDs) and in-depth interviews to explore the indigenous conflict resolution mechanisms of the Tigun people in Kurmi Local Government Area of Taraba State. The qualitative approach was considered appropriate because it enabled the researcher to obtain rich, detailed, and context-specific information from participants who possess extensive knowledge of Tigun history, customs, and traditional conflict resolution practices. The target population comprised knowledgeable adult male members of the Tigun community selected from different community areas based on their familiarity with the indigenous justice system. A total of seven participants were selected through a simple random sampling technique to ensure representation from the various Tigun communities. Data were collected using an interview guide, Focus Group Discussion sessions, audio and video recording devices, and note-taking during the discussions.

The data generated from the FGDs and in-depth interviews were analyzed using thematic analysis. This involved the systematic transcription of interview responses, repeated reading of the transcripts to achieve familiarity with the data, coding of relevant statements, and the identification of recurring themes and patterns related to the study objectives. The emerging themes were reviewed, refined, interpreted, and organized into coherent categories to provide a comprehensive understanding of the indigenous conflict resolution mechanisms of the Tigun people. The findings were subsequently presented narratively, with illustrative quotations from participants where necessary, to ensure that the analysis accurately reflected the views and experiences of the respondents.

## The History and Methods of Tigun Conflict Resolution Mechanisms

The Tigun people settled in Tigun area of Kurmi Local Government of Taraba State. The community is of multiplicity of sub-urban communities namely Abong community area, Ashuku community area, Eneme community area, Akwento community area, Boko Community area, and Njuande Community area, similarly, these communities have different multiple dialects but all share a common cultural heritage. These dialects in each community comprised of Mbwani Speaking Language which is the Abong people and Abong is the administrative center for these communities. We have the Nzare speaking people who are the Achukus and nama baba people who are in Ashuku and Eneme respectively. They migrated from the Kwararafa kingdom. There is the Nzare-speaking language who are the Akwawen people. Njuande-speaking language is known as the Asha people. Obiobionawo-speaking languages are the Batu people known as the Boko. Of all these diversities of languages, Nzare language was the major or generally spoken language of Tigun people. Their diversity

of language did not affect their cultural heritage; rather, they shared one common cultural heritage that they served.

**Types of the Resolution Mechanisms**

The Tigun people possess a well-developed indigenous conflict resolution system that combines customary authority, communal participation, and spiritual beliefs to maintain peace and social order. These traditional mechanisms are organized into different levels of adjudication depending on the nature and complexity of the dispute. The first level consists of institutions founded on the community's customs, norms, and accumulated wisdom. At this level, the Wakwan Yara (youth leaders) play a critical role in enforcing the decisions of the traditional authorities and ensuring compliance with established community rules. They serve as custodians of discipline among the youth, protect traditional leaders, safeguard the community against external threats, and ensure that no individual is above the customary laws of the Tigun society. Their role extends beyond conflict management to include maintaining law and order and defending the community from intruders and other forms of insecurity.

At a higher level of the traditional justice system are the Wakwan Du (council of elders), who are respected for their age, wisdom, integrity, and extensive knowledge of Tigun customs and traditions. These elders adjudicate disputes that have been appealed from family heads, extended families, clan leaders, market authorities, and other lower customary institutions. Their decisions are founded on truth, fairness, and communal trust, making them highly respected arbiters within the society. Where disputes remain unresolved after deliberation by the elders, they are referred to the Afan Shon Council, the highest traditional authority, for further adjudication. This hierarchical arrangement ensures that disputes are addressed progressively, allowing opportunities for reconciliation before they reach the highest level of traditional adjudication.

Beyond these physical institutions, the Tigun conflict resolution system incorporates spiritual mechanisms rooted in ancestral beliefs and cultural philosophy. These mechanisms are employed primarily for disputes that cannot be resolved through dialogue, mediation, or customary adjudication. Spiritual institutions serve the dual purpose of preserving the cultural heritage of the Tigun people while providing final and binding judgments in difficult cases. Among these mechanisms is the Effrobye, a supernatural institution believed to possess the ability to transform individuals into fierce animals such as cheetahs or hippopotamuses, symbolizing divine authority and justice. Another important institution is the Chu deity, popularly regarded as the god of thunder and lightning, which is invoked during oath-taking ceremonies. The Tigun believe that thunder reveals the guilty party by striking individuals who swear falsely or violate the truth. These spiritual sanctions are regarded as impartial because they apply equally to indigenes and non-indigenes, including strangers and herders, thereby reinforcing honesty and accountability within the community.

A notable illustration of the effectiveness of the Chu institution involved a dispute between a farmer and Fulani herders in Nama Baba, Tigun area. The farmer accused the herders' cattle

of destroying his crops, but the herders denied the allegation before their leader (Ardo). Both parties agreed to swear an oath before the Chu deity to establish the truth. According to community accounts, thunder subsequently struck and killed about twenty cattle belonging to the herders, which was interpreted as divine proof that the herders had lied. The incident compelled the Ardo to acknowledge the truth and accept responsibility for the destruction caused by his herders. Another important spiritual mechanism is the Nun Gbofin, regarded as the deity of detection and justice, which identifies individuals who refuse to accept the decisions of customary authorities after all peaceful avenues of settlement have been exhausted. Similarly, the Ekye Thon, commonly referred to as the "pot of water justice," is traditionally employed to address cases involving witchcraft and other forms of harmful spiritual practices believed to threaten communal peace and security.

The Tigun indigenous conflict resolution system is highly respected because it combines social authority with spiritual legitimacy, making its decisions widely accepted within the community. The severity of the sanctions associated with spiritual adjudication, including public disgrace, supernatural punishment, and in extreme cases death, serves as a powerful deterrent against dishonesty, injustice, and persistent conflict. The belief that supernatural forces operate impartially reinforces public confidence in the system and encourages disputants to comply with judgments reached through customary institutions. In addition to conflict resolution, cultural demonstrations associated with institutions such as the Effrobye reinforce communal values, preserve indigenous heritage, and remind members of the consequences of violating societal norms. Consequently, the Tigun traditional justice system functions not only as a mechanism for resolving disputes but also as an institution for promoting social cohesion, cultural continuity, accountability, and lasting peace within the community.

**The Tigun Traditional Strategies for Resolving Conflicts**

The Tigun indigenous conflict resolution system is founded on customs, traditions, cultural norms, and ancestral beliefs that have been transmitted orally from one generation to another. Rather than relying on written legal codes, the Tigun preserve their justice system through oral traditions, collective memory, and regular cultural performances that reinforce the values and philosophies of their ancestors. These customs constitute the basis for adjudication and social regulation, enabling community members to understand acceptable behaviour and the consequences of violating established norms. The indigenous legal system derives its legitimacy from the wisdom of elders, the accumulated experiences of community leaders, and the authority of ancestral spiritual institutions. Through continuous cultural demonstrations and community participation, younger generations are socialized into the principles of justice, fairness, and communal responsibility, ensuring the continuity of Tigun traditional institutions and conflict management practices.

At the grassroots level, conflict resolution begins within the family and youth structures. The Wakwan Yara (youth leaders) are responsible for handling disputes involving young people, including cases of rivalry, theft, indiscipline, and disrespect for elders. Sitting at designated youth centres, they employ dialogue, customary principles, and community rules to reconcile disputants and restore harmony. In addition to adjudication, the youth serve as the

enforcement arm of the traditional justice system by ensuring compliance with decisions reached by the elders. They also function as community security personnel, protecting villages against external threats, monitoring public order, and safeguarding the authority of traditional leaders. Their responsibilities therefore extend beyond dispute settlement to include the preservation of peace, discipline, and security within the Tigun communities.

The Wakwan Ndu (council of elders) constitute the principal customary institution responsible for adjudicating more complex disputes. Selected on the basis of age, wisdom, experience, and integrity, the elders deliberate in traditional council huts where they hear and resolve cases involving families, extended families, clans, markets, inheritance, and interpersonal disputes. They strive to resolve all matters brought before them through consensus, fairness, and strict adherence to customary law. Other traditional authorities, including the Wa Shon (village leaders) and Wa Shig (ward heads), adjudicate disputes relating to village boundaries, farmland ownership, forest resources, communal relationships, and inter-village disagreements. Appeals from these lower institutions are referred to the Afan Shon, the paramount traditional ruler of the Tigun people, whose decisions are regarded as final in matters that can be resolved through customary authority. This hierarchical arrangement ensures that conflicts are addressed systematically, allowing opportunities for mediation and reconciliation before disputes reach the highest level of traditional adjudication.

Where disputes remain unresolved after passing through the various customary institutions, they are referred to ancestral spiritual mechanisms, which represent the highest level of indigenous justice. These include the Effrobye, believed to manifest through supernatural transformations that symbolize divine justice; the Nun Chu, the deity of thunder and lightning invoked during oath-taking to expose falsehood and punish dishonesty; the Nun Gbofin, the deity responsible for detecting and identifying individuals who reject truthful judgments; and the Ekye Thon, commonly known as the "pot of water," which is traditionally employed to identify witches and individuals believed to engage in harmful spiritual practices. These spiritual institutions are regarded as impartial and final arbiters because their judgments are believed to originate from ancestral powers rather than human influence. The fear of supernatural sanctions—including illness, public disgrace, destruction of property, or death—encourages disputants to accept the decisions of customary authorities and discourages persistent conflict within the community.

The Tigun indigenous conflict resolution system operates through an integrated network of family heads (Wuna Andu), youth leaders (Wakwan Yara), elders (Wakwan Ndu), village leaders (Wa Shon), ward heads (Wa Shig), the paramount ruler (Afan Shon), and ancestral spiritual institutions. Each institution performs clearly defined responsibilities within a structured hierarchy that ensures disputes are resolved at the most appropriate level before progressing to higher authorities where necessary. The guiding principles of the system are truth, fairness, communal harmony, accountability, and respect for customary authority. The combination of human wisdom and spiritual legitimacy has historically promoted compliance with judgments, minimized insecurity, strengthened social cohesion, and preserved peace within Tigun society. Consequently, the indigenous justice system has remained an effective

mechanism for maintaining law, order, and sustainable conflict management while preserving the cultural heritage and identity of the Tigun people.

**Discussion of Findings**

The findings reveal that the indigenous conflict resolution mechanisms of the Tigun people are highly effective in restoring social harmony and preserving interpersonal relationships within the community. Unlike formal judicial systems, which often emphasize determining guilt and imposing legal sanctions, the Tigun indigenous system prioritizes reconciliation, forgiveness, and the restoration of broken relationships. Traditional leaders and elders seek to resolve disputes in ways that promote communal unity rather than deepen divisions between disputing parties. This restorative approach enables individuals to reintegrate into the community after disputes have been settled, thereby strengthening social cohesion and reducing the likelihood of recurring conflicts. The findings further suggest that the legitimacy of these mechanisms derives from their foundation in truth, fairness, impartiality, and respect for customary values, all of which encourage voluntary compliance with the decisions reached through traditional adjudication.

Another significant finding is that indigenous conflict resolution is fundamentally community-based and relies on respected mediators who possess extensive knowledge of Tigun customs, traditions, and social norms. Traditional rulers, elders, family heads, youth leaders, and other customary authorities enjoy widespread trust because they are regarded as impartial custodians of communal values and moral integrity. Their proximity to disputants enables them to understand the social, cultural, and historical contexts surrounding conflicts, allowing them to develop solutions that are both culturally appropriate and acceptable to the parties involved. In addition, the findings indicate that the participation of youth leaders in enforcing community decisions and maintaining security contributes significantly to the effectiveness of the indigenous justice system by ensuring that resolutions are respected and implemented.

The study also demonstrates that the Tigun indigenous conflict resolution process is highly participatory and inclusive. Members of the community are actively involved in dialogue, mediation, and consensus-building, creating opportunities for disputants, families, elders, and other stakeholders to express their views before decisions are reached. This participatory approach enhances transparency, strengthens public confidence in the justice system, and reinforces collective responsibility for maintaining peace. The emphasis on consensus rather than adversarial litigation ensures that resolutions reflect the shared interests of the community while preserving long-standing social relationships. Furthermore, because the process is rooted in local customs and values, it is capable of addressing disputes in ways that are culturally meaningful and socially acceptable, thereby increasing the durability of peace agreements.

Finally, the findings indicate that indigenous conflict resolution mechanisms are efficient, accessible, and responsive to the immediate needs of the community. Disputes are generally resolved promptly without the financial costs, procedural delays, and technical complexities

associated with formal courts. The use of context-specific norms enables traditional institutions to address a wide range of conflicts, including family disputes, land disagreements, inheritance issues, communal conflicts, and other social grievances. Respondents emphasized that the speed of adjudication, combined with the authority of traditional leaders and the fear of customary or spiritual sanctions, discouraged prolonged disputes and promoted compliance with resolutions. Consequently, the Tigun indigenous conflict resolution system has remained a sustainable and effective mechanism for maintaining peace, preventing violence, and promoting social stability across generations.

## Conclusion

The study concludes that traditional conflict resolution mechanisms remain indispensable institutions for maintaining peace, social cohesion, and justice in many African societies. Rooted in indigenous customs, communal values, and restorative principles, these mechanisms provide culturally legitimate, accessible, and cost-effective approaches to resolving disputes while emphasizing reconciliation, consensus-building, and the restoration of social relationships rather than punitive justice. Their resilience and continued relevance, despite the disruptions of colonialism and the expansion of formal legal systems, demonstrate their capacity to adapt to changing social realities and address conflicts in ways that reflect local cultural contexts. However, challenges such as gender exclusion, inadequate legal recognition, political interference, and inconsistencies with constitutional and human rights standards underscore the need for appropriate reforms and greater institutional support. Accordingly, the study concludes that integrating traditional conflict resolution mechanisms with formal judicial institutions through a complementary and legally recognized framework would enhance access to justice, strengthen community participation, promote legal pluralism, and contribute to sustainable peace, effective governance, and inclusive development across African societies.

## Recommendations

i. The Tigun Traditional Council should strengthen and institutionalize the roles of elders, youth leaders, and village heads in the prompt mediation and resolution of community disputes.

ii. The Kurmi Local Government Council should recognize and collaborate with Tigun traditional institutions in resolving family, land, inheritance, and communal conflicts before they escalate into violence.

iii. The Tigun Traditional Council and community leaders should preserve and transmit indigenous conflict resolution knowledge and customary values to younger generations through cultural education and regular community sensitization programmes.

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# IMPACT OF CLIMATE CHANGE ON FARMERS-HERDERS' CONFLICT IN NORTH-EAST NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** This study examines the impact of climate change on farmers-herders' conflict in North-East Nigeria. Climate change has created the problems of resource scarcity and forced migration, which contribute to the escalation of the conflict in the region. The study adopts the human needs theory propounded by Abraham Maslow and others as its theoretical framework. The theory assumes that violence is a tragic expression of unmet human needs, implying that all actions undertaken by human beings are attempts to satisfy their needs and means of livelihood. A qualitative research approach is adopted, and data gathering is through content analysis of a literature review. The findings of the study reveal that the resource-based conflicts in North-East Nigeria are often triggered by climate change. The study also finds that unsustainable environmental practices such as greenhouse gas emissions, bush burning, and deforestation have resulted in resource scarcity, which accentuates the conflict between farmers and herders, leading to the catastrophic loss of lives, property, and livestock. The paper recommends the adoption of climate change adaptation and mitigation, conflict resolution and peacebuilding, and integrated policy and planning strategies to enhance climate resilience and effectively manage the conflict.

**Keywords:** Climate change, conflict, farmers-herders, adaptation, resource scarcity, Northeast Nigeria.

## Introduction

Climate change is an urgent global challenge in the 21st century, attracting significant international attention due to its profound effects on human security, conflict dynamics, and patterns of displacement worldwide. International politics reflects the recognition of climate change as a primary environmental and developmental threat. It was first discussed in the World's political forum in 1988, when the World Meteorological Organization (WMO) and the United Nations Environment Program (UNEP) established the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC). This expert body would assess scientific information on climate change. Every part of the world is bedeviled by one aspect of climate change abuse or the other. It could be drought, desertification, ocean encroachment, erosion, flood, earthquake, landslide, pollution, and others. Over the years, due to climate change, the Sub-Saharan

African region has experienced a significant reduction in rainfall, resulting in the shrinking of Lake Chad, a vital water source for millions of people. This region has also experienced significant temperature increases, changing precipitation patterns, drought, and desertification, directly and indirectly affecting the current conflict between farmers and herders (Sweijs, Adger et al., 2022).

In a similar vein, experts predicted that Nigeria's climate is likely to see growing shifts in temperature, rainfall, storms, and sea levels throughout the twenty-first century and that poor adaptive responses to these shifts could help fuel violent conflict in some areas of the country. Lake Chad's current situation is the effect of climate change. It has brought massive famine as a result of low agricultural activities, unbridled migration, and even unemployment, which to a large extent have contributed to conflict in the North East region of the country, including that of Boko Haram that is currently ravaging Nigeria as a nation. The water level of Lake Chad was considered normal at 40.3 km3 before 1970; however, between 1970 and 1975, the lake started experiencing untold drought that led to its reduction in size (27.3 km3). Subsequently, from the 1980s through the 1990s, the size of the lake took another dramatic decrease to 17.7km3 and 12.7 km3, respectively. The adverse impacts of malnutrition due to climate effects are pronounced in Northeast Nigeria, where the region already grapples with high rates of malnutrition and child stunting. Over a million children in the northeast are acutely malnourished (Olugbode, 2023).

Recently, climate change has gained global attention as never before due to the problems it has triggered around the world. Nigeria, in particular, is experiencing the adverse effects of climate change, evident in the occurrence of drought and desertification, especially in the northern parts of the country, which are arid regions (Salihu, 2020). Subsistence farmers and pastoralists who are unable to access better technologies and improved agricultural practices are at the receiving end of these climate risks. Climate change affects the availability of pasture and water for animal consumption and is also responsible for droughts, desertification, extreme cold, and storms. Lakes are drying up, and there is a decline in river flow in the northern region of Nigeria. There is less water available for agricultural purposes like crop production and maintaining pasture for cattle rearing. When pastoralists are short-changed by these basic needs for their cattle due to climate change, it is common to find them moving from the far north down to the North Central in search of better environmental and weather conditions. This migration, usually for adaptation purposes, creates problems for the receiving communities. This kind of encroachment, according to Odoh and Chigozie, could engender conflict given the pressure on land, food shortage, conflicts of interest, cultural differences, overpopulation, social disorganization, and religious and cultural intolerance.

The farmers-herders' conflict is one of the most crucial problems that have bedeviled Nigeria at the moment. The conflict not only directly impacted the lives or livelihoods of those involved, but also disrupted and threatened the sustainability of agricultural and pastoral production and, invariably, the sustainability of rural communities' livelihoods in Nigeria, including the north-eastern part of the country. This conflict has a long history and has taken a different dimension in recent years, leading to widespread violence, displacement from the original place of residence, and the proliferation of small and light arms between the two parties. The conflict is primarily driven by the scramble for land, water, and resources as well

as ethnic and religious affiliations, reducing these areas into war zones as they try to clinch the right to use the land (Thalheimer & Webersik, 2020).

Conversely, climate change has consciously and unconsciously continued to define the nature of the conflict between farmers and herders, with associated environmental pressure directly linked to the competition and stress between the groups involved in North-east Nigeria; as resources decrease and the human population increases, migration and social fragmentation intensify. Addressing the intersection of changing climate and global food security requires a comprehensive approach involving evidence-based strategies, policy formulation, and collaborative efforts (Raimi, Vivien, & Oluwatoyin, 2021). The current conflict between farmers and herders in the north-east geopolitical zone of Nigeria can indeed be examined within the premises of this natural condition triggered by climate change. No doubt, the damages to the Earth's ozone layer and the attendant effects of climate change have been precipitated by the unprecedented global increase in material needs, such as food, shelter, clothes, and other technical apparatus, which has often necessitated the use of various harmful chemicals to advance the cause of modern society.

Against this background, the study examined the impact of climate change on farmers-herders conflict in northeast Nigeria. This is because the influence of climate change on the conflict in Northeast Nigeria is significant and multifaceted, exacerbating existing tensions and contributing to the complex interplay of factors that drive violence and instability in the region. Agriculture and pastoralism are two of the most vulnerable sectors that suffer the ramifications of climate change. The impact is even stronger in areas where agriculture and pastoralism are vital for daily subsistence and where adaptive capacity is low.

**Statement of Problem**

This paper examined the inherent effects of climate change on farmers-herders conflict in Northeast Nigeria. This problematic issue is anchored on the assertion that there is a nexus between climate change and conflict in Northeast Nigeria. This is prompted by concern that the environmental effects of climate change, such as floods, desertification, drought, and depletion of natural resources, will create conditions that increase the risk of violent conflict between farmers and herders. Climate change acts as a 'threat multiplier' that makes existing concerns, such as water scarcity and food insecurity, more complex and intractable. It plays a key role in human insecurity and is expected to do so even more in the future as its impacts manifest themselves. According to Nhemachena et al. (2020), these climatic anomalies have significantly disrupted planting and harvesting cycles, particularly in regions reliant on rain-fed agriculture. This is particularly critical in sub-Saharan Africa, where over 95% of cultivated land depends on rainfall rather than irrigation, rendering agricultural productivity highly vulnerable to climatic fluctuations. Similarly, the impact of climate change on farmers, herders, and agricultural activities has become a serious issue of concern in Northeast Nigeria.

However, as a result of unsustainable environmental practices such as greenhouse gas emissions, bush burning, and deforestation, humanity has been experiencing resource

scarcity, which accentuates the conflict between farmers and herders, leading to the catastrophic loss of lives and properties as well as livestock. Still, the farmers-herders' conflict is one of the most crucial problems that have bedeviled Nigeria at the moment. The conflict not only directly impacted the lives or livelihoods of those involved, but has also disrupted and threatened the sustainability of agricultural and pastoral production and, invariably, the sustainability of the livelihoods of rural communities in Nigeria. These conflicts have a terrible impact on the economy of the country, which is already suffering from food shortages and insecurity as well as constant price rises for food. Against this backdrop, therefore, the paper examined the link between climate change and farmers-herders' conflict. Although researchers have investigated related issues with a vast body of literature focusing on climate change and its impacts on developing countries of Africa, especially Nigeria, little is known about the impact of climate change on farmers-herders conflict in the north-east, a gap this study intends to fill.

**Methodology**

The study used a descriptive qualitative approach to data collection and analysis. Secondary sources of data collection were relied upon in the research. Data were obtained from journals, textbooks, reports, and internet sources. The data obtained were discussed and addressed the theme of the research, which is to contribute to the discourse on the impact of climate change on farmers-herders conflict in northeast Nigeria.

**Theoretical Framework: Human Needs Theory (HNT)**

This paper adopts the Human Needs Theory (HNT) (1943) as propounded by scholars such as Abraham Maslow, John Burton, Marshall Rosenberg, and Manfred Max-Neef. However, for this paper, emphasis will be given to John Burton's strand or perspective of the Human Needs Theory. Human Needs Theory contends that in order to live and attain well-being, humans need certain essentials. These are called human needs or basic human needs. Human needs theorists argue that unmet human needs cause conflicts and violent conflicts. Violence occurs when certain individuals or groups do not see any other way to meet their needs, or when they require understanding, respect, and consideration for their needs. Indeed, violence is a tragic expression of unmet human needs, implying that all actions undertaken by human beings are attempts to satisfy their needs. If we can connect with our needs and those of others, we will therefore be able to look at other ways of meeting such needs, avoiding violence and destruction. Indeed, this theory justifies that the conflict between farmers and pastoralists is a product of unmet needs.

This theory is pivotal because Needs, unlike interests, cannot be traded, suppressed, or bargained for. Thus, the human needs approach makes a case for turning away from traditional negotiation models that do not take into account nonnegotiable issues. These include interest-based negotiation models that view conflict in terms of win-win or other consensus-based solutions and conventional power models (primarily used in the field of negotiation and international relations) that construct conflict and conflict management in terms of factual and zero-sum game perspectives.

## Relevance of the Theory to the Study

In relation to this study, this theory assumes that violence is a tragic expression of unmet human needs, implying that all actions undertaken by human beings are attempts to satisfy their needs. Using this paradigm to explain constant violent confrontations in Northeast Nigeria, where farmers and herders are scrambling for scarce resources such as fertile land, green pasture, water, and areas with favorable temperatures to fulfill their basic needs. From the human needs theory, climate change leads to the loss of means of livelihood through an increase in extreme events such as droughts and desertification. Loss of means of sustenance, in this case grazing land and water sources for the cattle, influences migration decisions by herders. Migration, in turn, leads to pressure and competition over limited resources, among other things, and ultimately to conflict. Unlike the common explanation that clashes between herders and farmers are ethno-religious, this pathway offers a new perspective on how resource scarcity and the need for survival can engender conflict.

## Conceptual Clarifications

It is germane to clarify some of the basic concepts related to the study; such concepts are climate change, farmers, herders, and conflict, before engaging in the extensive issue of the impact of climate change on farmers-herders conflict.

## Climate Change

Climate change amplifies environmental pressures such as severe weather conditions, droughts, floods, and desertification in Nigeria, resulting in livelihood losses, property damage, and disruption of ecosystems (Adeniyi & Fasona, 2020). These environmental adversities disproportionately impact vulnerable communities, particularly those residing in coastal areas, arid regions, and flood-prone zones, where reliance on natural resources is high for sustenance. Climate change is caused by human activities that have resulted in an increased concentration of greenhouse gases in our atmosphere, including carbon dioxide, water vapor, methane, ozone, and nitrous oxide. Human activities that result in the release of these greenhouse gases well beyond natural levels include things like deforestation, burning of fossil fuels, changes in wetland construction, and so forth.

## Conflict

Conflict may be defined as a struggle or contest between people with opposing needs, ideas, beliefs, values, or goals, and also as a result of scarce resources. As such, conflict is normal, ubiquitous, and unavoidable. It is an inherent feature of human existence. It is even useful on occasion. It is difficult to conceive of a conflict-free situation. Indeed, the very presence of conflict is at the heart of all human societies. The term ‘conflict’ has been variously conceptualized. However, the multiplicity of definitions has always pointed to one fact: that conflict is an enduring aspect of social existence. It is believed that wherever a community of individuals is found, conflict is basically a part of their experiences. Thus, most conflicts are

social in character and usually arise as human beings pursue their different survival and security needs (Agada & Yakubu, 2022).

**Farmer**

A farmer is a person engaged in agriculture, raising living organisms for food or raw materials. The term usually applies to people who do some combination of raising field crops, orchards, vineyards, poultry, or other livestock. A farmer might own the farmed land or might work as a laborer on land owned by others, but in advanced economies, a farmer is usually a farm owner, while employees of the farm are known as farm workers or farmhands. The word farmer was originally used to describe a tenant paying a leasehold rent (a farm), often for holding a lord's manorial demesne. Without farmers, climate effects are leading to widespread crop damage in regions previously unaffected (FAO, 2021).

**Herders**

Herders are people who live mostly in dry and remote areas. Their livelihoods depend on their intimate knowledge of the surrounding ecosystem and on the well-being of their livestock. Pastoral systems take many forms and are adapted to particular natural, political, and economic environments. (Ekanem, 2022). The types of livestock kept by herders vary according to climate, environment, water and other natural resources, and geographical area. They may include camels, goats, sheep, yaks, horses, llamas, alpacas, reindeer and vicunas. In this paper, a herder keeps only animals as the main economic activity.

**Desertification**

Desertification is another critical environmental issue facing Northeast Nigeria, driven by climate change and human activities. Climate change contributes to desertification through increased temperature and decreased precipitation, which alter soil moisture dynamics and promote the spread of arid conditions (Okpara et al., 2016). Human activities, such as deforestation, overgrazing, and unsustainable agricultural practices, further exacerbate desertification by degrading the land and reducing its capacity to support vegetation and biodiversity (Okpara et al., 2016). Desertification has profound implications for the livelihoods of millions of people in Northeast Nigeria, as the process reduces the availability of productive land for agriculture, pastoralism, and other ecosystem services. The increasing scarcity of fertile land has intensified competition between land user groups, including farmers and pastoralists, and has contributed to the region's ongoing conflict (Okpara et al., 2016). Climate change in Northeast Nigeria, as evidenced by rising temperatures, changing precipitation patterns, and desertification, has significant implications for the region's environmental, social, and economic conditions. These climate change-induced stressors have contributed to resource scarcity and competition, thereby exacerbating the ongoing conflict and instability between farmers and herders in northeast Nigeria.

**Temperature increases**

Over the past several decades, Northeast Nigeria has experienced a consistent rise in temperatures, with average annual increases of approximately 0.4°C since the 1960s. This trend aligns with the broader pattern of global warming caused by human activities, such as greenhouse gas emissions from fossil fuel consumption, deforestation, and land-use changes. The increase in temperature has had numerous adverse effects on the region's environmental, social, and economic conditions. The rising temperatures have exacerbated water scarcity by increasing evaporation rates and reducing water availability for agriculture, human consumption, and ecosystem services (Ayanlade et al., 2022).

**Interconnection between Climate Change and Conflict in Nigeria**

Climate change and conflict represent intertwined global challenges that profoundly affect the socioeconomic and environmental fabric of nations worldwide, including Nigeria. Climate factors can influence both individual and group conflicts. At the individual level, climatic conditions like extreme temperatures can heighten aggression and violent behavior by impacting individuals' thoughts, emotions, and irritability (Ide et al., 2020). There is consensus that climate change could reinforce existing conflict patterns, particularly in already fragile regions or those with ethnic divisions (Burke et al, 2015). In Nigeria, climate change exacerbates environmental stressors such as extreme weather events, droughts, floods, and desertification, disrupting ecosystems and depleting natural resources. These challenges contribute to resource scarcity, livelihood loss, and socio-economic vulnerabilities, particularly in rural areas reliant on agriculture and natural resource extraction for survival. Competition for dwindling resources often escalates into conflicts over land, water, and grazing rights, especially between sedentary farmers and nomadic herders (Ekanem, 2022).

Climate-induced displacement and migration exacerbate social tensions and inter-communal conflicts as displaced populations vie for scarce resources and face discrimination and marginalization in host communities. A growing body of research by Behnassi, Gupta, Kruidbos, and Parlow (2022) analyses the interplay between climate extremes and conflict dynamics, focusing on the social, political, and economic consequences that can destabilize and reshape societies. The impacts of climate-induced conflict in Nigeria extend beyond immediate casualties and physical destruction (Fayomi, Adigun, Bako, & Bamidele-Ifedayo, 2021). Conflict undermines human security, disrupts social cohesion, and impedes economic development, perpetuating cycles of poverty, inequality, and instability. Displacement, whether internal or cross-border, exacerbates vulnerability and marginalization among affected populations, hindering access to basic needs such as food, water, shelter, healthcare, and education. Moreover, conflicts over natural resources impede sustainable development efforts, obstruct investments in infrastructure and social services, and hinder peace and reconciliation initiatives.

## Impacts of Climate Change on Farmers-Herders Conflict in Northeast Nigeria

The impacts of climate change on the conflict in Northeast Nigeria, especially farmers-herders conflict, can be observed through various pathways. First, resource scarcity induced by climate change can exacerbate tensions between communities, leading to competition for resources such as water, land, and grazing areas (Gleick, 2014). As the availability of these resources declines, communities may increasingly turn to violence to secure their livelihoods, further entrenching the cycle of conflict. Second, climate change can contribute to the proliferation of extremist groups like Boko Haram by creating conditions that enable their recruitment and radicalization efforts (Ide, 2017). In the context of Northeast Nigeria, poverty, food insecurity, and lack of education make individuals more susceptible to radical ideologies, providing a breeding ground for extremism. Still, climate change can undermine state capacity and governance, making it more difficult for governments to respond effectively to conflict (Brzoska, 2015). The Nigerian government has been struggling to address the crisis in the Northeast, as limited resources are stretched thin across numerous competing priorities, such as disaster management, infrastructure development, and public service provision. Thus, the socio-economic ramifications of climate change in Northeast Nigeria are substantial and pervasive, influencing agriculture, food security, livelihoods, and public health. These intertwined consequences further intensify existing vulnerabilities and contribute to the region's enduring conflict and instability. Furthermore, conflicts over scarce resources like land, water, and grazing rights exacerbate displacement drivers, compelling communities to flee due to violence, insecurity, and social unrest (Ajiboye & Azeez, 2021).

## Review of Related Literature on the Nexus between Climate Change and Conflict in Nigeria

Several experts have investigated the effects of Nigeria's changing climate on various sectors of the economy. Okon, Falana, Solaja, Yakubu, Alabi, Okikiola and Edeme (2021) caution that the impacts of global warming and climate change in Nigeria are currently a cause for concern among individuals, institutions, businesses, governments, environmentalists, trade organizations, and policymakers. They observe that climate change effects in the country often manifest as shifts in weather patterns, including unusually heavy rainfall and unexpected temperature rises, leading to significant changes in different parts of the nation, such as rising sea levels in coastal areas and an increase in extreme weather events. Sweijs, De Haan and Van Manen (2022) disclosed climate change's role as a threat that increases pre-existing vulnerabilities and tensions, especially in regions with weak governance structures and livelihoods dependent on natural resources.

Studies by Salihu (2020) have emphasized how environmental pressures, including alterations in rainfall patterns and land deterioration, can worsen existing socio-economic gaps and provoke disputes over natural resources in Nigeria. Additionally, research by Anthonia, Bello, Oliatan, and Macaulay (2021) has shown how climate-induced displacement can heighten social tensions and compromise human security, especially among vulnerable groups like farmers, herders, and marginalized communities.

Regan and Kim (2020) emphasize the links between environmental pressures, resource scarcity, and violent conflict. Competition for water, land, and other natural resources frequently acts as a trigger for communal clashes, conflicts between farmers and herders, and ethno-religious violence in Nigeria. Regarding the nexus between climate change, conflict, and human security in Nigeria, scholars such as Mwanzia (2024) and Felli (2017) stress the negative effects of climate-induced displacement on individuals' well-being, livelihoods, and social cohesion. Vulnerable populations are at increased risk of conflict, poverty, food insecurity, and marginalization due to displacement caused by climate change.

Ndubuisi (2018) analyzed conflicts between herders and farmers in Nigeria, with attention to the causes and the socio-religious and political effects on national development. The study indicates a high level of carnage in human and material resources, an unimaginable number of Internally Displaced Persons (IDP's) who are dislocated from their homes. It concludes that the situation has hampered development and consequently, threatened the peace and security of the country as an indivisible geographical entity. The herders' and farmers' violent actions have put more strain on the disjointed ethnic diversity of the nation because of a deficiency of political will by the government to punish culprits as the law stipulates. In a related manner, Anastasia (2018) in her study on the structural and processual factors which contribute to the increasing farmer herders‟ conflict in the Ukpabi-Nimbo community of Enugu state, with the aid of the qualitative method of data collection revealed that there is no single factor that can be pointed out as the causes rather a multifaceted issues, ranging from climate change to resource depletion; lack of freshwater to effects of cattle rustlers among others.

Lere, Ola, and Temitope (2017) conducted a study titled Climate change, pastoral migration, resource governance, and security: the Grazing Bill solution to the farmer-herder conflict in Nigeria." They concluded that climate change is a fact and has significant effects on human security through its antagonistic effects on pastoral livelihoods; they contend that migration and conflict go beyond this causal narrative. The combination of socio-historical factors provides a backdrop to the farmer-herder conflict in Nigeria amid a continuous decline in the natural resource base and increasing contention for land and its related resources. It is obvious from Lere (2017) that the increase in farmers' claims to rightful land ownership as a heritage bequeathed from their ancestors, and the counterclaim to the right of access to natural resources endowed by nature, complicates the conflict, and not necessarily because of depletion. This has been the case in Nigeria, as herders claim the right to settle and also graze wherever they want without permission.

Eje et al. (2017) investigated the pattern and consequences of farmer-herder conflicts in the Riyom local government area of Plateau State, Nigeria. According to the findings, conflicts between herders and farmers are caused by several factors, including damage to crops by cattle, land encroachment by farmers, inadequate grazing reserves, lack of access to water points and pollution of water points, killing of stray cattle, indiscriminate bush burning, cattle rustling, non-adherence to rules and regulations that guide forest reserves. It further established that these conflicts have far-reaching effects on the people and polity, such as destruction of farms, loss of cattle and loss of crop yield, destruction of places of worship,

destruction of houses, schools, health care facilities, strained relationships and loss of trust, and loss of lives.

Furthermore, conflicts over scarce resources like land, water, and grazing rights exacerbate displacement drivers, compelling communities to flee due to violence, insecurity, and social unrest (Ajiboye & Azeez, 2021). Displaced individuals encounter difficulties accessing fundamental necessities such as food, water, shelter, healthcare, and education as they abandon their homes, lands, and livelihoods (Adeniyi & Fasona, 2020). Additionally, displacement exacerbates poverty, inequality, and gender disparities, with women, children, and marginalized segments bearing disproportionate impacts and facing elevated risks of exploitation, abuse, and trafficking.

**Conclusion**

Climate change has become a long-standing major factor contributing to conflict between farmers and herders in northeast Nigeria. The adverse impacts of climate change, including disruptions to agricultural production, food insecurity, adverse effects on human health, and changes in migration patterns, are increasingly affecting economic activities such as fishing, farming, herding; brought about unemployment, unbridled migration coupled with lack of committed leadership to resuscitate and manage the lake which is critical for promoting employment for the teeming population around the Northeast region of Nigeria. The region has become vulnerable to climate change due to its heavy reliance on rain-fed agriculture, which is increasingly threatened by extreme weather events, such as droughts, floods, and heat waves. Farmers-herders conflicts, being a common feature of economic livelihood in Northern Nigeria, have been identified as a threat to peaceful coexistence, security, and orderliness. Climate change, along with its attendant consequences, has subjected both groups to an intensified struggle for scarce resources. In this regard, in northeast Nigeria, climate change exacerbates environmental stressors such as extreme weather events, droughts, floods, and desertification, disrupting ecosystems and depleting natural resources. These challenges contribute to resource scarcity, livelihood loss, and socio-economic vulnerabilities, particularly in rural areas reliant on agriculture and natural resource extraction for survival. Competition for dwindling resources often escalates into conflicts over land, water, and grazing rights, especially between farmers and herders.

**Recommendations**

The following recommendations are made to assess the menace of climate change and its impact on farmers-herders conflict in northeast Nigeria as enumerated below:

i. To address the nexus between climate change and conflict in northeast Nigeria, the government should encourage and support farmers through the provision of credit facilities as well as soft loans to enable them to concentrate on their farming activities, since a reduction in farming, fishing, livestock rearing, and other agricultural activities has fuelled Unemployment in the northeast.

ii. There should be comprehensive and multidimensional approaches that integrate environmental sustainability, through investments in climate resilience, disaster risk reduction, conflict resolution mechanisms, peacebuilding initiatives, and sustainable development strategies prioritizing the needs and rights of affected populations.

iii. Climate change strategies should be context-specific, prioritizing agricultural improvement, water management, livelihood diversification, low-carbon development, and enhanced resource management.

iv. There should be fostering collaboration, dialogue, and cooperation among stakeholders and those at local, national, and regional levels for enhancing resilience, promoting peace, and advancing sustainable development amid climate-induced challenges.

v. There should be an interface between military and civilian security forces to check the spread of insurgency in such an environment.

vi. There should be attempts to improve the environment through ecological activities and general infrastructural development.

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# GOOD GOVERNANCE AND SECURITY SECTOR REFORMS IN NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** Good governance is crucial for security sector reform, especially in Nigeria, where insecurity has persisted, requiring urgent institutional reforms. The study examined the nexus between the principles of good governance and security sector reform. The objective of the study is to interrogate how the quality of governance shapes the effectiveness, accountability, and legitimacy of security institutions in Nigeria. The study adopted the Desk Research Method, where data and relevant information were sourced from a range of scholarly journal articles, authoritative textbooks, and reputable online resources. The key findings revealed that security sector reform efforts have been obstructed by high-level corruption, weak civilian oversight, and political interference, all of which have often undermined the objectives of security sector reform in Nigeria. The consequences have been persistent insecurity across the country and, of course, erosion of public trust. Personal observations highlighted some conflict-torn areas in Nigeria. The study concluded that sustainable security in Nigeria will be enhanced when a robust SSR framework is deliberately entrenched as a major policy of democratic governance in Nigeria. Furthermore, the study recommended that governance-driven reform mechanisms be institutionalized to promote accountability, transparency, professionalism, and inclusive oversight in all security agencies for effective and efficient outcomes.

**Keywords:** Good governance, security, security sector reform, administration, Nigeria.

## Introduction

For over two decades now, Nigeria has witnessed persistent threats to national security, including insurgency, terrorism, communal violence, and organized crime. An insurgency that began in Borno State (Northeastern region) of Nigeria in 2009 started with the Boko Haram sect. Nigeria has perpetually faced persistent security challenges that call for effective security sector reforms (SSR). These reforms are targeted at achieving transparency, efficiency, accountability, and democratic oversight of institutions like the military, police, and intelligence agencies amid threats such as insurgency, banditry, and communal conflicts (Moses & Sunday, 2025). This suggests that Nigeria's security landscape is marked by intense insurgency ranging from kidnapping and ethnic clashes, straining overstretched institutions. Corruption, poor oversight, and opaque budgeting exacerbate operational failures and erode public trust (Chatham House, 2026).

Without the rule of law and the capacity of the state to provide security for its citizens, there cannot be good governance. Hence, Nigeria is a critical site of perpetual insecurity requiring conscious and deliberate restructuring of its security architecture to overcome the security threats posed by terrorists. Security sector reform will no doubt provide a safe and stable environment for political and economic growth. This entails reforming the military, police, and other paramilitary agencies, as well as intelligence, by making them more professional, transparent, and accountable, and by strengthening civil oversight mechanisms for the security sector.

Security Sector Reform efforts in Nigeria can be traced back to post-military rule transitions, including officer retirements and legislative monitoring under democratic governments. Recent initiatives emphasize national ownership, transparency, and addressing root causes like poverty and inequality. Security sector reforms are pivotal in uniting security, development, and governance for human wellbeing. The evolution and activities of Boko Haram and their counterparts in Nigeria have heightened insurgency (Gibson, 2022).

These threats have led to massive movement of refugees and internally displaced persons, with several lives lost. There is also widespread violation of human rights, requiring the state to prioritize SSR. As a major component of peacebuilding, SSR aims to provide effective and legitimate public services, and a security sector in particular, that are transparent, accountable, and responsive to civil authority. Such reform is necessary to address the security challenges inherent in Nigeria's systemic governance deficits, as characterized by corruption, weak accountability, and centralized power structures. Holistic reforms will prioritize civilian oversight and equitable resource distribution.

In the Nigerian context, security sector reform scholarship already uses good governance language to evaluate reforms (e.g., policing, intelligence, joint task force, border management) in terms of their contribution to human security and democratic accountability. This framework has been utilized in analyzing how corruption, politicization of the security forces, weak legislative and judicial oversight, and limited citizen participation undermine both good governance and effective security provision (Gibson, 2022). This has been corroborated by Nnabuile (2023), who opined that security sector reform is increasingly being recognized as essential for sustainable peace and democratic consolidation.

## Conceptual Clarifications

The following key concepts have been conceptualized for better understanding of the discourse on good governance and security sector reforms. These concepts are:

### Good Governance

Governance and good governance occupy center-stage in global political and developmental discourse. Governance has replaced government in political science and policy circles (Hajer & Wagenaar, 2003). It has been the catchphrase of international financial institutions and donors concerned with the effectiveness of aid since the 1990s. Good governance is a recent term reflecting citizens' new expectations of governing actors (Druke, 2007). As a matter of fact, Huther and Shah (2005) posit that the quality of governance is determined by the impact of exercising authority through formal and informal institutions in the management of state resources on the quality of life enjoyed by citizens. In effect, good governance demands a commitment to promote human rights and ensure that government actions are consistently scrutinized to prevent abuse of power. To achieve this, more robust policy enforcement institutions can be put in place to enhance sustainable development, protect citizens' welfare, and foster lasting national progress.

Good governance is a multifaceted concept central to public administration and political science, emphasizing principles like transparency, accountability, the rule of law, participation, and efficiency to enhance state legitimacy and development outcomes. It hinges on eight major pillars, including participatory decision-making, transparency, responsiveness, equity, the rule of law, accountability, effectiveness and efficiency, and conscious orientation (Rahim, 2019). This conscious orientation is meant to foster a government that serves the public interest effectively. The pillars ensure that citizens are not only informed and engaged in decision-making processes but also that their needs are met through systems that are both accountable and responsive.

**Security Sector Reform (SSR)**

Security sector reform is a process by which countries formulate, re-orient or develop the policies, structures, and capacities of institutions and groups engaged in the security sector, in order to make them more effective, efficient, and responsive to democratic control, and to allow them to better respond to the security and justice challenges confronting the state and its population. It is used in different contexts and focuses, such as security sector governance, security sector transformation, security sector development, security sector review, and security system reform as well (AU, 2020).

Security sector reform involves repositioning the institutions and agencies of the state responsible for the provision of security for optimum and efficient service delivery. Generally, it consists of a set of policies, programs, and activities undertaken by a series of stakeholders to improve the way the state or governing body provides safety, security, and justice to its civilian population within the context of the rule of law. Simply, the security sector consists of all the institutions of the state that are vested with the responsibility for securing the state and its population from fear of violence. They comprise the armed forces, the police and intelligence services, the related ministries and departments, paramilitary agencies, and governmental oversight organizations.

According to Wulf (2004), security sector reform is the transformation of the security system, which includes all the actors, their roles, responsibilities, and actions, so that it is managed and operated in a manner that is more consistent with democratic norms and sound principles of good governance, and thus contributes to a well-functioning security framework. Responsible and accountable security forces reduce the risk of conflict, provide security for citizens, and create the right environment for sustainable development. Security sector reform addresses security problems and tries to improve the situation through institutional reforms. Security and peace are seen as a public good (Mendez, 1999). Society as a whole, as well as its individual members, benefit from increased security. Therefore, security sector reform should be understood as a broad concept that requires more efficient use of scarce resources to improve security.

Democratic, civilian control over security forces is crucial for providing security in the interests of the population. Democratic decision-making requires transparency and accountability. Thus, the public at large needs to be involved. It is pertinent to note that democratization is no guarantee of improved security because democratization has been associated with rising political violence. It grants citizens the right to challenge established privileges and raises political expectations which are not always fulfilled (Luckham, 2003). The most significant benefit of security sector reform to the citizens is tied to quality political leadership that is interested in the welfare and well-being of its people. This is in addition to making adequate budgetary allocations for security equipment, training, and welfare of personnel.

**Literature Review**

Security sector reform is germane in all forms of governance; however, most African governments are considered the weakest in terms of mitigating corruption in the security sector, and this diminishes public trust in government and threatens national and regional security (George et al, 2020). Allegations of corruption in the security sector, as reported by Transparency International, show that very high levels of corruption risk exist in several governments in Africa.

Available literature on security sector reform, which has influenced this policy agenda, places greater emphasis on the “governance” dimension, which is Western models of security governance. This is due to a belief that a security sector governed according to democratic norms is the foundation for state security actions that are responsive to the needs of citizens. However, for many African countries, attaining democratic security governance is a long-term challenge, leaving African countries with difficult concessions to manage between short-term capability enhancements and longer-term institutional reforms (African Union, 2020).

In simple terms, governance is the exercise of political, economic and administrative authority in the management of a country’s affairs at all levels. To attain good governance and

security sector reform initiatives, African countries will have to collaborate closely with external partners. Africa must play a more active role in conceptualizing and driving its own SSR processes if they are to be truly locally owned and sustainable. This is both a practical and political necessity because without local approaches, African practitioners will continue to rely on external sources of inspiration and models. These models may not be suitable in the African context because they may infringe on African sovereignty in the security domain (Ball & Fayemi, 2005).

In Nigeria, during the Obasanjo administration, the government ensured that the National Assembly's legislative oversight gave special attention to the defense budget by scrutinizing and passing appropriate legislation in accordance with constitutional oversight powers. These steps gave rise to the formulation and enactment of the nation's National Defense Policy in 2006, though not without challenges. The security sector reform was meant to help Nigeria achieve its strategic security objectives. Records have it that the late President Umaru Musa Yar'adua/Goodluck Ebele Jonathan's joint presidency tinkered with the reforms to a reasonable extent. However, the efforts of the duo did not achieve much as a result of the ill-health and the subsequent passing of the president in 2010 (Aiyede, 2015 cited in Uzuegbu-Wilson, 2019).

Public accountability and transparency are critical challenges for African security sectors. There is evidence that, out of 45 African countries that publish a budget document, 28 provided no actual document (Tian, 2020). In fact, there is little or no engagement over budgets between security sector and civilian leaders. The point is that several African countries lack effective legislative oversight of the security sector, and this hampers security forces from achieving their mission. Unprofessionalism and impunity have continued to thrive within the security sector because of the absence of effective accountability, and this has degraded the capabilities of security forces.

According to Benson et al. (2019), oversight and accountability of the security sector ensure that the government can manage security organizations effectively and efficiently. This step helps in building trust in the defense and security forces. The security sector is guided by the principles of subordination to democratic civilian authority, allegiance to the constitution, commitment to political neutrality, and an ethical institutional culture.

The importance of security sector reform and governance is gaining global attention, especially because of the increase in asymmetric wars. In fact, countries are now prioritizing the security sector by providing equipment, training, and the general welfare of troops. Numerous unserviceable platforms in the military are being rehabilitated, or new ones are being procured. This will boost military morale to carry out their assigned tasks and responsibilities without inhibitions. The efforts of various oversight bodies may have contributed to this general improvement. Military budgets now undergo the normal process in the National Assembly before approval, as against the previous practice where a Service

Chief could walk to the Head of State to present his requirements and get it approved (Alao, 2000).

Basically speaking, the concept of the "security sector" connotes the entire society and its institutions, and its reform therefore implies and requires changes in the way of security thinking and practicing. It also demands changes in the constitutional and institutional arrangements in the system. There should be established and developed democratic civil control over the armed forces at all times. This entails redefining the purpose and tasks of each component of the armed forces and corresponding changes in their structure, training, equipment, and numerical size. Finally, this ensures various forms of international security cooperation and a higher degree of security integration (Kuhlmann & Callaghan, 2000).

Security reform is generally applicable to the armed forces in addition to their traditional constituents, the army and the police, including all state bodies authorized to carry and use arms or force. This comprises border units, secret services, financial police, special antiterrorist units, customs, court and correctional officers. To all these we should add the formations that emerged from the current privatization of parts of the security sector and armed forces (Damian & Michael, 2002).

**Governance Mechanisms and Parliamentary Oversight on Security Matters**

The oversight processes include collecting information from the Executive and security institutions. This can be achieved through annual meetings to discuss security issues, activity reports, field visits to undertake on-the-spot assessments, and organizing parliamentary hearings. Second, engage in dialogue with the Executive to seek explanations. This can be achieved through multi-stakeholder consultations, questions and answers, debates in committees, and public hearings. Third, making recommendations or changing laws through debates on reports in plenary, public hearings, questions and answers, and the production of reports. Fourth, monitoring and evaluation of how laws and recommendations are implemented. This can be done through debates in committees, production of reports, and debates on reports in plenary (Geneva: DCAF, 2019).

According to Roux and Ball (cited in Omitoogun & Hutchful, 2006), the military is a unique sector that thrives in confidentiality concerning national security questions. Again, its operational approaches are characterized by a politically discreet process about decisions relating to the procurement of arms and other war materials associated with the military and the security sector in general. It is imperative to note that secrecy laws could hinder efforts to enhance transparency in the security sector. This condition prevails more in emerging democracies and nations that are locked in divisive conflicts and war. Although secrecy laws may be necessary to safeguard vital security facts and details that otherwise could compromise national security, they may compromise transparency and accountability. Such secrecy laws could also jeopardize parliamentary oversight of the sector (Fluri et tal, 2003). It

is alleged that the Freedom of Information Bill exempts the security sector. This singular act is the major pitfall that gives the security sector the reason for non-adherence to internationally recognized standards in public expenditure management. Additionally, the lack of accountability and weak oversight enable corruption, impunity, and abuse of power within security agencies. Inadequate resources and training, including investment in personnel welfare, modern technology, and capacity-building, remain insufficient.

The policy implications for Nigeria would proffer deepening good governance in the country's security sector, and this requires moving beyond ad hoc responses toward a coherent, long-term reform agenda anchored in a national security policy that is periodically reviewed and publicly debated. Such an agenda should integrate development planning, conflict prevention, and human rights commitments, recognizing that socio-economic inequality, youth unemployment, and environmental stresses are drivers of insecurity as much as armed groups themselves. Ultimately, when security institutions operate transparently under democratic control, respect rights, and are responsive to citizens, they can regain legitimacy and become genuine instruments for consolidating peace, democracy, and development in Nigeria—key components of good governance relevant to Nigeria's security sector. How Nigeria has implemented security sector reforms since 2015 suggests the challenges hindering effective security sector reform in Nigeria.

## Methodology

For this study, data and relevant information were sourced from a range of scholarly journal articles, authoritative textbooks, and reputable online resources. These sources were carefully selected to provide a comprehensive understanding of the interplay between good governance and security sector reform in Nigeria.

## Recent Dimensions of Security Reform

Security sector management issues in Nigeria have continued to linger since independence because these issues are knitted into the politics of governance and the activities of civil society. All of this revolves around both military and human security, desiring to tackle the questions of development and conflict management. At the initial stage of the reform, the concept of security in Nigeria was militarized, thus placing the politics of reform under the control of officers who were only interested in protecting their position of power. With the return to democratic government, it was evident that the challenge was how well the security apparatus was managed to address the ethnic, social, economic, and political threats in the country (Abiodun, 2000). Considering the major task for security sector reform, Nigerian citizens have wished that the military remain professional by being apolitical. This means that the military must observe the supremacy of democratic institutions and also respect civilians and, of course, human rights.

A cursory glance at Nigeria's national security interest shows that it is epitomized by the strategy document, which underscores the generality of security and welfare of the Nigerian populace. Furthermore, it takes cognizance of other important variants of Nigeria's territorial integrity, justice system, equity, democratic consolidation and sustenance as well as increased economic growth. The hurdles for Nigeria's security sector reformers are that both internal security dynamics and sub-regional African security concerns must be aligned with global strategic interests. According to Nma, Idakula and Erunke (2018) as cited in Tsuwa (2018), national security is the most critical asset a nation must not compromise. The implication of this is that, where citizens feel threatened, the economy would also be insecure. The state must ensure the perpetual safety of its citizens by making them the referent point of security. Indeed, the Nigerian state has experienced a high magnitude of insecurity in recent times.

These new emerging threats have pushed Nigeria to expand SSR beyond traditional military and policing to include cyber and digital security. Legislative changes like amendments to the Cybercrimes Act aim to improve cybersecurity governance, require reporting of cyber incidents, and align with data protection standards, reflecting an attempt to integrate good governance principles into digital security regulation. These measures imply that effective security today includes protection of critical information infrastructure, financial systems, and personal data, alongside physical security (Ajayi, 2024).

Despite these efforts, several structural obstacles limit the impact of SSR in Nigeria, including entrenched corruption, patronage networks, and resistance to change within security institutions. Fragmentation of security responsibilities, overlapping mandates, and poor coordination among agencies impede coherent strategy and leave gaps exploited by armed groups. Aside from this, cases of extrajudicial killings, arbitrary detention, and violations by security agents who undermine human rights have been reported.

Entrenching democratic oversight through stronger roles for the National Assembly, State Assemblies, and independent oversight bodies will help scrutinize security policy, budgets, and procurement. Similarly, rebalancing security policy from state-centric to human security approaches will enhance the protection of civilians, socio-economic resilience, and conflict-sensitive development in vulnerable regions. It should be re-echoed that the issue of security sector management since Nigeria's independence has been tied to the politics of governance and to the activities of civil society. This encompasses both military and human security and involves questions of development and conflict management (Abiodun, 2000).

In a nutshell, security sector reform should promote greater transparency in security spending by enhancing public financial management, publishing detailed budget summaries, and ensuring that procurement processes are competitive and subject to independent audits. This will strengthen major justice and accountability institutions such as the judiciary, human rights commissions, and internal disciplinary bodies that are empowered to investigate abuses and provide remedies for victims. Furthermore, Security sector reforms will expand community-based security initiatives by actively involving traditional authorities, civil

society organizations, women's groups, and youth in early warning systems, dialogue processes, and local peacebuilding efforts, fostering a more inclusive and collaborative approach to security (ECOWAS, 2016). The outcome of this approach will not only improve security governance but also improve public trust by creating more resilient communities around the country.

## Conclusion and Recommendations

Good governance and security sector reform are fundamentally crucial in Nigeria's quest for peace, stability, and development. Nigeria's progress and development require political commitment, context-specific strategies, a peaceful society, and genuine participation by all stakeholders. Basically, sustainable security in Nigeria will be enhanced when a robust SSR framework is deliberately entrenched as a major policy of democratic governance in Nigeria. The study recommended the following:

i. The federal government should devolve security responsibilities by strengthening state and local governments' roles through constitutional amendments and the implementation of multi-level policing.

ii. The Nigerian government should utilize international support and technology to align its security reforms with global best practices and regional security frameworks. This will improve the effectiveness of the security sector, strengthen cooperation with international partners, and strengthen overall security and stability.

iii. Government at all levels should consider inclusivity in addressing the under-representation of women and minorities in security structures by ensuring reforms are participatory. The main benefit is that ensuring the participation of women and minorities in security structures will promote innovative and effective systems that adequately reflect and serve diverse communities. This will foster greater trust, reduce biases, strengthen social cohesion, and enhance lasting security and stability.

iv. Developmental policies that will facilitate Security Sector Reform, economic prosperity, education, and alleviate poverty are imperative for addressing socio-political roots of insecurity in Nigeria.

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# GRASSROOTS AUTHORITY AND PEACEBUILDING: TRADITIONAL INSTITUTIONS AND INTER-ETHNIC CONFLICT MANAGEMENT IN SOUTHERN TARABA, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** This study examines the role of traditional institutions in peacebuilding and inter-ethnic conflict management in Southern Taraba, Nigeria. Specifically, it investigates how traditional institutions contribute to conflict prevention, mediation, reconciliation, and the promotion of peaceful coexistence among diverse ethnic communities. Using a qualitative research design, data were collected through key informant interviews, documentary sources, and field observations. The findings reveal that traditional institutions serve as custodians of customary norms, mediators of land-related disputes, and symbols of communal identity, thereby playing a significant role in preventing the escalation of inter-ethnic conflicts. However, their peacebuilding efforts are constrained by political interference, declining traditional authority, inadequate resources, and the increasing complexity of contemporary conflicts. The study concludes that strengthening collaboration between traditional institutions, government agencies, and other community stakeholders is essential for sustainable peace in Southern Taraba. It recommends greater institutional support and policy recognition for traditional leaders to enhance their effectiveness in grassroots conflict management.

**Keywords:** Grassroots authority, traditional institutions, peacebuilding, inter-ethnic conflict management, Southern Taraba

## Introduction

Peacebuilding in contemporary African societies increasingly requires a multidimensional approach that combines formal state institutions with indigenous governance structures possessing long-standing legitimacy and community acceptance. Across many African societies, traditional institutions continue to play significant roles in promoting social order, mediating disputes, and fostering peaceful coexistence at the grassroots level. In Nigeria, where many communal conflicts are deeply rooted in historical grievances, ethnic identity, competition over land, and resource ownership, traditional institutions remain indispensable actors in conflict prevention and management.

Southern Taraba, comprising communities such as Wukari, Takum, Donga, Ussa, and Ibi, has experienced recurring episodes of inter-ethnic conflicts, communal violence, and herders–farmers clashes over the past two decades. These conflicts have resulted in loss of lives, destruction of property, displacement of populations, and disruption of socio-economic activities. Despite government interventions through security agencies and formal conflict management mechanisms, violence has continued to recur, revealing the limitations of state-centered approaches to peacebuilding. This situation has renewed scholarly and policy interest in the contributions of grassroots institutions, particularly traditional authorities, in preventing violence and promoting sustainable peace.

Traditional institutions, comprising chiefs, first-class rulers, district heads, clan leaders, and village heads, constitute the oldest and most respected governance structures in Southern Taraba. Their authority is derived from customary law, ancestral legitimacy, and community trust, enabling them to regulate social relationships, enforce customary norms, and mediate disputes. Because of their proximity to local communities and their intimate understanding of cultural values and historical relationships, traditional rulers often serve as the first point of intervention when disputes emerge. They facilitate dialogue, negotiate settlements over land and boundary disputes, promote reconciliation among conflicting groups, and mobilize community members towards peaceful coexistence.

The effectiveness of traditional institutions in peacebuilding is particularly evident in the management of inter-ethnic conflicts. Through palace councils, elders' forums, customary arbitration, and community reconciliation meetings, traditional authorities provide culturally acceptable mechanisms for resolving disputes before they escalate into violence. Their grassroots presence enables them to identify early warning signs of conflict, engage disputing parties promptly, and employ indigenous conflict resolution practices that are widely accepted within their communities. These culturally grounded approaches often complement formal government peace initiatives and contribute to strengthening social cohesion.

Despite their strategic importance, traditional institutions face numerous challenges that constrain their effectiveness in contemporary peacebuilding. Political interference, weakening customary authority, inadequate financial and institutional support, rapid socio-cultural change, youth disenchantment with traditional governance, and the proliferation of small arms have reduced their capacity to respond effectively to increasingly complex conflicts. Furthermore, changing patterns of migration, climate-induced resource competition, and evolving security threats have introduced dimensions of conflict that traditional mechanisms alone may find difficult to address.

Nevertheless, traditional institutions remain central to grassroots peacebuilding in Southern Taraba because they enjoy widespread legitimacy, possess extensive knowledge of local histories and customs, and command the confidence of diverse communities. Their ability to promote dialogue, restore damaged relationships, and facilitate reconciliation makes them indispensable partners in sustainable conflict management. Against this background, this

study examines the role of grassroots authority in peacebuilding by investigating how traditional institutions contribute to the management of inter-ethnic conflicts in Southern Taraba, Nigeria. The study further explores the strategies employed by these institutions, the challenges limiting their effectiveness, and measures required to strengthen their contributions to sustainable peace and community stability.

**Objectives of the Study**

The main objective of this study is to examine the role of grassroots authority in peacebuilding through traditional institutions in the management of inter-ethnic conflicts in Southern Taraba, Nigeria.

The specific objectives are to:

i. Examine the roles played by traditional institutions in promoting peacebuilding and managing inter-ethnic conflicts in Southern Taraba.

ii. Assess the mechanisms and strategies employed by traditional institutions in preventing, mediating, and resolving inter-ethnic conflicts.

iii. Examine the challenges facing traditional institutions in their peacebuilding and conflict management efforts in Southern Taraba.

iv. Identify measures for strengthening the capacity of traditional institutions to enhance sustainable peace and inter-ethnic harmony in Southern Taraba.

**Review of Related Literature**

**Traditional Institutions as Pillars of Grassroots Peacebuilding in Southern Taraba**

The role of traditional institutions in peacebuilding has attracted considerable scholarly attention, particularly in societies where formal state mechanisms face limitations in preventing and resolving communal conflicts. Across Africa, traditional institutions remain important custodians of indigenous governance systems, customary laws, and cultural values that promote social cohesion and peaceful coexistence. Scholars such as Zartman (2019) argue that indigenous institutions possess culturally embedded mechanisms for dialogue, mediation, reconciliation, and consensus-building, making them valuable actors in community-based peacebuilding. Similarly, Osaghae and Suberu (2005) observe that in plural societies such as Nigeria, traditional institutions continue to provide legitimate channels for resolving disputes involving ethnicity, land ownership, identity, and communal boundaries.

Traditional institutions derive their legitimacy from history, ancestry, and communal acceptance rather than statutory authority. This legitimacy enables traditional rulers, district heads, clan leaders, and village heads to mediate disputes and maintain social order through customary norms and indigenous conflict resolution practices. Folorunso (n.d.) and Nsama (2025) argue that because these institutions command widespread community trust, they are often more effective than formal legal systems in resolving local disputes. Their authority is particularly significant in rural communities where customary law remains the primary framework regulating access to land, natural resources, and communal relationships.

The literature further emphasizes the strategic role of traditional institutions in addressing herders-farmers conflicts across Nigeria. These conflicts are frequently associated with competition over agricultural land, grazing routes, water resources, population growth, and climate change (Boakye, 2021). In Southern Taraba, where farming and pastoralism constitute major sources of livelihood, traditional authorities have historically regulated land allocation, mediated resource-sharing arrangements, and settled boundary disputes before they escalated into violent confrontations. Their close interaction with community members enables them to identify emerging tensions early and initiate dialogue among disputing groups.

Notwithstanding these contributions, several scholars argue that the effectiveness of traditional institutions has declined due to political interference, modernization, weakening customary authority, and increasing complexity of contemporary conflicts (Miller, 1968). Government involvement in the appointment and recognition of traditional rulers has, in some instances, reduced their neutrality and public confidence. In addition, youth migration, changing social values, proliferation of small arms, and transboundary criminal activities have created security challenges that extend beyond the capacity of traditional conflict resolution mechanisms.

The literature nevertheless supports the view that sustainable peacebuilding is most effective when traditional institutions collaborate with government agencies, civil society organizations, and security institutions. Seixas and Berkes (2009) describe this approach as institutional complementarity, whereby indigenous governance structures complement formal conflict management systems. Similar experiences in Ghana and Kenya demonstrate that traditional institutions remain effective where their constitutional roles are recognized, adequately supported, and integrated into national peacebuilding frameworks (Agyeman & Awuah-Nyamekye, 2018).

Within Southern Taraba, traditional institutions continue to occupy a strategic position in managing inter-ethnic conflicts because of their proximity to local communities, knowledge of customary laws, and ability to mobilize communal participation in peace initiatives. Their involvement in mediation, reconciliation, customary arbitration, and community dialogue contributes significantly to reducing violence and promoting peaceful coexistence. Consequently, the literature strongly supports the argument that strengthening grassroots

authority through traditional institutions can enhance sustainable peacebuilding and improve inter-ethnic conflict management in Southern Taraba.

## Methodology

This study adopted a qualitative research design to examine the role of grassroots authority through traditional institutions in peacebuilding and inter-ethnic conflict management in Southern Taraba, Nigeria. A qualitative approach was considered appropriate because it facilitates an in-depth understanding of participants' experiences, perceptions, and interpretations regarding indigenous peacebuilding practices.

The study was conducted in selected communities within Southern Taraba, particularly Wukari, Takum, Donga, Ussa, and Ibi Local Government Areas, where inter-ethnic conflicts have occurred frequently. Primary data were collected through twenty-five (25) Key Informant Interviews (KIIs) conducted with carefully selected participants comprising traditional rulers (5), district heads and village heads (5), community elders (4), women leaders (3), youth leaders (3), security personnel (3), and officials of local government peace and conflict management units (2). These participants were purposively selected because of their direct involvement in community governance and conflict resolution.

To complement the interviews, the study conducted four (4) Focus Group Discussions (FGDs) consisting of 8–10 participants each. Separate FGDs were organized for community elders, youth representatives, women leaders, and farmers/pastoralists to obtain diverse perspectives on indigenous peacebuilding mechanisms and conflict management experiences. Field observation constituted another important source of data. The researcher undertook non-participant observations at traditional palaces, community meeting centers, customary courts, and selected communities previously affected by inter-ethnic conflicts. These observations enabled the researcher to document traditional conflict resolution practices, community interactions, customary symbols of authority, and peacebuilding activities. Secondary data were obtained from government reports, publications of peacebuilding organizations, academic journals, books, newspaper reports, archival documents, and policy papers relating to traditional institutions and conflict management in Nigeria.

A purposive sampling technique was employed to identify participants with relevant knowledge of indigenous peacebuilding processes. Snowball sampling was subsequently used to identify additional key informants based on recommendations from initial participants. All interviews and Focus Group Discussions were conducted with participants' informed consent, audio-recorded where permission was granted, transcribed verbatim, and analyzed using thematic analysis. The analysis focused on recurring themes including indigenous mediation, customary conflict resolution, grassroots peacebuilding strategies, challenges confronting traditional institutions, and collaboration with formal state institutions. Ethical principles guided every stage of the research. Participants were fully informed about the objectives of

the study, participation was voluntary, confidentiality and anonymity were guaranteed, and information capable of compromising the safety or identity of respondents was treated with the highest level of confidentiality.

## The Theoretical Framework

### Conflict Transformation Theory

Conflict Transformation Theory, developed by John Paul Lederach, offers a comprehensive framework for understanding and addressing protracted communal conflicts. Unlike traditional conflict-resolution models that focus on short-term settlement, conflict transformation emphasizes long-term structural and relational change (Lederach, 1997). It argues that sustainable peace emerges when the relationships, social structures, values, and patterns of interaction that fuel conflict are fundamentally reshaped (De Coning, 2016).

This theory is particularly suited to the Taraba context where conflicts ranging from communal clashes and ethno-religious tensions to herders–farmers disputes are rooted in historical grievances, identity struggles, competition over resources, and breakdowns in trust. Lederach holds that local actors, especially those with moral legitimacy and community trust, are central to transforming conflicts from destructive cycles into constructive social change. Such factors include traditional rulers, religious leaders, and other community authority figures who embody cultural knowledge and moral standing needed for durable peace efforts (Ruslan & Irham, 2022).

Traditional leaders in Taraba State mirror the type of grassroots, cultural intermediaries envisioned by Lederach. Their roles in mediating land disputes, upholding customary norms, and representing communal identities align with the theory's emphasis on addressing the deep-rooted structural dimensions of conflict (Young, 2017). Similarly, religious leaders embody the relational and normative aspects of conflict transformation. Their moral authority, capacity for interfaith dialogue, and role in shaping community values position them as vital agents for transforming hostile relationships, preventing escalation, and promoting reconciliation (Abdullah & Sajjad, 2024)

The constraints highlighted in the study, such as political interference, declining authority, and limited resources, also resonate with the theory's recognition that conflict transformation is hindered when local institutions are weakened or disconnected from state structures. Lederach stresses the need for vertical and horizontal integration of peace efforts, meaning there must be coordination between grassroots actors, mid-level leaders, and formal state institutions (Lederach, 1997). This aligns directly with the study's conclusion that sustainable peace in Taraba requires strengthened collaboration between traditional institutions, religious bodies, and government agencies. By focusing on long-term healing, rebuilding of trust, and strengthening of local capacities for peace, Conflict Transformation Theory provides a robust

analytical lens for understanding the contributions, challenges, and potential of traditional and religious leaders in Taraba State. It explains not only how these leaders intervene in preventing and resolving conflict, but also why their roles remain indispensable despite contemporary pressures. The theory therefore offers a strong conceptual foundation for analyzing the transformation of relations and structures that sustain communal peace.

**Traditional Authority and Community-Centered Peacebuilding in Southern Taraba**

Traditional leaders play a central and historically entrenched role in peacebuilding in Southern Taraba State, where communal diversity, land-based disputes, and herders–farmers tensions often generate conflict. Their authority is rooted in centuries-old customs, lineage structures, and community governance systems that predate the modern state. As custodians of tradition, culture, and communal identity, traditional rulers occupy a strategic position within local societies and remain among the most trusted actors in conflict-affected areas (Chotib, 2024). Their proximity to the people and understanding of local dynamics make them indispensable to grassroots peacebuilding efforts.

In many parts of Southern Taraba, particularly Wukari, Takum, Donga, Ussa, and Ibi Local Government Areas, traditional institutions, including chiefs, clan heads, district heads, and village heads, are responsible for enforcing customary norms that regulate land ownership, resource use, and inter-group relations (Blench, Longtau, Hassan, & Walsh, 2006). Conflicts related to farmland boundaries, grazing routes, inheritance, and communal identity often fall under their jurisdiction (Fernandez-Gimenez, 2002). Because many disputes in rural Southern Taraba revolve around land and natural resources, traditional institutions serve as frontline mediators, intervening early to prevent disagreements from escalating into violent conflicts. Their role in establishing community norms and maintaining social order enables them to facilitate dialogue and resolve disputes through culturally accepted mechanisms that often command greater local legitimacy than formal legal processes (Deveaux, 2003).

Traditional institutions also play a significant role in conflict prevention by enforcing customary laws that regulate relationships among different ethnic communities. Through palace councils, councils of elders, and customary arbitration forums, traditional rulers mediate disputes, sanction offenders, and negotiate settlements based on indigenous values and customary practices (Kariuki, 2015). In herders–farmers conflicts, for example, traditional authorities frequently mediate compensation for damaged crops and lost livestock, negotiate access to grazing routes, and resolve disputes over land boundaries affected by migration and climate variability (Beyene, 2007). Their grassroots presence enables them to identify early warning signs of conflict and mobilize community elders, youth groups, and other local stakeholders to prevent the escalation of violence.

Beyond conflict resolution, traditional institutions serve as enduring symbols of communal identity, cultural heritage, and social cohesion (Shamhuna, 2025). Their authority commands

widespread respect, and their participation in peacebuilding enhances the legitimacy of reconciliation processes. Following violent conflicts, traditional rulers facilitate reconciliation through customary peace ceremonies, community dialogue, forgiveness rituals, and the reintegration of displaced persons (Hancock & Mitchell, 2018). By promoting cultural values such as mutual respect, kinship, justice, and peaceful coexistence, they contribute significantly to rebuilding trust and strengthening long-term community stability.

Despite these important contributions, traditional institutions in Southern Taraba face several challenges that constrain their effectiveness in peacebuilding. Political interference has weakened the neutrality of some traditional authorities through attempts by political actors to manipulate customary institutions for electoral or ethnic advantage (McGarry & O'Leary, 1994). In addition, modernization, changing social values, declining respect for customary authority among younger generations, and the expansion of formal state institutions have reduced the influence of traditional governance systems (Zhang, 2011). Politicized chieftaincy disputes and competing claims to traditional stools have further undermined community cohesion in some areas. Moreover, the proliferation of small arms, the emergence of armed criminal groups, and the increasing complexity of contemporary conflicts (Lock, 1997) have created security challenges that extend beyond the capacity of traditional conflict resolution mechanisms.

Notwithstanding these constraints, traditional institutions remain indispensable actors in grassroots peacebuilding in Southern Taraba. Their historical legitimacy, cultural authority, and intimate knowledge of local communities provide unique advantages in preventing, managing, and resolving inter-ethnic conflicts. When effectively integrated into broader peacebuilding frameworks involving government agencies, security institutions, and civil society organizations, traditional institutions can provide sustainable and culturally appropriate solutions to communal conflicts. Strengthening their institutional capacity, clarifying their constitutional roles, and enhancing collaboration with formal peace and security structures will further improve their contributions to sustainable peace and social stability in the Southern Senatorial District of Taraba State.

**Religious Leaders and the Promotion of Peace and Social Cohesion in Southern Senatorial District of Taraba State**

Religious leaders play an important role in promoting peace and social cohesion in Southern Taraba, a region characterized by ethnic diversity, religious plurality, and recurring inter-ethnic conflicts. The area comprises predominantly Christian and Muslim communities alongside adherents of indigenous traditional beliefs (Ali & Lawal, 2024). These religious traditions exert considerable influence on moral values, social behavior, and community relationships. Consequently, religious leaders enjoy significant moral authority and public trust, enabling them to serve as mediators, advocates of peaceful coexistence, and facilitators of reconciliation during periods of communal tension.

In many communities across Southern Taraba, religious leaders are among the first individuals consulted when disputes arise. Their close relationship with community members and the confidence reposed in them enable them to interpret emerging conflicts, counsel aggrieved parties, and appeal for restraint before disagreements escalate into violence (Agbu et al., 2021). Churches, mosques, and other places of worship frequently provide neutral platforms where grievances can be discussed, misunderstandings clarified, and peaceful solutions explored. Through sermons, counseling sessions, home visits, and interfaith dialogue, religious leaders promote forgiveness, tolerance, and mutual understanding among their followers (Admirand, 2019). By presenting peace as a moral and religious obligation, they contribute significantly to strengthening social harmony within their communities.

Religious leaders also perform an important bridging role among diverse ethnic and religious groups (Ahmed & Adnan, 2024). In Southern Taraba, where many conflicts are associated with land disputes, ethnic rivalries, and herders–farmers confrontations, Christian and Muslim leaders have collaborated through interfaith councils and community peace committees to promote dialogue and peaceful coexistence. Such cooperation has been particularly evident in communities such as Wukari, Takum, Donga, and Ibi, where joint peace initiatives have helped reduce tensions and discourage retaliatory violence. These collaborative efforts demonstrate that peaceful coexistence across religious and ethnic boundaries is both achievable and sustainable.

Furthermore, religious leaders contribute to conflict prevention through early warning and early response mechanisms (Amadasun et al., 2023). Their frequent interaction with community members enables them to detect early signs of tension relating to youth unrest, political disagreements, land disputes, and resource competition. They often organize emergency meetings, communicate emerging security concerns to community leaders and relevant government agencies, and encourage dialogue before conflicts escalate into violence (Comfort, 2002). Religious institutions also support peacebuilding through peace education, trauma counseling, youth engagement programs, livelihood support initiatives, and interfaith forums designed to rebuild trust and promote reconciliation among communities affected by violent conflict (Bature, 2012).

Despite these important contributions, religious leaders encounter several challenges in promoting sustainable peace. Political interference, denominational differences, limited financial resources, and the overlap between religious and ethnic identities sometimes undermine their ability to maintain neutrality during communal conflicts (Williams et al., 2024). In some instances, inflammatory religious rhetoric and political manipulation of religious sentiments have further complicated peacebuilding efforts. Nevertheless, the majority of religious leaders in Southern Taraba continue to advocate dialogue, non-violence, forgiveness, and reconciliation, thereby complementing the efforts of traditional institutions and government agencies in promoting lasting peace and social cohesion.

Traditional Institutions and Peacebuilding in Southern Taraba: A Conflict Transformation Perspective

Using John Paul Lederach's Conflict Transformation Theory (1997), the role of traditional institutions in peacebuilding in Southern Taraba can be understood in terms of their capacity to address the structural, relational, and cultural dimensions of inter-ethnic conflict while promoting sustainable social change. Lederach argues that conflict should not merely be viewed as a problem to be resolved but as a dynamic process capable of transforming relationships, strengthening institutions, and promoting peaceful coexistence. His framework emphasizes the importance of integrating indigenous institutions and grassroots actors into peace processes rather than relying solely on top-down interventions by the state.

The role of traditional institutions in peacebuilding closely reflects Lederach's emphasis on local ownership and indigenous mechanisms of conflict transformation. In Southern Taraba, traditional institutions including traditional rulers, district heads, clan heads, village heads, and councils of elders serve as custodians of customary laws, mediators of communal disputes, and symbols of cultural identity. Their interventions in conflicts relating to land ownership, grazing routes, boundary disputes, inheritance, and communal identity demonstrate that sustainable peace requires addressing the underlying social, cultural, and structural causes of conflict rather than merely ending violence. Through customary arbitration, mediation, reconciliation meetings, and peace ceremonies, traditional institutions transform relationships between conflicting groups while reinforcing community values of justice, mutual respect, and peaceful coexistence.

Traditional institutions also contribute significantly to restoring trust and strengthening social cohesion after conflict. Their authority, which is rooted in history, culture, and community acceptance, enables them to mobilize disputing parties for dialogue and reconciliation. By applying customary laws and indigenous conflict resolution practices, they promote forgiveness, rebuild damaged relationships, and encourage collective responsibility for maintaining peace. These functions are consistent with Lederach's assertion that effective peacebuilding requires transforming relationships, empowering local communities, and utilizing culturally legitimate mechanisms to sustain long-term peace.

Furthermore, the grassroots presence of traditional institutions enables them to identify early warning signs of conflict and intervene before disputes escalate into widespread violence. Their close interaction with community members provides access to local knowledge that enhances conflict prevention and early response. In addition, collaboration between traditional institutions and formal government agencies strengthens peacebuilding efforts by combining indigenous approaches with statutory conflict management mechanisms. This institutional complementarity contributes to more inclusive, culturally appropriate, and sustainable peacebuilding processes.

Conflict Transformation Theory therefore provides an appropriate analytical framework for this study because it explains how grassroots authority exercised through traditional institutions contributes to peacebuilding and inter-ethnic conflict management in Southern Taraba. The theory underscores the importance of indigenous leadership, community participation, and culturally grounded conflict resolution mechanisms in achieving sustainable peace and social stability.

The theme on religious leaders and peacebuilding also resonates with Lederach's theory, particularly in addressing the relational and attitudinal dimensions of conflict. Religious leaders in Taraba State promote tolerance, interfaith dialogue, and moral guidance, contributing to changes in perception, empathy, and mutual recognition between communities. By framing peace in moral and spiritual terms, they influence attitudes and behaviors that underlie repeated cycles of violence. Their bridging role uniting Christian and Muslim communities, mobilizing early-warning responses, and facilitating dialogue demonstrates conflict transformation in practice: conflicts are not only managed. However, they are reoriented toward cooperative, cross-community relationships. Religious leaders' engagement in trauma healing, youth programs, and long-term reconciliation initiatives further illustrates Lederach's notion that transformative peacebuilding requires attention to social, emotional, and cultural dimensions, beyond immediate cessation of violence.

**Findings**

The application of John Paul Lederach's Conflict Transformation Theory to this study reveals several important findings regarding the role of traditional institutions in peacebuilding and inter-ethnic conflict management in Southern Taraba. First, the findings demonstrate that local legitimacy and cultural embeddedness are fundamental to effective grassroots peacebuilding. Traditional institutions derive their authority from customary law, historical legitimacy, and community acceptance, enabling them to influence behavior, mediate disputes, and promote peaceful coexistence more effectively than external actors or formal state institutions alone.

Secondly, the findings indicate that sustainable peace requires addressing the structural, relational, and cultural causes of conflict rather than merely resolving immediate disputes. Traditional institutions contribute to this process by regulating land ownership, mediating boundary disputes, facilitating dialogue among conflicting ethnic groups, and promoting reconciliation through customary conflict resolution mechanisms. These interventions address underlying grievances while restoring trust and strengthening relationships within affected communities.

Thirdly, the study finds that effective peacebuilding is enhanced through collaboration between traditional institutions and formal government structures. Partnerships involving traditional rulers, local government authorities, security agencies, and community-based

organizations provide a complementary approach to conflict prevention, mediation, and post-conflict reconciliation. Such collaboration combines indigenous knowledge with statutory mechanisms, thereby improving the effectiveness and sustainability of peacebuilding initiatives.

The findings also reveal several challenges affecting the effectiveness of traditional institutions in conflict management. Political interference, declining respect for customary authority, inadequate institutional support, increasing competition over land and natural resources, and the growing complexity of contemporary security threats have reduced the capacity of traditional institutions to respond effectively to some conflicts. These challenges underscore the need for stronger institutional support and greater collaboration with formal peace and security structures.

Finally, the findings affirm that traditional institutions remain indispensable actors in grassroots peacebuilding in Southern Taraba. Their moral authority, cultural legitimacy, and close relationship with local communities provide a strong foundation for preventing violent conflict, facilitating reconciliation, and promoting sustainable peace. Strengthening these institutions through appropriate policy support, capacity building, and institutional collaboration will further enhance their contribution to inter-ethnic conflict management and long-term community stability.

**Conclusion**

The application of John Paul Lederach's Conflict Transformation Theory to this study demonstrates the significant role of traditional institutions in promoting peacebuilding and managing inter-ethnic conflicts in Southern Taraba, Nigeria. The study reveals that traditional institutions possess cultural legitimacy, historical authority, and community trust, enabling them to address not only immediate disputes but also the deeper structural, relational, and cultural factors that sustain conflict. Through customary mediation, reconciliation meetings, dialogue, and the enforcement of customary norms, traditional institutions contribute to restoring social harmony, rebuilding trust, and strengthening peaceful coexistence among diverse ethnic communities.

The findings further indicate that sustainable peace is more likely to be achieved when traditional institutions work collaboratively with government agencies, security institutions, and other peacebuilding stakeholders. Such partnerships combine indigenous knowledge with formal conflict management mechanisms, thereby enhancing the effectiveness of peacebuilding initiatives and promoting community ownership of peace processes. However, the study also identifies challenges such as political interference, declining respect for customary authority, inadequate institutional support, and the increasing complexity of contemporary security threats, all of which constrain the effectiveness of traditional institutions in conflict management.

Despite these challenges, traditional institutions remain indispensable actors in grassroots peacebuilding in Southern Taraba. Their proximity to local communities, deep understanding of customary practices, and ability to foster dialogue and reconciliation position them as strategic partners in preventing violent conflict and promoting sustainable peace. The study therefore concludes that strengthening traditional institutions through appropriate legal recognition, capacity building, and closer collaboration with formal state institutions will enhance their contribution to effective inter-ethnic conflict management and long-term peace and stability in Southern Taraba, Nigeria.

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# IMPACT OF BOKO HARAM INSURGENCY ON ORGANISATIONAL VIABILITY IN NORTHEAST NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** Boko Haram insurgency has constituted one of the most persistent and destructive security crises in Nigeria, with far-reaching implications beyond immediate humanitarian and security concerns. This study examines the impact of Boko Haram insurgency on organizational viability in Northeast Nigeria, with a specific focus on government and public sector institutions, private business organizations, and educational establishments. Adopting a qualitative systematic review design, the study synthesizes evidence from selected empirical and theoretical studies to analyze how prolonged insecurity undermines organizational continuity, resilience, and long-term sustainability. The findings reveal that in the public sector, insurgency erodes state legitimacy, fragments institutional coordination, and shifts governance from planned administration to crisis management. In the private sector, persistent violence distorts investment decisions, disrupts supply chains, escalates operational risks, and weakens enterprise survival, particularly among small and medium-sized enterprises. Educational institutions are shown to face existential threats through targeted attacks, school closures, staff displacement, and declining enrolment. This study concludes that Boko Haram insurgency has systematically undermined organizational viability in Northeast Nigeria by transforming insecurity into a persistent structural condition that erodes institutional continuity, resilience, and sustainability across government, private, and educational sectors. The study therefore recommends, among others, that government at all levels in Northeast Nigeria should strengthen institutional resilience through security-sensitive governance reforms that restore administrative mobility, improve inter-agency coordination, and integrate conflict risk into planning and budgeting. Post-conflict reconstruction should prioritize rebuilding public infrastructure, retaining skilled personnel, and adopting flexible policy implementation frameworks capable of operating under residual insecurity.

**Keywords**: Boko Haram insurgency, organizational viability, public sector viability, private sector viability, education sector viability, Northeast Nigeria

## Introduction

Nigeria's security landscape over the past two decades has been profoundly shaped by escalating insecurity, with insurgency emerging as one of its most destabilizing

manifestations. Among these, the Boko Haram insurgency represents the most protracted and destructive violent conflict confronting the Nigerian state, particularly in the Northeast. Scholars consistently argue that Boko Haram is not merely a security problem but a multidimensional crisis rooted in structural inequalities, chronic poverty, weak governance, and social marginalization (Emmanuelar, 2015; Ebonyi, 2019; De Simone & Iocchi, 2022). Since its violent escalation in 2009, the insurgency has persisted despite military offensives, fragmenting into splinter factions and sustaining attacks on civilians, public institutions, businesses, and educational facilities (Kangdim et al., 2022). Empirical evidence demonstrates that the conflict has inflicted severe economic losses, eroded social cohesion, and undermined state authority across Borno, Yobe, and Adamawa States, with spillover effects across Nigeria's broader economy (Ikpe, 2017; Sylvester & Osimen, 2021). The persistence of Boko Haram, therefore, challenges conventional security responses and exposes deeper vulnerabilities within organizational systems operating in conflict-affected environments.

Within this context, examining organizational viability becomes both analytically and practically significant. Existing studies have largely concentrated on humanitarian crises, livelihood disruption, education, and macroeconomic consequences of the insurgency (Abubakar & Amurtiya, 2023; Muhammad et al., 2020; Nur et al., 2024), yet comparatively limited attention has been given to how prolonged insecurity threatens the continuity, resilience, and sustainability of organizations themselves. Government agencies face institutional paralysis through infrastructural destruction, workforce displacement, and weakened policy implementation, while private enterprises contend with investment flight, disrupted supply chains, and heightened operational risks (Abakpa & Tyokosu, 2022; Kangdim et al., 2022).

Educational institutions, in particular, experience existential threats through school closures, targeted attacks, and long-term erosion of human capital development (Muhammad et al., 2020; Jamri, 2021). This study, therefore, addresses the problem of how sustained insurgency undermines organizational viability across public, private, and educational sectors in Northeast Nigeria. Its significance lies in advancing a sector-wide understanding of conflict-induced organizational fragility, contributing to debates on security, development, and institutional resilience. Specifically, the study aims to investigate the impact of the Boko Haram insurgency on government and public sector organizations, private business enterprises, and educational institutions in the region. The rationale for the study is anchored in the need to inform security-sensitive governance reforms, post-conflict reconstruction strategies, and organizational resilience frameworks suitable for fragile settings.

## Conceptual Clarifications

### Boko Haram Insurgency

Boko Haram refers to a violent Islamist insurgent movement formally known as Jama'atu Ahlis Sunna Lidda'awati wal-Jihad, which emerged in the early 2000s in Maiduguri, Borno State. The group originated as a puritanical Islamic movement under the leadership of Mohammed Yusuf, advocating strict adherence to Salafi ideology and rejecting Western education, governance, and social values, which it framed as corrupt and sinful (Olatunde, Baban'umma and Luka, 2023; Akinteye, Baban'umma and Luka, 2024). Its ideological foundation is rooted in religious extremism combined with grievances arising from poverty, youth unemployment, political marginalization, and state neglect in Northeast Nigeria (Apikins, 2020). Following Yusuf's death in police custody in 2009, Boko Haram transformed from a relatively localized sect into a highly militarised insurgent organization, adopting violent jihad as its primary strategy (Elkaim, 2022). Over time, the group evolved through internal fragmentation and tactical adaptation, leading to the emergence of factions such as the Islamic State West Africa Province (ISWAP), which has demonstrated greater organizational discipline and strategic sophistication (Nimely, 2023). This evolution underscores Boko Haram's capacity to adjust to counterinsurgency pressures while sustaining its ideological commitment to undermining the Nigerian state.

The operational pattern of Boko Haram insurgency in Northeast Nigeria is characterized by asymmetric warfare, targeting both soft and hard targets to maximize psychological, political, and economic disruption. The group employs tactics such as suicide bombings, armed raids on communities, abductions, destruction of public infrastructure, and coordinated attacks on military formations (Ojo, 2020; Elkaim, 2022). Educational institutions, markets, places of worship, and rural settlements have been recurrent targets, contributing to mass displacement and social dislocation across the region (Janga, Adeola and Samuel, 2024). The intensity of violence has fluctuated over time, with periods of heightened attacks coinciding with military offensives or leadership transitions within the group (Nimely, 2023). Notably, Boko Haram exploits poorly governed and remote spaces, using them as operational bases and supply corridors, thereby complicating state security responses (Ojo, 2020). These sustained patterns of violence have entrenched insecurity in Northeast Nigeria, normalizing conflict conditions and creating an environment in which organizational stability and societal resilience are persistently undermined.

### Organisational Viability

Organizational viability refers to the capacity of an organization to continue functioning, fulfill its core mandate, and sustain its existence over time despite internal and external shocks. In conflict-affected contexts such as Northeast Nigeria, viability extends beyond routine operational efficiency to encompass continuity, resilience, and long-term

sustainability under conditions of persistent insecurity. Continuity relates to the organization's ability to maintain basic functions and service provision despite disruptions. At the same time, resilience denotes its capacity to absorb, adapt to, and recover from crises such as violent attacks, workforce displacement, and infrastructural damage (Osumah, 2013; Ebi, 2018). Sustainability, in this context, reflects the organization's long-term survival prospects, including its ability to rebuild institutional capacity, retain legitimacy, and align operations with changing security realities (Granville, 2020). Studies on insurgency in Northeast Nigeria demonstrate that prolonged violence erodes organizational structures, weakens leadership effectiveness, and constrains decision-making, thereby threatening institutional continuity across public, private, and educational sectors (Sule et al., 2019; Kanu & Bazza, 2023).

Indicators of organizational viability in crisis environments include service delivery capacity, financial stability, adaptability, and institutional survival. Service delivery capacity refers to the ability of organizations to consistently provide essential goods and services, such as governance functions, business operations, or educational instruction, even amid security disruptions (Ekereke, 2013; Abiodun et al., 2020). Financial stability is reflected in sustained revenue streams, budgetary resilience, and access to emergency funding or external support, all of which are often severely compromised by insurgency-induced economic decline and capital flight (Ebi, 2018). Adaptability captures the extent to which organizations can modify operational strategies, relocate activities, adopt risk management practices, and engage nontraditional coping mechanisms to function under insecurity (Sule et al., 2019). Institutional survival, the ultimate indicator of viability, entails the preservation of organizational identity, governance systems, and human resources despite prolonged crisis conditions (Granville, 2020). In Northeast Nigeria, the persistent Boko Haram insurgency has severely tested these indicators, exposing structural weaknesses and underscoring the fragility of organizational systems operating in violent conflict settings.

**Northeast Nigeria**

Northeast Nigeria is one of the six geopolitical zones in the country, comprising Adamawa, Bauchi, Borno, Gombe, Taraba, and Yobe States. Geographically, the region occupies an expansive territory that shares international borders with Niger, Chad, and Cameroon, making it strategically significant but also highly vulnerable to cross-border criminality and insurgent mobility (Ojo, 2020; Nimely, 2023). The ecological landscape is largely semi-arid and savannah, with the Lake Chad Basin historically sustaining agriculture, fishing, and trade for millions of inhabitants. Demographically, the region is characterized by ethnic and religious diversity and a predominantly youthful population, many of whom face limited access to education, employment, and social services (Apikins, 2020). Socio-economically, Northeast Nigeria has persistently recorded some of the lowest human development indicators in the country, including high poverty rates, weak infrastructure, low literacy levels, and heavy reliance on subsistence agriculture and informal economic activities (Olatunde, Baban'umma and Luka, 2023; Akinteye, Baban'umma and Luka, 2024). These conditions have constrained

economic productivity and reduced the resilience of both communities and organizations operating within the region.

Historically, the Northeast has been exposed to recurring insecurity, structural poverty, and institutional fragility, long predating the Boko Haram insurgency. Scholars note that weak state presence, poorly governed rural and border spaces, and limited institutional capacity created governance vacuums that undermined effective service delivery and social control (Ojo, 2020; Elkaim, 2022). Chronic unemployment, youth marginalization, and environmental degradation linked to the shrinking of Lake Chad further intensified social vulnerability and eroded traditional livelihoods, deepening poverty across the region (Apikins, 2020; Janga, Adeola and Samuel, 2024). These pre-existing fragilities provided fertile ground for the emergence and entrenchment of Boko Haram, whose activities have since compounded institutional breakdown through mass displacement, destruction of infrastructure, and prolonged disruption of economic and administrative systems (Nimely, 2023; Olatunde, Baban'umma and Luka, 2023). Consequently, Northeast Nigeria represents a context where historical underdevelopment, persistent insecurity, and weakened institutions interact in mutually reinforcing ways, posing severe challenges to organizational viability and sustainable development.

**Linkage Between Variables**

**Impact of Boko Haram Insurgency on Government and Public Sector Viability in Northeast Nigeria**

Boko Haram's insurgency disrupts government and public sector viability first by attacking the conditions that make public administration possible: territorial control, predictable mobility, and the legitimacy to rule. Rather than being an episodic "security incident", the conflict creates a persistent operating environment in which ministries, departments, agencies and local governments must function under threat, thereby converting routine governance into crisis management (Emmanuelar, 2015; Shuaibu, Salleh and Shehu, 2015). Kangdim et al. (2022) emphasize that Boko Haram's impacts are multi-sectoral and systemic, meaning the public sector is hit not only through direct violence but also through spillover effects that weaken coordination across security, welfare, infrastructure, and economic management. This matters for organizational continuity because public organizations depend on interagency links, stable revenue flows, and functional field presence; insurgency degrades each layer simultaneously, producing institutional fragility that is often misread as "capacity weakness" rather than conflict-induced organizational erosion (Ikpe, 2017; Ebonyi, 2019). Critically, the disruption also takes a governance form: by creating fear and contested authority, insurgents constrain the state's ability to impose rules and deliver visible public goods, which in turn undermines citizens' confidence and compliance, deepening a cycle of weak legitimacy and further insecurity (Ebonyi, 2019; Baba, 2016).

Public service delivery and administrative efficiency are then weakened through a dual mechanism of demand surge and system shrinkage. On one hand, insurgency increases the population's needs for protection, emergency health support, social assistance, and resettlement services; on the other, it reduces the government's delivery capacity by limiting safe access to communities, lowering staff availability, and diverting attention and funding toward security responses (Emmanuelar, 2015; Bello, 2022). The result is institutional instability where public agencies struggle to meet statutory mandates, not necessarily because mandates are unclear, but because the operational space for implementation collapses. For example, rural livelihood disruption associated with insurgency reduces household incomes and food security, which expands pressure on public welfare services, while simultaneously shrinking local economic activity that supports government revenue mobilization and administrative reach (Abubakar & Amurtiya, 2023; Abakpa & Tyokosu, 2022). Ikpe (2017) frames this as a measurable development cost of conflict: public sector performance is degraded not only through physical damage but also through lost productivity, impaired development programming, and weakened institutional trajectories. In practical terms, insurgency shifts the public sector from planned service delivery to reactive triage, where "what gets done" becomes "what can be done safely," and that is a profound threat to organizational viability.

Infrastructure destruction, workforce displacement, and operational constraints further translate insecurity into organizational dysfunction. When public buildings, roads, and utilities are damaged or become unsafe to use, administrative processes slow down, field monitoring collapses, and the cost of delivering services rises sharply, even where funding exists (Ikpe, 2017; Kangdim et al., 2022). Human resources are equally central: insecurity drives staff relocation, absenteeism, and high turnover, reducing institutional memory and weakening managerial control. This workforce disruption extends beyond civil servants to teachers, healthcare workers, agricultural extension officers, and local administrative personnel whose presence is essential for frontline governance (Emmanuelar, 2015; Bello, 2022). Moreover, counterinsurgency operations themselves can impose constraints on bureaucratic operations through movement restrictions, militarisation of civic space, and the redirection of state capacity toward coercive functions rather than developmental ones (Yalmi, 2020; Shuaibu, Salleh and Shehu, 2015). The argument here is not that security operations are unnecessary, but that a prolonged security-first posture can unintentionally institutionalize fragility by starving public organizations of the stable routines, planning horizons, and local trust required to function effectively (De Simone & Iocchi, 2022; Yalmi, 2020).

Over time, prolonged insecurity reshapes policy implementation and governance effectiveness in ways that threaten long-term public-sector sustainability. Policies depend on consistent implementation chains, data collection, stakeholder engagement, and monitoring and evaluation, yet conflict breaks these chains, creating implementation gaps that widen inequalities and fuel further grievances (Abubakar & Amurtiya, 2023; Ebonyi, 2019). Kangdim et al. (2022) imply that when insecurity becomes chronic, the state's development

role is structurally weakened: budgets are re-prioritized, projects stall, and institutions operate below capacity, producing a “low performance equilibrium” that becomes normalized. Post-insurgency activities and recovery efforts may improve livelihoods. However, they also reveal how weakened institutions struggle to coordinate reconstruction, manage compensation and reintegration needs, and restore routine governance without renewed insecurity risks (Ali & Ali, 2024; Bello, 2022). The sustainability challenge is therefore not simply rebuilding what was destroyed, but restoring organizational viability: a public sector able to plan, deliver, adapt, and retain legitimacy under risk. Without that, even well-designed policies remain paper commitments, and governance becomes episodic, donor-driven, or security-dominated, which reinforces institutional fragility rather than resolving it (Ikpe, 2017; De Simone & Iocchi, 2022).

**Impact of Boko Haram Insurgency on Private Business Viability in Northeast Nigeria**

The Boko Haram insurgency has fundamentally undermined business continuity and enterprise survival in Northeast Nigeria by transforming insecurity into a structural constraint on private sector activity rather than a temporary shock. Small and medium-scale enterprises (SMEs), which constitute the backbone of the regional economy, are particularly vulnerable because they rely on local markets, predictable mobility, and informal trust networks, all of which the insurgency erodes (Korimi, 2020; Abakpa & Tyokosu, 2022). Kangdim et al. (2022) argue that the insurgency’s economic effects are systemic, as violence simultaneously disrupts production, consumption, and investment confidence, creating a hostile environment in which firms struggle to sustain operations. Investment decisions are consequently distorted: entrepreneurs delay expansion, external investors withdraw, and capital accumulation declines due to heightened security risks and uncertainty (Ikpe, 2017; Ebonyi, 2019). This dynamic converts what would ordinarily be manageable business risks into existential threats, forcing many enterprises into downsizing, relocation, or outright closure, thereby weakening private sector organizational viability across the region.

Beyond firm-level survival, the Boko Haram insurgency disrupts supply chains, markets, and entrepreneurial ecosystems, which are essential for sustained business operations. Insecurity restricts access to raw materials, transportation routes, and distribution networks, especially in rural and peri-urban areas where insurgents frequently operate (Abubakar & Amurtiya, 2023). Market closures, curfews, and population displacement reduce consumer demand and fragment trading systems, undermining the scale economies that many businesses depend upon (Emmanuelar, 2015; Baba, 2016). Korimi (2020) documents that SMEs in Borno State experience irregular supply flows and market volatility, which increases transaction costs and weakens planning capacity. Critically, the erosion of entrepreneurial activity is not only a result of physical insecurity but also of institutional breakdown: weak enforcement of contracts, limited access to finance, and declining regulatory oversight further discourage business formation and innovation (Ebonyi, 2019; Kangdim et al., 2022). As a result, insurgency shrinks not just individual firms but the entire business ecosystem needed for long-term private sector viability.

The insurgency also escalates operational risks and costs, placing additional burdens on firms that continue to operate. Businesses incur higher expenditures on private security, insurance premiums, risk mitigation measures, and alternative logistics routes, all of which reduce profitability and competitiveness (Ikpe, 2017; Shuaibu, Salleh and Shehu, 2015). Uncertainty becomes a defining feature of the business environment, making revenue streams unpredictable and undermining strategic planning horizons. From a viability perspective, this is critical because sustained uncertainty discourages reinvestment and weakens organizational learning and adaptation processes (Kangdim et al., 2022). Moreover, firms face labor-related risks, including workforce absenteeism, staff displacement, and difficulties attracting skilled personnel willing to operate in high-risk zones (Emmanuelar, 2015; Abakpa & Tyokosu, 2022). These pressures disproportionately affect SMEs, which lack financial buffers and institutional support, thereby widening inequality between large firms capable of absorbing shocks and smaller enterprises pushed toward collapse.

The cumulative effect of insurgency-induced business fragility is a severe contraction in employment generation and regional economic growth, with long-term implications for organizational viability and development. As firms close or scale down, job losses rise, household incomes decline, and local purchasing power weakens, creating a negative feedback loop that further depresses business activity (Ikpe, 2017; Abubakar & Amurtiya, 2023). Kangdim et al. (2022) highlight that this employment shock is not sector-specific but economy-wide, affecting agriculture, trade, manufacturing, and services, thereby eroding the economic base needed for post-conflict recovery. The weakening of private sector capacity also undermines social stability, as unemployment and economic exclusion intensify grievances that insurgent groups can exploit for recruitment (Baba, 2016; Ebonyi, 2019). From an organizational viability perspective, the private sector's struggle to survive under prolonged insecurity limits its role as an engine of growth, employment, and resilience, reinforcing a cycle in which economic fragility and violent conflict mutually sustain one another (Ikpe, 2017; Emmanuelar, 2015).

**Impact of Boko Haram Insurgency on Educational Sector Viability in Northeast Nigeria**

Boko Haram insurgency has posed an existential threat to the survival and functioning of educational institutions in Northeast Nigeria, transforming schools from spaces of learning into targets of violence and symbols of ideological opposition. The group's explicit rejection of Western education, reflected in its name and doctrine, has translated into systematic attacks on schools, teachers, and educational administrators, thereby undermining the organizational viability of primary, secondary, and tertiary institutions (Baba, 2016; Emmanuelar, 2015). Educational organizations depend on stability, routine, and safe learning environments to function effectively, yet persistent insecurity disrupts academic calendars, weakens administrative capacity, and erodes institutional governance structures (Ekereke, 2013; Abiodun et al., 2020). Critically, the insurgency does not merely interrupt schooling temporarily; it destabilizes the foundational conditions required for educational continuity,

forcing institutions to operate intermittently or shut down entirely, which represents a direct assault on their long-term sustainability.

A defining feature of Boko Haram's impact on education is the closure and destruction of schools, coupled with the displacement of students and staff. Numerous learning facilities across Borno, Yobe, and Adamawa States have been damaged, occupied, or abandoned due to attacks, threats, and military operations, reducing the number of functional schools available to serve affected communities (Emmanuelar, 2015; Bello, 2022). Teachers and nonacademic staff are frequently displaced or unwilling to accept postings in high-risk areas, leading to acute shortages of qualified personnel and weakening institutional delivery capacity (Ekereke, 2013; Abiodun et al., 2020). Kangdim et al. (2022) emphasize that education is among the sectors most severely affected by insurgency because its infrastructure and human resources are highly sensitive to insecurity. From an organizational perspective, repeated closures and staff displacement fragment management systems, disrupt record-keeping, and erode institutional memory, thereby diminishing the resilience of educational organizations.

These disruptions have profound consequences for enrolment, retention, and academic performance across the region. Fear of attacks discourages parents from sending children to school, particularly girls, while displacement and economic hardship force many students into early marriage, child labor, or informal livelihoods (Abubakar & Amurtiya, 2023; Baba, 2016). High dropout rates and irregular attendance undermine learning outcomes and contribute to declining academic performance, even in schools that remain operational (Ekereke, 2013). Ikpe (2017) links these educational disruptions to broader development losses, arguing that prolonged conflict reduces the accumulation of human capital and weakens productivity in the long run. Organizational viability is further threatened when declining enrolment reduces funding allocations, community support, and stakeholder engagement, pushing schools into a cycle of underperformance and institutional fragility (Abiodun et al., 2020; Ebonyi, 2019).

In the long term, the insurgency's impact on educational organizational viability poses serious risks to human capital development and regional recovery. Education plays a critical role in building skills, social cohesion, and economic resilience, yet sustained disruption undermines the region's capacity to produce a skilled workforce capable of supporting governance, entrepreneurship, and innovation (Ikpe, 2017; Kangdim et al., 2022). The erosion of educational institutions also perpetuates inequality, as affected populations fall further behind national averages in literacy, employability, and civic participation, reinforcing structural conditions associated with conflict recurrence (Ebonyi, 2019; Abubakar & Amurtiya, 2023). From an organizational standpoint, rebuilding schools alone is insufficient; restoring viability requires sustained security, teacher retention, psychosocial support, and adaptive learning systems capable of functioning under risk. Without these, educational organizations remain fragile, limiting their contribution to long-term peacebuilding and sustainable development in Northeast Nigeria (Emmanuelar, 2015; Abiodun et al., 2020).

## Theoretical Framework

Conflict Theory, most strongly associated with Karl Marx, explains social order as a product of unequal power relations in which dominant groups protect economic and political advantage. In contrast, subordinate groups experience deprivation and exclusion, making conflict a predictable outcome rather than an abnormal interruption of society. Applied to Northeast Nigeria, the theory helps frame Boko Haram not only as a religious extremist movement but also as an outcome of structurally embedded inequality, where chronic poverty, unemployment, and limited access to education and state services intensify resentment and create recruitment opportunities for violent actors. The persistence of insurgency can also be interpreted through the lens of "ungoverned spaces" and weakened state authority, where governance vacuums and contested legitimacy enable armed groups to operate, extract resources, and reshape local power structures (Ojo, 2020; Elkaim, 2022). Critically, Conflict Theory highlights that organizational disruption is not merely collateral damage but a mechanism through which insurgent violence contests state control: attacks, fear, displacement, and infrastructural destruction reduce the capacity of public institutions, businesses, and schools to function, thereby widening inequality and reinforcing the very grievances that fuel conflict. In this sense, persistent conflict undermines organizational viability by degrading service delivery systems, shrinking financial and human resource bases, and forcing organizations into reactive survival modes rather than sustainable planning, which ultimately entrenches institutional fragility and prolongs insecurity.

## Methodology

### Research Design and Justification

This study adopts a qualitative systematic review design to critically examine the impact of Boko Haram insurgency on organizational viability in Northeast Nigeria. This design is appropriate because the study seeks to synthesize interpretive evidence on institutional disruption, resilience, and sustainability across sectors rather than generate new empirical data. Organizational viability in conflict settings involves complex governance processes, adaptive responses, and contextual dynamics that are best examined through qualitative synthesis. The systematic review approach enhances analytical rigor, transparency, and theoretical integration across government, private, and educational sectors.

### Data Sources and Search Strategy

Data were obtained exclusively from secondary sources through a systematic literature search. Peer-reviewed journal articles, postgraduate theses, and policy-oriented studies were retrieved from Scopus, Web of Science, Google Scholar, JSTOR, and African Journals Online (AJOL). Search strings combined key terms using Boolean operators, including "Boko Haram insurgency," "organisational viability," "public sector," "private business,"

“education,” “institutional resilience,” and “Northeast Nigeria.” The search process followed the PRISMA guidelines, enabling structured identification, screening, eligibility assessment, and inclusion of studies. From the initial pool, 10 studies were retained based on relevance and methodological suitability.

**Study Selection and Inclusion Criteria**

As a systematic review, the study employed criterion-based study selection rather than participant sampling. Studies were included if they focused on Boko Haram insurgency in Northeast Nigeria, examined impacts on organizational or institutional functioning, and adopted qualitative or mixed methods with clear analytical insights. Studies were excluded if they were purely military tactical analyses, focused on regions outside Northeast Nigeria, or lacked relevance to organizational viability. This structured selection process ensured that the review remained analytically focused and sectorally balanced.

**Quality Assessment of Included Studies**

To enhance the credibility and trustworthiness of the synthesis, a formal quality assessment was conducted on the 10 retained studies. Each study was appraised using an adapted Critical Appraisal Skills Program (CASP) qualitative checklist, assessing clarity of research aims, methodological appropriateness, data collection rigor, analytical transparency, and relevance of findings. Studies were categorized as high or moderate quality based on their methodological coherence and analytical depth; low-quality studies were excluded at the eligibility stage. This assessment ensured that conclusions drawn from the review were grounded in methodologically sound evidence and reduced the risk of bias influencing thematic interpretations.

**Data Extraction and Method of Analysis**

A structured data extraction framework was applied to the retained studies to ensure consistency and comparability. Extracted data included study objectives, sector focus, research design, key findings on organizational disruption, and implications for continuity, resilience, and sustainability. The extracted data were analyzed using thematic analysis, involving systematic coding, theme development, and cross-sector comparison. This method enabled the identification of recurring patterns and divergences in how insurgency affects organizational viability, while supporting critical interpretation aligned with Conflict Theory. The analytical process strengthened the study’s explanatory power and ensured coherence between evidence, theory, and conclusions.

## Findings and Discussion

As synthesized in Figure 1, Boko Haram insurgency undermines government and public sector viability in Northeast Nigeria through interconnected and mutually reinforcing pathways that transform routine governance into crisis-driven administration. The loss of territorial control, restricted administrative mobility, and erosion of state legitimacy weaken the authority of public institutions to impose rules and deliver public goods, forcing governance to occur under constant threat rather than stable conditions (Emmanuelar, 2015; Shuaibu et al., 2015; Ebonyi, 2019; Baba, 2016). These governance disruptions cascade into institutional fragmentation, as interagency coordination, revenue flows, and administrative continuity collapse, replacing planned governance with reactive, crisis-mode management (Kangdim et al., 2022; Ikpe, 2017). Simultaneously, public service delivery is strained by a dual pressure of rising demand for protection, health, welfare, and resettlement services alongside shrinking delivery capacity, resulting in unmet statutory mandates and administrative inefficiency (Emmanuelar, 2015; Bello, 2022). Infrastructure destruction and workforce displacement further erode operational capacity, weakening monitoring systems, increasing service delivery costs, and accelerating the loss of institutional memory and managerial control (Ikpe, 2017; Bello, 2022). Prolonged security-first policy orientation diverts resources away from development functions, constrains bureaucratic autonomy, and entrenches institutional fragility, ultimately producing policy implementation gaps, declining public trust, and a low-performance governance equilibrium that threatens long-term public-sector sustainability (Abubakar & Amurtiya, 2023; Ebonyi, 2019; De Simone & Iocchi, 2022).

Figure 1: Thematic Causal Pathway Diagram for the Impact of Boko Haram Insurgency on Government and Public Sector Viability in Northeast Nigeria

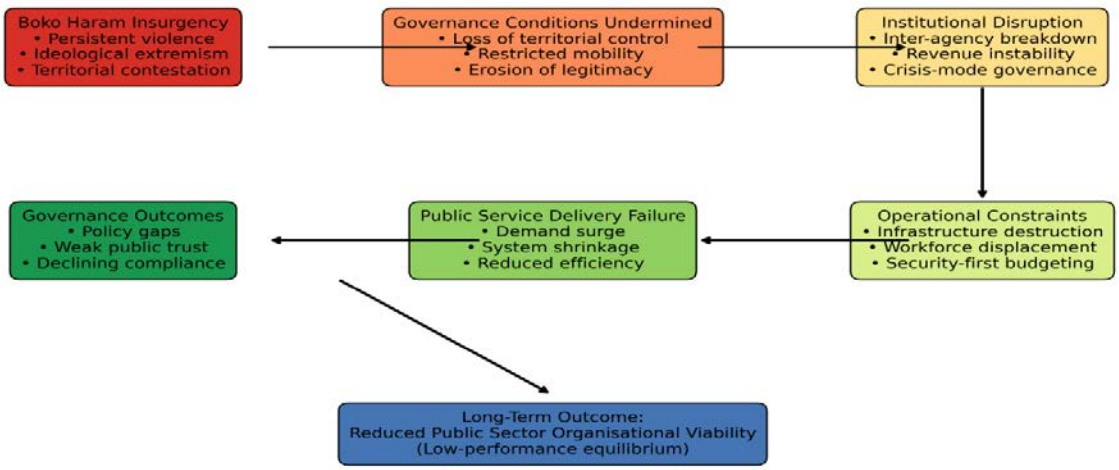


Figure 1: Thematic Causal Pathway Diagram for the Impact of Boko Haram Insurgency on Government and Public Sector Viability in Northeast Nigeria

As synthesized in Figure 2, Boko Haram insurgency undermines private business viability in Northeast Nigeria through a cascading and self-reinforcing process that converts insecurity into a structural constraint on economic activity rather than a temporary disruption. Persistent violence and uncertainty destabilize the business environment by restricting mobility, closing markets, and eroding informal trust networks on which SMEs depend, thereby distorting investment decisions and triggering capital flight, delayed expansion, and declining investor confidence (Ikpe, 2017; Ebonyi, 2019). These pressures escalate operational risks and costs through increased security expenditure, disrupted supply chains, workforce instability, and logistical inefficiencies, which weaken profitability and planning capacity, particularly among SMEs with limited financial buffers (Shuaibu, Salleh and Shehu, 2015; Abakpa & Tyokosu, 2022). The cumulative effect is enterprise fragility manifested in downsizing, relocation, and business closures, alongside broader entrepreneurial ecosystem breakdown characterized by weak contract enforcement, constrained access to finance, and declining innovation (Ebonyi, 2019; Kangdim et al., 2022). Ultimately, as illustrated in Figure 2, these dynamics translate into rising unemployment, reduced household incomes, and regional economic contraction, reinforcing a conflict–poverty cycle that erodes the private sector's capacity to generate growth, employment, and resilience under prolonged insecurity (Ikpe, 2017; Abubakar & Amurtiya, 2023; Emmanuelar, 2015).

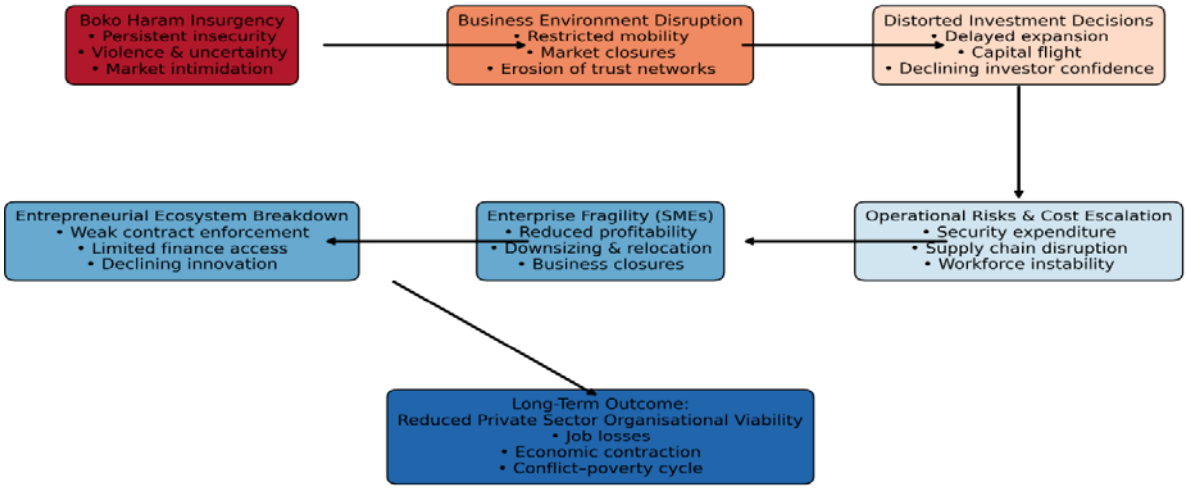



Figure 2: Thematic Causal Pathway Diagram Illustrating the Impact of Boko Haram Insurgency on Private Business Viability in Northeast Nigeria.

As synthesized in Figure 3, Boko Haram insurgency undermines educational sector viability in Northeast Nigeria through a progressive and cumulative pathway that transforms insecurity into long-term institutional and human capital erosion. Ideological opposition to Western

education and persistent targeted violence against schools and teachers convert learning spaces into zones of fear, leading to repeated school closures, disrupted academic calendars, and weakened governance structures within educational institutions (Baba, 2016; Ekereke, 2013). These disruptions cascade into capacity erosion as infrastructure is destroyed, staff are displaced or unwilling to accept postings in high-risk areas, and institutional memory and administrative coherence decline, severely constraining organizational resilience (Abiodun et al., 2020; Bello, 2022). At the learner level, fear, displacement, and economic hardship reduce enrolment and retention, exacerbate gender disparities through early marriage and child labor, and undermine academic performance, even where schools remain operational (Abubakar & Amurtiya, 2023; Ekereke, 2013). As illustrated in Figure 3, the long-term consequence is not merely interrupted schooling. However, a structural weakening of educational organizations, resulting in diminished human capital formation, deepening inequality, and reduced regional recovery capacity, which reinforces conditions associated with conflict persistence and undermines sustainable development in Northeast Nigeria (Ikpe, 2017; Ebonyi, 2019; Kangdim et al., 2022).

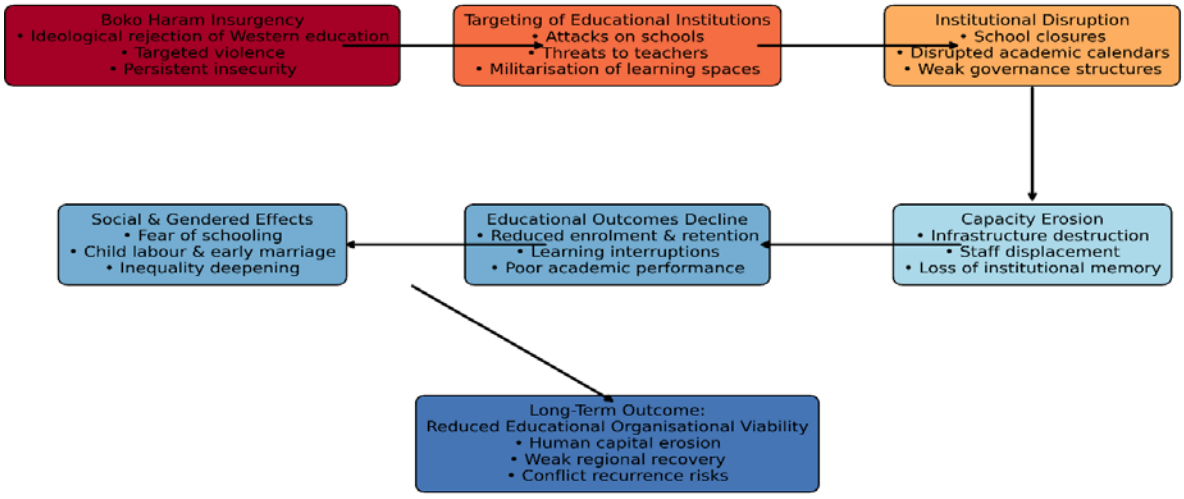



Figure 3: Thematic Causal Pathway Diagram of the Impact of Boko Haram Insurgency on Educational Sector Viability in Northeast Nigeria

Figures 1–3 present a unified comparative framework demonstrating that Boko Haram insurgency undermines organizational viability in Northeast Nigeria through structurally similar pathways across government, private business, and educational sectors, albeit with sector-specific manifestations. In each case, insurgency functions as a persistent structural shock that destabilizes operating environments by eroding territorial control and state legitimacy in the public sector, disrupting market access and investment confidence in the private sector, and transforming schools into insecure spaces of ideological contestation in the education sector (Emmanuelar, 2015; Ebonyi, 2019; Baba, 2016). These initial disruptions converge into institutional and operational breakdowns characterized by weakened

coordination, workforce displacement, constrained planning horizons, and escalating operational costs, confirming that organizational failure is conflict-induced rather than a reflection of inherent capacity weaknesses (Ikpe, 2017; Kangdim et al., 2022). Ultimately, as illustrated across Figures 1–3, all sectors arrive at comparable outcomes of reduced organisational viability sustained by negative feedback loops, manifested as low performance governance equilibria in the public sector, enterprise fragility and economic contraction in the private sector, and human capital erosion in the education system, collectively undermining long term development and recovery prospects in Northeast Nigeria (Ikpe, 2017; Abubakar & Amurtiya, 2023; De Simone & Iocchi, 2022).

## Conclusion

This study concludes that Boko Haram insurgency has systematically undermined organizational viability in Northeast Nigeria by transforming insecurity into a persistent structural condition that erodes institutional continuity, resilience, and sustainability across government, private, and educational sectors. The findings demonstrate that public sector organisations experience weakened legitimacy, fragmented coordination, and crisis-driven governance that constrain policy implementation and long-term state effectiveness; private businesses, particularly SMEs, face disrupted markets, distorted investment decisions, escalating operational risks, and enterprise fragility that suppress employment and regional economic growth; while educational institutions suffer targeted attacks, repeated closures, staff displacement, and declining enrolment that culminate in human capital erosion and long-term development losses. By integrating sector-specific evidence within a unified causal framework, the study advances policy and security discourse by highlighting that organizational failure in conflict settings is not merely a capacity deficit but a conflict-induced institutional process. The study therefore contributes to organizational resilience scholarship by underscoring the need for security-sensitive governance, conflict-aware economic recovery, and adaptive institutional frameworks capable of sustaining organizational viability under prolonged insecurity.

## Recommendations

The following recommendations are deemed imperative for this study.

i. Government and Public Sector: Government at all levels in Northeast Nigeria should strengthen institutional resilience through security-sensitive governance reforms that restore administrative mobility, improve inter-agency coordination, and integrate conflict risk into planning and budgeting. Post-conflict reconstruction should prioritize rebuilding public infrastructure, retaining skilled personnel, and adopting flexible policy implementation frameworks capable of operating under residual insecurity.

ii. Private Sector: Private sector recovery should be supported through targeted incentives and risk-mitigation mechanisms, including tax relief, access to affordable finance, security guarantees, and investment protection. Reviving supply chains and supporting SMEs are critical to restoring employment, rebuilding local economies, and reducing the conflict–poverty cycle in Northeast Nigeria.

iii. Educational Sector: Educational viability requires the promotion of safe schooling policies, protection of learning facilities, and incentives for teacher retention in high-risk areas. Expanding alternative and flexible learning systems alongside institutional rebuilding will help address learning losses and safeguard long-term human capital development in Northeast Nigeria.

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# FROM LOCALIZED VIOLENCE TO REGIONAL INSECURITY: THE DRIVERS AND SPILLOVER MECHANISMS OF BANDITRY AND KIDNAPING IN TARABA STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** Taraba State has witnessed a surge in banditry and kidnapping in recent years. These security challenges have resulted in loss of lives, displacement of communities, and economic instability. This paper examines localized violence in relation to regional insecurity, with the drivers and spillover mechanisms of banditry and kidnapping in Taraba State, and ponders: what are the principal drivers and enabling factors of banditry and kidnapping in the state? How have actors, markets, terrain, and governance conditions shaped the insecurity in the state? What are the implications of the insecurity in neighboring states on Taraba State, and what responses can be feasible in ameliorating the menace in the state? The methodology adopted in this study was content analysis, where secondary data was sourced from textbooks, journal articles, documentaries, and internet sources to examine the activities of bandits and kidnappers in the state. This study used state fragility theory, which points to states' inability to fulfill their social contract to provide basic security and services for their citizens. The study discovered that poverty, unemployment, and porous borders are key drivers. Large ungoverned areas and a lack of a legal framework to prohibit open grazing are the causes of banditry and kidnapping in the state and therefore recommends strengthening security presence, improving community engagement, strengthening reconciliatory efforts, and economic development and inter-state collaborative efforts to mitigate the menace. The paper therefore concludes that understanding these underlying dynamics can help policymakers and security experts develop more effective strategies to prevent and address these crimes.

**Keywords:** Localized violence, regional insecurity, drivers of banditry, spillover mechanisms, kidnapping, Taraba State

## Introduction

In recent years, banditry and kidnappings have evolved from episodic criminality into structured and profit-seeking violence across parts of Nigeria. Taraba State, strategically located between the North East and North Central zones, sharing an international border with Cameroon and with other states within Nigeria, has been made vulnerable, allowing criminals from all angles to operate within the state unchecked. The state's geographical location and large ungoverned spaces have created a complex situation that has made the state a criminal

hub for banditry and kidnapping activities (Okeke, 2021). Relatively, the diffusion of armed actors who are displaced from adjacent theaters of conflict such as Benue, Plateau, Nasarawa, and Adamawa, and even cross-border migrants from Cameroon, compounded security challenges in the state, which resulted in the displacement of communities, loss of lives, and economic instability (Okeke, 2021). The multiple conflict ecosystems in the state include pastoralist-farmer tensions, resource competition in forest and mining belts, cross-border smuggling, and communal crises.

Taraba State also has dense forest reserves, river valleys, and mountainous highlands, which create both sanctuary areas for armed groups and choke points along trade and transit routes, which bandits in the state conveniently use. The state's diverse ethno-linguistic composition coexists with shifting land-use patterns as climate stress and demographic pressures reshape pastoral and agricultural livelihoods (Olaniyan & Okeke, 2022). Disputes over alleged grazing routes and farm encroachment frequently intersect with electoral politics, which has deferred conflict resolution mechanisms that could have resolved the conflicts in the state (Okeke, 2023).

A close look at the banditry and kidnapping in the state has shown that the citizens are either victims within the state or outside the state, as witnessed on April 15, 2014, when Nwokyo was attacked in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State, where ten people were killed while eighteen others were seriously injured (Bello, 2021). Similarly, fifteen persons were killed in two communities in Gashaka Local Government Area of Taraba State on April 12th, 2016, in which no arrest was made in respect of the attack. On 12th July 2025, seventeen passengers were kidnapped along the Wukari highway near Federal University, Wukari. More so, in Karim Lamido Local Government Area, a 62-year-old man named Hassan Janyu was kidnapped from Mashinga Kirya but later rescued. All these are empirical evidence of banditry and kidnapping activities in the state.

This paper x-rays localized violence as a driver of regional insecurity, with the drivers and spillover mechanisms of banditry and kidnapping in Taraba State. The study attempted to answer the following questions: What are the principal drivers and enabling factors of banditry and kidnapping in the state? How do actors, markets, terrain, and governance conditions shape the insecurity in the state? What are the implications of the insecurity in Taraba State for the neighboring states, and what responses can be feasible in ameliorating the menace in the state? The methodology adopted in this study was content analysis, where the secondary data was sourced from textbooks, journal articles, documentaries, and internet sources to examine the activities of bandits and kidnappers in the state.

## Conceptual clarifications

### Localized Violence

Localized violence is acts that are geographically confined to specific communities, Local Government Areas, or regions, rather than spreading nationwide or across borders. Localized violence involves small-scale, area-specific conflict actors and dynamics. It has spatial confinement, meaning it happens in specific geographical regions and smaller geographical units, and it has local actor overlap. The violence pattern here depends on local strength ratios of groups active in that area.

An uprising is usually a localized act of popular violence, which sometimes is state-based violence, usually between states versus armed groups. Non-state-based violence is usually between armed groups, often localized, such as communal clashes, which is one-sided violence usually against unarmed civilians by state or non-state actors. Examples of localized violence are farmer-herder clashes in Benue, Plateau, Nasarawa and Taraba states. This conflict is geographically limited to grazing routes and border areas. Local actors include farmer-herder clashes, militias, urban gang or neighborhood violence, and sub-national post-conflict violence.

### Regional insecurity

Regional insecurity is the condition of instability, threat, and vulnerability affecting a specific geographic region where the safety and stability of states or actors within that region are interlinked. Insecurity itself is a lack of safety or protection, or a feeling of anxiety, fear, or self-doubt. It therefore means regional insecurity is a lack of safety or protection shared across a region due to interlinked threats. The components of regional insecurity include insurgency, militancy, separatist violence, banditry, identity conflicts, communal clashes, farmer-herder violence, poverty, uneven development, unemployment, climate change, drought, resource scarcity, and food insecurity. Regional insecurity creates regional vulnerability, which is the susceptibility of a specific area due to inherent characteristics such as exposure to hazards and limited capacity to cope. Regional insecurity is a shared insecurity among neighboring states due to geographic proximity. Insecurity clusters regionally because threats spread short distances.

### Banditry

Banditry is a term used to describe armed robbery, kidnapping, and other violent crimes often carried out by organized groups, typically in rural or unsecured areas (Akinyetun, 2022). In Nigeria, banditry has been a persistent security challenge, particularly in the North West and North Central regions of the country. Banditry activities involve armed attacks, kidnapping usually for ransom, cattle rustling, and violence against civilians, including murder, injury, or

displacement (Olaniyan & Okeke, 2022). Banditry is promoted by a weak security presence in the state, which often leads to economic hardships. Bandits can have chances to operate freely when there is collusion between bandits and security officials in the state (Okeke, 2023).

**Drivers of banditry**

Banditry is a violent criminal activity like armed robbery, kidnapping, cattle rustling, and extortion in rural areas. It is a multifaceted phenomenon driven by overlapping structural and local factors. The core drivers of banditry are poverty and youth unemployment, idleness, and economic frustration that push them into kidnapping and cattle rustling for income (Sani & Bakura, 2025). Many conflicts are perpetrated by youth due to poverty, inequality, unemployment, and lack of economic opportunities (Sani & Bakura, 2025).

**Spill-over Mechanisms of Banditry**

Spill-over is the impact of events or actions that affect other areas or groups beyond the initial context. Under security contexts, spill-over effects include conflict or violence spreading to neighboring states that share a border with the affected state. The effects could be displacement that can cause refugee flows or other humanitarian crises in the state. A good example can be seen where insurgency in the neighboring states of Benue, Adamawa, Nasarawa, and Plateau states has affected the state of security in Taraba State (Vanguard, 2025).

Banditry started in northwestern Nigeria but has spilled over into Taraba through several pathways. These incidents are popularly called regional insecurity interdependence. Threats travel short distances and affect neighbors. The spillover mechanisms into Taraba have been caused by the displacement of bandits in neighboring states by Military Operations (Vanguard, 2025). When troops pressured the bandits, they abandoned their camps in Zamfara and Katsina, fragmented into smaller mobile units, and relocated into new forest corridors; Taraba State's forests became fallback bases. Moreover, Taraba State shares porous borders and forest reserves with Benue, Plateau, Bauchi, and Adamawa. Through these porous borders, bandits used Gwana Mountain and Yunkunssu Forest as camps and transit routes (Daily Trust, 2025).

**Kidnapping**

Kidnapping is when someone is taken and held hostage against his or her will, usually for ransom or political gains (Abubakar, 2022). Kidnapping can be done by individuals, groups, or even governments for reasons of their interest. In Nigeria, kidnapping is a significant security concern often linked to demands for ransom, political motives, or other factors relating to the motive of the planner. The types of kidnapping usually found in the state

include: simple kidnapping, where no ransom is demanded but for just unlawful detention; kidnapping that involves harm, threats, or exploitation; and taking a child away from their guardians (Okeke, 2023).

**Taraba State**

Taraba State is a state in the northeastern part of Nigeria; the state shares an international border with Cameroon, which affects three Local Government Areas of the state, including Sadauna Local Government Area, Ussa Local Government Area, and Takum Local Government Area. The boundaries are mountainous and are predominantly occupied by farmers due to the land's fertility for agricultural purposes. The state is known for its diverse cultural and natural resources in agricultural production. The state's capital is Jalingo, and the state has a mix of ethnic groups. The state is often referred to as "Nature's Gift to the Nation" due to its rich natural resources, including agriculture, mineral resources, and tourism attraction centers.

**Theatrical framework**

State fragility theory is one of the economic, political, social, and environmental concepts that can be used to measure a state's capabilities in providing the societal needs of the people. The theory points to the state's inability to fulfill its social contract through providing the basic needs and services for its citizens (Perera, 2015). Fragility, in simple terms, is the act of being prone to or getting damaged by the slightest carelessness. A fragile state is a state that is delicate and vulnerable, and unable to provide the essential human needs of its citizens. Fragile states are usually vulnerable to environmental problems and are prone to being easily affected by vices such as poverty, unemployment, violent attacks, kidnappings, trafficking, and displacements. Torres & Anderson (2004) note that sovereign states are expected to perform certain minimal functions to guarantee the security and well-being of their citizens for the smooth working of the system. However, when the state fails to fulfill part of its social contract, people's expectations are not met. Citizens become plunged into difficult living conditions, thereby rendering states weak.

Similarly, Perera (2015) argued that, in a fragile state, there is an increased likelihood of violence, poor health, low educational attainment, banditry, and kidnapping. The state fragility theory stressed the fundamental failure of the state to perform functions necessary to meet citizens' basic needs and expectations. It also exposed the inability of government to meet basic security needs and maintain the rule of law and justice. The states' fragility theory underscores a weak and ineffective government with little practical control over much of its territory, leaving the country vulnerable to all forms of insecurity in the state. Towing the same line, Bolton & Hernandez (2016) pointed out that 50% of fragile states' population lives on less than $1.25 USD per day, which significantly increases the likelihood of violence, poor health, low educational attainment, armed conflict, and extreme poverty.

The fragility theory is relevant in explaining the living conditions of people in Taraba State in relation to human security in the state from the angle of government policies and their impacts on the larger society. The centrality of state fragility theory in this study, from localized violence to regional insecurity, with a focus on the drivers and spillover mechanisms of banditry and kidnapping in Taraba State, cannot be overemphasized because the numerous security challenges confronting the state range from ethno-religious conflict to insurgency, banditry, and kidnapping, which the state government appears to be unable to handle. This has obviously exposed the weakness of the state and qualified it as being structurally and institutionally fragile.

**Structural Drivers and Political Economy of Armed Violence in Taraba State**

To many scholars, pervasive material inequalities are factors propelling crime in society. Perera (2015) argues that the prevalence of banditry and kidnapping in any state is connected with a bad economy, poverty, and pervasive material inequalities. Similarly, Muhammad et al. (2015) argued that the causes of banditry and kidnappings in the state are when people struggle for land resources in the country, especially between herders and farmers. Similarly, Abbass (2012) attributes the violent conflict in the states to environmental factors such as climate change and exploitation of scarce resources. Global climate change and desertification have reduced green grass areas, thereby compelling pastoralists to move southward in search of pastures for their cattle. In addition, the capitalist tendency to acquire large land for farming and expand farmland for commercial purposes has also reduced the land space available, therefore making land a scarce commodity to compete for cattle grazing and cultivation by farmers, in which the two conflicting demands escalated conflicts in the state.

The pervasive material inequality has also contributed to the security challenges in Taraba State because there is growing awareness of inequalities and disparities in life chances among youths in the state, which made the majority of the youths engage in criminal acts. This agrees with Achumba et al. (2013), who aver that when there is a general perception of marginalization by a section of the people in a state through political patronage. This can trigger disaffection, resentment, and revolt among the youths in the state. Poverty has made the majority of youth in the state patronize crime and other social vices to make ends meet. There are clear indices of severe underdevelopment in the state considering the amount of looted money that goes in the echelon of the political realm. In a similar vein, Fiase & Abughdyer (2024) maintain that the rising rate of youth unemployment in the state is certainly one of the causes of social crimes like prostitution, armed robbery, armed banditry, oil bunkering, internet fraud, drug addiction, trafficking, and kidnapping. To these scholars, unemployment leads to economic deprivation and frustration, which lures many youths into violent crimes, compounding security challenges in the state. The research has shown that many of these youths who engaged in these criminal activities are university graduates.

The precarious security situation in Taraba State calls for attention because it is exacerbated by the limited presence of security personnel or law enforcement officials due to large ungoverned spaces in the state. These inadequate security personnel are, in most cases, underfunded and poorly equipped and, as a matter of fact, are compromised to make both ends meet. The corrupt nature of the security situation in the state is in line with the position of Addoh (2013), who avers that some corrupt ones even sell arms to criminals. At the border areas, weapons are either stolen from Nigerian military stocks or purchased from thriving Central African arms black market owing to the insurgents' source of weaponry. The circulation of arms in the hands of civilians in the state has been promoted through compromise on the part of the security agencies. A similar thought has been echoed by the former US Ambassador to Nigeria, John Campbell, who opined that there are sympathizers in the Nigerian Army that deliberately leave doors of armories unlocked for Boko Haram (Addoh, 2013).

The youth militias in Taraba State have entered a different phase since their inception because there has been a link between the leadership of the youth militia groups and top politicians and the security agents, on the other hand. This assertion agrees with Fiase & Abughdyer (2024), who aver that, in the 2015 and 2019 general elections, almost all leading politicians in the country had at least one youth group or another, and the causes of their engagement were poverty, unemployment, social exclusion, and frustration. Similarly, Akuhwa (2015) maintains that there are still other youth militia groups that spread sporadically in the state and are very ruthless, tactical, and dogged, and some are even educated but unemployed. Sympathetically, most of them engage in these illicit acts for nothing more than paltry sums, red wine, and spirits.

Bad governance and politically motivated violence are drivers of insecurity in the state because some violent acts in the state are politically motivated due to the desperation by the political class to win elections and control the resources of the state. The politics of do or die has taken center stage and has been exemplified by thuggery, violence, blackmail, and kidnappings. Politics is seen as a lucrative business, and the politics of a zero-sum game, where the winner takes all, and the loser loses everything, becomes the order of the day. The desire by the political class to amass wealth for personal gains is a driving force for every politician, as aptly captured by Jibo (2021), who eloquently stated that politicians have been less focused since the return of democracy in 1999 because many of them see politics as the capture of the state's power to enjoy it at the expense of the development of the larger society.

The above practices have made winning very important such that some politicians use violence to capture and maintain power and influence. This has happened repeatedly in the state, as witnessed in Chanchanji Ward, Takum Local Government Area, in the 1998 general elections. This has resulted in numerous politically motivated assassinations achievable through empowering bandits and supplying them with arms to execute them, since many assassinations and kidnappings in the state are not unconnected with the election in the state (Okoro, 2011). Similarly, the power tussle between the Jukuns and Kutebs people of the

Takum Local Government over the chieftaincy stool in the Local Government has been a recurrent decimal, as the event breeds armed militias on both sides that have caused insecurity in the Local Government for decades. It has become evident that the goals of political violence in the state have shifted from traditional instruments, which were matches and knives, to small arms such as locally fabricated and imported pistols and a range of assault rifles.

Also in Taraba State, the overwhelming poverty and underdevelopment today can easily be attributed to poor, visionless, inept and selfish leadership. Corruption is the biggest problem that has eaten deep into the fabric of the state's economy. The leadership's unwillingness to rise to the occasion in their respective responsibilities is a major challenge for security in the state. The leadership in the state has sustained underdevelopment through mismanagement of the enormous and God-given resources. The wealth of the state is wasted through the purchase of foreign and exotic goods and services for personal use. More so, a large chunk of that wealth is usually stolen through inflated contracts, fraud, and other dubious means. Public funds are directed at white elephant projects and programs that do not create employment opportunities for the people of the state, and colossal sums of public funds have been lost in the process. State treasuries are looted, and monies are often taken to foreign banks in Europe and America, depriving citizens of the benefits of reaping from the stolen money that would have been reinvested.

The similar economic situation in Taraba State was echoed by Fiase & Abughdyer (2024), who maintain that the stolen monies all ended up in the pockets of a few privileged government officials, and the general people are worse off for it because the political leaders that control these offices looted and subverted the system for their personal interest. The weakness of the judicial system in the country is manifested in its slow case resolution, low conviction rates, and perceived impunity, which has weakened deterrence in the state. Towing the same line, corruption has killed entrepreneurship in the state since it has left nothing to desire in hard work; consequently, diligence and honesty have been dethroned while dishonesty and greed have been enthroned, and merit has died in the state, which has paved the way for mediocrity. The present condition of unemployment in Taraba State is questionable since the unemployment rate is on the rise and the state government seems not to have come up with any effective public plan to tackle youth unemployment.

The porous borders across the state have made the state an entry and exit route for small arms and light weapons, paving the way for people to make use of these arms for personal gain. The security personnel have also promoted the proliferation of arms in the state through selling these arms and ammunition to the militia. This assertion agrees with Fiase & Abughdyer (2024), who stated that the security personnel have been accused of selling arms to criminals. Towing the same line, Abagen & Tyona (2018) stated that the Department of State Security (DSS) blamed the worsening condition of security in the state on corrupt members of the Armed Forces and other security agencies who allegedly sold arms to criminals. These arguments were buttressed when operations were conducted and discovered

that more than 30 people were involved in the supply of arms and ammunition. Some of them are serving security men in Nigeria. There was also a case in one of the armories belonging to the Armed Forces where many pistols went missing with quantities of ammunition, and all the pistols were new, and the armory was not broken into (Abagen & Tyona, 2018). The porous borders allow all sorts of cross-border crimes such as human trafficking, smuggling, drug trafficking, arms robbery, money laundering, and illicit arms trafficking in the state. The ineffectiveness of security agencies in border management has been exacerbated by a lack of political will on the part of the government. The lack of modern technological facilities and equipment to secure borders, and the lack of office accommodation for border patrol personnel, have all made the task of security agents in the state extremely difficult.

In the area of communication, there are poor communication channels such as radios and mobile phones for effective dissemination of information, making inter-agency networking a difficult task. There is a lack of a road network to enable smooth border patrol by the patrol officers (Ismail & Rabi, 2022). When borders cease to function effectively, different forms of crime prevail, and the security of people in that state is put to serious jeopardy.

Inadequate funding of the security agencies is also said to be a contributory factor to the level of insecurity in the state. Buttressing this point, Achumba et al. (2013) stated that lack of modern equipment, both in weaponry and training, poor welfare of security personnel, and inadequate personnel have aggravated the security situation in the state. He further stated that it is disheartening to notice that the police-population ratio in Nigeria is 1:45, which falls below the standard set by the United Nations. The implication of this is that Nigeria is grossly under-policed, which partly explains the inability of the Nigerian Police Force to combat crimes and criminality in the country effectively (Fiase & Abughdyer, 2024). The above fact explains why Taraba State, which has large ungoverned spaces, would not have adequate security personnel to guarantee security for all people of the state. Many large settlements in the state have no police station. Even in the places where there are, security reforms allow only the Police Headquarters to maintain arms and ammunition, leaving the outstations with only buttons, rendering the entire station vulnerable to militia that are always well armed.

**Operational networks, modalities of violence, and spatial diffusion of insecurity in Taraba State**

The dynamic nature and the operational methods of these bandits in Taraba State have led to them being classified as either core, auxiliary, or community-level bandits. The core bandit groups are flexible, with network cells that assemble and disband for specific operations, and they also share logistics and informants to facilitate their activities without being tracked by security personnel. These groups have coordinated networks and leadership that are recognized by the community and the political class in the state. These groups are often used during inter-ethnic and communal crises. They are often used during elections in the state. The auxiliaries are facilitators and informants who work along highways and in market squares to provide information to the core bandits. These groups provide information to the

core bandits and even assist them in escaping the sight of security personnel unnoticed. The Community-level armed actors are local vigilante and hunters' associations that provide protection but can also escalate conflict or, in some places, be co-opted to become bandits. It is always difficult to separate community-level armed actors from bandit groups in the community, considering the high degree of their integration in the state.

The implications of the activities of these bandit groups on the security of the state are pronounced and glaring to the extent that they attract scholarly attention. Jibo (2021) argued that the large ungoverned spaces in the state made it easy for these groups to operate freely without interference by any security agencies. Ungoverned spaces mean security personnel are grossly inadequate to cover them. Apart from the above, lack of equipment and modern technology also promotes insecurity, as maintained by Achumba et al. (2013), who stated that lack of modern equipment both in weaponry and training, poor welfare of security personnel, and inadequate personnel have aggravated the security condition of the state. The insecurity in the state has led to the destruction of some amenities. Intra-ethnic or communal misunderstandings and attacks by bandits, militants, and other criminal elements in the local communities of the state led to the destruction of hospitals, markets, and schools. They forced many children to drop out of school. Similarly, reduced planting and early harvest due to fear, abandonment of high-yield crops, and increased farm-gate transaction costs affected economic activities in the state. Displacement effects caused through intensified security operations in adjacent states have also pushed the criminal groups into Taraba State’s sanctuaries, thereby aggravating security in the state.

Kidnappings in Taraba State have many modes of operation and varying reasons for their activities. Some operate for ransom; their major targets include commuters on inter-local government area roads, farmers during marketing seasons, and traders transporting livestock or cash across the state, who operate on the highways. These ransoms become increasingly structured with tied negotiation tactics and mobile-money cash-out strategies conducted via proxy means. These bandits embark on road ambushes near bends, bridges, or forest edges, where escape routes are pre-surveyed to target travelers. Activities on these roads include illicit taxation of cattle convoys, timber trucks, and mass transit buses, and these activities are promoted by forest reserves and mountainous zones with limited patrol coverage by security personnel in the state.

There are activities of village raids by these bandits which include short-duration night raids for cash, food, phones, rapping and abductees. These activities are facilitated by the proliferation of small arms, recycled weapons from conflict zones, leakage from security stockpiles, and craft production. The circulation of these arms is perpetually unchecked, allowing bandits to operate without interception by any security outfit in the state.

The spill-over effects of insecurity into the states have been promoted through displacement of actors or pressure from neighboring states of Adamawa, Benue, Gombe, Plateau, and Nasarawa states respectively. The replication of kidnapping activities for ransom and, on the

whole, the maturity of these ransom markets in the state consequently created an insecure state. Cross-border supply of arms and ammunition from Cameroon and later diffusion of these arms across the state have helped sustain the operation of armed banditry in the state (Aboh, 2024). There is a high level of labor mobility across the state borders, thereby creating agricultural labor bottlenecks in Taraba State. The anti-open grazing laws enacted by the past administration have not been implemented, and bandits exploited jurisdictional gaps between state commands and local by-laws on grazing, logging, and mining to perpetuate crimes in the state.

The inter-state movement has made bandits move from Plateau State into Taraba State due to the unregulated movement of people across the states. The unregulated movement of people across the states has been witnessed in the state when the Nigerian Army arrested bandits in Karim Lamido Local Government Area of Taraba State who were originally from Plateau State, alleged to have paid a local chief ₦1.5m to establish a camp in the area. Also, bandits traveled from Tongo/Garin Alkali, Adamawa, to Shana in Bali Local Government Area of Taraba (Vanguard, 2025).

In Taraba State, the specific spillover hotspots are in Karim Lamido, Ardo-Kola, and Lau Local Government Areas in Northern Taraba, which borders Plateau and Bauchi states. In Southern Taraba, specifically in Wukari, Takum, and Ussa Local Government Areas that border Benue, the Operation Whirl Stroke troops destroyed Bajor syndicate hideouts in Takum Local Government Area, and the bandits moved in motorcycles, operated in hundreds, demarcated farmlands, and banned farming in the state (Vanguard, 2025). In Central Taraba, particularly in Gassol and Bali Local Government Areas, bandits imposed tax, abducted farmers and cattle owners. Fulani herdsmen have attacked several villages in Lau, Ardo-Kola, Bali, Donga, and Gassol Local Government Areas.

**Conclusion**

Banditry and kidnappings in the state emerged from a confluence of structural pressures, market incentives and ungoverned spaces. The current security challenges in the state are witnessing unrestrained proliferation of arms among bandits who terrorize innocent citizens in towns and villages, which calls for effective control mechanisms. The security of the people of Taraba State is sacrosanct and must not be compromised. There is a need for a layered approach-prevention, deterrence, disruption, and recovery through inter-state and cross-border cooperation that is anchored on community legitimacy. The spill-over effect from displacement in adjacent states, which pushed many groups into Taraba State, should be examined and possibly confined in identified central places to be monitored by the government.

**Recommendations**

i. The government should address poverty and unemployment through economic development initiatives that focus on youth empowerment programs like short-cycle vocational training, cash-for-work on feeder roads, and enterprise grants tied to mentorship. There should be scaled youth livelihood pipelines tied to private sector apprenticeships.

ii. The security agencies should increase patrols and community policing to deter banditry and kidnapping in the state. There should be time-bound joint operations on specific road segments and river crossings, with physical improvements such as vegetation clearance and lighting at choke points, to make those places open to destroy hideouts for criminals in the state. The government should establish controlled access to forest reserves with ranger-security joint patrols and smart boundary monitoring so that bandits cannot use them as hideouts.

iii. The Government of Taraba State should collaborate and share intelligence and coordinated efforts to combat banditry and kidnapping. There should be community early warning and response structured hotlines, incident logging, and rapid alert protocols linking village committees with local security posts. The state government should establish early warning networks in priority local government areas and also set up an inter-state incident dashboard and monthly coordination meetings for dictation of the activities of the bandits in the state. Inter-state and cross-border coordination should be promoted with shared incident maps, suspect rosters and after-action reviews. There should be institutionalized cross-border protocols with Cameroon.

iv. Information sharing on arms trafficking and safe house locations and synchronized patrols in border-adjacent reserves. The state government should make deliberate efforts to strengthen the intelligence-sharing mechanism between security agencies, local vigilante groups, traditional rulers, and hunters' associations to enhance their effectiveness. The government should create a wireless network that does not attract charges for calls and messages to enhance smooth inter-agency communication.

v. Taraba State government is advised to construct ranches in the designated areas and rent them to herders and educate them on the need for ranching in the state because ranching, as the best global practice in modern livestock farming, has a lot of benefits that herders need to be educated on. After education and construction of these ranches, open grazing should be criminalized to make the acts punishable by law in the state.

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# NIGERIA-CAMEROON OBLIGATIONS UNDER THE 1951 REFUGEE CONVENTION: IMPLICATIONS OF AMBAZONIA-BIAFRA SEPARATIST AGITATIONS

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**Abstract.** The resurgence of the Ambazonian separatist crisis in Cameroon's Anglophone regions and the renewed push for a sovereign State of Biafra in south-eastern Nigeria have forced thousands of people across borders, placing both governments under real pressure to live up to their obligations under the 1951 Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees and its 1967 Protocol. Despite the scale and complexity of this displacement, scholars have largely examined these crises in isolation, focusing either on their political character or on the humanitarian response, without seriously asking how Nigeria and Cameroon's actual conduct, as both refugee-generating and refugee-receiving states, measures up against their binding legal commitments. This study fills that gap through a systematic legal and empirical assessment of both states' compliance with the non-refoulement principle, the right to seek asylum, and related protections under the 1951 Convention. Although both states have ratified the relevant instruments, and Cameroon's constitution expressly recognizes the primacy of international treaties, the evidence points to persistent violations of non-refoulement and other refugee protection norms. Working within a dual theoretical framework of Realism and Human Needs Theory, and drawing on qualitative analysis of secondary data, the study finds that both governments have defaulted on their international refugee law obligations, most starkly illustrated by Nigeria's 2018 forced return of 47 Cameroonian asylum seekers in defiance of UNHCR protests. The findings reveal a troubling gap between what the law demands and what states actually do, showing how political calculations continue to overshadow humanitarian duty. The study recommends that both Nigeria and Cameroon close this gap and align their practices with the standards enshrined in the Convention and its Protocol.

**Keywords:** Refugee Convention, Ambazonia, Biafra, separatist agitation, Protocol.

## Introduction

Africa has long borne the double burden of producing and sheltering some of the world's largest populations of forcibly displaced people. Within the West and Central African sub-region, Nigeria and Cameroon occupy a particularly paradoxical position in the refugee protection architecture, each serving at once as a country of origin, transit, and asylum. Ezemenaka et al. (2021) point to the concurrent separatist agitations within their shared neighborhood as the sharpest illustration of this paradox: the Ambazonian crisis in Cameroon's Anglophone North-West and South-West regions, and the Biafran agitation in Nigeria's South-East. Sakhri (2024) notes that these twin crises have not only generated massive internal and cross-border displacement but have also drawn intense international scrutiny over whether both states are genuinely honoring their obligations under the 1951 Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees and its 1967 Protocol.

Taylor (2024) confirms that both Nigeria and Cameroon are legally bound by the 1951 Refugee Convention, its 1967 Protocol, and the 1969 Organization of African Unity (OAU) Convention Governing the Specific Aspects of Refugee Problems in Africa. The cornerstone of the 1951 Convention is the principle of non-refoulement under Article 33, which prohibits returning any refugee to a country where their life or freedom is at risk. The Convention further protects refugees from expulsion except under strictly defined conditions, from punishment for irregular entry, from discrimination, and guarantees rights to decent work, housing, and social protection. Nigeria has ratified these instruments and incorporated them into domestic law through the National Commission for Refugees Act. Eromo (2025) notes that Nigeria's commitment is further evidenced in its policy of granting Temporary Protection Status to Cameroonian refugees and its out-of-camp approach, which integrates refugees into host communities. Cameroon similarly ratified the 1951 Convention and the 1969 OAU Convention and was long regarded as one of Africa's most generous refugee-hosting countries.

However, the formal commitments of both states sit in troubling contradiction to how they have actually behaved in the face of the Ambazonian and Biafran crises. Amin (2020) argues that, different as their histories are, both crises share a common root in the structural denial of political recognition, cultural rights, and equitable governance to minority and marginalized communities. Anslem (2022) traces the Ambazonian crisis to the systematic sidelining of Cameroon's Anglophone minority within a Francophone-dominated unitary state. Oko (2024) observes that what began in October 2016 as peaceful strikes by Anglophone lawyers and teachers was met with violent state suppression, mass arrests, and an internet blackout. Bang et al. (2022) argue this heavy-handed response transformed a legitimate grievance about linguistic and educational marginalization into a full-blown armed conflict. Chukwudi et al. (2019) note that the unilateral declaration of the Republic of Ambazonia in October 2017 triggered a massive military counterinsurgency. Human Rights Watch (2021) has documented unlawful killings, sexual violence, the destruction of homes, and harassment of those who spoke out, while armed separatists have also committed serious abuses. Dicklitch (2011)

records that by mid-2023, the crisis had produced over 638,000 internally displaced people and left at least 1.7 million in need of humanitarian assistance.

In Nigeria, the Biafran agitation draws its energy from the unresolved wounds of the 1967-1970 civil war. The failure to address the structural causes of Igbo marginalization after the war, skewed resource distribution, political exclusion, and ethnic subordination, created fertile ground for the revival of separatist sentiment. The Indigenous People of Biafra (IPOB), under Nnamdi Kanu, grew into a transnational movement demanding self-determination. Moses (2014) argues that the Nigerian government's response has been characterized by escalating coercion. Amnesty International has documented unlawful killings, torture, enforced disappearances, arbitrary arrests, and displacement between January 2021 and December 2024. Military operations, including Operation Python Dance (2016), Operation Python Dance II (2017), and Operation Udo Ka (2023), each left documented abuses in their wake. The state-backed Ebube Agu paramilitary force has itself engaged in arbitrary arrests, extrajudicial executions, and the destruction of homes. Combined violence has produced more than 3.6 million internally displaced persons and sent approximately 383,000 Nigerian refugees to Chad, Cameroon, and Niger.

The displacement consequences of both crises are severe and mutually reinforcing. By the end of 2024, Nigeria was hosting 127,000 refugees and asylum seekers from 41 countries while grappling with 3.5 million of its own internally displaced people, and nearly 400,000 Nigerian refugees remained in neighboring countries as thousands more Cameroonians continued to arrive. Lekunze (2023) notes that between August 2021 and August 2022, the number of internally displaced persons in Cameroon rose by roughly 27,000, bringing the total to 385,372, while ongoing violence by Boko Haram and ISWAP in the Far North continued to drive fresh displacement. Penney (2019) documents that despite their formal commitments, Cameroon has forcibly returned over 2,600 refugees to Nigerian border communities against their will, with UNHCR (2017) confirming such forced returns constitute a serious violation of both the 1951 Convention and the 1969 OAU Convention. Nigeria, meanwhile, has exploited the securitization of the Biafran agitation to sidestep its protection obligations. Cameroon's government also walked away from mediation, halting a Swiss-led dialogue in September 2022. Human Rights Watch (2024) notes that these violations carry profound implications for the international legal standing of both states and the safety of hundreds of thousands of civilians caught in the crossfire. This paper examines Nigeria and Cameroon's obligations under the 1951 Refugee Convention in light of the Ambazonian and Biafran agitations, interrogates the gap between formal commitment and actual conduct, and proposes frameworks for accountability.

**Objectives of the Study**

The objectives guiding the study are:

i. To identify the gap between legal obligation and state practice that illustrates how Nigeria and Cameroon prioritize political interest over refugee and humanitarian concerns.

ii. To ascertain whether Nigeria and Cameroon have violated the 1951 Convention by forcefully arresting and deporting refugees, including the Ambazonian leaders and Mazi Nnamdi Kanu, whose imprisonment clearly contradicts the Convention.

iii. To determine whether the image and integrity of Nigerian and Cameroonian citizens are respected when they travel abroad.

**Research Questions**

The following research questions guided the study:

i. What are the existing gaps between legal obligation and state practice that illustrate the prioritization of political interest by Nigeria and Cameroon over refugee and humanitarian concerns?

ii. In what specific ways have Nigeria and Cameroon violated the 1951 Convention relating to the status of refugees?

iii. Are the image and integrity of Nigerians and Cameroonians compromised abroad as a result of their governments' violations of refugee law?

**Theoretical Framework**

This study draws on a dual theoretical framework, combining Realist Theory with Human Needs Theory. Realist Theory, advanced by Hans Morgenthau (1948), helps explain the state-centric, security-first logic that drives Nigeria and Cameroon's responses to separatism and refugee flows. A prominent critic, Andrew Linklater (1992), challenged the realist tradition for ignoring moral and humanitarian considerations, including human rights and refugee protection, and for failing to account for binding international legal obligations such as those under the 1951 Refugee Convention.

Human Needs Theory (HNT), developed by John W. Burton (1979), rests on the premise that human beings possess certain universal, non-negotiable needs whose frustration drives individuals and communities toward conflict and violence. Sandole (2001) explains that HNT treats violent conflict, separatism, and social deviance not as expressions of innate human aggression but as structural responses to the systematic denial of fundamental needs by institutions and governing systems. The theory places the individual, not the state, at the

center of analysis, and holds that conflict can be prevented or resolved where institutions genuinely serve the needs of all their members. A prominent critique, advanced by Laureen Park (2010), argues that Burton's approach is overly deterministic; critics suggest that his universalist framework marginalizes the shaping roles of culture, history, and political context.

Applied together, Realist Theory illuminates why Nigeria and Cameroon consistently prioritize state security over humanitarian obligation in responding to the Biafran and Ambazonian crises, while Human Needs Theory provides the analytical lens for examining both states' obligations under the 1951 Refugee Convention. HNT illuminates the study at three interconnected levels: conflict generation, displacement, and the protection obligation (Rubenstein, 2001). This study adopts a qualitative research design grounded in secondary data, drawing on books, academic journals, magazines, newspapers, and online reports.

**International Legal and Institutional Framework**

The international legal framework governing the protection of refugees is founded on several global and regional instruments that establish the rights of refugees and the obligations of states. Foremost among these is the 1951 Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees and its 1967 Protocol, which constitute the cornerstone of international refugee law. A central provision of the Convention is the principle of non-refoulement, contained in Article 33, which prohibits contracting states from expelling or returning a refugee to a territory where his or her life or freedom would be threatened on account of race, religion, nationality, membership of a particular social group, or political opinion. This protection, however, is not absolute. The Convention permits exceptions where there are reasonable grounds to regard a refugee as a danger to the security of the host state or where the individual has been convicted of a particularly serious crime and poses a threat to the community. These provisions establish the balance between humanitarian protection and legitimate national security concerns while reaffirming the fundamental obligation of states to safeguard refugees from persecution.

At the regional level, the 1969 Organization of African Unity (OAU) Convention Governing the Specific Aspects of Refugee Problems in Africa expands and strengthens refugee protection within the African context. Article II of the Convention obliges member states to make every effort, consistent with their domestic legislation, to receive refugees and facilitate the settlement of persons who are unable or unwilling to return to their countries of origin because of well-founded fears of persecution or other circumstances covered under the Convention. It further emphasizes that the granting of asylum is a peaceful and humanitarian act that should not be interpreted as unfriendly by other states. The Convention reinforces the principle of non-refoulement by prohibiting rejection at borders, return, or expulsion that would expose refugees to threats against their lives, liberty, or physical integrity. It also recognizes the collective responsibility of African states by encouraging burden-sharing where a host country faces difficulties in accommodating refugees, providing for temporary

residence pending resettlement, and recommending that refugee settlements be established at a reasonable distance from the borders of the country of origin to enhance security.

The OAU Convention also provides a detailed framework for voluntary repatriation under Article V. It unequivocally affirms that repatriation must always be voluntary and that no refugee should be compelled to return against his or her will. The Convention places responsibility on both the country of asylum and the country of origin to collaborate in ensuring the safe return and successful reintegration of refugees who voluntarily choose to repatriate. Returning refugees are to enjoy the full rights and privileges accorded to nationals and should not suffer any penalties for having sought refuge abroad. Furthermore, the Convention calls upon states, voluntary agencies, and international organizations to provide all necessary assistance to facilitate voluntary return and reintegration. Although these provisions clearly establish the voluntary nature of repatriation as a fundamental principle of refugee protection, the implementation of these obligations has often been inconsistent. The relative silence of regional institutions when African states compel or pressure refugees to return despite continuing insecurity has raised concerns about the effectiveness of regional oversight and the commitment to enforcing the Convention's humanitarian principles.

Nigeria and Cameroon are both parties to the principal international and regional refugee protection instruments, including the 1951 Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees, the 1967 Protocol Relating to the Status of Refugees, and the 1969 OAU Convention Governing the Specific Aspects of Refugee Problems in Africa. By ratifying these legal instruments, both countries have undertaken binding obligations to protect refugees within their territories, uphold the principle of non-refoulement, guarantee access to asylum, and ensure that any repatriation of refugees occurs voluntarily, safely, and with respect for their fundamental human rights. These international and regional commitments provide the normative framework for assessing the treatment of Cameroonian refugees in Nigeria and the extent to which both states have complied with their legal obligations under international refugee law.

## Domestic Legal Framework: Refugee Laws in Nigeria and Cameroon

### Nigeria’s Domestic Legal Framework

Nigeria’s domestic refugee protection architecture is built on its ratification and domestication of key international instruments. Having ratified the 1951 Convention, the 1967 Protocol, and the 1969 OAU Convention, Nigeria incorporated these obligations into national law through the National Commission for Refugees Act (Eromo, 2025). This step is constitutionally significant: it transforms international commitments into enforceable domestic law, binding on all arms of government and justiciable before Nigerian courts. The Act established the National Commission for Refugees, Migrants, and Internally Displaced Persons (NCFRMI) as the principal statutory body responsible for refugee governance, charged with coordinating the reception, registration, documentation, and protection of

refugees and asylum seekers, while liaising with UNHCR and other international humanitarian bodies.

A particularly notable feature of Nigeria's refugee policy is its out-of-camp approach, which integrates refugees into host communities rather than confining them to camps. This approach has been especially important in managing the Ambazonian crisis, with Cameroonian refugees absorbed into border communities in Cross River, Akwa Ibom, Benue, and Taraba States (Eromo, 2025). Nigeria has also extended Temporary Protection Status to Cameroonian refugees, providing a formal legal basis for their stay while their claims are processed (Taylor, 2024). The judiciary has played a critical role in enforcing refugee rights domestically. In a landmark ruling, Justice Anwuli Chikere of the Federal High Court, Abuja, declared the forced deportation of the 12 Ambazonian leaders and 39 other refugees from Taraba State illegal and unconstitutional, finding that the government had violated both the Nigerian constitution and Articles 32 and 33 of the 1951 Refugee Convention (Kajode, 2019). The court further ordered compensation of ₦5 million each to the 12 leaders and ₦200,000 each to the 39 other deportees, establishing a domestic judicial precedent for refugee rights accountability (Chikere, 2020). The Federal Government's continued silence on this verdict significantly undermines Nigeria's institutional credibility and its standing in the international community.

**Cameroon's Domestic Legal Framework**

Cameroon's domestic refugee protection framework rests on its ratification of both the 1951 Convention and the 1969 OAU Convention, supported by a constitutional provision that recognizes the primacy of duly ratified international treaties over domestic legislation (Sakhri, 2024). In theory, this constitutional supremacy clause places Cameroon's refugee obligations at the top of its legal hierarchy, making violations of non-refoulement not merely international wrongs but domestic constitutional breaches. Cameroon established the National Eligibility Commission as its primary mechanism for refugee status determination, with UNHCR playing a collaborative role in registration and documentation. Historically, Cameroon was regarded as one of Africa's most generous refugee-hosting countries, having accommodated displaced persons from Nigeria, Chad, and the Central African Republic (Amin, 2020).

The onset of the Ambazonian crisis from 2016 onwards dramatically changed this picture. Rather than extending protection to Anglophones displaced by its own military operations, the government intensified its counterinsurgency campaign. Human Rights Watch (2021) documented unlawful killings, sexual violence, destruction of homes, and arbitrary detention by Cameroonian security forces. The government further compromised its legal obligations by pressuring Nigeria to arrest and repatriate Ambazonian leaders formally registered as asylum seekers with UNHCR, the Nigerian Immigration Services, and the NCFRMI (Odinkalu & Mbuh, 2018). Cameroon also forcibly returned over 2,600 Nigerian refugees against their will, with UNHCR confirming these returns as serious violations of both the

1951 Convention and the 1969 OAU Convention (Penney, 2019). The government's subsequent decision to abandon Swiss-led dialogue in September 2022 and pursue a purely military solution further illustrates the subordination of humanitarian duty to political interest (Human Rights Watch, 2024).

Comparative Assessment

Both Nigeria and Cameroon present the same troubling paradox: strong legal frameworks on paper, systematic violations in practice. While Nigeria's judiciary has shown meaningful independence in holding the executive accountable, the executive's persistent non-compliance neutralizes those gains (Sakhri, 2024). In Cameroon, the constitutional primacy of international treaties has not stopped the government from carrying out forced returns and politically motivated deportations. The central problem in both states is not the absence of legal obligation but the consistent prioritization of political interest over humanitarian duty. This gap continues to expose hundreds of thousands of displaced persons to grave and preventable risk (Eromo, 2025).

**An Overview of The Ambazonia Separatist Agitation**

The name "Ambazonia" was coined from Ambas Bay and Ambozes, the local name for the mouth of the Wouri River. In 1858, the missionary Alfred Saker founded a settlement for formerly enslaved people near Ambas Bay, which was later renamed Victoria and is today known as Limbe. In 1884, the area was designated "the British Ambas Bay Protectorate," with Victoria as its capital (Roger, 2018). The Anglophone separatist movement took up arms in its push for a sovereign state on 1 October 2017, having begun with protests, strikes, and a ghost-town campaign enforced by separatist fighters. The agitation was rooted in long-standing marginalization in education, judicial administration, and governance. Ezemenaka et al. (2021) report that after Cameroon's reunification in 1961, the Federal system of government was abolished through a referendum in 1972, a step that concentrated power in Francophone hands and progressively excluded Anglophone Cameroon from legal, educational, and political institutions. As they further note, this marginalization was the product of a long-standing colonial and post-colonial project of structured exclusion of English-speaking Cameroon.

Fonkeng (2019) explains that in 2016 calls intensified for the restoration of the two-state Federation that existed before 1972, and for the government to stop posting Francophone magistrates to Anglophone courts — a practice the government had continued as recently as November 2016. When Common Law lawyers in Bamenda and Buea staged a peaceful protest, armed security forces responded by torturing lawyers, seizing their gowns and wigs, and injuring many with rubber bullets. Anglophone teachers who had written to Prime Minister Philemon Yang received no response and went on strike. Meanwhile, radio animator

Mancho Bibixy launched the “Coffin Revolution” in Bamenda; when security forces attacked this peaceful crowd, the crisis deepened.

Students at the University of Buea also protested, only to face violent repression: hundreds were arrested, some were forced into stagnant water and mud, and security forces raided student hostels. Odinkalu et al. (2018) note that the government subsequently targeted home villages of secessionist leaders — including Ewele, Akwaya, Eyumodjock, and Ekona — forcing thousands of young men to flee into the bush to avoid arrest, torture, or death. Fonkeng (2019) argues it was imperative to hold Cameroon accountable for these violations, including the enforced disappearance of the 47 people forcibly returned by Nigeria. Mukanga (2019) highlights that several individuals believed to be Nigerians who had lived in Cameroon for years could not prove their nationality or re-establish family ties upon being forced home by the crisis.

The armed separatist movement gave rise to multiple factions, leading to attacks on Cameroonian security forces. In his 2017 New Year's address, President Paul Biya attempted to manage the crisis by appointing new Anglophone ministers (Chikere, 2020). After two separate militant attacks killed 15 Cameroonian soldiers, the army accused separatists of using heavy weapons in violation of international humanitarian law for the first time (Boudombo, 2021). The government’s promise of a “special status” for Anglophone regions did little to ease tensions. Eromo (2025) reports that by the early 2020s, the crisis had displaced very large numbers of Cameroonians both within their own country and across the border into Nigeria. The United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) reported that the crisis had produced over 765,000 internally displaced persons and tens of thousands of refugees seeking asylum in Nigeria, particularly in the border states of Cross River, Akwa Ibom, Benue, and Taraba. Taylor (2024) notes that this influx has created significant challenges for Nigeria, which has had to expand its asylum capacity despite facing its own severe displacement crisis.

**An Overview of the Biafran Separatist Agitation**

The name “Biafra” carries contested origins. According to Kumolu (2016), the leader of the Niger Delta People’s Volunteer Front, Alhaji Mujahid Asari Dokubo, maintains that contrary to widespread perception, the name was not an Igbo designation but was suggested by Frank Opigo, an Ijaw man, at a consultative assembly in 1967. Kumolu (2016) notes that “Biafra” derives from the Kalabari Ijaw phrase “Bia fulo,” meaning “not properly cooked,” and that it was Opigo who proposed the name to Chief Chukwuemeka Ojukwu. Other scholars link the name more broadly to coastal geography or European cartographic usage. Madiebo (1980) identifies one of the fundamental reasons for Ojukwu’s declaration as the Nigerian government’s breakdown of the Aburi Accord, an agreement reached in Ghana that Ojukwu understood as a federal commitment to confederation; when Nigeria repudiated it, the East was pushed to the edge of secession.

The Biafra crisis cannot be understood apart from Nigeria's colonial construction and the ethnic fault lines it carved. Moses (2014) argues that the Nigeria-Biafra Civil War of 1967 to 1970 was a conflict rooted in colonial history and post-independence ethnic tensions. Nwangwu (2023) explains that growing inequalities among Nigeria's diverse ethnic groups, particularly between the Northern Region and the Igbo of the Eastern Region, fuelled widespread discontent after independence. Two military coups in 1966 shattered an already fragile national unity. Madiebo (1980) notes that the death of northern political leaders in the first coup led northern soldiers to frame it as an Igbo conspiracy, triggering a violent backlash and the mass massacre of Igbo living in northern Nigeria. These events, compounded by the federal government's May 1967 decision to divide Nigeria into twelve states and dismember the Eastern Region, precipitated the declaration of the Republic of Biafra on 30 May 1967 under General Emeka Odumegwu Ojukwu.

The Nigerian-Biafran War was not merely a tragic episode; it was a foundational rupture whose consequences continue to reverberate across Nigeria's political, cultural, and social fabric. Moses (2014) notes that between one and three million people, mostly Igbo, died through violence, starvation, and displacement. The federal military blockade of Biafra produced one of the most severe humanitarian catastrophes of the twentieth century, with famine weaponised as an instrument of war. SBM Intelligence (2025) reports that the war drew global headlines principally because of that famine, which mobilised academics, journalists, and the international community in an unprecedented relief operation. Taylor (2024) observes that when the war ended on 15 January 1970 with Biafra's unconditional surrender, reintegration was achieved without any genuine reckoning with the structural causes of the conflict. Rather than resolving Nigeria's nation-building challenges, the war deepened ethnic fissures, bred lasting mistrust, and exposed the fragility of a post-colonial state. Its legacy is visible in the ongoing marginalisation of the Igbo, the contested memory of the war, and the unresolved question of equitable resource distribution.

**Contemporary Resurgence of Biafra**

Nigeria's return to civilian governance in 1999, rather than extinguishing Biafran separatism, gave it new political space. Nweze, Ezemenaka & Iwu (2025) note that this revival was a direct reaction to perceived ethno-national subordination and the Nigerian ruling class's failure at inclusive state-building. The first vehicle for this resurgence was the Movement for the Actualisation of the Sovereign State of Biafra (MASSOB), founded by Ralph Uwazuruike, which pursued a non-violent approach. When state repression weakened MASSOB, a more radical successor emerged. Obiukwu & Njoku (2024) explain that Uwazuruike's arrest dampened the movement, paving the way for the Indigenous People of Biafra (IPOB), founded by Nnamdi Kanu in 2012, a London-based Nigerian-British citizen.

Under Kanu, IPOB became a powerful transnational movement, using Radio Biafra and social media to build a vast global following, particularly among the Igbo diasporas. IPOB has challenged the Nigerian federal government over poor investment in the South-East,

political alienation, inequitable resource distribution, ethnic marginalisation, a brutalising military presence, and extrajudicial killings. The Nigerian government proscribed IPOB as a terrorist organisation in 2017. In June 2021, Kanu was arrested in Kenya and subjected to what Nigerian courts and legal commentators described as an extraordinary rendition. The Court of Appeal, in FRN v. Kanu (CA/ABJ/CR/625/2022) delivered on 13 October 2022, found that the manner of his rendition violated his fundamental rights and nullified the charges against him. Despite this ruling, Kanu remained in custody, further radicalising parts of the movement.

Kanu's arrest opened a new and turbulent chapter. Obiukwu et al. (2024) note that IPOB's sit-at-home order has held the South-East in its grip since 2021, paralysing normal life across Abia, Anambra, Ebonyi, Enugu, and Imo States. SBM Intelligence (2025) reports that what began as symbolic acts of civil disobedience quickly became coercive, with armed actors widely described as "unknown gunmen" — targeting those who tried to go about their lives on shutdown days. SBM Intelligence (2025) estimates that the region lost over ₦7.6 trillion in the first two years alone, with daily transport sector losses reaching up to ₦13 billion at the height of the protests. In February 2026, Kanu formally ordered the permanent cancellation of the Monday sit-at-home, a significant de-escalatory step, though the underlying structural grievances that sustain the movement remain unaddressed (RSIS International Substack).

**Internal Displacement in the Biafran Separatist Agitation**

The security deterioration in Nigeria's South-East has produced significant internal displacement, compounding an already severe national crisis. According to the International Organization for Migration (IOM), over 1.3 million people were internally displaced in Nigeria's Northcentral and Northwest regions by April 2024. In May 2024, gunmen killed eleven people, including six civilians and five soldiers, in Obingwa Local Government Area, Abia State, with the government attributing the attack to IPOB. Uche & Iwuoha (2022) note that even after IPOB formally announced the suspension of the sit-at-home, armed enforcers continued to kill, maim, and destroy property, with some state governments sealing banks and shops for allegedly observing the shutdowns. The resulting climate of fear has triggered a secondary wave of displacement, with civil servants, businesses, and vulnerable populations moving elsewhere in Nigeria or fleeing to neighboring countries, with direct implications for Nigeria's refugee and asylum-seeker obligations.

**Regional Implications of Ambazonia and Biafra**

The Biafra crisis has long ceased to be purely Nigeria's internal concern and now carries weighty implications for the security of the wider West and Central African region. Intelligensis (2025) reports that the Ambazonian separatists in Cameroon have been partly inspired and emboldened by Nigeria's own Biafran agitation, specifically IPOB's activities, and their clashes with the Cameroonian military have claimed over 6,000 lives since 2017.

Emerging reports of tactical collaboration between IPOB and Ambazonian forces raise grave concerns about the cross-border spread of separatist ideologies and the risk of regional escalation, particularly in border communities that straddle state jurisdictions and suffer from chronic under-governance.

This convergence has serious practical consequences. Ambazonian insurgents have been implicated in drugs, arms, and human trafficking, extending their activities across the border into Nigeria. Aboh (2024) notes that the spillover of the Ambazonian conflict has not only deepened Nigeria's existing security challenges but has also intensified an ongoing humanitarian crisis in border communities, displacing thousands and stretching the capacity of authorities already struggling to care for their own internally displaced persons and incoming refugees. Madueke (2025) reports that as of June 2023, Nigeria had an estimated 2.3 million internally displaced persons and 93,130 refugees and asylum seekers.

At the broader regional level, Nigeria's stability is pivotal to West African security as a whole. Intelligensis (2025) documents that separatist pressures in the South-East, driven by IPOB, add yet another layer of complexity to a country already facing multiple overlapping security crises. Aboh (2024) argues that the escalating violence in south-eastern Nigeria and western Cameroon will only deepen national and regional security challenges at a moment when the region is already struggling with economic contraction, democratic backsliding, and a resurgence of violent extremism. Human Rights Watch (2025) concludes that the Biafra crisis is no longer a discrete post-colonial inheritance but a live driver of cross-border displacement, regional instability, and international legal obligations, with direct consequences for the conduct of both Nigeria and Cameroon as states parties to the 1951 Refugee Convention.

**Nigeria-Cameroon Obligations under the 1951 Refugee Convention and the 1967 Protocol**

Nigeria and Cameroon are bound to respect the principle of non-refoulement under Chapter V, Article 33(a), which provides that no Contracting State shall expel or return a refugee to territories where his life or freedom would be threatened on account of his race, religion, nationality, membership of a particular social group, or political opinion. Both states are therefore obligated not to expel or return refugees or asylum seekers to places where they risk persecution, arrest, or torture.

Both states must ensure that any return of refugees is genuinely voluntary, as required by Article II(c) of the 1969 OAU Convention, which prohibits any measure, whether rejection at the frontier, return, or expulsion, that would compel a person to return to a territory where their life, physical integrity, or liberty is at risk. Both governments must guarantee refugees' access to asylum procedures, registration, documentation, and identity papers; provide clear and accurate information about return conditions so that individuals can make truly free and

informed decisions; ensure safety, dignity, and humane treatment during both hosting and any return process; and domesticate their international obligations into national law enforceable through courts, oversight bodies, and commissions.

**Assessment of Responses on the 1951 Refugee Convention by the Nigerian and Cameroonian Governments**

In its effort to manage the Ambazonian conflict, the Cameroonian government pressured Nigerian authorities to arrest and detain Sisiku Julius Ayuk Tabe, leader of the Republic of Ambazonia, along with other members who had fled to Nigeria seeking asylum. Mbaku et al. (2004) and Okereke (2018) record that the separatist leader was arrested, detained, repatriated, and handed over to the Cameroonian government, where he was tried before a military tribunal, convicted, and sentenced to life imprisonment. In total, Sisiku Julius Ayuk Tabe and 47 others were repatriated from Nigeria. This act by both governments directly triggered the formation of two additional armed separatist groups, which announced that violence would continue in the Anglophone Region. The leaders arrested in Nigeria and deported to Cameroon are documented in Table 1.

**Table 1: Leaders of the Interim Government of Ambazonia and Nine Others on Asylum in Nigeria Who Were Arrested and Deported to Cameroon**

| S/N | Names | Position/ Rank Attained | Organization where they were working |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Sisiku Julius Ayuk Tabe, Leader of the Interim Government of Ambazonia | Assistant Vice President of Marketing and Recruitment | American University of Nigeria (AUN) |
| 2 | Dr. Fidelis Ndeh-Che, Associate Professor of Computer Science | Director in the Office of Institutional Research and Effectiveness and Vice Chair of the Institutional Review Board | American University of Nigeria (AUN) |
| 3 | Professor Augustine Awasum, Professor of Veterinary Medicine | Head of Surgery Unit of the Veterinary Teaching Hospital | Ahmadu Bello University (ABU), Zaria |
| 4 | Dr. Henry Kimeng, Associate Professor | Associate Professor of Geology | Ahmadu Bello University (ABU), Zaria |
| 5 | Dr. Cornelius Kwanga, Senior Lecturer | Senior Lecturer in the Department of Economics | Yar'Adua University, Katsina |
| 6 | Dr. Egbe Ogork Ntui, Associate Professor | Associate Professor of Civil Engineering | Bayero University, Kano |
| 7 | Mr. Wilfred Tassang Unionist | Union organizer and Leader of the Teachers Union | The Federation of Parent Teacher Union (CAPTAC) |
| 8 | Barr. Eyambe Elias | Organizer, Human Rights Lawyer and Legal Worker organizer | Human Rights Organization |

| S/N | Names | Position/ Rank Attained | Organization where they were working |
|---|---|---|---|
| 9 | Barr. Shufai Berimyuy | Human Right Lawyer | Human Rights Organization |
| 10 | Dr. Nfor Ngalla Nfor | Civil Society Leader | Civil Society Organization |

Source: Taka M. (2022), The Ambazonia Revolution and Nera 10. KAKAAKI (AIT) Live interview, 4th January, 2022.

The arrest and deportation of these Ambazonian leaders by the Nigerian government on 5 January 2018 drew sharp condemnation both domestically and internationally. Despite this, both Cameroon and Nigeria appeared to act in concert in violating court orders and disregarding the fundamental rights of the individuals concerned. The refugees had been formally and legally registered with the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR), the Nigerian Immigration Services, and the National Commission for Refugees, Migrants, and Internally Displaced Persons. They were arrested at the Nera Hotel in Abuja on 5 January 2018. UNHCR strongly condemned the arrest and deportation and called for the refugees' release from Cameroon and their return to Nigeria, where they had been seeking protection. On 1 March 2019, in proceedings brought by 12 Cameroonian separatist leaders against the Federal Government of Nigeria, Justice Anwuli Chikere of the Federal High Court, Abuja, ruled that:

> "The forceful deportation of the 12 leaders and 39 other Anglophones from Taraba State was illegal and unconstitutional. The court held that 'irrespective of whether they posed a threat to the Nigerian state or not, the Federal Government did not follow due process and thus violated both the Nigerian Constitution and articles 32 and 33 of the United Nations Convention relating to the status of Refugees', which states: 'The Refugee Convention of 1951 must respect the principle of non-refoulement. States are obligated under the Convention and under customary international law to respect the principle of non-refoulement. If this principle is threatened, UNHCR can respond by intervening with relevant authorities and, if it is deemed necessary, will inform the public. Refugees shall be treated at least like nationals (Refugee Convention, 1951).

The court accordingly found that the fundamental rights of the 12 Ambazonian leaders and the 39 other refugees from Taraba State had been violated, notwithstanding Nigeria and Cameroon's status as signatories to the 1951 Refugee Convention. Justice Anwuli Chikere further ordered that the Nigerian Government pay compensation of ₦5 million each to the 12 leaders and ₦200,000 each to the 39 other deportees. The Federal Government of Nigeria has remained silent on both the court's verdict and UNHCR's recommendations, a posture that has seriously damaged Nigeria's image at the sub-regional, regional, and international levels. Kajode (2019) argues that the arrest of the Ambazonian leaders directly fuelled further attacks by separatist fighters against Cameroonian security forces, to which the government responded by burning villages suspected of sheltering fighters and driving civilians, including women, children, the disabled, and the elderly, into the bush. Chikere (2020) reports that the

resulting displacement continued to rise, with the United Nations at one point estimating approximately 160,000 internally displaced persons within Cameroon and between 20,000 and 50,000 refugees who had fled to Nigeria for safety (Okereke, 2018).

The arrest and repatriation of the Ambazonian refugees by Nigeria can also be read in the context of bilateral history. During the Nigerian Civil War of 1967–1970, President Ahmadou Ahidjo of Cameroon initially declared neutrality but later provided critical support to Nigeria's Federal Military Government under General Yakubu Gowon, closing Cameroon's border with Nigeria and banning shipments of arms, medicines, foodstuffs, and other supplies to Biafra (Bainkong, 2021). At a later stage, Ahidjo invited the Nigerian government to use the Cameroonian village of Jabane as a base for monitoring supplies entering the Calabar Port, and publicly condemned nations that recognized Biafra (Kelechi et al., 2018).

**The Abduction, Repatriation, And Torture of Mazi Nnamdi Kanu (IPOB Leader)**

Mazi Nnamdi Kanu, founder of the Indigenous People of Biafra (IPOB) in 2012, was arrested at Jomo Kenyatta International Airport, Nairobi, Kenya, on 19 June 2021. Human Rights Council (2022) reports that Kanu, who was lawfully present in Kenya, was seized at the airport by Kenyan security forces and swiftly moved to an undisclosed location that was neither a police station nor any conventional security facility. According to the same source, Kenyan Special Forces reportedly subjected Kanu to eight days of severe torture and ill-treatment, causing him physical injury and lasting psychological harm. He was then extraordinarily rendered to Abuja without any prior hearing before a judicial or administrative body. While nominally given access to counsel, he was denied the extradition proceedings that international law and Kenya's own legislation required. Kanu was initially charged with four offenses: conspiracy to commit treasonable felony in 2014 and 2015, treasonable felony in those same years, defamation in 2015, and improper importation of goods in 2015. Human Rights Council (2022) notes that all these charges were widely viewed as fabricated. The charges were later expanded to seven, including an accusation of levying war against Nigeria in 2015 through a radio broadcast from London.

Ozekhome (2022) observes that the Court of Appeal noted Nigeria's status as a signatory to the OAU Convention, ratified on 28 April 2022, and to the Charter of Human and Peoples' Rights, both of which prescribe the procedure by which a wanted person may be transferred between countries. The court found that any extradition request must be made in writing, specifying the offenses for which the person is sought. It held that the Federal Government's manner of proceeding had tainted the entire prosecution and constituted an abuse of criminal process. The court stated plainly that it would not hesitate to restrain an executive who tilts toward recklessness.

Abuja-based lawyer Christopher Chidera accused the Kenyan government of complicity in the abduction. Kayode (2025) reports that Chidera alleged Kenya had failed in its duty to

protect Kanu and had acted in disregard of its own Constitution, the Extradition Act, the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR), the Mutual Assistance within the Commonwealth Act, and the London Scheme on Extradition.

In response, Ukachi (2025) reports that on 11 October 2024, Kenyan President William Ruto filed a case against Nigeria at the International Criminal Court, accusing Nigerian authorities of colluding with corrupt Kenyan immigration officials to arrest and unlawfully extradite Kanu. Ruto characterized the affair as a direct challenge to the culture of covert operations, impunity, and diplomatic sabotage plaguing the continent, declaring that "Kenya was invaded through the back door." Ukachi (2025) further notes that this revelation brought renewed attention to the 2018 abduction of Sisiku Julius Ayuk Tabe and the other Ambazonian leaders, repatriated from Nigeria in defiance of international asylum protocols. Both episodes, Ukachi observes, amount to state-sponsored kidnapping, prompting the question: how many more voices will be silenced through illegal extraditions and corrupt deals?

**Several other reports document the pattern of violations:**

i. UNHCR and Human Rights Watch have on multiple occasions reported that Cameroon has forcibly returned Nigerian refugees and asylum seekers in large numbers, despite a tripartite agreement between Cameroon, Nigeria, and UNHCR (Alexis, 2017).

ii. Nigeria was itself criticized for returning Cameroonian asylum seekers in 2018, an action UNHCR publicly condemned, as documented in the table and discussion above.

**Challenges and Effects of Implementing the 1951 Refugee Convention and 1967 Protocol**

Governments that violate the 1951 Convention and the 1967 Protocol often do so in the belief that there will be no serious consequences. The reality is very different. The costs of such violations are wide-ranging and enduring:

**Condemnation by the United Nations and the International Community:** Violations such as refoulement, arbitrary detention, and mass expulsion typically draw public condemnation from UNHCR, the UN Human Rights Council, the UN Special Rapporteur, and organizations such as Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch. This condemnation directly damages a country's international standing and strains its diplomatic relationships.

**International Legal Consequences:** Violations may trigger proceedings or heightened scrutiny before international human rights courts or treaty monitoring bodies.

**Sanctions or Aid Reduction:** Donor countries and international organizations may cut development assistance, suspend cooperation agreements, or delay and cancel trade and visa arrangements.

**Increased Scrutiny and Monitoring:** States found to be violating refugee rights may be placed under special UNHCR monitoring and subjected to Universal Periodic Reviews, as well as appearing on human rights watchlists and travel advisory lists.

**Domestic Legal Repercussions:** National courts may declare such actions unconstitutional or illegal and may order remedies such as release, non-return, or compensation. Justice Anwuli Chikere's ruling in the Ambazonian leaders' case and the Kenyan High Court's finding of unconstitutionality in the Nnamdi Kanu rendition, with compensation ordered in both cases, are concrete examples of this.

**Customary International Law Implications:** The principle of non-refoulement is recognized as customary international law, binding even on states not party to the 1951 and 1967 treaties. Violations can therefore engage broader international responsibility.

**Loss of UNHCR Goodwill and Support:** UNHCR may scale back cooperation, withdraw from refugee program implementation, and redirect resources to states that honor their obligations.

**Reciprocity and Regional Instability:** States that violate refugee rights risk reciprocal treatment from neighbors, who may become reluctant to offer refuge to their citizens in times of natural disaster or conflict.

**Potential Civil or Criminal Accountability:** Where violations involve torture, arbitrary detention, or enforced disappearance, individual officials may face international arrest warrants under universal jurisdiction or prosecution before international tribunals.

**Implications of the Ambazonian and Biafran Agitations on Nigeria-Cameroon Refugee Obligations**

The separatist agitations of Ambazonia and Biafra have generated profound humanitarian, legal, and geopolitical consequences that place serious strain on the refugee protection frameworks binding Nigeria and Cameroon. At the humanitarian level, the displacement figures are staggering. The Ambazonian conflict has produced over 765,000 internally displaced persons within Cameroon, with tens of thousands more seeking asylum in Nigeria's border states of Cross River, Akwa Ibom, Benue, and Taraba (Taylor, 2024). Simultaneously, the Biafran agitation and Nigeria's counterinsurgency response have contributed to over 3.6 million internally displaced persons within Nigeria and approximately 383,000 Nigerian refugees sheltering in Chad, Cameroon, and Niger (Human Rights Watch, 2025). This dual

displacement dynamic traps both states in the paradox of being simultaneously refugee-generating and refugee-receiving countries, stretching their institutional and legal capacities to breaking point.

Most critically, these agitations have exposed a dangerous gap between formal legal commitment and actual state conduct. Rather than upholding non-refoulement under Article 33 of the 1951 Convention, both states have turned the crises into instruments of political calculation. Nigeria's forced deportation of 47 Cameroonian asylum seekers in January 2018, including Ambazonian leader Sisiku Julius Ayuk Tabe, was condemned by UNHCR and subsequently ruled illegal by Justice Anwuli Chikere of the Federal High Court, Abuja, who found Nigeria had violated both its constitution and Articles 32 and 33 of the 1951 Convention (Kajode, 2019). Similarly, Cameroon has forcibly returned over 2,600 Nigerian refugees in violation of the OAU Convention it ratified (Penney, 2019). The extraordinary rendition of Nnamdi Kanu from Kenya to Nigeria in 2021 further demonstrates how both states consistently subordinate binding international obligations to narrow political interests, with the Kenyan courts finding the rendition unconstitutional (Ozekhome, 2022).

At the regional level, the two agitations have become mutually reinforcing security crises. Emerging reports of tactical collaboration between IPOB and Ambazonian forces signal a deeply worrying cross-border diffusion of separatist ideologies, with the Ambazonian conflict alone claiming over 6,000 lives since 2017 (Intelligensis, 2025). This convergence not only deepens the humanitarian emergency but also undermines the broader West African regional security architecture, threatening to erode the integrity of refugee protection norms at a time when the region is already beset by terrorism and democratic instability (Aboh, 2024).

**Gap in the Literature**

A critical review of the relevant scholarship reveals three significant gaps that this study addresses. First, existing literature fails to examine Nigeria and Cameroon's refugee obligations simultaneously within a single comparative legal framework. Scholars have largely treated the Ambazonian crisis and the Biafran agitation as separate political or humanitarian phenomena, without examining how both states' conduct as parties to the same international instruments measures up against their shared legal obligations. This fragmented approach has obscured the paradoxical position both states occupy as simultaneously refugee-generating and refugee-receiving countries, leaving a substantial analytical void (Ezemenaka et al., 2021).

Second, the literature has given insufficient attention to the specific legal implications that arise when a state is simultaneously suppressing an internal separatist movement and hosting refugees generated by a similar movement in a neighboring country. The mutual reinforcement between the Ambazonian and Biafran agitations, including emerging reports of cross-border tactical collaboration between IPOB and Ambazonian forces, has attracted very

limited legal and scholarly scrutiny. Existing studies have focused predominantly on the security and political dimensions of these crises without adequately examining how both governments have used the securitization of separatism to circumvent refugee protection obligations (Boudombo, 2021; Anslem, 2022).

Third, while international human rights organizations such as UNHCR, Amnesty International, and Human Rights Watch have documented specific violations, academic scholarship has not sufficiently examined the role and performance of domestic legal institutions in enforcing refugee rights against executive overreach. The landmark ruling by Justice Anwuli Chikere of the Federal High Court, Abuja, declaring Nigeria's deportation of the Ambazonian leaders illegal and unconstitutional, and the Nigerian government's continued silence on that ruling, represents a critical institutional failure that has received wholly inadequate scholarly attention. This gap limits understanding of how domestic legal frameworks can either reinforce or fatally undermine international refugee protection obligations (Kajode, 2019; Chikere, 2020).

**Findings**

The findings of this study reveal a significant divergence between the international legal obligations undertaken by Nigeria and Cameroon and their actual treatment of refugees and political dissidents. Although both states are parties to the 1951 Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees, its 1967 Protocol, and the 1969 OAU Convention Governing the Specific Aspects of Refugee Problems in Africa, implementation has frequently been undermined by political and security considerations. The evidence suggests that state actions have, in several instances, prioritized bilateral political cooperation, regime security, and national interests over the humanitarian principles of refugee protection. This finding is consistent with scholarship on refugee governance in Africa, which argues that governments often invoke sovereignty and security concerns to justify actions that weaken the protection regime established under international refugee law. Such practices undermine the principle of non-refoulement, erode confidence in international legal commitments, and weaken the credibility of regional and global refugee protection mechanisms.

The study also finds that both Nigeria and Cameroon have been involved in actions that have raised serious concerns regarding compliance with the principle of non-refoulement. The arrest, transfer, and subsequent prosecution of Ambazonian separatist leaders after their removal from Nigeria have been widely criticized by human rights organizations and legal scholars as inconsistent with obligations under international refugee and human rights law, particularly where individuals claiming refugee protection or asylum were transferred to jurisdictions in which they faced a substantial risk of persecution or unfair trial. Likewise, the extraordinary rendition of Mazi Nnamdi Kanu from Kenya to Nigeria has generated significant legal controversy, with domestic and international observers questioning its compatibility with international law, extradition procedures, and due process guarantees. Courts in Nigeria have also considered aspects of the legality of his rendition. These cases

illustrate the tension between states' pursuit of national security objectives and their obligations under international humanitarian and human rights law, demonstrating how political expediency can conflict with established legal norms.

Finally, the study suggests that persistent disregard for international legal obligations may have broader diplomatic and reputational consequences for states. Repeated allegations of violations of refugee and human rights law can affect a country's international standing, reduce confidence in its commitment to the rule of law, and complicate diplomatic relations and international cooperation. However, the proposition that such conduct directly causes foreign publics to perceive Nigerians or Cameroonians as "lawless or unpatriotic," or that it will inevitably lead to the denial of humanitarian assistance in future crises, is not conclusively established by the evidence presented in this study. Multiple political, diplomatic, and humanitarian factors influence such outcomes. A more defensible interpretation is that continued non-compliance with international legal obligations risks weakening international trust, attracting criticism from international organizations and human rights bodies, and potentially affecting the willingness of international partners to deepen cooperation. Consequently, adherence to refugee law is not only a legal obligation but also an important component of maintaining international credibility, strengthening diplomatic relations, and promoting effective humanitarian protection.

**Conclusion**

This study concludes that the 1951 Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees and its 1967 Protocol, reinforced in Africa by the 1969 OAU Convention Governing the Specific Aspects of Refugee Problems in Africa, constitute the cornerstone of the international refugee protection regime. These instruments impose binding obligations on states to protect refugees, uphold the principle of non-refoulement, and ensure that asylum and voluntary repatriation are administered in accordance with international humanitarian standards. The findings indicate that political and security considerations have, in some instances, taken precedence over these legal obligations in both Nigeria and Cameroon, thereby creating tensions between state practice and international law. Such departures from established legal norms have attracted criticism from human rights organizations and have implications for the credibility of both states within the international community. Sustained compliance with international refugee law is therefore essential not only for safeguarding the rights and dignity of refugees but also for reinforcing the rule of law, strengthening international confidence, and promoting responsible and accountable governance in accordance with accepted international standards.

**Recommendations**

i. There must be no gap between the legal obligations of Nigeria and Cameroon and their actual state practices. Both governments must align their conduct with the

standards enshrined in the 1951 Refugee Convention and the 1967 Protocol, particularly in how they manage refugee and humanitarian crises.

ii. Nigeria and Cameroon must honor Article 33 of the 1951 Convention on the Status of Refugees and comply with the ruling of Justice Anwuli of the Federal High Court, Abuja. The Ambazonian leaders arrested and deported to Cameroon, subsequently tried before a military tribunal, and sentenced to life imprisonment, must be returned. The Nigerian Government must pay the court-ordered compensation of ₦5 million each to the 12 leaders and ₦200,000 each to the 39 other deportees. This is a necessary step toward restoring Nigeria's credibility in the international community. The Cameroonian government must similarly comply with the ruling and release the refugees.

iii. The Nigerian government must take concrete steps to restore the dignity of its citizens abroad. Genuine compliance with international law, including the still-unresolved case of Mazi Nnamdi Kanu, whom the Kenyan Court ruled should be released and compensated but who remains in Nigerian custody, is the only credible path to reclaiming that dignity. Nigeria and Cameroon must respect human rights and uphold the rule of law. Their governments and leaders must be accountable to their obligations, not to political calculations.

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# NIGERIA-CHINA TRADE RELATIONS AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT IN NIGERIA, 2015 -2023

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**Abstract.** This study examined the impact of Nigeria-China trade relations on economic development in Nigeria, 2015-2023, with specific focus on the implications for trade patterns, foreign direct investment (FDI), and infrastructural partnerships. The study analyzed the nature, structure, and effects of the growing trade relationship to determine its contribution to Nigeria's economic trajectory. The study was anchored on dependency theory, reflecting on Nigeria's dependency on trade with China, which makes it a dependent economy in terms of development. The study relied on a qualitative descriptive research design, and data were generated from secondary data sources, including the Bureau for Statistics, the Central Bank Bulletin, and the World Bank, as well as other documentary evidence. The study's objectives were to: examine the nature and pattern of trade relations between Nigeria and China; assess the impact of these relations on Nigeria's industrialization and local manufacturing capacity; and evaluate the contribution of Chinese investments and infrastructural projects to Nigeria's economic development and job creation. Findings revealed that trade between Nigeria and China expanded significantly during the study period but remained characterized by a persistent trade imbalance in favor of China. Imports of Chinese goods consistently exceeded Nigerian exports, reinforcing a structural dependency on Chinese manufactured products. The study also found that Nigeria's external debt exposure to China increased substantially, largely due to concessional loans tied to infrastructure development projects. The study concluded that although Trade relations have stimulated short-term economic growth and infrastructural expansion, they have not fostered sustainable development or industrial self-reliance. It recommended that the Nigerian government implement strategic trade and industrial policies aimed at promoting export diversification, strengthening domestic manufacturing, and ensuring more equitable trade terms with China.

**Keywords:** Nigeria-China trade relations, economic development, foreign direct investment, trade imbalance, industrialization, bilateral trade

## Introduction

Nigeria-China trade relations have increasingly become a major feature of international economic interactions, reflecting the growing importance of bilateral partnerships in global trade. Globally, China has emerged as a leading trading power, with significant investments and trade linkages across continents, including Africa. Its engagement is not limited to

resource extraction but extends to infrastructure development, manufacturing, and technology transfer (Adebayo, 2020). For developing countries like Nigeria, China's economic rise offers opportunities for expanding trade, attracting foreign direct investment, and enhancing industrial growth. These interactions have both global and regional implications, influencing trade balances, market access, and economic development patterns.

At the African level, China's trade and investment initiatives have reshaped economic relations and development trajectories. Africa has witnessed increasing Chinese participation in sectors such as transportation, telecommunications, and energy (Wang & Lin, 2021). Nigeria, as Africa's largest economy and population center, plays a strategic role in China's African trade strategy. Bilateral trade between Nigeria and China has expanded rapidly, with imports of manufactured goods from China dominating the trade structure and exports from Nigeria mainly consisting of crude oil and raw materials (Uzonwanne, 2020). While this relationship has stimulated economic activities, it has also raised concerns about trade imbalances, dependency, and the implications for domestic industrialization.

Within Nigeria, trade relations with China have influenced several sectors of the economy. Chinese goods, especially electronics, textiles, and machinery, have become highly accessible to Nigerian consumers, promoting affordability and market variety (Ajayi & Oladipo, 2021). Infrastructural investments financed and constructed by Chinese firms, including roads, railways, and industrial parks, have the potential to enhance economic productivity and create employment (Okeke, 2021). However, critics argue that the influx of Chinese products has negatively affected local manufacturing, leading to challenges for domestic industries and employment generation (Onwuka & Iwuoha, 2022). These dynamics highlight the dual nature of Nigeria–China trade relations as both an opportunity and a potential constraint on economic development.

Despite the rapid growth in bilateral trade, challenges remain that hinder sustainable development. Trade imbalances, over-dependence on imports, and debt obligations associated with Chinese-funded infrastructure projects have been sources of concern for policymakers and scholars (Obi, 2022). Additionally, inadequate industrial policy frameworks and poor local content integration limit the potential developmental benefits of trade. These issues underscore the need for a comprehensive assessment of how Nigeria–China trade relations have impacted economic development from 2015 to 2023, including both the benefits and the potential risks.

While Nigeria's trade relations with China have expanded significantly, their impact on Nigeria's overall economic development remains contested. Empirical evidence suggests that although increased trade has enhanced market access, improved the availability of consumer goods, and supported infrastructural development, it has also contributed to widening trade imbalances and increasing dependence on Chinese imports (Onwuka & Iwuoha, 2022; Uzonwanne, 2020). The central problem, therefore, lies in the lack of clarity regarding the extent to which Nigeria–China trade relations have promoted sustainable economic

development at both the sectoral and national levels. Against this backdrop, the objective of this study is to examine the impact of Nigeria-China trade statistics on Nigeria's economic development between 2015 and 2023 by assessing the extent to which bilateral trade interactions have contributed to the country's economic growth during the period.

## Literature Review

### Nigeria-China Trade Relations

Nigeria-China trade relations refer to the economic, political, and diplomatic exchanges between the Federal Republic of Nigeria and the People's Republic of China, grounded in mutual interest, cooperation, and global economic integration. Historically, the relationship dates back to 1971 when diplomatic ties were formally established. However, trade volumes expanded significantly after Nigeria adopted economic liberalization policies in the late 1990s and China intensified its "Go Out" policy (Ogunkola et al., 2018). The partnership is driven by Nigeria's demand for manufactured goods and infrastructure support, and China's interest in natural resources and expanding its global market influence (Adewuyi & Okodua, 2019). As a result, trade between both countries has grown exponentially, making China Nigeria's largest trading partner by 2015.

Nigeria-China trade relations are also shaped by structured bilateral frameworks, including the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation (FOCAC) and several trade, investment, and infrastructural agreements aimed at boosting economic cooperation. These frameworks enable China to invest heavily in Nigeria's oil and gas, telecommunications, manufacturing, and construction sectors (Umeora, 2019). China's provision of concessional loans, technical expertise, and infrastructural financing has enhanced Nigeria's access to railways, roads, airports, and power projects. At the same time, Nigeria's export profile to China remains dominated by crude oil and raw materials, reflecting the asymmetric nature of the trade structure (Oyeranti & Babatunde, 2020). Such structural imbalance influences Nigeria's economic outcomes and shapes debates on sustainable trade engagement.

Furthermore, the concept of Nigeria–China trade relations encompasses both the opportunities and challenges arising from increasing economic interdependence. On one hand, the relationship supports infrastructural development, technology transfer, job creation, and revenue generation for Nigeria (Adewuyi & Okodua, 2019). On the other hand, concerns persist about Nigeria's widening trade deficit, overdependence on Chinese imports, limited export diversification, and rising external debt linked to Chinese loans (Egbula & Zheng, 2018). The relationship is, therefore, viewed as both beneficial and complex, requiring strategic policy measures to ensure balanced, sustainable economic development. Nigeria–China trade relations thus remain central to Nigeria's economic trajectory and represent one of the most significant bilateral relationships in Africa.

## Concept of Economic Development

Economic development refers to the sustained improvement in the economic, social, and institutional structures of a country, aimed at enhancing the overall well-being and quality of life of its citizens. Unlike economic growth, which focuses mainly on increases in national income, economic development encompasses broader indicators such as employment levels, equitable income distribution, improved health, education, industrialization, and poverty reduction (Todaro & Smith, 2020). Development, therefore, involves transformative changes in both the productive capacity of an economy and the living conditions of the population, making it a multidimensional process rather than a purely economic one. In developing countries like Nigeria, economic development is often associated with structural changes, especially the transition from reliance on primary commodities to diversified manufacturing and service sectors.

Contemporary discussions also highlight the influence of global economic relations on national development outcomes. International trade, foreign direct investment, and global market integration have become major drivers of development in many countries, especially in Africa (UNECA, 2021). For Nigeria, economic development is shaped by interactions with global partners such as China, whose investment and trade activities impact industrial growth, infrastructure, and employment. However, debates persist concerning whether such external engagements promote genuine development or deepen dependency (Adewuyi & Okodua, 2019). As a result, economic development is viewed as a dynamic process influenced by domestic policy choices, global economic structures, and the capacity of states to manage external relations effectively.

## Concept of Foreign Direct Investment (FDI)

Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) refers to cross-border investment made by an individual, company, or government from one country into business interests located in another country, with the intention of establishing a lasting management influence or control (IMF, 2020). Unlike short-term portfolio investments, FDI typically involves ownership of at least 10% equity in a foreign enterprise, often accompanied by managerial participation, technology transfer, and long-term commitment (UNCTAD, 2022). It is widely regarded as a catalyst for economic integration, global business expansion, and international production networks, making it a central feature of globalization.

In developing countries, FDI is considered an essential driver of economic growth because it brings in not only financial capital but also modern technology, managerial skills, and enhanced access to global markets. According to Dunning's Eclectic Paradigm, firms invest abroad due to ownership, location, and internalization advantages, which help explain the flow of FDI to resource-rich and large-market economies like Nigeria (Dunning, 2001). Empirical studies also show that FDI contributes to job creation, industrial diversification,

and increased productivity, especially when domestic policies and institutions support absorptive capacity (Adegboye & Adefabi, 2021). Thus, the developmental impact of FDI depends on both the quality of investment and the economic environment of the host country.

However, scholars argue that while FDI can enhance development, it may also produce dependency effects, crowd out local industries, and expose economies to external shocks (Aremu, 2005; Hymer, 1976) In the African context, concerns have been raised about the dominance of foreign firms in strategic sectors such as mining, telecommunications, and infrastructure, which may limit domestic value creation and profit retention (UNECA, 2021). In Nigeria, FDI inflows from China, particularly in construction, oil, and manufacturing, have been instrumental to infrastructure development but have also raised debates over debt sustainability, labor practices, and limited technology transfer. Overall, FDI remains a double-edged phenomenon whose impact varies depending on governance quality, regulatory frameworks, and the strategic interests of foreign investors.

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Specifically, China has become one of Nigeria's leading sources of FDI, accounting for approximately 15%–18% of total FDI inflows into Nigeria in recent years, depending on sectoral classification and reporting periods (UNCTAD, 2023; NBS, 2024). This makes China one of the top non-Western investors in Nigeria's economy, with strong involvement in large-scale infrastructure and industrial projects. However, this growing share has also generated debates over debt sustainability, labor practices, limited technology transfer, and long-term economic dependency.

## Historical Overview of Nigeria-China Trade Relations

Nigeria-China trade relations have evolved significantly over time, transitioning from limited diplomatic and commercial contacts in the early post-independence period to a robust strategic economic partnership in the 21st century. Formal diplomatic relations between Nigeria and China were established in 1971 following Nigeria's support for the "One China Policy." However, during the 1970s and 1980s, economic interactions between both countries remained minimal, largely characterized by limited trade exchanges and occasional technical cooperation agreements.

A major turning point in Nigeria–China relations occurred in the early 2000s, particularly after the return of democratic governance in Nigeria in 1999. This period marked Nigeria's intensified search for foreign investment, infrastructure development, and economic diversification. China, on the other hand, was expanding its global economic influence through its "Go Global Strategy," which encouraged Chinese firms to invest in developing economies, especially in Africa. As a result, bilateral trade and investment between Nigeria and China began to grow rapidly.

By 2006, Nigeria and China established a strategic partnership framework, which strengthened cooperation in sectors such as oil and gas, infrastructure, telecommunications, and manufacturing. Chinese companies such as the China Civil Engineering Construction Corporation (CCECC) became heavily involved in railway construction, road infrastructure, and housing projects across Nigeria. Trade volume between both countries also increased significantly, with China emerging as one of Nigeria's largest import partners, supplying machinery, electronics, textiles, and industrial goods.

In the 2010s, Nigeria–China economic relations deepened further under the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), which positioned Nigeria as a key African partner in China's global infrastructure development strategy. During this period, China financed and constructed major projects such as the Abuja–Kaduna railway and Lagos–Ibadan railway. Trade relations also expanded, although they remained largely asymmetric, with Nigeria importing far more from China than it exported, resulting in a persistent trade deficit.

In recent years, Nigeria–China trade relations have continued to grow, with China maintaining its position as one of Nigeria's largest trading partners. However, concerns have emerged regarding trade imbalance, debt dependency, and limited technology transfer to the Nigerian economy. Despite these challenges, the relationship remains highly strategic, as both countries continue to cooperate in infrastructure development, energy, manufacturing, and digital economy initiatives.

**The Impact of Nigeria–China Trade Relations on Economic Development in Nigeria**

Nigeria-China trade relations have expanded significantly in the last two decades, making China one of Nigeria's largest trading partners. The relationship is driven by Nigeria's demand for manufactured goods and China's need for energy resources and investment opportunities in Africa. According to Ogunkola and Adewuyi (2018), trade between both countries has grown exponentially due to China's strategic outreach to African economies under the Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC). This increased trade has provided Nigeria with access to affordable consumer goods, industrial machinery, and technological equipment, which support local industries and enhance productivity. As a result, the inflow of Chinese products and capital has contributed to Nigeria's economic modernization efforts.

One of the most significant contributions of China–Nigeria relations to economic development is the rise in infrastructure investment, especially through concessional loans and public–private partnerships. Chinese firms have been central to constructing major projects such as railways, roads, airports, and power plants. The Lagos–Ibadan Railway and Abuja–Kaduna Railway, built by the China Civil Engineering Construction Corporation (CCECC), are examples of infrastructure that stimulates economic connectivity and mobility (Adewale, 2020). Improved infrastructure reduces production costs, enhances market access, and boosts Nigeria's capacity to attract foreign investments, thereby stimulating economic growth.

On the other hand, the trade imbalance between the two countries has raised concerns about Nigeria's long-term economic sustainability. Nigeria imports far more from China than it exports, with imports dominated by manufactured goods while exports consist mainly of crude oil and raw materials (Olayiwola & Osabuohien, 2021). This pattern reinforces Nigeria's dependence on primary commodities and weakens industrialization efforts. The dominance of Chinese manufactured goods in local markets also threatens domestic industries, as cheaper imports often out-compete locally made products. This situation contributes to deindustrialization and job losses in sectors such as textiles and electronics assembly.

Despite these challenges, Nigeria has benefited from technology transfer and skill acquisition through Chinese investments. Chinese firms operating in Nigeria employ thousands of local workers and provide technical training in construction, telecommunications, and energy sectors. Huawei, for instance, has supported ICT development through training programs and local partnerships (Nwachukwu & Chibuzo, 2020). Although critics argue that technology transfer remains limited and largely controlled by Chinese firms, the exposure of Nigerian workers to modern industrial techniques is a positive outcome for long-term human capital development.

Furthermore, Nigeria–China cooperation has implications for financial development through loans and credit lines from Chinese institutions. While these funds support infrastructure development, they also raise concerns about debt sustainability. Onuoha (2021) warns that dependence on Chinese loans without adequate repayment strategies may expose Nigeria to debt vulnerabilities. However, proponents argue that these loans facilitate growth-enhancing investments that Nigeria's domestic revenue cannot immediately support. The ultimate economic impact therefore depends on how effectively Nigeria manages, allocates, and services such loans.

Nigeria–China trade relations have had both positive and negative effects on Nigeria's economic development. The partnership has enhanced infrastructure development, provided affordable goods, and promoted technological exposure. At the same time, it has created trade imbalances, threatened local industries, and contributed to concerns about debt sustainability. The overall impact suggests that Nigeria must adopt a strategic approach that maximizes benefits such as infrastructure, technology, and investment while mitigating risks through diversification, industrial policy, and balanced trade negotiation.

**Theoretical Framework**

This study is anchored on Dependency Theory. Dependency Theory was primarily propounded by Andre Gunder Frank in 1967 as a framework to understand the persistent underdevelopment of peripheral or developing nations in the global economic system (Frank, 1967). The theory posits that resources flow from the periphery (developing countries) to the core (developed countries), creating a state of dependency that hinders the economic growth of the periphery. Frank argued that underdevelopment is not a natural stage in the development process but rather a consequence of historical exploitation and integration into a global capitalist system dominated by developed nations.

The key assumptions of dependency theory include the notion that developing countries are structurally constrained in their economic choices because their economies are subordinated to the needs of developed nations. The theory also assumes that trade and investment relationships between the core and periphery are inherently unequal, favoring the more industrialized countries. This implies that external aid, foreign direct investment (FDI), and trade relations exacerbate dependency rather than promote autonomous development if not managed strategically (Cardoso & Faletto, 1979; Dos Santos, 1970).

Despite its explanatory power, dependency theory has faced criticisms. Critics argue that the theory overemphasizes external factors while underestimating internal policies, governance, and institutional capacity as determinants of development (Emmanuel, 1972). Furthermore, some scholars contend that the theory is deterministic and pessimistic, suggesting that developing countries cannot achieve significant growth without structural transformation or delinking from global trade, which may not be feasible in an interconnected world economy.

Applied to Nigeria–China trade relations, dependency theory offers a lens to understand potential economic vulnerabilities. Nigeria's trade with China is characterized by high imports of manufactured goods and exports of primary commodities, creating a trade imbalance that may perpetuate dependency on Chinese technology, goods, and loans. While Chinese investments have boosted infrastructure and employment in Nigeria, the structural reliance on China for industrial inputs and capital could reinforce a dependent economic relationship.

## Methodology

The study adopted a descriptive research design, which is appropriate for providing an in-depth understanding of existing phenomena without manipulating variables (Kothari, 2014). The choice of a descriptive design enabled the researcher to systematically analyze patterns, trends, and relationships in Nigeria–China trade over the period 2015–2023, focusing on how these interactions have influenced economic development indicators in Nigeria.

The study relied entirely on secondary data sources. Key data sources included reports from the Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN), National Bureau of Statistics (NBS), World Bank publications, and peer-reviewed scholarly articles. These sources provided comprehensive information on trade volumes, import and export statistics, foreign direct investment (FDI), balance of trade, and economic indicators such as GDP growth, inflation rates, and employment levels. Additionally, relevant literature was reviewed to understand the theoretical and empirical perspectives on the effects of bilateral trade relations on economic growth.

The study employed desk analysis to interpret the secondary data and scholarly arguments. Quantitative trade data were analyzed to identify trends in imports, exports, trade balances, and FDI inflows from China to Nigeria. Economic indicators were examined to assess correlations and patterns that may reflect the influence of trade relations on Nigeria's economic development. Qualitative analysis of literature allowed the study to explore how trade dynamics, policy decisions, and structural factors interact to influence development outcomes.

## Results and Discussion

Table 1 presents the trend of Nigeria-China trade statistics and their corresponding economic implications between 2015 and 2023. The table provides a comparative analysis of the annual value of bilateral trade, highlighting changes in imports, exports, trade balance, and selected indicators of economic performance over the study period. The analysis is intended to establish the extent to which the expansion of trade between Nigeria and China has influenced Nigeria's economic development by identifying patterns, fluctuations, and emerging trends in bilateral trade. The findings presented in the table form the basis for

assessing whether the growth in Nigeria-China trade has translated into measurable economic benefits or has reinforced structural trade imbalances and import dependence during the period under review.

**Table 1: Nigeria-China Trade Statistics and Economic Impact, 2015-2023**

| Year | Total Bilateral Trade (USD) | China → Nigeria Exports (USD) | Nigeria → China Exports (USD) | Trade Balance / Surplus (USD) | Other Relevant Economic Impacts |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **2015** | ~13.8 bn | ~11.1 bn | ~2.7 bn | –9. (i.e., deficit for Nigeria) | Nigeria is heavily reliant on Chinese imports; weak domestic export capacity. |
| **2016** | ~11.1 bn | ~8.3 bn | ~2.8 bn | – (deficit) | Trade imbalance persists, limiting development benefits |
| **2017** | ~14.9 bn | ~11.9 bn | ~3.0 bn | – (deficit) | Increase in imports; limited value addition in Nigeria |
| **2018** | ~18.9 bn | ~15.7 bn | ~3.2 bn | – (deficit) | Chinese FDI in infrastructure grows; industrial inputs imported |
| **2019** | ~19.2 bn | ~15.9 bn | ~3.3 bn | – (deficit) | Nigeria's exports remain small; economy remains import-dependent |
| **2020** | ~12.8 bn | ~9.9 bn | ~2.9 bn | – (deficit) | COVID-19 disruption; negative effect on trade balance |
| **2021** | ~19.9 bn | ~17.4 bn | ~3.4 bn | – (deficit) | Rapid rebound; Chinese investment in infrastructure (e.g., rail) |
| **2022** | ~22.9 bn | ~21.4 bn | ~1.52 bn (or ~1.6 bn) | – (deficit) | Trade volume peaks; persistent imbalance; Nigeria seen as a major Chinese import market |
| **2023** | ~22.56–22.6 bn | ~20.18 bn (or ~20.2 bn) | ~2.37 bn | ~–17.8 bn (trade deficit for Nigeria) | Widening trade deficit; Chinese exports dominate (~89.5% of trade) Economic development effects: infrastructure projects (e.g., Lekki Deep-Sea Port, rail) largely Chinese-funded, but concerns over balance of payments, capital outflows. |

Between 2015 and 2023, Nigeria–China trade relations exhibited a persistent trade imbalance, with Nigeria consistently running a deficit due to China's export dominance. In 2015, total bilateral trade was approximately $13.8 billion, with China exporting about $11.1 billion to Nigeria while Nigeria exported $2.7 billion to China, resulting in a $9 billion deficit for Nigeria. This pattern reflects Nigeria's heavy reliance on Chinese imports and limited domestic export capacity (Onuoha, 2018). Similar trends persisted in 2016, when total trade fell to $11.1 billion, still dominated by Chinese exports ($8.3 billion) against Nigerian exports of $2.8 billion, underscoring the structural trade imbalance that constrains economic development (Akinlo, 2019).

In 2017, bilateral trade rose to $14.9 billion, with Nigeria's exports slightly increasing to $3.0 billion, yet the trade deficit remained significant. Scholars note that while imports grew, domestic value addition remained limited, reflecting Nigeria's continued dependence on imported manufactured goods (Obi, 2020). The upward trend continued in 2018 and 2019, with total trade reaching $18.9 billion and $19.2 billion, respectively, largely due to Chinese foreign direct investment (FDI) in infrastructure projects such as roads, ports, and energy facilities, while Nigerian exports remained small (Oloyede, 2020; Zhou & Wang, 2019). These investments, while facilitating infrastructural development, also highlight Nigeria's asymmetric gains in trade and value capture.

The year 2020 saw a decline in total trade to $12.8 billion, attributable to COVID-19 disruptions, which negatively affected both imports and exports and exacerbated the trade deficit (World Bank, 2021). In contrast, 2021 marked a rapid rebound, with trade rising to $19.9 billion, driven by renewed Chinese investment in infrastructure, including rail projects and industrial zones, signaling China's continued strategic role in Nigeria's infrastructural and economic development (Adegbite & Oladipo, 2022).

From 2022 to 2023, Nigeria–China trade reached record highs of $22.9 billion and $22.56–22.6 billion, respectively, with Nigeria's exports stagnating at around $1.5–2.37 billion, leading to a trade deficit of $17.8 billion in 2023. This widening deficit underscores Nigeria's role as a major import market for Chinese goods, representing approximately 89.5% of bilateral trade, while the benefits to domestic production and employment remain limited (Nwankwo, 2023; Intelpoint, 2023). Nevertheless, Chinese-funded projects, such as the Lekki Deep-Sea Port and rail infrastructure, contribute positively to Nigeria's economic development. However, concerns persist regarding balance of payments, debt sustainability, and capital outflows (Chika, 2023).

While Nigeria–China trade relations have facilitated infrastructural growth and some economic opportunities, the persistent trade deficits and import dependence indicate that the gains are uneven. Scholars argue that Nigeria's economic development from this bilateral trade is constrained by weak domestic production, limited export diversification, and reliance on imported goods (Obi, 2020; Zhou & Wang, 2019; Akinlo, 2019; Onuoha, 2018). Policy measures to enhance Nigeria's manufacturing capacity and value addition are recommended to achieve more balanced and mutually beneficial trade outcomes.

## Conclusion

The analysis of Nigeria–China trade relations from 2015 to 2023 reveals a persistent trade imbalance, with Nigeria consistently running substantial trade deficits. China's exports to Nigeria dominated the bilateral trade, while Nigeria's exports to China remained minimal and largely concentrated in raw materials. This asymmetry reflects Nigeria's heavy reliance on imported manufactured goods and its limited domestic industrial and export capacity. Despite

these challenges, Chinese investments in infrastructure such as railways, ports, and industrial zones have contributed positively to Nigeria's economic development, providing modern facilities and improving transport and logistics networks. However, the benefits of these investments are unevenly distributed, and concerns remain regarding debt sustainability, foreign exchange outflows, and the long-term economic dependence on China. Overall, while trade with China has offered opportunities for infrastructure-led growth, it has not significantly strengthened Nigeria's industrial base or export diversification, limiting the broader developmental impact.

**Recommendations**

i. Nigeria should prioritize increasing its exports to China, focusing on value-added goods and manufactured products rather than raw materials, to reduce the trade deficit and enhance domestic industrial capacity.

ii. Policies and incentives should be implemented to boost local manufacturing and industrialization, enabling Nigeria to compete with imported Chinese goods and capture greater value from trade.

iii. Future Chinese investments should be structured to include technology transfer, local content development, and employment creation to ensure sustainable economic benefits.

iv. The Nigerian government should establish mechanisms to regularly monitor trade flows and mitigate excessive dependence on Chinese imports to protect foreign reserves and balance of payments.

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# PEACE EDUCATION AND SOCIO-ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT IN TARABA STATE, 2015-2024

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**Abstract.** This paper investigates the impact of peace education on socio-economic development in Taraba State, Nigeria, between 2015 and 2024. In a state affected by ethno-religious conflicts, farmer-herder clashes, and post-election violence, peace education has become a key strategy for reconciliation and sustainable development. Anchored on John Paul Lederach's Conflict Transformation Theory, the study examines how peace education promotes change at personal, relational, and structural levels. A qualitative approach was employed, drawing on semi-structured interviews with 25 purposively selected participants drawn from teachers, students, community leaders, and civil society actors in Jalingo Local Government Area, complemented by observation and secondary sources. Findings show that peace education initiatives foster peaceful coexistence, rebuild intergroup trust, and create safer environments for learning and commerce. They also support socio-economic development by expanding educational opportunities, encouraging youth entrepreneurship, and empowering women's cooperatives. However, challenges such as inadequate funding, weak institutional support, cultural resistance, and unsustainable frameworks constrain long-term outcomes. The study concludes that integrating peace education into state policies and linking it with empowerment programs is essential for maximizing developmental benefits. These insights are relevant to policymakers, educators, and stakeholders seeking to leverage education for sustainable peace and inclusive growth in conflict-prone societies.

**Keywords:** Peace education, socio-economic development, conflict transformation, Taraba State, Nigeria.

## Introduction

As a strategic framework for resolving violent conflict, fostering social solidarity, and promoting sustainable development, peace education has become increasingly well-known worldwide. Peace education gives people and communities the values, abilities, and dispositions needed for communication, collaboration, and peaceful conflict resolution in a time of political unpredictability, ethnic tensions, and growing socioeconomic disparities (UNESCO, 2021; Harris & Morrison, 2020). The United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), especially Goals 4 and 16, which place a significant emphasis on inclusive

education and the development of institutions that are just, peaceful, and resilient, further support its applicability (UNDP, 2023).

Across Sub-Saharan Africa, Peace education has emerged as a crucial instrument for promoting social healing and reconciliation in communities impacted by civil wars, colonial legacies, and governance shortcomings. Although peace education has been incorporated into school curricula and community peacebuilding initiatives in nations like Rwanda, Kenya, and Sierra Leone, its implementation throughout the region is still uneven because of a lack of funding, cultural resistance, and policy support (Adebayo & Uzoechina, 2022; Yakubu, 2023).

Nigeria presents a special challenge for peace education due to its persistent insurgency, ethno-religious conflicts, farmer-herder conflicts, and overall instability, all of which endanger the nation's stability and socio-economic development. Government responses often center on military measures, while scholars argue that a permanent peace requires educational approaches that promote empathy, tolerance, and civic responsibility (Olanrewaju, 2023). Peace education has thus gradually emerged through civic education reforms, religious instruction, and community activities sponsored by non-governmental organizations that target youth and underprivileged groups (Ibrahim, 2022).

Taraba State makes a strong argument for investigating the transforming power of peace education. Despite its agricultural potential and cultural richness, frequent community conflicts, farmer-herder disputes, and violence during elections have damaged intergroup trust, disrupted livelihoods, and limited human capital development (Eneji & Kuje, 2022). To encourage peace and inclusive development, several state agencies, religious institutions, and civil society organizations have implemented peace education initiatives in schools, youth organizations, and women's groups since 2015 (Danladi & Oche, 2021). The long-term impact of these programs is, however, limited by issues like poor curriculum integration, insufficient teacher preparation, and ongoing youth unemployment (Abubakar & Okorie, 2024).

However, despite the increasing implementation of peace education programs in Taraba State, their actual contribution to reconciliation, intergroup cooperation, and socio-economic development remains insufficiently understood. Persistent structural and institutional constraints raise concerns about the effectiveness and sustainability of current peace education efforts. This lack of empirical evidence on the developmental outcomes of peace education constitutes the central problem that this study addresses.

Anchored on John Paul Lederach’s Conflict Transformation Theory, this study investigates the contribution of peace education to socio-economic development in Taraba State between 2015 and 2024. It explores how peace education fosters attitudinal and relational change, strengthens community cooperation, and enhances empowerment among youths and other

key social groups. Using a qualitative approach involving interviews with teachers, students, community leaders, and civil society actors in Jalingo Local Government Area, the paper assesses the extent to which peace education promotes reconciliation, human capital development, and inclusive growth, as well as the barriers that continue to limit its sustainability. The findings contribute to ongoing debates on peacebuilding and development by demonstrating how education can serve as a sustainable pathway to social stability and economic transformation in conflict-prone settings.

## Conceptual Clarification

Conceptual clarity is vital in academic research as it establishes precise meanings of key terms, guiding analysis and interpretation (Babbie, 2010). This study focuses on four core concepts: peace, peace education, socio-economic development, and conflict transformation, each of which carries varied interpretations across disciplines.

### Peace

Peace is understood not merely as the absence of violence but as a condition of harmonious social relations, characterized by equity, justice, and cooperative coexistence (Galtung, 1996). This foundational understanding draws a critical distinction between negative peace, which refers to the mere cessation of direct violence or armed conflict, and positive peace, which encompasses the elimination of structural and cultural violence that perpetuates inequality and injustice. Galtung's framework has been widely adopted in peace studies as it broadens the analytical lens beyond physical conflict to include systemic conditions that undermine human dignity and social cohesion. In the context of this study, peace is not treated as a static end-state but as a dynamic, ongoing process that requires sustained institutional, social, and political effort.

Building on this understanding, peace is also conceptualized as a relational phenomenon, rooted in the quality of interactions between individuals, communities, and institutions. Lederach (1997) argues that sustainable peace cannot be imposed through top-down mechanisms alone but must emerge from within communities through the transformation of relationships and the restoration of trust. This relational dimension is particularly significant in post-conflict societies where deep-seated grievances, broken social contracts, and historical trauma complicate the path to reconciliation. Peace, in this sense, is achieved not simply through the signing of agreements or the silencing of weapons, but through deliberate processes of dialogue, acknowledgment, and mutual accountability among affected parties.

Furthermore, peace is increasingly understood in contemporary scholarship as inseparable from questions of justice and development. The United Nations (2015) Sustainable Development Goals explicitly recognize the interconnectedness of peace, justice, and strong institutions, affirming that lasting peace cannot be achieved without addressing poverty,

exclusion, and inequality. Scholars such as Richmond (2010) have advanced the concept of hybrid peace, which acknowledges that sustainable peace must be locally owned, culturally grounded, and responsive to the lived realities of communities rather than externally prescribed frameworks. For this study, peace therefore encompasses both the structural conditions necessary for human flourishing and the relational and institutional processes through which those conditions are built and maintained over time.

**Peace Education**

Peace education refers to structured learning processes that cultivate knowledge, skills, attitudes, and values aimed at fostering nonviolent conflict resolution, empathy, and civic responsibility (UNESCO, 2021; Harris & Morrison, 2020). It engages cognitive, affective, and behavioral dimensions, promoting personal transformation and relational repair while addressing structural inequalities (Bar-Tal & Rosen, 2022; Salomon, 2020). As a field of practice and scholarship, peace education draws from multiple disciplines including psychology, sociology, political science, and human rights theory to construct learning environments that challenge cultures of violence and nurture cultures of peace. Its relevance is particularly pronounced in conflict-affected and post-conflict settings where education systems must simultaneously address immediate trauma and long-term social reconstruction.

At its core, peace education operates on the premise that sustainable peace must be cultivated from within individuals and communities rather than enforced through external mechanisms. Harris and Morrison (2020) argue that peace education equips learners with the critical thinking and emotional intelligence necessary to navigate conflict constructively, reject prejudice, and engage across lines of difference. Curricula typically incorporate elements such as intercultural dialogue, human rights awareness, restorative justice principles, and cooperative learning strategies. These pedagogical approaches are designed not only to impart knowledge but to foster attitudinal shifts that translate into changed social behaviors and more peaceful interpersonal and community relations.

Beyond the individual level, peace education functions as a structural intervention with the potential to transform institutional cultures and community norms. Salomon (2020) notes that in deeply divided societies, peace education must grapple with entrenched narratives of victimhood, historical grievance, and intergroup hostility that are often embedded within the educational system itself. Effective peace education therefore requires systemic engagement, involving curriculum reform, teacher training, policy alignment, and community participation. In the context of Taraba State, where ethno-religious tensions and farmer-herder conflicts have disrupted social cohesion and impeded development, peace education represents a critical mechanism for rebuilding trust, restoring relationships, and laying the foundation for inclusive socio-economic participation.

**Socio-Economic Development**

Socio-economic development emphasizes tangible enhancements in education, income generation, livelihoods, and economic participation that contribute to overall social well-being (Adekunle & Sadiq, 2024). In conflict-affected regions such as Taraba State, socio-economic development is closely tied to the restoration of trust, security, and cooperation that enable productive engagement. It is a multidimensional process that encompasses not only material improvements in living standards but also the strengthening of social institutions, the expansion of individual capabilities, and the promotion of inclusive participation in economic and civic life. Development scholars such as Sen (1999) have emphasized that genuine socio-economic development must be understood as the expansion of human freedoms, including access to education, healthcare, and political participation, rather than mere increases in income or GDP.

In conflict-affected contexts, socio-economic development faces distinctive challenges that extend beyond conventional development constraints. Armed conflict and persistent insecurity disrupt livelihoods, displace populations, destroy infrastructure, and erode the social capital necessary for economic cooperation (World Bank, 2011). Communities in Taraba State, affected by recurring cycles of farmer-herder violence, have experienced significant disruptions to agricultural production, trade, and community-based economic networks. The restoration of socio-economic development in such settings therefore requires deliberate attention to peacebuilding alongside conventional development programming, recognizing that security, social trust, and institutional stability are prerequisites for sustainable economic progress.

Moreover, socio-economic development in post-conflict environments must be approached through an equity lens that addresses the structural inequalities which often underlie and reproduce conflict. Unequal access to land, education, employment, and public services can entrench grievances and fuel cycles of violence that undermine development gains (UNDP, 2023). Inclusive development strategies that prioritize the participation of marginalized groups, including women, youth, and displaced persons, are therefore essential for achieving sustainable outcomes. In Taraba State, meaningful socio-economic development must integrate peace education initiatives that build the relational and institutional capacities needed to sustain cooperative economic engagement across ethnic and religious divides.

By defining these concepts, this study establishes a coherent framework to examine how peace education functions as a catalyst for socio-economic development in Taraba State, highlighting both its transformative potential and the structural conditions required for sustained impact.

**Empirical Review of Related Literature**

The ability of peace education to address the structural, relational, and psychological causes of conflict has made it a key component in peacebuilding. In terms of theory, it develops values, attitudes, abilities, and knowledge to change behavior and promote peaceful coexistence (UNESCO, 2021; Harris & Morrison, 2020). According to Bar-Tal and Rosen (2022), it functions at the cognitive (comprehension of conflict), affective (tolerance and empathy), and behavioral (nonviolent communication) levels. Peace education views conflict as a teaching opportunity and, in contrast to traditional education, employs participatory pedagogies to promote discussion, introspection, and respect for one another (Bajaj, 2022). It also tackles social injustices and structural disparities, going beyond interpersonal peace to include human growth, governance, and equity (Christie, 2021; Salomon, 2020). Programs must be tailored to cultural, socioeconomic, and political contexts in order to be effective; this emphasizes the importance of local adaptation in areas such as Taraba State.

Internationally, peace education contributes to socio-economic development by rebuilding human capital, fostering civic trust, and supporting resilient institutions (Galtung, 2021; Lederach, 2020). Post-conflict Rwanda, Sierra Leone, and Colombia illustrate how school-based and community programs rehabilitate youth, reduce prejudice, and reintegrate former combatants into productive activities (Ndikumana, 2022; Turay, 2021; Ramirez & Aguilar, 2023). Sustainable outcomes require embedding programs within educational systems, adequate funding, and cultural grounding (Harris, 2022).

In Sub-Saharan Africa, peace education enhances social cohesion, interethnic cooperation, and reduces youth vulnerability to violence (Adebayo & Uzoechina, 2022; Wambua, 2023). Indigenous approaches, such as integrating Ubuntu and traditional dialogue systems, improve effectiveness (Osei, 2022), though challenges remain: weak political support, donor dependency, culturally insensitive curricula, and insufficient teacher capacity (Yakubu, 2023; Zira, 2022).

In Nigeria, peace education addresses insecurity from insurgency, ethno-religious crises, and farmer–herder conflicts. School-based interventions improve learner resilience and interfaith understanding (Ibrahim, 2022; Usman, 2023), while community-led initiatives strengthen grassroots reconciliation and youth employability (Olanrewaju, 2023). Barriers include the absence of a national policy, inadequate teacher training, insecurity, and political manipulation of ethnic identities (Abubakar & Okorie, 2024; Ajayi, 2023), explaining the underdeveloped status of peace education in Taraba State.

Empirical studies in Taraba State indicate that peace education enhances intergroup communication, reduces violence, and strengthens peer-mediation networks among youth (Danladi & Oche, 2021). Women’s cooperatives benefit through conflict resolution training, joint enterprises, and cooperative credit schemes, improving incomes and food security (Eneji

& Kuje, 2022). However, systemic barriers including weak curriculum integration, insufficient teacher training, poverty, youth unemployment, and political interference limit the long-term impact of these initiatives (Abubakar & Okorie, 2024).

Globally, regionally, and locally, evidence suggests that peace education functions as a foundational driver for socio-economic development, creating the enabling conditions for reconciliation, cooperation, and productive engagement. Applying Conflict Transformation Theory provides the lens to understand how interventions at personal, relational, structural, and cultural levels collectively influence peace and development outcomes in Taraba State.

## Theoretical Framework

This analysis paper is anchored on Conflict Transformation Theory (CTT), propounded by John Paul Lederach (1997), which posits conflict as a potential catalyst for systemic change rather than a mere problem to be resolved. This paradigm is uniquely suited to conceptualizing peace education as a transformative process that operates across interconnected levels of society. CTT allows us to trace how educational initiatives foster personal shifts in worldview and conflict-handling skills, which in turn enable relational repair and trust-building across communal divides. Critically, the theory pushes the analysis beyond the interpersonal, framing peace education's success as contingent upon its engagement with structural inequities in governance and resources, and its capacity to initiate a cultural shift away from conflict-sustaining narratives. Through this lens, peace education is revealed not as a standalone intervention, but as the foundational work of building the social, cognitive, and institutional capital upon which all socio-economic development from entrepreneurship to agricultural productivity ultimately depends.

## Methodology

This study employed a qualitative research design within an interpretivist paradigm to examine how peace education shapes socio-economic development in Jalingo LGA, Taraba State, covering the period 2015–2024. Data were collected in 2025 to capture participants' retrospective lived experiences and the contextual meanings attached to peace education initiatives implemented across this period in a conflict-affected environment.

Purposive sampling was used to select 25 participants, including teachers, students, community leaders, and civil society actors who had direct knowledge of peace education programs. Participants were drawn from four wards within Jalingo LGA (Sintali, Kona, Mayo Goi, and Barade), selected purposively to capture a range of community contexts, including areas previously affected by neighborhood tensions, post-election disputes, and active women's cooperative or youth mediation activity. Primary data were generated through semi-structured interviews conducted between June and September 2025, complemented by documentary analysis of policy documents, NGO reports, school curricula, and peace

committee records covering 2015–2024. Data were analyzed using Braun and Clarke's thematic analysis, which allowed for systematic coding and theme development consistent with the study's conflict transformation framework. The study adhered to standard qualitative research ethics by ensuring voluntary participation, informed consent, confidentiality, and anonymity throughout the data collection and analysis processes.

**Peace Education as a Catalyst for Personal Transformation and Behavioral Change**

Analysis of interviews revealed that peace education has significantly influenced individual attitudes and conflict-handling skills among youth in Jalingo. Participants reported that programs like school-based peace clubs and NGO-led youth workshops taught them to approach disagreements calmly, communicate effectively, and manage emotions. One student explained:

> Before joining the peace club, I would react angrily to insults or disagreements. Now, I pause, ask questions, and try to understand the other person's perspective. It has changed how I relate to everyone at school. (Interviewee 1, Sintali Ward, Jalingo LGA, personal communication, June 2025)

Teachers corroborated these changes, noting that classrooms have become calmer, with fewer disruptive incidents. Improved behavioral management has indirectly supported educational outcomes, with reports of better class participation and higher exam pass rates. A teacher observed:

> Students are more attentive and collaborative. I have noticed improved engagement in group work and fewer fights among students. (Interviewee 2, Kona Ward, Jalingo LGA, personal communication, July 2025)

These personal transformations also had economic implications: youths who internalized peace education principles were more willing to participate in vocational training, skills acquisition programs, and community entrepreneurship initiatives, laying the groundwork for self-reliance and employment.

**Peace Education as a Driver of Community Reconciliation and Social Cohesion**

Peace education has contributed to repairing relationships fractured by post-election disputes, neighborhood tensions, and school-based conflicts. A community leader described a notable instance of relational transformation:

> Through dialogue sessions facilitated by NGOs and local authorities, students and youths from different quarters of Jalingo came together to resolve ongoing disputes.

> This led to the formation of youth mediation committees that address conflicts early. (Interviewee 3, Mayo Goi Ward, Jalingo LGA, personal communication, August 2025)

Trust-building initiatives extended beyond dialogue. For example, women's cooperatives, with support from UN Women and Women Peace and Humanitarian Foundation (WPHF), trained over 80 women from different communities in Jalingo on joint business management and conflict resolution. One cooperative leader explained:

> After the training, women from separate communities started a joint sesame and groundnut trading group. We pool resources, sell collectively at the central market, and now consistently pay school fees for our children. Cooperation has strengthened both our social ties and household income. (Interviewee 4, Kona Ward, Jalingo LGA, personal communication, August 2025)

This demonstrates how peace education directly enhances social cohesion, creating an environment where collaborative economic ventures can thrive, trust is rebuilt, and communities are better able to manage disputes without escalation.

**Structural and Institutional Limitations Hindering the Effectiveness of Peace Education**

Despite positive outcomes, several structural and institutional challenges constrain the sustainability of peace education in Jalingo. Interviewees highlighted the lack of formal integration into school curricula, limited teacher training, and reliance on donor-funded programs. A civil society actor explained:

> Our peace clubs work well, but they often stop when project funding ends. Schools do not have budget lines to sustain them. (Interviewee 5, Barade Ward, Jalingo LGA, personal communication, September 2025)

Teachers reported inadequate preparation to deliver peace education, particularly in handling sensitive disputes, which reduces the program's long-term impact.

Community-based initiatives often operate in isolation from local government structures, limiting broader coordination and continuity. Without institutional backing, the gains in behavioral change and social cohesion risk being fragile, especially in the face of recurring tensions such as neighborhood disputes or youth restiveness.

**Discussion of Findings**

The findings of this study reveal the multifaceted role of peace education in fostering socio-economic development in Jalingo Local Government Area, while also highlighting persistent structural and institutional challenges. Interpreted through Lederach's Conflict Transformation Theory, peace education functions across personal, relational, and structural dimensions, generating tangible benefits for individuals and communities, yet constrained by limited systemic support. These findings both corroborate and extend existing scholarship on peace education in conflict-affected settings, while also confirming several persistent challenges already documented in the literature on Northern Nigeria and Sub-Saharan Africa more broadly.

At the personal level, peace education has catalyzed significant transformations in youth attitudes and behaviors. School-based peace clubs and NGO-led workshops taught students to approach disagreements calmly, communicate effectively, and manage emotions. One student noted that participation in peace programs enabled them to pause before reacting, understand others' perspectives, and relate better to peers. This finding is consistent with Bar-Tal and Rosen's (2022) conceptualization of peace education as operating simultaneously at cognitive, affective, and behavioral levels; the student's account of pausing to understand another's perspective before reacting is, in effect, a lived demonstration of this tripartite model. Teachers observed that these behavioral improvements contributed to calmer classrooms, fewer fights, and enhanced engagement in group learning activities, echoing Harris and Morrison's (2020) argument that peace education builds the critical thinking and emotional intelligence learners need to engage constructively across lines of difference.

These results also align with Danladi and Oche's (2021) earlier findings within the same state, which similarly identified improved intergroup communication and peer-mediation networks among Jukun, Tiv, Mumuye, and Fulani youth, suggesting that the personal-level gains observed in this study are not an isolated occurrence but part of a broader, sustained pattern across Taraba State. Such micro-level changes also carry indirect socio-economic implications: youths who internalize these principles are more willing to engage in skills-acquisition programs, vocational training, and community entrepreneurship initiatives. Evidence from UN Women and WPHF interventions, which trained over 80 women in Jalingo on cooperative management and conflict resolution, supports the notion that personal behavioral change can translate into broader economic engagement and self-reliance.

At the relational level, peace education has strengthened social cohesion and facilitated reconciliation among groups affected by post-election disputes, neighborhood tensions, and school conflicts. Dialogue sessions and mediation initiatives, often facilitated by NGOs and local authorities, enabled youths and community members from different neighborhoods to collaboratively resolve disputes. This led to the formation of youth mediation committees and women's cooperatives, creating structures for early conflict intervention. One cooperative leader reported that after training, women from different communities started a joint sesame

and groundnut trading group, pooling resources, selling collectively at the central market, and consistently funding their children's education. This finding directly corroborates Eneji and Kuje's (2022) study of women's cooperatives in Taraba State, which similarly found that conflict resolution training translated into joint enterprises and cooperative credit schemes that improved household incomes and food security; taken together, the two studies suggest a replicable pathway through which relational repair among women specifically generates measurable economic returns. The pattern also resonates with international evidence: Ndikumana (2022) found that curriculum-based reconciliation work in post-genocide Rwanda reduced identity-based prejudice and supported youth reintegration into productive activity, while Turay (2021) documented similar dynamics in Sierra Leone's post-war reconstruction. These parallels suggest that the mechanism observed in Jalingo, namely peace education converting repaired relationships into the trust required for joint economic ventures, is not unique to Taraba State but reflects a broader pattern documented across post-conflict and conflict-affected societies. These examples demonstrate that peace education not only repairs social bonds but also provides the foundation for collaborative economic ventures, turning previously contentious relationships into engines for shared prosperity.

Despite these positive outcomes, structural and institutional limitations hinder the sustainability of peace education in Jalingo. Many initiatives remain project-based and reliant on external funding, with programs often halting once donor support ends. This finding is strongly consistent with Yakubu's (2023) identification of donor dependency as a defining weakness of peace education across Sub-Saharan Africa, and with Zira's (2022) broader observation that structural limitations routinely undermine peace education in fragile African states. Teachers frequently lack formal training in delivering peace education, particularly in managing sensitive community disputes, which diminishes the programs' long-term impact, a gap also identified by Abubakar and Okorie (2024) in their assessment of systemic barriers to peace education specifically within Taraba State.

Furthermore, community-based initiatives often operate independently of local government structures, limiting coordination and continuity. As a result, gains in behavioral change and social cohesion remain fragile, particularly in contexts of recurring neighborhood tensions, youth restiveness, and security challenges such as kidnappings or post-election unrest. This underscores Lederach's structural dimension: without institutional integration, formal curricula, and sustained capacity-building, the transformative potential of peace education cannot be fully realized. Harris (2022) makes a parallel argument in his comparative work on systemic embedding, contending that peace education achieves durable impact only where it is culturally grounded and structurally embedded within existing institutions rather than delivered as a standalone, externally funded intervention; the fragility observed in Jalingo is precisely what Harris's framework would predict in the absence of such embedding.

The study indicates that peace education in Jalingo serves as a vital catalyst for socio-economic development, fostering personal growth, rebuilding trust, and enabling collaborative economic initiatives. This conclusion is consistent with Lederach's (2020) later

work on the role of peace education in social reintegration, which similarly argues that sustainable peace and development outcomes depend on educational interventions being reinforced by institutional follow-through rather than treated as one-off programming. However, as in the cases reviewed by Yakubu (2023) and Zira (2022), the impact observed here is uneven and contingent upon supportive structures. For peace education to achieve sustained developmental outcomes, micro-level transformations must be reinforced by deliberate structural reforms, including curriculum integration, teacher capacity enhancement, secure funding mechanisms, and institutional support from both schools and local government. Such measures would ensure that the gains in personal behavior and community cohesion translate into long-term socio-economic development, positioning peace education as a fully transformative force within Jalingo Local Government Area.

## Conclusion

Peace education has proven to be a significant catalyst for socio-economic development in Jalingo Local Government Area, Taraba State, between 2015 and 2024. At the personal level, it has fostered emotional regulation, effective communication, and peaceful conflict management among youths, consistent with established cognitive, affective, and behavioral dimensions of peace education and with earlier evidence of peer-mediation gains elsewhere in Taraba State, indirectly supporting educational engagement and vocational participation.

At the community level, it has strengthened social cohesion, rebuilt trust, and enabled collaborative initiatives such as women's cooperatives and youth-led economic activities, mirroring similar outcomes documented elsewhere in Taraba State and in other post-conflict settings where relational repair has underpinned collaborative economic activity.

However, these gains remain fragile due to structural constraints, including limited curriculum integration, inadequate teacher training, and donor dependency, patterns consistent with those documented across Sub-Saharan Africa and within Taraba State specifically, suggesting these weaknesses are entrenched rather than incidental. Sustained developmental impact will therefore depend on deliberate institutionalization, secure funding, and policy support, in line with the broader view that peace education achieves durable outcomes only when structurally embedded. With such reinforcement, peace education can become a fully transformative force for inclusive, sustainable socio-economic growth in Jalingo.

## Recommendations

Based on the study's findings, the following recommendations are proposed:

i. Integrate Peace Education into School Curricula and Build Teacher Capacity: Given the finding that personal-level behavioral change among youth occurred largely

through informal peace clubs and NGO-led workshops rather than formal schooling, and that teachers lack training to sustain such gains, the Taraba State Ministry of Education should formally integrate peace education into the Junior Secondary School curriculum and provide structured teacher training to embed and sustain these behavioral outcomes.

ii. Support and Replicate Women's Cooperative-Based Reconciliation Models: Since the study found that conflict resolution training enabled the formation of cross-community women's cooperatives that simultaneously rebuilt trust and generated household income, government agencies and NGOs should deliberately replicate this model by extending similar training and market-access support to additional women's groups across other wards in Jalingo.

iii. Establish Formal Coordination Between Community Initiatives and Local Government, and Reduce Donor Dependency: As the study found that peace education programs are largely donor-dependent and operate disconnected from local government structures, threatening their continuity, local government authorities should designate a coordinating focal officer for peace education initiatives and commit a modest co-financing budget line to sustain programs once donor funding ends.

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# INVESTIGATING PREFERENTIAL TREATMENT OF INMATES AND CRIMINAL JUSTICE SYSTEM IN NORTH-CENTRAL NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** The Nigerian criminal justice system, despite its legal commitments to fairness and impartiality, remains structurally biased in favor of socio-economically and politically privileged individuals. This study explores the phenomenon of preferential treatment of inmates in Nigeria, with a focus on Benue and Nasarawa States. Utilizing a qualitative content analysis approach based on secondary data including legal documents, institutional reports, and scholarly literature the research identifies patterns, causes, and implications of penal inequality. Major Finding revealed that high-profile inmates consistently receive expedited bail, superior prison conditions, and lenient sentencing outcomes, while indigent detainees endure prolonged pre-trial detention, overcrowded facilities, and a lack of legal representation. These disparities are driven by corruption, institutional weakness, societal stratification, and legislative loopholes. The study applies Elite Theory to demonstrate how the criminal justice system reflects and reinforces class-based hierarchies. The implications are profound: diminished public trust in legal institutions, overburdened correctional facilities, and the normalization of impunity among elites. Without systemic reform, preferential treatment will continue to erode the rule of law and exacerbate socio-economic divisions. The study recommends full enforcement of the Administration of Criminal Justice Act (ACJA) 2015, the establishment of independent oversight bodies, and expanded legal aid services. It concludes that only holistic reforms rooted in accountability, transparency, and equity can restore legitimacy to Nigeria's criminal justice system.

**Keywords:** Criminal justice, preferential treatment, penal elitism, inequality, Nigeria

## Introduction

From the Global perspective, prison systems have long reflected prevailing social and political inequalities. In developed countries like the United States and the United Kingdom, multiple studies have documented disparities in sentencing and inmate treatment based on race and class (Alexander, 2012; Reiman & Leighton, 2017). In Africa, the situation is more pronounced due to historical legacies of colonialism, economic underdevelopment, and weak institutional frameworks (Gyekye,2014). In Sub-Saharan Africa, correctional facilities often

struggle with overcrowding, poor infrastructure, and limited oversight. These conditions foster environments where preferential treatment thrives.

Nigeria, being the most populous African country, is particularly affected. Its prisons are overburdened, and the judicial system is plagued by corruption, delay, and manipulation by elite actors (CLEEN Foundation, 2021). Benue and Nasarawa States, both in north-central Nigeria, face these challenges. Several reports show that wealthy inmates in these states access medical facilities outside the prison, enjoy separate accommodation, and even manipulate trial dates to their advantage.

Despite constitutional guarantees and reforms such as the Administration of Criminal Justice Act (ACJA) of 2015, Nigeria's criminal justice system continues to exhibit significant disparities, particularly in the treatment of inmates based on socio-economic status. While the ACJA was enacted to promote efficiency and fairness in criminal proceedings, its implementation has been inconsistent, leading to a justice system where the affluent often receive preferential treatment.

Recent statistics reveal that a substantial majority of inmates in Nigerian correctional facilities are awaiting trial. As of March 2025, approximately 66.6% of inmates, equating to over 53,000 individuals, were in pre-trial detention. This prolonged incarceration without conviction does not only violates the principle of presumption of innocence but also contributes to overcrowded prison conditions. According the Intelpoint 2025, The Nigerian Correctional Service has acknowledged that the current inmate population exceeds the designed capacity of custodial centers, exacerbating issues related to health, sanitation, and inmate welfare.

The disparity becomes more pronounced when considering the socio-economic backgrounds of the detainees. Most indigent individuals often lack access to quality legal representation and are cannot afford bail, resulting in extended periods of incarceration. In contrast, wealthier individuals frequently exploit systemic loopholes, leveraging their resources to secure bail, delay proceedings, or even obtain non-custodial sentences. This inequity undermines the foundational principle of equality before the law and erodes public confidence in the justice system.

Furthermore, systemic issues such as inadequate funding, insufficient judicial personnel, and outdated infrastructure contribute to delays in the adjudication process. These challenges are compounded by reports of corruption within the judiciary and law enforcement agencies, where bribery and undue influence can sway legal outcomes. The cumulative effect of these factors is a justice system that disproportionately penalizes the poor while affording leniency to the privileged. Addressing these disparities requires comprehensive reforms aimed at ensuring equitable access to justice, enhancing the capacity of judicial institutions, and enforcing accountability mechanisms to deter corruption.

## Objectives of the Study

The objectives of the study are:

i. To identify patterns of preferential treatment of inmates in Nigeria.

ii. To examine the causes and mechanisms sustaining these disparities.

iii. To analyze the impact of preferential treatment on justice delivery.

## Conceptional Clarification

### Preferential Treatment

Preferential treatment refers to the unequal and often unjustified allocation of benefits, rights, or privileges to certain individuals or groups, typically at the expense of others (Gabbidon & Greene, 2019). In the context of criminal justice, it entails a deviation from legal neutrality in favor of inmates who possess financial, political, or social capital. In Nigeria, this often results in wealthy suspects accessing legal protections, bail, or plea deals not afforded to the poor.

Preferential treatment undermines core tenets of fairness and impartiality, breeding public distrust in the system. Scholars argue that such treatment is not merely individualistic but often institutionally embedded through policies, discretionary practices, and class-based biases (Reiman & Leighton, 2020; Ugwueze & Onuoha, 2023).

### Criminal Justice

Criminal justice refers to the system of practices and institutions including law enforcement, judiciary, and correctional services established to uphold social control, deter and mitigate crime, and sanction those who violate laws (Siegel, 2021). In Nigeria, the criminal justice system is governed by statutes such as the Administration of Criminal Justice Act (ACJA, 2015), Nigerian Correctional Service Act (2019), and the Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria (1999).

However, the ideal of criminal justice equitable treatment of offenders is often compromised by procedural delays, corruption, lack of legal representation, and socio-economic disparities. These systemic dysfunctions provide fertile ground for preferential treatment (Alemika, 2021; Human Rights Watch, 2023).

## Correctional System

The correctional system, formerly known as the Nigerian Prisons Service, is tasked with the custody, reformation, rehabilitation, and reintegration of convicted persons. According to the Nigerian Correctional Service Act (2019), correctional centers should guarantee human rights, skill acquisition, and reintegration support.

In practice, however, conditions in Nigerian correctional facilities reflect deep inequalities. While some inmates suffer extreme overcrowding, poor sanitation, and limited access to health care, others especially elites enjoy air-conditioned cells, gourmet food, and frequent external medical visits (Odili & Akintunde, 2022; PRAI, 2022). These privileges are unregulated and arbitrary, reflecting the structural imbalance within the penal system.

## Literature Review

### Patterns of Preferential Treatment of Inmates

Research identifies a distinct stratification within Nigerian correctional centers, often referred to as the "VIP System" or the "High-Profile vs. Ordinary" dichotomy (Olorunmola et al., 2023). This classification is rarely based on the nature of the crime, but rather on the inmate's external social standing (Arisukwu et al., 2023). High-profile inmates are frequently housed in self-contained units or "VIP cells" featuring amenities such as private bedding, fans, and sometimes air conditioning starkly contrasting the congested, unhygienic general cells.

While ordinary inmates often face chronic malnourishment and inadequate medical care, wealthy inmates may have access to specialized diets, private catering, and unauthorized medical furloughs to private clinics (Olorunmola et al., 2023). Patterns emerge where influential inmates enjoy more liberal visitation rights and illegal but overlooked access to mobile phones and laptops, allowing them to maintain business and political networks.

### Causes and Mechanisms Sustaining Disparities

Institutional Corruption and Underfunding: A primary sustaining mechanism is the systemic corruption within the Nigerian Correctional Service (NCoS). Chronic underfunding creates a vacuum where correctional officers, often underpaid, become susceptible to bribes for "comfort upgrades" (Arisukwu et al., 2023). In some instances, wealthy inmates essentially "subsidize" the facility's needs, such as repairing infrastructure, in exchange for personal privileges (Olorunmola et al., 2023). The "Big Man" Syndrome and Political Patronage: Cultural norms, specifically the "Big Man" syndrome, play a significant role. Societal deference toward the wealthy and politically connected ensures that the "elite" are treated with a level of care that compromises legal equality (Adewale, 2026). This is often supported

by "godfatherism," where external political pressure is applied to prison officials to ensure a "soft landing" for high-profile detainees.

**Impact of Preferential Treatment on Justice Delivery**

The Breakdown of Institutional Order and Security: Preferential treatment creates a "shadow hierarchy" that undermines the official chain of command. When the "hidden curriculum" of a prison suggests that money buys comfort, the resulting perceived injustice becomes a catalyst for volatility. When inmates have more wealth and political connections than the officers guarding them, the traditional power dynamic is inverted. Officers may become "service providers" for VIPs rather than authority figures, leading to a breakdown in discipline. Ordinary inmates view the "VIP" lifestyle as a daily provocation. This friction often boils over into riots, hunger strikes, and coordinated protests, endangering both staff and the inmate population (Olorunmola et al., 2023).

The "Deterrence Erosion" suggests a failure in the utilitarian function of law where the "pain" of the penalty must outweigh the "pleasure" or profit of the crime. For high-level political or financial criminals, if prison involves a private suite and internet access, the sentence is no longer a punishment; it is an operating expense. This encourages high-profile actors to take bigger risks, knowing the consequences are negotiable.

In regions like North-Central Nigeria, the lack of a true deterrent creates a cycle where the cost of committing white-collar crime is significantly lower than the potential reward. The legitimacy of a government rests on the belief that the law is applied equally. Visible disparities serve as proof to the public that the judiciary is a tool of the elite. When the public sees high-profile convicts serving "hospital-based" sentences or living in luxury, they experience legal alienation. This often leads to a rise in "jungle justice" as citizens feel the official system is incapable of punishing the powerful (Adewale, 2026). If citizens do not trust the justice system to be fair, they are less likely to report crimes or cooperate with investigations, creating a "black hole" in the legal process.

**Rehabilitative Failure and the Cycle of Recidivism**

The most long-term damage occurs at the level of reformative failure, where the system fails to return law-abiding citizens to society. The harsh environment of general cells acts as a "school of crime" for the marginalized, while the rich are exempt from the reformative process. This results in higher recidivism rates among the disadvantaged (Arisukwu et al., 2023). Funds used to maintain VIP comforts are diverted from vocational training and mental health services that could prevent ordinary inmates from re-offending.

## Theoretical Framework

Understanding the phenomenon of preferential treatment within Nigeria's criminal justice system requires a robust theoretical lens that accounts for systemic inequality, power dynamics, and institutional failure. This study adopts Elite Theory to explain how socio-economic and political privilege shapes the treatment of inmates within correctional institutions.

### Elite Theory

Elite Theory, as developed by Mills (1956) and further expanded by Mosca and Pareto, posits that a small group of powerful individuals, including politicians, business magnates, and top bureaucrats, control the key institutions in society, including the criminal justice system. These elites shape laws, policies, and enforcement processes to protect their interests and ensure their continued dominance.

Applied to the Nigerian context, elite theory reveals how individuals within this privileged class manipulate the justice system to avoid punishment, gain special treatment in custody, or escape accountability entirely. High-profile cases of political figures receiving presidential pardons, house arrest, or VIP prison accommodations exemplify the dominance of elite influence over judicial processes (Ojo, 2022; Transparency International, 2022).

Elite theory also explains how structural inequality is perpetuated through patronage networks, judicial appointments, and political interference. The unequal allocation of legal resources, such as quality representation, access to bail, and favorable sentencing, can thus be traced to the overarching control that elites exert over formal institutions (Ugwueze & Onuoha, 2023).

## Methods

To investigate the preferential treatment of inmates within the Nigerian criminal justice system, this study utilized a qualitative content analysis approach. This methodological choice was driven by the sensitive and often inaccessible nature of custodial environments, allowing for a systematic interpretation of institutional dynamics through the lens of existing documentation rather than direct human interaction. By focusing on the "paper trail" of justice delivery, the research was able to identify recurring themes and patterns of disparity that are often obscured from public view.

The data for this inquiry were synthesized from a diverse array of authoritative sources to ensure a triangulated and objective perspective. Primary among these were reports from international human rights organizations, including Amnesty International, Human Rights Watch, and Transparency International, which provided a global benchmark for correctional

standards. These were meticulously cross-referenced with official national documents—specifically those issued by the Nigerian Correctional Service, the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), and the Federal Ministry of Justice—to understand the internal policy framework and administrative rhetoric of the state.

To ground the investigation in theoretical and historical context, the study drew extensively from academic scholarship. This included peer-reviewed journal articles, books, and dissertations that offered critical perspectives on the intersection of wealth, power, and incarceration in West Africa. Finally, to capture real-time developments and specific case studies of "VIP" inmate privileges, the analysis incorporated investigative media reports from reputable national outlets such as Premium Times, The Guardian, and Channels TV. These sources were selected based on their relevance, credibility, and recent publication dates (2015–2024).

**Discussion of Major Findings**

This section presents and discusses the major findings of the study based entirely on the review and analysis of secondary data sources such as government reports, legal statutes, human rights assessments, and peer-reviewed academic literature. The discussion is structured around major themes derived from the research objectives and literature, interpreted through the lens of Structural Conflict Theory.

**Unequal Access to Bail and Legal Representation**

Secondary data reveal that access to bail and quality legal representation in Nigeria is highly unequal and primarily influenced by socio-economic status. Numerous reports, including those from the Prisoners' Rights Advocacy Initiative (PRAI, 2022), indicate that thousands of indigent detainees are held in prolonged pre-trial detention simply because they cannot afford bail or competent legal representation. The legal provisions in the Administration of Criminal Justice Act (ACJA) 2015 are designed to safeguard the rights of all defendants, but in practice, implementation is inconsistent and often ineffective for the poor.

In contrast, affluent individuals and politically connected suspects often gain prompt bail through influential networks, high-ranking legal representation, or favorable judicial discretion. Amnesty International (2022) and Human Rights Watch (2023) have documented several cases where wealthy or prominent individuals accused of serious offenses were granted bail within a few days, while those accused of petty theft or non-violent crimes remained in detention for years. These disparities support the assumptions of Structural Conflict Theory, which argues that the law is selectively applied in ways that protect elite interests and repress marginalized groups.

A consistent pattern observed in the responses is the disparity in the ability of inmates to access bail. Wealthier or politically connected detainees often secured bail within days, facilitated by top-tier lawyers or direct intervention from influential figures. In contrast, poor detainees languished in custody due to their inability to meet stringent bail conditions or afford legal representation. A Correctional Officer in Makurdi noted:

> "A well-connected inmate in Makurdi left within 48 hours. Meanwhile, another inmate arrested on the same charge is still here after six months." (Correctional Officer, Makurdi)

This finding reflects the conclusions of Reiman and Leighton (2017), who argued that criminal justice systems tend to treat the wealthy more leniently. In the Nigerian context, Ajomo and Okagbue (1991) also highlighted this issue. This theme aligns with the first objective of the study: to identify patterns of preferential treatment of inmates. It further supports Conflict Theory by revealing how access to legal freedom is stratified along economic lines.

**Preferential Prison Conditions for the Elite**

Another significant finding pertains to the glaring inequalities in prison conditions. Reports from Transparency International (2022), the Nigerian Correctional Service (2021), and investigative journalism indicate that wealthy or high-profile inmates are often accorded special privileges, including access to private or well-ventilated cells, superior meals, medical care, and even telecommunication gadgets. These “VIP cells” are segregated from the general prison population and shield privileged inmates from the overcrowded and unsanitary conditions that ordinary prisoners endure.

Conversely, the average inmate, typically poor and without political backing, is subjected to dehumanizing conditions, such as severe overcrowding, limited access to food, poor sanitation, and inadequate medical care. The differential treatment of inmates according to their social class reaffirms the relevance of Structural Conflict Theory, particularly the notion that criminal justice systems are constructed to serve and protect the interests of dominant social classes.

**Disparities in Sentencing and Legal Outcomes**

Disparities in sentencing outcomes between the elite and the underprivileged are another critical area of concern. Evidence from judicial case reviews and legal commentaries (Okeke & Onuoha, 2021; PRAI, 2022) shows that wealthy individuals, especially those charged with white-collar crimes such as fraud or embezzlement, often negotiate plea bargains, receive suspended sentences, or pay fines in lieu of imprisonment. In contrast, poor defendants, even

those convicted of minor property crimes or misdemeanors, are frequently subjected to custodial sentences without the opportunity for alternative sanctions.

These unequal outcomes reveal a justice system where punishment is not based solely on the gravity of the offense but is also influenced by the socio-economic standing of the defendant. Such a system contradicts the principle of equality before the law and aligns with Reiman and Leighton's (2020) assertion that the criminal justice system functions to selectively punish the powerless while shielding the powerful.

**Delays in Legal Proceedings and Selective Prosecution**

The problem of judicial delays disproportionately affects poor defendants. Data from the Nigerian Bar Association (NBA, 2021) and legal analysts point to a trend where cases involving elites are strategically delayed through adjournments, appeals, and technicalities. Powerful individuals can afford high-ranking lawyers who manipulate legal procedures to stall trials indefinitely, often leading to the eventual collapse of cases.

Meanwhile, the poor are hurried through the justice system without adequate representation or the benefit of procedural safeguards. The use of prolonged adjournments and procedural technicalities for elites results in selective prosecution, contributing to a pattern of legal impunity for powerful offenders. This selective use of legal procedures supports the structural conflict view that legal institutions can be manipulated to preserve class privilege and systemic inequality.

Amnesty International (2022) corroborates this issue, noting that 70% of Nigerian inmates are awaiting trial, with the majority being from impoverished backgrounds. The theme ties directly to the third objective: to analyze the impact of preferential treatment on justice delivery. Delayed justice deepens inequality, criminalizes poverty, and reduces faith in legal institutions.

**Public Perception and Institutional Legitimacy**

Widespread public perception reinforces the reality of class-based discrimination within the justice system. Surveys conducted by the CLEEN Foundation (2022) and Afrobarometer (2023) indicate that a large proportion of Nigerians believe that the criminal justice system disproportionately targets the poor while allowing the rich to escape accountability. This public sentiment is reinforced by media coverage of high-profile corruption cases where well-connected individuals often walk free despite overwhelming evidence.

Such perceptions contribute to a deep erosion of trust in legal institutions. Citizens increasingly view the justice system not as a means of resolving disputes fairly but as an instrument of elite protection. This erosion of trust undermines the legitimacy of the criminal

justice system and contributes to the growing preference for informal justice mechanisms, which are themselves often violent and extrajudicial.

The decline in institutional legitimacy and rising public frustration confirm Tyler's (2006) procedural justice theory, which posits that public support for the law depends largely on the perceived fairness of legal processes. When preferential treatment is evident, the justice system loses credibility, reinforcing cynicism, resentment, and lawlessness.

The findings reveal a consistent pattern of systemic bias in the criminal justice system, favoring wealthy and influential individuals while criminalizing poverty. From the point of arrest and bail hearings to sentencing and prison conditions, disparities in treatment are closely linked to social class, political affiliation, and financial power. This pattern is not accidental but structurally embedded in institutional practices, legislative loopholes, and cultural attitudes that valorize power and wealth.

The application of Structural Conflict Theory has been particularly useful in interpreting these findings. The theory emphasizes that legal systems in capitalist societies are structured to maintain the dominance of ruling classes by criminalizing the behaviors of the underprivileged. In the Nigerian context, preferential treatment in criminal justice processes is a manifestation of this broader structural inequality.

**Causes of Preferential Treatment**

The prevalence of preferential treatment in Nigeria's criminal justice system is driven by a confluence of socio-political, economic, and institutional factors. These causes include:

**Corruption:**

Corruption remains a central challenge in Nigeria's criminal justice landscape. Bribes are frequently exchanged to influence police investigations, secure bail, or obtain favorable court decisions. Wealthy individuals and political actors often manipulate the system by financially incentivizing judicial and correctional officials to receive lenient treatment or expedited processing. According to Amnesty International (2022), high-profile detainees often evade legal consequences through bribery and behind-the-scenes negotiations.

**Institutional Weakness:**

The justice sector suffers from chronic underfunding, inadequate staffing, and outdated infrastructure. Correctional institutions lack sufficient mechanisms for transparency and accountability, making it easier for officials to extend privileges to certain inmates. The National Human Rights Commission (2022) highlights the absence of independent inspection

bodies as a barrier to uniform standards of inmate treatment. Additionally, weak internal checks within the judiciary and correctional system further exacerbate discriminatory practices.

**Societal Stratification:**

Nigeria's deeply hierarchical social structure contributes to unequal justice. The wealthy and politically connected are often treated with deference, both within and outside the courtroom. Cultural norms that revere status and affluence reinforce the notion that elites are entitled to different treatment. As Oloyede (2019) explains, such societal attitudes not only influence judicial behavior but also justify the marginalization of economically disadvantaged offenders.

**Legislative Gaps and Inconsistent Implementation:**

While progressive laws like the Administration of Criminal Justice Act (ACJA) 2015 aim to reduce arbitrariness and protect the rights of detainees, their implementation has been uneven across states. Legal practitioners often exploit ambiguities in the law to favor their elite clients. Ugwueze and Onuoha (2023) note that the lack of strict enforcement and the manipulation of procedural technicalities have undermined the egalitarian intentions of the ACJA.

**Political Patronage and Executive Interference:**

The influence of political actors on judicial processes is another major factor. Politically exposed persons (PEPs) often leverage their connections to secure bail, delay prosecution, or obtain special prison privileges. The politicization of judicial appointments and case assignments further entrenches bias and inhibits judicial independence.

**Implications of Preferential Treatment**

Preferential treatment in the Nigerian criminal justice system carries profound implications for justice delivery, societal equity, and democratic governance:

**Erosion of Public Trust:**

When justice appears to be for sale or influenced by connections, public faith in the legal system erodes. This disillusionment weakens civic engagement and may lead to increased reliance on vigilante justice. Transparency International (2021) found that over 70% of Nigerians believe the justice system disproportionately favors the wealthy.

**Overcrowding of Prisons:**

The inability of indigent detainees to meet bail conditions or secure timely legal aid leads to long-term pre-trial detention. In contrast, affluent suspects quickly regain freedom, exacerbating inequality. According to Human Rights Watch (2023), approximately 70% of Nigeria's prison population consists of awaiting trial inmates, most of whom are poor.

**Undermining Rule of Law and Legal Equality:**

Selective justice undermines the principle of legal equality, a cornerstone of democratic societies. When laws are applied unevenly, the integrity and legitimacy of the judiciary come into question, potentially destabilizing the legal order (Reiman & Leighton, 2020).

**Normalization of Impunity and Criminality:**

Preferential treatment reinforces a dangerous norm where those with power feel insulated from consequences. This normalization of impunity incentivizes repeated offenses and breeds public resentment. Quinney (1974) argued that such systemic bias perpetuates crime by reinforcing class inequalities.

**Stifling of Reform Efforts:**

Efforts to reform Nigeria's criminal justice system face resistance when elites benefit from the status quo. Preferential treatment can sabotage reform policies by reducing pressure for change from those who wield influence.

**Conclusion**

The Nigerian criminal justice system exhibits entrenched patterns of preferential treatment driven by class-based inequalities and institutional weaknesses. The existing justice framework, though equipped with progressive legislation, fails to serve the majority equitably. The elite manipulate the system to their advantage, while poor inmates are subjected to injustice and neglect. This perpetuates public distrust, social tension, and institutional decay. The research confirms that preferential treatment of inmates is a deeply entrenched problem in Nigeria's criminal justice system, perpetuated by wealth, political influence, and institutional weaknesses. From global observations to the local context of Benue and Nasarawa States, disparities in justice delivery remain stark. While some inmates enjoy a privileged status with access to medical care, better food, and legal reprieve, the indigent majority endure subhuman conditions and legal neglect. Unless holistic reforms are enacted anchored in transparency, accountability, and inclusiveness the Nigerian justice

system will continue to favor the powerful and disenfranchise the poor, eroding societal trust and democratic values.

**Recommendations**

i. To dismantle the "VIP System" and the hidden patterns of comfort, the Nigerian Correctional Service must move beyond manual, paper-based logs which are easily manipulated, but implement a National Inmate Biometric Tracking System (NIBTS), where the system should digitally log every inmate's cell assignment, medical referral, and visitation frequency in real-time. By making inmate data accessible to an independent central oversight body, the "shadow hierarchy" of VIP cells becomes visible and auditable, making it harder for facility heads to grant unauthorized privileges without detection.

ii. The government should establish a Correctional Trust Fund to be managed by an independent board of trustees, specifically dedicated to facility maintenance and staff welfare in the North-Central region. This will ensure that correctional centers are adequately funded through official channels, the "Big Man" syndrome is neutralized.

iii. There should be full operationalization of Section 34 of the ACJA 2015, which requires Chief Magistrates to conduct monthly inspections of detention centers, but with a new "Equity Clause" that mandates the immediate provisional release of any indigent inmate held longer than 30 days for a bailable offense. This addresses the "Deterrence Erosion" and "Public Confidence" issues.

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# EVALUATING THE ROLE OF TRADITIONAL AND RELIGIOUS LEADERSHIP IN PROMOTING PEACE IN TARABA STATE: AN IMPACT ASSESSMENT

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**Abstract.** This study provides an in-depth assessment of the role of traditional and religious leadership in promoting peace in Taraba State, a region marked by cultural diversity, religious plurality, and persistent communal tensions. Traditional leaders including chiefs, district heads, and clan heads serve as custodians of indigenous norms, mediators in local disputes, and stabilizing forces in community governance. Religious leaders, on the other hand, offer moral guidance, spiritual direction, and ethical frameworks rooted in Christianity, Islam, and African Traditional Religions. This study adopts a qualitative research approach, which is appropriate for examining social institutions, cultural practices, and conflict dynamics. The research is descriptive and analytical, focusing on understanding the roles, structures, and challenges of traditional and religious leadership in peacebuilding. Qualitative research enables an in-depth exploration of social realities and provides rich insights into the functioning of indigenous institutions, the study explores how these institutions individually and collectively contribute to conflict prevention, early warning systems, mediation, reconciliation, and peace education in the state. Findings reveal that the synergy between traditional and religious institutions fosters stronger community engagement, enhances moral persuasion in conflict resolution, and reinforces social cohesion across multi-ethnic areas such as Jalingo, Wukari, Takum, and Sardauna. However, the study also identifies significant challenges, including political interference, resource limitations, inter-group mistrust, and the increasing complexity of farmer–herder conflicts. The paper concludes that enhancing institutional collaboration, strengthening peacebuilding capacity, promoting interfaith dialogue, and reducing political manipulation will significantly improve the effectiveness of traditional and religious leaders in sustaining long-term peace and stability in Taraba State.

**Keywords:** Traditional leadership, religious leadership, peace promotion, conflict resolution, mediation, social cohesion, interfaith dialogue and peacebuilding.

## Introduction

Peacebuilding in contemporary African societies remains a critical concern due to persistent ethnic tensions, political instability, inter-communal violence, and religious conflicts. In Nigeria, particularly in the Middle Belt region, issues such as land disputes, farmer–herder clashes, ethno-religious hostilities, and political marginalization have created an environment where sustainable peace is difficult to achieve (Adebayo, 2020). Taraba State, known for its cultural plurality and diverse religious composition, has witnessed several conflict episodes,

especially in areas like Wukari, Takum, Gassol, and Bali. These conflicts often stem from competition over resources, historical grievances, and identity politics (Bawa & Nwogu, 2019). Consequently, the quest for peace has necessitated the involvement of indigenous systems of authority, particularly traditional and religious leaders.

Traditional leadership in Nigeria has historically served as custodians of culture, mediators in communal disputes, and stabilizing agents in collective decision-making (Olayinka & Yusuf, 2018). Even though the modern state has formal institutions for conflict resolution, traditional rulers such as chiefs, emirs, and clan heads continue to wield significant influence at the community level. Their authority is rooted in cultural legitimacy, proximity to the grassroots, and long-standing mechanisms for dialogue and reconciliation. In Taraba State, traditional rulers such as the Aku Uka of Wukari, the Ukwe Takum, and various local chiefs play indispensable roles in managing tensions, negotiating ceasefires, and facilitating inter-group dialogue.

Similarly, religious leaders have emerged as vital actors in peace promotion due to their moral authority, influence over followers, and capacity to shape public opinion (Ibrahim, 2021). Christianity and Islam coexist alongside African Traditional Religion in Taraba State, and religious leaders often mediate conflicts, preach tolerance, and engage in interfaith collaborations aimed at fostering harmony. Organizations such as the Christian Association of Nigeria (CAN) and the Jama'atu Nasril Islam (JNI) have been pivotal in mitigating violence and promoting interreligious engagement during periods of heightened tension.

Despite these contributions, the effectiveness of traditional and religious leadership in sustaining peace remains underexplored. Some scholars argue that the changing socio-political landscape, youth militancy, political interference, and erosion of traditional institutions may limit their peacebuilding capacity (Eze & Onah, 2022). Others highlight that religious leaders sometimes struggle with internal divisions or politicized interpretations of doctrine that undermine peace efforts (Chukwu, 2020). Therefore, assessing the impact of these leadership structures is essential for understanding their contemporary relevance and identifying strategies for strengthening their roles.

Given the unique cultural diversity and history of conflict in Taraba State, evaluating the contributions, challenges, and impact of traditional and religious leaders is crucial for enhancing community-driven peacebuilding initiatives. This study seeks to fill the research gap by providing an empirical assessment of their roles, strategies, limitations, and overall influence on peace and cohesion within the State.

## Structure and Functionality of Traditional and Religious Leadership

Traditional leadership in Taraba State operates within a hierarchical structure that reflects long-standing cultural organization and governance systems. At the apex are paramount rulers who exercise authority over extensive territories, followed by district heads, village heads, and clan leaders who administer smaller community units. This structure ensures that governance is decentralized and that conflict resolution mechanisms are accessible to the grassroots. The functionality of traditional leadership is deeply rooted in customary laws and indigenous knowledge systems, which regulate social relations, land ownership, and communal responsibilities. As noted by Ubink (2018), traditional authorities continue to play vital roles in governance across Africa due to their legitimacy and embeddedness in local culture.

Religious leadership, in contrast, is structured along doctrinal and organizational lines. In Christianity, leadership is organized through hierarchical systems involving pastors, bishops, and denominational authorities, while in Islam authority is exercised by imams, scholars, and emirs. African Traditional Religion also maintains spiritual custodians who oversee rituals and moral order. Religious leaders function primarily through moral instruction, spiritual guidance, and social influence, shaping the attitudes and behaviours of their followers (Ibrahim & Mukhtar, 2021).

The interaction between these structures creates a complementary system in which cultural authority and moral legitimacy reinforce each other. This synergy enhances the effectiveness of conflict resolution by addressing both the social and ethical dimensions of disputes, thereby promoting sustainable peace (Ajayi & Ojo, 2020).

## Importance of Local Chiefs and Religious Leaders in Conflict Resolution

The findings of this study indicate that local chiefs and religious leaders are indispensable actors in conflict resolution in Taraba State due to their grassroots legitimacy and accessibility. Traditional leaders are often the first point of intervention in disputes because they are embedded within the community and possess deep knowledge of local histories and customs. Their mediation processes emphasize reconciliation, restoration, and communal harmony rather than punitive justice, which aligns with indigenous African conflict resolution systems (Eze & Onah, 2022).

Religious leaders complement these efforts by providing moral and spiritual frameworks that encourage forgiveness, tolerance, and peaceful coexistence. Through sermons, counseling, and interfaith engagements, they shape public attitudes and discourage violence. Studies have shown that faith-based interventions play a significant role in reducing tensions and fostering dialogue in multi-religious societies (Appleby, 2020; Chukwu, 2020).

Furthermore, both traditional and religious leaders function as early warning agents due to their close interaction with community members. They are able to detect emerging tensions and intervene before conflicts escalate into violence. Their ability to mobilize communities for peace campaigns, reconciliation meetings, and dialogue platforms significantly enhances social cohesion and stability (Adebayo, 2020).

**Constitutional Challenges**

Despite their critical roles, traditional leaders in Nigeria operate within a constitutional framework that does not explicitly recognize or define their functions in governance and conflict resolution. The Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria provides for democratic institutions but remains largely silent on the formal roles of traditional authorities. This omission creates ambiguity regarding their legal status and limits their participation in formal governance processes (Ojo, 2019).

The lack of constitutional recognition also exposes traditional institutions to political interference, as state governments often control their appointment and removal. This undermines their independence and weakens their credibility in conflict mediation. Furthermore, the absence of a clear legal framework for integrating traditional and religious leaders into national peacebuilding strategies limits their effectiveness (Okeke & Eme, 2020). These challenges highlight the need for constitutional and policy reforms to strengthen indigenous governance systems.

**Appointment of Local Chiefs**

The appointment of local chiefs in Taraba State reflects a combination of traditional customs and modern political processes. Traditionally, chiefs are selected based on hereditary lineage, rotational systems among ruling families, and the consensus of kingmakers or traditional councils. These processes are guided by customary laws that ensure legitimacy and acceptance within the community (Ubink, 2018).

In contemporary practice, however, state governments play a significant role in formalizing appointments through official recognition and the issuance of staff of office. While this system aims to regulate traditional institutions, it has also introduced challenges such as politicization, imposition of candidates, and disputes over legitimacy. As noted by Olaniyi (2019), political interference in traditional leadership selection has weakened the authority of chiefs and contributed to conflicts within communities. Balancing traditional selection methods with modern governance requirements remains essential for preserving the integrity and effectiveness of traditional leadership in conflict resolution.

**Traditional Leadership and Peace Promotion**

Traditional leadership remains one of the most enduring institutions for peacebuilding in African communities. In Taraba State, traditional rulers serve as custodians of culture, mediators of disputes, and symbols of unity among diverse ethnic groups. Their long-standing authority and grassroots legitimacy make them central actors in preventing, managing, and resolving conflicts. As modern state institutions often struggle to address deep-rooted communal tensions, traditional rulers continue to play a vital role in sustaining social stability and fostering peaceful coexistence (Olayinka & Yusuf, 2018).

Traditional leaders carry the responsibility of safeguarding cultural norms, values, and customary laws that regulate social behaviour within their communities. Their authority is derived from generations of cultural continuity, making them seen as fathers of the land and protectors of communal identity. In Taraba State, rulers such as the Aku Uka of Wukari, the Ukwe Takum, and several district heads provide moral guidance and leadership grounded in indigenous customs. These customary structures are crucial for resolving conflicts tied to land ownership, inheritance, and inter-group relations issues that frequently fuel violence in many communities (Bawa & Nwogu, 2019).

One of the most significant peace roles of traditional leaders is conflict mediation. Their involvement is often sought before government authorities intervene, especially in rural communities. Through dialogue, arbitration, and collective negotiation, traditional rulers help conflicting parties reach mutually acceptable solutions. Their conflict-resolution strategies emphasize reconciliation, social harmony, and restoration of relationships principles that differ from the punitive approaches of formal courts. Studies indicate that interventions by traditional councils have contributed significantly to de-escalating conflicts in regions prone to ethno-communal violence (Eze & Onah, 2022).

Traditional institutions function as informal early warning systems because of their close relationship with grassroots communities. Traditional rulers are able to sense rising tensions, detect grievances, and anticipate violent outbreaks through everyday interactions with community members. When potential conflicts are identified early, leaders can mobilize elders, youth leaders, and women groups to intervene promptly. In contexts like Taraba State, this early warning role is crucial for preventing local disputes from escalating into wider regional conflicts (Adebayo, 2020).

Beyond mediation, traditional rulers mobilize communities for peace campaigns, sensitization meetings, and inter-group dialogues. Their influence enables them to convene large gatherings where messages of unity, tolerance, and peaceful coexistence are disseminated. These platforms foster trust between ethnic groups and encourage citizens to reject violence. Traditional festivals, cultural ceremonies, and communal events are also used as opportunities to rebuild social cohesion after periods of conflict (Ibrahim, 2021). Such

efforts greatly contribute to peace and reconciliation, especially in areas recovering from ethnic or religious tensions.

**Challenges Facing Traditional Leaders**

Despite their centrality in peacebuilding, traditional leaders face numerous challenges that undermine their effectiveness. Modern political structures often interfere with traditional authority, creating legitimacy crises when leaders are imposed or influenced by political elites. The rise of youth militancy, proliferation of small arms, and the spread of extremist ideologies have weakened the influence of traditional councils in conflict-prone areas. Distrust among communities especially when rulers are perceived as favouring one ethnic group, also affects their ability to mediate disputes impartially (Chukwu, 2020). Moreover, insufficient government support and lack of formal integration of traditional institutions into peace frameworks limit their operational capacity.

**The Continued Relevance of Traditional Leadership**

Despite these limitations, traditional leadership remains a vital component of peacebuilding. The enduring influence of traditional rulers, their understanding of local dynamics, and their ability to mobilize cultural resources underscore their importance in promoting sustainable peace. Strengthening their roles through policy support, capacity-building programs, and improved collaboration with government agencies would enhance their impact. In a culturally diverse state like Taraba, traditional leadership provides a foundation for social harmony, inter-ethnic cooperation, and long-term community peacebuilding (Olayinka & Yusuf, 2018).

**Religious Leadership and Peace Promotion**

Religious leadership plays a fundamental role in shaping values, attitudes, and social behaviour in many African societies. In Taraba State, where Christianity, Islam, and African Traditional Religion coexist, religious leaders have significant influence over community members and often mediate crises, promote coexistence, and contribute to stability. Their authority is grounded not only in spiritual mandates but also in their moral credibility and social responsibility. As a result, religious leaders remain critical actors in both preventing and transforming conflict in the region (Ibrahim, 2021).

**Moral and Spiritual Influence in Peacebuilding**

Religious leaders promote peace primarily through moral and spiritual teachings that emphasize forgiveness, tolerance, justice, and reconciliation. Churches, mosques, and traditional religious institutions often serve as platforms for spreading messages on peaceful coexistence. Sermons, prayer sessions, and spiritual counseling help shape community attitudes, reduce fear, and discourage violence. In Taraba State, leaders from both Christian

and Islamic communities have used their pulpits to condemn hostility and encourage dialogue among their followers, especially during periods of tension (Chukwu, 2020). Through these moral appeals, religious leaders counteract hateful narratives and promote unity among diverse groups.

**Interfaith Dialogue and Cooperation**

Interfaith collaboration has become an essential peacebuilding strategy in multi-religious regions such as Taraba State. Bodies like the Christian Association of Nigeria (CAN), Jama'atu Nasril Islam (JNI), and various interfaith councils frequently engage in joint peace initiatives. These include peace marches, interfaith conferences, prayer meetings, and advocacy campaigns against extremism. Such collaboration not only encourages mutual understanding but also reduces suspicion and fear between Christian and Muslim communities. Effective interfaith dialogue fosters cooperation, enhances trust, and helps manage sensitive issues that could otherwise escalate into conflict (Adebayo, 2020).

**Mediation and Conflict Transformation**

Religious leaders often act as mediators in conflict situations, leveraging their respected social positions to intervene in disputes. Their roles include facilitating dialogue between conflicting groups, counseling victims and perpetrators, and helping restore broken relationships. They have been instrumental in resolving issues related to resource access, land disputes, political tensions, and inter-group violence. Through their involvement in peace committees and reconciliation forums, religious leaders emphasize non-violence, justice, and social harmony. Their ability to bring moral weight into negotiations often encourages conflicting parties to commit to peace agreements (Bawa & Nwogu, 2019).

**Humanitarian and Social Support Roles**

Beyond spiritual guidance and mediation, religious institutions provide essential humanitarian support during and after conflicts. Churches, mosques, and faith-based organizations distribute relief materials, shelter displaced persons, provide trauma counseling, and support reintegration efforts for affected individuals. These acts of compassion help reduce the suffering associated with conflict and contribute to rebuilding trust and social cohesion. Religious organizations in Taraba State have also supported community development initiatives such as education, health outreach, and poverty alleviation which indirectly reduce vulnerabilities that fuel conflict (Olayinka & Yusuf, 2018).

**Challenges Facing Religious Leaders in Peace Promotion**

Despite their critical role, religious leaders encounter various challenges in promoting peace. Doctrinal differences and denominational rivalries sometimes weaken collaboration between religious groups. Political interference also affects their neutrality, as some leaders are perceived as aligning with political elites or ethnic factions. Additionally, extremist preaching by a minority of clerics can heighten tensions and undermine peace efforts. Lack of professional training in conflict resolution further limits the effectiveness of some religious interventions (Eze & Onah, 2022). These challenges highlight the need for continuous capacity building and the strengthening of interfaith mechanisms.

**The Continued Relevance of Religious Leadership**

Despite these constraints, religious leaders remain indispensable in peacebuilding processes. Their moral authority, social influence, and spiritual mandate position them uniquely to guide communities toward forgiveness, reconciliation, and non-violence. Strengthening interfaith cooperation, enhancing conflict-resolution training, and supporting faith-based peace initiatives will further improve their effectiveness. In a diverse state like Taraba, religious leadership continues to serve as a vital pillar for establishing and sustaining peace.

**Relationship Between Traditional and Religious Institutions**

The interaction between traditional leadership and religious leadership in promoting peace in Taraba State demonstrates a complementary relationship that strengthens conflict resolution mechanisms and enhances communal harmony. Traditional rulers in the state such as clan heads, district heads, and paramount chiefs serve as custodians of indigenous norms and cultural values, while religious leaders provide moral guidance, spiritual instruction, and ethical frameworks rooted in faith traditions. When both institutions collaborate, they create a powerful synergy that supports stable, peaceful coexistence among diverse groups.

One major area of synergy is joint mediation and conflict resolution. In many communities across Taraba State, conflicts related to land disputes, communal clashes, and farmer–herder crises often require the involvement of both traditional and religious authorities. Traditional leaders provide historical context and customary laws that guide communal relations, while religious leaders bring moral persuasion, scriptural teachings, and mediation skills that appeal to conscience and social responsibility (Ibrahim & Mukhtar, 2021). This combination enhances credibility and increases acceptance of peace agreements among community members.

Another significant area of synergy is seen in community sensitization and peace education. Both institutions often participate in peace campaigns, interfaith dialogues, and community awareness programmes aimed at fostering tolerance and mutual understanding. Their joint

presence sends a strong message of unity, demonstrating that despite differences in roles, both institutions are committed to peacebuilding. Such collaborative efforts reduce suspicion between ethnic and religious groups, particularly in heterogeneous communities like Jalingo, Wukari, and Takum (Ajayi & Ojo, 2020).

Furthermore, the synergy extends to policy support and governance collaboration. Traditional and religious leaders frequently engage with state authorities, NGOs, and security agencies to develop strategies for mitigating conflict and promoting community cohesion. Their joint advocacy strengthens policy interventions and ensures that programmes reflect local realities and cultural sensitivities. This partnership also enhances early warning and early response systems, as both institutions often have firsthand knowledge of tensions or emerging threats at the grassroots level (Egwu, 2016).

In addition, the synergy between the two institutions helps rebuild trust in communities recovering from conflict. Through joint peace ceremonies, interfaith prayers, reconciliation meetings, and cultural events, traditional and religious leaders work together to restore broken relationships and promote healing. Their shared influence reinforces the legitimacy of reconciliation efforts, making community members more willing to forgive, reconcile, and reintegrate displaced persons (Umaru & Kwabe, 2019).

The relationship between traditional and religious institutions in Taraba State strengthens peacebuilding processes and creates a holistic framework for conflict management. Their collaboration enhances resilience, promotes tolerance, and supports sustainable peace across diverse communities. The fusion of cultural authority and spiritual legitimacy provides a unique and effective mechanism for addressing both the structural and emotional dimensions of conflict within the state.

**Importance of Assessing Their Impact**

Evaluating the role and impact of traditional and religious leadership in promoting peace is essential for strengthening community-based peacebuilding strategies. Such an assessment helps determine which interventions have been most effective, identifies existing gaps, and guides policymakers in integrating indigenous leadership structures into formal conflict management systems. It also provides insights into how traditional and religious leaders can be empowered through training, government collaboration, and institutional support. Understanding their impact contributes not only to academic knowledge but also to practical peacebuilding strategies aimed at sustainable development, security enhancement, and social harmony in Taraba State.

## Conclusion

Traditional and religious leaders are central to the peace architecture of Taraba State due to their deep-rooted authority, cultural influence, moral credibility, and grassroots connections. Their roles in mediation, dialogue facilitation, moral guidance, and humanitarian support significantly contribute to mitigating conflicts and promoting peaceful coexistence. Although they face challenges related to modern political dynamics, institutional weaknesses, and social change, these leaders remain indispensable in community-driven peacebuilding. Strengthening their structures and enhancing collaboration with government bodies and civil society will help promote lasting peace and development across Taraba State. Traditional and religious leadership play a central role in fostering peace, stability, and social cohesion in Taraba State. Traditional rulers serve as custodians of cultural norms, arbiters in communal disputes, and key actors in grassroots governance, while religious leaders contribute moral guidance, spiritual direction, and ethical frameworks that shape community behaviour. Their combined influence is crucial in preventing conflicts, mediating disputes, and promoting reconciliation in ethnically and religiously diverse communities. The synergy between traditional and religious institutions enhances peacebuilding processes by integrating cultural authority, moral legitimacy, and local knowledge into conflict management strategies. Despite existing challenges such as political interference, resource constraints, and the complexity of identity-based conflicts the cooperative engagement of these institutions remains indispensable for sustainable peace in Taraba State.

## Recommendations

i. Government and civil society organizations should establish and support formal platforms where traditional and religious leaders can regularly meet, share information, and coordinate peace initiatives. Such platforms can enhance early warning and early response mechanisms across communities.

ii. Both traditional and religious leaders should receive continuous training in modern conflict resolution techniques, mediation skills, and peacebuilding strategies. This will equip them to manage emerging conflicts more effectively, especially those linked to land use, farmer–herder relations, and political competition.

iii. Regular community dialogues involving Christians, Muslims, and practitioners of traditional religions should be encouraged to foster understanding, reduce stereotypes, and strengthen inter-group trust. Leaders from both institutions should champion these dialogues.

iv. The government should respect the autonomy of traditional and religious institutions, avoiding undue political manipulation that undermines their authority and neutrality. Policies should be developed to protect these institutions from politicization.

v. Joint sensitization campaigns by traditional and religious leaders should be intensified to educate community members on peaceful coexistence, tolerance, and the dangers of violence. Using local languages and culturally relevant messages can increase impact.

vi. Government, NGOs, and development partners should invest in community-level peace programmes that involve traditional councils, faith-based organizations, and youth groups. These initiatives should include peace clubs, local mediation centers, and cultural exchange programmes.

vii. State authorities should integrate the roles of traditional and religious leaders into broader peace and security policies. Clear guidelines on collaboration between local leaders, security agencies, and government officials will help streamline conflict prevention efforts.

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# WESTERN EDUCATION AND PEACEFUL COEXISTENCE IN TARABA STATE: A STUDY OF COMMUNITIES IN SOUTHERN SENATORIAL DISTRICT

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**Abstract.** Western education in Nigeria is widely regarded as a legacy of the colonial era, yet it continues to shape social, cultural, and political life across the country, including in Taraba State. At the same time, both Nigeria and Taraba State have faced recurring challenges to peace, with different communities experiencing conflict and coexistence in diverse ways. Although existing literature discusses peaceful co-existence broadly, limited scholarly attention has been given to how Western education influences peaceful relations among communities in Taraba State. Even more scarce are studies focusing on communities in the Southern Senatorial District of the state. This research seeks to address this gap by examining the impact of Western education on peaceful coexistence, or the lack thereof, among communities in southern Taraba, thereby contributing to a deeper understanding of education's role in fostering community harmony.

**Keywords:** Western education, Traditional leadership, religious leadership, peace promotion, conflict resolution, mediation, social cohesion, interfaith dialogue and peacebuilding.

## Introduction

Education is widely recognized as a foundational element in nation-building and societal development. It equips individuals with the knowledge, values, and skills necessary for personal growth and collective progress. In Nigeria, Western education, introduced during the colonial era, has played a central role in shaping political institutions, social interactions, and community relations. Despite its significance, the Nigerian educational system continues to face numerous challenges, including inadequate funding, policy inconsistencies, manpower shortages, strikes, and leadership gaps (Ada, 2020; Chile, 2019). These issues undermine the capacity of Western education to deliver on its potential and to effectively contribute to national stability and cohesion. Yet, education remains a powerful tool for promoting understanding, tolerance, and peaceful coexistence. As Pascal (2019) notes, education fosters consciousness and knowledge that help build united and harmonious societies. In contexts where communities experience ethnic, cultural, and religious diversity,such as Taraba State, education can serve not only as a mechanism for empowerment but also as a medium for conflict prevention and social integration.

Taraba State, particularly the Southern Senatorial District, is characterized by rich ethnic pluralism, which has historically produced both cooperation and conflict. While various studies have examined the challenges confronting Nigeria's educational sector, limited attention has been given to how Western education influences peaceful coexistence among communities in this region. Understanding the relationship between education and community harmony is therefore critical, especially in an area that has experienced episodes of tension and competition. This study aims to explore the role of Western education in shaping attitudes, relationships, and patterns of peaceful coexistence among communities in Southern Taraba. By examining its influence within this unique sociocultural context, the research seeks to contribute to broader discussions on how education can catalyze peace, stability, and sustainable development in Nigeria.

**Conceptualising Education and Its Societal Role**

Education has long been regarded as a fundamental driver of societal transformation and national development. Scholars argue that education is not merely a process of acquiring knowledge, but also a mechanism for transmitting societal values, developing competencies, and fostering human capital (Duze, 2012; Ada, 2020). In many nations, the strength of educational institutions directly correlates with levels of economic development, political stability, and social cohesion. As a social institution, education is designed to reflect and reinforce the norms and aspirations of society, preparing individuals to contribute meaningfully to national growth.

Theoretical perspectives such as functionalism view education as a tool for integrating individuals into the larger social system through shared values and collective goals (Durkheim, 1893). In contemporary contexts, education plays a similar role by creating platforms for interaction among diverse groups. This is particularly important in multi-ethnic societies like Nigeria, where education can promote tolerance and understanding among groups that might otherwise be divided by cultural, religious, or linguistic differences.

Education also fosters the formation of civic values essential for peaceful coexistence. When properly delivered, it cultivates respect for human rights, appreciation of diversity, and recognition of shared national identity. Pascal (2019) emphasizes that effective education instills consciousness and social awareness necessary to build united and harmonious communities. Therefore, education is not only instrumental in individual empowerment but also in the collective construction of peaceful, stable societies.

Historical Context of Western Education in Nigeria

Western education was introduced in Nigeria during the nineteenth century through missionary activities, later formalized under colonial administration. The early missionaries focused on literacy, evangelism, and clerical training, while colonial authorities expanded its

scope to include administrative and vocational functions (Fafunwa, 2018). Over time, Western education became deeply woven into Nigeria's political and socio-economic structures, producing elites who would later spearhead nationalist movements and shape governance after independence.

However, scholars have critiqued Western education for its colonial origins, arguing that it disrupted indigenous systems of knowledge and replaced them with a foreign model that did not fully align with Nigeria's socio-cultural realities (Osokoya, 2009). Despite these criticisms, Western education remains the backbone of Nigeria's educational framework and continues to influence patterns of social mobility, political participation, and community relations.

In regions such as Taraba State, the introduction of Western education played a significant role in uniting diverse ethnic groups by creating shared spaces for learning and interaction. Schools became sites where individuals from different cultural backgrounds interacted, fostering understanding and reducing prejudices. As such, Western education contributed not only to literacy and empowerment but also to the promotion of peaceful coexistence.

**Challenges Facing Western Education in Nigeria**

Despite its transformative potential, Western education in Nigeria faces numerous challenges that undermine its effectiveness. These include poor funding, inadequate infrastructure, frequent industrial strikes, leadership gaps, and inconsistencies in policy implementation (Chile, 2019; Adeyemi & Uko-Aviomoh, 2017). These structural weaknesses limit the capacity of educational institutions to meet societal expectations and perform their integrative functions.

**Funding Constraints**

Education in Nigeria is chronically underfunded, with budgetary allocations falling below UNESCO's recommended 15–20% of national expenditure. Poor funding leads to dilapidated facilities, inadequate learning materials, and an inability to recruit and retain qualified teachers. These limitations directly affect the quality of education delivered and reduce the system's potential to shape peaceful, progressive communities.

**Policy and Leadership Issues**

The Nigerian educational sector is also plagued by unstable and inconsistent policies. Frequent changes in curricula, leadership turnover, and lack of long-term planning contribute to systemic inefficiency. According to Best (2018), genuine progress in education requires collaborative dialogue among stakeholders and a willingness to address institutional weaknesses.

**Manpower Shortages and Strikes**

Teacher shortages and poor welfare conditions trigger frequent industrial disputes, resulting in interruptions in the academic calendar. These disruptions weaken students' educational experience and diminish trust in the system. Chukes (2021) argues that the sustainability and success of education depend on commitment and collective responsibility among stakeholders.

**Education and Peaceful Coexistence**

A growing body of literature highlights the role of education in fostering peace, social stability, and conflict mitigation. Peace education theorists argue that learning environments can cultivate values such as tolerance, empathy, cooperation, and respect for diversity (Harris & Morrison, 2012). Educational institutions serve as platforms where individuals interact across ethnic, cultural, and religious divides, learning to negotiate differences and form shared identities. In the Nigerian context, education has been recognized as a key factor in promoting national unity. Policies such as the National Policy on Education emphasize the integrative function of schooling, including the use of a common curriculum, language policies, and school placement strategies designed to promote interaction among diverse populations (Federal Republic of Nigeria, 2013). Experiences from diverse classrooms expose students to different worldviews, helping reduce stereotypes and prejudice.

Furthermore, education enhances critical thinking, enabling individuals to challenge extremist ideologies and resist participation in violent conflicts. It also strengthens civic engagement by promoting awareness of rights, responsibilities, and mechanisms for peaceful dispute resolution. Thus, the relationship between education and peaceful coexistence is both direct, through value transmission, and indirect, through socio-economic empowerment.

**Western Education and Peaceful Coexistence in Northern and Middle-Belt Nigeria**

Studies across Northern and Middle-Belt Nigeria have shown mixed outcomes regarding the influence of Western education on community relations. In some areas, Western education has contributed to increased social mobility, improved communication, and reduced tensions among ethnic groups (Ochonu, 2014). Schools have also served as important sites for interethnic interaction, enabling students to develop friendships and networks that cross traditional boundaries.

However, other scholars contend that disparities in access to education have sometimes reinforced inequalities and tensions. Unequal distribution of educational resources, competition for employment opportunities, and perceptions of marginalization can exacerbate grievances among communities (Danladi, 2020). These contradictions suggest that while education has significant potential to promote peaceful coexistence, its impact is highly

context-dependent. In many Middle-Belt states, including Taraba, education has produced elite groups that mediate conflicts and participate in peacebuilding efforts. Educated individuals often engage in dialogue, advocate for inclusive governance, and serve as intermediaries in conflict resolution processes. Thus, Western education's influence on peace may extend beyond the classroom into broader community dynamics.

**Ethnic Diversity, Social Relations, and Peace in Taraba State**

Taraba State is one of Nigeria's most ethnically diverse states, with over fifty ethnic groups distributed across its northern, central, and southern regions. The Southern Senatorial District, in particular, is home to communities such as the Jukun, Kuteb, Ichen, Tiv, Chamba, Ndoro, and others. This diversity contributes to rich cultural traditions but has also historically produced tensions over land ownership, political representation, and resource distribution (Audu, 2015).

Literature on conflict dynamics in Taraba reveals a recurring pattern where competition over socio-political advantages escalates into communal clashes. Scholars have argued that weak communication channels, limited intergroup understanding, and historical grievances contribute to these tensions (Nwozor & Olanrewaju, 2019). In such a context, education can serve as a critical tool for bridging divides.

Western education creates shared spaces, schools, colleges, training centers, where individuals from diverse groups meet, interact, and build mutual understanding. It promotes the use of English as a lingua franca, which facilitates communication across ethnic boundaries. It also exposes learners to civic values that emphasize unity, cooperation, and peaceful coexistence. Nevertheless, empirical studies specifically linking Western education to peace in Southern Taraba remain limited. Most existing research focuses on conflict drivers rather than peace facilitators. This gap highlights the need for studies that examine how educational experiences shape intergroup relations and contribute to peacebuilding in the region.

**Gaps in the Literature**

Although substantial literature exists on education and national development, and on conflict dynamics in Nigeria, there is a notable gap in studies examining the intersection of Western education and peaceful coexistence in Taraba State, particularly within the Southern Senatorial District. Existing studies rarely explore how Western education shapes attitudes toward other groups, influences communication patterns, or contributes to conflict prevention and resolution at the community level. Furthermore, limited empirical research investigates the lived experiences of communities regarding the role of education in fostering peace. This gap is significant because local narratives, perceptions, and community-specific dynamics are crucial for understanding how education interacts with socio-cultural environments.

The literature reviewed shows that Western education has substantial potential to promote peaceful coexistence through value formation, social integration, and empowerment. However, structural challenges within Nigeria's educational system undermine its effectiveness. Taraba State's ethnic diversity presents both opportunities and challenges for peaceful coexistence, making education a potentially powerful, but underexplored, instrument for peace building. The limited scholarly focus on Southern Taraba creates a critical gap that this study seeks to fill by examining how Western education influences relationships, attitudes, and communal harmony in the region.

**Theoretical Framework**

Peace Education Theory is shaped significantly by the work of Johan Galtung and Betty Reardon, who together provide a comprehensive foundation for understanding how education can cultivate cultures of peace. Their approaches differ in emphasis, Galtung focuses on structural analysis and conflict transformation, while Reardon centers on human rights, gender, and global responsibility, but they converge on the belief that peace must be actively taught, practiced, and embedded in social systems.

Johan Galtung, widely regarded as the founder of peace studies, introduced several core ideas that underpin peace education. His distinction between negative peace, defined as the absence of direct, physical violence, and positive peace, characterized by the presence of social justice and equitable structures, is foundational. Galtung argues that violence is not limited to physical harm; it also exists in structural forms, such as poverty, discrimination, and political oppression, as well as in cultural patterns that legitimize or normalize inequality. Peace education, from this perspective, must help learners recognize these often invisible forms of harm so that they can work toward transforming them. He also views conflict as a natural and potentially constructive part of human relationships. Rather than seeking to eliminate conflict, peace education should promote the skills and attitudes necessary for conflict transformation, including dialogue, empathy, mediation, and nonviolent action. Ultimately, Galtung's work assumes that peace is a systemic condition, achievable only when individuals and institutions learn to dismantle oppressive structures and develop constructive, nonviolent ways to resolve differences.

Betty Reardon expands and complements this foundation through her emphasis on human rights, gender justice, and the development of a global consciousness. She argues that peace education is inherently a transformative, value-based practice aimed at challenging the systems and ideologies that sustain violence. For Reardon, patriarchy is a fundamental structure of violence, making gender equality an essential component of peace. Her feminist perspective highlights the ways in which militarism, domination, and hierarchy operate in both public and private life, and she maintains that peace education must empower learners, especially young people, to critically examine and change these patterns. Reardon also emphasizes human rights education as a crucial pillar of peace education, arguing that understanding universal rights and responsibilities fosters a shared ethical foundation for

peaceful coexistence. She sees learners as active agents who must develop skills in empathy, cooperation, and ethical reflection so they can participate in building more just and sustainable societies.

Galtung and Reardon articulate a vision of peace education that goes beyond teaching about peace as an abstract ideal. Their theories share several key assumptions: that peace is multidimensional, involving not only the absence of violence but also the presence of justice; that violence is intertwined with social, political, economic, and cultural structures; that conflict can be transformed through nonviolent means; and that education plays a central role in cultivating the critical consciousness, values, and skills required for building peaceful societies. Their combined contributions position peace education not just as a classroom subject, but as a holistic, lifelong process of developing individuals and communities capable of fostering both personal and structural peace.

**Western Education as a Catalyst for Peace**

Western education in southern Taraba State has played a meaningful role in promoting intergroup harmony and social cohesion. According to historical analyses, the introduction and expansion of Western schooling brought different ethnic groups into shared social spaces. Through schools, students from Jukun, Tiv, Chamba, Kuteb, Ichen, and other groups come together daily, interact, and learn side by side. This interaction fosters mutual understanding and breaks down parochial divides.

One of the most important peace-building functions of Western education in the region has been in promoting tolerance and inter-ethnic dialogue. As students learn to read, write, and engage in subjects like history, civics, and social studies, they acquire a broader worldview. Education encourages them to see beyond ethnic loyalties and recognize shared values. The common language of instruction, English, also acts as a unifying medium, enabling communication across linguistic divides.

Beyond cultural understanding, Western education has helped counteract inferiority complexes among marginalized groups. Historically, some of southern Taraba's ethnic communities may have internalized negative stereotypes or felt socially and economically disadvantaged. The introduction of Western education empowered many to overcome these feelings, gaining skills and confidence to advocate for their rights. Education also opened up opportunities for women, who might have been excluded from traditional roles: with schooling, girls in southern Taraba have greater access to knowledge, and this contributes to gender balance in social participation.

Politically, access to Western education has nurtured greater political consciousness in southern Taraba. Educated citizens are more likely to participate in local governance, ask for accountability, and engage in peaceful political processes. Historical studies report that

Western education introduced values of citizenship, leadership, hard work, and integrity. These civic values are critical in a region where ethnic and religious pluralism could otherwise become fault lines for tension.

Furthermore, the rise in enrollment following the free education policy enhances the future prospects for cohesion. When children from diverse communities go to the same schools, they develop relationships that cut across ethnic and religious lines. Over time, these relationships can weaken prejudices and build trust. The more inclusive the educational space, the more likely young people from different backgrounds will see each other as fellow citizens rather than "others."

**Limitations and Risks**

While Western education has made positive contributions, its ability to deliver peace is not automatic or unproblematic. First, unequal access persists. Rural, remote, or economically disadvantaged communities may still lag behind in school quality, infrastructure, teacher availability, and educational outcomes. If these inequalities align along ethnic or religious lines, then education could inadvertently reinforce existing divisions rather than heal them. Second, the tension between Western education and traditional or religious systems is real. Many communities maintain strong loyalty to non-formal educational forms, especially the Qur'anic Tsangaya schools, which may not teach civic or national values in the same way. The coexistence of these parallel systems can sometimes foster a dual identity that undermines a shared civic culture, especially if students in religious schools are isolated from broader curricular content like social studies or citizenship education. Third, schooling alone does not guarantee peace. Education must be intentionally peace-oriented. Curricula that ignore issues like inter-ethnic conflict, historical grievances, or religious pluralism risk being superficial. Without deliberate peace education elements (e.g., conflict resolution, critical thinking, respect for diversity), western education may promote academic skills but fall short of social reconciliation. The recent surge in enrollment thanks to free education is encouraging, but rapid expansion may strain resources. If classroom overcrowding, poor teacher-student ratios or inadequate facilities become the norm, the quality of education, and thus its transformative power, could be compromised.

## Western Education and Peaceful Coexistence

In the contemporary world, marked by cultural pluralism, rapid globalization, political tensions, and technological advancements, the question of how different groups can live together peacefully remains central to human development. Education, in all its forms, is widely recognized as a powerful agent for shaping societies and individual mindsets. Among various educational traditions, Western education has played a particularly significant role in promoting values, skills, and social norms that support peaceful coexistence. Rooted in Enlightenment ideals, human rights philosophies, democratic principles, and scientific rationality, Western education seeks to prepare individuals not only for economic participation, but also for harmonious social interaction in diverse communities.

This discussion explores the relationship between Western education and peaceful coexistence by examining (1) the philosophical foundations that tie Western education to peace, (2) the mechanisms through which it promotes peaceful coexistence, and (3) the challenges and limitations that arise, especially in multicultural or post-colonial contexts. The goal is to show that while Western education is not a perfect system, it remains a powerful tool for fostering understanding, tolerance, and collaborative living.

### Philosophical Foundations Connecting Western Education to Peace

Western education is strongly influenced by humanism, a philosophy that places human dignity, reason, and individual rights at the center of intellectual thought. This philosophical orientation encourages the development of empathy, respect for human life, and a recognition of shared humanity, values essential for peaceful coexistence. Through exposure to disciplines such as literature, history, and social studies, learners encounter diverse human experiences and develop the ability to appreciate differences rather than fear them.

Another foundation of Western education is its emphasis on democratic principles: freedom of expression, rule of law, equality, and participatory governance. Students are taught not only to understand these principles but also to practice them in their interactions. Democratic education stresses dialogue over violence, cooperation over domination, and negotiation over conflict. These values create a framework for societies to manage diversity without degenerating into conflict.

Western education encourages rational inquiry, scientific thinking, and evidence-based reasoning. These skills help individuals question assumptions, challenge prejudices, and reduce irrational fears, especially those that often fuel ethnic, religious, or cultural conflict. By learning to think critically, individuals become less susceptible to extremist ideologies, misinformation, and manipulative rhetoric that can incite violence.

**Mechanisms Through Which Western Education Promotes Peaceful Coexistence**

One of the most significant contributions of Western education to peaceful coexistence is its ability to broaden individuals' understanding of cultural, religious, and ideological diversity. Through subjects such as world history, comparative religion, global literature, and multicultural studies, learners are exposed to different worldviews, traditions, and belief systems that foster tolerance and mutual respect (Ada, 2020; Chile, 2019). This exposure helps to reduce ignorance, challenge stereotypes, and cultivate appreciation for diversity rather than fear of differences. In societies characterized by ethnic, religious, or cultural divisions, such educational experiences promote intercultural dialogue, social integration, and peaceful coexistence (Ben, 2015; Chukes, 2021). Scholars have also observed that Western education has significantly shaped social institutions and intercultural interactions in Nigeria, although its influence has generated debates regarding its relationship with indigenous cultures and values (Arinola, 2013; Okpilike, 2012). Beyond promoting cultural understanding, Western education develops learners' communication and interpersonal skills through debate, discussion, collaborative learning, and problem-solving activities. These competencies enable individuals to express their opinions respectfully, appreciate opposing viewpoints, negotiate differences, and resolve disputes through dialogue rather than violence (Amanda, 2020; Vipene, 2005; Tobin, 2010).

Western education also contributes to peaceful coexistence by promoting civic consciousness and responsible citizenship. Through civic education, learners acquire knowledge of their rights and responsibilities, democratic principles, the rule of law, and the importance of active participation in community development (Orji & Job, 2013; Pasacal, 2019). This orientation encourages accountability, respect for justice, equality, and social responsibility while discouraging discrimination, intolerance, and antisocial behaviour. Within the Nigerian context, educational policies have consistently emphasized the role of education in promoting national unity, although policy implementation has often been constrained by socio-political and administrative challenges (Afolabi & Loto, 2012; Okoroma, 2016). Furthermore, education contributes to peace through economic empowerment by providing literacy, numeracy, scientific knowledge, technological competence, and vocational skills that improve employment opportunities and socio-economic well-being (Charles, 2020; Best, 2018). Since poverty, unemployment, and social exclusion frequently contribute to conflict and instability, expanding access to quality education can help address structural conditions that undermine peaceful coexistence (Osoba & Fajana, 2004; Daniel, 2017).

In an increasingly interconnected world, Western education further promotes a global outlook by exposing learners to international institutions, human rights, sustainable development, migration, and other global challenges that require collective action. Such knowledge cultivates global citizenship and encourages individuals to recognize peace as a shared human responsibility that transcends ethnic, religious, and national boundaries (Ben, 2018; Okwuku, 2019). Schools themselves serve as important agents of peacebuilding by bringing together students from diverse backgrounds and creating opportunities for interaction, cooperation,

and mutual respect. Through inclusive school cultures, collaborative learning, anti-bullying policies, and extracurricular activities, educational institutions model the principles of peaceful coexistence and social harmony (Amanda, 2020; Baddey, 2021). Teachers equally play a critical role by demonstrating fairness, tolerance, and respect while employing pedagogical approaches that promote emotional intelligence, inclusivity, and constructive conflict resolution (Vipene, 2005; Tobin, 2010). These efforts are reinforced through peace-oriented curricula that encourage learners to challenge discrimination, appreciate diversity, and embrace non-violent approaches to resolving social differences.

Despite these contributions, Western education continues to face several challenges that limit its effectiveness in promoting peaceful coexistence. Its historical association with colonialism has led some scholars to argue that it often privileges foreign values at the expense of indigenous knowledge systems and cultural identities, thereby creating tensions between modern educational practices and African traditions (Arinola, 2013; Okpilike, 2012). In addition, inequalities in access to quality education arising from socio-economic disparities continue to reinforce social exclusion and limit the transformative potential of education (Okoroma, 2016; Obindu & Kelechi, 2021). The politicization of educational content and disruptions resulting from industrial actions within the education sector may also undermine the realization of educational objectives and social cohesion (Ahmed, 2014; Obindu & Kelechi, 2021). To strengthen its peacebuilding capacity, Western education should increasingly integrate indigenous knowledge systems, multicultural perspectives, peace education, and social-emotional learning while ensuring equitable access to quality education for all learners (Ada, 2020; Ben, 2015; Chukes, 2021). Ultimately, education, whether Western or indigenous, should remain committed to developing individuals who uphold human dignity, appreciate cultural diversity, resolve conflicts peacefully, and contribute to building inclusive, harmonious, and sustainable societies.

**Challenges and Limitations**

Although Western education has made significant contributions to promoting peaceful coexistence through the advancement of democratic values, critical thinking, and respect for diversity, it is not without limitations. One of its major criticisms is its historical association with colonialism and cultural imperialism, particularly in many postcolonial societies where it is perceived as promoting foreign values at the expense of indigenous cultures, traditions, and knowledge systems (Arinola, 2013; Okpilike, 2012). This perception has often generated resistance, identity conflicts, and cultural alienation, thereby limiting the effectiveness of Western education as a tool for peacebuilding. In Nigeria, the introduction and expansion of Western education significantly transformed indigenous social institutions and value systems, creating tensions between traditional cultural practices and modern educational ideals (Osoba & Fajana, 2004; Ada, 2020). Consequently, scholars increasingly advocate educational curricula that integrate indigenous knowledge, local histories, and cultural diversity alongside global perspectives in order to promote culturally responsive learning and strengthen social cohesion (Daniel, 2017; Best, 2018).

Another important limitation of Western education is the persistence of socio-economic inequalities within educational systems. Although education is widely regarded as a pathway to social mobility and equal opportunity, access to quality education remains uneven due to disparities in income, geographical location, gender, and other socio-economic factors (Okoroma, 2016; Afolabi & Loto, 2012). These inequalities often reinforce social exclusion, widen existing socio-economic gaps, and generate resentment among disadvantaged groups, thereby undermining the peacebuilding objectives of education. Furthermore, educational systems may sometimes be manipulated to promote political ideologies, nationalistic agendas, or selective interpretations of history that encourage division rather than unity (Charles, 2020; Orji & Job, 2013). Instead of nurturing critical inquiry and democratic engagement, such practices may perpetuate prejudice, intolerance, and conflict. In addition, frequent policy inconsistencies and disruptions to educational activities, including industrial actions within the education sector, have continued to weaken the effectiveness of educational institutions in achieving their broader developmental and peacebuilding goals (Ahmed, 2014; Obindu & Kelechi, 2021).

A further criticism of traditional Western educational models is their historical emphasis on intellectual and cognitive achievement with comparatively less attention given to learners' emotional, moral, and social development. As a result, individuals may acquire academic knowledge and professional skills without developing empathy, emotional intelligence, ethical values, and interpersonal competencies necessary for peaceful coexistence (Vipene, 2005; Tobin, 2010). Recent educational reforms have sought to address this limitation through the incorporation of social-emotional learning, character education, and peace education into school curricula (Amanda, 2020; Baddey, 2021). These approaches aim to cultivate compassion, resilience, effective communication, and conflict-resolution skills while encouraging learners to appreciate diversity and engage constructively with people from different cultural and religious backgrounds. Such holistic educational approaches recognize that sustainable peace depends not only on intellectual development but also on the cultivation of appropriate attitudes, values, and behaviours.

## Conclusion

Western education has made substantial contributions to the promotion of peaceful coexistence by fostering democratic values, critical thinking, intercultural understanding, and civic responsibility. It provides individuals with the knowledge and competencies needed to appreciate diversity, engage in constructive dialogue, and resolve conflicts through peaceful means. Nevertheless, its effectiveness depends on its ability to respond to contemporary challenges, including cultural alienation, educational inequality, political interference, and the need for holistic human development. By integrating indigenous knowledge, promoting inclusive and equitable educational opportunities, and strengthening peace and values education, Western education can become a more effective instrument for social cohesion and sustainable peace. Ultimately, education should transcend the mere transmission of

knowledge to cultivate responsible, tolerant, and compassionate citizens capable of contributing to peaceful, inclusive, and just societies.

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# TRADITIONAL RULERS AND INTERFAITH DIALOGUE IN WUKARI LOCAL GOVERNMENT AREA, TARABA STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** Prior to the coming of the colonial masters in Africa, traditional rulers are held in high esteem as custodians of culture and traditions. The influence and control gained by Nigerian traditional rulers might not be unconnected with the value systems of most of the ethnic groups of the areas within which the traditional rulers are based. Traditional rulers put a lot of effort through various peace building initiatives to ensure peaceful coexistence among their subjects in their respective domains. This study will examine the role of traditional rulers and interfaith dialogue in Wukari local government Area Taraba State. Interview instruments will be used to source for primary data with five respondents. Structural functionalism Theory will be adopted as a theoretical framework to guide the study. The choice of the theory is informed by the fact that, the society is interconnected as a system which has different structures with their distinct functions, for society to be at peace the structures has to function well. The traditional rulers is a structure and the religious bodies is also a structure and structures has functions to carry out for the peace, unity and development of the entire society by such doing the have to engage in dialogue to achieve its goals. The study will find out the roles played by the traditional rulers and interfaith dialogue in Wukari local government Area of Taraba state, it will also look at how the traditional rulers and interfaith engages in dialogue to ensure there's peace throughout the community. The study will look at the measures put in place in order to find solutions to the reoccurring crisis in Wukari Local Government Area. The study will also look at the roles played specifically by the traditional rulers and interfaith in contending with crisis and are still playing to ensure there's peace and unity. The study will come up recommendations out of the findings.

**Keywords:** Traditional rulers, interfaith and dialogue

## Introduction

Prior to colonial incursions into Africa, many African societies had well-established traditional mechanisms for conflict resolution. Various communities across the continent developed unique conventions aimed at mitigating interpersonal, intra-communal, and inter-communal conflicts. According to Woko and Osagie (2014), these conventions were reinforced by taboos and customary laws that regulated human activities and relationships among community members, thereby promoting peaceful coexistence.

In Africa, many cultural groups adopted effective dispute resolution mechanisms that helped address conflicts according to their customs and traditions before the advent of British colonial rule. These traditional mechanisms were rooted in indigenous customs and proved culturally effective in resolving disputes within communities. Such methods of conflict resolution among cultural groups in Nigeria were based on knowledge and practices transmitted from one generation to another (Ajayi, 2014).

Christians and Muslims, often portrayed as the principal parties in religious conflicts, have historically competed for power, dominance, and spheres of influence in areas they consider their strongholds. This competition is frequently driven by religious exclusivism and unhealthy rivalry. Consequently, the history of religious pluralism in Nigeria is marked by numerous conflicts and tensions, with religion often serving as a catalyst for deep-seated crises in the country (Okwueze, 2003).

Since Nigeria's return to democratic governance in 1999 after decades of military rule, religiously motivated crises have become a recurring feature of social interaction (Njoku & Kolapo, 2022). However, the introduction of Western civilization has gradually weakened some traditional methods of conflict resolution. Many Nigerians, particularly urban dwellers, now prefer modern or conventional methods of conflict resolution, which are largely based on the formal criminal justice system (Ajayi, 2014).

Despite Western influence, traditional conflict resolution mechanisms continue to be utilized in many African societies to maintain peace and social harmony. Zartman (2009) observed that traditional African societies often viewed conflict as arising from a breakdown in relationships among humans and between humans and supernatural entities such as deities, ancestors, and supreme beings. Consequently, traditional African methods of conflict resolution emphasize mediation, negotiation, and dialogue, involving traditional rulers, community leaders, security committees, and religious leaders.

Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State, Nigeria, is characterized by rich cultural diversity and a complex interaction among various religious groups, predominantly Christians and Muslims. The area has experienced a series of conflicts often rooted in ethnic and religious differences. As custodians of culture and mediators in disputes, traditional rulers play a significant role in fostering peace, promoting interfaith dialogue, encouraging youth participation in peacebuilding processes, and urging religious leaders to preach peace, tolerance, and unity within their congregations. It is against this backdrop that this study examines how traditional rulers promote peace through interfaith dialogue in Wukari Local Government Area.

## Statement of the Problem

Despite the significant role played by traditional rulers in conflict resolution, there remains limited understanding of their effectiveness and the specific mechanisms they employ in preventing religious conflicts in Wukari Local Government Area. The persistence of religious tensions, coupled with the changing socio-political environment, raises concerns about the adequacy of traditional leadership in addressing contemporary conflict challenges.

Furthermore, the relationship between traditional authority and modern governance structures remains insufficiently explored, particularly within the context of Wukari. This knowledge gap makes it difficult to assess the extent to which traditional rulers contribute to conflict prevention and peacebuilding. Therefore, this study seeks to investigate the role of traditional rulers in promoting interfaith dialogue and mitigating religious conflicts, as well as identify the factors that enhance or hinder their effectiveness in Wukari Local Government Area.

## Objectives of the Study

The broad objective of this study is to examine traditional rulers and interfaith dialogue as strategies for conflict prevention in Wukari Local Government Area. The specific objectives are:

i. To examine the role of traditional rulers in promoting interfaith dialogue in Wukari Local Government Area.

ii. To explore the concept and practice of interfaith dialogue in Wukari Local Government Area.

iii. To identify the strategies employed by traditional rulers to facilitate interfaith dialogue and prevent conflicts in Wukari Local Government Area.

## Traditional Rulers

Traditional rulers are individuals who occupy positions of authority and leadership within a community based on cultural heritage, historical lineage, and customary practices. They are often recognized for their contributions to governance, conflict resolution, cultural preservation, and community cohesion (Bassey, 2022).

According to Babalola (2020), a traditional ruler is a person who, by reason of inheritance or lineage, has been appointed to a chieftaincy position by those entitled to do so under customary law and whose appointment has been approved by the appropriate authorities.

Traditional rulers may be hereditary or elected indigenous leaders whose authority is derived from pre-colonial governance systems, customs, and cultural traditions of a particular ethnic or community group. Their legitimacy is usually based on ancestral lineage, tradition, and community acceptance rather than constitutional or electoral processes. They often perform vital functions in conflict resolution, cultural preservation, spiritual guidance, and community mobilization.

Osaghae (1987) describes traditional rulers as custodians of culture and tradition whose authority derives from customary norms and lineage rather than statutory instruments, yet who continue to exert considerable influence in governance, particularly in rural and peri-urban communities. Similarly, Sklar (1993) defines traditional rulers as indigenous leaders whose positions are rooted in the traditions of pre-colonial political systems and who continue to exercise moral, religious, and, in some cases, political authority within contemporary states. The roles and responsibilities of traditional rulers vary considerably across African societies and are influenced by both historical experiences and contemporary state structures (Ayoade, 1980).

**Traditional Institutions**

Traditional institutions refer to indigenous socio-political arrangements through which leaders with proven integrity and community acceptance are appointed and installed according to the customs and traditions of their people (Orji & Olali, 2010). The primary purpose of these institutions is to preserve the customs and traditions of the people, manage conflicts among community members through customary laws and practices, and promote social harmony. Traditional institutions serve as active agents in maintaining social order, ensuring peaceful coexistence, and fostering sustainable peace within their respective communities (Nweke, 2012).

**Interfaith Dialogue**

Interfaith dialogue, also referred to as inter-religious dialogue, involves conversations and interactions between adherents of two or more different religions or faith traditions (Catherine, 2013). Fundamentally, interfaith dialogue is understood as an encounter between people of diverse faith traditions in an atmosphere of mutual trust, respect, and acceptance, where participants seek common understanding and cooperation without focusing on differences or faults (Olagunju, 2013).

Interfaith dialogue is generally regarded as the establishment of positive and constructive relationships among adherents of diverse religious traditions (Sergey, 2020). Catherine (2013) further defines inter-religious dialogue as any form of constructive and practical engagement between different religious traditions.

Interfaith dialogue brings together diverse voices, stories, perspectives, and experiences of religious individuals with the aim of fostering mutual understanding and learning. It provides a conducive environment for sharing experiences, listening to others, and developing greater understanding of various religious issues (Olu, 2008).

With particular emphasis on Christian-Muslim relations, interfaith dialogue can be described as the coming together of followers of the "Cross and the Crescent" for various purposes, in different places, and at different times (Babs, 2017). This interaction may focus on discussing issues that affect adherents of both faiths and promoting peaceful coexistence. It can also be described as a cooperative, constructive, and positive interaction between Christians and Muslims (Babs, 2017).

Dialogue between faiths extends beyond mere conversations to include meaningful interactions and relationships. Since peace is the ultimate objective of interfaith dialogue, the process itself must be characterized by peaceful engagement. Furthermore, interreligious dialogue encompasses all positive and productive relationships among individuals and communities of different faiths that seek to promote mutual understanding, respect, truth, and religious freedom (John, 1984).

**Religious Conflicts**

Religious conflict means different things to different people. According to Otite and Olawale (1999), religious conflict refers to "the struggle over values and claims to scarce resources, status, and power in which opponents seek to neutralize or eliminate their rivals." Oyeshola (2006) defines religious conflict as disagreement, dispute, or controversy arising from differing ideas, beliefs, or viewpoints held by individuals, communities, or religious groups. Similarly, Davies and Egbuchu (2019) describe religious conflict as a specific type of conflict between groups based on ideological differences along religious lines within a plural society, with each group striving for political relevance and influence. In a broader perspective, Aliyu (2004), as cited in Anwuluorah, Udeh, and Sapientia (2019), posits that religious conflict is a process of interaction involving struggles over resources, power, status, beliefs, preferences, and other competing interests among groups.

**Empirical Review**

**Traditional Rulers and Conflict Resolution**

Traditional rulers have historically played significant roles in conflict prevention, mediation, and peacebuilding in many African societies. Scholars generally agree that traditional institutions remain relevant because they possess cultural legitimacy, local knowledge, and the trust of community members.

Recent studies continue to affirm the importance of traditional rulers in peacebuilding and conflict management. Emmanuel (2025), in a study of Northeast Nigeria, found that traditional rulers contribute significantly to conflict mediation, reconciliation, community cohesion, and peacebuilding efforts in conflict-affected communities. Similarly, Maijama, Mohammed, and Zamani (2025) observed that traditional rulers in Taraba North Senatorial District play vital roles in resolving communal disputes through mediation, dialogue, and indigenous conflict resolution mechanisms. Their findings suggest that traditional institutions remain indispensable in promoting peace and stability at the grassroots level.

Despite this consensus, the studies differ in their scope and focus. Emmanuel (2025) examined the broader peacebuilding role of traditional rulers across Northeast Nigeria, while Maijama et al. (2025) focused specifically on conflict resolution mechanisms in Taraba State. Furthermore, both studies emphasize mediation and reconciliation but pay limited attention to interfaith dialogue as a distinct strategy for conflict prevention. This omission is particularly important in communities such as Wukari, where religious diversity significantly influences social relations and community stability.

**Interfaith Dialogue and Peacebuilding**

Interfaith dialogue has been widely recognized as an important strategy for promoting peaceful coexistence in religiously diverse societies. Scholars argue that dialogue creates opportunities for understanding, tolerance, and cooperation among people of different faiths.

Iweze (2022) examined the role of religious leaders in fostering interfaith dialogue in Kano State during the Boko Haram insurgency and found that sustained interaction among religious leaders contributed to reducing extremism and promoting peacebuilding among religious communities. Similarly, Emmanuel and Damila (2022) argued that interfaith dialogue enhances trust, reduces stereotypes, promotes reconciliation, and transforms hostile relationships into cooperative ones.

Although both studies acknowledge the importance of dialogue in peacebuilding, they differ in their approaches. Iweze (2022) employed an ethnographic approach involving interviews and focus group discussions, while Emmanuel and Damila (2022) adopted a conceptual approach focused on conflict transformation. However, both studies paid limited attention to the role of traditional rulers as facilitators of interfaith engagement. Consequently, they do not adequately explain how indigenous institutions contribute to sustaining dialogue and peaceful coexistence at the community level.

## Religious Conflict and Peacebuilding in Nigeria

Nigeria's religious diversity has generated both opportunities for coexistence and challenges associated with conflict. Several scholars attribute religious conflicts to political manipulation, ethnic competition, poverty, unemployment, insecurity, and social exclusion.

Recent studies indicate that communal and religious conflicts in Nigeria are often linked to broader socio-economic and political factors rather than purely doctrinal differences. Emmanuel (2025) observed that insecurity, communal tensions, and weak social cohesion continue to threaten peace in many communities in Northeast Nigeria. Similarly, Maijama et al. (2025) found that conflicts in Taraba State are often driven by competition over resources, identity issues, and communal grievances, requiring the intervention of traditional institutions to maintain peace and stability.

While these studies provide valuable insights into the causes and management of conflicts, they do not sufficiently examine how traditional rulers can promote sustainable interfaith relations through structured dialogue mechanisms. Most of the existing literature focuses on mediation and conflict resolution generally, leaving a gap in understanding the specific role of traditional rulers in facilitating interfaith dialogue. This gap is particularly evident in Wukari Local Government Area, where religious diversity makes interfaith engagement an important component of conflict prevention and social cohesion.

## Gap in the Literature

Although existing studies have established the importance of traditional rulers in conflict resolution and peacebuilding, significant gaps remain. First, Emmanuel (2025) and Maijama, Mohammed, and Zamani (2025) focused primarily on the roles of traditional rulers in mediation, reconciliation, dispute settlement, and community peacebuilding. However, these studies paid little attention to interfaith dialogue as a specific mechanism through which traditional rulers promote peaceful coexistence among adherents of different religions.

Second, studies on interfaith dialogue by Iweze (2022) and Emmanuel and Damila (2022) emphasized the contributions of religious leaders and dialogue processes in fostering peace and reducing religious tensions. Nevertheless, these studies largely overlooked the role of traditional rulers as facilitators, coordinators, and custodians of indigenous peacebuilding structures that support interfaith engagement at the community level.

Third, while previous studies have examined conflict management and peacebuilding in Northeast Nigeria, Kano State, and Taraba North Senatorial District, none specifically focused on Wukari Local Government Area. Given the unique religious diversity, historical communal tensions, and strategic role of the Aku Uka institution in Wukari, findings from other locations may not adequately explain the realities of interfaith relations in the area.

Most existing studies concentrated on general conflict resolution and peacebuilding strategies without investigating how traditional rulers employ structured interfaith dialogue to prevent religious conflicts, build trust among different faith groups, and strengthen social cohesion. Consequently, there is limited empirical evidence on the specific contributions of traditional institutions to interfaith dialogue and sustainable peace in Wukari Local Government Area.

Therefore, this study seeks to fill these gaps by examining the role of traditional rulers, particularly the Aku Uka institution, in promoting interfaith dialogue and peacebuilding in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State. The study will provide context-specific evidence on how traditional institutions facilitate interfaith engagement, foster peaceful coexistence, and contribute to sustainable peacebuilding.

**Theoretical framework**

Structural Functionalism Theory provides the theoretical foundation for this study by explaining society as a system of interrelated and interdependent institutions that perform complementary functions necessary for maintaining social order, stability, and continuity (Blench, 2006). Although the theory evolved through the contributions of Auguste Comte, Herbert Spencer, Emile Durkheim, and Talcott Parsons, Parsons' formulation remains the most influential. Parsons (1964) argued that every social system must perform four essential functions, which includes Adaptation, Goal Attainment, Integration, and Latency (Pattern Maintenance), collectively known as the AGIL model. Within the context of this study, these functions illuminate the role of traditional rulers in facilitating interfaith dialogue and promoting peaceful coexistence in Wukari Local Government Area. Through adaptation, traditional rulers respond to emerging religious and communal challenges by creating avenues for mediation, consultation, and dialogue. Goal attainment is reflected in their ability to mobilize religious and community leaders towards shared objectives such as peace, unity, and social harmony. Integration is demonstrated through their efforts to strengthen cooperation among Christians, Muslims, and adherents of traditional religion, while pattern maintenance is achieved by preserving cultural values, moral norms, and traditions that encourage tolerance, mutual respect, and peaceful coexistence.

The theory is particularly valuable because it highlights the importance of social institutions in fostering cooperation, integration, and stability within society. It provides a systematic framework for understanding how traditional institutions contribute to conflict prevention, community development, and the maintenance of social cohesion. However, Structural Functionalism has been widely criticized for placing excessive emphasis on consensus, stability, and equilibrium while paying limited attention to conflict, inequality, power relations, and social change. Critics further argue that the theory tends to interpret institutions solely in terms of the functions they perform, overlooking the broader political, economic, and historical forces that shape their operations. Consequently, it may not fully capture the complexities of contemporary conflicts, competing interests, and changing social realities that influence interfaith relations.

Despite these limitations, Structural Functionalism remains highly relevant to this study because it provides a useful framework for examining the contributions of traditional rulers to interfaith dialogue and peacebuilding in Wukari Local Government Area. The concept of integration explains how traditional rulers facilitate dialogue, consultation, and mediation among diverse religious groups, thereby strengthening social cohesion and reducing the potential for religious conflict. Likewise, the concept of pattern maintenance illustrates how these leaders preserve cultural norms and shared values that promote tolerance and harmonious coexistence. By emphasizing the interconnected roles of traditional leadership, religious institutions, and community members in maintaining social order, the theory offers an appropriate lens for understanding how traditional rulers contribute to conflict prevention, social cohesion, and sustainable peace in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State.

## Methodology

This study adopted a qualitative research design to investigate the role of traditional rulers in promoting interfaith dialogue in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State. A qualitative approach was considered appropriate because it enabled the researcher to obtain in-depth information and detailed insights into the experiences, perceptions, and practices of key stakeholders involved in interfaith relations and conflict management within the study area. The study relied exclusively on primary data collected through Key Informant Interviews (KIIs). The use of interviews provided an opportunity to obtain firsthand information from individuals who possess extensive knowledge and experience regarding traditional leadership, religious relations, and peacebuilding activities in Wukari Local Government Area.

## Population and Sample Selection

The target population for this study comprised traditional rulers, religious leaders, community elders, and youth leaders who play significant roles in promoting peace and interfaith relations in Wukari Local Government Area. A purposive sampling technique was adopted to select participants based on their positions, experience, and knowledge of interfaith dialogue and conflict management. Accordingly, five key informants were selected for the study: the Chief of Tsokundi, the Chairman of the Christian Association of Nigeria (CAN), Wukari Chapter, an elder statesman, the Chairman of the Muslim Council, and the Youth Chairman. These participants were deliberately chosen because they occupy strategic leadership positions within the community and possess firsthand knowledge and practical experience in fostering peaceful coexistence, resolving religious disputes, and facilitating interfaith dialogue among diverse religious groups.

## Sample Size and Data Saturation

The study interviewed five key informants. Although the number may appear small, qualitative research emphasizes the depth and richness of information rather than statistical representation. The selected participants were regarded as information-rich cases capable of providing detailed insights into the phenomenon under investigation. Data collection continued until thematic saturation was achieved. Saturation occurred when no substantially new information, themes, or perspectives emerged from subsequent interviews. The responses obtained from the five participants revealed recurring patterns and consistent views regarding the role of traditional rulers in facilitating interfaith dialogue and preventing conflicts in Wukari Local Government Area.

## Instrument for Data Collection

The primary instrument for data collection was a semi-structured interview guide consisting of open-ended questions designed to elicit participants' views and experiences regarding the role of traditional rulers in conflict prevention and management, the concept and practice of interfaith dialogue in Wukari, strategies employed to promote interfaith dialogue, challenges affecting interfaith relations, and measures for strengthening peaceful coexistence among religious groups. The semi-structured format provided flexibility for probing and follow-up questions to obtain deeper insights and clarifications. Data were collected between 18th and 20th July 2025 following prior appointments with the participants. Each interview lasted between 30 and 60 minutes, depending on the availability of the respondent and the depth of the discussion. Interviews were conducted in English, Hausa, and Jukun languages. With the participants' consent, detailed notes were taken during the interviews, while responses obtained in Hausa and Jukun were translated into English to facilitate analysis.

## Method of Data Analysis

The data collected were analyzed using thematic analysis. Interview responses were first transcribed and, where necessary, translated into English before being systematically coded to identify recurring themes, patterns, and categories relevant to the study objectives. The analysis involved organizing the data into major themes and sub-themes, followed by the interpretation of participants' perspectives in relation to the research questions. The findings were presented narratively and supported with relevant direct quotations from participants to enhance the credibility and richness of the analysis.

## Ethical Considerations

Ethical principles were strictly observed throughout the study. Participants were informed about the purpose of the research and their voluntary participation was sought before the interviews commenced. Informed consent was obtained from all participants. Confidentiality

and anonymity were assured, and information obtained from participants was used strictly for academic purposes. Participants were also informed of their right to withdraw from the study at any stage without any consequences.

**Overview of Religious Conflicts in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State**

Wukari is a cosmopolitan and multi-religious town that possesses many of the social, cultural, and economic characteristics commonly found in African urban centers. The town is located in Taraba State, Nigeria (Ukaogo & Adihikon, 2012). Wukari is widely recognized by the Jukun people as their traditional capital and remains a significant cultural and political center for the ethnic group (Ukaogo & Adihikon, 2012).

As the headquarters of Wukari Local Government Area, the town is situated in the southern part of Taraba State. Due to its cosmopolitan nature and relatively high population density, which has contributed to identity-related tensions, Wukari possesses several modern facilities and infrastructures that are uncommon in many towns across Nigeria. The town hosts two universities, one privately owned and the other federally owned.

Abimbola and Akin (2009), in their study Indigenship and Citizenship in Nigeria: Myth or Reality?, observed that the Jukun people, one of the major ethnic groups in Taraba State, had firmly established themselves in Wukari as far back as the seventeenth century. Historically, Wukari served as a principal town in the ancient Kwararafa (Kororofa) Confederacy. Emma-Lawson (2012) further noted that the Jukun people maintained political dominance within the confederacy from the late sixteenth century until its eventual decline.

Madu and Goni (2013) classified the Wukari crises as both ethnic and religious in nature. Their study, Religious Conflict in Taraba State and Its Implications for Socio-Economic, Political, and Educational Development of Youths, highlighted the prolonged and recurring nature of these conflicts. According to their findings, out of the fourteen major religious crises recorded in Taraba State between 1991 and July 2013, three major conflicts with multiple occurrences and devastating consequences took place in Wukari.

The persistence of violence in Wukari was further highlighted by Itodo (2013) in The Weekly Trust newspaper. He observed that violence in Wukari had become a recurring phenomenon requiring urgent attention from all stakeholders in the interest of peace, unity, and development. He noted that a crisis that erupted in February 2013 occurred barely two months after a previous violent incident that resulted in the loss of lives and the destruction of property worth millions of naira.

According to reports, a disagreement among youths during a football match on February 23, 2013, escalated into violence after one youth allegedly killed another, leading to widespread destruction throughout the town. Similarly, on July 13, 2010, a dispute over the construction

of a place of worship at the Police Area Command triggered another crisis. Earlier records also indicate that in 1990, a political crisis occurred in Wukari following the alleged killing of a youth. Additionally, several violent clashes have been reported between the Tiv and Jukun ethnic groups over the years (Itodo, 2013).

These recurring conflicts have resulted in the loss of thousands of lives and the destruction of properties worth millions of naira. Numerous individuals have been killed or injured in clashes involving indigenous groups and Hausa youths in the community.

As earlier indicated, the conflicts in Wukari have increasingly assumed both ethnic and religious dimensions. One side of the conflict largely comprises the predominantly Christian and traditionalist Jukun indigenes of Wukari, who are regarded as descendants of the ancient Kwararafa (Kororofa) Confederacy. The opposing side consists mainly of Muslim Jukun indigenes and Hausa/Fulani residents of the town, whom some indigenous Jukun communities often perceive as settlers or non-indigenes. These competing claims over identity, political representation, and access to resources have contributed significantly to the persistence of conflict in the area (Itodo, 2013).

Table 1: The dates of the major Wukari crises, key participants, estimated casualty figures, displaced people and property damaged

| **Date** | **Major participants** | **Estimated Casualties Figures** | **Estimated Displaced Persons** | **Estimated worth of property destroyed (₦)** |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 23/2/2013 | Jukun Christians/ other Christian settlers and/ Versus Jukun Muslims/ other Muslims settlers | | 10,000 | 23 million |
| 3/5/2013 | Jukun Christians/other Christian settlers/ Versus Jukun Muslim and other Muslim settlers | 144 | 11,000 | 21 million |
| 15/4/2014 | Jukun Christians/other Christian settlers and/ Versus Jukun Muslims/other Muslim settlers | 175 | 8,000 | 14 million |
| 15/6/2014 | Jukun Christians/other Christian settlers and/ Versus Jukun Muslims/other Muslim settlers | 800 | 15,490 | 10 million |
| 2/9/2014 | Jukun Christians/few animists/other Christians settlers and/ Versus Jukun Muslims/other Muslim settlers in Wukari/missionaries who were mostly Muslims | 281 | 12,000 | 12 million |
| 8/11/2014 | Jukun Christians/few animists/other Christians settlers and/ Versus Jukun Muslims/other Muslim settlers in Wukari/missionaries who were mostly Muslims | 132 | 40,000 | 44 million |

Source: Itodo (2013).

## Discussion of Findings

### The Roles of Traditional Rulers and Interfaith Dialogue in Conflict Prevention and Management in Wukari Local Government Area

In Wukari, a multi-ethnic and multi-religious community often prone to tension, traditional rulers serve as key actors in conflict prevention and resolution. From the Aku Uka of Wukari to district heads and community elders, their influence extends across both religious and communal affairs. According to the Tsokundi Chief, whenever signs of tension or conflict emerge, the Aku Uka convenes his council, which comprises high-ranking traditional leaders such as the Abon Cio, Abon Zekhen, and Kenda Cio. Religious leaders and respected elders from both Christian and Muslim communities are also invited. Together, they discuss the root causes of the conflict and develop peaceful intervention strategies. Religious leaders subsequently communicate these peace messages to their followers (Tsokundi Chief, 18th July, 2025).

The CAN Chairman emphasized the proactive role of traditional rulers in preventing conflicts through early intervention dialogues. He explained that such meetings are instrumental in addressing grievances before they escalate, while religious leaders serve as effective communication channels between the traditional council and the grassroots population (CAN Chairman, 18th July, 2025).

Similarly, the Elder Statesman highlighted the swift response of traditional rulers during periods of insecurity. According to him, the traditional council promptly issues peace advisories to religious leaders, who in turn sensitize their followers. This rapid communication process plays a vital role in stabilizing potentially volatile situations (Elder Statesman, 20th July, 2025).

From the perspective of the Muslim Council, traditional rulers are regarded as neutral mediators who provide an inclusive platform for dialogue. The Council appreciates the opportunity given to all religious groups to express their concerns and contribute to conflict resolution, thereby enhancing mutual understanding and reducing tensions (Chairman, Muslim Council, 20th July, 2025).

The Youth Chairman further emphasized the grassroots dimension of peacebuilding. He noted that traditional rulers promote peace through social initiatives such as interfaith sporting activities, which encourage interaction and cooperation among young people from different religious backgrounds. These initiatives strengthen communal relationships and reduce hostility (Youth Chairman, 20th July, 2025).

## Concepts and Practices of Interfaith dialogue among traditional rulers in Wukari Local Government Area

### Interfaith Dialogue in Wukari

The Tsokundi Chief identified community festivals and cultural gatherings as important platforms for interfaith dialogue. These events bring together Christians and Muslims to celebrate cultural values and foster mutual understanding. Through such interactions, interfaith dialogue becomes an accepted and sustained practice at the grassroots level.

According to the CAN Chairman, structured initiatives such as workshops and seminars organized by traditional rulers provide opportunities for representatives of different faiths to discuss their beliefs and identify common values that promote peaceful coexistence (CAN Chairman, 18th July, 2025).

The Youth Chairman emphasized the role of youth-oriented activities, including football competitions and inter-religious committees. These initiatives address common social issues and create a sense of belonging among adherents of different faiths, thereby strengthening interfaith relations (Youth Chairman, 20th July, 2025).

The Elder Statesman highlighted the importance of informal gatherings, such as shared meals and social interactions, as effective avenues for promoting peace and understanding among religious groups (Elder Statesman, 20th July, 2025).

The Chairman of the Muslim Council pointed to joint religious celebrations and community outreach programmes as important practices that encourage cooperation and strengthen social cohesion among diverse faith communities (Chairman, Muslim Council, 20th July, 2025).

A major theme that emerged from the interviews was the institutionalization of regular interfaith dialogue. The Tsokundi Chief suggested that traditional rulers should organize regular meetings involving religious leaders. Likewise, the CAN Chairman advocated the establishment of a formal council of religious leaders that would serve as a permanent platform for discussing communal issues, fostering mutual understanding, and preventing conflicts before they escalate (CAN Chairman, 18th July, 2025).

### Strategies Adopted by Traditional Rulers in Facilitating Interfaith Dialogue in Wukari Local Government Area

Another major strategy identified by respondents was the promotion of community-based collaborative efforts. The Tsokundi Chief explained that joint community service projects involving members of different faiths encourage cooperation, dialogue, and solidarity. Such

initiatives create shared goals that transcend religious differences and strengthen community identity (Tsokundi Chief, 18th July, 2025).

The Elder Statesman stressed the importance of capacity-building programmes for religious leaders. He recommended training in conflict resolution, mediation, and communication skills to enhance the ability of religious leaders to manage tensions and promote peace within their communities (Elder Statesman, 20th July, 2025).

The Chairman of the Muslim Council advocated educational initiatives aimed at promoting tolerance, empathy, and interfaith understanding, particularly within schools and religious institutions. He viewed education as a long-term solution to prejudice, discrimination, and mistrust among religious groups (Chairman, Muslim Council, 20th July, 2025).

The Youth Chairman highlighted the need to actively involve young people in peacebuilding activities. He suggested that traditional rulers should organize peacebuilding workshops and forums for youths from different religious backgrounds. Such initiatives would foster friendships, encourage collaboration, and create a network of youth peace ambassadors (Youth Chairman, 20th July, 2025).

**Discussion of findings**

The findings demonstrate that traditional institutions play a pivotal role in promoting interfaith dialogue and preventing religious conflict in Wukari Local Government Area. Respondents consistently indicated that traditional rulers, alongside religious and community leaders, facilitate peaceful coexistence by creating opportunities for interaction among adherents of different faiths. Interfaith engagement is promoted through cultural festivals, workshops, seminars, joint religious celebrations, and other community-based activities that encourage dialogue, mutual understanding, and cooperation. The findings further reveal that interfaith interactions occur through both formal platforms, such as organized meetings and conferences, and informal settings, including social gatherings and everyday community interactions. These complementary approaches enhance inclusiveness and foster stronger relationships among religious groups, thereby reinforcing social cohesion and reducing the likelihood of religious tensions.

Another major finding is that interfaith dialogue in Wukari is largely centred on shared values and collective community interests rather than theological or doctrinal differences. Respondents noted that discussions frequently focus on issues such as peace, community development, mutual respect, social responsibility, and harmonious coexistence. This finding suggests that emphasizing common goals enables members of different religious communities to build trust and strengthen collaborative relationships despite their religious diversity. By shifting attention away from divisive issues and concentrating on shared

aspirations, interfaith dialogue serves as an effective mechanism for reducing suspicion, promoting tolerance, and enhancing unity within the community.

The study also reveals a broad consensus regarding the central role of traditional rulers as custodians of peace and mediators in conflict prevention and resolution. Their cultural legitimacy, moral authority, and deep understanding of local customs position them to intervene promptly in emerging disputes before they escalate into violent conflicts. Respondents emphasized that traditional rulers regularly convene community meetings, consultations, and public forums where grievances are openly discussed and amicable solutions are negotiated. Beyond mediating disputes, these leaders actively promote values of tolerance, respect, and cooperation among religious and ethnic groups, thereby strengthening social cohesion and sustaining community stability. Their leadership therefore extends beyond conflict resolution to encompass broader responsibilities for maintaining social harmony and fostering peaceful intergroup relations.

Finally, the findings identify several practical measures for strengthening interfaith relations in Wukari Local Government Area. Respondents emphasized the need for regular dialogue sessions involving traditional rulers, religious leaders, and community stakeholders to facilitate continuous communication and the early resolution of emerging tensions. They also highlighted the importance of educational programmes that promote religious tolerance, mutual understanding, and conflict resolution as effective means of reducing prejudice and misconceptions. In addition, respondents underscored the value of actively engaging young people through workshops, mentorship programmes, sporting activities, and community service initiatives to cultivate future leaders committed to peaceful coexistence. The use of storytelling and personal experiences was also identified as an important strategy for fostering empathy, challenging stereotypes, and deepening mutual understanding among members of different religious communities. Collectively, these findings underscore that sustainable peace in Wukari depends on continuous dialogue, inclusive participation, and the collaborative efforts of traditional institutions, religious leaders, and the wider community.

**Conclusion**

The study concludes that traditional institutions play a vital role in promoting interfaith dialogue, preventing conflicts, and strengthening social cohesion in Wukari Local Government Area. As respected custodians of culture and community leadership, traditional rulers facilitate mediation, dialogue, and cooperation among diverse religious and ethnic groups through both formal and informal platforms, including community meetings, workshops, cultural festivals, religious celebrations, and everyday social interactions. These initiatives foster mutual understanding, tolerance, and peaceful coexistence while contributing to the prevention of religious tensions and communal disputes. The study further concludes that sustaining peace in the area requires strengthening existing dialogue platforms, expanding educational initiatives that promote religious tolerance and conflict resolution, and actively involving young people in peacebuilding efforts. Ultimately, effective collaboration

among traditional institutions, religious leaders, community stakeholders, and government remains essential for achieving enduring peace, unity, and sustainable development in Wukari Local Government Area.

**Recommendations**

Based on the findings of this study, the following recommendations are proposed:

i. Traditional rulers in Wukari Local Government Area should institutionalize quarterly interfaith dialogue meetings involving leaders of the Christian Association of Nigeria (CAN), the Muslim Council, traditional religion practitioners, youth representatives, women leaders, and community elders. These meetings should provide a structured platform for discussing emerging religious and communal issues, mediating disputes at an early stage, and developing joint strategies for promoting peaceful coexistence.

ii. The Wukari Local Government Authority, Taraba State Ministry of Education, and religious organizations should collaborate to design and implement community-based educational programmes on religious tolerance, peacebuilding, and conflict resolution. These programmes should be delivered through schools, community centres, places of worship, and public awareness campaigns to reduce prejudice, promote mutual respect, and strengthen understanding among adherents of different faiths.

iii. Traditional rulers, religious leaders, youth associations, and civil society organizations should establish interfaith youth engagement programmes that bring together young people from different religious backgrounds through leadership training, community service projects, sporting competitions, cultural exchange activities, and peace education workshops. Such initiatives should promote positive interactions, build trust across religious divides, discourage religious extremism, and develop a new generation of community leaders committed to peaceful coexistence.

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# DISCURSIVE CONSTRUCTIONS OF VIOLENCE: A STUDY OF MEDIA NARRATIVES, RUMOR MONGERING, AND CONFLICT ESCALATION IN TARABA STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** This study aimed to explore the discursive constructions of violence in Taraba State, Nigeria, with a focus on media narratives, rumor mongering, and conflict escalation. The objective was to investigate how media narratives and rumor mongering contribute to the escalation of violent conflicts in the region. The problem of violent conflicts in Taraba State is complex and multifaceted, with various factors contributing to the persistence of violence. Despite efforts by government and non-governmental organizations to address the issue, violence continues to plague the region, resulting in loss of lives and property. The study employed a qualitative research approach, using critical discourse analysis to examine media narratives and rumour mongering in Taraba State. The findings revealed that media narratives often perpetuate stereotypes and biases, contributing to the escalation of conflicts. Rumour mongering was also found to play a significant role in fueling tensions and violence in the region. The study concludes that media narratives and rumour mongering are critical factors in the escalation of violent conflicts in Taraba State. The study recommends that media practitioners should adopt a more nuanced and balanced approach to reporting conflicts, avoiding stereotypes and biases that can exacerbate tensions among people. Additionally, community leaders and government officials should take steps to address rumour-mongering and promote fact-based information to reduce tensions and prevent violence. The study's findings have implications for conflict resolution and peacebuilding efforts in Taraba State and beyond.

**Keywords:** Discursive constructions, violence, media narratives, rumor mongering, and conflict escalation

## Introduction

The discursive formulation of violence has received much focus in recent years, especially concerning conflict-affected areas in Nigeria. Violence and conflict have become ubiquitous elements of modern civilisation, yielding extensive repercussions for individuals, communities, and nations. The intensification of violent conflicts in Nigeria is particularly significant, influenced by several variables that contribute to the intricate dynamics of violence (Böhmelt et al., 2020). Taraba State, situated in Nigeria's North-East region, has been a focal point for violent conflicts, including farmer–herder clashes, communal strife, and banditry (Okoro & Nwafor, 2022). These conflicts have caused considerable human

suffering, displacement, and economic losses, highlighting the necessity for a deeper understanding of the factors driving violence in the region.

The growth of media narratives and rumour-mongering has been identified as a significant factor contributing to the escalation and spread of violence. The media significantly influences public attitudes and narratives surrounding violence. Through selective reporting and framing, the media can shape public perception and reactions to violent events (Büchi & Vogler, 2021). For example, sensationalised media coverage can exacerbate fear and anxiety, leading to a distorted public perception of the frequency and nature of violence (Houghton, 2022). Research further indicates that media narratives can shape public opinion and influence policy decisions (Entman, 2021).

By emphasising specific elements of a narrative, the media may construct a particular storyline that appeals to the public and decision-makers. This may result in a misallocation of resources, prioritising topics deemed more urgent owing to media coverage (Wolfsfeld, 2021). The media significantly influences popular perceptions of violence, especially with terrorism. Research indicates that media reporting on terrorist acts might exacerbate public fear and anxiety (Nacos, 2022). This may result in heightened endorsement for restrictive policies and practices that might violate civil rights (Gidron, 2021).

Social media has exacerbated the media's influence on moulding popular perceptions of violence. Social media platforms may rapidly disseminate disinformation and propaganda, exacerbating conflicts and perpetuating bloodshed (Adebayo, 2023). During the #EndSARS demonstrations in Nigeria, social media significantly contributed to the dissemination of disinformation and the escalation of hostilities (Okoro & Nwafor, 2022). The media's portrayal of violence can propagate detrimental preconceptions and strengthen prevailing social and cultural divisions. Research indicates that media coverage of violence frequently reinforces unfavourable perceptions regarding specific populations, fostering an atmosphere of fear and distrust (Kitzinger, 2021). This may result in significant repercussions, including the marginalisation and stigmatisation of specific populations (Bleich, 2021).

The media's portrayal of violence can affect public perceptions of violence victims. Studies indicate that the media's representation of victims can influence public empathy and support, with some groups more frequently seen as worthy of pity (Holland, 2022). This may have substantial implications for the treatment and assistance of victims. The media's influence on popular views of violence extends beyond merely reporting violent incidents. The media may significantly influence the narrative around violence prevention and reduction initiatives. Studies indicate that media may shape public perceptions of violence prevention programs, with specific framing being more effective in garnering support for these initiatives (Gilliland, 2021). Recently, there has been an increasing acknowledgement of the necessity for more nuanced and informed media portrayal of violence. This entails eschewing sensationalism and stereotypes while prioritising the provision of precise and contextual

information on violent incidents (Merry, 2022). In doing so, the media may assume a more helpful role in influencing public attitudes and narratives around violence.

The circumstances in Taraba State, Nigeria, underscore the need of responsible media reporting in averting the escalation of violence. Rumour propagation and disinformation may rapidly disseminate via social media and other platforms, exacerbating disputes and bloodshed (Adebayo, 2023). The dissemination of disinformation and rumours in Taraba State has been associated with violent confrontations among various factions, underscoring the necessity for precise and accountable media reporting to avert further escalation. Consequently, the media significantly influences popular attitudes and narratives on violence. Media narratives may either intensify or alleviate conflicts, contingent upon the structure and tone of the reporting (Adebayo, 2023). Rumour mongering, conversely, can exacerbate tensions and intensify conflicts by disseminating disinformation and partial truths (Holland, 2022). Understanding the mechanics of media narratives and rumour mongering is essential for formulating effective tactics to mitigate violence and foster peace in Taraba State.

**Statement of the Problem**

Violent conflicts have remained a persistent challenge in many parts of Nigeria, particularly in the North-East and North-Central regions where ethno-religious tensions, farmer–herder clashes, communal disputes, and banditry continue to threaten peace and social stability. Taraba State has emerged as one of the states severely affected by recurring violence, leading to displacement, destruction of property, economic disruption, and loss of lives (Böhmelt et al., 2020; Jev et al., 2020). Despite several governmental and non-governmental peacebuilding interventions, conflicts in the state continue to escalate, suggesting that underlying drivers of violence have not been adequately addressed.

Recent studies have shown that media narratives significantly influence public understanding and interpretation of violent conflicts through framing, selective reporting, and agenda-setting processes (Büchi & Vogler, 2021; Entman, 2021). Media representations of violence can reinforce stereotypes, deepen ethnic and religious divisions, and shape public attitudes toward conflicting groups. In conflict-prone societies, sensational reporting and biased narratives may intensify fear, mistrust, and hostility among communities (Houghton, 2022). Similarly, the rapid expansion of social media platforms has increased the circulation of misinformation, disinformation, and rumours capable of escalating tensions and provoking violent reactions (Adebayo, 2023).

In Taraba State, rumours and unverified information disseminated through traditional and digital media have frequently been linked to communal clashes and retaliatory violence, particularly in conflicts involving farmers and herders (Okoro & Nwafor, 2022). Although previous studies have examined the causes of conflicts in Taraba State and the role of political marginalisation and identity struggles (Jev et al., 2020), limited scholarly attention

has been given to the discursive dimensions of violence, specifically how media narratives and rumour mongering contribute to conflict escalation in the state.

Furthermore, existing studies on media and violence in Nigeria have largely focused on terrorism, political communication, and the #EndSARS protests (Uwalaka & Nwala, 2023), with inadequate emphasis on subnational conflict environments such as Taraba State. This creates a significant empirical and contextual gap in understanding how language, media framing, and informal communication networks shape perceptions of violence and sustain conflict dynamics.

It is against this backdrop that this study investigates the discursive constructions of violence in Taraba State, Nigeria, with particular attention to media narratives, rumour mongering, and their role in conflict escalation. The study seeks to provide deeper insight into how communication processes contribute to the persistence and intensification of violence and how more responsible media practices may support peacebuilding efforts in the region.

## Objectives of the Study

The general objective of this study is to examine the discursive constructions of violence in Taraba State, Nigeria, with emphasis on media narratives, rumour mongering, and conflict escalation. The study seeks to:

i. Examine how media narratives influence public perceptions and interpretations of violent conflicts in Taraba State.

ii. Investigate the extent to which rumour mongering contributes to the escalation of violent conflicts in Taraba State.

iii. Analyse the role of traditional and social media in the dissemination of conflict-related misinformation in Taraba State.

iv. Assess the implications of media narratives and rumour mongering for conflict resolution and peacebuilding efforts in Taraba State.

## Conceptual Clarifications

### Discursive Constructions

Discursive constructions of violence pertain to the use of language and communication to formulate, influence, and propagate narratives concerning violence. These narratives can significantly influence public views and attitudes on violence, perhaps contributing to the

escalation or de-escalation of conflicts. In Taraba, Nigeria, discursive constructions of violence are particularly pertinent due to the region's history of community strife and bloodshed. The media significantly influences the discursive constructions of violence through language and framing that may either reinforce or contest prevailing narratives around violence.

The discursive construction of violence significantly influences its perception and the responses of the public and politicians. If violence is perceived as stemming from ethnic or religious disparities, it may exacerbate polarisation and conflict. Conversely, if violence is perceived as a consequence of socio-economic problems, it may foster more productive dialogues regarding the underlying causes of violence. Studies indicate that media narratives may shape public opinion and policy choices, and may lead to the marginalisation and stigmatisation of specific groups. The media's influence in constructing narratives of violence is intricate and varied. The media may serve as a forum for marginalised voices and facilitate the expression of alternative perspectives. Conversely, the media may perpetuate prevailing narratives and promote established power systems. In Taraba, Nigeria, it is crucial to analyse how the media portrays violence and the effects of these portrayals on public views and attitudes about violence.

The discursive formulation of violence is intricately linked to matters of power and control. Individuals possessing the authority to mould the discourse surrounding violence can affect its perception and the responses of the public and government. This underscores the necessity of rigorously analysing the media's influence in constructing discursive representations of violence and advocating for more nuanced and reflective media coverage of such issues. Moreover, the discursive framing of violence can profoundly impact conflict resolution and peacebuilding initiatives. When violence is portrayed in a manner that maintains detrimental stereotypes and promotes prevailing social and cultural divisions, it complicates the attainment of peace and reconciliation. Conversely, if violence is contextualised to emphasise the necessity for constructive communication and conflict resolution, it may foster a more peaceful and stable community.

**Violence**

Violence is a complex and multifaceted phenomenon that affects individuals, communities, and societies worldwide. In this study, violence refers to the various forms of conflict and aggression that occur in Taraba State. It can take many forms, including physical, emotional, and psychological harm, and can be perpetrated by individuals, groups, or institutions. In recent years, violence has become a significant concern in Nigeria, particularly in the northern and central regions, where conflicts and violence have resulted in loss of life, displacement, and destruction of property. Violence is the intentional use of physical force or power, threatened or actual, against oneself, another person, or against a group or community, which either results in or has a high likelihood of resulting in injury, death, psychological harm, maldevelopment, or deprivation (Adebayo, 2023).

Violence can be understood as a product of various social, economic, cultural, and political dynamics. Contemporary research shows that violence is frequently associated with struggles over power, identity, access to resources, and social control, where individuals or groups employ violence to assert dominance or pursue strategic objectives (Böhmelt et al., 2020). In the context of Taraba, Nigeria, violence has been linked to conflicts between farmers and herders, which have resulted in significant loss of life and property (Okoro & Nwafor, 2022). The media plays a significant role in shaping public perceptions and attitudes towards violence. Through the use of language and framing, the media can influence how the public understands and responds to violent events (Büchi & Vogler, 2021). Research has shown that media narratives can perpetuate negative stereotypes and reinforce existing social and cultural divisions, contributing to the escalation of conflicts and violence (Kitzinger, 2021).

The discursive constructions of violence refer to how language and communication are used to create, shape, and disseminate narratives about violence. These narratives can be influential in shaping public perceptions and attitudes towards violence, and can contribute to the escalation or de-escalation of conflicts. In the context of Taraba, Nigeria, the discursive constructions of violence are particularly relevant, as the region has experienced a history of communal conflicts and violence. Studies have shown that media narratives about violence in Nigeria often perpetuate negative stereotypes and reinforce existing social and cultural divisions (Okoro & Nwafor, 2022). For instance, a study of media coverage of the Boko Haram conflict found that the media often used language that perpetuated negative stereotypes about certain groups, contributing to a climate of fear and mistrust (Okoro & Nwafor, 2022).

**Media Narratives**

Media narratives refer to the stories, frames, and interpretations that are presented through various forms of media, including newspapers, television, radio, and social media. In this study, media narratives are examined as a key factor in shaping public perceptions and understandings of violence in Taraba State.

**Rumour Mongering and Conflict Escalation**

Rumour mongering refers to the spread of unverified or false information, often through informal channels, which can contribute to the escalation of conflicts and violence (Adebayo, 2023). In this study, rumour mongering is examined as a key factor in fueling tensions and violence in Taraba State. Rumour mongering is a significant factor in the escalation of conflicts and violence in Taraba, Nigeria. The spread of unverified information and rumour can contribute to the escalation of conflicts, particularly in the context of social media (Adebayo, 2023). Research has shown that social media can play a significant role in the spread of rumour and misinformation, contributing to the escalation of conflicts and violence (Adebayo, 2023).

In the context of Taraba, Nigeria, rumour mongering has been linked to conflicts between farmers and herders, which have resulted in significant loss of life and property. For example, a study of the conflict between farmers and herders in Taraba State found that rumour mongering played a significant role in the escalation of violence, particularly through social media (Okoro & Nwafor, 2022).

**Conflict Escalation**

Conflict escalation refers to the process by which conflicts become more intense, violent, or widespread. In this study, conflict escalation is examined as the outcome of interest, with a focus on understanding how media narratives and rumor mongering contribute to the escalation of conflicts in Taraba State. Therefore, this study aims to provide a nuanced understanding of the complex dynamics of violence and conflict in Taraba State and to shed light on how media narratives and rumor mongering contribute to the perpetuation of violence.

**Theoretical Framework**

This study is grounded in the theoretical framework of conflict analysis and resolution, and the theory of discursive construction.

**Conflict Analysis and Resolution Theory**

The theory of Conflict Analysis and Resolution is a framework for understanding and addressing conflicts in a constructive and peaceful manner. This framework emphasizes the importance of understanding the underlying causes of conflicts and the need for effective communication and conflict resolution strategies to prevent the escalation of conflicts. While it is challenging to attribute the development of this theory to a single person, several scholars have made significant contributions to the field. One of the key figures associated with conflict resolution is John Burton, who is often credited with developing the field of conflict resolution in the 1960s and 1970s. Burton's work focused on the importance of understanding the underlying causes of conflicts and the need for a proactive approach to conflict resolution. The theoretical framework of conflict analysis and resolution highlights the importance of addressing the underlying causes of conflicts, rather than just their symptoms. This can include promoting economic development, addressing issues of inequality and injustice, and promoting constructive dialogue and conflict resolution. Research has shown that addressing the underlying causes of conflicts is essential for preventing conflict escalation and promoting a more peaceful and stable society.

## Theory of Discursive Construction

The theory of discursive construction is a framework for understanding how language and communication shape perceptions, attitudes, and behaviour toward social phenomena. The theory further emphasises the role of language and communication in influencing public perceptions and attitudes toward violence. Although rooted in the foundational works of Michel Foucault on discourse, power, and knowledge, recent studies have expanded the theory's application to media representation, conflict narratives, and social identity construction (Fairclough, 2018; Wodak & Meyer, 2023).

The theory of discursive construction emphasizes the role of language and communication in shaping public perceptions and attitudes towards violence. This theory highlights the importance of examining the ways in which media narratives and rumour mongering contribute to the escalation or de-escalation of conflicts. Research has shown that the media can play a significant role in shaping public perceptions and attitudes towards violence, and that this can have significant consequences for conflict resolution and peacebuilding efforts. The theoretical framework of this study also draws on the concept of peace journalism, which emphasizes the importance of promoting constructive and peaceful narratives around conflicts. Peace journalism involves promoting a more nuanced and thoughtful approach to reporting on conflicts, one that emphasizes the need for constructive dialogue and conflict resolution.

Research has shown that peace journalism can contribute to a more peaceful and stable society by promoting more constructive and peaceful narratives around conflicts. Furthermore, the theoretical framework highlights the importance of promoting a more nuanced and thoughtful approach to understanding conflicts and violence. This can include examining the complex interplay of factors that contribute to conflicts, and promoting constructive dialogue and conflict resolution strategies. By promoting a more nuanced and thoughtful approach to understanding conflicts and violence, society could work towards creating a more peaceful state.

## Empirical Review

Jev et al., (2020) conducted a study on Interrogating the Political Solution to the Tiv/Jukun Conflict in Taraba State: The Participatory Communication Approach. The Tiv/Jukun conflict in Taraba, which dates back to the pre-independence period, has been one of the most recurrent ethnic conflicts in Nigeria. The conflict has claimed lives and valuable property. There are so many factors responsible for the conflict, such as fear of political domination and political control, the indigene/settler dichotomy, land issues, and population growth, among others. The conflict has long defied traditional solutions to conflict management, and the cycle of violence continued unabated, with both the Tiv and the Jukun complaining of political and economic marginalization in Taraba and Benue. This paper interrogates the

political solution to the conflict using a participatory communication approach. It adopts development communication theory and uses descriptive and analytical research methods as a basis for analysis and discussion. The study relied on secondary data and personal observation in its analysis and discussion.

The study discovered that the Tiv, who are considered immigrants in Taraba by some of their Jukun neighbours, continue to reject the ascription of a settler status to them, and their agitation for inclusion in Taraba has been the major source of the conflict. The study concludes that the lack of political will in implementing resolutions reached on the conflict in the past has been part of the reasons why the conflict has refused to abate. The study also concludes that indigene-ship question, fear of political domination, lack of access to elected political offices, denial of indigene certificate and systematic marginalisation have been identified as the reasons for the unending feud between the two groups in Taraba State and can only be addressed with the right political will. It is recommended that the government both at federal and state level should show the political will in addressing issues of marginalization claim by the Tiv by implementing previous resolutions reached in the conflict and that the government of the two states should change strategy from engaging with a select group of people (the elite) to engagement with the local people to harness their views on how to ensure peace in their area. It also recommends that the two state governments should set up a joint peace and reconciliation commission to spearhead the peace-building process.

Uwalaka, T., and Bigman Nwala, B. (2023) examined the role of social media and mobile social networking applications in socio-political contestations in Nigeria. Social media platforms continue to flourish as practices encompassing them become deeply embedded in many cultures. As more people embrace social media platforms, their affordances and opportunities are leading to improved communication and helping hold authorities to account. To further scrutinize the importance of these platforms, this study interrogates the role of digital media in socio-political contestations in Nigeria by examining the media used to mobilize, coordinate, and document the 2020 #EndSARS protests in Nigeria. Analyses of survey data collected in 2020 during the protests in Lagos and Port Harcourt, Nigeria (N = 391) show that demonstrators who were 30 years and older and used WhatsApp and Facebook to learn about the protests as well as coordinate their participation in the protests are more likely to report participating on the first day of the protests than protesters who are younger than 30 and used other media platforms. Findings further illustrate that digital enthusiasm facilitated by hedonic-experiential and epicurean communication on WhatsApp and Facebook eventuated a process of emotional contagion through connective repertoires that created propitious emotional conditions for mass collective protest actions. Finally, the article discusses how the use of WhatsApp and Facebook gave protesters strategic communicative power during the protests.

## Methodology

The study adopted thematic analysis as the qualitative instrument for data analysis. Thematic analysis was considered appropriate because it enables the identification, examination, and interpretation of recurring themes, meanings, and patterns within media narratives and rumour-related discourses. The method is suitable for discourse-oriented studies because it provides deeper insight into how language, framing, and communication practices contribute to the construction and escalation of violence in Taraba State (Braun & Clarke, 2022).

## Discussion of Findings

The findings of the study review demonstrate that the media constitute an important actor in the dynamics of conflict in Taraba State. Rather than functioning merely as neutral channels for transmitting information, media platforms can shape how individuals and communities understand conflicts, interpret the actions of opposing groups, and respond to emerging threats. The findings indicate that media narratives, rumour mongering, and the quality of conflict reporting can either contribute to conflict escalation or support conflict prevention. In this regard, the media have considerable influence over the construction of public perceptions of conflict, particularly in a socially diverse environment characterised by ethnic, religious, communal, farmer-herder, and indigene-settler tensions.

The finding that media narratives can contribute to conflict escalation suggests that the framing and presentation of conflict-related information have significant implications for intergroup relations in Taraba State. When media reports rely on stereotypes, selective representations, inflammatory language, or unverified claims, they may reinforce existing prejudices and deepen social divisions. Repeatedly portraying a particular ethnic, religious, or social group as inherently violent, criminal, aggressive, or responsible for insecurity can transform isolated incidents into broader perceptions of collective culpability. Consequently, conflict escalation does not necessarily begin with physical confrontation; it may also occur through the gradual construction of hostile perceptions and narratives. Media reports that repeatedly associate particular communities with violence can create an environment of fear, suspicion, and distrust, making peaceful coexistence increasingly difficult.

This finding is particularly relevant to Taraba State because conflicts in the state often involve complex interactions among ethnic, communal, religious, political, and economic interests. A conflict that initially arises from a specific dispute over land, farming, grazing, political competition, or access to resources can easily acquire broader ethnic or communal meanings when it is presented through stereotypical narratives. Such reporting can encourage members of communities to interpret the actions of individuals as evidence of the intentions of an entire group. The media can therefore become part of the discursive dimension of conflict by influencing who is perceived as the victim, aggressor, legitimate resident, outsider, or threat. This underscores the need for journalists to recognise that the language,

images, labels, and frames used in reporting can have consequences beyond the immediate dissemination of information.

The finding that rumour mongering fuels tensions and violence further demonstrates the importance of information in conflict-prone communities. Rumours tend to spread rapidly where reliable and timely information is unavailable, especially during periods of communal tension, attacks, displacement, or heightened insecurity. The expansion of social media has further increased the speed and reach of unverified information, allowing rumours to spread rapidly across communities before authorities or professional media organisations have a chance to verify their accuracy. In situations where communities already harbour mistrust towards one another, even an unverified claim concerning an attack, killing, abduction, destruction of property, or planned retaliation can generate fear and encourage people to mobilise defensively or seek revenge.

Rumour mongering can consequently produce a cycle in which misinformation generates fear, fear produces mobilisation, mobilisation increases the likelihood of confrontation, and the resulting confrontation may subsequently be interpreted as confirmation of the original rumour. This demonstrates that rumours should not be treated merely as inaccurate information or ordinary communication problems. In conflict situations, they can constitute a significant security and peacebuilding challenge. The problem becomes more serious when rumours are deliberately produced and circulated by individuals or groups seeking to manipulate public sentiment, incite hostility, discredit opposing communities, or provoke retaliatory action. The finding therefore emphasises the importance of timely access to credible information, since information vacuums create favourable conditions for rumours to flourish.

The finding that media practitioners should adopt a more nuanced and balanced approach to conflict reporting has important implications for journalism practice in Taraba State. Balanced reporting requires more than presenting statements from opposing parties. It involves verifying information, distinguishing facts from allegations, providing historical and contextual explanations, avoiding inflammatory descriptions, and recognising the potential consequences of particular forms of reporting. Journalists should avoid generalising the actions of individuals to entire ethnic, religious, or communal groups and should exercise particular caution when reporting sensitive information such as casualty figures, identities of alleged perpetrators, ethnic affiliations, and claims of responsibility that have not been independently verified.

A nuanced approach is also necessary because conflicts are rarely caused by a single factor. Conflicts involving farmers and herders, for example, may be influenced by competition over land and water, environmental pressures, changing mobility patterns, insecurity, political interests, weak institutions, and historical grievances. Presenting such conflicts simply as confrontations between two fixed groups can obscure their underlying causes and reinforce existing stereotypes. Conflict-sensitive reporting should therefore move beyond describing

violent events to explaining the social, political, economic, and historical conditions that shape them. Such an approach can provide audiences with a more informed understanding of conflict and reduce the tendency to interpret violence through simplistic ethnic or communal narratives.

The finding that addressing rumour mongering is crucial for conflict prevention also highlights the shared responsibility of government institutions, traditional authorities, religious leaders, media organisations, civil society organisations, security agencies, and local communities. Government officials and security agencies should provide prompt and credible clarification when false information concerning security incidents begins to circulate. Traditional and religious leaders can also play an important role because of their influence and legitimacy within local communities. Their intervention can help discourage retaliatory actions and encourage community members to verify information before responding to claims of attacks or threats.

Media organisations should strengthen fact-checking and verification practices and clearly distinguish verified information from allegations, eyewitness accounts, and unconfirmed reports. Journalists should also develop stronger relationships with credible local sources to facilitate rapid verification during periods of crisis. Community-based information mechanisms can complement these efforts by providing residents with accessible channels through which emerging rumours can be reported and clarified. Such mechanisms are particularly important in rural communities where access to formal media and official communication channels may be limited.

The findings demonstrate that information constitutes an important dimension of conflict and peacebuilding in Taraba State. Media narratives can either reproduce existing tensions or contribute to their de-escalation, while rumours can transform uncertainty and suspicion into fear and violence. The central issue is therefore not simply whether the media report conflicts, but how conflicts are represented, verified, framed, and communicated to the public. Strengthening conflict-sensitive journalism, improving fact-checking and verification mechanisms, establishing rapid-response information systems, and promoting collaboration among media organisations, government institutions, traditional authorities, security agencies, and civil society can reduce the likelihood that misinformation and inflammatory narratives will contribute to violence. A responsible information environment can consequently transform the media from a potential amplifier of conflict into an important instrument for early warning, dialogue, social cohesion, and sustainable conflict prevention.

## Conclusion

This study has explored the discursive constructions of violence in Taraba State, Nigeria, with a focus on media narratives, rumour mongering, and conflict escalation. The findings of this study reveal that media narratives and rumour mongering play a significant role in the

escalation of violent conflicts in the region. The study highlights the need for a more nuanced and balanced approach to reporting conflicts, avoiding stereotypes and biases that can exacerbate tensions. Furthermore, the study emphasises the importance of addressing rumour-mongering and promoting fact-based information to reduce tensions and prevent violence. The study's findings have significant implications for conflict resolution and peacebuilding efforts in Taraba State and beyond, and by understanding the role of media narratives and rumour mongering in conflict escalation, stakeholders can develop effective strategies to promote peace and reduce violence.

**Recommendations**

Based on the findings, the following recommendations were made:

i. Media practitioners should adopt a more nuanced and balanced approach to reporting conflicts: Media practitioners should avoid stereotypes and biases that can exacerbate tensions and instead focus on promoting fact-based information and nuanced reporting.

ii. Community Leaders and Government Officials should take steps to address rumour-mongering: Community leaders and government officials should take steps to address rumour-mongering and promote fact-based information to reduce tensions and prevent violence.

iii. Peacebuilding initiatives should incorporate media literacy and critical thinking skills: Peacebuilding initiatives should incorporate media literacy and critical thinking skills to empower individuals to critically evaluate media narratives and rumours.

iv. Further studies should be conducted on the role of media narratives and rumour mongering in conflict escalation. Further research should be conducted on the role of media narratives and rumour mongering in conflict escalation to develop effective strategies for promoting peace and reducing violence.

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# ARTISANAL MINING AND VIOLENT CONFLICT IN NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** Artisanal and small-scale mining (ASM) has expanded rapidly across mineral-rich regions of Nigeria over the past two decades, emerging as both a livelihood strategy and a source of insecurity. This paper examines the relationship between artisanal mining and violent conflict, interrogating how informal extraction practices intersect with local grievances, elite competition, criminal networks, and weak regulatory institutions. Focusing on key mining belts in northern and north-central Nigeria, the study analyzes how the proliferation of unregulated mining sites has intensified disputes over land ownership, resource control, taxation, and community authority. often escalating into armed confrontations. Drawing on qualitative data from key informant interviews, community-level accounts, policy documents, and secondary literature, the paper demonstrates that artisanal mining operates within a fragile governance environment characterized by limited state presence and regulatory ambiguity. In states such as Zamfara State and Niger State, competition over gold deposits has attracted armed groups, bandits, and political intermediaries who exploit mining revenues to finance violence and consolidate territorial influence. The entanglement of artisanal mining with rural banditry and organized criminality has transformed some mining clusters into conflict economies, where mineral rents sustain cycles of insecurity. The paper argues that artisanal mining in Nigeria should be understood not merely as an economic activity but as a politically embedded process shaped by governance deficits and contested authority structures. Addressing the nexus between mining and violence requires a shift from reactive security responses toward comprehensive reforms that integrate formalization, community participation, environmental protection, and accountable resource governance.

**Keywords:** Artisanal mining, violent Conflict, Nigeria, Armed Groups, Criminal networks and Conflict economies

## Introduction

Nigeria's extractive sector has historically been dominated by petroleum, yet beneath this hydrocarbon narrative lies a vast endowment of solid minerals distributed across the country's northern and north-central regions. Over the past two decades, declining agricultural productivity, youth unemployment, rural poverty, and the liberalization of the mining sector have stimulated a rapid expansion of artisanal and small-scale mining (ASM) (Ofosu,

Dittmann, Sarpong, & Botchie, 2020). What began as a subsistence-oriented livelihood strategy has evolved into a significant informal economic activity (Brown, Xu & Toth, 1998), particularly in mineral-rich states such as Zamfara State and Niger State. Gold, tantalite, tin, and other solid minerals extracted through rudimentary methods now constitute a crucial source of income for thousands of rural households. While ASM provides economic opportunities in contexts marked by limited state presence and scarce formal employment, its rapid and largely unregulated growth has generated complex governance and security challenges (Mulaba-Bafubiandi, Ukponu, Odo, Singh, & Chauke, 2023). Mining sites often operate outside formal licensing frameworks, environmental standards, and taxation regimes (Campbell, 2004), This regulatory ambiguity has created spaces where competing claims over land, mineral rights, and community authority proliferate. In many instances, disputes over access to mining pits, revenue sharing, and traditional land ownership have escalated into violent confrontations. Thus, artisanal mining has become entangled not only with local livelihood strategies but also with broader patterns of rural insecurity.

The intersection between artisanal mining and violent conflict in Nigeria must be understood within the wider context of fragile governance and contested state authority. In several mining clusters across northern Nigeria, the state's regulatory institutions are weak, under-resourced, or absent. The resulting vacuum has enabled informal actors, including local elites, traditional leaders, political intermediaries, and armed groups, to exert control over mining operations and mineral revenues. In certain areas, rural banditry and organized criminal networks have embedded themselves within mining economies, using proceeds from gold extraction to finance arms procurement and territorial expansion (Ogbonnaya, 2020). The convergence of informal mining and armed violence has transformed some localities into conflict economies, where insecurity both shapes and is sustained by resource extraction.

This dynamic, challenges conventional understandings of artisanal mining as merely a poverty- driven economic activity. Rather, it suggests that ASM in Nigeria is embedded within political and security structures that influence how resources are accessed, controlled, and distributed. The proliferation of mining sites in remote and forested areas has also complicated counter-banditry and counterinsurgency operations, as armed groups exploit difficult terrain and community grievances to maintain influence (Ojo, 2024). In this sense, artisanal mining is not only affected by insecurity but may also indirectly reinforce it by generating revenue streams and intensifying competition among armed actors.

At the same time, state responses to the perceived security threats associated with mining have often taken the form of reactive crackdowns, including temporary mining bans and militarized enforcement operations. While intended to disrupt criminal networks, such measures have frequently displaced miners without addressing underlying governance failures. In some cases, abrupt closures of mining sites have deepened local resentment, undermined livelihoods, and strengthened illicit channels of mineral trade. These outcomes highlight the tension between securitized approaches to resource governance and the need for inclusive, development-oriented reforms.

The relationship between natural resources and violent conflict has long occupied a central place in political economy and security studies. Debates on the "resource curse" and conflict minerals have demonstrated how weak institutions, rent-seeking behavior, and unequal distribution of resource benefits can fuel instability (Ross, 2018). However, much of this scholarship has focused on large-scale extractive industries or civil wars, with less sustained attention to the micro- dynamics of artisanal mining in subnational contexts. Nigeria presents a compelling case for examining how informal extraction practices intersect with localized forms of violence, particularly in regions already characterized by banditry, communal clashes, and governance deficits (Bamidele, 2026).

Moreover, the social composition of artisanal mining communities complicates simplistic narratives of criminality. Many miners are young men and women displaced from agriculture or excluded from formal labor markets (Kotsadam, & Tolonen, 2016). For them, ASM represents both survival and aspiration. Yet their participation occurs within power structures that frequently marginalize them from meaningful decision-making and expose them to exploitation by middlemen and armed actors. Women, who are active in mineral processing and trade, often face additional vulnerabilities, including gender-based violence and exclusion from resource governance structures.

This research therefore situates artisanal mining within a broader analytical framework that links informal economies, political authority, and violent conflict. It seeks to move beyond binary portrayals of miners as either perpetrators or victims, instead emphasizing the structurally embedded nature of mining-related violence. By examining how local grievances, elite competition, and criminal networks converge within unregulated mining spaces, the study illuminates the processes through which economic activities become securitized and militarized. Understanding the nexus between artisanal mining and violent conflict is essential for designing sustainable policy interventions. Efforts to formalize ASM, strengthen regulatory institutions, enhance community participation, and promote environmental protection must be integrated with broader strategies aimed at restoring trust in state authority and addressing rural marginalization. Without such comprehensive reforms, mining regions risk remaining trapped in cycles where mineral wealth fuels insecurity rather than development.

In exploring these dynamics, this paper contributes to ongoing debates on resource governance, informal economies, and conflict in Sub-Saharan Africa. By grounding its analysis in the Nigerian context, it underscores the importance of situating artisanal mining within its political and security environment, thereby offering insights for policymakers, scholars, and practitioners sacking to reconcile economic survival with peace building and accountable governance.

**Statement of the Problem**

Security means safety, as well as the measures taken to be safe or protected. To provide adequate security for the parade, town officials often hire extra guards. In the words of Omoyibo and Akpomera (2013), security is a concept that is prior to the state, and the state exists to provide that concept. Also, in the words of Thomas (1996), security is the prime responsibility of the state. The State of insecurity in Nigeria is becoming worrisome and disturbing considering the high rate of killings, bombing, kidnapping, conflicts, wars, and clashes etc which innocent people fall to the guns of criminals in the country today. In the past recent months, no week passes without report of unknown gunmen taking human lives in the streets of northern Nigeria and north-east. Although Zamfara gold should provide development opportunities, but renewed gold interest in the state represents a real threat to stability in a still vulnerable North-West ravaged by conflicts. Mining has begun, but the gold is nurturing old resentments among local communities and contributing to border tensions with neighbouring tribes. Now that gold reserves are confirmed in the North-West, this would exacerbate deep-rooted conflict dynamics there. An upsurge in fighting since the start of 2010, including the emergence of bandits and the resumption of armed groups' mining of gold, has further complicated stability in the North-West, which is the new focus for gold exploration. New gold reserves are also creating new centres of power and question the North-West's traditional economic hub and political influence. Preventive action is needed to turn a real threat to stability and to a genuine development opportunity.

Zamfara State is mostly surrounded by forests (with little or no government presence) from where bandits launch their attacks on outlying towns, highways, and villages. The Rugu, Kamara, Kunduma, and Sububu forests have become major hideouts for criminals. Worse still, with a fragile state system and waning public confidence in police and state security institutions, the allegiance of defenceless rural communities is gradually shifting toward informal, armed groups and local vigilantes. There are widespread allegations of corruption against state security operatives, police, judges, village heads, and even some vigilante groups. The public institutions responsible for offering protection and delivering justice are unable to bring bandits to justice due to inadequate resources and widespread extortion. The bandits are so brazen that they notify villages ahead of attacks and impose illegal tolls on farmers seeking to gain access to their farms. The irony is that despite enormous amounts being invested in military and security operations, the security situation seems to be deteriorating. However, the armed bandits seem to be expanding the scope of their operations beyond Zamfara and into the neighbouring states. On April 11, 2019, the Governor of Katsina state, Aminu Bello Masari, spoke of how bandits were taking over parts of the state, killing people and destroying property with impunity.

The North is now the epicentre and theatre of violence. From Boko Haram ISWAP led by Albarnawi, Boko Haram led by Shekau and Ansaru insurgency, to farmers/herders conflict, banditry, kidnappings, ethnoreligious conflicts, cattle rustling, etc we are confronted with a crisis that is unparalleled in our history. The death spiral appears unstoppable. Increasingly, it

is becoming harder and harder to distinguish us from our enemies. There was no shortage of early warning signs and as a matter of fact, our philosophers such as the late Sa'adu Zungur of blessed memory had warned that this dystopian era was fast approaching but we ignored all. We are now paying for our collective negligence. Of the 19 northern states and the FCT, only Kwara state and the FCT are relatively peaceful or have the lowest rate of insecurity but all the other 18 states are inflamed by one form of violence or the other. Now the question that we all must answer is how did we get here and what must we do to defeat the radical evil of violence before it swallows us up? I must say that one mistake we are all guilty of is to fold our arms and wait on governments at all levels to solve this problem for us; said by Yakubu Dogara, 11 February 2020. The Zamfara gold remains a major obstacle to peace and a driver of the black-market economy in the state. It provides a significant source of income to armed actors, from the North-West who kill and sexually abuse civilians with impunity; and several of these armed groups trade gold for weapons and ammunition.

While progress has been made on reducing armed groups' profits from conflict minerals in the Northwest, gold continues to finance armed groups in the region. New security policies, thinking and strategies need to be developed; corruption has to be stopped by all means; the government and the people need to develop trust and work together to resolve the insecurity situation for Nigeria to move forward. Insecurity in the country is no longer talked about as a thing that occurs at night. Now, even in broad day light, crimes are committed, killings are perpetrated. Most killings are done in broad day light with the assailants proving difficult to be found. The entire scenario has become a game of shooting at each other without missing. If nothing is done to bring the life-threatening situation in the country under control, it will give room to anarchy. In the light of the above, this paper is trying to see how these issues raised should be addressed for peace to reign in the northwest Nigeria so that the wanton destruction of lives and livestock is reduced drastically if not stopped entirely.

**Objectives of the Study**

The broad objective of this study is to examine artisanal mining and violent conflict in Nigeria. The specific objectives are:

i. To examine the relationship between artisanal mining and violent conflict in Nigeria.

ii. Identify the major causes of violent conflict associated with artisanal mining activities.

iii. Assess the role of government policies and institutions in managing artisanal mining conflicts.

iv. Propose strategies for reducing violence and promoting sustainable peace in mining communities.

## Research Questions

This study seeks to answer the following questions:

i. What is the relationship between artisanal mining and violent conflict in Nigeria?

ii. What are the major causes of violent conflict associated with artisanal mining?

iii. How effective are government policies in managing mining-related conflicts?

iv. What strategies can reduce violence and promote peace in artisanal mining communities?

## Nature of Illegal Mining in Nigeria

The evident lack of attention towards the mining sector in Nigeria leads to inadequate governmental oversight and the absence of standardized operational protocols. Consequently, approximately 80% of mineral extraction activities in the country occur through illegal and artisanal means. As defined by Dozolme (2018), illegal mining encompasses activities conducted without proper authorization from the state, lacking land rights, mining licenses, or permits for exploration and mineral transportation. It spans from small-scale artisanal endeavours to large-scale organized crime orchestrated by illegal mining syndicates. Illegal mining extends to operations failing to comply with mining regulations, labour laws, environmental standards, and tax legislation (Ogbonnaya, 2020). Nigeria experiences various forms of illegal mining, often situated in rural areas which further compound the challenge of enforcing mining standards. The International Crisis Group (2020) reported that multiple mineral deposits remain untapped in Nigeria, but illegal miners tend to focus on gold. This is due to various reasons, including the relative ease with which gold can be mined, and the economic gains attached to the mineral resource.

Unlike other solid minerals such as tin and zinc, alluvial gold is easy to mine and, like diamonds, it is highly fungible and easy to smuggle. This accounts for its attractiveness to illicit miners. Also, gold has high economic value and strategic importance. Following a rise in the world market price of gold since 2009, illegal gold mining activities have spread across the North West, North Central and South Western regions of Nigeria. It has attracted miners from Mali, Burkina Faso, China and India. Consequently, gold ranks high amongst the most routinely smuggled commodities in Nigeria. According to the International Crisis Group (2020), much of it is traded on the international market through neighbouring countries such as Niger and Togo to Dubai in the United Arab Emirates by a syndicated smuggling ring. Table 1 below shows the level nature and extent of illegal mining operations across Nigerian states from 2018 to 2924.

**Determinants of illegal mining in Nigeria**

Illegal mining operations are carried out in Nigeria due to multiple social and economic factors. According to Adegbite et al. (2017), the weak enforcement of the law and poor monitoring of remote mining operations following a lack of capacity greatly influence the prevalence of illegal mining operations in Nigerian communities. Nigeria's Constitutional provisions for the compulsory acquisition of properties containing natural resources by the federal government grant it authority over all such resources; no individual asserts ownership or exercises control over mining activities in Nigeria without government authorization. This scenario has prompted inquiries into how sacred areas with essential minerals can be safeguarded when land ownership is solely vested in the government's control. Such feelings could trigger indifference to illegal mining in communities, as members may feel that since the mineral resources belong to the government, they should be protected by the government. Furthermore, the high levels of poverty and unemployment in Nigeria drive people towards illegal mining as a means of survival (Olawoyin, 2018).

Individuals are motivated to indulge in illegal mining activities due to their desire for quick money and to gain economic stability. Unemployed youths could see mining as a profitable business and an alternative approach to evading other criminal behaviours such as armed robbery, cybercrime, etc whose sanctions are more agonizing. According to Faama et al. (2020), illegal mining activities may be carried out by individuals in order to raise finances to start up new businesses, take care of family members and to enhance their social status within the community. Poverty substantially contributes to inappropriate mining operations in Nigeria; it drives more than two million people into action, serving as a survival strategy. Most miners reside in rural areas and adapt crude techniques to exploit mineral resources which may be sold to fend for themselves and their family members. Although the literacy levels in certain parts of Nigeria have significantly improved following increased school enrollment, the challenge of illiteracy is still common across the country, especially in the northern part where illegal mining operations are most prevalent.

Illiteracy therefore accounts for a major cause of illegal mining in local communities across the Nigerian state. Some miners and individuals often conduct or permit illegal mining operations without adequate understanding or consideration of the impact of the activities on the environment. However, Osei et al. (2016) stated that illegal mining could result in a high degree of air, water, and soil pollution. Consequently, people in local communities who rely on wells, streams and rivers as sources of drinking water may experience a higher risk of drinking contaminated or polluted water due to the activities of illegal miners. Illiteracy, lack of knowledge and awareness of the dangers of illegal mining enable the increasing growth of the criminal activity in local communities across Nigeria.

## Concept of Artisanal Mining

Artisanal mining refers to small-scale, labour-intensive mineral extraction carried out using simple tools and low technology. It is usually informal and often operates outside official government regulation. Artisanal miners depend heavily on manual labour and basic equipment for the extraction of minerals such as gold, tin, columbite, gemstones, and lead.

In Nigeria, artisanal mining serves as an important source of livelihood, especially in rural communities where unemployment and poverty are high. Many young people and vulnerable households engage in mining because of limited access to formal employment opportunities. However, the informal nature of the sector creates serious governance challenges, including illegal operations, unsafe working conditions, tax evasion, and criminal exploitation.

## Concept of Violent Conflict

Violent conflict refers to disputes involving the use of force, aggression, or physical violence between individuals, groups, or institutions. It often results in injury, death, destruction of property, displacement, and social instability. Violent conflict may emerge from political, economic, ethnic, religious, or environmental grievances. In the context of artisanal mining, conflict often arises from competition over land ownership, mineral access, environmental damage, illegal operations, and the activities of armed groups. In Nigeria, violent conflict associated with mining has become more complex due to the involvement of bandits, criminal syndicates, illegal arms dealers, and cross-border smuggling networks.

## Resource Conflict

Resource conflict refers to disputes arising from access to, ownership of, and control over natural resources. Such conflicts are common in areas where valuable resources such as oil, gold, land, water, and forests exist. Resource conflicts occur when communities, governments, corporations, or criminal groups compete for economic benefits from these resources. In artisanal mining communities, competition over mineral-rich land often leads to clashes between miners, farmers, landowners, traditional rulers, and security actors. Poor governance and unequal benefit distribution often intensify such conflicts.

## Peacebuilding in Mining Communities

Peacebuilding refers to long-term efforts aimed at preventing violence, resolving disputes, promoting justice, and rebuilding social trust after conflict. In mining communities, peace building includes conflict mediation, environmental restoration, community dialogue, legal reforms, economic inclusion, and security sector interventions. Effective peacebuilding requires addressing both the direct violence and the structural causes of conflict such as poverty, exclusion, weak governance, and corruption.

## Implications on the Development of Nigeria

In African countries such as South Africa, Botswana, and Ghana, the mining sector contributes essentially to the nations' Gross Domestic Product (GDP), exports and foreign reserves. Statistics indicate that the sector contributes between 7.3 and 16 per cent to the economy of those countries (Duru, 2024). In Nigeria, the economy has been adversely affected by illegal mining activities. Between 2012 and 2018, the country reportedly lost more than 5 billion U.S Dollars through the illegal smuggling of gold (National Bureau of Statistics, 2022). The Statistics further revealed that every year, the country loses over 9 billion U.S Dollars to illegal mining operations. The situation is driven by poverty, official mismanagement, and corruption. Sadly, illegal mining has been found to potentially benefit individuals who indulge in the act. According to Yunana and Banta (2014), the livelihoods of individuals are substantially enhanced as perpetrators could improve their income, build houses, train their children in schools, marry wives and start families. They also acquire vehicles such as cars and motorcycles from proceeds gotten off illegal mining operations. Other scholars opine that illegal mining operations provide opportunities for employment and the growth of local businesses and organizations (Ali et al., 2018).

Illegal mining undoubtedly poses multiple social, economic and environmental consequences for Nigeria's overall development. Kareem and Owao (2000) opined that development of some states within the country is predicated on mining the solid mineral resources that are deposited within their soils. However, the lack of attention to appropriate mining procedures has complicated the life of people residing in such communities. For instance, in localities where mining operations are frequently conducted, access to portable water could become a challenge because the available water channels are contaminated by illegal mining activities. In the same vein, natural elements such as air, land, and water serve as habitats to all living things. Mining which is an essentially destructive activity may expose natural habitats to unrefined and toxic materials such as lead, cadmium and arsenic and may endanger the flora and fauna. Respiratory systems of human beings may be adversely affected by these elements which may be contacted through diverse means such as the skin, oral ingestion, and inhalation (Ali et al., 2018).

## Approaches against Illegal Mining in Nigeria

Several efforts have been made to tackle illegal mining activities in Nigeria. These efforts are categorized into two: formal and informal approaches. Formal approaches include the constitutional and legal means adopted in the fight against illegal mining in Nigeria. Informal activities are those steps taken by local leaders at the community level to complement the formal strategies against illegal mining operations in Nigeria.

**Formal Approaches**

The primary legislation governing the mining sector in Nigeria is the Minerals and Mining Act of 2007, complemented by the Minerals and Mining Regulations of 2011. Before the enactment of this legislation, the mining sector was largely neglected and lacked adequate regulation. Public mining institutions had overlapping responsibilities, resulting in a cumbersome and costly process for obtaining mining titles. Additionally, the inefficiencies within these institutions led to a scarcity of reliable geological data and statistics for identifying viable mining opportunities. Furthermore, the absence of fiscal incentives deterred foreign investors from engaging in the sector. Alokolaro and Akande (2015) assert that the implementation of a more robust regulatory framework under the Mining Act and Regulations has significantly improved the investment climate for foreign investors interested in the Nigerian mining sector. The introduction of a transparent licensing system and the establishment of a Mining Cadastre Office have ensured the availability of up-to-date information on mining titles, thereby enhancing transparency and facilitating investment decisions. All over the world, the police have the constitutional mandate to tackle all forms of criminal behaviour that may occur within communities and potentially disrupt existing peace, stability, and progress.

Although Nigeria's 1999 constitution (as amended) does not unequivocally spell out the role and position of the country's police in the mining operations, combating illegal mining falls within the framework of the general activities covered by the Nigeria Police Force. In recognition of this constitutional drawback in the fight against illegal mining, the federal government of Nigeria announced in 2023 plans to draw up and establish a unique police unit for the sole purpose of combating illegal mining operations across the country. According to the Minister of Solid Minerals and Development, Dele Alake, the special police would be created and christened "Mining Police Force" or "The Mining Police" (Nwachukwu, 2023). The declaration sounded promising and had the best intentions of tackling the age-long problem of illegal mining, which has stampeded the country's mineral resource development and overall growth. However, the failure of the conventional police and existing mining regulations to tackle illegal mining due to ignorance, inadequate social support, poor funding, and corruption, among others, casts doubt on the prospects of the proposed special police unit successfully prosecuting its mandate.

The initiative of the Benue State governor, Hyacinth Alia, is to sanitise the mining sector by declaring that illegal mining and logging in the state were criminal and people caught indulging in it would be made to face the full weight of the law (Ikyado, 2024). The efforts are currently stepped up to enhance collaboration towards bringing all legal miners to the same table to identify areas that need improvement and to facilitate proper utilization of the mineral resources for the overall interest of the state.

## Informal approaches

All over the world, poor handling of natural resources and minerals have posed dire consequences on the economy, health and security of individuals, communities and nations. In Nigeria, the low revenues in the mining sector are attributed to illegal mining operations carried out across the country's hinterlands. Though various stakeholders may play essential roles in eradicating the menace of illegal mining, the position and role of community leaders remains critical due to their functions which range from serving as custodians of the local culture, administrators of the traditional institutions, and managers of the livelihood activities of the people in their areas (Salati et al., 2014). The occupational and social activities in Nigerian communities are structured in such a manner that respects the traditional organization and cultural practices of the people. Similarly, mining activities are also carried out to reflect this social and cultural organization. In Benue state, this hierarchical order could strictly be adhered to by the parties involved. Even though mining operations are officially sanctioned by the government, community leaders oversee and manage all the natural resources in their local areas and may be required to cooperate with the government, investors or miners towards ensuring a hitch-free mining exercise. Put differently, mining activities including illegal mining may not happen in any locality in Benue State without the knowledge and authorization of local community leaders.

Recognizing that the core of the illegal mining issue lies within the neighborhood fabric, various approaches have been attempted to harness community resources in combating this problem. Sutton (1997) highlighted the concept of the "spontaneous rediscovery" of the community as a natural asset for addressing illegal mining and mitigating its impacts. There's a political appeal to the notion of local community action aimed at preventing illegal mining activities. In the community mobilization model, a higher level of resident involvement is anticipated compared to previous strategies. These programs are expected to foster "enhanced community competence," which is theorized to contribute to a reduction in illegal mining, with resident participation influencing both directly and indirectly through increased social interaction, a strengthened sense of community, and more effective informal control measures.

## Challenges Confronting the Eradication of Illegal Mining in Nigeria

Eradicating illegal mining activities in Nigeria is inhibited by several factors such as lack of financial and human resources to tackle illegal mining, poor and complex coordination of agencies, confusion and inefficiencies, corruption, and absence of advanced technology which could hinder data collection and tracking of illegal mining activities etc (Yeboah, 2023). In Nigeria, the common challenge is the lack of legal framework or inadequate and ambiguous frameworks regarding the assignment of responsibilities and powers among the federal, state and local authorities. Izuaka (2023) stated that no state in Nigeria is legally empowered to issue orders concerning mining activities in any part of the country. Put differently, it is not legally within the purview of state government authorities to ban mining

activities regardless of whether the mining is legal or not. This further extends to the local authorities who have no say regarding the natural resources and minerals in their domain. In circumstances where some state governors issued executive orders banning all illegal mining activities, there has been counter-reaction from the federal government through the Minister of Solid Minerals Development (Premium Times, 2023; Onuminya, 2023; Izuaka, 2023).

Another factor that is identified to be responsible for the poor enforcement of policies and regulations at local and state levels to combat illegal mining in Nigeria is the level of laxities observed in applying appropriate penalties/sanctions for violating environmental laws. If there are no significant consequences for breaching environmental regulations, licensees or lessees have little incentive to consider the impact of their mining operations on the environment. This lack of accountability often leads to a propensity for engaging in illicit activities, given the weak or nonexistent enforcement of penalties. The government's failure to establish sufficient sanctions for unlawful practices, coupled with the enforcement agencies' shortcomings in ensuring compliance with mining regulations, exacerbates the situation (Akinleye, 2023).

According to Ogbonnaya (2020), the difficulty in tackling illegal mining lies in the lack of trust among residents of mining communities in the judicial system's capacity to effectively prosecute individuals engaged in illegal mining. Shortcomings such as insufficient resources and pervasive corruption cast doubts in the minds of the people about the ability of state institutions to hold illegal miners accountable. Additionally, there have been accusations from community members that security personnel exploit the situation for personal gain, citing instances of soliciting bribes without proper identification (Suleiman, 2019). Effective collaboration between local and state actors against illegal mining is challenged by the fact that mining falls under the Exclusive List of the federal government. Thus, attempted collaboration between the actors at the state and community levels are met with constitutional gridlocks. It has been publicly declared by the minister of Solid Minerals Development that state and local communities in Nigeria lack the powers to interfere in mining operations (Munir, 2023). This condition makes it difficult for actors at the state and community levels to effectively collaborate in the fight against illegal mining activities in Nigeria.

**Theoretical framework**

Two theories – Rational Choice Theory and Resource Curse Theory – are employed for the study. The rational choice theory developed by Ronald V. Clarke and Derek Cornish in 1986, is based on the assumption that man is a reasoning actor who weighs means and ends, cost and benefits, and makes rational choices. The theory relies on the economic principle of "cost-benefit analysis" and proposes that a potential offender calculates and chooses the activity, legal or illegal, that offers the best return (Burke, 2009). Across Nigeria, illegal mining is fuelled by the quest to make quick money and the lack of appropriate sanctions against the act. People and companies engage in illegal mining activities because they perceive the benefits to be more favourable than the costs. In the spirit of the rational choice

theory, increasing the punishment for crimes, particularly illegal mining, in the hope that the pain outweighs the gain, will therefore prevent future occurrence of the crime in Benue State. Although the rational choice theory explains the basic thought processes that inform the actions of individuals who embark on illegal mining activities, the theory is limited in the explanation of illegal mining in Benue State because it neglects social, economic and other external factors such as poverty and the failure of law enforcement agencies, which may contribute to the menace. The theory also fails to acknowledge the fact that not all individuals are rational actors (Grady, 2011). Following the shortcomings of rational choice theory, the Resource Curse theory was introduced.

Resource Curse theory, developed by Richard Auty (1993) is also known as "the paradox of plenty" and assumes that mineral and fuel abundance in less developed countries tends to generate negative developmental outcomes, including poor economic performance, growth collapses, high levels of corruption, ineffective governance and greater political violence (Di John, 2010). The theory reflects the situation in Nigeria whereby the abundance of natural resources and minerals in the country has led to unequal economic growth and development and increasing potential for conflict. Illegal mining has exacerbated social conflicts in resource-rich regions of the Niger-Delta, and in states like Benue, Borno, Zamfara, Taraba, Kaduna, Katsina, Kebbi, Sokoto, etc. Communities surrounding illegal mining sites continuously face environmental degradation, health risks, and displacement due to unregulated mining activities. The abundant natural resources in Nigeria are perceived among many people in the country to be more of a curse than a blessing. A major criticism of this theory is that it oversimplifies its assumption. Apparently, not all resource-rich countries experience negative outcomes and not all resource-poor countries are unsuccessful. Despite the shortcomings, the framework is useful for understanding the basic challenges faced in Nigeria due to the abundance of natural resources in the country.

**Thematic Explanation of the Causes of Insecurity in Northwest Nigeria**

Banditry violence has affected populations living in Nigeria's Zamfara, Kaduna, Niger, Sokoto, Kebbi and Katsina states in the northwest. About 21 million people living in these states have been exposed to insecurity from activities of bandits. Unconnected to the Boko Haram insurgency in the northeast, the banditry violence began as a farmer/herder conflict in 2011 and intensified between 2017 and 2018 to include cattle rustling, kidnapping for ransom, sexual violence, and killings. The violence has affected about 35 out of 92 local government areas in the 4 states. The discovery of gold mines and the activities of illegal miners competing for control of gold reserves have served to further intensify the existence and activities of armed groups in the northwest. By March 2020, more than 210,000 people had been internally displaced. More than 35,000 refugees have crossed communal borders to Maradi in the Niger Republic by the beginning of March 2020. These refugees are hosted in Madaou in Tahoua region, Dan Dadji Makaou, Garin Kaka and Guidan Roumdji. The question now is: what drives or causes this banditry? Crime thrives in contexts where there's little deterrence. In most of Nigeria's rural communities, there are many opportunities for

criminal activity. For one thing, some of these communities are in remote areas where there is little or no government presence. More importantly, households are in some cases separated by and interspersed with forest areas. This renders them vulnerable to banditry.

This situation is made worse by the absence of effective community policing mechanisms capable of addressing the hinterlands' peculiar security challenges. In effect, the incidence and prevalence of rural banditry in northwest Nigeria raises a fundamental question about the government's ability to govern effectively. The state security machinery has so far failed to tackle the scourge of banditry and artisanal gold mining in this locale. This failure stems from a lack of political will and operational challenges. Essentially, the prevailing socio-existential conditions in north-western Nigeria have complicated the security situation. The rural pastoral sector is not well regulated. Illicit artisanal mining and the proliferation of arms in the region are also veritable factors. Geography plays a role, too. North-western Nigeria's forestlands are vast, rugged and hazardous. They are also grossly under-policed. Some of the forests run alongside the diverse porous borderlines on the region's frontiers. Borders are poorly delineated, under-policed and thus not well governed. The consequence of this is an abundance of nefarious activity, often facilitated by criminal syndicates.

Rural banditry in north-western Nigeria also derives impetus from the poorly governed mining and small arms sector. Bandits have been drawn to the region by illicit and artisanal mining in states like Zamfara, where bandits have been raiding mining sites for gold and cash. Another school of thought associates the growing insecurity with state failure due to corruption, the collapse of institutions of governance, deindustrialisation, growing poverty, and a culture of impunity that pervades state and local governance in Zamfara State. Still on the issue of insecurity, some observers explain the instability in Nigeria's Northwest in terms of porous borders and the proliferation of small arms and light weapons (Mohammed J. Kuna &Jibrin Ibrahim, Ed, 2015). They argue that arms have found their way into the region from the Maghreb following uprisings in North Africa and countries of the Sahel, including post-Ghaddafi Libya.

Protagonists of a natural resource curse trace the conflict to competition over "gold deposits," pitching those engaged in illicit gold mining against local communities, as well as certain big-time mine owners believed to have strong links with government (Igwe, 2010). Yet, there are those who believe the conflict is spiritual, and the problem facing the region is the result of a "test from God" (www.thecable.ng/i-know-whatto-do-buhari-reassures-nigerians).While some of the narratives may or may not be true, the responsibility of securing the lives and properties of the citizens remains that of the government.

**Environmental and Health Implications of Artisanal Gold Mining**

In March 2010, the humanitarian organisation Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF) discovered an unprecedented epidemic of lead poisoning in remote villages of Zamfara State, Nigeria

(MSF 2010b, 2010c). The first set of children brought to MSF clinics with convulsions and high fevers were treated for severe malaria and meningitis. As patients failed to recover, blood samples sent to a German laboratory (Labour Lademannbogen MVZ GmbH, Hamburg, Germany) confirmed lead poisoning (Greig et al. 2014). The source of lead contamination was prolific artisanal gold mining in response to high gold prices in 2009-2010.

The environmental implications of illegal mining are quite diverse. The first is that it destroys farmland and distorts the livelihood of agrarian communities. The trenches dug for these mining activities are abandoned after the mining is over. They therefore become death traps and easy entry points for devastating gully erosion. As was the case with the communities in Zamfara State, many of these mines are contaminated with impurities. In this case, gold ash was intermingled with deposits of lead. In a few cases, some of the impurities are even radioactive in nature. Ignorant community members therefore go to these mines and meet contaminants. An eyewitness account stated that reports of vomiting and stomach pain among children in Zamfara State began to come in a year ago. As is usual in most communities, deaths are attributed to one spirit or another. The death toll continued to rise until the blood samples of patients were taken abroad for adequate tests. Experts reported that lead poisoning as in the case of Zamfara, can persist in the environment for up to 15 years. There are also other long-term health problems such as permanent learning and behavioural problems and brain damage. Lead, for instance, is known to bioaccumulate and propagate within the ecosystem, giving rise to cancer-causing cells popularly called oncogenes.

Gold mining and processing have been the main sources of heavy metal contamination in the environment. During the processing of the ores for gold, poisonous substances such as oxides and sulphides of heavy metal pollutants are released into the environment, and these affect the populace in those communities in Zamfara and neighbouring communities. No single event illustrates this more than the tragic events of 5 June 2010 in Zamfara State in northwestern Nigeria. It was supposed to be the World Environmental Day celebration on 5 June 2010, but the inhabitants of gold-bearing communities Anka and Bukkuyum and local governments in Zamfara State had a different fate in store for them. About 335 suspected cases of strange ailments were reported in several hospitals in the locality. It turned out that 163 lives were lost, of which 111 were children between the ages of five and ten years old. Further investigations conducted by Doctors Without Borders, a French aid agency, led to the discovery of an epidemic due to lead poisoning. The epidemic wrought havoc among the communities involved in small-scale mining.

Several questions remain unanswered as one examines what appears to have been an avoidable tragedy (Pambazuka News, 2010). From the death toll in Zamfara State, it was apparent that women and children were the worst-hit by the side effects of small-scale mining. Indeed, more than 60 per cent of illegal miners in Nigeria are women. When they meet contaminants, the whole family is affected.In the case of children, many drop out of school in pursuit of the token pay they receive when they engage in mining. They therefore become victims of child labour and are sometimes forced into premature family life and may

be victims of HIV/AIDS.Child prostitution can also occur in artisanal and small-scale mining communities, where virginity is held in high esteem and where fears of HIV/AIDS and other sexually transmitted diseases also exist (www.eli.org). Since 2010, there has been widespread acute lead poisoning in Zamfara state has killed at least four hundred (400) children. Considered the worst outbreak of lead poisoning in modern history, more than 3,500 affected children require urgent, life-saving treatment. Less than half are receiving such treatment.

Among adults, there are high rates of infertility and miscarriage. The most common effects of mercury exposure are mental retardation, delayed development, seizures, and vision and hearing loss, with the cardiovascular and central nervous systems the most vulnerable (United Nations Environment Programme, Mercury: Time to Act (2013). Many of these same effects occur with lead poisoning, in addition to nerve damage, reproductive problems, liver and kidney damage, and muscle coordination. For both mercury and lead poisoning, the health effects are more pronounced in young children. Extreme exposure can lead to coma or even death. For women, mercury exposure positively correlates with an increase in malformations and miscarriages during pregnancy (Gerhard et al, 1998). Many women have also reported menstrual cycle disorders (A Right to Health Issue, 2011).

Other serious health and safety concerns for women living and working in artisanal mining communities include violence and threats to sexual and reproductive health from prostitution and sexual violence (Hinton, et al). Illicit trade in drugs and prostitution, and the violence that often accompanies it, may be more prevalent in communities established as part of a gold rush than in more well-established communities that have a stronger government presence, family ties, and social cohesion. Nevertheless, violence against women in artisanal mining communities has been documented on a global scale. Along with such violence, the sex trade in artisanal mining communities leads to a high rate of infection with HIV/AIDS and other sexually transmitted diseases. Zamfara is a mineral-rich state, with significant deposits of gold. The acute lead poisoning in Zamfara is a result of artisanal gold mining; small-scale mining done with rudimentary tools. Miners crush and grind ore to extract gold, and in the process release dust that is highly contaminated with lead.

Children in affected areas are exposed to this dust when they are labouring in the processing site, when their relatives return home covered with dust on their clothes and hands, and when the processing occurs in their home. Children are also exposed to this highly toxic lead in contaminated water and food sources. Testing showed that the level of lead in her home is 23,000 parts per million, while the safe level of lead is below 400 parts per million (Human Rights Watch). Artisanal gold mining is not only in Zamfara, Nigeria, but also in other countries, particularly in the African sub-region. Pure Earth (2017) has found 132 ASGM sites that cause mercury contamination, affecting more than 3.5 million people, particularly in Africa and Southeast Asia. Pure Earth (2017) has identified 69 countries as major sources of mercury pollution from ASGM activities in 2011 and estimated the corresponding population at risk (Global Trends in Artisanal and Small-Scale Mining, 2017 (ASM).

Men and children work in the mines outside of Bagega; and they dig deep to find the rock and then crush these rocks to find gold ore. Inside the rocks are deposits of other metals, including lead, which has poisoned many of the children in the village in Zamfara. The Convention on the Rights of the Child also seek to protect children from work that is likely to be hazardous or harmful to the child's health or physical and mental development. International Labour Organisation Convention No. 182, which is binding on Nigeria, prohibits the worst forms of child labour, including work in an unhealthy environment that exposes children to hazardous substances. Some workers even crush rocks in a flour grinder. The dust is highly toxic, and many adults suffer the effects of lead poisoning, ranging from swelling, dizziness and vomiting to organ failure, infertility, and death (www.hrw.org).

The use of hazardous substances for mining puts the health of miners and their communities at risk; they are exposed, for example, to mercury, zinc vapour, cyanide, or other acids (Obiri et al., 2010). This is a concern in gold mining, where mercury is frequently deployed, and cyanide use is growing. Mercury can be inhaled, swallowed, or absorbed through the skin, but the health consequences are usually not immediate (Armah et al., 2016). Inhaling dust and fine particles from blasting and drilling processes can cause respiratory diseases such as silicosis or pneumoconiosis in men and women, and in children, who often accompany their parents (Armah et al., 2016). According to the authors, a lack of ear protection to filter noise from equipment like drills or crushers can cause temporary or permanent hearing loss and speech interference. Most OHS risks in sub-Saharan Africa are borne by women, due to the division of tasks between male and female miners.

**Gold Banditry and Insecurity in Northwestern Nigeria**

Northern states have become the hub of violence in Nigeria, from the Maitatsine religious crises in Kano in 1980 and 1983 in Maiduguri, Yola and Gombe, the Fulani Herdsmen-Farmers crisis, and the Boko Haram Movement, which started in Borno and Yobe states. Today, it is banditry with its security implications in the country, and our security apparatus is not doing much to quell this insecurity. The question is: what is banditry? Rural banditry refers to armed violence driven principally by the criminal intent to steal and plunder. It is motivated by the quest for economic accumulation. The victims are individuals and communities with material valuables. The most common examples of rural banditry in Nigeria are armed robbery, kidnapping, cattle rustling, and village raids. Rural banditry in the north-western states of Zamfara, Kaduna and Katsina has reached alarming heights in recent years. Bandits terrorise villages with impunity. They have settled in Zamfara state, setting up fortified enclaves in the hinterland and on the frontiers, from where they plot and carry out their operations (Okoli, 2019).

Nigeria's Northwest is gradually becoming another major regional theatre of violence, much like the Northeast where Boko Haram terrorists have wreaked havoc in the past ten years. A problem, which initially appeared as localised disputes between herders and farmers over access to land, has morphed into an intractable crisis posing a major threat to national and

regional security. The level of rural banditry escalated between 2014 and 2019, attracting a lot of attention, while assuming increased political undertones in the run-up to the 2019 Nigerian elections (Suleiman, 2019). Banditry violence has affected populations living in Nigeria's Zamfara, Kaduna, Niger, Sokoto, Kebbi and Katsina states in the northwest. About 21 million people living in these states have been exposed to insecurity from activities of bandits. Unconnected to the Boko Haram insurgency in the northeast, the banditry violence began as a farmer/herder conflict in 2011 and intensified between 2017 to 2018 to include cattle rustling, kidnapping for ransom, sexual violence, and killings.

The violence has affected about 35 out of 92 local government areas in the 4 states. The discovery of gold mines and the activities of illegal miners competing for the control of gold reserves have served to further intensify the existence and activities of armed groups in the northwest. By March 2020, more than 210,000 people had been internally displaced. More than 35,000 refugees have crossed communal borders to Maradi in the Niger Republic by the beginning of March 2020. These refugees are hosted in Madaou in Tahoua region, Dan Dadji Makaou, Garin Kaka and Guidan Roumdji (https://www.acaps.org/country/nigeria/crisis).

In Zamfara and parts of neighbouring Katsina state in the Northwest, rampaging gangs of armed bandits have engaged in violent acts, attacking, abducting, killing, and robbing villagers and travellers, and engaging in cattle rustling. Although sometimes exaggerated or underestimated by some political actors, casualty figures are quite alarming. The former Governor of Zamfara State, Abdulaziz Yari, is reported to have said that nearly five hundred villages and thirteen thousand hectares of land have been devastated, and two thousand eight hundred and thirty-five people killed between 2011 and 2018. It is also estimated that there are at least ten thousand armed bandits and cattle rustlers operating out of eight major camps in Zamfara State. Also, some reports put the number of children orphaned as a result of such attacks at forty-four thousand since 2010. In Anka Local Government Area of the state, over sixteen thousand people have been internally displaced (Premium Times, April 7, 2019).

Following this artisanal gold mining and its security implications in the northwest, the Nigerian government has suspended mining in the restive north-western state of Zamfara, a presidential aide and the police chief said on Sunday, amid concerns that illegal miners were connected to a surge in banditry (Reuters, World News, April 7, 2019). The suspension underscores the breakdown of security in a part of the country where the military, police and state security forces have been deployed in recent weeks to tackle criminal gangs behind a spate of killings and kidnappings. "The federal government has ordered the suspension of all mining activities in Zamfara State with immediate effect," said presidential aide Bashir Ahmed in a tweet. Nigeria has largely untapped deposits of minerals including gold, tin, and zinc. Some 80 percent of mining in Nigeria is carried out on an artisanal basis and gold in Zamfara is routinely smuggled out of the country illegally to neighbouring Niger and Togo. Zamfara gold miners war of ex-generals and politicians is a threat to stability and development. More than 5,000 people have been killed in five years. Then the Federal Government suddenly woke up to ban illegal mining in the North, a crime ignored for several

decades because of the privileged persons involved. Innocent civilians are dying every day, and nothing is been done to curtail the activities of these bandits.

**Gaps in Literature**

Existing studies have provided useful insights into artisanal mining and violent conflict, but many focus on specific states such as Zamfara, Niger, or Plateau without offering a broader national analysis. Some studies concentrate mainly on economic and environmental effects while giving less attention to peacebuilding and conflict resolution strategies. Others focus heavily on illegal mining and banditry without fully examining the institutional weaknesses that sustain these problems. There is also limited comprehensive analysis of how artisanal mining can be formalised in ways that reduce violence and promote sustainable peace across Nigeria. This study fills these gaps by examining artisanal mining and violent conflict from a national peace and conflict resolution perspective, combining security analysis with peacebuilding recommendations.

**Methodology**

This study adopts a descriptive survey research design, which is considered appropriate because it enables the researcher to obtain information on respondents' views, experiences, and observations regarding artisanal mining and violent conflict in Nigeria without manipulating the variables under investigation. The study employs a mixed-methods approach, combining quantitative and qualitative techniques to provide a more comprehensive understanding of the causes, patterns, and consequences of conflicts associated with artisanal mining. The population comprises stakeholders directly involved in mining governance, peacebuilding, and conflict management, including government officials in mining and security agencies, members of non-governmental organisations, community leaders, traditional rulers, artisanal miners, environmental officers, security personnel, and academic experts in Peace and Conflict Resolution.

From this population, a sample of 200 respondents is selected using purposive and simple random sampling techniques, with purposive sampling used to identify participants with relevant knowledge and experience of artisanal mining and conflict issues, while simple random sampling provides equal opportunities for eligible respondents to participate and helps minimise selection bias. Data are collected from both primary and secondary sources. Primary data are obtained through structured questionnaires and oral interviews, with the questionnaire designed to elicit respondents' views on artisanal mining activities, violent conflict, and peacebuilding strategies, while interviews with selected experts and stakeholders provide more detailed insights into the issues under investigation. Secondary data are sourced from academic journals, textbooks, government reports, policy documents, conference papers, reports of international organisations, and relevant online scholarly materials.

The principal instrument for primary data collection is the structured questionnaire, supported by interview guides, with the questionnaire divided into sections covering respondents' demographic information and issues relating to artisanal mining and violent conflict and structured largely around a four-point Likert scale of Strongly Agree, Agree, Disagree, and Strongly Disagree. The validity of the instrument is established through expert assessment by specialists in Peace and Conflict Resolution, Mining Governance, and Research Methodology, whose observations and recommendations are incorporated before the final administration of the instrument. Reliability is established through a pilot test conducted among a small number of respondents outside the main study area, after which necessary modifications are made to improve the consistency and dependability of the instrument.

Quantitative data obtained from the questionnaires are analysed using descriptive statistical techniques, including frequency distributions, percentages, and mean scores, while interview data are subjected to qualitative content analysis to identify recurring themes, patterns, and explanations relating to artisanal mining and violent conflict. The study also observes relevant ethical principles by informing participants about the purpose of the research, obtaining their informed consent, ensuring voluntary participation, and protecting their anonymity and confidentiality. Participants are assured that the information provided will be used strictly for academic purposes and that no respondent will be exposed to harm, discrimination, or other adverse consequences as a result of participation. Overall, the combination of descriptive survey design, mixed-methods data collection and analysis, appropriate sampling procedures, instrument validation and reliability assessment, and ethical safeguards provides a systematic framework for examining the relationship between artisanal mining and violent conflict in Nigeria.

**Discussion of Findings**

The findings indicate that the rise of illegal mining and rural banditry in Nigeria is not merely a consequence of individual criminal behaviour but reflects deeper social, institutional, economic, and structural weaknesses within the Nigerian governance system. The expansion of illegal mining has created economic and territorial spaces in which criminal networks can operate, while the proliferation of rural banditry demonstrates the inability of state institutions to effectively regulate strategic rural spaces and protect communities. The two phenomena are therefore interconnected, particularly in areas where mineral resources provide financial opportunities for criminal actors and where weak state presence allows illicit networks to develop, recruit members, acquire weapons, and establish influence over local populations.

The finding on the increasing governance deficit and weakening state control suggests that the inability of the state to exercise effective authority over resource-rich rural communities has created opportunities for non-state criminal actors to expand their activities. Governance deficit becomes evident where public institutions are unable to provide security, regulate economic activities, enforce laws, and deliver basic services. In such circumstances, illegal

miners and bandit groups can exploit institutional gaps to establish alternative systems of authority and economic control. Rural communities that experience limited police presence, inadequate infrastructure, poor administrative coverage, and weak regulatory enforcement become particularly vulnerable to the penetration of criminal networks. The problem is therefore not simply the absence of government officials but the limited capacity of state institutions to effectively exercise legitimate authority and provide public goods.

The study also finds that poor governance and inadequate regulatory oversight in the mining sector constitute important conditions for the expansion of illegal mining. Although Nigeria possesses extensive legal and institutional arrangements for regulating mineral exploration and exploitation, the existence of laws does not necessarily translate into effective regulatory practice. Weak monitoring, inadequate personnel, corruption, limited logistical capacity, poor coordination among regulatory agencies, and weak enforcement mechanisms can allow individuals and organised groups to undertake mining activities outside established legal frameworks. Where mining regulations are inconsistently enforced, illegal operators may perceive the risks of engaging in illicit extraction as relatively low compared with the potential economic benefits. This creates an environment in which illegal mining can become normalised within communities and increasingly connected to broader networks of criminality.

The findings further reveal that socio-economic deprivation constitutes another important factor linking illegal mining to rural banditry. The limited availability of employment and income-generating opportunities, particularly for young people in rural communities, creates conditions of economic vulnerability that can facilitate recruitment into illicit activities. Where formal employment is scarce and government responses to poverty, unemployment, education, healthcare, and rural development remain inadequate, illegal mining may become an attractive survival strategy. For some young people, participation in illegal mining may initially represent an economic necessity rather than deliberate criminality. However, the proceeds generated through illicit mining can subsequently become connected to banditry, arms acquisition, kidnapping, protection rackets, and other forms of organised violence. Thus, economic deprivation does not automatically produce criminality, but it can create a pool of vulnerable individuals who may be recruited by criminal entrepreneurs and sponsors.

The finding concerning the state's failure to effectively respond to illegal mining and rural banditry also points to contradictions within Nigeria's legal and institutional framework governing mineral resources. The concentration of ownership and control of mineral resources in the federal government has generated tensions within the broader federal structure, particularly in relation to land administration and subnational governance. The issue reflects a broader constitutional and institutional contradiction in which state governments exercise significant responsibilities over land administration while having limited constitutional authority over the solid minerals located within their territories. This arrangement can create coordination problems between federal and state institutions and may weaken local ownership and accountability in mining governance. State governments and

local communities may therefore have limited authority to regulate mining activities occurring within their territories, even though they are directly exposed to the environmental, social, security, and developmental consequences of mining.

Institutional inadequacies within regulatory and law-enforcement agencies further explain the persistence of illegal mining and rural banditry. Effective regulation requires adequate personnel, technical expertise, surveillance capacity, transportation, communication infrastructure, financial resources, and institutional coordination. Where regulatory and security agencies lack these capacities, their ability to monitor remote mining sites, identify illegal operators, enforce licensing requirements, and respond promptly to emerging criminal networks becomes severely constrained. In addition, overlapping institutional responsibilities and poor inter-agency coordination can produce gaps in enforcement. Criminal actors can exploit these gaps by moving between jurisdictions or taking advantage of uncertainty over which institution has responsibility for particular aspects of mining regulation and security.

The finding on the excessive militarisation of state responses is particularly significant because it challenges the assumption that the deployment of military force alone can resolve illegal mining and banditry. Military intervention may be necessary in situations involving heavily armed criminal groups and immediate threats to civilian security, but it does not necessarily address the underlying conditions that reproduce these problems. Illegal mining and rural banditry are simultaneously ecological, economic, social, political, and security phenomena. Environmental degradation, competition over land and natural resources, poverty, youth unemployment, weak local institutions, displacement, communal grievances, and political patronage can all contribute to their persistence. Consequently, a predominantly military response may suppress violent actors temporarily without eliminating the socioeconomic and institutional conditions that enable their emergence and regeneration.

The militarisation of the response can also produce unintended consequences when security operations are not accompanied by effective civilian governance and development interventions. Communities may experience security operations as coercive rather than protective, particularly where there are allegations of human rights abuses, collective punishment, or inadequate distinction between civilian populations and suspected criminal actors. More importantly, military operations may disrupt particular criminal networks without establishing sustainable governance mechanisms in the affected areas. Once security forces withdraw, criminal groups may return and reconstruct their networks. This demonstrates the need for a broader strategy that combines security measures with regulatory reform, economic opportunities, environmental restoration, community engagement, and accountable local governance.

Finally, the finding concerning the structural crisis within Nigeria's fiscal federal system provides a broader explanation for the persistence of illegal mining and rural banditry. Nigeria's federal arrangement concentrates significant fiscal and resource-management powers at the centre, while state and local governments remain responsible for many

functions that directly affect rural communities. This creates a mismatch between responsibilities and resources. State governments may be expected to respond to insecurity, poverty, environmental degradation, and unemployment within their territories while possessing limited control over the resources and institutional instruments required to address these challenges effectively. The resulting dependence on federal institutions can weaken subnational autonomy and reduce the effectiveness of locally responsive governance.

## Conclusion

The study concludes that illegal mining and rural banditry in Nigeria are interconnected manifestations of deeper governance, institutional, socioeconomic, and structural challenges rather than isolated security problems. Weak regulatory oversight, corruption, poverty, unemployment, inadequate service delivery, institutional incapacity, illicit arms proliferation, and poor coordination among government agencies have created an enabling environment for criminal networks to exploit Nigeria's mineral resources and rural spaces. The study further establishes that the excessive reliance on military responses has been insufficient because it does not adequately address the ecological, economic, political, and social conditions sustaining illegal mining and banditry. Although artisanal and small-scale mining has considerable potential for employment creation, rural development, and economic diversification, its developmental benefits are undermined by criminal networks, illicit gold trading, foreign involvement, and weak state regulation. Sustainable control of illegal mining and rural banditry therefore requires a comprehensive governance strategy that combines effective regulation and law enforcement with socioeconomic development, environmental protection, community participation, institutional reform, and stronger collaboration between federal, state, and local actors.

Based on these findings, the study recommends that federal and state governments adopt a multi-stakeholder approach that combines security operations with the active participation of traditional and religious leaders, community vigilante groups, civil society organisations, and local communities in preventing illegal mining and rural banditry. Governments should create alternative livelihood and employment opportunities, particularly for vulnerable youth, while improving basic services and addressing the ecological, socioeconomic, and political conditions that sustain illicit mining and violent crime. The Federal Ministry of Mines and Steel Development should strengthen collaboration with agencies such as NEITI to improve regulatory capacity, formalise artisanal and small-scale mining, establish clear operational standards, and enforce compliance, while corruption within the mining, security, and judicial sectors should be decisively addressed through investigation and prosecution of both perpetrators and sponsors. The Federal Government should also strengthen diplomatic and regional cooperation with neighbouring and destination countries to combat gold smuggling and the involvement of foreign nationals and corporations in illegal mining, while border agencies should be equipped with modern surveillance and inspection technologies to control the movement of illicit minerals and small arms. The National Assembly should review the Nigerian Minerals and Mining Act, 2007, particularly the existing arrangements for mineral-

resource governance, to strengthen state and community participation in resource management and improve accountability, while state governments should develop long-term strategic plans for sustainable mining development and the welfare of mining communities. Finally, comprehensive reforms of the security and judicial sectors, combined with stronger arms-control mechanisms and improved inter-agency coordination, are necessary to establish a professional, accountable, and development-oriented institutional framework capable of addressing the interconnected challenges of illegal mining and rural banditry in Nigeria.

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# A DECADE OF KIDNAPPING IN ADAMAWA AND TARABA STATES, NORTHEASTERN NIGERIA: TRENDS IN GENDER, TIME, AND SPACE

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**Abstract.** Kidnapping has become one of the major human security challenges in Northeastern Nigeria. The abduction of school children in Chibok town in Borno State by Boko Haram in 2014 brought the attention of the world to the region. The focus of extant literature has been on kidnapping perpetrated by Boko Haram insurgents, without much insight into the escalation of this crime in other states of the northeast. This study, therefore, explored the trend of kidnapping incidents in Adamawa and Taraba that were not perpetrated by Boko Haram from 2014-2023. Adopting the qualitative research method and descriptive analysis, the study relied on data from the Armed Conflict Location and Event Data Project. The data were manually coded into gender distribution, monthly distribution, yearly distribution, and LGA distribution in order to understand the complex dynamics of gender, time, and space in kidnapping in northeast Nigeria. Findings show that males constituted the highest number of victims in both states, suggesting that the male gender has a higher kidnap ransom value than the female gender. The last quarter of the year has been the most vulnerable period for kidnapping, while the yearly trend shows that kidnapping increased from 2020 in both states. This can be attributed to the lockdown caused by the COVID-19 pandemic. Spatial vulnerability was dominant in LGAs like Yola North, Fufore, Mayo Belwa, Jalingo, Gassol, and Takum, respectively. To this end, kidnapping trend analysis should be integrated into state security strategy as part of early warning systems.

**Keywords:** Kidnapping, human security, peace and security, Adamawa and Taraba States, Northeastern Nigeria

## Introduction

Since the emergence of the Niger Delta militancy in the Southern region of Nigeria, kidnapping for ransom has become a common human security challenge in the country (Ayuba et al., 2025). This form of insecurity spread quickly to other parts of the country, especially the Northeast region in the mid-2010s. The abduction of 276 schoolgirls in Chibok in 2014 by Boko Haram marked a turning point in the proliferation of this criminal activity, particularly in terms of scale and visibility (Boyle, 2023). It also led to more concerted efforts toward counterinsurgency in the northeast by local and global actors. Extant literature has focused almost exclusively on terrorist kidnapping by the Boko Haram insurgency and its likes. But there is enough evidence to show that kidnapping incidents that were not perpetrated by Boko Haram but by criminal elements have increased in number and spatial spread. Adamawa and Taraba states were less affected by Boko Haram in relation to Borno State. However, the two states have been engulfed by criminal incidents of kidnapping that are not connected to Boko Haram. Understanding the gender, time, and spatial trends of non-insurgent kidnapping in these states is very important to security policy and interventions.

Attah et al. (2021) believe that kidnapping is perhaps one of the fastest rising crimes in Nigeria. What started as isolated criminal incidents has evolved into an organized and sustained criminal activity of abduction, ransom, and victimisation. The Northern part of the country is the most affected because of the presence of insurgency, rural banditry, communal violence, porous borders, and lack of security presence in many areas of the region (Abdulrasheed & Nurain, 2024). Kidnapping incidents have increased over the last decade. Driven mainly by profit through ransom, victims have expanded from rich politicians and businessmen to include farmers, traders, commuters, students, women, girls, and community leaders. The effects on human security can be seen in the spate of displacement, loss of livelihoods, psychological trauma, gender-specific violence like rape, and general fear among people at the grassroots (Segun & Muscati, 2014)

Even though there is a growing incidence of non-insurgency kidnapping in the northeast region, there is little research on the phenomenon. Most studies on kidnapping in Nigeria are set in the northwest and south-south regions (Abdulrasheed & Nurain, 2024; Opene & Opene, 2023; Otu & Adedeji, 2022; Okoro, 2019; Owonikoko, 2016). The few studies on kidnapping in the northeast focus mainly on insurgency kidnapping by Boko Haram (Maduka, 2025; Abdulbasit & Ankpa, 2018; Segun & Muscati, 2014). Nothing or little is known about kidnapping incidents that were perpetrated by non-insurgent armed groups in Adamawa and Taraba States. There is a lack of empirical data on who the victims are (by gender), when (monthly and yearly), and where (Local Government Areas). As a result, policymakers and security agencies will not be able to take informed decisions and actions towards fighting kidnapping and assisting victims in the region.

This paper tried to fill this identified gap by engaging in a decade-long analysis of kidnapping in Adamawa and Taraba, with a focus on the gender, time, and spatial trends. The paper posits

that a structured trend analysis is important for unravelling the dynamics of kidnapping that can serve as an early warning system at both state and local levels. By analysing the trends in gender exposure, increase or decrease of incidents in time, and changes in space, the paper unravels an opportunity for context-specific policies and grassroots interventions in the region. The remaining sections of the article include literature review, theoretical framework, methods, results, discussion, conclusion, and recommendations.

**Literature Review**

Kidnapping has increased exponentially in Nigeria over the past decade in terms of incidents and sophistication. A report by ICIR Nigeria shows that there were 2,694 incidents of kidnapping with 19,366 victims in Nigeria between 2014 and June 2023. After 2018, the number of incidents kept increasing and peaked in 2021 before having irregular fluctuations. Attah et al. (2021) corroborate these statistics by stating that kidnapping for ransom is one of the most reported crimes in Nigeria. The gender dimension of kidnapping, especially in Northeast Nigeria, has not been given much-needed attention. Ilori and Adeleye (2023) explain the socio-economic variations of both male and female victims of kidnapping in Ekiti State. Segun and Muscati (2014) examined the harrowing experiences of women and girls kidnapped by Boko Haram in Borno State, and show how women and girls are more vulnerable in relation to male victims. These studies show that, even though the male victims are more targeted because of their perceived high kidnap ransom value, women and girls suffer more victimisation.

The time trend of kidnapping show that there are certain seasons, events, festive periods, and natural shocks like pandemics that determine the rise or fall of kidnapping incidents. For instance, the lockdown period, necessitated by Covid19 opened new frontiers for kidnapping because of lack of movement, economic constraints, and absence of security presence. Data shows an increase in the incidents of kidnapping in northeast region in 2020 during the Covid19 lockdown (Boyle, 2021). Geography also plays an important role in the occurrence of kidnapping. Kidnapping and other related crimes like banditry have been proven to be more prevalent in borderland communities and those close to forests and mountains (Ladan, 2014). These geographical features provide cover for kidnappers, especially with respect to keeping victims in captivity. Among other reasons, banditry in states like Zamfara, Katsina, and Sokoto in the Northwest have been attributed to the topography (Rufa'I, 2021). All these studies point to the fact that, spatial mapping is therefore very important in identifying vulnerable locations within Adamawa and Taraba States.

Generally, the spate of insecurity bothering on militancy in the Niger-Delta, terrorism in the Northeast, banditry in the Northwest has increased scholarship on kidnapping in Nigeria. There are basically three dimensions of research on kidnapping gleaned from extant literature. The first are the ones that focus on the causes of kidnapping in Nigeria to include poverty, unemployment, corruption, use of hard drugs, the proliferation of small arms and light weapons and military uniforms, quick money syndrome, communal violence,

ungoverned spaces, poor governance, and general lack of social justice (Onuoha, & Okolie-Osemene, 2019; Omotola & Oyewole, 2024; Ahom & Azaigba, 2021; Ibrahim & Ahmad, 2020; Olulowo et al., 2021). Kidnapping from these works is seen as a symptom of a systemic state failure rather than an isolated criminal behaviour.

The next identified focus of extant literature is the regionalization of kidnapping. The Niger Delta region received much of the attention in kidnapping literature, followed by the northwest. Many empirical studies have established the fact that kidnapping in the Niger Delta is as a result of the militancy that found expression since the discovery of oil and its attendant environmental degradation (Yakubu, 2022; Watts, 2007, Omonijo et al., 2019; Owonikoko, 2016; Essien & Ema, 2013; Demola, 2011). While research on the northwest shows that banditry, ethnic contestations, transnational organized criminal structures, and lack of security governance in rural spaces are majorly responsible for high incidents of kidnapping in the region (Abdulrasheed & Nurain, 2024; Atubi, 2022; Ojewale et al., 2022). Literature on kidnapping in the Northeast are very scanty. The few available ones did not treat kidnapping as distinct emerging crime by non-insurgent actors. Rather, they are treated as a sub-crime under the umbrella of Boko Haram insurgency.

Victimization experiences and geographical dynamics of kidnapping also received considerable attention in literature. Though very few in Nigeria, this strand of literature emphasizes the lived experiences of victims to include physical violence and emotional abuse (Tade et al., 2019; Segun and Muscati, 2014). Victims of kidnapping often undergoes beating, tying, blindfolding, torture, and even sexual violence as strategies for ransom bargaining and collection. The studies also observed that kidnapping is not just an opportunistic crime but, an organized crime made possible by absence of capable guardians, porous border, and socio-economic vulnerabilities.

From the above, there are three gaps in literature that this study attempted to fill. One, there is no single study that examines a decade-long trend of kidnapping in Adamawa and Taraba states. Two, little or absence of research on gender-based vulnerabilities associated with kidnapping. Third, insufficient literature on non-Boko Haram kidnapping. Filling these gaps will add more empirical knowledge on the trends of kidnapping and help governmental and security sector interventions aimed at tackling the crime of kidnapping in Northeastern Nigeria.

**Routine Activity Theory and Human Security Framework**

The study is anchored on Routine Activity Theory (RAT) and Human Security Framework (HSF). Developed by Marcus Felson and James Cohen in 1979 (Stubbert et al., 2015), RAT state that crime is a function of three interconnected elements in time and space. They include a motivated offender; a suitable target; and the absence of a capable guardian (Abdullahi et al., 2022). The theory explains the relationship between time, space, and the commission of

crime. A crime is likely to occur when there is a person or group of persons (motivated offender) who are propelled by push and pull factors to carry out a crime. In respect to this study, kidnappers are mostly motivated by ransom. The huge amount of ransom they get from victims and their significant others serve as incentives for going into the crime. Other motivating factors include poverty, illiteracy, unemployment, extremism, and psychological makeup. The second element is the availability of a prospective victim (suitable target). This is mostly determined by the kidnap ransom value (KRV) of the target. They include rich and influential people within the community. They also include settlements at the outskirt of a town or city. The third element is the absence of security (capable guardian). There are a lot of ungoverned spaces in Adamawa and Taraba states, especially in rural areas where kidnappers have found mountains and forests as safe haven for launching their attacks. No doubt, the absence of security has emboldened kidnappers to carry out their activities with ease and vigour. The rising cases of kidnapping since 2014 in Northeast Nigeria is therefore, not surprising. All the three elements, motivated offenders, suitable targets, and absence of capable guardians, are all present in the region.

Human Security is a contemporary framework that has gained prominence as one of the most important aspects of security in the world today. The aim of this framework is to ensure that individuals and groups are free from traditional and non-traditional security threats. Unlike traditional conception of security as an exclusive state affair, the HSF sees security from the angle of the people and not the state. HSF is based on the thesis that the state cannot be safe if the people living in it are not safe (Afolabi, 2025). To secure the state therefore, the people must be secured from all seven dimensions of human security, including economic security, food security, health security, environmental security, personal security, community security, and political security. HSF focuses on the safety of individuals and not the state. It is a shift from the traditional way of seeing and applying security. The framework argues that state-centric view of security only represents the interests of the few, mostly the political class, while neglecting the people who gave them the mandate, especially in the case of democracy. HSF aimed at creating an atmosphere of sustainable development where all humans can excel maximally in all areas of human development. Kidnapping is one of the major non-traditional security threats against human security in Adamawa and Taraba States. It affects the victims, their families and friends; and the community at large in so many ways, including general fear; loss of lives, loss of properties and money; health challenges; and livelihoods disruption. People don’t feel secured in urban centers, on the highways, and even in rural communities. Farmers are always afraid of going to farm. The threat of kidnapping has made some people to live quiet and secret lifestyle so that they will not appear rich and become suitable targets. There high lack of trust among people in social groups because nobody knows who is a kidnapper and who is an informant. Victims of kidnapping often go through horrible victimization experiences that affects their personal security.

By integrating the two theories, the study revealed, on one hand, through RAT, that kidnapping can occur when there is the presence of three interconnected factors: motivated offenders, suitable targets, and lack of a capable guardian. This explains the temporal and

spatial vulnerability of kidnapping. On the other hand, the study used the HSF to shed more light on the impacts of kidnapping on victims, their significant others, and the society at large; and to justify the need for people centered security policy frameworks.

## Methods

The study adopts a qualitative descriptive research design that made use of secondary data. The data were coded into three thematic areas of gender, time, and space. The geographical scope of the study is Adamawa and Taraba States in Northeastern Nigeria, while the time scope is one decade, from 2014 to 2023. The choice of this time scope underscores the event of 2014 when over 200 girls were abducted by Boko Haram terrorists from Chibok town in Borno State. This incident sparked a global outcry for the release of the girls and brought the attention of the world to the Northeast. However, this attention only focused in Borno state and found expression in Boko Haram related kidnappings, without any attention to non-insurgent incidents of kidnapping in neighbouring states like Adamawa and Taraba. Another justification for the choice of this time scope is the fact that there has also been an increase in the both insurgent and non-insurgent incidents of kidnapping in the region since 2014.

Data for the study were extracted from the repository of Armed Conflict Location and Event Data Project (ACLED) from 2014-2023, covering a period of ten years. Only incidents of kidnapping that were not carried out by Boko Haram that were extracted and included in the final analysis. Data processing and coding were systematically carried out. The process started with cleaning the data to remove non-insurgent incidents. Then, the data were manually coded into four variables including gender distribution, monthly distribution, yearly distribution, and Local Government Area distribution. In the case of gender distribution, there were some data that did not specify the gender of victims, whether male or female. Thus, they were coded as “Unknown.” The validity and reliability of data were tested through a thorough cross checking of ACLED data against other secondary sources, especially online newspapers. This method of triangulation ensured that every incident of kidnapping captured by ACLED was verified against other sources. This process showed that there were many incidents, especially at the rural areas that were not captured by ACLED data, and that informed one of the limitations of this study. After the coding and classification of data into different variables, data analysis was carried out using simple descriptive statistics such as tables, frequencies, and percentages.

## Results

**Table 1: Gender distribution of victims of kidnapping incidents in Adamawa and Taraba**

| Gender | Adamawa | Percentage (%) | Taraba | Percentage (%) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Male | 26 | 43% | 54 | 28% |
| Female | 11 | 18% | 19 | 10% |
| Unidentified | 24 | 39% | 117 | 62% |
| **Total** | **61** | 100% | **190** | 100% |

Source: Researcher, 2025

Table 1 shows that male victims were the majority in both Adamawa and Taraba states within the decade under study. There was approximately 43 percent of male victims in Adamawa while in Taraba, 28 percent made up the male proportion. Females constitute the lowest percentage. The data shows a very high percentage of unknown victims up to 39 and 62 in Adamawa and Taraba respectively.

**Table 2: Monthly distribution of incidents of kidnapping in Adamawa and Taraba**

| Month | Adamawa | Percentage | Position | Taraba | Percentage | Position |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| January | 3 | 7% | 4th | 4 | 8% | 4th |
| February | 1 | 2% | 6th | 4 | 8% | 4th |
| March | 1 | 2% | 6th | 5 | 10% | 3rd |
| April | 1 | 2% | 6th | 0 | 0% | 0% |
| May | 5 | 12% | 2nd | 2 | 4% | 6th |
| June | 4 | 9% | 3rd | 3 | 6% | 5th |
| July | 4 | 9% | 3rd | 6 | 13% | 2nd |
| August | 2 | 4% | 5th | 3 | 6% | 5th |
| September | 4 | 9% | 3rd | 4 | 8% | 4th |
| October | 4 | 9% | 3rd | 7 | 15% | 1st |
| November | 4 | 9% | 3rd | 3 | 6% | 5th |
| December | 8 | 19% | 1st | 7 | 15% | 1st |
| **Total** | **41** | | | **48** | | |

Source: Researcher, 2025

Table 2 shows that the last quarter of the year, October, November, and December holds the highest incidents of kidnapping in both states. The first quarter constitutes the period with low incidents, though with little variation, especially in January in both states.

**Table 3: Yearly distribution of kidnapping incidents in Adamawa and Taraba**

| S/N | Year | Adamawa | Percentage | Position | Taraba | Percentage | Position |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 2014 | 5 | 12% | 4th | 0 | 0% | 6th |
| 2 | 2015 | 1 | 2% | 5th | 0 | 0% | 6th |
| 3 | 2016 | 1 | 2% | 5th | 0 | 0% | 6th |
| 4 | 2017 | 0 | 0% | 6th | 1 | 2% | 5th |
| 5 | 2018 | 1 | 2% | 5th | 0 | 0% | 6th |
| 6 | 2019 | 8 | 20% | 2nd | 6 | 13% | 4th |
| 7 | 2020 | 9 | 22 | 1st | 9 | 18% | 3rd |
| 8 | 2021 | 6 | 15 | 3rd | 12 | 25% | 2nd |
| 9 | 2022 | 5 | 12 | 4th | 6 | 13% | 4th |
| 10 | 2023 | 5 | 12 | 4th | 14 | 29% | 1st |
| | **Total** | **41** | | | **48** | 100% | |

Source: Researcher, 2025

Table 3 shows that the yearly distribution of kidnapping was low from 2014 to 2018. It started peaking from 2019, and peaked from 2020 onwards. This increase is not unconnected with the COVID19 pandemic era, especially in Adamawa State. In Taraba state, the highest incidents occurred in 2023 with 29 per cent.

**Table 4: Location (LGAs) distribution of kidnapping incidents in Adamawa and Taraba**

| S/N | LGAs (Adamawa) | No of Incidents | % | Position | LGAs (Taraba) | No of Incidents | % | Position |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Demsa | 1 | 2% | 5th | Ardo Kola | 4 | 8% | 4th |
| 2 | Fufore | 5 | 12% | 2nd | Bali | 2 | 4% | 6th |
| 3 | Ganye | 1 | 2% | 5th | Donga | 2 | 4% | 6th |
| 4 | Girei | 2 | 4% | 4th | Gashaka | 0 | 0% | 8th |
| 5 | Gombi | 1 | 2% | 5th | Gassol | 8 | 16% | 2nd |
| 6 | Guyuk | 0 | 0% | 6th | Ibi | 3 | 6% | 5th |
| 7 | Hong | 1 | 2% | 5th | Jalingo | 13 | 27% | 1st |
| 8 | Jada | 0 | 0% | 6th | Karim Lamido | 4 | 8% | 4th |
| 9 | Lamurde | 0 | 0% | 6th | Kurmi | 1 | 2% | 7th |
| 10 | Madagali | 4 | 9% | 3rd | Lau | 1 | 2% | 7th |
| 11 | Maiha | 0 | 0% | 6th | Sardauna | 1 | 2% | 7th |
| 12 | Mayo-Belwa | 4 | 9% | 3rd | Takum | 5 | 10% | 3rd |
| 13 | Michika | 1 | 2% | 5th | Ussa | 0 | 0% | 8th |
| 14 | Mubi North | 0 | 0% | 6th | Wukari | 1 | 2% | 7th |
| 15 | Mubi-South | 1 | 2% | 5th | Yorro | 3 | 6% | 5th |
| 16 | Numan | 1 | 2% | 5th | Zing | 0 | 0% | 8th |
| 17 | Shelleng | 1 | 2% | 5th | | | | |
| 18 | Song | 1 | 2% | 5th | | | | |
| 19 | Toungo | 0 | | | | | | |
| 20 | Yola North | 15 | 37% | 1st | | | | |
| 21 | Yola-South | 2 | 4% | 4th | | | | |
| | **Total** | **41** | | | | **48** | | |

Source: Researcher, 2025

Table 4 indicates that Yola North, Fufore, and Mayo Belwa in Adamawa state had the highest incidents of kidnapping within the decade under study. While Jalingo, Gassol, and Takum constitutes the hotspots of kidnapping in Taraba state.

**Discussion of Findings**

The findings of this study provide a deeper knowledge on the trends of kidnapping in Adamawa and Taraba States from 2014 to 2023, with special focus on gender distribution, time distribution, and spacial distribution. This discussion is a synthesis of the results with extant literature and theories that formed the basis of the study, particularly Routine Activity Theory (RAT) and the Human Security framework.

The study finds out that majority of victims of kidnapping in Adamawa and Taraba Sates within the study period were male, constituting 43 percent in Adamawa and 28 percent in Taraba. This is higher than the female victims with 18 percent in Adamawa and 10 percent in Taraba. Though a good number of the victims were not identified as either male or female. They constitute 39 and 62 percent respectively. This finding aligns with the works of Ilori and Adeleye (2023) and Abdullahi et al. (2022) in which they argued that men are most often being targeted by kidnappers because they possess higher kidnap ransom value. Their patriarchal social standing as the sole providers (especially in Northern Nigeria) in a typical African home, often propels them to work even in uncertain terrain, making them vulnerable to kidnapping. From the perspective of RAT, males are more suitable targets to motivated offenders because their day-to-day routines expose them to spaces that are not secured by virtue of absence of capable guardian. The chronic case of underreporting can be attributed to the reason why unidentified victims constitute a high percentage in the number of victims across the two states (Onuoha & Okolie-Osemene, 2019).

The monthly trend of kidnapping shows that October with nineteen percent and December with fifteen percent were the periods with highest incidents of kidnapping in both Adamawa and Taraba States. This finding agrees with the study of Ilori and Adeleye (2023) who posits that kidnapping is more prevalent during end of the year. This means that the months of October to December are associated with festive seasons such as Christmas and New Year celebrations. Thus, the season involves increased movements, travels, buying and selling, harvest etc, all of which create opportunities for kidnapping. on the opposite side, the months of February, March, and April saw decreased incidents of kidnapping. The reason for this cannot be far-fetched from the fact that these months hold little economic activities compared to end of the year. The period between 2018 and 2018 witnessed low incidents of kidnapping. however, there was spiral increase from 2019 to 2023. The increase from 2020 can be attributed to the COVID19 pandemic, which created economic hardship that could be responsible for motivated offenders. The lockdown policy also created an opportunity for kidnappers to attack potential victims with certainty. This finding echoes the work of ICIR Nigeria (2023) which find out that the incidents of kidnapping increased in Nigeria after 20220 majorly due to the socio-economic hardship occasioned by COVID19, and decreased

security presence because of the lockdown policy. Applying RAT to this finding, it is obvious that the lack of capable guardians as a result of the lockdowns motivated offenders to engage in kidnapping.

The analysed data show that spatial vulnerability was more prevalent in Yola North, Fufore, and Moya Belwa LGAs of Adamawa state. While in Taraba State, Jalingo, Gassol, and Takum constitutes the LGAs with highest incidents. The similarities between these six LGAs include urban location and border communities. They also have ungoverned spaces and highways that are often vulnerable to kidnapping. Yola and Jalingo are capital cities of the respective states and therefore serve as economic hubs that draws kidnapping for ransom. This finding is in line with extant literature that alluded to the fact that road transportation and forests have become spaces for kidnapping (Rufa'I, 2021; Abdulrasheed & Nurain, 2024). Attributing this finding to the human security framework, it shows that kidnaping post not just physical security but also social, economic, and psychological security concerns for communities. The incessant disruptions of farming activities, trade, education, and constant fear are human security issues affecting communities in Adamawa and Taraba States.

## Conclusion

In conclusion, this study has been able to show that the interconnected variables of gender, time, and space are very important in understanding the phenomenon of kidnapping in Adamawa and Taraba States. Using secondary data from Armed Conflict Location & Event Data Project (ACLED), the study discovered that kidnapping is no longer a reserve of insurgent groups. Rather, it is more an organized criminal activity that is motivated by ransom. Specifically, the study has proven the fact that there is a gendered vulnerability in kidnapping. the male gender is more at risk of kidnapping because of perceived kidnap ransom value and work exposure that are associated with the African tradition of the man being the main provider in a family setting. The temporal analysis shows that kidnapping is more prevalent in the fourth quarter of the year, reflecting the festive season and increased economic activities. Spatial vulnerability was more seen in LGAs that are considered urban centers (Jalingo and Yola), those with more ungoverned spaces (Takum, Gassol, Fufore, Mayo-Belwa), and those with weak policing system. One important finding is that, the increased incidents of kidnapping after 2020 is as a result of the economic downturn occasioned by COVID19 lockdowns. To this end, the study infer that kidnapping is a human security challenge that have transcended insurgency backed violence to organized and opportunistic criminal activity that is motivated by ransom.

## Recommendations

The study makes the following recommendations:

1. The state governments of Adamawa and Taraba should develop a Data repository on the trends of kidnapping to include gender, time, and space that will serve as an early warning system. This should form part of weekly or monthly security briefings.

2. Vulnerable LGAs should be targeted with community policing that focuses on local intelligence, improved surveillance, and cooperation with vigilante and traditional leaders.

3. Adamawa, Gombe, Taraba, and Benue states should create a joint taskforce that will focus on kidnapping and other related crime, especially at border communities.

4. As a human security challenge, the states and non-governmental organisations should provide aftercare package for victims of kidnapping in order to increase their resilience in terms of recovery and reintegration.

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# WOMEN'S PARTICIPATION IN PEACE BUILDING AND POST-CONFLICT RECOVERY: A CASE STUDY OF INTERNALLY DISPLACED COMMUNITIES IN LAU LOCAL GOVERNMENT

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**Abstract.** This study examines women's participation in peacebuilding and post-conflict recovery: A study of internally displaced communities in Lau Local Government Area, Taraba State, Nigeria. Women have historically played significant but often under-recognised roles in peacebuilding, reconciliation, and community recovery following violent conflicts. The study investigates the extent of women's involvement in peace initiatives, the challenges they encounter, and the strategies employed to enhance sustainable peace and recovery within internally displaced communities in Lau. A mixed-method research design was adopted, combining surveys, interviews, and focus group discussions with women leaders, community members, and local government officials. Data were analyzed using both descriptive and thematic techniques. Findings reveal that women in Lau Local Government Area contribute actively through conflict mediation, psychosocial support, economic rebuilding, and fostering inter-group dialogue. However, their participation is constrained by socio-cultural barriers, limited access to resources, gender stereotypes, and weak institutional support. The study concludes that strengthening women's voices and participation in peacebuilding processes is critical for long-term stability and recovery in post-conflict societies. It recommends that government, non-governmental organizations, and community stakeholders adopt gender-inclusive policies, provide capacity-building programs, and enhance women's access to resources to ensure sustainable peace and development in Lau Local Government and beyond.

**Keywords:** Women's participation, peacebuilding, post-conflict recovery, internally displaced communities, reconciliation

## Introduction

Conflict and insecurity have remained recurring challenges across different regions of the world, leading to displacement, destruction of livelihoods, and disruption of socio-economic and political structures. In the aftermath of such crises, peacebuilding and post-conflict recovery become crucial for restoring social harmony, rebuilding institutions, and promoting sustainable development. Within this context, women's participation has increasingly been recognized as vital to achieving inclusive peace and effective recovery (United Nations,

2015). Despite this global recognition, women often remain marginalized in decision-making processes, particularly in conflict-affected communities such as internally displaced populations.

Globally, the participation of women in peacebuilding gained formal recognition through the adoption of United Nations Security Council Resolution (UNSCR) 1325 in 2000, which called for the inclusion of women in conflict resolution, peace negotiations, humanitarian response, and post-conflict reconstruction (UN, 2000). In Africa, the impact of violent conflicts and internal displacement has been severe, with women bearing disproportionate burdens. Many women face sexual and gender-based violence, loss of family members, and destruction of livelihoods during conflicts. Yet, post-conflict settings also provide women opportunities to step into leadership roles, mediate disputes, and participate in rebuilding education, healthcare, and social structures (Okoro, 2018). Studies in Uganda, Sudan, and the Democratic Republic of Congo, for instance, have highlighted how women's organizations engage in peace education, community mediation, and socio-economic empowerment of conflict-affected families (Pankhurst, 2020).

In Nigeria, conflicts such as insurgency, farmer–herder clashes, ethnic rivalries, and communal disputes have led to the displacement of millions of people. The National Commission for Refugees, Migrants, and Internally Displaced Persons (NCFRMI) (2021) reported that Nigeria has one of the largest populations of internally displaced persons (IDPs) in Africa. Women in these displaced communities often play dual roles bearing the brunt of displacement challenges while simultaneously acting as caregivers, mediators, and community mobilizers. However, patriarchal norms, lack of resources, and exclusion from formal decision-making processes limit their potential contributions (Odo & Samuel, 2019).

Taraba State, located in North-East Nigeria, has experienced conflicts ranging from communal clashes, farmer–herder crises, and insurgency-related displacements. Lau Local Government Area (LGA), in particular, has recorded several incidents of violent clashes leading to the displacement of communities (Taraba State Government Report, 2022). Internally displaced persons in Lau face challenges such as inadequate shelter, lack of access to basic services, food insecurity, and threats to livelihood security. Within this fragile context, women emerge as critical actors in community survival and recovery. They are involved in small-scale economic activities, informal conflict mediation, provision of psycho-social support, and rebuilding of communal relationships.

Despite these efforts, women's participation in peacebuilding and recovery in Lau LGA remains under-documented. Many humanitarian interventions often focus on immediate relief food, water, and shelter without sufficiently recognizing the strategic roles women play in long-term recovery processes (Amadi & Sule, 2021). Moreover, cultural and gendered barriers continue to hinder women from being recognized as equal stakeholders in formal peacebuilding structures (Okonkwo, 2019). This exclusion not only undermines gender equity but also reduces the effectiveness of peacebuilding strategies, as sustainable peace

requires inclusivity. When women are included in recovery programs, it enhances not only gender justice but also the overall resilience of communities. For example, women's involvement in agricultural cooperatives, vocational training, and education for children in displaced camps can contribute to socio-economic stability and reduce the risks of relapse into conflict (Onyango, 2020).

Therefore, examining women's participation in peacebuilding and post-conflict recovery in internally displaced communities in Lau LGA, Taraba State, is crucial for several reasons. First, it highlights the gendered dynamics of conflict and displacement. Second, it provides insights into how grassroots contributions by women can complement formal recovery mechanisms. Third, it can inform policy recommendations aimed at strengthening inclusive peacebuilding that leverages the potential of women as key stakeholders in community resilience and sustainable development.

In Africa, conflicts have caused large-scale displacement, destruction of infrastructure, and breakdown of governance structures. Women, in particular, often face heightened risks such as gender-based violence, poverty, and exclusion from leadership. Nevertheless, post-conflict environments provide opportunities for women to engage in peace education, community mobilization, grassroots mediation, and economic recovery (Okoro, 2018). For instance, women in Rwanda and Liberia have played decisive roles in reconciliation and community rebuilding (Tripp, 2015).

In Nigeria, conflict-related displacements are widespread, particularly in the North-East region due to insurgency, farmer–herder clashes, and communal violence. According to the National Commission for Refugees, Migrants, and Internally Displaced Persons (NCFRMI) (2021), Nigeria hosts one of the largest internally displaced populations in Africa. Taraba State has been affected by recurring violent clashes, including in Lau Local Government Area (LGA), where communities have suffered from destruction of farmlands, killings, and mass displacement (Taraba State Government Report, 2022). In such fragile settings, women play crucial but often unacknowledged roles in peacebuilding and recovery, ranging from sustaining families through informal economic activities to mediating community disputes and providing psychosocial support.

Despite these efforts, women's contributions in Lau LGA remain underexplored in academic and policy literature. Humanitarian interventions tend to focus on short-term relief, neglecting the long-term peacebuilding roles women play (Amadi & Sule, 2021). Moreover, socio-cultural barriers and patriarchal structures limit women's participation in formal decision-making, undermining the inclusivity of recovery processes (Okonkwo, 2019). Thus, this study seeks to investigate women's participation in peacebuilding and post-conflict recovery in internally displaced communities in Lau LGA, Taraba State. It examines the nature, extent, challenges, and prospects of women's involvement, highlighting the significance of gender-inclusive strategies for sustainable peace.

Conflicts in Nigeria have led to widespread displacement, particularly in regions such as Taraba State. Lau Local Government has witnessed violent communal clashes resulting in loss of lives, property, and massive displacement. Women and children are the most affected, bearing the burden of insecurity, hunger, and loss of livelihood. Yet, women are also instrumental in rebuilding social cohesion and fostering peace within affected communities.

Despite global recognition of women's roles in peace-building—as reflected in the United Nations Security Council Resolution 1325—many post-conflict recovery programs still marginalize women's participation. This study, therefore, investigates the extent and nature of women's involvement in peace-building and recovery in Lau, Taraba State, and identifies challenges and opportunities for enhanced inclusion.

**Concept of Peace-Building**

Peace-building refers to sustained efforts aimed at addressing the root causes of conflict and establishing conditions for lasting peace. It involves reconciliation, institution-building, and socio-economic rehabilitation (Galtung, 1996). Women, through their social networks and caregiving roles, often serve as informal peace-builders within families and communities (Anderlini, 2007).

Peacebuilding refers to deliberate and sustained efforts aimed at addressing both the immediate and structural causes of conflict, with the ultimate goal of establishing lasting peace within societies affected by violence. It involves a combination of strategies designed to prevent the recurrence of conflict, promote reconciliation, and strengthen social, political, and economic institutions (Lederach, 1997). Unlike traditional peacekeeping, which primarily focuses on ending active hostilities, peacebuilding is a proactive and long-term process that emphasizes the creation of conditions necessary for sustainable peace. This includes promoting justice, ensuring security, and fostering development to address the root causes of disputes and grievances that often fuel conflict (Paris, 2004).

Peacebuilding operates on multiple levels: at the grassroots, it may involve local mediation, dialogue facilitation, and reconciliation efforts among affected communities; at the institutional level, it encompasses the reform of governance structures, legal systems, and public service institutions to ensure inclusivity, transparency, and accountability (Lederach, 1997; Richmond, 2008). In practice, peacebuilding also integrates social, economic, and political dimensions, such as providing livelihoods for vulnerable populations, reconstructing educational and health systems, and rebuilding community infrastructure that may have been destroyed during conflicts (Galtung, 2000).

Moreover, effective peacebuilding requires the restoration of trust between conflicting groups, fostering social cohesion, and promoting collaborative mechanisms for conflict resolution. It is a dynamic process that acknowledges the complexity of human relationships

and the need for culturally sensitive approaches that empower local actors, including marginalized groups such as women and youth, to participate meaningfully in reconciliation and reconstruction (Boutros-Ghali, 1992; UN, 2015). By addressing both the tangible and intangible legacies of conflict, such as damaged infrastructure, disrupted social networks, and psychological trauma, peacebuilding seeks not only to prevent the resumption of violence but also to build resilient societies capable of managing disagreements through non-violent means.

**Women and Conflict**

Women experience conflict in unique and complex ways compared to men, as their roles within the family and community often place them in vulnerable positions during times of crisis. They are disproportionately affected by violence, displacement, and the breakdown of social structures. In many conflict situations, women suffer from gender-based violence, including rape, abduction, and forced marriages, which are sometimes used as weapons of war to intimidate and destabilize communities. Beyond physical harm, women also face psychological trauma, loss of livelihood, and the burden of caring for children and the elderly amidst insecurity and displacement.

Despite these challenges, women have consistently shown remarkable resilience, creativity, and strength in the face of conflict. They often become primary caregivers, humanitarian responders, and community organizers, ensuring that families survive and communities continue to function even under dire conditions. Women frequently engage in informal peace-building efforts, such as organizing inter-ethnic dialogues, leading local peace committees, and advocating for reconciliation and forgiveness. According to Puechguirbal (2010), women are not only victims of conflict but also active agents of peace, often acting as mediators, negotiators, and advocates for non-violence within their communities. Their lived experiences position them as key players in understanding the social dynamics of conflict and identifying practical solutions to restore peace and stability.

**Women's Role in Post-Conflict Recovery**

Post-conflict recovery extends beyond the cessation of violence; it encompasses rebuilding the physical, social, and economic foundations of communities affected by war. Women are central to this process because they are often the first to initiate reconstruction efforts. They engage in activities such as rebuilding homes, restoring agricultural production, organizing literacy programs, and providing psychosocial support to trauma victims. Women's traditional roles as mothers, teachers, and caregivers enable them to act as bridge-builders who promote forgiveness and social healing.

Moreover, women's organizations have been instrumental in advocating for justice, human rights, and inclusive governance after conflicts. They mobilize communities for disarmament,

reintegration of ex-combatants, and the promotion of democratic participation. Studies show that when women participate in peace negotiations and post-conflict governance, the likelihood of lasting peace increases significantly. According to UN Women (2015), peace agreements that include women are 35% more likely to endure beyond 15 years compared to those that exclude them.

**Barriers to Women's Participation**

Despite their proven capacity for peace-building and recovery, women continue to face multiple barriers that hinder their full participation in formal peace processes. Deep-rooted cultural and traditional norms often confine women to domestic roles, excluding them from leadership and decision-making spaces. Patriarchal systems perceive peace and politics as male domains, thereby silencing women's voices in negotiations and policy formulation.

Illiteracy and low levels of education further limit women's access to opportunities for leadership and advocacy. Economic dependency on male relatives or spouses also reduces their ability to participate independently in community or national peace-building activities. In addition, insecurity, fear of stigmatization, and lack of institutional support discourage women from taking active roles in public affairs.

Olonisakin (2012) observes that in northern Nigeria, traditional and religious institutions are particularly patriarchal, and women's participation is often informal and undervalued. Even when women are consulted in peace processes, their inputs are rarely reflected in final decisions. The absence of gender-sensitive policies, weak implementation of Nigeria's National Action Plan on UN Security Council Resolution 1325, and insufficient government support for women's organizations exacerbate these challenges.

To overcome these barriers, there is a need for deliberate efforts to promote gender equality, strengthen women's education and economic empowerment, and institutionalize their roles in peace and recovery frameworks. Building the capacity of women's groups and recognizing their traditional peace-building mechanisms can significantly enhance the inclusivity and sustainability of post-conflict recovery in Nigeria.

**Theoretical Framework**

This study is anchored on the Feminist Peace Theory and Conflict Transformation Theory. On the one hand, the Feminist Peace Theory emphasizes that women's experiences in conflict and peace are shaped by gendered power relations. It argues for inclusivity and gender equity in peace processes (Tickner, 1992). On the other hand, Conflict Transformation Theory (Lederach, 1995) views conflict as an opportunity to transform relationships and structures through dialogue, reconciliation, and social change. Women's peace initiatives in communities align with this theory as they focus on rebuilding trust, empathy, and harmony.

## Methodology

The study employed a descriptive survey research design, which was considered appropriate because it enabled the researcher to collect data systematically from respondents regarding their opinions, perceptions, experiences, and participation in peacebuilding and post-conflict recovery without manipulating the variables under investigation (Creswell & Creswell, 2018). The study was conducted in Lau Local Government Area (LGA) of Taraba State, Nigeria, and the population comprised internally displaced women, community and traditional leaders, women leaders, local officials, and humanitarian or non-governmental organisation workers in selected IDP and host communities within the LGA. Given the large population of internally displaced persons, purposive and stratified random sampling techniques were employed, with purposive sampling used to identify relevant IDP locations and host communities, while stratified random sampling was used to select respondents from the identified categories. Based on the projected IDP population of approximately 10,000 in Lau LGA, the sample size was determined using Yamane's (1967) formula at a 95% confidence level, resulting in an estimated sample of 370 respondents. Data were collected through structured questionnaires and key informant interviews, with the questionnaire containing closed- and open-ended items covering women's roles in peacebuilding, contributions to post-conflict recovery, challenges to their participation, and strategies for enhancing their involvement, while semi-structured interviews were conducted with selected women leaders, community leaders, local officials, and humanitarian workers to obtain detailed qualitative insights into women's experiences and contributions to recovery processes. The questionnaire employed a five-point Likert scale ranging from Strongly Agree to Strongly Disagree. Quantitative data were analysed using descriptive statistics, including frequencies, percentages, mean, and standard deviation, while inferential statistics, particularly Chi-square and regression analysis, were employed to examine the relationship between women's participation and peacebuilding and post-conflict recovery outcomes. Qualitative data obtained from the interviews were analysed thematically to identify recurring patterns, experiences, challenges, and strategies relating to women's participation in peacebuilding and post-conflict recovery in Lau LGA.

## Discussion of Findings

The findings demonstrate that women played significant and multifaceted roles in peacebuilding and post-conflict recovery in internally displaced and conflict-affected communities in Lau Local Government Area of Taraba State. Although their contributions were largely informal and often received limited institutional recognition, women acted as mediators between conflicting parties, mobilisers of reconciliation meetings, caregivers to victims, and promoters of dialogue and social cohesion. Their position within families and communities enabled them to maintain social relationships across divided groups and facilitate communication where formal mechanisms were weak or inaccessible. By encouraging dialogue and reconciliation, women contributed to reducing mistrust and rebuilding relationships among community members affected by conflict. Their participation

in communal farming and the reconstruction of destroyed houses further demonstrates that their peacebuilding roles extended beyond mediation to practical community reconstruction. This finding suggests that peacebuilding in Lau was not confined to formal negotiations or interventions by government and security institutions but was also sustained through everyday activities undertaken by women within their families and communities.

The study further found that women made important contributions to post-conflict recovery through livelihood restoration, care provision, and psychosocial support. Women participated in skill-acquisition programmes, petty trading, farming, food processing, and other income-generating activities that helped households recover from the economic consequences of displacement and violence. Their support for orphans and other vulnerable persons was particularly important in communities where conflict had disrupted family structures and weakened traditional systems of social protection. Women also facilitated trauma counselling and provided psychosocial support to children and other victims of conflict, demonstrating that recovery involved not only the reconstruction of physical infrastructure but also the restoration of social and emotional wellbeing. The reported contribution of women-led cooperatives to livelihood restoration is especially significant because collective economic activities can strengthen women's economic independence while simultaneously rebuilding community networks and mutual support. Thus, women's economic activities constituted an important component of peacebuilding because economic recovery can reduce vulnerability, strengthen household resilience, and create conditions conducive to peaceful coexistence.

The findings nevertheless reveal that women's contributions remained constrained by significant cultural, institutional, and socioeconomic barriers. Respondents identified exclusion from formal peace committees and other decision-making structures as a major limitation. This suggests that there was a gap between women's actual contributions to peace at the community level and their representation in formal peacebuilding institutions. Women could mediate disputes, mobilise reconciliation, care for victims, and support community recovery, yet they were often excluded from the structures where major decisions concerning security, reconstruction, resource allocation, and peace agreements were made. Patriarchal norms and cultural expectations further reinforced this exclusion by associating leadership, negotiation, and security matters primarily with men. Consequently, women's peacebuilding activities were often informal and community-based, while formal peace processes remained predominantly male-dominated.

The lack of funding and limited access to productive resources also restricted the capacity of women to sustain their peacebuilding and recovery activities. Many women affected by displacement and conflict experienced economic vulnerability, making it difficult for them to participate effectively in organised peace initiatives or maintain livelihood projects. Inadequate education compounded these difficulties by limiting access to information, leadership opportunities, formal employment, and institutional decision-making. Gender-based violence and other forms of vulnerability associated with conflict further weakened women's capacity to participate fully in public affairs. These challenges indicate that women's

limited representation in peacebuilding cannot simply be attributed to lack of interest or capacity; rather, it reflects structural inequalities that restrict their access to resources, institutions, and decision-making spaces.

The identification of education, microcredit, and political inclusion as strategies for improving women's participation is therefore significant. Education can strengthen women's knowledge, confidence, communication skills, and ability to engage effectively with formal peace institutions. Access to microcredit and other forms of economic empowerment can reduce women's dependence and strengthen their capacity to participate in livelihood reconstruction and community development. Economic empowerment is particularly important in internally displaced communities because women with sustainable sources of income are better positioned to support their households and contribute to collective recovery. Political inclusion, including deliberate representation of women in peace committees and community decision-making structures, would also enable women's experiences and priorities to influence formal peacebuilding processes. Community sensitisation is equally necessary to challenge gender stereotypes and demonstrate that women's participation in peacebuilding benefits the wider community rather than threatening established social structures.

The findings indicate that women in Lau were not merely victims or beneficiaries of post-conflict interventions but active agents of peacebuilding, reconciliation, resilience, and community recovery. Their roles as mediators, caregivers, livelihood providers, counsellors, community mobilisers, and participants in reconstruction demonstrate that sustainable peace depends partly on recognising and strengthening forms of peacebuilding that occur at the grassroots level. However, the persistence of patriarchal norms, exclusion from formal institutions, inadequate education, limited financial resources, and insufficient political representation constrained the full realisation of their peacebuilding potential. The findings therefore suggest that peacebuilding interventions in Lau should move beyond viewing women primarily as vulnerable conflict-affected populations and recognise them as important peace actors. Integrating women into formal peace committees, providing access to education and skills development, supporting women-led cooperatives and microcredit schemes, strengthening protection against gender-based violence, and creating institutional mechanisms for women's representation would enhance their capacity to contribute to reconciliation and sustainable recovery. In this sense, women's participation should be understood not as an optional component of peacebuilding but as a critical pathway towards durable peace and social reconstruction in conflict-affected communities in Lau Local Government Area.

## Conclusion

The study concludes that women played significant and multifaceted roles in peacebuilding and post-conflict recovery in internally displaced and conflict-affected communities in Lau Local Government Area of Taraba State. They served as mediators between conflicting

parties, mobilised reconciliation meetings, provided care and psychosocial support to victims, supported orphans, participated in communal farming and reconstruction, and contributed to livelihood recovery through petty trading, farming, food processing, skills acquisition, and women-led cooperatives. Despite these contributions, their participation was constrained by patriarchal norms, exclusion from formal peace committees and decision-making structures, inadequate education, limited access to funding and productive resources, and exposure to gender-based violence. The study therefore concludes that sustainable peace and recovery in Lau require the recognition of women not merely as victims of conflict but as active agents of peacebuilding and community reconstruction. Accordingly, government and community leaders should ensure women's representation in peace committees, traditional councils, and other decision-making institutions through appropriate gender-inclusive measures, while NGOs and development partners should provide literacy, leadership, vocational training, microfinance, agricultural support, and small-business grants to strengthen women's economic and peacebuilding capacities. Security agencies and humanitarian organisations should strengthen mechanisms for protecting women from violence and providing psychosocial support to survivors, while local and state governments should implement gender-sensitive peacebuilding and recovery policies that recognise women's needs and contributions. Women's associations and community-based organisations should also be supported to facilitate grassroots dialogue, mediation, and reconciliation, with development partners such as UN Women and UNDP collaborating with local stakeholders to implement the principles of UNSCR 1325 and related frameworks on women, peace, and security.

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# TRADITIONAL LEADERS, RELIGIOUS LEADERS AND PEACE BUILDING IN TARABA STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** This study investigates the role of traditional and religious leaders in peacebuilding processes in Taraba State, Nigeria. As custodians of cultural values and spiritual authority, traditional rulers and religious leaders possess significant influence in mediating disputes, fostering dialogue, and promoting social cohesion among the state's diverse ethnic and religious groups. Guided by Conflict Transformation Theory (Lederach, 1997), which emphasizes the need to address the root causes of conflict while fostering relationships and building long-term structures for peace, the study explores how these leaders engage in peacebuilding beyond immediate dispute resolution. Employing a qualitative research design, data were gathered through interviews, focus group discussions, and documentary analysis of relevant reports and literature. The findings indicate that traditional leaders play a vital role in conflict resolution by utilizing indigenous mechanisms, while religious leaders contribute to reconciliation through teachings that emphasize tolerance, forgiveness, and unity. Nonetheless, the study identifies major challenges, including political interference, inadequate institutional support, and persistent ethno-religious rivalries, which constrain their effectiveness. The paper concludes that sustainable peace in Taraba State requires stronger collaboration between traditional and religious leaders, supported by government and civil society. It recommends enhanced capacity building, policy recognition of their roles, and inclusive dialogue platforms as pathways to harness their authority in advancing long-term stability and peaceful coexistence.

**Keywords:** Conflict, peacebuilding, religious leaders, traditional leaders, sustainable peace.

## Introduction

Generally, within the African Setting, traditional institutions have served as custodians of local customs and conflict-resolution mechanisms, while religious leaders have provided moral and spiritual guidance that shapes community values toward forgiveness and reconciliation (Haynes, 2016). Their influence at the grassroots level often surpasses that of formal political institutions, particularly in rural areas where state presence is weak (Appleby, 2015). Thus, their roles are essential in mitigating communal and religious conflicts that often erupt (UNDP, 2021).

Taraba State is characterized by a complexity of diverse ethnic and religious groups, primarily comprising adherents of Christianity, Islam, and traditional African religions. While this diversity has the potential to foster inter-communal harmony, it has instead frequently been a source of tension, especially when combined with issues of land ownership, political marginalization, economic disparities, and ethnic competition. Over the past decade, the state has experienced recurrent violent conflicts, particularly in areas like Wukari, Takum, Lau, and Bali, where clashes between different religious and ethnic communities have led to loss of lives, destruction of property, and mass displacement of people (Usman, 2019; Adebayo, 2020). These conflicts, although often rooted in political or economic grievances, are frequently expressed through religious identities, making religious leaders central figures in both the escalation and resolution of such crises (Idris, 2017).

Religious leaders, by virtue of their moral authority, grassroots influence, and community trust, are often seen as key actors in conflict prevention and resolution. In many parts of Nigeria, including Taraba State, religious leaders are called upon to mediate disputes, preach peace, and foster reconciliation among conflicting parties. However, despite their involvement, the frequency and intensity of conflicts in Taraba State have continued unabated, raising questions about the effectiveness of their roles in peacebuilding. In some instances, religious leaders have been accused of bias, inflammatory rhetoric, or silence in the face of violence, which undermines their credibility and neutrality as peacebuilders. These perhaps inform the rationale for this study. Moreover, inter-religious mistrust remains high in many communities, making collaboration between Christian and Muslim clerics difficult in practice. Above all is government's continued preference for a militaristic approach towards deeply rooted conflicts. These contexts have led to inconsistent peace outcomes and the resurgence of violence in areas previously considered stabilized (Ezeoba, 2021).

In view of the foregoing, this paper seeks to examine how religious and traditional leaders engage in peacebuilding in Taraba State, the impact of their interventions, and strategies for enhancing their contribution to sustainable peace. The major objective is to accentuate their relevance and key obstacles limiting their effective role in achieving lasting peace in Taraba State.

## Literature Review

Peacebuilding connotes sustained, collaborative efforts often led or supported by religious leaders to establish lasting peace by addressing root causes of conflict, promoting reconciliation, and rebuilding relationships within and across communities. In a complex and diverse nation like Nigeria, such efforts leave much to be desired. According to Lederach (1997), peacebuilding involves a transformation of relationships, systems, and structures to foster a culture of peace, trust, and coexistence. It is a multidimensional approach that goes beyond ceasefire agreements and treaties to create the conditions necessary for lasting peace.

Ahmad and Hamat (2017) conceived religious leaders as custodians of faith and values, whose words and actions can shape the beliefs and behaviours of large groups of people. Their influence extends beyond religious teachings, often encompassing community development, education, and conflict resolution. However their roles of religious leaders have evolved over time, especially in multi-religious and conflict- prone societies like Nigeria. Okoye (2018) noted that religious leader's act as intermediaries between the divine and the people, but in modern society, they are also increasingly expected to act as peacebuilders, advocates of social justice, and agents of change.

Customarily, traditional leaders are custodians of culture, norms, and customary laws who derive their authority from historical, ancestral, and communal legitimacy rather than from modern constitutional systems (Adewumi & Egwurube, 2019). In many African societies, including Nigeria, traditional leadership predates colonial administration and has remained an integral part of governance and social organization. These leaders such as chiefs, emirs, obas, and village heads serve as intermediaries between the people and the state, performing administrative, judicial, and ceremonial functions that promote stability and social cohesion. Their authority is rooted in the trust and respect accorded to them by their communities, making them vital actors in the preservation of indigenous knowledge systems, local dispute resolution, and moral governance (Ezeani, 2020).

In Nigeria and across Africa, religious and traditional leaders have become key actors in peacebuilding. Their moral authority and proximity to grassroots populations make them effective mediators and advocates for peace. Ugwueze (2019) noted that when religious leaders engage in interfaith dialogue and community outreach, they help to bridge divisions and foster mutual respect among diverse groups. However, peacebuilding is not without challenges. It often requires sustained funding, political will, and coordination among multiple actors including governments, NGOs, international organizations, and civil society. In fragile contexts, these conditions are difficult to achieve, leading to gaps between peacebuilding theory and practice. Akinwale (2017) cautions that without genuine commitment and local ownership, peacebuilding initiatives risk becoming superficial or ineffective.

Musa and Adebisi (2022) assert that empowering local actors including traditional rulers, religious leaders, youth, and women ensures that peace processes are culturally relevant and more likely to gain community acceptance. They emphasize the importance of contextual knowledge, arguing that international interventions often fail because they overlook local realities and indigenous practices

Ngomba, Nwadiogbu, Idris & Philip (2025) examined traditional rulers in Taraba and found that they retain high legitimacy, serve as mediators, but are hampered by weak institutional support, political interference and lack of formal integration. The literature emphasises that traditional leaders are best placed to utilise cultural norms, local knowledge and moral suasion in resolving disputes (Okoli, Oyebode & Asala, 2024).

**Challenges Faced by Traditional and Religious Leaders in Peace-Building**

Traditional and religious leaders face numerous challenges that undermine their effectiveness in peace-building, particularly in contexts such as Taraba State where conflicts are often multidimensional. One of the major challenges is the erosion of authority and legitimacy due to political interference and modernization. According to Eze (2014), the influence of traditional institutions has declined as governments increasingly centralize power, reducing the autonomy of local leadership structures. Political manipulation often compromises the neutrality of traditional rulers, as they may be co-opted into partisan politics, thereby losing credibility among their subjects (Olayiwola, 2019). Similarly, religious leaders sometimes face pressure from political elites or extremist factions, making it difficult for them to maintain impartiality during conflict mediation. This erosion of moral and cultural authority hampers their ability to act as trusted mediators and peace brokers within their communities.

Another significant challenge lies in the socio-economic and security environment within which these leaders operate. Persistent poverty, unemployment, and weak governance structures exacerbate community tensions and make peacebuilding efforts more complex (Adamu & Ben, 2020). Traditional and religious leaders are often expected to address conflicts arising from competition over land, resources, and political representation without adequate institutional or financial support. Moreover, insecurity caused by armed conflicts, banditry, and terrorism especially in Northern Nigeria poses physical risks to local leaders who engage in mediation efforts (Okeke & Chukwuemeka, 2021). In some cases, these leaders become direct targets of violence, as their peace interventions threaten the interests of conflict entrepreneurs or militant groups. The absence of robust state protection mechanisms limits their capacity to mediate effectively and sustain peace initiatives.

Internal divisions within religious and traditional institutions present another obstacle to effective peacebuilding. Rivalries among traditional rulers or between different religious sects can weaken collective action and create distrust among communities (Ibrahim & Tukur, 2022). For instance, doctrinal differences and competition for followers sometimes undermine interfaith dialogue and reconciliation efforts. Limited access to education and capacity-building programs further constrains the ability of local leaders to adapt modern peacebuilding techniques to traditional practices (Albert, 2019). As Adebanwi and Obadare (2011) note, the integration of traditional authority into modern governance requires both institutional reform and training to enhance conflict management skills. Without addressing these structural, political, and institutional challenges, the peace-building potential of traditional and religious leaders will remain underutilized, despite their crucial grassroots influence.

**Theoretical Framework**

This study adopts the Conflict Transformation Theory as articulated by John Paul Lederach (1997). The theory posits that sustainable peace is not merely the absence of violent incidents but the transformation of relationships, structures, norms and attitudes that give rise to conflict. It emphasises just local ownership, inclusion of indigenous actors, cultural sensitivity, and long-term relational change rather than top-down, purely legalistic or military interventions.

In the Taraba context, traditional and religious leaders represent precisely those local indigenous actors whose legitimacy, cultural embeddedness, and relational networks can contribute to transforming underlying causes of conflict. Their ability to mediate, reconcile, mobilise community consensus, and endorse norms of peace fits the transformation paradigm. At the same time, the theory reminds us that such actors must be supported by structural change, institutional linkages and resources.

Therefore, traditional and religious leaders in Taraba State play a relational role in line with Conflict Transformation Theory. They are often deeply embedded in their communities and possess moral authority and legitimacy that enable them to mediate disputes and rebuild trust among conflicting groups. Their involvement in conflict prevention and mediation aligns with Lederach's idea of transforming hostile relationships into constructive ones. Through dialogue, cultural rituals, and faith-based reconciliation processes, these leaders help foster understanding, forgiveness, and coexistence among different ethnic and religious groups that have historically clashed in the state

The theory highlights the structural dimension of peace-building, where transformation involves addressing the root causes of conflict such as inequality, marginalization, and weak governance systems. Traditional and religious leaders in Taraba contribute to this by advocating for justice, equity, and community development. They act as intermediaries between local populations and government institutions, promoting inclusive participation and representing grassroots concerns. However, their effectiveness is often constrained by limited resources, political interference, and reduced authority under modern governance systems. These challenges mirror the structural barriers identified in Conflict Transformation Theory, suggesting that for transformation to occur, both state and community systems must empower these leaders with resources and institutional recognition. Thus this framework helps to analyse how the involvement of traditional/religious actors either contributes to or is constrained in peace-building efforts, and how their activities may transform conflict dynamics in Taraba

## Methods

The research design adopted for this study is a qualitative approach, and data collection was done through Semi-structured interviews with traditional rulers, religious leaders, and community members; Focus group discussions with youth and women's groups and Documentary analysis of reports, government documents, and peacebuilding literature. Thematic analysis was employed to identify recurring patterns and insights.

## Results and Discussion

The findings reveal that traditional and religious leaders play important and complementary roles in peacebuilding in Taraba State, particularly at the grassroots level where formal state institutions may have limited reach or legitimacy. Their involvement in conflict management is rooted largely in their social, cultural, and moral authority, which enables them to influence the behaviour of community members and facilitate peaceful resolution of disputes. The literature reviewed indicates that traditional rulers employed indigenous mechanisms such as mediation, arbitration, negotiation, and community dialogue to manage conflicts (Musa and Inusa, 2020). These mechanisms are particularly significant because they are embedded in local customs and social relationships, making them more accessible and culturally acceptable to disputing parties. Rather than relying exclusively on formal legal procedures, traditional institutions often seek reconciliation, restoration of relationships, compensation, and reintegration, thereby addressing both the immediate dispute and the underlying social relationships affected by conflict.

The authority of traditional rulers, derived from cultural legitimacy and longstanding relationships with their communities, also enhances their capacity to de-escalate disputes before they develop into widespread violence. Their proximity to community members allows them to identify emerging tensions and intervene through dialogue and consultation. This is particularly relevant to conflicts involving land, family relationships, chieftaincy, and communal disagreements, where disputing parties may be more willing to accept the intervention of traditional authorities than formal state institutions. The effectiveness of traditional rulers in such situations is therefore partly associated with their familiarity with local histories, customs, personalities, and patterns of interaction. Their intervention can provide an avenue for disputants to communicate, clarify grievances, negotiate acceptable solutions, and restore social relationships.

The findings further demonstrate that traditional rulers have an important preventive function in addition to resolving conflicts that have already occurred. Because they are continuously present within their communities, they can serve as early-warning actors by identifying grievances and tensions before they escalate into violence. Through community meetings, consultations with family heads, youth groups, women, religious leaders, and other local stakeholders, traditional authorities can facilitate communication between groups and

discourage actions that could intensify existing disputes. This suggests that their contribution to peacebuilding extends beyond conventional dispute settlement to include conflict prevention, community mobilisation, social cohesion, and the maintenance of local order.

Religious leaders similarly contribute to peacebuilding through moral and spiritual interventions. The findings indicate that they promoted values of tolerance, forgiveness, peaceful coexistence, and unity through sermons, religious teachings, counselling, and interfaith dialogue (Yahaya, 2017). In a religiously diverse state such as Taraba, these interventions are significant because religious institutions possess considerable influence over the attitudes and behaviour of their followers. By emphasising the common humanity of different groups and discouraging hatred, revenge, and discrimination, religious leaders can challenge narratives that justify violence. Their messages of forgiveness and reconciliation can also create opportunities for communities affected by violence to move beyond cycles of retaliation.

The role of religious leaders in discouraging retaliatory violence is particularly important in conflict situations where grievances can easily acquire religious or communal dimensions. Gambo (2019) and Ibrahim and Garba (2019) indicate that religious leaders provided moral guidance that encouraged reconciliation and discouraged revenge. This demonstrates that peacebuilding is not exclusively a political or security process but also has an important normative and ethical dimension. Religious teachings can influence how individuals interpret conflict, respond to grievances, and perceive members of other communities. When religious leaders actively promote tolerance and peaceful coexistence, they can weaken narratives that legitimise violence and strengthen social norms that favour dialogue and reconciliation.

Another important finding is that the influence of religious leaders can extend beyond ethnic boundaries by creating spaces for interaction based on shared or overlapping spiritual identities. The works of Egwu (2018), Olayiwola (2020), and Danladi and Bitrus (2022) suggest that religious institutions can contribute to bridging social divisions among diverse groups. This is particularly important in Taraba State, where ethnic and communal identities frequently intersect with political, religious, and socioeconomic differences. Interfaith dialogue provides an avenue through which Christian and Muslim leaders, for example, can jointly condemn violence, communicate messages of peace, and encourage their followers to reject stereotypes and hostility against other religious communities. Such engagements can generate trust and create channels of communication that remain useful during periods of heightened tension.

The findings suggest that traditional and religious leaders perform complementary functions in Taraba State's peacebuilding architecture. Traditional rulers draw largely on customary authority, indigenous conflict-resolution mechanisms, and knowledge of local community structures, while religious leaders rely on moral authority, spiritual teachings, counselling, and interfaith engagement. Both forms of authority can contribute to conflict prevention, mediation, reconciliation, and social cohesion. Their effectiveness is enhanced by their

proximity to communities and the legitimacy they derive from local social and cultural institutions. However, their contributions should complement rather than replace formal state institutions. Stronger collaboration between traditional rulers, religious leaders, government agencies, security institutions, civil society organisations, and community-based organisations would create a more comprehensive peacebuilding framework. Such collaboration would enable early identification of conflicts, improve community-level mediation, strengthen reconciliation efforts, and promote sustainable peace across Taraba State.

The above is thematically summarized as follows:

| Theme | Sub-theme | Illustrative Finding |
|---|---|---|
| Roles of Traditional Leaders | Indigenous mediation | Traditional rulers use cultural mediation to resolve disputes. |
| | Arbitration | They arbitrate land and family conflicts using customary laws. |
| | Grassroots conflict resolution | They intervene directly in community disputes at the grassroots level. |
| Roles of Religious Leaders | Tolerance | Religious leaders preach tolerance to reduce tensions. |
| | Forgiveness | They promote forgiveness to foster reconciliation. |
| | Unity | They emphasize unity across religious divides. |
| | Interfaith dialogue | They engage in interfaith dialogue to build trust. |
| Collaborative Efforts | Joint peace committees | Traditional and religious leaders form joint peace committees. |
| | Credibility | Their combined authority enhances credibility of peace efforts. |
| | Acceptance | Community acceptance of peace initiatives increases with joint leadership. |
| Challenges | Political interference | Political actors manipulate leaders, undermining neutrality. |
| | Weak institutional support | Lack of formal recognition and resources limits effectiveness. |
| | Ethno-religious rivalries | Deep-rooted rivalries hinder reconciliation efforts. |

Author's Design, (2025)

Traditional rulers act as first-responders to disputes, convening local dialogue, mobilizing community forums, leveraging customary sanctions and legitimizing peace accords. As one

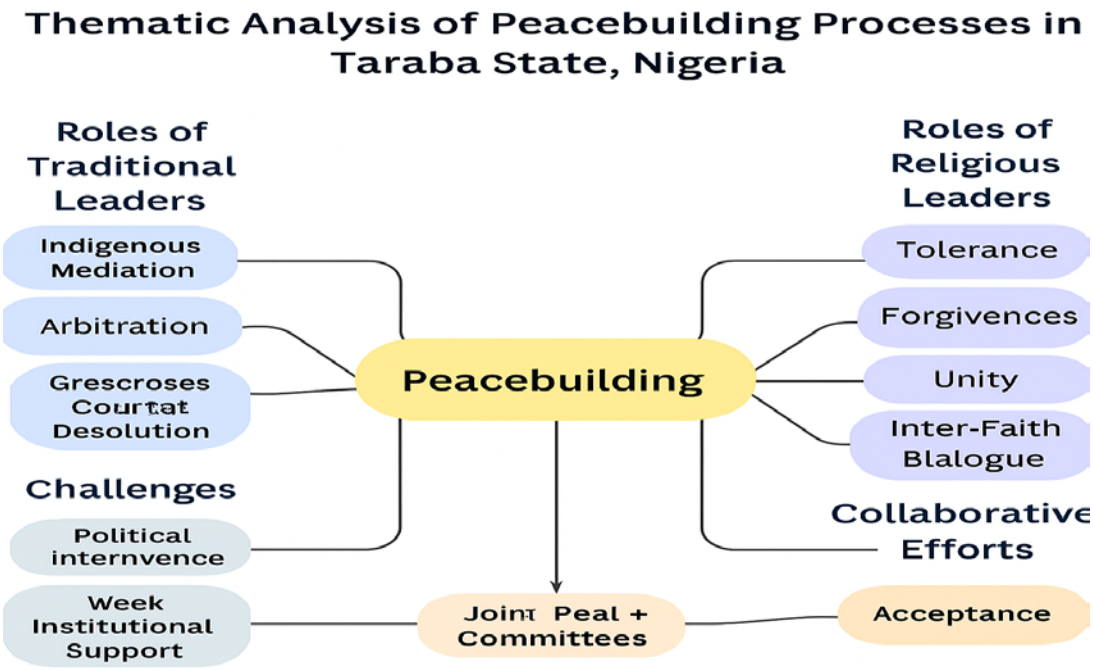
traditional ruler noted: *"We call the disputing parties, we sit them down under the tree, we recall our ancestors' value of peace."* These roles align with the transformation framework's emphasis on local actors. Religious leaders were similarly identified as peace advocates: for example, in Taraba, Rev. Para-Mallam's initiative to bridge ethnic/religious divides involved forming Conflict Management Support Groups in three LGAs (Bolaji, 2024). Ibrahim and Sulaiman (2018) confirms this development underscoring that religious leaders in Taraba State, especially those representing both Christian and Muslim communities, frequently collaborate through interfaith organizations to discourage the use of religion as a tool for political or ethnic mobilization

The signing of the peace accord between Tiv and Fulani communities in Gassol is a tangible outcome where traditional and community elders convened, along with security agents and religious actors, to end years of violence. Building on this, Usman and Danjuma (2022) highlighted the emergence of faith-based peacebuilding networks supported by civil society organizations. These networks, such as the Taraba Interfaith Peace Initiative (TIPI), have trained religious leaders in nonviolent communication, trauma healing, and early warning systems. Through mosques and churches, these leaders are now involved in conflict early-warning alerts and mediation, especially in flashpoint areas like Donga and Kurmi.

Musa and Aisha (2023) further lend credence by revealing that religious leaders now act not only as spiritual guides but also as community mediators and peace educators. Importantly, it was found that pointed out how Christian and Muslim leaders in Jalingo organized interdenominational peace walks and school-based workshops promoting tolerance. These efforts were particularly significant during periods of electoral tension, where religious rhetoric could otherwise be manipulated for political gain.

Collaboratively, both sets of leaders often worked together in joint peace committees and interfaith forums. Their combined authority enhanced credibility and acceptance of peace initiatives among communities.

However, several impediments were identified: inadequate formal recognition of traditional/religious leaders in state peace structures (Ngomba et al., 2025) limited financial/institutional resources; politicization of chieftaincy or religious leadership; ethnic bias; youth restiveness and declining deference to elders; and weak coordination with formal state security or conflict-management mechanisms. Furthermore, while traditional and religious leaders in Taraba hold potent capabilities for peace-building; their impact is conditioned by structural, institutional and relational factors.




Author's design, 2025

The discoveries support the conflict transformation theory's emphasis on local actors and relational change, but also highlight that without institutional support and embedding within formal systems; their roles may remain episodic or limited. Furthermore, this study suggests that integrative approaches which combine customary authority, religious legitimacy and formal peace-building frameworks yield stronger outcomes in contexts such as Taraba.

The implication of the forgoing in relation to sustainable peace is that stronger collaboration between traditional and religious leaders, supported by government and civil society, is essential. This is in addition to institutionalizing their roles through policy frameworks would enhance their legitimacy and provide resources for long-term peacebuilding. Inclusive dialogue platforms could bridge divides, reduce mistrust, and create shared visions of coexistence.

**Conclusion**

The study demonstrates that in Taraba State, traditional leaders and religious leaders are important but under-utilised assets for peace-building. Their proximity, cultural legitimacy, and moral authority enable them to address disputes, restore relationships, and mobilise communities toward dialogue and reconciliation. However, their potential is constrained by institutional exclusion, resource deficits, youth disengagement, and political interference. If properly integrated and supported, these actors can accelerate the transformation of conflict-prone settings in Taraba towards sustainable peace and development.

**Recommendations**

i. State government should amend relevant legislation to clearly define roles of traditional and religious leaders in peace-building, and include them in local peace councils and security frameworks.

ii. Provide training in mediation, conflict analysis, inter-faith dialogue, and grant access to resources (funds, logistics) so that these leaders can convene, monitor and sustain peace processes.

iii. Encourage traditional and religious leaders to engage youth forums, inter-generational dialogues and mentorship to restore authority and mobilise younger cohorts for peace.

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# TRADITIONAL LEADERS, RELIGIOUS LEADERS AND PEACE BUILDING IN TARABA STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** This study examines the roles of traditional and religious leaders in peacebuilding efforts in Taraba State, a region historically affected by communal violence, ethno-religious tensions, and herders–farmers conflicts. Using a qualitative approach that draws on interviews, documentary sources, and field observations, the research explores how these leaders contribute to conflict prevention, mediation, reconciliation, and community cohesion. The findings reveal that traditional rulers serve as custodians of customary norms, mediators of land-related disputes, and symbols of communal identity, while religious leaders play critical roles in promoting tolerance, moral instruction, and interfaith dialogue. Despite their significant influence, their peacebuilding efforts are often constrained by political interference, declining authority, resource limitations, and the complexity of contemporary conflicts. The study argues that strengthening collaboration between traditional institutions, religious bodies, and state security agencies is essential for sustainable peace. It concludes that leveraging the moral legitimacy, local knowledge, and community trust enjoyed by these leaders can enhance conflict resolution mechanisms and foster long-term stability in Taraba State.

**Keywords:** Traditional leaders, religious leaders, peacebuilding, Interfaith dialogue and land-mediated disputes

## Introduction

Peacebuilding in contemporary African societies increasingly demands a multidimensional approach that integrates both formal state mechanisms and indigenous institutions with long-standing legitimacy. In Nigeria, and particularly in Taraba State, the persistence of violent conflicts has brought renewed attention to the roles played by traditional and religious leaders in fostering stability and communal coexistence. Taraba State, located in Nigeria's North-East geopolitical zone, is one of the most ethnically and religiously diverse states in the federation. Its mosaic of ethnic groups, cultural traditions, and faith communities provides a rich social landscape but also makes it prone to complex conflict dynamics. Over the past two decades, the state has experienced recurring episodes of communal clashes, ethno-religious violence, and herders–farmers confrontations that have undermined social cohesion, displaced populations, and disrupted socio-economic development. These conflicts expose the limits of

state-centric security responses and highlight the continued relevance of indigenous peacebuilding actors who possess deep-rooted influence within their communities.

Traditional leaders, such as chiefs, emirs, and village heads, have historically played a central role in maintaining order, mediating disputes, and regulating community affairs across Nigeria. Their authority is grounded in custom, ancestry, and communal trust, making them indispensable actors in local governance and conflict resolution. In Taraba State, where land ownership, cultural identity, and communal heritage are central to the causes and escalation of conflict, traditional rulers often serve as the first point of contact when violence looms. They interpret customary laws, negotiate access to land and grazing routes, and intervene in disputes before they deteriorate into widespread hostilities. Their presence at the grassroots level allows them to detect early warning signs, mobilize communal dialogue, and appeal to cultural values that promote restraint and reconciliation. At the same time, their influence extends beyond administrative functions to symbolic roles that reinforce shared identities and collective belonging within multi-ethnic communities.

Religious leaders also occupy a significant space in peacebuilding processes in Taraba State. The state's religious diversity, which includes substantial Muslim and Christian populations as well as minority traditional faith groups, means that religious institutions often shape social behaviour, moral norms, and community interactions. Pastors, imams, and other faith-based actors wield considerable authority over their followers and possess platforms through which messages of tolerance, forgiveness, and peaceful coexistence can be propagated. In periods of tension, they help de-escalate violence by preaching restraint, discouraging retaliation, and facilitating interfaith dialogue. Their ability to influence emotions, perceptions, and collective action gives them a moral legitimacy that complements the structural authority of traditional leaders. Religious leaders also spearhead initiatives that bring divided communities together, such as peace marches, joint worship programmes, interfaith forums, and community outreach activities designed to rebuild trust and repair fractured relationships.

However, the peacebuilding efforts of traditional and religious leaders are not without challenges. In recent years, the authority of traditional rulers has been weakened by political interference, administrative restructuring, and the gradual erosion of cultural norms that once upheld their influence. Many traditional leaders face pressure from political actors seeking to manipulate communal structures for electoral advantage, thereby undermining their neutrality. Religious leaders, on their part, are sometimes confronted with doctrinal divisions, radical interpretations, and competing denominational interests that reduce the coherence of their peace messages. Both sets of leaders also contend with limited resources, inadequate institutional support, and the increasing complexity of conflicts driven by external factors such as climate change, small arms proliferation, criminality, and demographic pressures. These challenges often diminish the effectiveness of local peace initiatives and widen the gap between traditional mediation practices and the evolving realities of contemporary conflicts.

Despite these constraints, traditional and religious leaders remain indispensable in Taraba State's search for sustainable peace. Their proximity to the grassroots, their intimate knowledge of local histories and grievances, and their moral authority make them uniquely positioned to facilitate dialogue, restore damaged relationships, and rebuild social trust. This study therefore seeks to examine systematically the nature of their involvement in peacebuilding efforts, the strategies they employ, and the constraints they encounter. By drawing on interviews, documentary evidence, and field observations, the research provides an in-depth analysis of how these leaders contribute to conflict prevention, mediation, reconciliation, and community cohesion. Understanding their roles is crucial for designing peace frameworks that harmonize indigenous approaches with formal security structures.

## Review of Related Literature

### Traditional and Religious Leadership as Pillars of Community-Based Peacebuilding in Taraba State

Scholarly interest in the role of traditional and religious leaders in peacebuilding has grown considerably, particularly in regions where formal state mechanisms struggle to manage local conflicts. Across Africa, these leaders have long served as custodians of community values, arbiters of disputes, and symbols of authority, making them indispensable actors in conflict transformation. Scholars such as Zartman, Boege, and Osaghae argue that traditional institutions embody indigenous knowledge systems that can contribute to resolving disputes in culturally grounded ways (Zartman, 2019). In contexts such as Nigeria, where conflict dynamics often intersect with issues of land, identity, and lineage, the relevance of these institutions becomes even more pronounced (Osaghae & Suberu, 2005). Research shows that traditional rulers often possess moral legitimacy and deep-rooted community trust derived from their historical roles as guardians of customary law (Folorunso, (n/d); Nsama, 2025). This legitimacy enables them to mediate disputes, especially those involving land and natural resources, which are central to many communal conflicts in rural states like Taraba.

Existing literature also highlights the centrality of traditional rulers in managing herders–farmers conflicts, particularly in regions where state presence is weak or where formal legal structures are viewed with suspicion. Studies by Tonah, Abbass, and Okoli emphasize that these conflicts are often triggered by land encroachment, destruction of crops, cattle migration patterns, and climate-induced pressures, all of which are issues that traditional institutions have historically regulated (Boakye, 2021; Janet, Kundi, Ogah, & Alkali, (n/d). In several Nigerian communities, including those in Taraba State, traditional leaders have been responsible for allocating land, settling boundary disputes, and managing resource-sharing arrangements between pastoralists and farming groups. Their authority is therefore linked to mitigating tensions before they escalate into violent confrontations. However, scholars also observe that the effectiveness of these leaders has diminished in modern times due to political interference, the erosion of customary authority, and the complexities introduced by contemporary patterns of mobility and armament among conflict actors (Miller, 1968).

Parallel to traditional authorities, religious leaders are recognized as influential peacebuilding actors due to their spiritual legitimacy and ability to shape moral values. Literature on faith-based peacebuilding. Religious figures often serve as trusted voices capable of calming tensions, discouraging violence, and promoting reconciliation (Kassas, Abdelnour & Makhoul, 2022). In many Nigerian communities, religious institutions possess organizational structures and networks that allow them to disseminate messages of tolerance and peaceful coexistence (Oyetoro & Talabi, 2023). Interfaith dialogue, joint religious forums, and faith-based conflict prevention programs have proven effective in reducing suspicion and fostering cooperation among diverse groups (Agantem & Ekaya, 2025). In states like Taraba, where Christianity and Islam are both deeply rooted, religious leaders play a crucial role in bridging divides, moderating extremist narratives, and creating platforms for harmonious communal relations (Mala & Hunaida, 2023).

Despite their potential, scholars consistently point out the structural and political challenges that undermine the contributions of traditional and religious leaders. Studies have documented how political actors sometimes manipulate traditional institutions for electoral or ethnic advantage, weakening their neutrality and credibility (Mann, 1999). Additionally, the decline in state support, limited financial resources, and reduced respect for customary authority among younger generations have further constrained their effectiveness. Religious leaders also face challenges when conflicts acquire strong political or ethnic dimensions, making it difficult for them to maintain impartiality (Lutz & Linder, 2004). Moreover, the proliferation of non-state armed groups, increased access to firearms, and the commercialization of violence have made conflict settings more complex than what traditional mechanisms were historically designed to handle.

Nevertheless, the literature converges on the argument that peacebuilding in multi-ethnic states such as Nigeria is most effective when local institutions are integrated into the broader conflict management architecture. Scholars advocate for stronger collaboration between traditional institutions, religious bodies, and state security agencies, noting that such partnerships combine local knowledge with formal authority (Seixas, & Berkes, 2009). This hybrid approach, known in the literature as “institutional complementarity,” helps bridge gaps between community-based conflict resolution and formal state-led processes. Experiences from other African regions, such as Ghana and Kenya, reinforce the notion that traditional and religious institutions thrive when their roles are clearly defined, supported, and harmonized with state structures (Agyeman, & Awuah-Nyamekye, 2018).

In the context of Taraba State, existing studies underscore the strategic importance of these leaders in addressing the root causes of conflict and promoting sustainable peace. Their proximity to communities, understanding of local histories, and possession of cultural capital position them as vital actors in mediating disputes arising from communal rivalries, religious differences, and herders–farmers tensions. The literature therefore supports the argument that harnessing the moral legitimacy and community trust enjoyed by traditional and religious

leaders can strengthen conflict resolution mechanisms and enhance long-term stability in the region.

## Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative research design to investigate the roles of traditional and religious leaders in peacebuilding in Taraba State. A qualitative approach is appropriate because the research seeks to understand meanings, perceptions, and lived experiences rather than measure variables or test hypotheses statistically. Conflict dynamics, cultural norms, and customary leadership practices are deeply embedded in social contexts, and qualitative methods enable the exploration of these complex interactions in a nuanced and interpretive manner. The study relies on primary and secondary sources of data. Primary data were obtained through semi-structured interviews with traditional rulers, religious leaders, community elders, youth representatives, women leaders, security personnel, and local government officials in selected communities across Taraba State. These interviews allowed participants to describe their experiences, perspectives, and involvement in conflict prevention, mediation, and reconciliation. The semi-structured format ensured flexibility in probing deeper into issues while maintaining consistency across discussions.

Field observations were also employed to complement interview data. The researcher conducted on-site visits to palaces, places of worship, community meeting grounds, and locations affected by communal or herders–farmers conflicts. Observing interactions, rituals, conflict-resolution sessions, and community engagements helped to contextualize the narratives from interviewees and provided insights into the authority structures, cultural symbols, and mechanisms through which peacebuilding processes are practiced. Documentary analysis formed the second pillar of the study. Relevant documents—including government reports, security briefings, NGO publications, local newspapers, archival materials, and academic works—were reviewed to trace historical trends, identify conflict patterns, and assess existing peacebuilding interventions in Taraba State. The use of multiple sources ensured methodological triangulation, thereby enhancing the credibility and validity of the findings.

A purposive sampling technique was used to select participants who possess direct knowledge or involvement in peacebuilding processes. This method was necessary because traditional and religious leaders constitute a small, specialized group whose experiences cannot be captured through random sampling. Snowballing was additionally used to identify other key informants recommended by initial participants. All interviews were recorded with consent, transcribed, and subjected to thematic analysis. Thematic analysis enabled the identification of recurring themes such as mediation strategies, interfaith dialogue, political interference, declining authority, and collaboration with state institutions. These themes guided the interpretation of findings in line with the research objectives. Ethical considerations were strictly observed throughout the study. Participants were informed about the purpose of the research, participation was voluntary, and confidentiality was ensured.

Sensitive information relating to conflict actors or politically charged issues was handled with caution to avoid compromising the safety of respondents or their communities.

**The Theoretical Framework: Conflict Transformation Theory**

Conflict Transformation Theory, developed by John Paul Lederach, offers a comprehensive framework for understanding and addressing protracted communal conflicts. Unlike traditional conflict-resolution models that focus on short-term settlement, conflict transformation emphasizes long-term structural and relational change (Lederach, 1997). It argues that sustainable peace emerges when the relationships, social structures, values, and patterns of interaction that fuel conflict are fundamentally reshaped (De Coning, 2016).

This theory is particularly suited to the Taraba context where conflicts—ranging from communal clashes and ethno-religious tensions to herders–farmers disputes—are rooted in historical grievances, identity struggles, competition over resources, and breakdowns in trust. Lederach holds that local actors, especially those with moral legitimacy and community trust, are central to transforming conflicts from destructive cycles into constructive social change. Such factors include traditional rulers, religious leaders, and other community authority figures who embody cultural knowledge and moral standing needed for durable peace efforts (Ruslan, & Irham, 2022).

Traditional leaders in Taraba State mirror the type of grassroots, cultural intermediaries envisioned by Lederach. Their roles in mediating land disputes, upholding customary norms, and representing communal identities align with the theory's emphasis on addressing the deep-rooted structural dimensions of conflict (Young, 2017). Similarly, religious leaders embody the relational and normative aspects of conflict transformation. Their moral authority, capacity for interfaith dialogue, and role in shaping community values position them as vital agents for transforming hostile relationships, preventing escalation, and promoting reconciliation (Abdullah & Sajjad, 2024)

The constraints highlighted in the study—such as political interference, declining authority, and limited resources—also resonate with the theory's recognition that conflict transformation is hindered when local institutions are weakened or disconnected from state structures. Lederach stresses the need for vertical and horizontal integration of peace efforts, meaning there must be coordination between grassroots actors, mid-level leaders, and formal state institutions (Lederach, 1997). This aligns directly with the study's conclusion that sustainable peace in Taraba requires strengthened collaboration between traditional institutions, religious bodies, and government agencies. By focusing on long-term healing, rebuilding of trust, and strengthening of local capacities for peace, Conflict Transformation Theory provides a robust analytical lens for understanding the contributions, challenges, and potential of traditional and religious leaders in Taraba State. It explains not only how these leaders intervene in preventing and resolving conflict, but also why their roles remain

indispensable despite contemporary pressures. The theory therefore offers a strong conceptual foundation for analyzing the transformation of relations and structures that sustain communal peace.

**Traditional Authority and Community-Centered Peacebuilding in Taraba State**

Traditional leaders play a central and historically entrenched role in peacebuilding in Taraba State, where communal diversity, land-based disputes, and herders–farmers tensions often generate conflict. Their authority is rooted in centuries-old customs, lineage structures, and community governance systems that predate the modern state. As custodians of tradition, culture, and communal identity, traditional rulers occupy a strategic position within local societies and remain among the most trusted actors in conflict-affected areas (Chotib, 2024).. Their proximity to the people and understanding of local dynamics make them indispensable to grassroots peacebuilding efforts.

In many parts of Taraba State, such as the Mambilla Plateau, Wukari, Bali, Karim-Lamido, Gassol, and Takum, traditional institutions, including chiefs, emirs, clan heads, and village leaders, are responsible for enforcing customary norms that regulate land ownership, resource use, and inter-group relations (Blench, Longtau, Hassan, & Walsh, 2006). Conflicts related to farmland boundaries, grazing paths, inheritance, and communal identity often fall under their jurisdiction (Fernandez-Gimenez, 2002). Because many disputes in rural Taraba revolve around land and natural resources, traditional rulers become frontline mediators, intervening early to prevent disagreements from escalating. Their role in setting community norms and maintaining order allows them to facilitate dialogue between disputing parties in a culturally acceptable manner that resonates more deeply than formal legal mechanisms (Deveaux, 2003).

Traditional leaders also oversee conflict prevention by reinforcing customary laws that guide the relationship between different groups. Through palace councils and elders' forums, they arbitrate disputes, sanction offenders, and negotiate settlements anchored in local values (Kariuki, 2015). In herders–farmers conflicts, for instance, traditional rulers often mediate compensation arrangements for destroyed crops or injured cattle and help reestablish grazing patterns or boundary markers disrupted by migration and climate pressures (Beyene, 2007). Their influence is most visible during early warning and early response processes, as they possess first-hand information about rising tensions and can mobilize community elders, youth groups, and vigilantes to prevent violence.

Beyond dispute resolution, traditional rulers serve as symbols of communal identity and unity (Shamhuna, 2025). Their authority commands respect across generations, and their involvement in peacebuilding lends legitimacy to reconciliation processes. When conflicts occur, traditional leaders help restore social cohesion through rituals of forgiveness, community meetings, peace ceremonies, and reintegration efforts for displaced persons

(Hancock & Mitchell, 2018). By invoking cultural values of kinship, mutual respect, and coexistence, they foster conditions for long-term peace and enable fractured communities to rebuild trust.

However, their peacebuilding efforts in Taraba State face significant constraints. One major challenge is political interference, as successive governments have attempted to manipulate traditional institutions for electoral or ethnic advantage (McGarry & O'Leary, 1994), thereby undermining their neutrality and credibility. The erosion of customary authority due to modernization, younger generations' declining respect for traditional systems, and the spread of Western-style governance further weaken their influence (Zhang, 2011). In some cases, multiple claimants to traditional stools—resulting from politicized chieftaincy disputes—also generate divisions within communities, complicating peacebuilding. The proliferation of small arms, rise of non-state armed groups, and increasing commercialization of violence (Lock, 1997), have created conflict dynamics that exceed the capacity of traditional mechanisms, which were originally designed for simpler disputes.

Despite these challenges, traditional leaders remain crucial actors in fostering peace in Taraba State. Their local legitimacy, deep-rooted historical authority, and intimate knowledge of community dynamics give them unique capabilities in conflict mitigation. When integrated effectively into broader peace frameworks—such as partnerships with state security agencies, local governments, and religious leaders—traditional rulers can provide sustainable, culturally grounded solutions to the state's complex conflict landscape. Strengthening their institutions and clarifying their roles within the modern governance structure can enhance peacebuilding outcomes, making them vital partners in Taraba State's pursuit of long-term stability.

**Religious Leaders, the Promotion of Peace and Social Cohesion in Taraba State.**

Religious leaders play a central and deeply influential role in peacebuilding in Taraba State, a region characterized by ethnic plurality, cultural diversity, and periodic communal tensions. The state's landscape is shaped by multiple religious traditions, predominantly Christianity and Islam, alongside indigenous beliefs (Ali, & Lawal, 2024), which hold significant authority over social behavior, moral guidance, and community cohesion. Because religion permeates everyday life and identity, religious leaders naturally occupy a position of trust and moral legitimacy, enabling them to serve as mediators, advocates for tolerance, and architects of reconciliation during conflicts. Their influence operates at both the grassroots and institutional levels, making them indispensable actors in peacebuilding across Taraba's diverse communities.

In many parts of Taraba State, religious leaders act as the first responders during moments of tension. Given their proximity to the community and the moral weight they carry, they are often approached to interpret the causes of emerging disputes, calm aggrieved groups, and

appeal for restraint (Agbu, Akombo & Agbu, 2021). Churches, mosques, and traditional worship centers have historically served as spaces where grievances are aired, emotional tensions are diffused, and collective strategies for nonviolent engagement are crafted. Through public sermons, counseling sessions, home visits, and interfaith dialogues, religious leaders shape attitudes, encourage forgiveness, and promote empathy among followers (Admirand, 2019). Their ability to frame peace as a divine commandment resonates strongly with their congregations, creating a moral foundation for coexistence even when political or ethnic tensions rise.

One of the most notable strengths of religious leaders is their bridging function across communities (Ahmed & Adnan, 2024). In Taraba State, where many conflicts emerge from ethnic mistrust, land disputes, or misunderstandings between farmers and pastoralists, religious leaders often transcend communal boundaries. Christian and Muslim leaders, for instance, have come together at various times through interfaith councils and peace committees to address violence in areas such as Wukari, Jalingo, Bali, and Gembu. Their joint appearances during crises send a symbolic message that peace is possible and that cooperation across religious lines is not only achievable but necessary. Such collaboration often helps to de-escalate retaliatory violence, reassure frightened populations, and counter inflammatory narratives that circulate during periods of insecurity.

In addition to mediation, religious leaders in Taraba State contribute to peacebuilding through early warning and early response mechanisms (Amadasun, Egberi, Kassim, & Museh, 2023). Their regular interactions with community members place them in a strategic position to identify signs of rising tensions—whether related to youth restiveness, disputes over land and grazing routes, or political grievances. Where government security structures may be slow to respond, religious authorities can quickly convene emergency meetings, alert local leaders, and communicate with law enforcement to prevent violence from escalating (Comfort, 2002). Their moral authority also helps to mobilize citizens for community surveillance, conflict monitoring, and volunteer-based peace initiatives. Furthermore, religious institutions often complement state peacebuilding structures by offering long-term reconciliation programs. Faith-based NGOs and mission organizations in Taraba State have organized peace education workshops, trauma healing programs, livelihood trainings, and interfaith youth camps aimed at rebuilding social trust after conflict (Bature, 2012). For communities recovering from violent clashes, these programs help victims process trauma, rebuild relationships, and strengthen resilience against future violence. Through these efforts, religious leaders promote a holistic notion of peace, one that extends beyond the cessation of hostilities to include emotional healing, social justice, and the restoration of dignity.

However, the role of religious leaders in peacebuilding is not without challenges. While many clergy and imams work tirelessly for peace, a few may inadvertently deepen tensions through biased preaching, political alignment, or the reinforcement of stereotypes about other groups (Williams, King & Fulton, 2024). In some communities, religious identity overlaps with ethnic identity, making neutrality difficult. Yet, even in such contexts, the broader body of

religious leadership in Taraba has continued to show commitment to nonviolence, dialogue, and reconciliation, often stepping forward when political institutions falter or when security agencies face credibility issues.

**Traditional and religious leaders in peacebuilding in Taraba State**

Using John Paul Lederach's Conflict Transformation Theory, the roles of traditional and religious leaders in peacebuilding in Taraba State can be analyzed in terms of how they address the structural, relational, and cultural dimensions of conflict while fostering sustainable social change. Lederach's framework emphasizes that conflicts are not merely problems to be solved but dynamic processes that can be transformed into opportunities for building relationships, improving social structures, and reshaping community interactions. It also underscores the importance of integrating local actors and indigenous mechanisms into peace processes, rather than relying solely on top-down interventions.

The theme on traditional leaders and peacebuilding aligns closely with Lederach's emphasis on indigenous structures and local ownership in conflict transformation. Traditional rulers in Taraba State act as mediators, custodians of customary norms, and symbols of communal identity. Their interventions in disputes over land, grazing routes, and inheritance exemplify the principle that sustainable peace requires addressing underlying social structures and cultural values. By enforcing customary laws, mediating disputes, and organizing reconciliation rituals, traditional leaders do not merely settle immediate disagreements but reshape the relational patterns between conflicting parties. Their ability to restore trust, uphold community norms, and legitimize reconciliation processes reflects Lederach's assertion that peacebuilding should transform social relationships, empower local actors, and integrate cultural understandings into conflict resolution.

The theme on religious leaders and peacebuilding also resonates with Lederach's theory, particularly in addressing the relational and attitudinal dimensions of conflict. Religious leaders in Taraba State promote tolerance, interfaith dialogue, and moral guidance, contributing to changes in perception, empathy, and mutual recognition between communities. By framing peace in moral and spiritual terms, they influence attitudes and behaviors that underlie repeated cycles of violence. Their bridging role—uniting Christian and Muslim communities, mobilizing early-warning responses, and facilitating dialogue—demonstrates conflict transformation in practice: conflicts are not only managed but are reoriented toward cooperative, cross-community relationships. Religious leaders' engagement in trauma healing, youth programs, and long-term reconciliation initiatives further illustrates Lederach's notion that transformative peacebuilding requires attention to social, emotional, and cultural dimensions, beyond immediate cessation of violence.

## Findings

The application of Conflict Transformation Theory to these themes reveals several key findings. First, local legitimacy and cultural embeddedness are crucial for effective peacebuilding. Both traditional and religious leaders derive authority from historical, spiritual, and social foundations, enabling them to influence communities more effectively than external actors or formal state mechanisms. Second, transformative peace requires addressing structural and relational sources of conflict, not just immediate disputes. Traditional leaders' regulation of land use and dispute mediation addresses structural inequalities, while religious leaders' promotion of interfaith understanding tackles relational and perceptual tensions. Third, sustainable peace is strengthened by integrating local actors into broader governance and security frameworks. Collaboration between traditional institutions, religious bodies, and state authorities exemplifies a multi-layered approach advocated by Lederach, bridging grassroots knowledge with formal structures.

Finally, the findings highlight constraints and opportunities for conflict transformation. Political interference, erosion of customary authority, biased interventions, and the increasing complexity of violence present challenges that can limit transformative outcomes. Nevertheless, the combination of moral authority, community trust, and culturally grounded practices provides a unique foundation for reshaping conflict dynamics in Taraba State. Transformative interventions that combine local leadership with institutional support can address both immediate disputes and deeper social tensions, ultimately fostering resilience, reconciliation, and sustainable peace.

## Conclusion

In conclusion, the application of John Paul Lederach's Conflict Transformation Theory to the peacebuilding roles of traditional and religious leaders in Taraba State underscores their critical contribution to sustainable conflict management. Both sets of leaders leverage their cultural legitimacy, moral authority, and community trust to address not only the immediate disputes but also the deeper structural, relational, and attitudinal dimensions of conflict. Traditional rulers transform social relationships through mediation, enforcement of customary norms, and reconciliation rituals, while religious leaders foster interfaith dialogue, moral guidance, and social cohesion. The integration of these local actors into broader governance and security frameworks demonstrates the potential of a multi-layered, culturally grounded approach to conflict transformation. Despite challenges such as political interference, erosion of authority, and the increasing complexity of violence, the combined influence of traditional and religious institutions provides a resilient foundation for fostering reconciliation, rebuilding trust, and promoting long-term peace. Their involvement illustrates that effective conflict transformation is achieved not merely through resolution of disputes, but through the holistic reshaping of relationships, norms, and community dynamics toward sustainable stability.

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# THE ROLE OF ECONOMIC SANCTIONS IN INTERNATIONAL CONFLICT RESOLUTION: AN ANALYSIS OF THE RUSSIA-UKRAINE WAR

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**Abstract.** Economic sanctions have emerged as a key instrument in modern international diplomacy, intended to influence state behavior and deter aggression without direct military engagement. The Russia–Ukraine conflict has renewed global debate on the effectiveness of such measures as mechanisms of conflict resolution. This study investigates the role and effectiveness of the economic sanctions imposed on Russia following its 2022 invasion of Ukraine, with the aim of generating practical insights for future international conflict management. Using a qualitative case study approach, the research draws on policy documents, economic data, and scholarly literature to evaluate the political, economic, and humanitarian impacts of these sanctions. Findings reveal that while sanctions have considerably weakened Russia's economic capacity and limited its access to global markets, their effectiveness has been constrained by the adaptability of the Russian economy and inconsistent enforcement among international actors. The study concludes that economic sanctions can be effective when implemented as part of a coordinated and multilateral diplomatic strategy; however, they remain insufficient as an independent tool for achieving lasting conflict resolution.

Keywords: Economic sanctions, conflict resolution, Russia-Ukraine war, international relations, diplomacy

## Introduction

Conflict, a fundamental aspect of human interaction, arises from divergent interests, values, and goals among individuals, groups, or nations, often resulting in clashes that require negotiation or mediation (Davies, 2014). While conflict can stimulate growth and innovation, it also presents risks of escalation and societal instability if mismanaged (Rahim, 2017). In global contexts, conflicts such as the Russia–Ukraine crisis illustrate how geopolitical, economic, and cultural tensions intertwine to produce large-scale instability. The conflict's resurgence in 2014, marked by Russia's annexation of Crimea, underscored deep-rooted historical grievances and competing aspirations between Ukraine's westward orientation and Russia's pursuit of regional dominance (Smith, 2018). The subsequent military confrontations and international condemnation transformed the issue into a defining geopolitical crisis of the 21st century.

The annexation of Crimea triggered widespread unrest in Eastern Ukraine, where pro-Russian separatist movements escalated tensions into full-scale warfare, resulting in severe humanitarian and economic consequences. The conflict displaced millions, destroyed infrastructure, and strained relations between Russia and the international community, with sanctions imposed by Western nations in an effort to compel Russian compliance with international law (Wirtz, 2017; Drezner, 2015). Despite the involvement of international organisations such as the OSCE and numerous diplomatic efforts, peace has remained elusive, as ceasefires are repeatedly violated and mutual distrust persists (Fischer, 2019). The situation highlights not only the challenges of modern conflict resolution but also the limitations of economic sanctions as instruments of coercive diplomacy. Critics argue that sanctions, while symbolically powerful, may impose disproportionate suffering on civilians without achieving meaningful policy change (Pape, 2018).

The persistence of the Russia-Ukraine war reveals the complex interplay between sanctions, diplomacy, and conflict dynamics. Although sanctions aim to deter aggression and enforce compliance with international norms, their broader impacts on economic stability and humanitarian conditions raise serious ethical and strategic questions (Wirtz, 2017). The failure to achieve lasting peace despite sustained diplomatic efforts reflects the fragility of current international mechanisms in managing hybrid conflicts that blend military confrontation with economic warfare (Blank, 2016). Thus, the central problem lies in understanding whether economic sanctions effectively contribute to de-escalation or instead exacerbate human suffering and geopolitical polarisation. This study therefore seeks to empirically examine the role and consequences of economic sanctions in the Russia–Ukraine conflict, with a focus on their implications for global conflict resolution and international security strategies.

**Objectives of the Study**

The broad objective of the study is to examine the role of economic sanctions in international conflict resolution: analysis of the Russia-Ukraine war. The specific objectives are:

i. To examine the role of economic sanctions in the international response to the Russia–Ukraine conflict since 2022.

ii. To assess the effectiveness of economic sanctions in influencing Russia’s political and military behaviour since the outbreak of the conflict in 2022.

iii. To examine the key economic, political, and humanitarian impacts of economic sanctions on Russia, Ukraine, and the global economy.

**Conceptual Clarification**

## Economic Sanctions

Economic sanctions have become a central tool of contemporary international diplomacy, employed to shape the conduct of states or organisations through targeted economic and financial pressures. According to Eneanya (2019), sanctions restrict economic exchanges and financial flows to compel adherence to international norms, including those related to good governance and human rights. They operate as key instruments of coercive diplomacy, using economic strain as leverage to push for policy revisions without resorting to direct military confrontation (Ojie & Ewetan, 2020). This strategic function highlights both the political and legal significance of sanctions as mechanisms for preserving global order and discouraging violations of international law (Adetula, 2021). Omotola (2018) further situates sanctions within economic statecraft, noting that they serve as non-military means by which states influence the decisions of other nations. Agwu (2020) adds that sanctions are often intended to isolate targeted governments economically and diplomatically, creating domestic pressure that may drive political change. These perspectives underscore sanctions as tools with both punitive and preventive capacities, intended to influence international conduct while supporting global peace and security.

Economic sanctions exist in multiple forms, including trade restrictions, financial penalties, and broad or sector-specific embargoes. Trade sanctions, which limit import and export activities, are commonly used to generate economic disruption capable of altering state behaviour, as illustrated by Nigeria's experiences during the apartheid period (Eneanya, 2019; Hufbauer et al., 2017). Financial sanctions, such as asset freezes or constraints on accessing global banking systems, seek to erode a state's fiscal strength, a strategy evident in the economic pressure placed on Iran (Drezner, 2015; Peksen, 2019). In recent years, targeted or "smart" sanctions have gained wider acceptance for focusing on individuals, elites, or specific sectors, thereby aiming to limit humanitarian repercussions (Cortright & Lopez, 2022). Measures like travel bans and arms embargoes further demonstrate how sanctions can be tailored to suit distinct political circumstances, including actions taken against Russia following the 2014 annexation of Crimea (Gordon, 2021; Baldwin, 2020). Nonetheless, scholars continue to debate their overall effectiveness, with critics emphasizing that sanctions can inadvertently intensify poverty and civilian suffering (Pape, 2017). Despite these concerns, many argue that sanctions remain a vital mechanism for enforcing global norms and addressing international violations.

## International Conflict Resolution

International conflict resolution encompasses the coordinated strategies, processes, and institutions dedicated to preventing, managing, and resolving disputes that cross national borders. It draws on diplomatic, legal, and humanitarian approaches aimed at promoting stability and peaceful relations among states or groups. Agwu (2020) explains that this field includes tools such as negotiation, mediation, arbitration, and peacekeeping operations, all of which rely on the active collaboration of global actors to achieve durable agreements.

Omotola (2018) emphasizes the communicative dimension of conflict resolution, describing it as the establishment of platforms where disputing parties can articulate grievances, negotiate interests, and build mutually acceptable solutions. This dialogue-oriented approach underscores the importance of trust, mutual understanding, and sustained communication in overcoming entrenched hostilities and fostering reconciliation. Through these mechanisms, conflict resolution not only seeks to end direct violence but also aims to address the deeper structural and psychological drivers that sustain conflicts.

A preventive and restorative perspective further broadens the scope of international conflict resolution. Adetula (2021) views it as a proactive endeavour that incorporates early-warning systems, preventive diplomacy, and confidence-building measures designed to prevent disputes from escalating into violent confrontations. This anticipatory approach prioritises cooperation and early intervention to resolve tensions before they intensify. Eneanya (2019) adds a restorative justice perspective, portraying conflict resolution as a process of rebuilding relationships, restoring trust, and reintegrating affected communities through inclusive participation and accountability. This comprehensive framework incorporates humanitarian, social, and institutional dimensions, acknowledging the need to rebuild cohesion in societies recovering from conflict. In addition, Ojie and Ewetan (2020) underline the essential role of international organisations such as the United Nations in institutionalising these processes through legal standards, peacekeeping structures, and multilateral cooperation. Their analysis affirms that effective international conflict resolution depends on adherence to global norms, shared diplomatic responsibility, and strong institutional frameworks capable of sustaining peace and preventing future crises.

**The Russian-Ukraine Conflict: Background and Context**

The Russia–Ukraine conflict, which escalated into a full-scale war in February 2022, is anchored in long-standing historical, political, and geopolitical tensions that trace back to the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991. Ukraine emerged from the Soviet dissolution as an independent state with diverse linguistic communities, unresolved territorial concerns, and a complicated relationship with its larger neighbor, creating conditions ripe for future friction. Russia’s annexation of Crimea in 2014 marked a decisive shift in the relationship, drawing widespread international condemnation and triggering extensive economic sanctions (Lynch, 2015). This move aligned with Russia’s broader strategy to reassert influence over its former Soviet sphere and counter Ukraine’s increasing engagement with Western institutions such as the European Union and NATO (Mearsheimer, 2014). During this period, Russia’s backing of separatist forces in Donetsk and Luhansk transformed local disturbances into a prolonged armed conflict that displaced thousands and intensified civilian hardship (Wilson, 2016).

The lead-up to the 2022 invasion was shaped by rising military activities, diplomatic failures, and increasingly assertive messaging from Moscow. Charap and Colton (2021) observe that Russia’s military mobilization throughout 2021, paired with sharp political rhetoric, clearly signaled preparation for a broader offensive. By early 2022, Russia had positioned large

numbers of troops along Ukraine's borders, effectively laying the groundwork for the invasion (McFaul, 2022). The offensive provoked swift and widespread condemnation from the international community, resulting in extensive sanctions aimed at isolating Russia both politically and economically. Pifer (2022) notes that although these measures were intended to weaken Russia's strategic position and pressure a policy reversal, debates continue over their effectiveness in changing Russian behavior. At the same time, Western governments significantly increased military and financial support to Ukraine to enhance its defense capacities and resilience (Dempsey, 2022).

The humanitarian consequences of the war have been profound. Volker Turk (2023) reports that millions have been displaced, while many more face deepening humanitarian emergencies as the destruction of infrastructure and urban centers continues. Civilian suffering has escalated amid ongoing bombardments and occupation. Holliday (2023) emphasizes that beyond these physical impacts, the conflict has profoundly shaped Ukrainian national consciousness, strengthening unity and determination in the face of Russian aggression. Melnyk and Klymenko (2022) further argue that this heightened sense of nationalism has reinforced Ukraine's capacity to endure prolonged conflict despite severe economic and social pressures. The resilience demonstrated by Ukrainian society, combined with the firm commitment of its leadership to national sovereignty, has become a central theme in understanding the war's broader trajectory (Kuzio, 2021).

The Russia–Ukraine war has also reshaped contemporary global security dynamics. The conflict has reinvigorated NATO's strategic direction and highlighted Europe's exposure to territorial threats (Oliker, 2022). Stent (2022) observes that the renewed cohesion among NATO member states marks a major geopolitical adjustment, as European countries reassess defense priorities and reduce dependence on Russian energy. The economic implications have been similarly extensive, particularly in global energy markets. Haffner (2023) and Yergin (2022) show that disruptions in Russian oil and gas supplies have generated significant price instability and placed additional pressure on international energy systems. In sum, the Russia–Ukraine conflict illustrates the complex interplay between historical grievances, power politics, and global interdependence. Its unfolding developments continue to demonstrate the difficulties of fostering lasting peace and stability in a world where geopolitical ambitions and humanitarian concerns remain deeply intertwined (Mearsheimer, 2019).

**Economic Sanctions in Relation to International Conflict Resolution within the Context of the Russia–Ukraine War**

Economic sanctions imposed on Russia have become one of the central tools of international pressure, reflecting global disapproval of Moscow's annexation of Crimea in 2014 and its full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022. The earliest rounds of sanctions focused on Russia's financial, energy, and defense sectors, restricting access to global capital markets and limiting the acquisition of crucial technologies (Pifer, 2015). Following the outbreak of the 2022 war, Western governments led by the United States and the European Union expanded these measures to include asset freezes, travel bans, and the removal of major Russian banks from the SWIFT payment system (Hufbauer et al., 2022). These steps were intended to weaken Russia's economic foundation and reduce its ability to sustain prolonged military operations. Restrictions on high-tech exports, software, and dual-use goods further strained Russia's military-industrial complex, while curbs on oil and gas revenues targeted one of the country's most vital sources of income (Snyder, 2021). However, Russia's ability to adapt economically, supported by substantial foreign reserves and strengthened trade relations with non-Western partners, has softened some of these impacts, slowing the sanctions' expected political effect (Faure Atger, 2023).

In addition to broad economic measures, the sanctions regime also included targeted restrictions on oligarchs and political figures closely associated with the Kremlin. These personalized sanctions were designed to disrupt the financial networks and patronage systems that reinforce elite loyalty, freezing assets abroad and limiting international mobility (Charap & Colton, 2021). Although they carried strong symbolic and punitive value, their practical outcomes have been mixed. Russia has faced currency instability, capital outflows, and inflation, yet it has demonstrated resilience through import substitution, alternative trading blocs, and deeper economic ties with countries such as China and India (Lynch, 2022). This shift underscores broader geopolitical realignments occurring within an increasingly multi-polar international order. Meanwhile, the ripple effects of the sanctions have extended beyond Russia, contributing to global energy market disruptions. Reduced Russian oil and gas supplies have heightened price volatility and intensified inflationary pressures across many regions (Holland, 2023). These developments reveal both the capacity and the limitations of sanctions as instruments of global governance and conflict management.

While sanctions aim to pressure political leaders, their humanitarian consequences have become more visible over time. The restrictions have contributed to shortages, rising consumer prices, and declining living conditions for ordinary Russians (Volker Turk, 2023). This has sparked ethical debates about the proportionality of collective economic hardship used as leverage for political change. Although the sanctions have succeeded in isolating Russia diplomatically and economically, they have not yet forced a substantial shift in its military strategy toward Ukraine. Dempsey (2022) argues that the effectiveness of sanctions depends heavily on consistent international enforcement and strong diplomatic collaboration to prevent circumvention. Ultimately, the sanction measures imposed on Russia highlight

both the strategic potential and the inherent constraints of economic statecraft in modern international relations, functioning as a powerful yet imperfect tool for conflict resolution and geopolitical deterrence.

## Theoretical Framework: Offensive Realism and Its Application to the Russia–Ukraine War

Offensive realism, developed by John J. Mearsheimer in his influential 2001 book The Tragedy of Great Power Politics, provides a compelling framework for understanding how great powers behave within an anarchic international system. According to this theory, major states are not satisfied with simply ensuring their survival; instead, structural pressures push them to maximise their relative power, often through expansionist or assertive strategies. Unlike defensive realism, which views power accumulation mainly as a way to maintain security, offensive realism argues that the pursuit of regional hegemony is the most reliable path to long-term survival. The absence of a central authority to enforce global order, coupled with persistent uncertainty about other states' intentions, creates a system defined by mistrust and competition. As a rational response to these conditions, states seek opportunities to enhance their power, not out of inherent aggression but out of strategic necessity. Mearsheimer's core assumptions, anarchy, offensive capability, uncertainty, and survival as the primary goal, form a theoretical model in which conflict is not accidental but structurally inevitable, as great powers continually attempt to dominate their regional environments (Mearsheimer, 2001; Tella, 2022).

When applied to the Russia-Ukraine war, offensive realism offers valuable insights into Russia's foreign-policy behaviour and the limits of international countermeasures. Russia's actions, including the annexation of Crimea in 2014 and the full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022, can be interpreted as calculated efforts to reassert regional hegemony and resist NATO's eastward expansion. From this viewpoint, Moscow's decisions reflect systemic pressures rather than impulsive aggression. Economic sanctions imposed by Western countries, although intended to deter further escalation, have limited influence within this theoretical framework because they do not alter the anarchic structure of the international system or Russia's deep-seated perception of NATO as a strategic threat. Offensive realism suggests that a great power like Russia may be willing to absorb significant economic costs to secure long-term geopolitical advantages, viewing such sacrifices as necessary for survival. As a result, the theory underscores the limitations of sanctions and moral appeals in constraining great-power ambitions, reinforcing the central role of power politics in shaping contemporary global conflicts (Ogunleye, 2021; Mearsheimer, 2014; Eze, 2023).

## Methodology

This study adopted an ex post facto research design, which is appropriate for analyzing past events without manipulating variables. The approach enabled a contextual exploration of how

economic sanctions functioned as instruments of international conflict resolution during the Russia–Ukraine war. Since both the conflict and the sanctions had already unfolded, the design provided a suitable framework for examining their geopolitical effects. The study focused specifically on the Russia–Ukraine war.

Data for the study were sourced entirely from secondary materials such as scholarly articles, government publications, reports from international organisations, books, and reputable news outlets. This ensured access to diverse and credible evidence, supporting an objective assessment of the effectiveness of sanctions as tools of conflict management. The analysis employed qualitative content and thematic techniques to identify recurring trends, policy implications, and broader patterns in the data. Document analysis enabled detailed examination of policy frameworks and international responses, while a comparative approach was used to highlight differences between the sanctions imposed after 2014 and those enacted in 2022. Ethical considerations were strictly upheld through proper citation, adherence to academic integrity, and respect for intellectual property. Through this methodological framework, the study offered a comprehensive understanding of how economic sanctions operate within the realm of international diplomacy and conflict resolution.

## Discussion

### The Role of Economic Sanctions in International Response to the Russia-Ukraine Conflict Since 2022

Economic sanctions have become a central non-military mechanism for addressing international conflicts, especially where direct intervention risks escalating tensions. In the Russia-Ukraine war, sanctions were strategically deployed to pressure Moscow into halting its aggression and complying with international norms. O'Malley and Ziegler (2020) describe sanctions as essential diplomatic tools capable of influencing state behaviour by weakening economic capacity and raising the costs of continued conflict. This approach aligns with broader conflict-resolution strategies that prioritise negotiation, deterrence, and economic coercion over military engagement. Although Western sanctions on Russia have been extensive, targeting energy, trade, and financial systems, their overall effectiveness remains contested. Baker (2021) notes that the sanctions contributed to economic contraction, high inflation, and restricted access to advanced technology. However, despite these pressures, Russia has continued its military operations, demonstrating that economic pain alone may not compel a fundamental policy shift.

The effectiveness of sanctions ultimately relies on their ability to reduce the target state's political and military capacity. The measures imposed on Russia aimed to diminish its war-sustaining infrastructure by cutting off foreign capital, limiting imports of military technology, and isolating key financial institutions from global systems. Zilinsky (2022) argues that although these sanctions have strained Russia's energy and defence sectors, their

overall impact has been diluted by the country's economic adaptability. Strengthened economic ties with China, India, and other non-Western partners have helped Russia absorb some of the economic shock (Chaudhry & DeVries, 2023). This highlights the limitations of regionally concentrated sanctions in an interconnected world where alternative markets exist. The uneven enforcement of sanctions among major powers has further weakened their coercive value, allowing Russia to maintain both its domestic economic stability and its foreign-policy objectives.

Politically, sanctions sought not only to damage Russia's economy but also to weaken the elite networks supporting President Vladimir Putin. Asset freezes and travel bans targeting oligarchs were intended to create internal pressure on the regime. However, as Williams (2023) observes, these measures have largely failed to undermine Putin's authority. Instead, the Russian government has used sanctions to reinforce nationalist narratives, framing Western actions as attempts to weaken Russia's sovereignty. This has helped consolidate domestic support, revealing a paradox of sanctions: while they impose economic hardship, they may also strengthen the legitimacy of the targeted leadership by invoking narratives of resistance. Consequently, rather than fostering internal divisions, sanctions have contributed to political cohesion within Russia.

More broadly, the Russia–Ukraine case reflects the evolving limitations of sanctions as tools of conflict resolution. Miller and Brown (2020) argue that sanctions have shifted from narrowly targeted measures to broad economic restrictions affecting entire populations. While this intensifies pressure, it also expands humanitarian suffering without necessarily producing decisive political outcomes. Russia's response—marked by economic diversification and the establishment of alternative financial systems—demonstrates the declining effectiveness of sanctions in a multipolar world. Petrova (2021) notes that although Ukraine views sanctions as essential for weakening Russia's military capacity, their limited success underscores the need for complementary diplomatic and security strategies. The Russian experience shows that sanctions alone cannot resolve deeply entrenched geopolitical disputes shaped by history, ideology, and power politics.

**The Effectiveness of Sanctions in Influencing Russia's Political and Military Behaviour**

The sanctions imposed during the Russia–Ukraine conflict reveal a complex interplay between economic coercion, political resilience, and global strategic shifts. Although originally intended to deter Russian aggression, sanctions produced measurable economic consequences by weakening the ruble, limiting foreign investment, and disrupting trade. Over time, however, their ability to reshape state behaviour proved limited. Russia's authoritarian structure and control over domestic media reframed sanctions from punitive measures into symbols of national resistance. By portraying Western sanctions as hostile acts, the Kremlin mobilised public sentiment and encouraged citizens to view economic hardship as part of a patriotic struggle. This undermined the political pressure expected from sanctions and strengthened domestic support for the regime.

Internationally, sanctions have contributed to substantial geopolitical realignment. Instead of isolating Russia, they accelerated its shift toward non-Western economic partnerships, especially with China, India, Iran, and BRICS members. These alliances facilitated new financial mechanisms, local-currency trade, and alternative energy routes that bypass Western systems. As a result, sanctions have indirectly weakened Western financial dominance and supported the emergence of a more multipolar global order. Russia's adaptability—visible in import substitution, fiscal interventions, and redirected exports—shows that sanctions can prompt strategic recalibration rather than compliance.

At a structural level, the conflict highlights that the effectiveness of sanctions depends on cohesive international enforcement and the target state's access to alternative support. Russia's ability to maintain global economic connections through Asian and Middle Eastern partners exposes the vulnerabilities of Western-centric sanctions systems. Without complementary diplomatic initiatives, humanitarian coordination, and negotiation pathways, sanctions risk entrenching hostility rather than promoting policy change. In authoritarian contexts, economic coercion alone is insufficient to trigger political transformation, making sanctions more symbolic than transformative.

**The Economic, Political, and Humanitarian Impacts of the Sanctions**

The sanctions imposed in response to the Russia–Ukraine conflict have produced wide-ranging economic, political, and humanitarian effects extending far beyond the immediate war zone. Their impact is evident across global markets, diplomatic relations, and daily human welfare.

**Major Impacts of the Conflict**

Global Energy Price Volatility: Restrictions on Russian oil and gas exports increased global energy prices, raising household costs and production expenses worldwide.

Supply Chain Disruptions: Sanctions and war-related blockages disrupted the flow of key commodities—including grains, fertilisers, and metals—destabilising food markets and manufacturing industries.

Worldwide Inflationary Pressure: Rising food and energy prices contributed to higher inflation rates in Europe, Africa, and parts of Asia, deepening economic hardship.

Financial and Currency Strain on Russia: Limited access to international banking, frozen foreign assets, and reduced investment weakened Russia's financial system and constrained long-term growth.

Humanitarian Hardship in Ukraine: Blocked trade routes, reduced government revenue, and ongoing conflict exacerbated food insecurity, displacement, and reliance on aid.

## Conclusion

In conclusion, the use of economic sanctions in international conflict resolution, illustrated by the Russia-Ukraine war, demonstrates both their strategic utility and inherent constraints. While sanctions have imposed substantial economic pressure on Russia by restricting trade, isolating financial networks, and limiting access to technology, they have not compelled a decisive shift in state behaviour. Russia's internal political cohesion, control over public narratives, and ability to build alternative alliances have significantly reduced the sanctions' coercive power. The uneven enforcement of sanctions across countries further weakens their impact, while humanitarian consequences and unintended geopolitical shifts underscore the limitations of sanctions as stand-alone instruments. Sustainable conflict resolution therefore requires a comprehensive approach that integrates economic pressure with diplomacy, negotiation, and long-term peacebuilding strategies.

## Recommendations

Strengthen International Coordination: Global actors should enhance collaboration and enforcement mechanisms to prevent sanction evasion. A unified framework involving both Western and non-Western countries is essential to ensure consistency and effectiveness.

Complement Sanctions with Diplomacy: Economic measures should be paired with ongoing diplomacy, peace negotiations, and humanitarian assistance. An integrated approach prevents the entrenchment of hostility and creates conditions for meaningful conflict resolution.

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# FARMER-HERDER CRISIS AND FOOD SECURITY IN NORTHEAST NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** The farmer-herder crisis in Northeast Nigeria has become a significant threat to food security, livelihoods, and regional stability. What began as localized disputes over land, grazing routes, and water resources has escalated into violent clashes, fueled by environmental degradation, population pressures, climate change, and weak governance. The study examines the interplay between farmer–herder conflicts and food insecurity in the region, highlighting how recurring violence disrupts agricultural production, displaces households, undermines access to food. Employing a mixed-methods approach that combines field interviews, focus group discussions, and secondary data analysis, the research investigates the socio-economic, environmental, and institutional factors that exacerbate the crisis. Findings reveal that destruction of farmlands, loss of livestock, and displacement of farming and pastoralist communities contribute to decreased food availability and heightened vulnerability among affected populations. The study further identifies gaps in government response, inadequate conflict resolution mechanisms, and the proliferation of small arms as key drivers of ongoing insecurity. The study underscores the need for integrated strategies that combine conflict management, climate-sensitive land-use policies, and community-based interventions to enhance food security. It concludes that sustainable solutions require coordinated efforts that address both immediate humanitarian needs and long-term structural vulnerabilities to restore agricultural productivity and ensure access to adequate food in Northeast Nigeria.

**Keywords:** Farmer, Herder, Crisis, Violent Conflicts, Food security

## Introduction

Northeast Nigeria has experienced recurring conflicts between farmers and herders over the last decades, posing serious threats to food security, livelihoods, and regional stability. Historically, farmers and pastoralists coexisted through mutually beneficial arrangements where the seasonal livestock migration and shared access to arable land and water ensured a state of minimal conflict and sustained agricultural production. Over time, however, this balance has been disrupted by environmental, demographic, and socio-political pressures,

transforming manageable disputes into violent confrontations with widespread humanitarian and developmental consequences.

Environmental degradation such as desertification, soil erosion, and climate change has reduced fertile land and availability of water, increasing competition for the scarce resources. Population growth, expanding settlements, and changed migration routes increase tensions, while weak governance, a lack of adequate mechanisms for resolving conflicts, and politicizing of disputes have transformed localized disputes to protracted conflict. These dynamics disrupt farming activities, destroy livestock, displace communities, and weaken local food systems, which heighten food insecurity.

The crisis also has broader socio-economic implications: displaced populations, disrupted livelihoods, limited market access, and heightened vulnerability to hunger, while social cohesion between ethnic and occupational groups deteriorates. Thus, response to the crisis must be multidimensional, moving beyond short-term security measures to include long-term food production strategies, natural resource management, and resiliency-building at the community level.

This paper brings to light the inter-link between the farmer-herder crisis and food security among the farming communities in Northeastern Nigeria, through a mixed-methods approach combining field interviews, focus group discussions, and secondary data analyses. This will explore the socioeconomic, environmental, and institutional drivers of the recurring conflict, while informing integrated policy interventions that can restore agricultural productivity, enhance food security, and promote stability in the region.

**Literature Review on Farmer-herder Crisis and food Security in Northeast Nigeria**

In understanding, the historical background of the farmers and herder's crisis in Nigeria and the world at large scholars come up with two main standpoints: The historical account of the Fulani people and the history of their migration, and the extent to which it is viewed on the political economy of the federation.

As observed by Miller (2007) the Fulani's are an ethno-linguistic group spread across fifteen countries in Africa. By the year 2000, there were thirteen million Fulani speakers inhabiting an area of over 3000 square miles, from Mauritania in the north to Cameroon in the south, Sudan in the east and Senegal in the west. In spite of that, the cooperation between Fulani's and herding remains strong in the minds of many Africans, and many present day Fulani's are pastoralists, because of their prevalent; the Fulani's have a great history of interaction with a large range of groups of peoples, including many whose subsistence is primarily based on agriculture. Fulani's are historically been known as herders. Many do not engage solely in pastoralism and the marketing and exchange of animal products, however. In some parts of occupation, Fulanis are known as traders and shopkeepers and for numerous others

cultivation has become increasingly important. The increasing numbers of Fulanis have intensified some agricultural activity to their production strategies; others have accepted farming as their primary mode of survival. This led to the development and sustainability of food security such as food availability, food accessibility, food stability and food utilization.

According to (World Bank Overseas Evaluation Department (1994:4); farmers and herders are interdependent and interrelated who have established symbiotic relationships among themselves were based on commonality of interest. On his own opinions, Bassett (1988); that the farmers and herders in most of West African countries including the Sahel regions, were mutually benefiting from each other by the cattle entrustment of dung and stubble exchange. This cooperative skill increases productivity, socio-economic development, and reduces risks of famine for both producers (farmers and herders). By Cattle, entrustment is a situation where a farmer lends cattle that he or she owns to a herder, who will then take care of them in return for being able to keep some or all of the milk and offspring that the cattle produce.

With the approval of farmers, herders, and local authorities, a system known as "Burti," a Fulani term for a legally allocated path of land for cattle migratory routes, surely accepted by herders and farmers during the British colonial era in Nigeria. After the British colonial masters withdrew from Nigeria, farmers started claiming ownership of areas taken from them and given to herders as migratory routes in the early 1970s (Blench R. 2010). This claim of ownership triggered a series of disputes between farmers and herders.

According to Blench (2016), the Fulani herdsmen have a powerful and effective national group that stands up for them wherever they settle in Nigeria. The Miyetti Allah Cattle Breeders' Association of Nigeria (MACBAN) is the name of this association. The main body representing Fulani herdsmen in Nigeria called MACBAN. The organization's operations involve speaking out for pastoralists or Fulani nomads before the government, defending land use rights, providing education to nomadic communities, and mediating disputes between farmers and pastoralists. The organization supports cattle producers' access to more and better grazing lands.

From a societal perspective, a farmer is one of the most important members of the community, responsible for providing food to the population. Farmers may engage in various agricultural activities, including cultivating crops, raising dairy cattle, or producing other agricultural products. Their roles may involve planting, cultivation, post-harvest processing, overseeing farm labor, and managing agricultural enterprises (OECD, 2023).

The Nigerian Land Use Act of 1978 further exacerbated tensions. This law allowed indigenous people to apply for certificates of ownership for ancestral lands while giving state and federal government’s authority over land allocation (Okello, Anna, Majekodunmi, & Ayodele, 2014). Many Fulani pastoralists, due to their nomadic lifestyle and frequent transhumance, failed to secure legal ownership of grazing routes. Consequently, they found

themselves in precarious situations, often encroaching on other people's farmlands, leading to violent conflicts (Pastoralism Journal, 2014).

A new definition of food security that considers the basic needs and struggles of people vulnerable to famine, hunger, and food crises was deemed necessary (Shaw, 2007). Food security was defined as "the availability at all times of sufficient supplies of basic foodstuffs to sustain a consistent increase of food consumption and to counterbalance production fluctuations" during the World Food Conference in 1974 (United Nations, 1975)

The definition of food security divided into four categories (FAO, 2008):

i. The availability of food that is imported from overseas and produced locally.

ii. Accessibility. The consumer has enough money to make the purchase and the food can reach them (transportation infrastructure). Socio-cultural accessibility is added to such physical and economic accessibility to guarantee that the cuisine is culturally appropriate and that social safety nets are in place to assist the less fortunate.

iii. Utilization. This refers to the ability of individuals to consume sufficient and nutritious food to lead healthy lives. Adequate water and sanitation are integral at this level. A human has to be able to eat enough food, both in terms of quantity and quality. Adequate water and sanitation are also involved at this level both food and water must be safe and clean. To effectively digest and utilize the food you eat, a person must also be in good physical health.

iv. Stability. The nation, society, and a person's ability to withstand shocks to the food chain system whether driven on by man-made or natural disasters like wars or economic crises. It is clear from this that there are several levels of food security. One could say that Stability includes a time component that affects all the levels, including Availability (national), Accessibility (household), as well as Utilization (individual), is the resilience of nations, societies, individuals to shocks that disrupt food systems, such as wars, economic crises and natural disaster.

**Impacts of Farmers-Herders crisis on Food Security in Northeast, Nigeria**

The farmers-herders crisis in Northeast Nigeria has profoundly weakened food security by disrupting agricultural production, market systems, and household livelihoods. Recurrent clashes lead to the abandonment of farmlands, destruction of crops, and reduced cultivation during key agricultural seasons, resulting in lower food availability across affected communities (Tukur et al., 2024). Pastoralist livelihoods are similarly undermined as restrictions on grazing mobility, cattle rustling, and loss of grazing routes reduce livestock productivity and diminish the supply of animal protein (Dabo et al., 2024). These conditions

align with evidence showing that the frequency and intensity of farmer–herder conflict significantly heighten household food insecurity in rural Nigeria (Nnaji et al., 2022). The violence has also displaced thousands of farming and herding households, stripping them of access to productive assets and increasing dependence on humanitarian support (Mohammed, 2023). Market disruptions further compound these challenges, as insecurity along transport corridors constrains the movement of agricultural goods, inflates food prices, and limits household access to affordable and nutritious food (Obikaeze et al., 2023). Over time, the erosion of assets, livelihoods, and coping mechanisms deepens vulnerability, contributing to rising levels of hunger, malnutrition, and weakened food system resilience in the region (Al-Hikmah University, 2025; Ioryue, 2024).

**Theoretical Framework**

This paper is anchored on the Relative Deprivation Theory, which articulately illustrates a framework for understanding the farmer-herder crisis and its influence on food security in Northeast Nigeria. RDT posits that conflict occurs when groups perceive a difference between what they feel they deserve and what they, in reality, receive. Land and livestock are core resources round which these perceptions of deprivation revolve in this setting. To farmers, land is their most important source of livelihood, identity, and security, while to Fulani herders, livestock kept on land are the most vital asset and measure of wealth (Okoli, 2014). Thus, both parties look upon each other's threat to land access as an attack on their existence.

Such perceptions are further heightened by desertification and the decline in pasture quality. To farmers, cattle encroachment is an attack on their farms, while herders view blocked grazing routes and restrictive land-use policies as threats to their very existence. These differing interpretations feed grievances and suspicion, and often turn contestation over resources into overt violence. RDT helps make sense of how such perceived injustices escalate into sustained hostilities.

The theory also explains the implications for food security more broadly. The conflict has disrupted farming cycles, displaced rural communities, and destroyed the traditional patterns of farmer–herder cooperation upon which local food systems relied. Farmlands have been destroyed, livestock lost, and trade routes obstructed-all factors that reduce food availability and stability and have worsened hunger and poverty in this already fragile region. From this perspective, food insecurity seems not just an agricultural concern but a direct result of profound injustices around land and resource access.

The utility of Relative Deprivation Theory (RDT) provides a vital analytical framework for comprehending the dynamics of the farmers-herders dispute and its consequences for food security in Northeast Nigeria. RDT contends that conflict frequently arises not from absolute scarcity, but from perceived disparities in expected and real access to resources,

opportunities, and rights. This impression of injustice or marginalization can cause frustration and, in certain cases, provoke communal violence. In Northeast Nigeria, both farming and herding communities feel themselves as underprivileged in comparison to one another and their historical entitlements.

Applying this idea (relative deprivation theory) to the study of the farmer-herder crisis on food security in North-East Nigeria, it is all about herders owning livestock on the one hand and farmers having access to land on the other. In this grave scenario, it is apparent that farmers see land as a highly precious asset. It is not just a means of life but also a source of wealth and conflict; lack of access to land not only deprives people of their primary source of income but also threatens their continued existence as humans.

Regrettably, the people of North-East Nigeria loved (valued) land the same way a Fulani pastoralist valued his cattle. In the words of Okoli (2014), the most valued possession in a Fulani's life is his livestock, which he keeps on land. The quantity he preserves is the measure of his riches; hence, both farmers and herders would go to any length to protect their rights of access to any area of land."

Furthermore, the application of RDT assists in understanding the crisis's broader consequences for regional food security. The ongoing fighting has disrupted agricultural processes, uprooted rural populations, and undermined traditional farmer-herder collaboration. These developments have directly harmed food supply, accessibility, and stability in an already fragile region. The devastation of farms, loss of animals, and blockage of trade routes aggravate hunger and poverty, continuing the cycle of deprivation and violence. RDT explains how social and psychological frustrations manifest as tangible challenges to food systems and human security.

**Methodological Context**

The paper adopted a mixed-methods approach, integrating quantitative and qualitative techniques and the ex-post facto research design in understanding the relationship existing between the farmer-herder crisis and food security in Northeast Nigeria. This is so because the independent variable the crisis already occurred and could not have been manipulated; this design therefore allows the researcher to investigate its effects on the dependent variable, which is food security, by assessing food availability, accessibility, affordability, and nutritional status. Within this framework, communities in Northeast Nigeria were selected based on their varying exposures to the conflict, allowing a comparative analysis of the food security outcome across high- and low-conflict areas. The farmer-herder crisis was operationalized using documented incidents, the frequency of clashes, and levels of population displacement. Food security, in turn, was measured through established indicators such as household dietary diversity scores, malnutrition rates, market accessibility, and agricultural output. The study area covers Adamawa, Gombe, and Taraba States. These states

were selected from the six states in the Northeast due to the high incidence of farmer-herder conflicts, as well as the challenges they face in food production.

## The nature and dynamic of farmers-herders crisis and food security in the northeast, Nigeria

The nature and dynamics of the farmer-herder crisis in Northeast Nigeria reflect a complex interplay of environmental pressures, competition for resources, and socio-economic vulnerabilities. As grazing lands shrink due to desertification, with increasing population intensifying the demand for farmland, clashes between farmers seeking to protect their crops and herders in search of pasture have become increasingly frequent and violent. Such conflicts disrupt agricultural activities, displace rural communities, and undermine systems of cooperation that traditionally enabled local livelihoods. This impact translates to poor food security in the region, characterized by declining crop production, loss of livestock, and restricted market access, which have consequently reduced the availability of food, its affordability, and enhanced malnutrition levels. This sets the stage for understanding the way the crisis is continuing to threaten the overall stability and well-being of communities throughout Northeast Nigeria. Table 1 shows the nature and dynamics of the farmer-herder crisis on food security in North-East Nigeria.

**Table 1: Respondents' opinion on the nature and dynamics of the farmers-herders crisis**

| Question | SD | D | U | A | SA | Total | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | F | % | F | % | F | % | F | % | F | % | F | % |
| The farmers-herders conflict has worsened over the years. | 257 | 22.43 | 107 | 9.34 | 22 | 1.92 | 242 | 21.12 | 518 | 45.20 | 1146 | 100 |
| Conflicts are driven by competition over land and water. | 188 | 16.40 | 123 | 10.73 | 9 | 0.79 | 225 | 19.63 | 601 | 52.44 | 1146 | 100 |
| Climate change contributes to herder-farmer clashes. | 191 | 16.67 | 133 | 11.61 | 58 | 5.06 | 206 | 17.98 | 558 | 48.69 | 1146 | 100 |
| The crisis pattern varies across states in the northeast. | 233 | 20.33 | 87 | 7.59 | 8 | 0.70 | 230 | 20.07 | 588 | 51.31 | 1146 | 100 |
| There are significant seasonal trends in the conflicts. | 178 | 15.53 | 89 | 7.77 | 5 | 0.44 | 273 | 23.82 | 601 | 52.44 | 1146 | 100 |

Source: Fieldwork 2025

Clear evidence of the nature and dynamics of the farmers-herders crisis in Northeast Nigeria is provided by the descriptive and inferential analysis of Table 1. The emerging patterns

among respondents are supported by chi-square tests and interview data that reveal a conflict that is deepening, increasingly complex, and strongly linked to environmental and livelihood pressures.

A majority of the respondents reported that the crisis had escalated over the years, 45.2% strongly agreeing and 21.1% agreeing. This is also reflected in interview statements such as that of journalist Raymond Enoch of Taraba State, who observed that “in the past, disputes ended with village talks; now we count casualties before peace talks even begin.” This reflects how the conflict has escalated from localized scuffles to more violent and protracted confrontations.

Resource competition became a main driver, with over 72% agreeing that the scarcity of land and water was responsible for fueling the crisis. This is in line with established research on land-use conflict in agrarian societies and reflects the shrinking arable land and desertification-driven migration patterns in the region. Similarly, nearly 67% cited climate change as a contributing factor, echoing interview commentary that “grazing routes have disappeared… everybody fights for what is left.” These kinds of perspectives reveal an increased recognition that environmental stress is reconfiguring the landscape of conflict.

Spatial differences were also highlighted, with over 71% agreeing that the crisis manifests differently across states, and thus confirmed that Gombe, Adamawa, and Taraba states represent different forms of conflict intensity and dynamics. Over 76% of respondents similarly affirmed seasonal variation consistent with field narratives of dry-season movements being a major trigger for clashes when farms are ripe and pasture is scarce.

The findings emphasize a multidimensional conflict shaped by livelihood pressures, ecological stress, and weak governance responses. The evidence reinforces the paper that the farmers–herders’ crisis is intensifying and structurally rooted, with significant implications for food security and regional stability.

**Farmers-herders crisis impact on food security in northeast Nigeria**

The impact of the farmer–herder crisis on food security in Northeast Nigeria is profound and far-reaching. Agricultural productivity in this region has progressively declined due to violent clashes that disrupt farming seasons and destroy crops, thus displacing rural households. Herders equally suffer losses through cattle deaths, theft, and restricted access to grazing areas, reducing livestock availability and market supply. Trade routes are becoming unsafe and, consequently, limiting food distribution and driving up prices in local markets. These disruptions reduce availability, access, affordability, and nutritional outcomes. With already high levels of poverty, climate stress, and poor governance, this crisis is becoming a major driver of increasing hunger and instability. Table 2 shows the impact of farmers-herders crisis on food security.

**Table 2: Respondents' views on the impact of farmers-herders crisis on food security**

| S/N | Question | SD | | D | | U | | A | | SA | | Total | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | F | % | F | % | F | % | F | % | F | % | F | % |
| 1. | The crisis has disrupted food production in your community. | 198 | 17.28 | 134 | 11.69 | 16 | 1.40 | 199 | 17.36 | 599 | 52.27 | 1146 | 100 |
| 2. | Prices of agricultural products have increased due to the crisis. | 133 | 11.61 | 107 | 9.34 | 3 | 0.26 | 200 | 17.45 | 703 | 61.34 | 1146 | 100 |
| 3. | Farming areas have become unsafe, reducing food output. | 239 | 20.86 | 99 | 8.64 | 33 | 2.88 | 214 | 18.67 | 561 | 48.95 | 1146 | 100 |
| 4. | There is a decline in food availability in local markets. | 144 | 12.57 | 129 | 11.26 | 13 | 1.13 | 350 | 30.54 | 510 | 44.50 | 1146 | 100 |
| 5. | Food insecurity is more severe in conflict-affected areas. | 207 | 18.06 | 111 | 9.69 | 8 | 0.70 | 130 | 11.34 | 690 | 60.21 | 1146 | 100 |

Source: Fieldwork 2025

As indicated in Table two, there is strong consensus that the farmers–herders crisis has considerably undermined food security across Northeast Nigeria. All the indicators show high agreement levels of disruption to food production, price increases, reduced availability at markets, and increased insecurity around farming.

About 69.6% of the respondents agreed that the crisis has disrupted food production, reflecting reduced farming due to displacement, fear, and destruction of crops. One interviewee (The chief of Bakula chiefdom, HRH Chief Tahir Nyawo) explained this way in Taraba: "Many people can't go to their farms anymore. It's too risky." This confirms other research that shows pastoral conflict undermines agrarian systems. An overwhelming 78.8% agreed that food prices have raised sharply-a clear supply shock from reduced production and insecure transportation routes. This pattern is consistent with FAO reports attributing food inflation in fragile countries to conflict.

The same percentage, about 67.6%, confirmed that farmlands are no longer safe; this was evident in the output produced, a fact further supported by interviewees' observations: fear alone simply keeps farmers off their farms. Even without experiencing direct attacks, the feeling of insecurity has served to further depress productivity in farming.

Food availability has also declined; 75% of respondents have reported food shortages in local markets. This again may reflect cascading effects from reduced production and disrupted markets, in line with previous literature from other conflict-shocked states.

Finally, 71.5% agreed that food insecurity is most severe in the conflict-affected communities. Indeed, field interviews confirm this, as some villages have come to depend on humanitarian assistance instead of local production. Data reveal a clear trend: the farmers-herders' crisis has badly destabilized the food systems in Northeast Nigeria, from weakened production and markets to reduced access to food by households.

**Major Findings**

From the forgoing, the study arrived at the following findings;

(a) The nature and dynamics of the farmers-herders conflict in Northeast Nigeria have increased over the past three decades primarily due to increased competition for arable land and water resources. Environmental degradation due to climate change-induced processes and a shift in migratory routes have also increased the competition.

(b) It was also found that the crisis has had significant effects on food security in the region by disrupting agricultural production and food production systems.

**Conclusion**

In sum, this study shows that within the last three decades, the conflict between farmers and herders in Northeast Nigeria has grown more heated, largely because of unprecedented competition for land and water, worsening environmental conditions, and changing migration patterns. This pressure turns what was once a manageable conflict over resources into one that is more frequent and destructive. The findings further indicate that this growing crisis has had devastating impacts on food security in the region by disrupting agricultural production, weakening food systems, and constraining the availability and accessibility of key food supplies. Collectively, the evidence affirms that resolving the conflict and restoring food security will require addressing both the environmental and socio-economic factors at the heart of the crisis.

**Recommendations**

a. Available studies from the findings show that most of the crisis between farmers and herders was as a result of grazing land and water resources.
   In view of that, the paper recommends that the Federal government and state governments should provide grazing routes as well as water to herders; this will go a long way to prevent and manage the farmer-herder crisis in the affected states.

b. Improve Security in At-Risk Communities: The government should apply adequate and community-sensitive security measures across areas with frequent clashes. Improved security will protect farmers and herders, give stability to agricultural

activities, and make food production uninterrupted. Ensuring a safe environment is critical for restoring food security and rebuilding rural livelihoods in the region.

c. That the Nigerian state government should ensure that life and economic resources, particularly food and water resources as well as environmental sustainability, are adequately secured to galvanise development and prevent crises that will trigger the displacement of human and natural resources in the Northeast region and Nigeria as a whole.

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# THE IMPACT OF SECURITY AGENCIES ON PEACEBUILDING IN TARABA STATE, NORTHEAST NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** Security agencies play a pivotal role in conflict prevention, management, and peace building, particularly in regions affected by recurrent violence. In Taraba State, Northeast Nigeria, episodes of farmer–herder clashes, communal violence, and political conflicts have placed immense pressure on security institutions to restore order and create a conducive environment for peace. This study investigates the impact of security agencies in promoting peacebuilding in Taraba State, with a focus on their strategies, challenges, and effectiveness in mitigating violence. Adopting a mixed-method approach, the research integrates quantitative data from household surveys with qualitative insights from key informant interviews involving members of the Nigeria Police Force, Civil Defence Corps, the Nigerian Army, local vigilante groups, and community leaders. The study examines the contributions of these actors to conflict resolution, early warning and response, protection of civilians, and post-conflict stabilization efforts. Preliminary findings suggest that while security agencies have been instrumental in quelling violence, however their interventions are sometimes reactive rather than preventive, and occasionally exacerbate tensions due to allegations of bias, human rights violations, and delayed response times. The study concludes that security agencies remain veritable instruments for enhancing peace building in Taraba State, and to ensure their continuous relevance measures such as capacity building, adequate funding and community-oriented policing must be put in place for long term stability.

**Keywords:** Security agencies, peacebuilding, conflict, early warning system, capacity building.

## Introduction

The pursuit of peace and security remains a central challenge in Nigeria's socio-political development, particularly in regions affected by persistent communal and identity-based conflicts. Taraba State, located in Nigeria's North-East geopolitical zone, exemplifies this challenge due to its prolonged exposure to diverse forms of insecurity. Over the years, the state has experienced farmer–herder conflicts, communal clashes, banditry, kidnapping, and ethno-religious violence. These threats have not only undermined stability and economic development but have also weakened public confidence in state institutions. Consequently, the role of security agencies in maintaining order and fostering peace has become

increasingly important in understanding peacebuilding processes in the state (Bello, 2020; Okom, 2019).

Created in 1991, Taraba State is endowed with fertile agricultural land and a rich diversity of ethnic groups, including the Jukun, Tiv, Fulani, Mumuye, Kuteb, Chamba and others. While this diversity presents opportunities for cultural integration and economic growth, it has also intensified competition over land, political representation, and resource control. These tensions have contributed to recurring conflicts, particularly the farmer–herder crisis, which escalated significantly after 2013. The proliferation of small arms and the rise of organized banditry have further complicated the security landscape, stretching the capacity of both traditional conflict resolution mechanisms and formal security institutions (Alemika & Okoye, 2020; Okeke, 2021).

In response, several security agencies, including the Nigerian Police Force, Nigerian Army, Department of State Services, and the Nigeria Security and Civil Defence Corps, have assumed prominent roles in maintaining peace and order. Beyond their constitutional mandate to protect lives and property, these agencies have expanded their responsibilities to include peace enforcement, conflict mediation, and post-conflict recovery efforts (Ibrahim, 2018). Military operations such as Operation Whirl Stroke and Operation Ayem Akpatuma, alongside initiatives like the Agro Rangers unit, have been deployed to address violent conflicts and mediate disputes between farmers and herders.

Although these interventions have produced some short-term stability, such as reducing attacks and facilitating the return of displaced persons, they have also faced criticism. Many analysts argue that the dominance of militarized approaches emphasizes coercion rather than reconciliation, limiting their effectiveness in achieving sustainable peace. By focusing primarily on immediate security concerns, these strategies often fail to address the underlying causes of conflict, including land disputes, political exclusion, and economic marginalization. As a result, while violence may temporarily decline, the root tensions frequently persist (Okom, 2019; Ibeanu, 2020).

Recent efforts to improve security outcomes in Taraba State have emphasized collaboration among security agencies and between these agencies and the state government. Joint operations involving the military, police, and civil defence corps have been carried out to deter criminal activities, particularly during elections and festive periods. These operations, often combined with community engagement initiatives, have contributed to a reduction in certain forms of insecurity in volatile areas such as Wukari, Takum, and Donga (Guardian, 2023; Von, 2023). Such developments reflect a growing recognition of the need for coordinated and integrated security responses.

Despite these efforts, an important question remains whether these interventions constitute genuine peacebuilding or merely peacekeeping. Peacebuilding extends beyond the cessation

of violence to include the creation of sustainable structures and relationships that address the root causes of conflict and prevent recurrence (Bercovitch & Jackson, 2009). In Taraba State, however, security responses have largely remained reactive and militarized, often neglecting critical elements such as inclusive governance, socio-economic development, and community participation (Okeke, 2021).

Furthermore, the reliance on coercive strategies has, in some cases, led to unintended consequences, including strained civil–military relations. Reports of human rights abuses—such as harassment, arbitrary arrests, and excessive use of force—have eroded trust between communities and security agencies, thereby undermining cooperation in conflict resolution efforts (Human Rights Watch, 2021). These challenges are compounded by issues such as inadequate training, poor logistics, and limited understanding of local conflict dynamics among security personnel (Ibrahim, 2018). Thus, while security agencies may restore order in the short term, they often struggle to build the trust and institutional capacity necessary for long-term peace.

Nevertheless, the contributions of security agencies to peacebuilding in Taraba State remain significant. Their presence in conflict-prone areas has helped deter violence, protect civilians, and support humanitarian efforts. In some instances, security agencies have also engaged in dialogue and mediation processes, particularly in collaboration with traditional leaders and civil society organizations. These efforts have yielded modest successes, including localized peace agreements and disarmament initiatives (Von, 2023).

This study, therefore, examines the impact of security agencies on peacebuilding in Taraba State by assessing both their contributions and limitations. It focuses on how their operations influence community trust, conflict dynamics, and reconciliation processes, as well as how they interact with other peacebuilding actors. Adopting a multidimensional perspective that integrates security, governance, and development, the study highlights the importance of balancing coercive measures with participatory and development-oriented strategies.

Ultimately, sustainable peace in Taraba State depends not only on the effectiveness of security agencies but also on the establishment of inclusive, accountable, and community-driven institutions. Strengthening collaboration between formal security structures and local peacebuilding actors will be essential for addressing the root causes of conflict and ensuring long-term stability.

**Statement of the Problem**

Taraba State continues to experience persistent violent conflicts despite ongoing interventions by federal and state security agencies. Incidents such as farmer–herder clashes, communal and ethno-religious violence, banditry, kidnapping, and politically driven unrest highlight concerns about the effectiveness of these agencies in fostering sustainable peace. Although

institutions like the Nigerian Army, Nigeria Police Force, and Nigeria Security and Civil Defence Corps are mandated to maintain security, their responses have largely been reactive, focusing on immediate crisis control rather than addressing underlying causes of conflict.

A key challenge is the disconnection between security operations and community-based peacebuilding efforts. Reports of excessive force, human rights violations, perceived bias, and delayed responses have weakened public trust, particularly in rural areas most affected by conflict. This mistrust reduces cooperation, limits intelligence gathering, and undermines early-warning systems, thereby weakening long-term peace efforts.

In addition, issues such as poor inter-agency coordination, inadequate logistics, insufficient training in conflict-sensitive approaches, and political interference hinder the effectiveness of security agencies. The absence of a comprehensive state-level peacebuilding framework further fragments collaboration among security actors, traditional institutions, and civil society groups.

Moreover, there is a lack of empirical research examining the role of security agencies in peacebuilding from the perspective of affected communities. This gap restricts informed policymaking and security reforms. Therefore, a systematic assessment is necessary to evaluate their impact, identify challenges, and propose strategies for achieving sustainable peace in Taraba State.

**Research Objectives**

This study is guided by the following objectives:

i. To examine the strategies employed by security agencies in conflict prevention and peacebuilding in Taraba State.

ii. To assess the effectiveness of security agencies in mitigating violence and promoting peacebuilding in Taraba State.

iii. Identify the challenges faced by security agencies and analyze community perceptions of their roles in conflict prevention and resolution in Taraba State.

**Research Questions**

i. What strategies do security agencies employ to promote peacebuilding and conflict prevention in Taraba State?

ii. How effective are security agencies in mitigating violence and promoting peacebuilding in Taraba State?

iii. What challenges hinder the performance of security agencies, and how do communities perceive their roles in conflict prevention and resolution in Taraba State?

## Conceptual Clarification

### Peace-Building

Peace building refers to continuous efforts aimed at preventing violent conflict and promoting sustainable peace within society. It involves addressing the root causes of conflict through reconciliation, justice, social development, and peaceful coexistence (Galtung, 1996). Peace building goes beyond the absence of war by creating structures and relationships that encourage long-term harmony and stability. It includes activities such as dialogue, mediation, institution building, poverty reduction, human rights protection, and community development (Lederach, 1997). Governments, civil society organizations, religious institutions, and international bodies often participate in peace building initiatives. In conflict-prone societies, peace building also helps restore trust, strengthen democratic institutions, improve governance, and encourage citizen participation in decision-making processes.

### Security Agencies

Security agencies are government institutions established to maintain law and order, protect lives and property, and ensure national security. Their responsibilities include preventing and responding to crimes, terrorism, insurgency, kidnapping, communal violence, and other threats to public safety (Alemika, 2013). In Nigeria, examples include the Nigeria Police Force, the Nigerian Army, the Department of State Services, the Nigeria Security and Civil Defence Corps, and the Economic and Financial Crimes Commission. These agencies contribute to peace and stability through intelligence gathering, conflict prevention, peace enforcement, and post-conflict recovery. However, their effectiveness may be limited by challenges such as corruption, poor funding, inadequate training, political interference, and lack of public trust (Nwolise, 2006).

### Peace Building Efforts

Peace building efforts refer to specific actions, programmes, and policies designed to promote peace and prevent violence. Such efforts may involve peace education, negotiation, mediation, reconciliation programmes, youth empowerment, poverty alleviation, rehabilitation of displaced persons, and social justice initiatives (Paris, 2004). In Nigeria, peace building efforts have been applied in addressing insurgency in the North-East, farmer-herder conflicts, militancy in the Niger Delta, and communal clashes. Government

institutions, non-governmental organizations, religious groups, and international organizations such as the United Nations and ECOWAS have played major roles through humanitarian assistance, mediation, and capacity-building programmes.

**Impacts of Peacebuilding and Security Management**

Impacts refer to the outcomes or consequences of policies, programmes, or actions. In peace building and security management, impacts may be positive or negative depending on the effectiveness of the strategies used. Positive impacts include reduction in violence, restoration of peace, economic growth, political stability, protection of human rights, and improved public confidence in government institutions (Call & Cousens, 2008). Successful peace building can also promote national integration, encourage the return of displaced persons, and create conditions for sustainable development. Conversely, weak peace building efforts and ineffective security institutions may result in continued violence, displacement, destruction of property, and economic decline.

**Positive Impacts of Security Agencies on Peacebuilding**

Scholars generally agree that security agencies contribute to creating the stability necessary for peacebuilding. Security agencies play important roles in peacebuilding by maintaining law and order, deterring violence, and supporting humanitarian and mediation efforts. Scholars such as Bercovitch and Jackson (2009) argue that peace processes succeed more effectively in stable environments. In Taraba State, security agencies have contributed to reducing violence through joint patrols, inter-agency cooperation, and protection of communities. Their presence also creates confidence for community-based peacebuilding initiatives and dialogue among conflicting groups. Capacity-building and security-sector reforms, especially through inter-agency training programs, further strengthen peacebuilding efforts and democratic governance.

**Negative Impacts of Security Agencies on Peacebuilding**

Despite these positive contributions, multiple studies document significant limitations in how security agencies approach peacebuilding. However, several challenges limit the effectiveness of security agencies in sustaining peace. Excessive militarization and reliance on force often deepen grievances and weaken public trust. Reports of human rights abuses, including arbitrary arrests and harassment, undermine the legitimacy of security institutions and discourage community cooperation. Poor coordination among security agencies also leads to duplication of efforts and weak operational responses. In addition, most interventions focus on containing violence rather than addressing root causes such as poverty, political exclusion, and land disputes. Limited consultation with local leaders and traditional institutions further creates distrust, especially in rural communities, thereby reducing the effectiveness of peacebuilding operations.

**Nature and Dimensions of Insecurity in Taraba State**

Insecurity in Taraba State is shaped by a complex interplay of historical, political, socio-economic, and environmental factors. As part of Nigeria's North-East region, characterized by fragile institutions, diverse ethnic identities, and porous borders, the state reflects broader national insecurity trends while exhibiting distinct local dynamics. Scholars define insecurity as the absence of protection from threats to life and livelihood, particularly where state authority is weak (Adebayo, 2014; Ezeoha, 2018). This definition aptly captures the situation in Taraba, where multiple, overlapping forms of conflict persist.

A major driver of insecurity is communal and ethno-religious conflict. With over eighty ethnic groups, Taraba experiences frequent clashes rooted in competition over land, political power, and traditional leadership. Notable examples include conflicts between the Jukun and Tiv, Kuteb and Chamba, and Mambilla and Fulani communities. These tensions are often intensified by perceptions of marginalization and unequal access to resources (Osaghae & Suberu, 2005; Ukiwo, 2011). The spread of small arms and weakening traditional conflict-resolution mechanisms further escalate violence.

Farmer-herder conflicts also constitute a critical dimension. Competition over land, water, and grazing routes, worsened by climate change, desertification, and population growth, has led to recurrent violent encounters. This pattern aligns with trends across the Sahel and Nigeria's Middle Belt, where environmental stress fuels resource-based conflicts (Blench, 2010; Okoli & Atelhe, 2014). Such conflicts have caused displacement and disrupted agricultural livelihoods in several local government areas.

The rising banditry, kidnapping, and organized crime have intensified insecurity. Forested and remote areas provide safe havens for criminal groups, while weak border controls and limited state presence enable their operations (International Crisis Group, 2021). These activities undermine economic stability by restricting movement and trade.

Although not a core Boko Haram zone, Taraba experiences spillover effects from nearby states, with porous borders facilitating arms trafficking and insurgent movement (Idowu, 2017; Agbiboa, 2021). Youth unemployment, political thuggery, and electoral violence further aggravate the situation, as unemployed youth are easily recruited into violent activities (Olanrewaju & Alabi, 2021).

Environmental degradation and resource conflicts, such as disputes over logging, mining, and fishing, also contribute to instability, particularly in resource-dependent communities (Raleigh & Urdal, 2007). The humanitarian impact is severe, including displacement, disrupted education and healthcare, and declining agricultural productivity. Prolonged insecurity weakens development outcomes and social cohesion (UNDP, 2020).

**Institutional Framework of Security Agencies in Nigeria and Their Mandates in Peacebuilding**

Nigeria's institutional framework for security is built on a complex structure of constitutional, statutory, and policy provisions designed to maintain order, protect sovereignty, and promote stability. The Constitution of 1999 (as amended), alongside key legal instruments such as the Police Act (2020), Armed Forces Act (2004), and Civil Defence Corps Act (2007), defines the mandates and operational responsibilities of security agencies. These frameworks assign roles not only in enforcement but also in conflict prevention, crisis response, and peacebuilding. Scholars emphasize that effective peacebuilding requires coordinated efforts among multiple agencies combining coercive and non-coercive strategies (Alemika & Chukwuma, 2015; Onuoha, 2020).

The Nigerian Armed Forces represent a core pillar of this system. Established under the Armed Forces Act, they are mandated to defend territorial integrity, suppress insurrection, and support civil authorities during internal crises. In practice, the Nigerian Army plays a significant role in counter-insurgency, stabilization operations, and protection of critical infrastructure. Its involvement in internal security has increased due to rising conflicts and insurgency (Agbiboa, 2021). Beyond combat, the military contributes to peacebuilding through humanitarian assistance, securing internally displaced persons (IDP) camps, rebuilding communities, and supporting disarmament, demobilization, and reintegration (DDR) programs. These efforts often create conditions for civilian-led peacebuilding initiatives (Okoli & Ugwu, 2019).

The Nigeria Police Force (NPF), guided by the Police Act 2020, is the primary agency responsible for law enforcement and internal order. Its functions include crime prevention, protection of lives and property, and community engagement. In peacebuilding, the police are vital in early warning, mediation, and post-conflict reconstruction. Recent community policing reforms aim to strengthen trust and collaboration between the police and local communities (Alemika, 2016). Effective policing is widely regarded as essential to sustaining peace and legitimacy in fragile settings (Ekhomu, 2019).

The Nigeria Security and Civil Defence Corps (NSCDC), established under the Civil Defence Act (2007), focuses on protecting critical infrastructure, disaster response, and community-based security. Its grassroots presence enhances rapid response to local conflicts and strengthens early warning systems (Abiodun & Oluwaseun, 2020). The NSCDC plays a key role in mediating disputes, protecting schools, and supporting displaced populations, making it particularly effective in underserved rural areas (Onuoha, 2020).

Other institutions, such as the Department of State Services (DSS), National Security Adviser (NSA), National Orientation Agency (NOA), and National Emergency Management Agency (NEMA), contribute through intelligence, coordination, civic education, and humanitarian

response. Despite this robust framework, challenges like weak coordination, limited resources, and political interference persist (Francis et al., 2020). Nonetheless, the system provides a foundation for continuous peacebuilding and conflict management (Ibeanu & Orji, 2014).

## Theoretical Framework

Understanding the interaction between security agencies and peacebuilding in conflict-affected regions such as Taraba State requires a theoretical foundation. This study is anchored on Conflict Transformation Theory complimented by Human Security Theory.

## Conflict Transformation Theory

Conflict Transformation Theory is principally associated with John Paul Lederach, who systematically articulated the framework in 1995. Lederach developed the theory as an alternative to traditional conflict resolution approaches that focus on short-term settlement rather than long-term social change (Lederach, 1995).

The theory is grounded in several key assumptions. First, conflict is not inherently negative but a natural and dynamic social process that can generate constructive change if properly managed. Second, sustainable peace requires transforming the underlying causes of conflict, including relationships, social structures, and historical patterns of interaction. Third, peacebuilding must be long-term, inclusive, and relationship-centered, involving multiple levels of society, elite leaders, mid-level actors, and grassroots communities. Fourth, the theory identifies four dimensions of transformation: personal, relational, structural, and cultural. Finally, it assumes that durable peace cannot be achieved through coercion alone but through dialogue, participation, and justice-oriented engagement (Lederach, 1995; Ramsbotham, Woodhouse, & Miall, 2011).

In Taraba State, where conflicts are driven by deep-rooted issues such as ethnic mistrust, land disputes, and political exclusion, Conflict Transformation Theory provides a strong analytical lens. It enables this study to assess whether security agencies go beyond immediate violence control to address structural and relational drivers of conflict. The theory is particularly relevant in examining how security interventions either support or undermine community dialogue, traditional mediation, and trust-building processes necessary for sustainable peace.

## Human Security Theory

This was popularized by the United Nations Development Programme, with intellectual contributions from Mahbub ul Haq and Amartya Sen. the theory emerged as a response to the limitations of state-centric security models (UNDP, 1994; Haq, 1995; Sen, 1999).

Human Security Theory rests on several core assumptions. First, the individual, not the state, is the primary referent of security. Second, security is multidimensional, encompassing economic, food, health, environmental, personal, community, and political aspects. Third, it emphasizes “freedom from fear” and “freedom from want” as essential conditions for human well-being. Fourth, the theory prioritises prevention by addressing the root causes of insecurity, such as poverty, inequality, and marginalisation. Finally, it assumes that effective security requires inclusive governance, protection of human rights, and active community participation (UNDP, 1994; Alkire, 2003).

The relevance of Human Security Theory lies in its ability to complement Conflict Transformation Theory by focusing on human-centred outcomes. In Taraba State, conflicts not only produce violence but also disrupt livelihoods, displace communities, and deepen socio-economic vulnerabilities. This theory helps evaluate whether security agencies enhance or undermine the safety, dignity, and well-being of civilians. It also highlights the need for security strategies that integrate development, social protection, and participatory governance.

Conflict Transformation Theory and Human Security Theory provide a comprehensive framework for this study. While the former explains the processes required to transform conflict, the latter defines the human-centred goals of such transformation. Their integration enables a balanced assessment of how security agencies in Taraba State can move from coercive stabilisation to sustainable, inclusive, and people-oriented peacebuilding.

**Empirical Review**

One of the most relevant empirical studies is that of Okom (2019) Militarization and Internal Security Management in Nigeria’s Middle Belt. The study employed a qualitative research design, relying on document analysis, key informant interviews, and case studies drawn from selected Middle Belt states including Plateau, Benue, and Taraba. Data were sourced from policy documents, media reports, human rights publications, and interviews with security officials and community leaders. The study adopted a conflict transformation lens to examine the implications of military-led security interventions on communal peace.

A major strength of this study lies in its context-sensitive analysis of internal security operations. By integrating perspectives from both state security actors and affected communities, the study provides rich insights into how militarized interventions shape peace outcomes. Its regional focus allows for comparative understanding of shared conflict dynamics across the Middle Belt, making its conclusions broadly relevant to Taraba State. The study also contributes theoretically by linking militarization to legitimacy deficits in peacebuilding.

Despite its depth, the study suffers from methodological limitations. The reliance on qualitative data without complementary quantitative indicators (such as conflict incident trends or perception surveys) limits the generalizability of its findings. Additionally, Taraba State is not examined as a standalone case; rather, it is subsumed under a regional narrative, which weakens the specificity of conclusions related to local institutional dynamics. The study does not empirically measure community trust levels or systematically assess how different security agencies (Police, Army, NSCDC) perform distinct peacebuilding roles. There is also a gap in analyzing inter-agency coordination mechanisms and their effectiveness at the sub-national level. This current study addresses these gaps by focusing specifically on Taraba State and examining both institutional practices and community perceptions.

Furthermore, study by Alemika and Okoye (2020) Community Policing and Peacebuilding in Fragile Nigerian States. The study adopted a mixed-methods approach, combining survey questionnaires administered to community members with in-depth interviews of police officers and local leaders in selected conflict-prone states. The study evaluated the impact of community policing initiatives on crime prevention, trust-building, and conflict mitigation. The use of mixed methods strengthens the credibility of the findings by triangulating quantitative perception data with qualitative insights. The study convincingly demonstrates that community engagement enhances early warning, reduces mistrust, and supports non-violent conflict resolution. Its emphasis on police–community partnerships provides a valuable framework for evaluating peacebuilding beyond coercive security measures.

One limitation is the study's institutional narrowness. It focuses primarily on the Nigeria Police Force, with limited attention to other critical security actors such as the Nigerian Army, NSCDC, and DSS, agencies that play prominent roles in Taraba State. Additionally, the study does not sufficiently interrogate the political and structural constraints—such as elite interference and resource deficits, that affect community policing outcomes. The study does not also explore how community policing interacts with military-led operations in high-conflict environments, nor does it assess rural contexts where police presence is minimal. Taraba State, with its heavy reliance on joint military–police operations and vigilante structures, remains underexplored. This study fills this gap by adopting a multi-agency perspective and focusing on rural and semi-urban conflict settings.

Human Rights Watch (2021) Nigeria: Security Operations and Civilian Protection. The study conducted a rights-based empirical investigation using field interviews, victim testimonies, and case documentation across several Nigerian states affected by internal security operations. The study examined allegations of excessive force, arbitrary detention, and civilian abuses by security agencies during peace enforcement operations. The study's strength lies in its rigorous documentation of civilian experiences and its adherence to international human rights standards. By foregrounding the voices of affected communities, it highlights how security practices influence legitimacy, trust, and long-term peacebuilding. Its

findings are particularly relevant for Taraba State, where civil-military relations remain fragile.

However, the study adopts a predominantly normative and advocacy-oriented approach, which limits analytical balance. It places minimal emphasis on the operational constraints faced by security agencies, such as inadequate training, poor logistics, and intelligence gaps. Furthermore, it does not assess instances where security interventions may have contributed positively to stability. The report does not empirically link human rights practices to measurable peacebuilding outcomes, such as reconciliation, displacement reduction, or conflict recurrence. Nor does it disaggregate findings by state to capture local variations. This study addresses these gaps by examining both positive and negative impacts of security agencies on peacebuilding in Taraba State within a balanced analytical framework.

**Methodology**

This study adopts a quantitative research design which allows for the systematic collection and statistical analysis of data to examine the impact of security agencies on peace building in Taraba State. The choice of this design is appropriate because it enables the measurement of variables numerically, thereby facilitating objective analysis and generalization of findings. The study area is Taraba State, Nigeria, with particular focus on conflict-prone Local Government Areas of Wukari, Bali, and Karim-Lamido (a local government from each of the senatorial district). These areas are selected due to their history of recurrent farmer–herder conflicts, communal violence, and security interventions.

The target population consist of residents of affected communities including famers, traders, youths and local leaders who have the direct experience with security operations. Security personnels may also be included where accessible. A multi-stage sampling technique is employed. First, purposive sampling is used to select conflict-affected LGAs, followed by stratified sampling to categorize respondents into relevant groups. Finally, simple random sampling is used to select community respondents. A sample size of approximately 105 respondents is considered adequate for the study.

Data is collected using structured questionnaires designed with closed-ended questions based on a likert scale administered to residents. Data is analyzed using descriptive statistics such as frequencies, percentages, and mean scores to assess perceptions of security effectiveness and community trust.

To ensure validity and reliability, research instruments are pre-tested, and triangulation is employed by comparing multiple data sources. Ethical considerations are strictly observed, including informed consent, confidentiality, and anonymity of respondents. Overall, this methodology provides a systematic framework for evaluating the role of security agencies in

peacebuilding and generating evidence-based recommendations for sustainable peace in Taraba State.

## Results and Discussion

Table 1: **Demographic Characteristics of Respondents**

| Variable | Category | Percentage (%) |
|---|---|---|
| Gender | Male | 57 |
| | Female | 43 |
| Age (years) | 18–30 years | 28 |
| | 31–45 years | 40 |
| | 46–60 years | 22 |
| | 61 years and above | 10 |
| Education | No formal education | 15 |
| | Primary education | 25 |
| | Secondary education | 40 |
| | Tertiary education | 20 |
| Occupation | Farming | 52 |
| | Herding | 18 |
| | Trading | 15 |
| | Civil service | 10 |
| | Others | 5 |

Source: Researcher, 2025

**Table 2: Strategies Employed by Security Agencies in Peacebuilding**

| Strategy | Finding |
|---|---|
| Early Warning and Monitoring Systems | 62% |
| Conflict Mediation | 55% |
| Patrols and Rapid Response | 48% |
| Felt safer | 32% |
| Reported delayed responses | 65% |

Source: Researcher, 2025

**Table 3: Effectiveness of Security Agencies in Peacebuilding**

| Indicator | Mean Score | Interpretation |
|---|---|---|
| Conflict Prevention | 3.2 | Moderate |
| Protection of Civilians | 3.5 | Moderate |
| Post-Conflict Stabilization | 2.9 | Low |
| Early Warning Response | 3.0 | Moderate |

Source: Researcher, 2025

**Table 4: Challenges Faced by Security Agencies in Peacebuilding**

| Challenges Identified | Findings |
|---|---|
| Resource constraints (manpower, logistics, funding) | 68% |
| Poor inter-agency coordination | 55% |
| Human rights concerns and perceived bias | 52% |
| Environmental and geographical barriers | 49% |
| Community distrust | 45% |

Source: Researcher, 2025

**Table 5: Community Perceptions of Security Agencies' Peacebuilding Roles**

| Category of Response | Percentage |
|---|---|
| Positive | 45% |
| Negative | 38% |
| Neutral | 17% |

Source: Researcher, 2025

**Discussion**

The present study raised the possibility that Peacebuilding in Taraba State depends on the combined efforts of the Nigeria Police Force, NSCDC, Nigerian Army, and local vigilante groups. Each contributes uniquely through its geographical spread, manpower deployment, and operational mobility. While the Police and NSCDC focus on civil protection and community relations, the Army provides deterrence and stability in high-risk areas, and vigilante groups ensure grassroots surveillance and mediation. Their collective roles underscore the importance of multi-agency collaboration and community participation in sustaining peace and promoting long-term security in Taraba State.

The findings indicate that while security agencies play an indispensable role in mitigating insecurity, their effectiveness is often limited by structural, logistical, and operational constraints. These agencies frequently lack adequate manpower, mobility, and intelligence-gathering capacity, which undermine their ability to respond swiftly and decisively to emerging threats. As a result, a shift toward more proactive and well-structured security strategies becomes essential. This includes adopting preventive approaches, improving inter-agency coordination, and strengthening early-warning systems to address potential conflicts before they escalate. Furthermore, community-centred interventions, such as closer engagement with traditional rulers, local leaders, and civil society, can help bridge trust gaps and enhance the flow of reliable information critical for operational success.

The research also underscores the value of collaborating with local vigilante groups, who possess intimate knowledge of the terrain and community dynamics. Their involvement has proven helpful in intelligence sharing, rapid response, and grassroots conflict mitigation. However, for such collaborations to yield sustainable results, clear accountability and

oversight mechanisms are required. Without these, risks such as human rights abuses, misuse of power and parallel security structures may emerge. Therefore, strengthening institutional frameworks, enhancing transparency, and establishing community-based monitoring systems are vital for ensuring that security agencies and vigilante groups operate within legal and ethical boundaries while contributing meaningfully to peacebuilding efforts.

**Conclusion**

Security agencies remain indispensable to peacebuilding and the maintenance of stability in Taraba State. Their interventions through patrols, mediation, early warning mechanisms, intelligence gathering, and responses to emerging conflicts have contributed to containing violence and protecting communities. However, the effectiveness of these strategies remains moderate because many interventions are predominantly reactive rather than preventive. Resource constraints, inadequate logistics and communication infrastructure, weak inter-agency coordination, and limited community trust further constrain the ability of security institutions to respond effectively to emerging threats. These challenges suggest that sustainable peace cannot be achieved through coercive security responses alone but requires an integrated approach that combines security provision with conflict prevention, community participation, institutional strengthening, and human security.

**Recommendations**

To strengthen the contribution of security agencies to peacebuilding in Taraba State, there is a need for sustained capacity building. Security personnel should receive regular training in conflict prevention and resolution, negotiation, mediation, community engagement, intelligence gathering, and other relevant technical skills. Such training would improve their ability to identify emerging threats, respond appropriately to local conflicts, and engage communities in ways that reduce tensions rather than exacerbate them.

Adequate resources are equally essential for effective peacebuilding. Government should provide security agencies with sufficient funding, operational vehicles, communication equipment, surveillance technologies, and other logistical support required for timely intervention. Improved working conditions and operational capacity would enable agencies to move beyond reactive responses and develop more effective preventive mechanisms.

Inter-agency coordination should also be strengthened through the establishment or reinforcement of joint task forces, clearly defined standard operating procedures, and systematic intelligence-sharing mechanisms. Regular joint operations, coordination meetings, and information-sharing platforms can reduce institutional rivalry, duplication of responsibilities, and communication gaps while promoting a more coherent security response.

Building community trust and institutional legitimacy should constitute another central priority. Security agencies should promote transparency, accountability, community participation, and public awareness through sustained engagement with traditional rulers, religious leaders, civil society organisations, youth groups, women's associations, and other community stakeholders. Stronger relationships between security agencies and local communities can improve intelligence flows, strengthen early warning systems, and encourage collective ownership of peacebuilding initiatives.

Finally, peacebuilding efforts should extend beyond the immediate cessation of violence. Post-conflict communities require sustained dialogue, reconciliation programmes, psychosocial support, livelihood assistance, and continuous monitoring and evaluation. Government and security agencies should therefore develop mechanisms for assessing the effectiveness of interventions and identifying emerging grievances before they develop into violent conflicts.

**Policy Implications**

The findings have important implications for security and peacebuilding policy in Taraba State. Policies should move beyond predominantly reactive approaches by integrating preventive, responsive, and post-conflict measures within a broader human-security framework. Strengthening institutional capacity, improving inter-agency collaboration, and ensuring adequate resources are necessary for effective security provision. At the same time, community engagement should be institutionalised as a core component of security policy because local participation enhances legitimacy, improves access to information, and strengthens the sustainability of peacebuilding interventions.

Ultimately, a combination of institutional strengthening, adequate resource mobilisation, effective coordination, preventive action, and meaningful community engagement would enable security agencies to become more proactive and responsive peacebuilding actors. Such an approach would not only reduce violence and protect civilians but also contribute to durable peace, social cohesion, and long-term stability in Taraba State.

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# HUMANITARIAN INTERVENTION AND REFUGEE PROTECTION: ASSESSING UNHCR'S RESPONSE TO THE CAMEROONIAN REFUGEE CRISIS IN BENUE STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** The escalation of the Anglophone crisis in Cameroon since 2016 has generated significant cross-border displacement, with thousands of Cameroonians seeking refuge in neighbouring countries, including Nigeria. Benue State has become an important destination for Cameroonian refugees fleeing armed conflict, insecurity, and human rights violations. In response to such crises, the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR), as the principal international agency mandated to protect refugees, is expected to provide humanitarian assistance, ensure access to safety and asylum, prevent refoulement, and facilitate access to essential services and durable solutions. This study examines humanitarian intervention and refugee protection by assessing UNHCR's response to the Cameroonian refugee crisis in Benue State, Nigeria. Specifically, the study assesses the extent to which UNHCR's intervention provided timely protection, shelter, water, sanitation and hygiene services, life-saving supplies, non-food items, cash-based assistance, and other essential humanitarian services to affected refugees. The study adopted a qualitative research design and utilised structured interviews and focus group discussions to obtain data from UNHCR officials, relevant humanitarian actors, and Cameroonian refugees in the refugee settlement. The findings indicate significant gaps between UNHCR's expected refugee-protection responsibilities and the experiences of refugees in Benue State. The study found that UNHCR's initial response was delayed and that refugees did not receive timely protection and assistance consistent with the requirements of an effective emergency intervention. These shortcomings exposed refugees to heightened humanitarian vulnerability and undermined the effectiveness of refugee protection in the affected communities. The study concludes that although UNHCR remains a critical actor in responding to the Cameroonian refugee crisis, weaknesses in the timeliness, coverage, coordination, and monitoring of its humanitarian intervention limited the effectiveness of refugee protection in Benue State. It recommends strengthening early-warning and refugee monitoring mechanisms, improving rapid-response capacity, expanding access to essential humanitarian services, and enhancing coordination among UNHCR, government institutions, and humanitarian partners to ensure timely and effective protection of refugees.

**Keywords:** UNHCR, Cameroonian refugee, Benue State, Cameroon and Nigeria

## Introduction

The protection of populations displaced by armed conflict, political instability, persecution, and organised violence remains a major challenge for the international community. Contemporary conflicts frequently generate cross-border displacement, forcing civilians to abandon their homes in search of safety and protection (Lischer, 2007). Refugees are particularly vulnerable because displacement often results in the loss of homes, livelihoods, social networks, documentation, and access to basic services (Buscher, 2011). Consequently, humanitarian intervention extends beyond material assistance to include protection from violence, access to asylum, respect for human dignity, prevention of forced return, and support for durable solutions. A central institution within the international refugee-protection system is the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR), established by the United Nations General Assembly in 1950. Although initially created to address the displacement of Europeans following the Second World War, UNHCR, has evolved into the principal international organisation responsible for refugee protection and assistance to forcibly displaced populations globally. Its responsibilities include protection, humanitarian assistance, advocacy for refugee rights, and support for durable solutions (Stevens, 2016). During emergencies, UNHCR is expected to respond rapidly and coordinate with governments and humanitarian partners to ensure refugees have access to safety, shelter, food, water, sanitation, healthcare, non-food items, cash-based assistance, and other essential services.

The effectiveness of humanitarian intervention depends not only on the quantity of assistance provided but also on its timeliness, adequacy, accessibility, coverage, coordination, and contribution to refugee protection. Refugee protection requires ensuring that persons fleeing violence can reach safety, access asylum, and are protected from refoulement and other threats to their lives and freedoms (Jones, 2016). It also requires monitoring emerging protection risks, particularly among women, children, older persons, persons with disabilities, and other vulnerable groups. Humanitarian assistance and refugee protection are therefore closely interconnected, as assistance addresses immediate material needs while protection safeguards the rights, security, dignity, and wellbeing of displaced populations (Perrin, 2025). These concerns are particularly relevant to the Cameroonian refugee crisis, which emerged from the escalation of the Anglophone conflict in Cameroon's Northwest and Southwest Regions from 2016. The conflict, involving government forces and armed separatist groups, has been associated with killings, destruction of property and infrastructure, arbitrary arrests, attacks on civilians, kidnappings, sexual violence, and disruption of livelihoods and social services (Farrell & Schmitt, 2012). These conditions have forced large numbers of Cameroonians to flee their communities and seek refuge in neighbouring countries, particularly Nigeria.

Nigeria has consequently become an important destination for Cameroonian refugees because of its geographical proximity to Cameroon. Several Nigerian states have received refugees, with Benue State becoming an important host location. The influx has placed additional

humanitarian and socioeconomic pressures on host communities and created urgent needs for shelter, food, water, sanitation, healthcare, security, documentation, education, livelihoods, and psychosocial support (Matlin, Depoux, Schütte, Flahault, & Saso, 2018). Where these needs are not addressed promptly, refugees may face increased exposure to insecurity, disease, exploitation, poverty, secondary displacement, and other vulnerabilities. The Cameroonian refugee crisis in Benue State therefore provides an important context for assessing the capacity of humanitarian institutions to translate international refugee-protection principles into practical interventions. UNHCR, in collaboration with Nigerian government institutions and other humanitarian actors, has a critical responsibility to support refugee registration and documentation, protection monitoring, emergency assistance, access to essential services, and advocacy for refugee rights. However, the existence of humanitarian intervention does not necessarily guarantee effective refugee protection. Institutional constraints, logistical difficulties, inadequate infrastructure, limited resources, geographical barriers, and weak coordination may delay assistance and undermine protection outcomes.

Timeliness is particularly important because refugees are often most vulnerable immediately after displacement. Delays in providing shelter, safe water, sanitation, food, non-food items, healthcare, cash assistance, and protection services can intensify humanitarian risks and increase refugees' dependence on host communities. Effective response therefore requires early identification of displaced populations, rapid protection assessment, immediate access to basic services, and coordinated humanitarian action. At the same time, refugee protection depends on cooperation among UNHCR, government agencies, humanitarian organisations, host communities, and other stakeholders. Weak coordination can produce gaps in assistance and leave critical needs unattended.

Against this background, this study examines Humanitarian Intervention and Refugee Protection: Assessing UNHCR's Response to the Cameroonian Refugee Crisis in Benue State, Nigeria. The study assesses UNHCR's intervention in terms of timely access to safety and protection, shelter and settlements, water, sanitation and hygiene, delivery of life-saving supplies and non-food items, cash-based assistance, and coordination of humanitarian support. By examining the experiences of Cameroonian refugees alongside the perspectives of relevant humanitarian actors, the study seeks to determine the extent to which UNHCR's response addressed the immediate humanitarian needs and broader protection requirements of refugees in Benue State.

**Methodology**

The study adopted a descriptive qualitative research design to examine the nature of UNHCR's humanitarian intervention and refugee protection in response to the Cameroonian refugee crisis in Benue State, Nigeria. The qualitative approach was considered appropriate because the study sought to understand the experiences, perceptions, and perspectives of refugees and relevant humanitarian actors regarding the nature, timeliness, adequacy, and effectiveness of the humanitarian response. Data were collected through focus group

discussions (FGDs) and structured interviews. Three FGDs were conducted with a total of 30 Cameroonian refugees at the Refugee Settlement in Ikyogen, Benue State. The participants were organised into separate groups comprising men, women, and children to enable the study to capture experiences that may differ according to age and gender. An interview guide was used to facilitate the discussions and obtain information relating to access to safety, shelter, water, sanitation and hygiene, life-saving supplies, cash-based assistance, and other aspects of humanitarian intervention.

In addition, a structured interview was conducted by telephone with an official of the Refugee Settlement to obtain an institutional perspective on the humanitarian situation and the response to the refugees. The inclusion of the settlement official provided an opportunity to complement and contextualise the accounts obtained from the refugee participants.

The study employed purposive sampling to select participants and the key informant. The selection was based on participants' direct experience of the Cameroonian refugee crisis and their knowledge of the humanitarian response in Benue State. The data generated from the FGDs and structured interviews were analysed thematically, with attention to recurring patterns and issues relating to emergency response, refugee protection, provision of essential humanitarian services, and coordination of assistance. This approach enabled the study to compare experiences of refugees with the perspectives of humanitarian officials and assess the extent to which UNHCR's intervention corresponded with the protection and humanitarian needs of the affected population.

**Theoretical Framework**

The theoretical framework adopted for this study is Functionalism. Functionalism emerged in Europe during the nineteenth century and subsequently became one of the major perspectives for understanding the structure and functioning of society (Haralambos, Horbon, & Heald, 2008). Émile Durkheim is widely regarded as one of its principal classical proponents, while the perspective was subsequently developed and refined by scholars such as Talcott Parsons. Durkheim conceptualised society as an integrated system whose various institutions and structures perform specific functions that contribute to the maintenance, continuity, and stability of the social order. Drawing an analogy between society and a biological organism, he argued that just as different organs perform complementary functions necessary for the survival of an organism, social institutions perform interconnected functions necessary for the maintenance of society.

From the functionalist perspective, society is therefore understood as a system comprising interdependent parts that work, ideally, in coordination with one another to satisfy the needs of the wider social system and preserve social equilibrium. Functionalists examine social institutions in terms of the functions they perform and their contribution to social stability. Consequently, understanding a particular institution requires an examination of the functions

it performs, the relationships it maintains with other institutions, and the consequences that may arise when it fails to perform its expected functions. Charles (2005) explains that functionalists perceive society as a system characterised by various system needs or requisites. The different components of the system are interconnected and are expected to work harmoniously to satisfy these needs, thereby maintaining the normal functioning and equilibrium of the wider system.

Functionalism further assumes that social order is sustained through shared norms, values, expectations, and patterns of behaviour. Institutions perform their functions within this normative framework, while socialisation enables individuals to acquire the values and expectations necessary for participation in social life. However, this assumption has attracted considerable criticism. Critics argue that functionalism places excessive emphasis on consensus, integration, and the normative dimensions of social action while paying insufficient attention to conflict, inequality, coercion, and individual agency. Its assumption that individuals are adequately socialised into the norms and values of society has also been challenged. Skidmore (1979), for instance, questions the extent to which individuals can simply be regarded as passive recipients of societal expectations. Similarly, Lockwood (1956, p. 134) argues that some individuals may deviate from established norms or fail to conform to them because they have not been adequately socialised, as may be the case with infants and other individuals whose socialisation is incomplete. These criticisms demonstrate that social systems do not always function harmoniously or automatically as functionalism may imply.

Despite these limitations, Functionalism provides a useful framework for understanding the role of humanitarian institutions in responding to forced displacement. Its central proposition that society consists of interconnected parts whose effective functioning contributes to system stability is particularly relevant to the present study. A humanitarian crisis represents a disruption or dysfunction within the social system because conflict, forced displacement, insecurity, loss of livelihoods, and the breakdown of normal social relations undermine the ability of individuals and communities to function normally. Such disruption creates needs that require institutional intervention to restore stability and protect vulnerable populations.

Within this framework, the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) can be understood as an important institutional component within the broader international humanitarian system. Its refugee-protection functions cannot be performed in isolation but depend upon its interaction with other components, including national and subnational governments, host communities, donor agencies, non-governmental organisations, United Nations agencies, and other humanitarian actors. These institutions perform complementary functions such as providing protection, shelter, water and sanitation, food, healthcare, cash assistance, security, logistics, and other forms of humanitarian support. The effective functioning of the humanitarian system therefore depends on the capacity of these interconnected actors to coordinate their activities and respond collectively to the needs created by displacement.

Applied to the Cameroonian refugee crisis in Benue State, Functionalism suggests that the influx of refugees represents a disruption that places additional demands on existing social and institutional structures. The displacement of Cameroonians from their communities of origin disrupted their normal social and economic lives and created new humanitarian needs in the areas where they sought refuge. UNHCR, as the principal international refugee-protection institution, is expected to perform specific functions aimed at mitigating these disruptions. These include facilitating access to safety, preventing refoulement, providing or coordinating emergency shelter, ensuring access to water, sanitation and hygiene, delivering life-saving supplies, providing cash-based assistance where appropriate, monitoring protection risks, and coordinating humanitarian assistance with governments and other partners.

The theory is particularly useful for interpreting the findings of this study because it draws attention to the consequences of institutional dysfunction and weak interdependence. Where UNHCR or other relevant institutions fail to perform their expected functions promptly or adequately, the consequences extend beyond the refugees themselves and may affect host communities and the wider humanitarian system. For example, inadequate shelter, water, sanitation, food, and protection can increase refugees' vulnerability, place additional pressure on host communities, generate competition over scarce resources, and potentially create new sources of social tension. Conversely, effective institutional coordination can help absorb the pressures created by displacement, protect refugees, support host communities, and contribute to the restoration of social stability

The theory also helps explain the importance of host communities in the study. Where formal humanitarian institutions were slow to respond, host communities reportedly provided initial accommodation, water, and other forms of assistance to refugees. From a functionalist perspective, this demonstrates the adaptive capacity of the wider social system, whereby other components compensate, at least temporarily, for deficiencies in one component. However, reliance on host communities cannot permanently substitute for the functions of specialised humanitarian institutions. Excessive dependence on already limited community resources may itself generate pressure, resentment, or conflict between refugees and host populations.

Functionalism therefore provides the analytical basis for examining whether UNHCR and its partner institutions performed their expected functions effectively during the Cameroonian refugee crisis in Benue State. The study focuses particularly on the extent to which the humanitarian system fulfilled its protective and stabilising functions through timely access to safety, adequate settlements and shelter, WASH services, delivery of life-saving supplies, cash-based interventions, and effective coordination of assistance. The reported delays and inadequacies in these areas can consequently be interpreted as forms of institutional dysfunction that weakened the capacity of the humanitarian system to restore stability and provide effective refugee protection.

**Humanitarian Protection and Access to Safety in the Refugee Site**

The findings from interviews indicate significant shortcomings in the initial response of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) to the Cameroonian refugee crisis in Benue State, particularly with regard to ensuring timely access to safety and protection. The UNHCR was reportedly not visible at the onset of the emergency and did not respond to the refugees within the 72-hour period associated with its emergency-response standard. Although respondents provided varying accounts of the period that elapsed before UNHCR intervention, their responses consistently indicated that the organisation did not respond swiftly to the unfolding crisis. Some respondents reported that it took between two and three weeks, others indicated two to three months, while some stated that the response took between three and four months. Even the shortest period reported by respondents exceeded the 72-hour timeframe, which is equivalent to three days, thereby suggesting a considerable delay in the organisation's initial intervention. This finding raises concerns about the extent to which the response met the UNHCR's stated commitment to act swiftly when humanitarian emergencies become known (UNHCR, 2026).

The delay is particularly significant given that the conflict in Cameroon's Anglophone regions had been widely reported in the media from 2016, when the crisis began (Nfor, 2024, p36). As an international organisation with a global mandate for refugee protection and emergency response, the apparent delay in responding to the displacement of Cameroonians into Benue State raises questions about the effectiveness of its early-warning, monitoring, and emergency-response mechanisms. According to the interviewees, UNHCR's intervention became visible only in 2017 or 2018, rather than immediately when Cameroonians began arriving in Benue State. Some respondents further indicated that the organisation became involved only after the Nigerian government notified it of the humanitarian situation. This suggests that the organisation's response was largely reactive rather than anticipatory, despite the prolonged visibility of the conflict and the likelihood of cross-border displacement.

The findings further reveal limited UNHCR presence at the border during the initial influx of refugees. Respondents did not report the presence of UNHCR personnel at the border to facilitate safe entry or intervene where refugees might have faced the possibility of refoulement. Although the refugees were eventually admitted into Nigeria and Benue State, their access to safety did not appear to have been facilitated directly by UNHCR. Rather, host communities located along the border reportedly received the refugees on the basis of their own hospitality. This finding is important because access to safety constitutes a fundamental element of refugee protection, particularly during the initial stages of displacement when individuals fleeing violence are most vulnerable to insecurity, exploitation, separation, and other forms of harm.

The absence of a visible roving response team was another significant finding. Respondents did not indicate that UNHCR deployed mobile teams to monitor the border areas, identify endangered Cameroonians, and facilitate their movement to safer locations. Instead, refugees

were largely responsible for navigating their own routes from Cameroon into Benue State. The experiences of the respondents demonstrate the considerable difficulties associated with this movement. Male respondents reported that many refugees travelled on foot, although some used commercial motorcycles. The women described running on foot and, in some cases, carrying elderly women on their backs. They explained that they often lacked the financial resources required to pay for commercial motorcycles even when such transportation was available. The children reported that they travelled primarily by bus, while many adolescents used commercial motorcycles. According to the respondents, children generally did not pay for the bus journeys, whereas those who used motorcycles had to pay for the service. These accounts illustrate the precarious conditions under which many refugees crossed into Nigeria and the absence of organised emergency transportation to facilitate their movement from areas of danger to locations of greater safety.

The account provided by Tor, S. of the Benue State Emergency Management Agency, during an interview conducted on 12 December 2025, corroborates the refugees' testimony that many Cameroonian refugees entered Benue State on foot and were not immediately received by UNHCR. The convergence between the accounts of refugees and the government humanitarian official strengthens the evidence that UNHCR's initial presence at the point of entry was limited. Rather than being immediately received through an organised humanitarian mechanism, refugees depended substantially on host communities for initial assistance and reception. The challenges experienced by refugees extended beyond physical movement to access to basic services. Respondents reported that they obtained water primarily from wells in host communities or from streams, depending on their location. Access to healthcare was also reported to be inadequate. There were accounts of refugees receiving no immediate medical attention, with respondents reporting that some children died as a consequence. Those who eventually accessed healthcare reportedly did so through their own efforts rather than through an immediate and systematic UNHCR intervention. Respondents further indicated that the most vulnerable refugees did not receive special attention. This situation raises concerns about the extent to which the emergency response adequately addressed the differentiated needs of children, older persons, women, and other vulnerable members of the refugee population.

Another concern emerging from the findings relates to family separation. Respondents reported that not all missing family members were subsequently located. Family separation is a particularly serious protection concern in situations of forced displacement because it can expose children, women, older persons, and other vulnerable individuals to heightened risks of exploitation, abuse, trafficking, and further displacement. The reported inability to locate some missing family members therefore indicates an additional gap in protection monitoring and emergency assistance during the initial phase of the crisis.

Notwithstanding these shortcomings, the findings indicate that UNHCR eventually took steps to relocate refugees away from the immediate border area to locations considered relatively safer. This intervention was consistent with the organisation's approach of locating refugees at

least 70 kilometres away from the border where circumstances permit, particularly where remaining close to the border may expose refugees to continuing security threats. The relocation was also associated with reported harassment of refugees by members of the host community at Amana. Moving refugees farther from the border therefore represented an important protection measure intended to reduce their exposure to insecurity and other risks associated with proximity to the conflict zone. However, the relocation process was not undertaken with the speed expected in an emergency situation. Women respondents reported that they remained at the border for approximately two months even after UNHCR became involved before they were relocated to a safer location. This prolonged stay raises questions about the timeliness of the protection intervention, particularly given that the purpose of relocation was to remove refugees from an environment perceived to pose security and protection risks.

The UNHCR eventually intervened and contributed to the relocation of Cameroonian refugees to safer areas, its initial response to the crisis in Benue State was characterised by delays, limited border presence, inadequate emergency transportation, weak protection monitoring, and insufficient provision or coordination of essential services. The refugees' ability to reach Nigeria and access initial safety appears to have depended largely on their own efforts and the hospitality of host communities rather than on an organised UNHCR emergency mechanism. The evidence therefore points to a gap between the normative expectations of humanitarian intervention and the practical experience of refugees during the initial phase of the crisis. Although the eventual relocation of refugees represented an important protection measure, the delayed nature of the intervention limited its effectiveness in providing immediate access to safety and comprehensive refugee protection.

**Settlements and Shelter in Host Communities of Benue State**

The findings reveal significant inadequacies in the provision of safe and appropriate shelter for Cameroonian refugees during the initial phase of their displacement into Benue State. Refugees reportedly lacked secure accommodation that could adequately protect them from harsh weather conditions and provide a sense of safety and dignity. The absence of appropriate shelter was particularly concerning given the vulnerability of refugees immediately after crossing the border, when many had lost their homes and livelihoods and had limited financial resources with which to secure alternative accommodation. The experiences of male respondents illustrate the precarious conditions under which some refugees lived. Amande, C. (16/10/2025) reported that refugees slept in uncompleted buildings, churches, and schools. Although the respondents indicated that they were not physically attacked in these locations, they noted that their former Cameroonian adversaries attempted to attack them after they arrived in Benue State. The use of open and unsecured spaces therefore potentially exposed refugees to additional protection risks, particularly given the possibility of attacks and the absence of controlled and secure accommodation. The fact that refugees were not attacked does not necessarily imply that the accommodation

arrangements were safe or adequate; rather, the conditions under which they were accommodated left them potentially vulnerable to security threats and environmental hazards.

The experiences of female refugees were similarly indicative of inadequate shelter arrangements. Women respondents reported sleeping on bare floors in primary schools, using their wrappers as makeshift bedding. While schools and other public facilities may provide temporary refuge during the initial stages of an emergency, their use as prolonged accommodation without appropriate sleeping materials, privacy, sanitation, and protection facilities falls short of the conditions generally associated with safe and dignified refugee shelter. Such arrangements may also create additional vulnerabilities for women, children, older persons, and other individuals requiring specific protection and assistance.

The findings further indicate that UNHCR did not provide temporary emergency shelters, such as tents or organised communal shelters, at the border or in other locations immediately following the refugees' arrival in Benue State. Consequently, refugees depended heavily on existing public structures and the hospitality of host communities for accommodation. This limited the extent to which the humanitarian response could provide immediate protection from severe weather conditions and other environmental risks. It also suggests that shelter provision was not adequately integrated into the initial emergency response.

The absence of UNHCR at the point of the refugees' initial arrival further complicated the situation. The organisation was therefore not immediately positioned to establish or coordinate suitable reception and settlement arrangements. Ideally, refugees arriving from an active conflict zone should be moved away from immediate border risks and provided with safe and appropriate accommodation as part of an organised protection response. The reported standard of locating refugee settlements at least 70 kilometres away from the border reflects the importance of reducing refugees' exposure to continuing insecurity. However, the practical application of this principle was constrained by the organisation's limited presence during the initial influx.

The evidence therefore suggests that the shelter response did not adequately correspond with the immediate protection needs of the Cameroonian refugees. Although churches, schools, and uncompleted buildings provided temporary spaces in which refugees could stay, these locations did not constitute adequate or systematically organised emergency settlements. The reliance on such facilities indicates that host communities and existing local infrastructure played a significant role in filling the gap created by the delayed humanitarian intervention.

Overall, the findings demonstrate a substantial gap between the expected standards of emergency refugee protection and the actual shelter conditions experienced by Cameroonian refugees in Benue State. The absence of timely provision of temporary shelters, coupled with the prolonged use of schools, churches, and uncompleted buildings, exposed refugees to environmental and protection vulnerabilities. This situation underscores the need for

humanitarian interventions to incorporate rapid shelter provision and organised settlement planning into the earliest stages of refugee emergencies.

**Coordination of Humanitarian Assistance**

Effective humanitarian intervention in refugee emergencies also depends heavily on coordination among relevant institutions and actors. UNHCR emphasises its capacity to coordinate rapid and efficient humanitarian responses by working with national and subnational governments, United Nations agencies, international and national non-governmental organisations, and other humanitarian partners. Such coordination is intended to mobilise emergency teams, identify priority needs, avoid duplication of assistance and ensure that life-saving supplies and services reach persons who require them. The findings from Benue State, however, suggest weaknesses in the coordination and immediacy of humanitarian assistance during the initial phase of the Cameroonian refugee crisis. The fact that refugees reportedly arrived in the state before receiving organised assistance indicates that existing humanitarian mechanisms were not sufficiently activated at the point of entry.

The reliance of refugees on host communities for initial reception, water and accommodation further suggests that local communities played a substantial role in filling gaps in the formal humanitarian response. The reported need for notification by the Nigerian government before UNHCR became actively involved also raises questions about the effectiveness of the organisation's early-warning and emergency coordination mechanisms. Given the visibility of the conflict in Cameroon and the likelihood of cross-border displacement, a more anticipatory approach would have enabled humanitarian actors to prepare reception arrangements, identify potential settlement locations, mobilise emergency supplies and establish WASH facilities before or immediately upon the arrival of refugees. The delay in such interventions suggests that coordination was more reactive than preventive.

The nature of UNHCR's response to the Cameroonian refugee crisis in Benue State cannot be assessed solely in terms of how quickly the organisation arrived. The effectiveness of humanitarian intervention also depends on whether refugees receive safe shelter, WASH services, life-saving supplies, cash-based assistance, protection monitoring and coordinated humanitarian support. The evidence indicates shortcomings across several of these dimensions. While UNHCR eventually contributed to the relocation and protection of refugees, deficiencies in the provision and coordination of essential humanitarian assistance limited the comprehensiveness of its intervention. The situation consequently underscores the need for a more integrated emergency-response system capable of simultaneously addressing access to safety, shelter, WASH, emergency supplies, cash assistance and inter-agency coordination from the earliest stages of refugee displacement.

## Provision and Coordination of Humanitarian Assistance

### Water, Sanitation and Hygiene

The findings indicate that the Cameroonian refugees did not receive timely access to safe and adequate water upon their arrival at the border. Rather than being provided with organised water facilities, refugees reportedly sourced water independently from members of the host communities. They also reported that soap and other basic hygiene materials were not supplied, while toilet facilities were unavailable. The absence of these basic WASH facilities suggests that appropriate sanitation structures had not been established for the refugees during the initial phase of the emergency. The reliance on host communities for access to water potentially created additional sources of tension and dependency between refugees and their hosts. Where scarce resources are shared by displaced and host populations, competition over access can generate friction, particularly in communities with limited water infrastructure. More importantly, the absence of adequate sanitation facilities exposed refugees to significant health and protection risks. Respondents reported that refugees were compelled to defecate in surrounding bushes because there were no toilets available. Such practices exposed them to possible attacks from snakes and other dangerous animals and increased their vulnerability in an already insecure environment. The absence of readily available and free medical care could further aggravate the consequences of injuries or illnesses arising from these conditions.

Open defecation also had wider environmental and public-health implications. Human waste deposited in the surrounding environment could contaminate the immediate area and increase the risk of the transmission of communicable diseases among both refugees and members of the host communities. Thus, the absence of WASH facilities did not constitute merely an inconvenience; it represented a significant gap in humanitarian protection, with implications for health, dignity, safety and relations between refugees and host communities. The findings further indicate that UNHCR was not visibly collaborating with the local government at the border during the early phase of the crisis to establish or strengthen sanitation facilities for the refugees. This is significant because UNHCR's humanitarian approach emphasises collaboration with governments and other partners in incorporating refugee-hosting areas into water and sanitation systems. The reported absence of such coordinated intervention suggests that the WASH component of the emergency response was inadequate during the critical early period of displacement.

### Delivery of Life-Saving Supplies

The findings also reveal substantial delays in the provision of life-saving supplies to the Cameroonian refugees. Respondents reported that essential supplies were not made available to refugees at the border during their initial arrival. Refugees who entered Benue State through Amana and Agbatse reportedly began receiving food only after UNHCR became

involved considerably later. Unaccompanied children were reportedly provided with buckets and blankets at the border by Save the Children after approximately two months. This indicates that the initial provision of essential relief items was largely inadequate and delayed.

The reported delay is particularly significant considering UNHCR's stated capacity to maintain emergency supplies in warehouses located across different parts of the world, including tents, blankets and other essential items, to facilitate rapid humanitarian intervention. The organisation's emergency supply system is designed to anticipate humanitarian needs, prepare essential materials and deliver them to affected populations when and where they are most required. The experiences reported by refugees in Benue State, however, suggest that this capacity was not translated into a timely and comprehensive supply response during the initial phase of the Cameroonian refugee crisis. The inadequacy of food assistance further compounded the vulnerability of the refugees. Respondents reported that the quantities of food supplied to refugees at Amana and Agbatse were insufficient. They also stated that some of the food was reportedly taken by youths from the host communities, while other bags were allegedly pierced, leaving only limited quantities for the refugees. Consequently, some respondents considered the assistance ineffective in meeting their basic food requirements and reported cases of children dying from starvation. These accounts point not only to shortcomings in the quantity of assistance but also to weaknesses in the protection and distribution mechanisms surrounding humanitarian supplies.

The situation reportedly became particularly difficult for refugees who remained in Amana and Agbatse. Male respondents stated that some refugees eventually left these locations independently in search of safer environments because of the hardships they experienced. In doing so, some were reportedly left without adequate water, food and other life-saving supplies. This forced movement demonstrates how inadequate humanitarian assistance can itself become a factor contributing to secondary displacement. Rather than being moved systematically from areas of insecurity to safer locations through an organised humanitarian mechanism, some refugees reportedly had to determine their own routes and means of escape.

Some male respondents reported that UNHCR subsequently transported refugees by bus to Anyake, while others stated that some refugees reached safety independently and others were assisted by UNHCR. Although these interventions provided assistance to some refugees, their timing and coverage raise concerns about the comprehensiveness of the emergency response. An effective emergency response would ideally identify and assist the affected population collectively, particularly vulnerable persons who may lack the physical, financial or social capacity to relocate independently. The findings therefore suggest that UNHCR's intervention did not fully meet the urgency implied by its emergency-response mandate. The need for some refugees to relocate themselves because they could no longer endure the conditions in their initial locations indicates that the response was insufficiently anticipatory and protective. The vulnerability of displaced populations to hostility or tension within host

communities is a recognised concern in humanitarian emergencies. Consequently, mechanisms for monitoring host-refugee relations, identifying protection risks and intervening before such tensions escalate are important components of effective refugee protection.

The experiences reported in Benue State consequently point to a broader weakness in preparedness and foresight. Given UNHCR's longstanding mandate in refugee protection, the organisation would be expected to anticipate the immediate humanitarian and protection needs associated with a large influx of people fleeing armed conflict. The delayed provision of food and other essential supplies, combined with the reported difficulties surrounding their distribution and the independent movement of some refugees to safer locations, suggests that the response did not adequately anticipate or contain the emerging humanitarian challenges. Overall, the evidence indicates that the delivery of life-saving supplies was slow, insufficient and unevenly distributed during the initial stage of the crisis.

**Cash-Based Interventions**

The findings further indicate that the Cameroonian refugees did not receive cash-based assistance to enable them to purchase food and access essential goods and services in the same manner as members of the host communities. The absence of cash-based interventions limited the refugees' ability to make independent decisions concerning their immediate needs and reduced their capacity to respond flexibly to changing circumstances.

Cash-based assistance can provide displaced persons with greater autonomy and dignity by enabling them to determine which goods and services are most urgently required. In the context of the Cameroonian refugee crisis, the absence of such assistance meant that refugees remained largely dependent on whatever forms of in-kind assistance were made available to them and on support from host communities. This was particularly problematic given the reported inadequacy of food supplies and other essential items.

The findings therefore suggest that the lack of cash-based interventions constituted another limitation in the humanitarian response. While cash transfers may not be appropriate in every emergency context, their use, where feasible, can complement other forms of assistance and strengthen refugees' ability to meet their needs in a dignified manner. In this case, the absence of such assistance further constrained the refugees' capacity to exercise choice and independently address their basic needs.

**Coordination of Humanitarian Assistance**

The evidence from the various dimensions of the humanitarian response indicates that UNHCR did not effectively mobilise a rapid and comprehensive response from itself and its humanitarian partners during the initial phase of the Cameroonian refugee crisis in Benue

State. According to the respondents, Save the Children was one of the few humanitarian organisations visibly present and providing assistance at the border, while Nigerian government involvement was reported at one of the border locations. The limited presence of humanitarian actors during the early stages of the crisis suggests that the response was not sufficiently coordinated to address the scale and urgency of the displacement.

Effective coordination is particularly important during refugee emergencies because no single organisation can independently address all the needs arising from mass displacement. UNHCR's coordination role requires it to work with government institutions, United Nations agencies, international and national non-governmental organisations and local actors to mobilise resources, identify needs, establish protection mechanisms and ensure that essential assistance reaches affected populations. The reported absence of a broad and coordinated humanitarian presence at the border therefore raises concerns about the effectiveness of this coordination function.

The evidence from the provision of water, sanitation and hygiene facilities, life-saving supplies, cash-based assistance and transportation further reinforces this conclusion. Refugees reportedly depended on host communities for water and initial accommodation, received limited and delayed supplies, had no access to cash-based assistance and, in some instances, moved themselves to safer locations. These circumstances suggest that humanitarian actors were not mobilised rapidly enough to establish a comprehensive emergency-response structure capable of addressing the multiple and interconnected needs of the displaced population. The effectiveness of emergency coordination cannot be separated from the issue of timeliness. Emergency response inherently implies urgency, preparedness and rapid mobilisation. Where refugees remain for extended periods without safe water, adequate sanitation, essential supplies, appropriate shelter, financial assistance or organised transportation to safer locations, the humanitarian response risks losing its defining emergency character. The experience of the Cameroonian refugees in Benue State therefore indicates that the response was largely reactive rather than anticipatory.

Findings demonstrate that the humanitarian intervention provided to Cameroonian refugees in Benue State fell short of a comprehensive emergency response during its initial phase. The principal shortcomings were evident in the delayed provision of WASH facilities, inadequate and poorly protected distribution of life-saving supplies, absence of cash-based assistance, and limited mobilisation and coordination of humanitarian partners. Although UNHCR eventually provided assistance to some refugees and facilitated the movement of some to safer locations, the evidence suggests that these interventions occurred after significant humanitarian and protection needs had already emerged. The slow and fragmented nature of the response consequently weakened the effectiveness of refugee protection and exposed displaced Cameroonians to avoidable risks and hardship.

**Findings of the Study**

The study found that UNHCR's initial response to the Cameroonian refugee crisis in Benue State was delayed and inadequate in ensuring timely access to safety and protection. Although UNHCR is expected to respond rapidly to humanitarian emergencies, the experiences of refugees and humanitarian actors indicate that the organisation was not immediately present when refugees began arriving at the border. Respondents reported delays ranging from several weeks to several months before substantial UNHCR intervention became visible. Many refugees consequently crossed into Nigeria on foot or through other informal means and relied heavily on host communities for initial reception and assistance. The study further found that UNHCR did not initially maintain a sufficiently visible presence at the border to facilitate safe movement, prevent protection risks, monitor vulnerable refugees, or rapidly relocate the displaced population to safer areas. Although some refugees were eventually transported or relocated to safer settlements, others had to move independently because of insecurity and hardship in their initial locations. This demonstrates a significant gap between the expected standards of emergency refugee protection and the practical experience of refugees during the early stages of the crisis.

The study also found that the provision of essential humanitarian assistance, including shelter, WASH facilities, life-saving supplies and cash-based interventions, was inadequate during the initial phase of displacement. Refugees reportedly stayed in uncompleted buildings, churches and schools, while some women slept on bare floors in primary schools using their wrappers as bedding. They were not provided with adequate temporary shelters at the border, exposing them to harsh weather and other protection risks. Access to water, sanitation and hygiene facilities was similarly inadequate, with refugees relying on wells and streams in host communities and, in the absence of toilets, resorting to open defecation. The lack of adequate water and sanitation facilities created health, environmental and protection risks for both refugees and host communities. The study further established that the delivery of life-saving supplies was delayed and insufficient. Food assistance reportedly arrived only after a considerable delay, while some supplies were allegedly lost or taken before reaching refugees. Unaccompanied children reportedly received some relief materials from Save the Children after approximately two months. In addition, refugees did not receive cash-based assistance that could have enabled them to independently obtain food and other essential goods and services. These shortcomings increased refugees' dependence on host communities and humanitarian organisations and undermined their ability to meet their basic needs with dignity.

The third major finding is that weak humanitarian coordination and limited preparedness reduced the overall effectiveness of UNHCR's intervention and refugee protection. The study found that UNHCR did not sufficiently mobilise itself and its humanitarian partners at the onset of the crisis to provide an integrated emergency response. The limited presence of humanitarian actors at the border meant that host communities assumed a substantial responsibility for receiving and supporting refugees. Although organisations such as Save the

Children and Nigerian government institutions provided assistance in some locations, the response was not sufficiently coordinated to ensure comprehensive coverage of the refugee population. The evidence of delayed WASH services, inadequate shelter, insufficient life-saving supplies, absence of cash-based interventions and the independent movement of some refugees to safer locations points to a response that was largely reactive rather than anticipatory. The study therefore concludes that the principal weakness of the intervention was not simply the absence of humanitarian assistance, but the timeliness, adequacy, coordination and coverage of that assistance. While UNHCR eventually contributed to refugee relocation and protection, the delays and gaps in its intervention exposed refugees to avoidable humanitarian and protection risks and limited the effectiveness of its response to the Cameroonian refugee crisis in Benue State.

**Discussion of Findings Using Functionalism Theory**

The findings of the study can be meaningfully explained through the Functionalist Theory, which views society as a system composed of interconnected institutions, organisations and social structures whose effective functioning is necessary for maintaining social order, stability and equilibrium. From a functionalist perspective, institutions perform specific functions that contribute to the survival and stability of the wider social system. In the context of refugee crises, humanitarian organisations such as the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR), governments, host communities and non-governmental organisations constitute interconnected components of a broader humanitarian system. Each has particular functions, and the effectiveness of the system depends largely on how well these functions are performed and coordinated.

The finding that UNHCR's initial response was delayed and inadequate in providing timely access to safety and protection suggests a dysfunction within the humanitarian system. From a functionalist perspective, UNHCR performs the important institutional function of protecting refugees from insecurity, facilitating access to safety and coordinating emergency responses. When this function is not performed promptly, other parts of the system are compelled to compensate for the institutional deficiency. This was evident in the experiences of Cameroonian refugees who crossed into Benue State largely through their own efforts and depended on host communities for initial reception and assistance. The fact that some refugees travelled on foot, remained at the border for extended periods and independently sought safer locations demonstrates that the formal humanitarian institution did not initially perform its expected protective function effectively. Consequently, informal social structures, particularly host communities, assumed responsibilities that would ordinarily be expected to form part of an organised humanitarian response.

Functionalism also provides an explanation for the consequences of inadequate shelter, WASH facilities, life-saving supplies and cash-based interventions. These services perform important stabilising functions within a refugee settlement. Shelter provides physical security; water and sanitation protect health; food and other supplies sustain life; while cash

assistance provides refugees with a degree of autonomy in meeting their needs. When these functions are inadequately performed, the wider humanitarian system experiences dysfunction. The refugees' reliance on wells and streams, use of schools, churches and uncompleted buildings for accommodation, and resort to open defecation indicate that essential institutional functions were not adequately fulfilled. These deficiencies did not affect refugees alone but also created potential health, environmental and social pressures for host communities. From a functionalist standpoint, therefore, the inadequacy of humanitarian services disrupted the mechanisms necessary for maintaining stability within both the refugee population and the host community.

The finding concerning weak humanitarian coordination and limited preparedness is particularly significant from the functionalist perspective. Functionalism emphasises the interdependence of institutions, meaning that no single institution can effectively maintain the stability of a complex social system in isolation. In the context of the Cameroonian refugee crisis, UNHCR, Nigerian government institutions, humanitarian organisations, local authorities and host communities had complementary responsibilities. The reported limited mobilisation of humanitarian actors at the onset of the crisis indicates a failure of functional integration. Save the Children and government institutions provided assistance in some locations, while host communities played a major role in receiving and supporting refugees. However, these interventions were not sufficiently integrated into a coordinated system capable of ensuring comprehensive protection and assistance. The resulting gaps in shelter, WASH, supplies, cash assistance and protection demonstrate what functionalism would describe as a breakdown in institutional coordination.

The substantial role played by host communities further illustrates the adaptive capacity of the social system. Functionalism recognises that when one institution fails to perform adequately, other institutions or social structures may adapt to preserve a degree of social stability. In this study, host communities provided initial accommodation, water and other forms of support when formal humanitarian mechanisms were inadequate or delayed. This support helped prevent an even greater humanitarian crisis. However, the reliance on host communities also placed additional pressure on local resources and potentially created competition and tension between refugees and members of the host population. Thus, while informal community support performed a compensatory function, it could not substitute fully for a properly coordinated institutional humanitarian response.

The findings also reveal that the consequences of institutional dysfunction extended beyond the immediate refugee population. In functionalist terms, humanitarian systems are expected to contribute to social equilibrium by addressing disruptions caused by displacement and conflict. Where refugees lack food, water, shelter, healthcare and protection, the resulting vulnerabilities can generate further instability, including secondary displacement, dependence, health risks and tension with host communities. The reported movement of some refugees away from Amana and Agbatse because of insecurity and inadequate assistance illustrates this problem. Rather than the humanitarian system stabilising the displaced

population in a safe location, inadequacies in the initial response contributed to further movement and uncertainty.

However, the findings also demonstrate that the humanitarian system was not completely dysfunctional. UNHCR eventually intervened, provided assistance in some locations and facilitated the relocation of some refugees to safer settlements. Save the Children and Nigerian government institutions also contributed to the response. From a functionalist perspective, these interventions demonstrate the system's capacity for adaptation and correction. Once institutional actors became involved, some of the functions that had initially been absent or inadequately performed were gradually restored. The relocation of refugees away from the border, for example, represented an attempt to restore the protective function of the humanitarian system. Nevertheless, the delayed nature of these interventions indicates that the system responded reactively rather than maintaining equilibrium through early anticipation and prevention.

**Conclusion**

This study concludes that the humanitarian intervention and refugee protection provided by the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) in response to the Cameroonian refugee crisis in Benue State were characterised by significant gaps in timeliness, adequacy, coverage, coordination, and preparedness. Although UNHCR has a central international mandate to protect refugees and provide emergency assistance to populations displaced by conflict, the experiences of Cameroonian refugees indicate that the organisation's initial response did not sufficiently correspond with the urgency and scale of the humanitarian situation. The study establishes that access to safety was not adequately facilitated during the early phase of the crisis. Many refugees reached Benue State through their own efforts, often travelling on foot and relying on host communities for initial reception and support. UNHCR was not sufficiently visible at the border during the onset of the influx, and its intervention occurred after considerable delays. Although the organisation eventually assisted in relocating some refugees away from the border to safer locations, the prolonged stay of some refugees in insecure and inadequate locations demonstrates that protection measures were not implemented with the urgency expected in an emergency situation.

The study further concludes that the provision of essential humanitarian assistance was inadequate during the initial stages of displacement. Refugees lacked appropriate shelter and were compelled to stay in schools, churches and uncompleted buildings. Access to safe water, sanitation and hygiene facilities was also insufficient, resulting in dependence on host-community water sources and, in some instances, open defecation. The delayed and inadequate provision of food and other life-saving supplies further intensified refugees' vulnerability. The absence of cash-based interventions also limited their capacity to independently meet their basic needs and reduced the dignity and choice that such interventions are intended to promote. Another important conclusion is that weaknesses in

humanitarian coordination and preparedness significantly affected the effectiveness of the intervention. Rather than a comprehensive and anticipatory response involving UNHCR, government institutions and humanitarian partners from the onset of the crisis, the evidence suggests a largely reactive response. Host communities consequently assumed considerable responsibility for receiving and supporting refugees, while organisations such as Save the Children and government agencies assisted in particular locations. This indicates that the humanitarian system was not sufficiently prepared to anticipate the scale and immediate needs of Cameroonians fleeing the conflict.

**Recommendations**

First, UNHCR should strengthen its early-warning, emergency preparedness and rapid-response mechanisms for refugee influxes into Benue State. The findings indicate that delayed intervention was a major weakness of the response. UNHCR should establish or strengthen permanent border-monitoring and rapid-response teams capable of identifying emerging displacement, facilitating safe entry, conducting protection screening and immediately relocating refugees from insecure border areas to designated safe settlements. Such teams should work closely with the Nigerian government, local authorities and community structures to ensure that refugees receive protection from the moment they cross the border.

Second, UNHCR and its humanitarian partners should ensure the immediate provision of comprehensive basic humanitarian services to newly arrived refugees. Emergency response should include safe and appropriate shelter, potable water, sanitation and hygiene facilities, food, non-food items, healthcare and, where appropriate, cash-based assistance. Emergency supplies should be pre-positioned in strategic locations close to potential refugee entry points so that they can be distributed without significant delay. Particular attention should be given to vulnerable groups, including children, women, older persons, persons with disabilities and unaccompanied children. This would reduce refugees' dependence on already-constrained host communities and improve the dignity, safety and effectiveness of humanitarian assistance.

Third, UNHCR should strengthen coordination among government institutions, humanitarian organisations and host communities. The study revealed that the limited coordination of humanitarian actors contributed to gaps in assistance and placed considerable responsibility on host communities. UNHCR should establish a clearly defined coordination mechanism involving the relevant Nigerian government agencies, local authorities, Save the Children and other humanitarian and civil-society organisations. The mechanism should provide for joint needs assessments, clear division of responsibilities, protection monitoring, coordinated distribution of relief materials and regular evaluation of refugee needs. Stronger coordination would enable humanitarian actors to respond collectively and proactively rather than reactively, thereby improving the overall effectiveness of refugee protection in Benue State.

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# CIVIL SOCIETY ORGANIZATIONS AND CONFLICT MANAGEMENT IN TAKUM LOCAL GOVERNMENT AREA OF TARABA STATE, NIGERIA

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**Abstract.** The study examined the role of Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) in conflict management in Takum Local Government Area (LGA) of Taraba State, Nigeria. The study focuses on two prominent CSOs; the Kuteb Yatso of Nigeria (KYN) and the Ichen Cultural and Development Association (ICADA), and their contributions to managing conflicts between 1996 and 2025. Anchored on Vamik Volkan's Psycho-Cultural Conflict Theory, the research explores how identity-based grievances and historical traumas sustain communal tensions in Takum, while analysing CSOs' interventions as mechanisms for psychological healing and reconciliation. The study adopted a descriptive survey research design, integrating a qualitative approach. Data were collected from forty respondents, including CSO leaders, community heads, government officials, and security personnel, using interviews and focus group discussions. Thematic analysis was applied to interpret narratives and identify recurring patterns. The findings revealed that CSOs play a multifaceted role in conflict management through dialogue facilitation, shuttle mediation, peace education, and early warning systems. Their neutrality and grassroots engagement enable them to act as trusted intermediaries between conflicting communities and formal institutions. However, their effectiveness is largely limited to conflict prevention and mitigation, as deep-rooted political and chieftaincy disputes often surpass their mediatory capacity. Challenges such as inadequate funding, security threats, political interference, and lack of institutional recognition further constrain their operations. The study concluded that CSOs are indispensable actors in promoting peace and social cohesion in multi-ethnic settings like Takum, despite their operational constraints. It recommends that government and donor agencies provide financial and capacity-building support to CSOs, and that the Local Government Peace and Security Committee institutionalise regular collaboration with recognised CSOs for intelligence sharing and joint peacebuilding initiatives.

**Keywords:** Civil society organisations, conflict management, peacebuilding, mediation, dialogue.

## Introduction

Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) have long been recognised globally as critical actors in the interconnected fields of conflict management and peacebuilding, particularly in geopolitical areas characterised by protracted socio-political instability. Their capacity to mitigate conflicts, promote dialogue, and facilitate the establishment of sustainable peace is well-documented across various global contexts. In Nigeria, a nation distinguished by profound ethnic heterogeneity, complex historical narratives, and continuous political and economic volatility, CSOs have assumed a particularly significant role as key stakeholders in addressing endemic conflicts and advocating for broader social justice. The state of Taraba, and specifically its Takum Local Government Area (LGA), epitomizes a region burdened by persistent conflicts, manifested as ethnic and communal hostilities, political electoral disputes, and recurrent resource-based tensions. The fundamental drivers of these conflicts are frequently structural and psychological, encompassing perceived marginalization, inequitable resource distribution, entrenched ethnic rivalries, and systemic corruption.

The evolution of CSO involvement in Nigeria's conflict landscape can be historically traced to the colonial era, during which early civil society groups were central to resistance movements and the eventual struggle for political independence. Post-independence, the scope of CSOs expanded considerably to address critical governance deficiencies, human rights violations, and the socio-economic inequalities that commonly form the underlying causes of conflicts nationwide. The various internal conflicts faced by Nigeria, ranging from the Biafran War to the Niger Delta militancy and the ongoing Boko Haram insurgency, have progressively compelled CSOs to intensify their peacebuilding efforts. These efforts primarily involve facilitating mediation and negotiation, actively promoting intergroup dialogue, and implementing crucial reintegration programs for ex-combatants and internally displaced persons. The core strength of CSOs in this domain lies in their intrinsic grassroots engagement, which permits operational access to areas that may be inaccessible to formal government actors. This closeness to the affected populace allows CSOs to develop a deeper understanding of the root causes of conflicts, thereby enabling the formulation of culturally relevant and effective resolution strategies. Furthermore, CSOs contribute substantially to democratic governance by championing transparency, accountability, and adherence to the rule of law, elements universally recognised as essential in conflict prevention. They also invest heavily in capacity-building programs, training local community leaders, grassroots actors, and even government officials in effective conflict resolution techniques and sustainable peacebuilding practices.

Despite these considerable contributions, CSOs in Nigeria frequently grapple with significant operational challenges, including precarious funding, political manipulation, acute security threats, and poor inter-organisational coordination. The institutional scepticism and occasional hostility from government bodies, which often view CSOs as adversaries rather than essential development partners, further complicate their work. Consequently, CSO activities have sometimes been restricted, and their members subjected to harassment. The

dynamic and often escalating nature of contemporary conflicts, exemplified by the rise of violent extremism and the proliferation of small arms, necessitates that CSOs must continuously adapt their strategies. This adaptation demands innovative approaches, stronger institutional frameworks, and significantly enhanced collaboration with both international organizations and domestic policymakers.

Takum Local Government Area remains a focal point for recurring conflicts, driven by deep-seated ethnic tensions, occasional religious violence, and protracted communal clashes, which have generated significant loss of life, widespread displacement, massive destruction of property, and severe disruption of socio-economic life. The persistent nature of this conflict, despite military operations, policy interventions, and official peace initiatives by the government, underscores fundamental deficiencies in current conflict management strategies.

In this context, CSOs have naturally emerged as indispensable actors in peacebuilding and conflict resolution, often acting to supplement and complement state-led efforts. Prominent among these organizations are the Kuteb Yatso of Nigeria (KYN), a socio-cultural body representing the Kuteb ethnic group, and the Taraba State Peace and Conflict Resolution Initiative (TSPCRI). The KYN, given the area's historical disputes over land, chieftaincy succession, and political representation, is deeply involved in mediating disputes, advocating for the rights of the Kuteb community, and fostering dialogue with other groups. Collectively, CSOs contribute through community engagement and grassroots conflict resolution strategies.

Notwithstanding these dedicated efforts, the continuation and frequent escalation of conflicts in Takum raise serious academic and policy questions concerning the overall effectiveness, inherent challenges, and ultimate limitations of civil society-led conflict management approaches. There is a critical, unmet need for a rigorous, systematic, and critical examination of the specific roles CSOs play in mitigating conflict, their actual level of influence across different dispute types, the specific challenges they face on the ground, and the potential areas where their impact can be sustainably improved.

Therefore, this study is specifically designed to assess the tangible contributions of CSOs, focusing predominantly on the Kuteb Yatso of Nigeria (KYN) and, where applicable, the Taraba State Peace and Conflict Resolution Initiative (TSPCRI), in conflict management within Takum Local Government Area. The ultimate goal is to generate actionable insights for identifying and implementing more sustainable strategies that can genuinely enhance the impact of these vital civil society interventions. The goal of this research is to investigate the complex role of civil society organisations in conflict management within the Takum Local Government Area of Taraba State. The specific, guiding objectives are:

i. To examine the specific roles that civil society organisations (CSOs), with particular reference to the Kuteb Yatso of Nigeria and TSPCRI, play in conflict management in Takum Local Government Area.
ii. To rigorously assess the operational effectiveness of CSOs in conflict management processes within Takum LGA.
iii. To comprehensively identify and analyse the primary challenges faced by CSOs during the implementation of conflict resolution and peacebuilding initiatives within the study area.

## LITERATURE REVIEW AND THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

### The Concept of Civil Society

The conceptual definition of civil society presents an enduring challenge, with scholars and practitioners finding it difficult to establish a single, universally accepted definition. This conceptual difficulty is magnified when attempting to apply the concept to African contexts, where the political, social, and cultural realities diverge significantly from the Western societies in which much of the original discourse was developed. The distinctiveness of African social structures, historical trajectories, and governance models raises questions regarding the applicability of established Western frameworks in fully capturing the complex, diverse realities of civil society across the continent. Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) are crucial for nurturing democratic governance, social cohesion, and effective conflict resolution. Scholars offer various definitions to capture their diverse nature:

Mpozios (2024) defines CSOs as a broad spectrum of non-governmental and non-profit organizations actively engaged in public life, advocating for the specific interests and values of diverse societal segments. These organizations are motivated by a wide array of principles, including ethical, cultural, political, scientific, religious, or philanthropic goals. Paudel (2023) stresses the essential characteristics of CSOs as being formal, voluntary, and independent organizations, highlighting their nonprofit mandate and their driving role in social, political, and economic transformation. This emphasizes their autonomy from governmental control, which is necessary for advocating reform and development initiatives. Rakodi (2024) views CSOs as a distinct associational sphere operating separately from both the state and the market. His categorization includes NGOs, community-based organizations (CBOs), faith-based organizations (FBOs), labor unions, and professional associations, all contributing to advocacy, service provision, and conflict resolution.

Syal et al. (2021) describe CSOs as a network of voluntary associations, social movements, and nonprofit institutions that operate autonomously to safeguard citizens' rights, champion democracy, and support development efforts. Their definition underscores the vital function of CSOs in ensuring citizen participation, accountability, and inclusivity in governance. Briguglio et al. (2023) emphasize the role of CSOs in generating social capital, which

involves building civic engagement, trust, and cooperation among individuals. By strengthening democratic institutions and enhancing societal cohesion, CSOs contribute to a more stable and participatory social order.

In synthesis, CSOs can be characterized by four key dimensions: Autonomy and Independence, allowing them to hold state institutions accountable; Diversity of Forms and Functions, encompassing advocacy, service delivery, and capacity building across various sectors; a crucial Democratic and Participatory Role, fostering civic engagement and political reform; and a central role in Conflict Management and Peacebuilding, through dialogue and grassroots reconciliation. Essentially, CSOs serve as an indispensable bridge between the state and society, amplifying marginalized voices, strengthening democratic governance, and actively contributing to conflict resolution and sustainable peace. The contemporary literature on civil society has seen a significant increase in focus on its role in peace, governance, and development, particularly in conflict-affected and fragile states. Civil society is commonly presented as a crucial link between the state and the populace, capable of promoting social justice, fostering community cohesion, and ensuring governmental accountability. However, in contexts like West Africa, the discourse is often narrowly focused on formal, internationally-recognized, and donor-funded Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs), which can lead to a limited understanding of the concept.

Lewis (2018) contends that this narrow focus excludes a vast array of groups that truly reflect West Africa’s rich associational culture. These include traditional governance structures, religious organizations, women's and youth groups, and local cooperatives, all of which wield substantial social and political influence. Traditional leaders, for instance, are often central to conflict resolution, land dispute mediation, and social welfare. These deeply embedded actors are essential for any accurate analysis of civil society in the region, even if they do not fit the conventional Western NGO model.

The complexity of civil society in Africa is further compounded by its hybrid nature, resulting from historical and colonial legacies. The imposition of external political systems disrupted indigenous governance structures, leading to a complex blending of traditional institutions and external influences that defies a simple, universal definition. While modern civil society is associated with ideals like participatory governance and human rights, the concept itself is not modern, possessing a long and contested history in political philosophy. Thinkers from Aristotle to Marx explored the relationship between the individual, society, and the state, shaping contemporary understandings. In recent decades, however, there has been a pronounced global emphasis on civil society as a critical tool for international development and peacebuilding, with donors frequently viewing CSOs as catalysts for social and political transformation and a means of addressing weak institutions and conflict. This dependence on external funding, however, raises legitimate concerns about the genuine autonomy and authenticity of CSOs, particularly when their operations align more closely with donor priorities than with the urgent needs of local communities. Therefore, understanding CSOs in Takum requires an inclusive, context-specific approach that moves

beyond formal NGOs to recognize the full spectrum of actors involved in peace and development.

**Functions of Civil Society Organizations**

The functions of civil society organizations are highly contested and multifaceted, often encompassing both beneficial and detrimental roles, as noted by Rousseau, who suggested civil society engenders both the best and the worst of human nature, our virtues and vices alike (Babbo, 2021).

One significant dimension is the economic function, which is viewed optimistically by some and pessimistically by others. Pessimistic views, such as that of Olsen (Putman, 1993:176), suggest that small interest groups within civil society are primarily motivated by self-interest, engaging in rent-seeking, lobbying for tax breaks, and colluding to restrain competition, rather than working for the common good. This perspective argues that a growing density of special interest groups can effectively choke off innovation and dampen overall economic growth. Callaghy (cited in Webb, 2023) further feared that the "wild passions of civil society" could ultimately undermine sound economic management and necessary economic reform. Conversely, other scholars contend that civil society is a powerful engine for economic growth. Putnam, for example, analyzed data across Italian regions and found that levels of associational life were strongly correlated with higher economic development. Jensen and Ramey (2020) highlighted Inglehart's attempt to reconcile these two opposing theories, concluding that dense associational networks are conducive to economic growth in the earlier stages of development, aligning with Putnam's view. However, Inglehart also noted that in advanced industrial societies, these associations can become "hypertrophied," excessively powerful, and capable of distorting policy to defend entrenched interests at the expense of general economic prosperity, thus supporting Olson's later-stage pessimism.

A second major function is the stabilizing function, centered on the extent to which civil society can support and stabilize the state and its institutions. Both Tocqueville and Putnam emphasized the critical role of voluntary associations in supporting a culture of trust and cooperation, factors essential for the successful functioning of democratic institutions. However, empirical tests suggest that this link is not universally automatic or necessary. For instance, Inglehart’s multiple regression tests showed that although membership in voluntary associations strongly correlates with stable democracy, the variable loses statistical significance when the effects of other variables are controlled. Furthermore, Pinckney et al. (2022) caution that civil society can negatively impact democracy, particularly if it fragments into several exclusive societies organized along ethnic, linguistic, or cultural lines, thereby undermining national unity.

A third, widely recognized function is the democratic function. Studies consistently show that members of organizations, regardless of whether the organization is explicitly political or not,

are more likely to consider themselves competent citizens and to be more active participants in politics. Bolleyer (2021) concludes that members more closely approximate the ideal of the democratic citizen: pertinent, active, and open with their opinions. Crucially, even passive membership or membership in nonpolitical organizations has been shown to positively impact political competence and pluralism, which are core foundations of political democracy (Hertel-Fernandez, 2024). Nie, Powell, and Prewitt (1969:808) also explored this, suggesting that as the density and complexity of organizations increase, larger segments of the population acquire higher levels of political information, awareness, and a sense of political efficacy, leading directly to increased political participation. Civil society also serves the democratic function of facilitating democratic transitions. From a theoretical standpoint, Montesquieu (cited in Harbeson, 1994:26) believed civil society functions as an essential counterweight to government, inhibiting tyrannical tendencies, a capacity he also suggested was performed in practice.

A wide range of other functions are noted in the international literature, particularly those relevant to conflict management and peacebuilding, as itemised by Mbugua (2020):

i. Establishing alternative media and engaging in responsible war and peace reporting.
ii. Monitoring elections and the activities of state institutions related to democratisation.
iii. Youth work, including community-based social policy, income generation, education, and empowerment initiatives.
iv. Support for education sector reforms and the promotion of peace education.
v. Establishing peace cultures by offering incentives for overcoming cultures of war through arts, music, films, and cultural events.
vi. Strengthening local peace constituencies through inter-religious dialogue and the empowerment of marginalised groups, especially women.
vii. Advocacy and human rights monitoring, including campaigns against human trafficking and for women's rights.
viii. Protection of endangered individuals, and providing security for minority groups, refugees, and returnees.
ix. Support for demobilization, disarmament, and demilitarization (DDR), as well as community building and reintegration efforts.

In summary, the functions of CSOs are extensive, encompassing economic, political, democratic, and social dimensions. Anheier et al. (2019) emphasize that these functions also include the core activity of representing the interests of specific groups within society. This diversity underscores the indispensable nature of CSOs in modern governance and conflict-affected regions like Takum LGA.

**Civil Society Organisations and Conflict Management**

The involvement of Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) in conflict management is a well-established practice, particularly effective due to their proximity to local communities and their ability to mobilise resources and local knowledge in ways that government institutions often cannot. Their activities are generally categorised into three main phases: conflict prevention, conflict resolution, and post-conflict peacebuilding.

In conflict prevention, CSOs are crucial for early warning and early response. By maintaining deep roots within the community, they are uniquely positioned to monitor subtle shifts in social dynamics, track escalating grievances, and detect potential flashpoints before violence erupts. Organizations like the Kuteb Yatso of Nigeria (KYN) and the Taraba State Peace and Conflict Resolution Initiative (TSPCRI) likely gather and disseminate grassroots intelligence, providing timely information to traditional rulers, security agencies, and government officials, allowing for proactive intervention. Adelaja, George, & Rasheed (2018) emphasize the role of community-based early warning systems in Nigeria, noting their essential contribution to peacebuilding efforts. Beyond warning, CSOs engage in educational campaigns and dialogue initiatives aimed at reducing inter-group hostility, promoting tolerance, and dispelling misinformation, which can often fuel ethnic and religious conflicts.

In conflict resolution, CSOs primarily function as mediators and facilitators. They create non-adversarial platforms, such as dialogue forums, where conflicting parties can meet under conditions of neutrality to negotiate disputes. Bercovitch (2019) notes that third parties, which CSOs often constitute, employ various strategies to manage conflicts. A key strategy for CSOs in Takum, as revealed by the study's abstract, is shuttle mediation, which is particularly effective in high-tension environments where direct negotiation is initially impossible. This process involves the mediator moving between the two sides, relaying messages, identifying common ground, and subtly guiding them toward a negotiated settlement. Their neutrality, or at least perceived impartiality, is their greatest asset in establishing the necessary trust for negotiation.

In post-conflict peacebuilding, the role of CSOs shifts to addressing the deeper, structural, and psychological root causes of the conflict. This involves a range of activities such as:

i. Reconciliation and Trauma Healing: Creating spaces for victims and perpetrators to engage in truth-telling and collective trauma processing, aligning with the principles of psycho-cultural healing (Volkan's theory).
ii. Socio-Economic Reintegration: Implementing programs for ex-combatants and displaced persons, focusing on livelihoods, education, and vocational training, thereby reducing the risk of recidivism to violence.

iii. Advocacy for Justice and Governance Reform: Pushing for reforms that address the initial drivers of conflict, such as advocating for accountability, transparency, and inclusive political participation.

Smith (2021) examined CSO contributions across Nigeria's Middle Belt and North-East, emphasizing their instrumental role in building trust, facilitating dialogue, and conducting peace education workshops. This is highly relevant for understanding the potential strategies of CSOs in the multi-ethnic and multi-religious context of Takum LGA. The capacity of CSOs to localize peace efforts, addressing the unique challenges of rural conflict zones as noted by Okeke & Musa (2021), highlights their vital importance in regions where state presence may be distant or mistrusted. However, the same studies often point to the limitations: CSOs often face the challenge of maintaining neutrality in highly politicized conflicts, a dilemma highlighted by Adebayo & Salihu (2021), which is particularly relevant in the context of deep-seated chieftaincy and political disputes in Takum.

**Role of the Civil Society Organisations in Peace Building**

Peacebuilding is the complex process of establishing long-term, self-sustaining peace by identifying and addressing the structural and cultural root causes of conflict, while simultaneously supporting reconciliation, justice, and healing. CSOs are central to this work, moving beyond merely stopping violence to fostering harmony and preventing the recurrence of future conflicts. Their role in peacebuilding is executed at multiple levels: local, national, and transnational.

At the local/grassroots level, CSOs are the primary drivers of community-level transformation. They facilitate inter-communal initiatives, such as inter-faith and inter-ethnic dialogue committees, which are essential for repairing the social fabric torn by conflict. This grassroots work is crucial because it promotes cultural tolerance and mutual understanding, transforming the relationship between former adversaries. Musinguzi (2019), for example, highlighted the expansive role of CSOs in the post-conflict reconstruction and development of northern Uganda, a model with parallels for Takum, which also faces post-conflict challenges. CSOs mobilize local resources, skills, and commitment, ensuring that peace processes are locally owned, a factor universally recognized as essential for sustainability. Adeniyi & Okon (2023) affirm the importance of grassroots peacebuilding in Nigeria's Middle Belt, stressing the capacity of CSOs to translate national peace policies into culturally relevant local practices.

At the national level, CSOs engage in crucial advocacy and monitoring roles. They lobby government officials and political institutions for policy reforms that institutionalize peace and justice. This includes advocating for judicial reforms, land tenure security, and inclusive political processes to address systemic grievances that fuel conflict. CSOs monitor the

implementation of peace accords and governmental programs, providing independent oversight and reporting on compliance, which increases transparency and accountability.

The involvement of CSOs in peacebuilding is heavily influenced by the contemporary discourse on security, which has evolved to include human security and the critical role of women in peace processes. Ibrahim & Zubairu (2023) discuss the implementation gaps in the UN Security Council Resolution 1325 (Women, Peace, and Security) in Northern Nigeria, an area with similar conflict dynamics to Takum. CSOs often lead efforts to empower women and ensure their participation in peace talks and post-conflict governance, recognizing that gender-inclusive peace processes are statistically more likely to succeed.

Finally, the sustainability of CSO peacebuilding initiatives hinges on their ability to build local peace infrastructures. This involves formalizing collaborative governance models where local authorities, traditional rulers, security agencies, and civil society actors co-manage peace and security affairs. Albert (2021) argues that this multi-stakeholder model is essential for sustainable peacebuilding in Nigeria's conflict zones. Institutionalizing the role of CSOs, as recommended in the study's abstract, would legitimize their operations, protect their staff, and grant them essential access to resources and intelligence necessary for effective long-term peacebuilding. This formal recognition transitions CSOs from ad-hoc helpers to indispensable, permanent components of the state's security and development apparatus.

**Theoretical Framework**

To understand the intractability of conflicts in Takum and the specific challenges faced by peacebuilders, this paper employs Vamik Volkan's Psycho-Cultural Conflict Theory. This theory moves beyond purely rationalist explanations of conflict, such as competition over scarce resources, to incorporate the powerful, often non-rational, psychological and cultural dimensions that sustain large-group antagonisms (Ossana, 2021).

Volkan argues that conflicts rooted in ethnic or communal identity are often "dangerous, violent, intractable and highly protracted" (as cited in Faleti, 2006, p. 51). This intractability stems from the central place of identity, which provides individuals with a sense of worth, meaning, and psychological safety. When this identity is perceived to be threatened, through marginalisation, historical humiliation, or discrimination, the defensive reaction can be existential and violent (Faleti, 2006).

**Key concepts from this theory are highly relevant to Takum:**

i. Chosen Trauma: This refers to a shared, collective memory of a historical defeat or humiliation inflicted by an "other" group. In Takum, competing historical narratives over land ownership and chieftaincy legitimacy function as chosen traumas for groups like the Kuteb and Jukun. These memories are not relegated to the past but are

actively mourned and invoked to define present-day group identity and justify hostility.

ii. Time Collapse: This is the psychological process where past traumas are experienced as if they are happening in the present. A contemporary land dispute in Takum is thus not just about the plot of land but becomes a re-enactment of centuries-old grievances over territory and sovereignty, making compromise feel like a betrayal of ancestors.

iii. The "Container/Contained" Dynamic: Political and traditional leaders can become "containers" for their group's collective anxiety, trauma, and aggression. They may mobilise followers by channelling these emotions toward rival groups, thereby personalising and politicising conflicts. Chieftaincy disputes in Takum are prime examples, where traditional stools become focal points for elite competition, making them exceptionally difficult for neutral CSOs to mediate (Volkan, 1997).

The theory helps explain why top-down, legally focused government interventions often fail in Takum: they address the surface-level manifestations (the violent clash) but not the underlying psycho-cultural wounds (the chosen trauma). Conversely, it illuminates the potential value of CSOs. Their work in facilitating sustained dialogue, creating spaces for shared storytelling, and promoting peace education can be seen as attempting to address these deeper affective layers—to facilitate a process of "shared mourning" and break down rigid "us vs. them" boundaries (Marchetti & Tocci, 2020).

However, the theory also predicts the limits of such efforts. When conflicts are deeply entangled with identity and manipulated by powerful elites (containers), the space for neutral, civil society mediation shrinks dramatically. Thus, Psycho-Cultural Conflict Theory provides a robust lens for analysing both the crucial contributions and the inherent constraints of CSOs in a setting like Takum.

## METHODOLOGY

This study adopted a descriptive survey research design, utilising a qualitative approach to gain in-depth insights into the perceptions and experiences of key stakeholders involved in conflict management in Takum LGA (Creswell & Poth, 2018). The primary objective was to explore the roles, effectiveness, and challenges of CSOs, with a particular focus on KYN and ICADA.

Area of Study: The research was conducted in Takum LGA, Taraba State, a region with a history of recurrent ethno-communal conflicts. The area is multi-ethnic, with the Kuteb, Jukun, Tiv, Ichen, and Chamba as major groups.

Population and Sampling: The target population included individuals directly engaged in or affected by conflict management processes. A purposive sampling technique was employed to

select 40 respondents who could provide rich, information-laden perspectives (Patton, 2015). The sample comprised:

i. CSO Representatives (10): Leaders and active members of KYN and ICADA.
ii. Community Leaders (10): Traditional rulers, ward heads, and respected elders from various ethnic groups.
iii. Local Government Officials (10): Personnel from the LGA administration and the Security Committee.
iv. Security Personnel (10): Officers from the Nigeria Police Force and other security agencies deployed in Takum.

Data Collection: Primary data was collected through semi-structured interviews and Focus Group Discussions (FGDs). Interview guides and FGD protocols were designed to explore the three core research objectives. All interviews and discussions were conducted in settings convenient for the respondents, recorded with permission, and later transcribed.

Data Analysis: Thematic analysis was used to analyse the qualitative data (Braun & Clarke, 2006). This involved a systematic process of transcribing interviews, repeated reading to ensure familiarity, generating initial codes, searching for and reviewing themes, and finally, defining and naming themes. Direct quotations from respondents are used in the findings section to ground the analysis in the participants' voices.

Ethical Considerations: Informed consent was obtained from all participants. Anonymity and confidentiality were assured, with respondents identified only by their stakeholder category (e.g., "CSO Representative, Takum") to protect their identities given the sensitive nature of conflict discussions.

## FINDINGS AND DISCUSSION

The Multifaceted Roles of CSOs in Takum's Conflict Landscape

The study revealed that CSOs in Takum are not monolithic in their approach but engage in a repertoire of complementary roles that position them as unique peacebuilding actors. Their strength derives from their embeddedness within the community, which grants them trust, cultural intelligence, and rapid response capabilities often absent in formal state institutions.

### i. Facilitators of Dialogue and Mediation

The most prominent role identified was that of a neutral intermediary or "bridge" between conflicting parties. CSOs actively organise "Dialogue Forums" that bring together youth and elders from opposing groups. As one CSO representative explained:

"Our main work is through Dialogue Forums that bring youth and elders from opposing groups together... We organize shuttle mediation between conflicting parties. Our approach is to find a mutually acceptable temporary respite and get both parties to sign a peace accord pending LGA intervention." (CSO Representative, Takum).

This shuttle diplomacy, where CSO mediators move between parties to convey messages, reduce hostility, and build consensus, is a classic track-two diplomacy technique (Montville, 2006). It is particularly valuable in Takum, where direct face-to-face meetings in the early stages of a conflict may be impossible due to high tensions. The community recognises this bridging function, with a leader noting, "They are like a bridge between the fighting groups. They help to calm the youth down" (Community Leader, Takum).

### ii. Providers of Early Warning and Ground Intelligence

CSOs have developed an organic early warning system through networks of volunteer 'Peace Observers' embedded in flashpoint communities. These observers monitor signs of impending violence, such as unusual migration, hate speech in markets, or gatherings of armed youth. This intelligence is crucial for preventive action. A local government official corroborated this role, stating, "CSOs are vital for ground intelligence and facilitating local buy-in" (Local Government Official, Takum). This function aligns with best practices in conflict prevention, where local actors are best positioned to detect early signs of escalation (Adelaja et al., 2018).

### iii. Conductors of Peace Education and Social Sensitisation

Moving beyond reactive mediation, CSOs invest in long-term conflict transformation through peace education programs in local schools and community sensitisation campaigns. These initiatives aim to change the narratives that fuel conflict, especially among youth. A security personnel acknowledged this transformative role: "They play a significant role in Peace Education, helping to change the narrative among the youth who are often the perpetrators of violence" (Security Personnel, Takum). By teaching tolerance, conflict resolution skills, and the value of diversity, CSOs work to undermine the psycho-cultural foundations of conflict identified by Volkan's theory.

### iv. Collaborative Partners with State and Security Actors

Contrary to viewing CSOs as antagonists, the study found evidence of functional, if informal, collaboration with local government and security agencies. CSOs provide intelligence that informs security responses and help the government implement contentious policies by building community consensus. For instance, they were instrumental in organising town hall meetings on the state's anti-open grazing law. This collaborative role positions CSOs as

essential components of a multi-track peacebuilding system, linking grassroots concerns with formal governance structures (Lederach, 1997).

**Assessing Effectiveness: Mitigation Success Amidst Structural Limits**

Stakeholder assessments of CSO effectiveness were measured and contextual, highlighting a clear distinction between success in managing immediate crises and failure in resolving deep-seated conflicts.

**i. High Effectiveness in Conflict De-escalation and Prevention**

There was strong consensus that CSOs excel at preventing localized disputes from erupting into wider violence. They are valued for their speed and local legitimacy. A community leader gave a concrete example:

"Last year during the market dispute where a Jukun man and a Kuteb man fought over a stall. The CSO (KYN) held a meeting with the market leaders from both sides for three days... It stopped the fight from spreading to the whole town." (Community Leader, Takum).

Security personnel echoed this, stating, "The interventions of the CSOs have been very effective in preventing localized flare-ups; they are excellent at de-escalation" (Security Personnel, Takum). This ability to "cool down" situations and create breathing space for dialogue is their most tangible contribution to human security in Takum.

**ii. Limited Effectiveness in Resolving Deep-Rooted and Political Conflicts**

The same respondents who praised CSOs for mitigation were quick to point out their limitations. Their effectiveness was often rated as "moderate" (3 out of 5), primarily because they lack the authority to address structural drivers of conflict. The most frequently cited example was chieftaincy disputes. A CSO representative explained the difficulty:

"Chieftaincy disputes are the most challenging. They are deeply rooted in historical claims and are often tied to powerful political figures, making it very difficult for a non-political CSO to mediate effectively without being seen as taking sides." (CSO Representative, Takum).

This aligns perfectly with the psycho-cultural concept of the "container/contained." When a conflict becomes a tool for political elites (the containers) to mobilise ethnic sentiment, the neutrality of a CSO is easily compromised. Furthermore, CSOs cannot enforce agreements or allocate state resources, which limits their ability to broker durable solutions to conflicts over land or political representation. As the security personnel noted, their "main challenge is in

ensuring the agreements reached during mediation are sustained over the long term when political interests conflict" (Security Personnel, Takum).

## Navigating a Landscape of Constraints: Key Challenges Facing CSOs

The study identified a triad of interconnected challenges that severely constrain CSO operations: resource scarcity, physical insecurity, and political vulnerability.

### i. Chronic Funding and Capacity Deficits

The most universal challenge reported was a severe lack of sustainable funding. CSOs typically rely on small, irregular local donations, which cripples their planning and outreach. A CSO representative stated bluntly, "The biggest challenge is funding; we are reliant on small local donations" (CSO Representative, Takum). This financial precarity leads to limited capacity, poor documentation of activities, and an inability to reach remote but conflict-prone villages, a gap noted by community leaders. This "resource-scarcity trap" is common among grassroots CSOs in conflict zones, forcing them into a reactive rather than strategic mode of operation (Adebisi, 2023).

### ii. Security Risks and Operational Hazards

Operating in a volatile environment entails significant personal risk. CSO staff and their network of Peace Observers face threats when travelling to remote areas or when their identities as conflict monitors are revealed. Security personnel highlighted this vulnerability: "CSOs need to improve in information security; sometimes, their peace observers' identity is compromised, putting them and their network at risk" (Security Personnel, Takum). This constant threat undermines their operational reach and the safety of their volunteers.

### iii. Political Interference and the Neutrality Dilemma

CSOs pride themselves on being apolitical intermediaries. However, the highly politicised nature of Takum's conflicts constantly threatens this neutrality. Local elites often attempt to co-opt peace dialogues to advance their agendas. A CSO representative lamented, "Finally, political interference; some local elites try to use our dialogues to push their own agenda" (CSO Representative, Takum). This interference can erode community trust in the CSO, making mediation impossible. Furthermore, bureaucratic hurdles from the very state agencies they seek to collaborate with, such as delays in providing official letters of support for funding applications, further hinder their work.

## CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

This paper argued that indigenous Civil Society Organisations like KYN and ICADA are indispensable, yet not omnipotent, actors in the conflict ecosystem of Takum LGA. Grounded in their communities, they perform critical functions- mediation, early warning, peace education, and liaison- that state actors are poorly positioned to execute. Their work directly addresses the relational and psycho-cultural dimensions of conflict by fostering dialogue and building trust across ethnic divides, thereby mitigating violence and saving lives.

However, their effectiveness is structurally bounded. As illuminated by Psycho-Cultural Conflict Theory, the deepest conflicts in Takum are anchored in historical trauma, identity, and elite political manipulation. CSOs, lacking coercive power or political authority, cannot single-handedly resolve these entrenched issues. Their efforts are further hamstrung by a pervasive lack of resources, persistent security threats, and the ever-present risk of political co-optation. Therefore, the path to more sustainable peace in Takum does not lie in expecting CSOs to do more with less, but in strategically strengthening and integrating them into a coherent, multi-actor peacebuilding framework.

CSOs in Takum are not a substitute for effective, accountable, and inclusive governance. Rather, they are a vital complement. In acknowledging their unique strengths, understanding their limitations, and investing in their capacity within a supportive ecosystem, policymakers and peacebuilding practitioners can significantly enhance prospects for lasting peace in Takum and other communities fractured by deep-seated conflict. Based on the findings, this paper proposes the following recommendations:

i. The Taraba State Government and Takum LGA should formalise partnerships with credible CSOs. This could involve granting them official observer or advisory seats on the Local Government Security Committee. As one official suggested, “We need a formal LGA-CSO partnership framework that guarantees them a seat on the LGA Security Committee. This would institutionalise their early warning system and ensure their recommendations are acted upon promptly” (Local Government Official, Takum). This would enhance information-sharing, coordinated responses, and give CSOs a measure of official protection.
ii. Donor agencies, philanthropic foundations, and corporate social responsibility initiatives should design funding streams specifically for grassroots, indigenous peacebuilders. This funding should be flexible and long-term to allow for strategic programming beyond immediate crisis response. Coupled with funding, targeted capacity-building in project management, digital security for field staff, mediation skills, and monitoring and evaluation is essential to professionalise their operations and improve sustainability.
iii. A holistic approach requires linking CSOs more effectively with other key actors. Traditional institutions, which command significant respect, should be engaged as partners in CSO-led dialogues. Religious leaders can amplify messages of tolerance.

Security agencies need to develop standard operating procedures for rapidly acting on CSO-generated early warnings. Creating a regular forum for consultation among these tracks would build a more resilient and responsive peace infrastructure.

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# THE MULTINATIONAL JOINT TASK FORCE IN THE LAKE CHAD BASIN: A STRATEGIC LOOK AT COUNTERINSURGENCY RESULTS

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**Abstract.** This study examines the efforts of the Multinational Joint Task Force (MNJTF) in countering the significant threat of Boko Haram insurgency in the Lake Chad Basin. Formed by Nigeria, Chad, Cameroon and Niger, the MNJTF stands as the regional force against cross-border insurgency undermining both human safety and state security. It examines the force through a functional reinterpretation of David Galula's counterinsurgency theory. Rather than treating Galula as a state-specific operational doctrine, it employs his "clear–hold–build–legitimize" sequence as a framework of necessary counterinsurgency functions applicable to distributed security environments. The analysis shows that these failures are not solely operational but structural, arising from the incomplete realization of Galula's functional requirements across disaggregated state systems. The study concludes that counterinsurgency success in the Lake Chad Basin depends on achieving functional closure of all four Galulian requirements across multiple institutional actors rather than sequential military progression. It also noted that although the MNJTF has demonstrated considerable effectiveness in degrading Boko Haram's conventional operational capacity, long-term stabilization remains constrained by weak coordination between military operations and civilian governance institutions. Consequently, tactical gains are frequently not translated into sustainable political and security outcomes.

**Keywords:** Multinational Joint Task Force, Boko Haram, Lake Chad Basin, Insurgency, Counterinsurgency, Regional Security

## Introduction

Regional security alliances have become an essential component of contemporary security governance, particularly in addressing transnational security threats. In Africa, frameworks such as the African Union's Peace and Security Architecture and regional organizations like ECOWAS have developed coordinated responses to terrorism and other cross-border security challenges (Francis, 2006).

The Multinational Joint Task Force (MNJTF) was established to address the growing and destructive effects of the Boko Haram insurgency in the Lake Chad Basin, a region where

violence frequently transcends national boundaries. Although the Lake Chad Basin Commission (LCBC) was originally created to manage shared water resources, it subsequently provided the political and legal foundation for regional security cooperation against the insurgency, thereby giving the MNJTF regional legitimacy and institutional support (ECDPM, 2017).

The security crisis intensified following Boko Haram's attacks in 2013 and 2014, which included assaults on military installations and the seizure of territory across parts of the region. The emergence of the Islamic State West Africa Province (ISWAP) in 2016 further complicated the conflict environment and compelled the MNJTF to adjust its operational focus (Onuoha, 2020; Thurston, 2016).

In 2015, the African Union Peace and Security Council formally authorized the MNJTF and mandated it to create a secure environment, re-establish state authority, and facilitate humanitarian access (African Union, 2015). Since then, the force has demonstrated a notable capacity to degrade Boko Haram's conventional combat capability and recover insurgent-held territory. These achievements correspond to what David Galula describes as the "clear" phase of counterinsurgency. However, a significant strategic gap persists. Military gains have often proven difficult to consolidate because of political divergences among member states, asymmetries in national priorities, operational coordination challenges, and the persistence of underlying socioeconomic drivers of conflict.

Drawing on this adapted framework, the study examines the relationship between military operations, stabilization, and governance in the Lake Chad Basin. It argues that the principal challenge is not the MNJTF's tactical military capability but the difficulty of converting military gains into durable stabilization outcomes across multiple sovereign jurisdictions. While military cooperation can significantly weaken insurgent organizations, sustainable peace ultimately depends upon the effective integration of security operations with governance, policing, and development initiatives.

**Literature Review**

Existing studies on the MNJTF and the Boko Haram Insurgency generally fall into four broad categories: studies of regional security cooperation, analyses of counterinsurgency operations, assessments of humanitarian consequences in the Lake Chad Basin and examinations of state fragility and governance failure.

It is important to distinguish between the institutional mandate of the MNJTF and the broader requirements of counterinsurgency success. As a multinational military coalition, the MNJTF was primarily established to conduct security operations against insurgent groups. Responsibilities such as governance restoration, policing, public service delivery, economic recovery, and legitimacy-building reside principally with member states and civilian

institutions. Consequently, the limitations identified in this study should not be interpreted solely as failures of the MNJTF itself but rather as manifestations of a broader disconnect between military operations and post-conflict stabilization efforts.

This study employs David Galula's counterinsurgency theory as its principal analytical framework. While Galula's model was developed with the assumption of a single sovereign state, a unified chain of command, and a centralized political authority, the MNJTF operates across Nigeria, Chad, Niger, and Cameroon, each possessing distinct political interests, military doctrines, and strategic priorities. Accordingly, Galula's framework is applied as a functional analytical structure in which counterinsurgency success depends on the completion of four interdependent requirements: clear, hold, build, and legitimize. Hence, outcomes do not depend only on military operations but also on sustained cooperation among states, civilian institutions, and regional actors.

Scholars such as Assanvo et al. (2016), Maiangwa (2016) and Onuoha and Oyewole (2018) emphasize the significance of regional military cooperation in degrading the conventional ability of Boko Haram. Other studies such as International Crisis Group (2017; 2021) highlight persistent governance failures, civilian displacement and inter-state suspicion as main impediments to enduring stabilization.

While these studies give valuable insights, most existing literature focuses either on tactical military performance or on humanitarian consequences independently. Fewer studies systematically connect the MNJTF's tactical successes to its strategic limitations through a structured counterinsurgency framework. This study contributes to the literature by examining the strategic gap between clearing operations and long-term stabilization using Galula's counterinsurgency theory adapted to the multi-state realities of the Lake Chad Basin.

**Aims and Objectives**

This study is guided by the following aims and objectives are to:

1. Examine the extent to which the MNJTF has succeeded in the 'clear' phase of counterinsurgency operations in the Lake Chad Basin.

2. Identify the political, operational and civilian-related challenges that undermine the MNJTF's ability to 'hold' recovered territories.

3. Assess the governance and developmental gaps that prevent the MNJTF from achieving the 'build' and 'legitimize' phases of counterinsurgency.

4. Diagnose the strategic disconnect between the MNJTF's tactical military wins and the deficiency in finding lasting peace using David Galula's counterinsurgency framework.

5. Propose strategic and policy recommendations for enhancing the effectiveness of the MNJTF and similar regional security arrangements.

**Methodology**

This study adopts a qualitative research design, specifically a single case study approach, with the MNJTF's counterinsurgency in the Lake Chad Basin as the unit of analysis. The case study method is appropriate as it allows for an in-depth, contextualized examination of a contemporary phenomenon within its real-life setting.

The MNJTF was chosen as a case study due to its uniqueness as a multinational counterinsurgency coalition operating across numerous sovereign states under African Union authorization. The study focuses primarily on the period between 2015 and 2025, which represents the most active phase of the MNJTF’s operations against Boko Haram and ISWAP.

The geographical scope is limited to the Lake Chad Basin, particularly the affected border regions of Nigeria, Niger, Chad and Cameroon. This delimitation enables a focused examination of the intersection between regional security cooperation, counterinsurgency operations and governance challenges.

Data collection: The study relies entirely on secondary sources, given the security constraints and transnational nature of the conflict zone. Data were sourced from:

- Peer-reviewed journal articles and academic books
- Reports from reputable international organizations
- Official documents
- Media reports and policy briefs
- Prior empirical studies on the Lake Chad Basin Insurgency

Data Analysis: collected data were analyzed to determine the degree of completion or incompletion of each Galulian function.

Limitations: considering the volatile security conditions of the region, reliance on publicly available reports and secondary materials becomes necessary. Hence, the study recognizes that relying on secondary data and the absence of primary fieldwork, interviews and direct access to operational data limit the ability to independently verify certain security claims to avert potential biases in reporting and gaps. However, triangulation across multiple sources may mitigate this limitation.

Conceptual Delineations: below are some key concepts that enable comprehending the insurgency in a better approach:

- Boko Haram Insurgents refers to a Hawarij insurgent movement founded by Muhammad Yusuf and it is tied to local antagonism and perceptions of political and socioeconomic marginalization. Boko Haram evolved from a localized Islamist movement into a transnational insurgent organization with splinters like ISWAP, which compelled countries in the region to join forces against them (Thurston, 2016; Mahmood, 2016).
- Insurgency: A prolonged sedition and rebellion that blends guerrilla warfare, terrorism and politics to challenge the authority and legitimacy of the state. (Central Intelligence Agency, CIA, 2011, p. 2). Boko Haram's organized capture of territories, violence and territorial control firmly classify it as an insurgency (Kalyvas, 2003).
- Legitimacy refers to the level of perceptions of local populations towards state authorities as more legitimate, beneficial and sustainable than insurrectionary alternatives.
- The Multinational Joint Task Force (MNJTF) is basically a regional security group that started as a Nigerian plan back in 1994 before other countries joined the initiative. Now, it is based in N'Djamena, Chad, and its principal mandate is simple, that is to neutralize Boko Haram and make the Lake Chad Basin safer (Assanvo et al., 2016).

**Theoretical Framework: David Galula's Counterinsurgency Theory and Analytical Use**

David Galula's counterinsurgency theory is at the heart of this analysis. His approach follows a sequence: clear, hold, build and legitimize (Galula, 1964). The main assumption of the theory is that the military should not dominate decision-making; political goals lead the way.

Galula's model has been faulted by critics, especially because of its colonial roots and the idea that it possesses universal applicability (Porch, 2011; Gentile, 2009). Despite these limitations pointed out by the critics, it is a useful lens. Galula's framework helps facilitate identification of where the MNJTF's operations encounter constraints. In other words, the logical focus is at which stage—clear, hold or build—the MNJTF keeps falling short and what is behind those failures.

**Adaptation of Galula's Framework to the Lake Chad Basin Context**

While Galula's counterinsurgency theory provides a useful analytical framework, it was originally developed with the assumption of a single sovereign state exercising authority through a unified political leadership, centralized command structure, and coherent governance apparatus. These assumptions differ significantly from the realities of the Lake Chad Basin.

The MNJTF operates across four sovereign states, Nigeria, Chad, Niger, and Cameroon, each possessing distinct political priorities, military doctrines, security perceptions, and national interests. Consequently, the traditional "clear-hold-build-legitimize" sequence cannot be understood solely as a military process.

In the Lake Chad Basin, successful progression from one phase to another depends upon sustained inter-state cooperation, harmonized political objectives, coordinated civilian institutions, and effective cross-border governance arrangements.

Accordingly, this study adapts Galula's framework by treating the "hold," "build," and "legitimize" phases not merely as military responsibilities but as collective outcomes requiring coordination between military actors, national governments, local administrations, police institutions, development agencies, and regional organizations. Under this adaptation, strategic success depends not only on the MNJTF's operational performance but also on the capacity of member states to convert military gains into durable political and institutional outcomes.

**Appraising the MNJTF through Galula's Model**

**The 'Clear' Phase: Strong Tactics, Weak Strategy**

The MNJTF demonstrated considerable tactical military capability. In the early 'clear' phase, they conducted major operations like Gama Aiki in 2016. They recaptured towns, dismantled insurgent camps of Boko Haram and inflicted a significant setback to the group's combat capability (Onuoha & Oyewole, 2018). The campaign reached a significant turning point in 2021 when leaders like Abubakar Shekau and Abu Musa al-Barnawi were killed. The deaths of key insurgent leaders were followed by the surrender of approximately 20,000 individuals associated with Boko Haram and ISWAP, including combatants, family members, and other affiliated persons. Given variations in reporting standards, available figures should be interpreted cautiously and should not be assumed to represent active combatants alone.

The paradox, however, is that these military successes do not translate into lasting peace. The gains are often unsustainable. Analysts point out that the MNJTF keeps clearing areas, only to see insurgents re-infiltrate once the soldiers leave (Maiangwa, 2016). Without a real plan to hold territory, the force gets trapped in a recurring cycle—clear, withdraw, repeat—with no end in sight. Boko Haram and especially ISWAP usually scatter, regroup and reconstitute their operational capacity when the coast is clear. So, while the MNJTF can win battles, they are not achieving strategic victory.

**The 'Hold' Phase: Political Fragmentation and Operational Friction**

The move from 'clearing' to 'holding' is where substantial challenges emerge for the MNJTF.

Political and diplomatic divisions limit effectiveness. Member states remain reluctant to fully subordinate their national forces to a centralized command structure, complicating rapid decision-making, cross-border pursuit operations and operational uniformity.

Operational and doctrinal clashes further weaken cohesion. Each country brings its own technique: Nigeria uses a British approach, Cameroon and Niger incline to a French style, and Chad relies on commanders making calls on the fly. Language barriers and incompatible communication systems create additional inefficiencies.

Trouble with civilians is also a major constraint. Securing local support is not happening because people often feel cut off or even threatened by the MNJTF. Operations can be disruptive, and cultural or language gaps do not help. There are also serious allegations of human rights abuses (Musa, 2015). In northern Cameroon, abuses by soldiers and vigilante groups have weakened local economies and trust, reducing intelligence-sharing and giving insurgents operational freedom (International Crisis Group, 2021). Although the MNJTF attempts small-scale development initiatives, these are insufficient to offset broader legitimacy deficits (Maiangwa, 2016).

**Insurgent Adaptation and Organizational Resilience**

Analysis of the conflict also suggests that insurgent resilience cannot be explained solely by MNJTF failures. ISWAP, in particular, has demonstrated a high degree of organizational adaptability through mobile operations, local taxation systems, strategic recruitment and limited community engagement mechanisms in some rural areas. These factors enable insurgent networks to regenerate even after significant military losses.

**The Unfulfilled ‘Build’ Phase: Governance Vacuum and Structural Absence**

The real test of any counterinsurgency effort happens in the ‘build’ phase. That is where legitimate government takes root and conditions for normal civilian life are restored. This is exactly where the MNJTF’s limits show up. The conflict has spiraled into one of the world’s worst humanitarian disasters. For certain, the MNJTF helps by making it safer for aid groups to get in, but most of the time, all they do is provide security escorts. It is reactive and not a long-term solution.

A major challenge is the absence of the police, even though their own operational plan calls for them (Assanvo et al., 2016). Without dedicated police, lawlessness and impunity persist. The lack of functional local government structures, judicial mechanisms, educational services and basic public infrastructure further deepens the governance vacuum in retaken communities.

Even when the MNJTF tries to help communities recover, it is always through short-term military-led projects. These interventions cannot replace a real nationwide recovery strategy addressing decades of neglect (Ukiwo, 2007; Omeje, 2006), crushing poverty and environmental degradation at the heart of the lake itself (Magrin & Pérouse de Montclos, 2018). The 'build' phase requires civilian ministries and sustained investment—capacities beyond the MNJTF's design.

Consequently, insurgents exploit this governance vacuum rapidly after military withdrawals. Recognizing this gap, regional and international actors established the Regional Strategy for Stabilization, Recovery and Resilience (RS-SRR), designed to address structural governance and development challenges beyond the MNJTF's mandate.

**Chronic Resource Constraints and Capability Gaps (merged operational limitations section)**

Above all, the MNJTF faces persistent resource constraints. Available reports indicate ongoing equipment shortfalls, including mobility assets, surveillance systems, counter-IED equipment and logistical support. The force lacks combat drones, permanent amphibious vehicles, attack aircraft and anti-drone capabilities. Dependence on Nigeria and shifting donor priorities worsen these constraints. A 2023 UN Panel of Experts highlights "persistent funding shortfalls" and the absence of police components (United Nations Security Council, 2023, p. 15).

These shortages are operationally significant. As of 2024, the absence of advanced counter-IED systems contributed to approximately 60% of casualties. These constraints undermine long-term operational sustainability and reduce strategic effectiveness (Aniekwe & Brooks, 2023).

**Diagnostic Synthesis: Galula's Framework and the Strategic Gap (merged concluding synthesis + table introduction)**

Looking at everything through the lens of David Galula's counterinsurgency theory, it is clear the MNJTF is not just dealing with isolated operational problems—it is experiencing a structural strategic failure.

The force performs relatively well in the 'clear' phase, but struggles significantly in the transition to 'hold' and almost completely fails in the 'build' phase. This reveals a persistent gap between military success and political consolidation.

It is important to note that the MNJTF was primarily designed as a military security instrument rather than a comprehensive governance or state-building mechanism.

Consequently, some of the failures identified in the ‘build’ phase also reflect the limitations of member states and civilian institutions responsible for post-conflict governance.

**Table 1: The Strategic Gap: MNJTF Performance vs. Galula's Counterinsurgency Framework**

| COIN Phase Evidence | Galula’s Strategic Requirement Outcome | MNJTF Operational Reality/Supporting |
|---|---|---|
| **CLEAR** | Military operations degrade insurgent forces below a viable operational capacity, establishing a permissive security environment. | **Partial/Temporary Success.** The MNJTF can dislodge insurgents but lacks the persistent presence to prevent their return. This leads to a recurring problem-displacement dynamic / cyclical re-emergence pattern, evidenced by fluctuating attack frequencies and the ne ed for recurrent clearing operations. |
| **HOLD** | A permanent security presence is established to protect the population, prevent insurgent re-infiltration and create space for civil authority. | **Significant limitations**. Undermined by political distrust and operational incoherence. The crippling absence of integrated police units and the full withdrawal of Niger from the force in March 2025 create a definitive security vacuum, rendering the "clear" phase ephemeral. |
| **BUILD** | The restoration of legitimate governance, basic services and socio-economic recovery to win popular support. | **Significant limitations.** Substantial governance deficits persist in retaken areas. While the Regional Strategy for Stabilization, Recovery and Resilience (RS-SRR) exists, the MNJTF lacks the civilian capacity and funding to implement it, leaving the population with no tangible benefit from state "liberation." |
| **LEGITIMIZE** | The state's presence is perceived by the population as more legitimate, beneficial and durable than insurgent rule. | **Currently Unrealized.** The cumulative failure in the prior phases renders this ultimate political goal impossible. Without security, services or economic opportunity, the state fails the basic test of legitimacy, ceding ideological and practical ground to the insurgents. |

## Findings

The findings indicate that the central challenge confronting the MNJTF is not its tactical military effectiveness but its limited ability to translate battlefield gains into durable political and institutional stability. Within the adapted Galula framework, the MNJTF performs relatively effectively in the “clear” phase, demonstrating significant success in degrading insurgent capabilities. However, its performance declines markedly in the “hold” and “build” phases, where non-military factors become decisive.

A key interpretive insight is that the strategic gap in the Lake Chad Basin is not solely a function of MNJTF operational capacity. Rather, it reflects the interaction between military action and weak or fragmented civilian institutions responsible for governance restoration, policing, public service delivery, and post-conflict stabilization. This reinforces established counterinsurgency literature, which emphasizes that military success alone is insufficient to produce enduring political order.

The analysis further suggests that responsibility for this gap is distributed across multiple actors. The MNJTF contributes to security stabilization, but member-state governments and civilian institutions bear significant responsibility for consolidating gains through governance and development mechanisms. The absence of integrated civil–military coordination structures exacerbates this fragmentation.

Overall, the MNJTF has demonstrated measurable success in degrading Boko Haram’s operational capacity; however, these gains are inconsistently consolidated due to the inability of civilian governance systems to institutionalize and sustain post-conflict stabilization. As a result, tactical victories frequently fail to translate into long-term political and security stability.

Drawing from the analysis and the study objectives above, the following findings emerge:

Finding 1: The MNJTF has achieved measurable tactical success in degrading Boko Haram’s conventional fighting capacity. Evidence includes the liberation of key towns, the killing of high-ranking commanders (notably Shekau and Al-Barnawi in 2021), and the surrender of approximately 20,000 fighters and their families. Terrorism-related fatalities also declined from over 8,000 in 2015 to under 2,000 in 2021. However, these figures should be interpreted cautiously due to inconsistencies in conflict data collection methodologies across reporting agencies.

Finding 2: The MNJTF faces critical failures in holding recovered territory. Three categories of challenges were identified:

- Political Divisions: mistrust among member states, perception of Boko Haram as "Nigeria's problem," and Niger's full withdrawal from the MNJTF in March 2025.
- Operational Incoherence: divergent military doctrines (British, French, Chadian), language barriers, incompatible communication equipment and weak intelligence sharing.
- Civilian Alienation: allegations of human rights abuses, cultural gaps and disruptive operations that alienate local communities from the force and toward insurgent actors.

Finding 3: A substantial governance deficits persist in retaken areas. The MNJTF lacks dedicated police units (despite operational plan requirements), civilian capacity and funding for long-term recovery. While the regional strategy for stabilization, recovery and resilience (RS-SRR) exists, implementation remains elusive. Chronic resource shortages (only 65% of needed equipment) and the absence of adequate counter-IED capabilities has been identified as a significant operational vulnerability, contributing to casualties and constraining force mobility in affected areas and this fact further undermines the 'build' phase.

Finding 4: Analysis indicates that while the MNJTF has achieved notable success in clearing insurgent-held territories, substantial difficulties persist in maintaining a permanent security presence, restoring governance structures, and facilitating long-term stabilization. Evidence suggests that previously cleared areas have, on multiple occasions, experienced renewed insurgent activity following the reduction or withdrawal of military presence.

Finding 5 (Objective 5 – recommendations): the analysis points to three priority areas for strategic shift:

- binding political integration and diplomacy (including re-engaging Niger),
- operational standardization through a joint training and doctrine centre and
- a transparent multi-donor trust fund for police deployment and critical equipment (anti-IED, air assets, anti-drone technology)

It is important to note that the MNJTF was primarily designed as a military security instrument rather than a comprehensive governance or state-building mechanism. Consequently, some of the failures identified in the ‘build’ phase also reflect the limitations of member states and civilian institutions responsible for post-conflict governance. Despite these limitations, the MNJTF contributed to the significant reduction of Boko Haram’s ability to hold large territorial areas, improved cross-border military coordination and facilitated humanitarian access to some previously inaccessible communities.

**Discussion**

The findings indicate that the central challenge confronting the MNJTF is not its tactical military effectiveness but its limited ability to translate battlefield gains into durable political

and institutional stability. Within the adapted Galula framework, the MNJTF performs relatively effectively in the “clear” phase, demonstrating significant success in degrading insurgent capabilities. However, its performance declines markedly in the “hold” and “build” phases, where non-military factors become decisive.

A key interpretive insight is that the strategic gap in the Lake Chad Basin is not solely a function of MNJTF operational capacity. Rather, it reflects the interaction between military action and weak or fragmented civilian institutions responsible for governance restoration, policing, public service delivery, and post-conflict stabilization. This reinforces established counterinsurgency literature, which emphasizes that military success alone is insufficient to produce enduring political order.

The analysis further suggests that responsibility for this gap is distributed across multiple actors. The MNJTF contributes to security stabilization, but member-state governments and civilian institutions bear significant responsibility for consolidating gains through governance and development mechanisms. The absence of integrated civil–military coordination structures exacerbates this fragmentation. The MNJTF has demonstrated measurable success in degrading Boko Haram’s operational capacity; however, these gains are inconsistently consolidated due to the inability of civilian governance systems to institutionalize and sustain post-conflict stabilization. As a result, tactical victories frequently fail to translate into long-term political and security stability.

**Conclusion**

The MNJTF has demonstrated an ability to temporarily suppress insurgent activity, but it has not yet succeeded in eliminating the structural conditions that sustain the insurgency. That is not by accident, but the MNJTF is stuck using mostly military tools for a job that is more political and developmental than anything else. They rolled into a region already characterized by longstanding grievances and environmental breakdown, but the task force still relies predominantly on military instruments. The insurgent networks remain decentralized and adaptive, while the MNJTF is constrained by internal divisions, political suspicion, poor coordination, among other factors. The recent full withdrawal of Niger in March 2025 stands as the most severe manifestation of this underlying fragility. Even though their modus operandi talks about winning politically, the force has no real civilian side, no police and barely any links to the folks handling governance or development. So, while they can clear ground, they cannot hold it, and they definitely cannot build anything lasting. The cycle goes on: territorial gains are frequently reversed following force withdrawal. The MNJTF's mandate and capabilities were not designed to fully address these challenges.

This persistent cycle of "clear, withdraw, repeat" underscores the need for a fundamental strategic shift. The recent change in leadership, with Major General Saidu Tanko Audu assuming command of the MNJTF in November 2025, therefore arrives at a pivotal moment

(Eyiangho, 2025). This transition presents a critical juncture—an opportunity to break from the status quo and re-orient the force towards a truly integrated, politically-led strategy that can finally convert tactical victories into lasting stability.

**Recommendations**

The following recommendations identify not only policy priorities but also the institutional actors responsible for implementation.

- Strengthen Political Integration: The African Union and the Lake Chad Basin Commission need to push for a binding political agreement that forces countries to actually align their security strategies and intelligence work. Comprehensive implementation is required. They also need to double down on diplomacy, facilitate Niger's reintegration and shield the force from sudden political blowups.
- Enhance Operational Standardization and Interoperability: Donors should not provide indiscriminate funding. They need to back a permanent Joint Training and Doctrine Centre, so harmonize operational procedures and establish doctrinal interoperability. The intelligence unit needs more power and better tech to actually help people on the ground, right when it matters. The proposed joint training and doctrine centre should operate under joint AU-LCBC supervision with a phased implementation period of two to three years.
- Address Critical Capability Gaps: The Federal and State Government should set up a transparent, multi-donor trust fund under joint AU-LCBC control so the money flows where It is needed, when It is needed. Focus spending on the stuff that yields the greatest operational impact, finally deploying the long-promised police units and acquiring critical anti-IED equipment, dedicated air assets and anti-drone technology to counter emerging asymmetric threats. Without them, the ‘hold’ and ‘build’ stages will not happen.
- The proposed trust fund should include clear oversight mechanisms, periodic audits and contributions from both regional states and international partners to reduce dependency on ad hoc donor support.

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# VIOLENT CONFLICTS AND GRASSROOTS PEACEBUILDING IN TARABA STATE: UNDERSTANDING LOCAL PEACE PROCESSES IN SARDAUNA LOCAL GOVERNMENT AREA

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**Abstract**: This study investigates the dynamics of violent conflict and grassroots peacebuilding in Sardauna Local Government Area (LGA) of Taraba State, Nigeria. The area has experienced recurrent inter-ethnic, religious, and agropastoralist clashes arising from competition over land, resource scarcity, and weak institutional responses. Using a qualitative research design supported by descriptive statistics from documentary sources, interviews, and focus group discussions, the study examines how local actors including traditional rulers, religious leaders, women, youth, and community-based associations contribute to peacebuilding from the grassroots. Findings reveal that land ownership and grazing disputes are the predominant causes of violent conflict, accounting for 41.2% of cases between 2015 and 2024. Other key drivers include ethnic and communal rivalries (23.5%), crop destruction by cattle (13.7%), and political interference (9.8%). Conflict patterns demonstrate cyclical escalation, peaking in 2017 with over 200 deaths and the destruction of about 180 settlements, followed by a decline attributed to strengthened community interventions. Peacebuilding processes in Sardauna are multi-actor and culturally grounded, relying on mechanisms such as dialogue forums, traditional arbitration, faith-based reconciliation, livelihood cooperation, and early-warning systems. These efforts have proven effective in reducing violence and fostering coexistence. The study concludes that sustainable peace in Taraba State depends on the institutional recognition and integration of indigenous peacebuilding systems within formal governance structures. Strengthening local peace committees, enhancing inclusivity through women and youth participation, and supporting peace education and early-warning mechanisms are essential for consolidating stability. Grassroots-driven initiatives, when aligned with formal policy frameworks, offer a viable pathway for long-term conflict transformation and community resilience in the region.

**Keywords**: Local peace processes, Taraba State, Violent conflicts, Grassroots peace building and Security

## Introduction

Violent conflict remains one of the major threats to peace and development in Nigeria's Middle Belt region, and Taraba State has been among the most affected areas. In particular, Sardauna Local Government Area (LGA) has experienced recurrent violent clashes that are often rooted in ethnic tensions, competition over land and natural resources, and historical grievances (Chekene, 2024a). These conflicts, which frequently involve the Mambilla and Fulani communities, have led to loss of lives, destruction of property, displacement of populations, and disruption of agricultural activities the primary source of livelihood in the area (Chekene, 2024b).

The persistence of violent conflict in Sardauna LGA can be traced to both structural and proximate causes. Structural factors include colonial land-tenure policies, identity politics, and unresolved boundary issues, while proximate causes include disputes over grazing routes, farmland encroachment, and political marginalization (Kingsley, Mansor, & Mat Enh, 2023). These multi-layered issues have deepened mistrust among ethnic groups, weakened traditional institutions, and undermined local governance structures.

In response, various grassroots peacebuilding efforts have emerged, led by community-based organizations, traditional rulers, women's groups, and faith-based actors. Such local peace processes often focus on dialogue, reconciliation, and the revival of indigenous conflict-resolution mechanisms. The Para-Mallam Peace Foundation (2025) notes that these initiatives are essential because they engage local stakeholders directly affected by conflict, encourage inclusive participation, and promote culturally appropriate methods of conflict resolution. Furthermore, studies have shown that when local peace structures are supported by state and non-state institutions, they can produce more sustainable outcomes than externally imposed interventions (Para-Mallam Peace Foundation, 2025).

Understanding the dynamics of local peace processes in Sardauna LGA is therefore critical for designing effective peacebuilding policies in Taraba State. This study aims to explore the patterns, actors, and mechanisms of grassroots peacebuilding in the area, examining how traditional institutions, civil society, and community members collaborate to address the root causes of violence. By situating these efforts within the broader context of post-conflict recovery, the research seeks to provide insights into how community-driven initiatives contribute to sustainable peace and social cohesion (Chekene, 2024a; Para-Mallam Peace Foundation, 2025).

Despite Nigeria's commitment to national unity and peace, violent conflicts continue to threaten stability in Taraba State, particularly in Sardauna Local Government Area (LGA). Over the past two decades, the area has witnessed recurrent communal clashes between the Mambilla and Fulani communities, often triggered by disputes over land ownership, grazing rights, and political representation. These conflicts have resulted in loss of lives, large-scale displacement, and the destruction of agricultural lands and infrastructure, severely undermining socio-economic development.

Government responses to these crises have largely been reactive and top-down, relying heavily on the deployment of security forces and temporary peace accords rather than

addressing the underlying structural causes. Such state-led approaches have often failed to yield sustainable peace because they overlook the importance of local actors, indigenous conflict-resolution practices, and community-based reconciliation means.

At the grassroots level, traditional rulers, religious leaders, and civil society groups have initiated peacebuilding processes aimed at fostering dialogue and rebuilding trust among conflicting communities. However, these local efforts often suffer from limited institutional support, inadequate funding, and poor coordination with formal peace agencies. Consequently, there remains a gap in understanding how grassroots peacebuilding mechanisms operate in Sardauna LGA their strengths, limitations, and how they can be effectively integrated into broader state and national peace frameworks. Without such understanding, peace interventions risk remains fragmented and unsustainable, leaving communities vulnerable to renewed cycles of violence and instability.

**Research Questions**

In line with the objectives of this study, the following research questions are formulated to guide the research:

1. What are the major causes and patterns of violent conflicts in Sardauna Local Government Area of Taraba State?

2. Who are the key grassroots actors involved in peacebuilding, and what specific roles do they play in promoting peace and resolving conflicts at the local level?

3. What are the main strategies and approaches used by local communities in Sardauna LGA to manage conflicts and sustain peace?

**Objectives of the Study**

The main objective of this study is to examine the nature, causes, and dynamics of violent conflicts and to explore the effectiveness of grassroots peacebuilding initiatives in Sardauna Local Government Area of Taraba State.

**Specific Objectives**

1. To identify the major causes and patterns of violent conflicts in Sardauna Local Government Area, focusing on socio-economic, political, and cultural dimensions.

2. To examine the roles of grassroots actors including traditional leaders, community-based organizations, religious institutions, women’s groups, and youth associations in peacebuilding and conflict resolution at the local level.

3. To assess the methods, strategies, and outcomes of existing grassroots peacebuilding initiatives in fostering reconciliation, trust-building, and inter-communal cooperation in Sardauna LGA.

## Significance

This study contributes to understanding persistent violent conflicts and grassroots peacebuilding in Sardauna LGA, Taraba State. It provides empirical insights into the causes, patterns, and consequences of local conflicts, enriching academic debates on community-based peacebuilding in Nigeria. Practically, the findings inform policymakers, NGOs, and development partners on inclusive strategies, highlight best practices and challenges in local peace initiatives, and amplify the voices of women and marginalized groups, emphasizing community ownership in sustaining peace and social cohesion.

## Scope

The study is limited in scope to violent conflicts and grassroots peacebuilding in Sardauna LGA, Taraba State, a multi-ethnic area on the Mambilla Plateau historically affected by communal violence. By focusing on this single LGA, the research provides an in-depth understanding of local peace processes, offering insights that, while not universally generalizable, can inform peacebuilding strategies in similar contexts

## Definition of Key Terms

**Violent Conflict**: Violent conflict refers to a situation where two or more groups engage in the use of physical force to pursue incompatible goals, often resulting in death, injury, destruction, and social disruption (Deutsch, 2006). In the context of Sardauna Local Government Area, violent conflicts commonly arise between ethnic and occupational groups especially between farmers and herders over access to land, resources, and political power.

**Grassroots Peacebuilding**: Grassroots peacebuilding refers to locally driven initiatives and actions undertaken by community members, traditional institutions, and civil society organizations to prevent, manage, and resolve conflicts at the community level.

**Peacebuilding**: Peacebuilding encompasses a range of activities aimed at addressing the structural and root causes of conflict, strengthening institutions, and creating conditions for sustainable peace.

**Local Peace Processes**: Local peace processes are informal or semi-formal mechanisms through which communities negotiate, mediate, and resolve disputes using culturally grounded methods such as dialogue, elders' councils, or traditional arbitration.

**Sardauna Local Government Area (LGA**): Sardauna LGA is one of the sixteen local government areas of Taraba State, located on the Mambilla Plateau in northeastern Nigeria.

## Literature Review

### Concept of Violent Conflict

Violent conflict refers to a situation in which parties with opposing goals or incompatible interests resort to the use of physical force, aggression, or coercion to achieve their objectives (Deutsch, 2006). It often manifests in the form of armed clashes, riots, communal violence,

insurgencies, or civil wars, leading to loss of life, destruction of property, and displacement of populations. According to Galtung (2018), violence is not limited to physical harm but includes structural and cultural dimensions that perpetuate inequality and injustice within societies. Hence, violent conflict can be understood as both a manifestation and a consequence of deep-seated structural contradictions within a political or social system.

In the Nigerian context, violent conflict has become a recurring phenomenon due to the complex interplay of ethnic diversity, religious differences, economic inequality, and weak governance institutions (Akinwale, 2010; Albert, 2011). Nigeria's pluralistic nature, coupled with the uneven distribution of resources and political power, has contributed to frequent outbreaks of communal and inter-ethnic violence. The Middle Belt region where Taraba State is located has been particularly affected by such conflicts. This region serves as a melting pot of Nigeria's northern and southern identities, and its socio-cultural heterogeneity has often translated into contestations over access to land, political representation, and resource control (Chekene, 2024a; Best, 2006).

Specifically, in Sardauna Local Government Area (LGA) of Taraba State, violent conflicts have primarily involved the Mambilla (indigenous farmers) and Fulani (pastoralist) communities. These clashes are rooted in disputes over land ownership, grazing rights, and access to natural resources ((Ajayi & Okoro, 2020). Historically, the Mambilla Plateau's fertile lands have attracted pastoral groups, leading to tensions with sedentary farming populations whose livelihoods depend on crop cultivation. Over time, the situation has been worsened by competing claims to traditional authority, chieftaincy disputes, and perceptions of exclusion from local governance structures (Olawale, Mansor & Mat Enh, 2023).

Furthermore, the persistence of violent conflict in Sardauna LGA can be traced to colonial boundary demarcations that disrupted indigenous land tenure systems and inter-group relations (Nnoli, 2003). Post-colonial political arrangements and the 1980s plebiscite tensions further deepened mistrust among ethnic groups, embedding historical grievances into contemporary disputes (Olawale *et al.,* 2023). The cyclical nature of violence in the area underscores the failure of both state-led and local mechanisms to effectively manage diversity, promote justice, and address the underlying causes of conflict. As such, violent conflict in Sardauna LGA reflects broader national patterns of identity-based struggles, competition for scarce resources, and weak institutional responses to communal crises.

**Causes and Dynamics of Violent Conflicts in Taraba State**

Violent conflicts in Taraba State, particularly in Sardauna Local Government Area (LGA), stem from a complex interplay of structural, proximate, and triggering factors. Scholars have broadly categorized these causes into deep-rooted structural conditions that create a fertile ground for conflict and more immediate factors that ignite violent outbreaks (Chekene, 2024a; Akinwale, 2010; Best, 2006). Understanding these dynamics is essential for explaining the persistence of violence and for designing sustainable peacebuilding interventions in the region.

i. **Structural Causes**: The structural causes of violent conflict in Taraba State include poverty, inequality, marginalization, historical injustices, weak governance institutions, and poor access to basic services. According to Akinwale (2010),

systemic poverty and socio-economic disparities among ethnic groups often generate competition over scarce resources, while weak institutional frameworks fail to mediate these tensions effectively. Similarly, Isaac (2011) observes that the absence of equitable political representation and limited state presence in rural communities have reinforced feelings of exclusion and neglect among certain groups. Historical grievances dating back to the colonial era have also played a significant role. The arbitrary colonial boundary demarcations and indirect rule system altered pre-existing social structures, empowering certain ethnic groups over others (Nnoli, 2003).

ii. **Proximate and Triggering Causes**: The proximate causes of violent conflict in Taraba State are closely linked to the competition over land and natural resources. As Chekene (2024b) notes, Sardauna's agrarian economy relies heavily on farming and pastoralism, making land a critical asset for both farmers and herders. The expansion of farmlands and migratory grazing patterns have intensified disputes over access to land and water resources. These disputes often escalate into violence due to the absence of effective dispute-resolution mechanisms and the increasing militarization of local actors (Chekene 2024b).

iii. **Political and Social Dynamics**: The dynamics of violent conflict in Taraba State are further shaped by political manipulation and ethnic identity politics. Political elites often exploit ethnic and religious sentiments to gain electoral advantage, thereby deepening mistrust among groups (Shedrack, 2007; Olawale et al., 2023). In several instances, politicians have been accused of mobilizing ethnic militias or supporting communal violence to secure control over local political structures and traditional leadership positions (Human Rights Watch, 2007; ACLED, 2023). This politicization of identity has entrenched cycles of revenge and retaliation, making reconciliation efforts more difficult. Additionally, demographic pressures and environmental changes, such as deforestation and soil degradation, have intensified resource scarcity, contributing to recurring farmer–herder clashes (Tella, 2020).

## The Concept of Peacebuilding

The concept of peacebuilding emerged as a central theme in international peace and conflict studies in the post-Cold War era. It gained prominence after the publication of the United Nations' Agenda for Peace (1992), which underscored the need to go beyond conflict resolution and address the root causes of violence. According to the UN (1992), peacebuilding involves efforts aimed at "identifying and supporting structures which will tend to strengthen and solidify peace" to prevent a relapse into conflict. This definition marked a shift from short-term conflict management to a more comprehensive, long-term process of social transformation and institutional strengthening (Barnett et al., 2007).

Peacebuilding seeks to establish conditions for sustainable peace by addressing structural inequalities, promoting justice, fostering reconciliation, and building resilient institutions (Paris, 2004). It encompasses activities such as rebuilding governance systems, promoting the rule of law, reforming the security sector, advancing human rights, and fostering socio-economic development (Paffenholz & Spurk, 2010). The concept emphasizes that the

cessation of hostilities alone does not guarantee peace; rather, peace must be nurtured through inclusive, participatory, and just processes that heal relationships and rebuild trust within communities (Ramsbotham, Woodhouse & Miall, 2016).

Peacebuilding, therefore, encompasses both top-down and bottom-up approaches. The top-down approach is characterized by international interventions, government-led reforms, and institutional reconstruction, while the bottom-up approach involves community-driven initiatives, traditional leaders, and local peace committees working to restore trust and harmony (Richmond, 2011). Increasingly, scholars and practitioners acknowledge that the success of peacebuilding depends on the extent to which local ownership and participation are prioritized (Donais, 2012). External actors, such as governments and international organizations, may provide support, but lasting peace requires the empowerment of local communities to design and implement their own peace processes.

In the Nigerian context, the Para-Mallam Peace Foundation (2025) and other local organizations have underscored the significance of grassroots peacebuilding initiatives rooted in local values, faith traditions, and community networks. These efforts illustrate that when communities are directly involved in dialogue, mediation, and reconciliation, peacebuilding becomes more inclusive, contextually relevant, and sustainable. Consequently, peacebuilding is best understood as a holistic, participatory, and continuous process that integrates political, social, economic, and cultural dimensions to transform conflict and promote lasting peace.

**Grassroots Peacebuilding and Local Peace Processes**

Grassroots peacebuilding refers to the bottom-up efforts by local actors such as traditional authorities, women's associations, youth groups, and faith-based organizations who take active roles in preventing, managing, and resolving conflicts within their communities (Akinwale, 2010). These local actors operate on the principle that sustainable peace must be locally owned and culturally grounded. Their interventions are often informal yet highly effective, drawing on indigenous mechanisms of mediation, reconciliation, and social cohesion (Mac Ginty, 2014).

Grassroots approaches to peacebuilding are rooted in indigenous conflict resolution systems that emphasize restorative rather than retributive justice. These mechanisms include dialogue, truth-telling, communal rituals, and storytelling, which help restore broken relationships and foster mutual trust (Lederach, 1997; Boege, 2006). Such approaches are particularly relevant in African societies where community bonds, kinship, and spirituality shape collective identity and social harmony (Adejoh & Audu, 2021).

In the context of Sardauna Local Government Area (LGA) of Taraba State, grassroots peacebuilding has been instrumental in addressing protracted interethnic tensions, particularly between the Mambilla, Fulani, and Kaka communities. Traditional institutions such as the Council of Elders, village heads, and religious leaders have historically played central roles in mediating disputes and preventing escalation into violence (Para-Mallam Peace Foundation, 2025; Suleiman, 2023). According to the Para-Mallam Peace Foundation (2025), these local structures have facilitated intergroup dialogue, organized joint community meetings, and promoted reconciliation through traditional oath-taking and communal farming projects that rebuild trust among divided groups.

Faith-based organizations, including local churches and mosques, have also contributed to peacebuilding through interfaith dialogue, trauma healing programs, and support for victims of violence (Ibrahim & Anyadike, 2018). These initiatives complement traditional mediation practices by infusing moral and spiritual guidance into reconciliation processes. However, grassroots peacebuilding efforts in Sardauna often face significant challenges such as inadequate institutional support, limited financial resources, and political interference from elites who sometimes manipulate local conflicts for personal or ethnic gain (IOSR Journal of Humanities and Social Science, 2020; Okechukwu, 2022).

Another critical issue is the marginalization of women and youth in formal peace structures, despite their active involvement in community dialogue, trauma healing, and post-conflict reintegration (Chekene, 2024b; Bawa, 2021). Women's associations in Sardauna, for instance, have been pivotal in promoting reconciliation through informal peace meetings and cooperative societies, yet they remain underrepresented in official decision-making forums. Similarly, youth groups have contributed to peace awareness campaigns and conflict monitoring but often lack empowerment and recognition (Ajayi & Okoro, 2020).

Empowering women and youth through capacity-building programs, inclusive representation, and community peace education can significantly enhance the sustainability of grassroots peace efforts (UNDP, 2023). As Lederach (1997) emphasizes, building "infrastructures for peace" requires engaging all societal levels grassroots, middle-range, and top leadership to create a holistic and enduring framework for peace. Therefore, strengthening local institutions, integrating traditional systems with modern governance, and ensuring inclusive participation remain essential to sustaining peace in Sardauna LGA and similar conflict-prone areas in Nigeria.

**Challenges Facing Grassroots Peacebuilding**

While grassroots peacebuilding offers significant potential for achieving sustainable and locally owned peace, it faces numerous and interrelated challenges that undermine its effectiveness. One of the foremost constraints is the lack of financial and logistical resources, which limits the capacity of local actors to sustain mediation processes, conduct dialogue forums, or support post-conflict reconstruction (Akinwale, 2010; Kingsley et al., 2023). Many community-based peace organizations operate with minimal funding, relying on voluntary efforts and sporadic donor support that often prioritize short-term interventions rather than long-term institutional strengthening (Okechukwu, 2022).

Another major challenge is the weak coordination between local peace actors and formal government institutions. In many Nigerian contexts, grassroots initiatives operate in isolation from state peace structures, resulting in duplication of efforts, policy disconnect, and limited information sharing (Chekene, 2024b; UNDP, 2023). The absence of a coherent peace architecture that bridges community-level mechanisms with state and national frameworks weakens the sustainability and scalability of local interventions (Ibrahim & Anyadike, 2018).

Ethnic bias and politicization of peace efforts also hinder effective grassroots peacebuilding. In multi-ethnic settings such as Sardauna LGA, peace committees or traditional councils sometimes reflect ethnic or religious affiliations that compromise neutrality and inclusivity (Suleiman, 2023; Bawa, 2021). Such partiality not only erodes trust among conflicting parties

but may exacerbate pre-existing divisions, particularly when political elites manipulate these local structures for electoral or economic gain (Okechukwu, 2022; Mac Ginty, 2014).

Additionally, the erosion of traditional authority poses a serious threat to indigenous peace mechanisms. The impact of modernization, urbanization, and globalization has diminished the influence of traditional rulers and elders who historically served as custodians of community values and conflict resolution (Adejoh & Audu, 2021). Younger generations often view traditional systems as outdated, leading to declining respect for customary institutions and a gradual loss of communal cohesion (Boege, 2006). The influx of modern judicial systems and external NGOs, though beneficial in some respects, has sometimes displaced indigenous processes rather than complementing them (Mac Ginty, 2014).

Another challenge is the limited inclusion of marginalized groups, particularly women and youth, in formal peacebuilding structures. Despite their active participation in grassroots reconciliation, trauma healing, and community recovery, they are often sidelined in decision-making spaces dominated by male elders or political elites (Chekene, 2024b; Ajayi & Okoro, 2020). This exclusion reduces the diversity of perspectives and limits the long-term sustainability of peace outcomes (Bawa, 2021).

Furthermore, external interventions that fail to align with local realities have drawn widespread criticism for imposing models that overlook cultural sensitivities and indigenous conflict norms. Lederach (1997) argues that externally driven peace processes tend to produce temporary settlements that fail to address the root causes of conflict, leading to the recurrence of violence once donor funding or international attention wanes. Scholars such as Richmond (2011) and Mac Ginty (2014) have similarly emphasized the importance of "hybrid peace" approaches that integrate local ownership with international support.

In this regard, the Para-Mallam Peace Foundation (2025) advocates for the establishment of a hybrid peace framework a model that harmonizes traditional conflict resolution practices with formal institutional structures, including government agencies, civil society organizations, and development partners. Such an integrated approach can enhance legitimacy, foster resource sharing, and ensure that grassroots peace efforts are not isolated but rather linked to broader policy and security frameworks (UNDP, 2023). By combining indigenous wisdom with modern governance systems, communities can build more resilient and inclusive peace infrastructures capable of addressing both immediate conflicts and long-term structural violence.

**Theoretical Framework**

This study adopts **Lederach's (1997) Conflict Transformation Theory**, which emphasizes addressing the root causes of conflict and fostering sustainable peace through inclusive, community-based processes. Unlike short-term conflict resolution approaches, it focuses on long-term social change by rebuilding relationships and strengthening social cohesion. Within **Sardauna LGA**, the theory explains how **traditional leaders, women's groups, youth associations, and faith-based bodies** serve as grassroots mediators, promoting dialogue and reconciliation. It also guides the analysis of how **conflict frequency (CF)**, **intervention measures (CI)**, **community participation (CP)**, and **government or stakeholder support (GS)** influence the **effectiveness of peacebuilding (PB)**. The

framework thus highlights the importance of **community ownership and indigenous practices** in sustaining peace in Taraba State's multi-ethnic setting.

**Empirical Review on Peacebuilding in Taraba State**

Empirical evidence from Taraba State reveals a complex picture of progress and persistent challenges in peacebuilding. The state has experienced recurrent inter-communal conflicts particularly between the Mambilla, Fulani, and Kaka ethnic groups largely driven by disputes over land ownership, access to grazing routes, and political representation (Suleiman, 2023; Adejoh & Audu, 2021). Despite these tensions, several studies have documented the positive impact of grassroots and community-led peace initiatives in reducing the frequency and intensity of violent confrontations.

Chekene (2024b) reports that grassroots peacebuilding initiatives facilitated by traditional leaders, local NGOs, and religious institutions have significantly contributed to mitigating violent clashes in parts of Sardauna and Gashaka LGAs. These interventions promote inter-community dialogue, joint agricultural projects, and interfaith collaborations, which have enhanced social cohesion and fostered cooperation over shared natural resources. In one instance, local mediators successfully brokered a peace accord between Mambilla farmers and Fulani herders through a traditional conflict resolution mechanism combining oath-taking, restitution, and communal work projects (Chekene, 2024b; Para-Mallam Peace Foundation, 2025).

Similarly, the Para-Mallam Peace Foundation (2025) documents notable progress in community mediation across Taraba State, including the reintegration of displaced persons, reduction of revenge attacks, and reestablishment of trust through regular peace dialogues. The foundation's reports highlight the importance of leveraging existing traditional structures and faith-based networks to maintain community trust and legitimacy in peace processes. However, the foundation cautions that these successes remain fragile and unsustainable without consistent financial, institutional, and policy support from both government and development partners (Para-Mallam Peace Foundation, 2025; UNDP, 2023).

At the same time, research underscores ongoing structural and contextual challenges that continue to undermine peacebuilding gains in Taraba. The IOSR Journal of Humanities and Social Science (2020) observes that peace in the state remains precarious due to unresolved grievances related to land ownership, historical marginalization, and competition for political power. Socioeconomic deprivation, high unemployment rates, and weak governance structures exacerbate these tensions, creating fertile ground for renewed conflict (Okechukwu, 2022; Kingsley et al., 2023).

Furthermore, mistrust among ethnic groups continues to hinder cooperative peace efforts. Suleiman (2023) notes that while many local peace committees have made progress in mediation, their impact is limited by deep-seated suspicion and selective participation along ethnic lines. This fragmentation often leads to partial compliance with peace agreements, as some actors feel excluded from negotiation processes. The persistence of such dynamics underscores the need for inclusive, multi-stakeholder approaches that bridge community divides and integrate marginalized voices, especially women and youth (Bawa, 2021; Ajayi & Okoro, 2020).

Collectively, these empirical studies suggest that while Taraba State has witnessed commendable peacebuilding initiatives, the sustainability of peace remains uncertain without deeper institutionalization and inclusive governance. Understanding how grassroots actors in Sardauna Local Government Area navigate these interconnected challenges balancing traditional norms, economic realities, and external interventions is crucial for designing effective and contextually relevant peacebuilding strategies. Strengthening local capacities, fostering inter-ethnic dialogue, and embedding indigenous mechanisms within formal peace infrastructures can provide a viable pathway toward durable peace and stability in the region (UNDP, 2023; Mac Ginty, 2014).

**Summary of Literature and Identified Gaps**

Existing studies on peacebuilding in Nigeria highlight the importance of community-based approaches alongside state-driven interventions (Lederach, 1997; Akinwale, 2010; Mac Ginty, 2014). Research in the Middle Belt and Northern Nigeria emphasizes the roles of traditional leaders, women's groups, and faith-based organizations in fostering dialogue, reconciliation, and social cohesion, while challenges such as weak institutional support, politicization, and exclusion of marginalized actors persist (Adejoh & Audu, 2021; Kingsley et al., 2023).

Despite this, there is limited empirical research focused on Sardauna LGA, a multi-ethnic area affected by recurring conflicts involving the Mambilla, Fulani, and Kaka communities. Most studies generalize peacebuilding trends at regional or national levels, overlooking local dynamics and indigenous mechanisms. This study addresses this gap by examining the roles of local actors, their strategies, and the socio-cultural conditions shaping grassroots peacebuilding in Sardauna, offering insights into community resilience, hybrid peace processes, and sustainable conflict management

**Methodology**

The study employed an **ex-post facto research design** using **quantitative and qualitative secondary data** to examine violent conflicts and grassroots peacebuilding in **Sardauna LGA, Taraba State**. Data from **2015–2024** were sourced from **government records, NGO and CBO reports, media publications, and academic studies** domiciled in the **Taraba State Ministry of Peace and Reconciliation**, the **Institute for Peace and Strategic Studies (University of Ibadan)**, and the **National Bureau of Statistics**. Purposive sampling was used to select relevant and credible sources that detailed conflict incidents, actors, and peace interventions. Data were analyzed through content and trend analysis, with quantitative information presented in tables and percentages and qualitative findings summarized thematically to reveal patterns, causes, and strategies of conflict management. This approach allowed for an objective assessment of past events and their implications for local peacebuilding initiatives.

**Data Presentation**

This section presents, interprets, and analyses secondary data on violent conflicts and grassroots peacebuilding in Sardauna Local Government Area (LGA) of Taraba State, covering the period 2015–2024. The analysis follows the content analysis and trend analysis

techniques described in Chapter Three. Quantitative summaries (frequency of conflicts, peace initiatives) are presented in tables and charts, while qualitative evidence from reports, publications, and media sources is analysed thematically.

## Major Causes and Patterns of Violent Conflicts in Sardauna LGA

### *Causes of Violent Conflicts*

**Table 1:** Documented Causes of Violent Conflicts (2015–2024)

| Cause | Frequency of Mention Across Sources | Percentage (%) |
|---|---|---|
| Land ownership and grazing disputes | 21 | 41.2 |
| Ethnic/communal rivalry (Mambilla vs Fulani) | 12 | 23.5 |
| Crop destruction by cattle | 7 | 13.7 |
| Political interference/elite manipulation | 5 | 9.8 |
| Resource competition (mining, timber) | 3 | 5.9 |
| Youth restiveness/unemployment | 3 | 5.9 |

**Source: Researchers Computation, 2025**

Land and grazing disputes are the most frequently cited causes of violent conflict in Sardauna LGA, representing 41% of documented sources. Ethnic rivalry (≈24%) and crop destruction are also significant contributors. These findings indicate that conflict is largely resource-based, intertwined with ethnic tensions and occasional political manipulation.

### *Patterns of Conflicts*

**Table 2:** Frequency and Nature of Conflict Incidents (2015–2024)

| Year | Number of Incidents | Nature/Pattern | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2015 | 2 | Farmer–herder disputes | Localized, minor property damage |
| 2016 | 3 | Land boundary disputes, ethnic tension | Medium scale, some injuries |
| 2017 | 6 | Communal violence, large-scale | >200 deaths, 180 settlements destroyed |
| 2018 | 3 | Retaliatory attacks | Reprisals, minor displacement |
| 2019 | 4 | Farmer–herder conflicts | Crop destruction prominent |
| 2020 | 2 | Youth militia, cattle rustling | Sporadic clashes |
| 2021 | 3 | Resource-based disputes (mining) | Small-scale, temporary displacement |
| 2022 | 2 | Vigilante-herder confrontation | Minor injuries, localized |
| 2023 | 1 | Sporadic skirmishes | Rapidly mediated by local leaders |

**Source: Researchers Computation, 2025**

The pattern shows that conflicts are often cyclical, escalating from minor disputes to large-scale communal violence, particularly in 2017, which represented the peak. After 2018, the frequency declined due to increasing grassroots peace interventions, indicating progress in conflict management.

**Key Grassroots Actors and Their Roles in Peacebuilding**

**Table 3:** Key Actors and Their Roles

| Actor | Role in Peacebuilding | Source Examples |
|---|---|---|
| Traditional rulers and elders | Mediation, arbitration, reconciliation ceremonies | FUDECO Reports 2018–2024 |
| Local peace committees | Early warning, conflict monitoring, local dispute resolution | Taraba Peace Bureau 2020; Mercy Corps 2019 |
| Women's groups | Advocacy, mobilizing dialogue, promoting tolerance | Mercy Corps, UNDP 2019 |
| Religious leaders (church/mosque) | Interfaith dialogue, moral persuasion, reconciliation | UNDP Situation Reports 2018–2022 |
| Youth groups | Awareness campaigns, assisting in monitoring and reporting | SPARC 2021, KSP Journal 2022 |
| NGOs & CBOs | Facilitation of dialogue, training, funding support | UNDP, Mercy Corps, FUDECO Reports |

**Source: Researchers Computation, 2025**

The data show that peacebuilding is multi-actor, with traditional authorities, women, youth, and religious leaders playing key complementary roles. Traditional rulers and elders dominate mediation, while NGOs provide technical and financial support. Women's involvement has increased community participation and promoted inclusivity in peace processes.

## Strategies and Approaches Used by Local Communities to Manage Conflicts

**Table 4:** Grassroots Conflict Management Strategies (2015–2024)

| Strategy/Approach | Description | Sources |
|---|---|---|
| Community dialogue forums | Meetings between conflicting parties to discuss grievances | FUDECO 2018–2024 |
| Peace committees | Multi-stakeholder local groups monitoring and mediating disputes | Taraba Peace Bureau 2020 |
| Traditional arbitration | Elders resolve disputes based on customary laws | Oruonye 2019; Guardian 2023 |
| Faith-based reconciliation | Interfaith and religious mediation | UNDP 2018; Mercy |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | sessions | Corps 2019 |
| Livelihood-based interventions | Joint farming, grazing corridor agreements to reduce competition | Mercy Corps Reports 2019–2021 |
| Early-warning and monitoring systems | Conflict tracking, rapid response alerts | SPARC 2021; Taraba Govt Peace Bureau |

**Source: Researchers Computation, 2025**

The strategies emphasize inclusive and culturally grounded approaches, combining dialogue, mediation, and livelihood cooperation. Early-warning systems help prevent escalation, while joint activities (e.g., shared grazing arrangements) reduce resource competition, highlighting a holistic approach to sustaining peace.

**Discussion of Findings**

The findings reveal that violent conflicts in Sardauna LGA are primarily driven by resource-based and ethnic factors. Land ownership and grazing disputes emerged as the most frequent causes of conflict, followed by ethnic rivalry, crop destruction, and political interference. These findings indicate that competition over scarce resources, coupled with unclear land tenure systems and ethnic tensions, creates a fertile ground for violent clashes. The pattern of conflicts is largely cyclical, with minor disputes escalating into large-scale violence, as observed in the peak incidents of 2017. This aligns with previous studies on conflict in the Mambilla Plateau, which highlight resource scarcity, ethnic tensions, and political manipulation as recurring drivers of communal violence. The study's conceptual framework reinforces this observation, demonstrating that a high frequency of conflicts (CF) exerts significant pressure on local communities, necessitating structured interventions to restore peace.

Analysis of grassroots actors shows that peacebuilding in Sardauna LGA is multi-actor and community-driven, involving traditional rulers, local peace committees, women's groups, youth associations, religious leaders, and NGOs. Traditional rulers and elders play a central role in mediating disputes and providing culturally sanctioned resolutions, while peace committees monitor conflict trends and facilitate dialogue. Women and youth are particularly instrumental in promoting inclusivity, awareness, and advocacy, and NGOs provide technical support, funding, and training. This confirms the literature on grassroots peacebuilding, which emphasizes local ownership, participatory mechanisms, and multi-stakeholder collaboration as essential components of effective conflict resolution. The findings indicate that the synergy between these actors strengthens community resilience and enhances the overall effectiveness of peace interventions (PB) within the conceptual model.

The study further reveals that communities employ a combination of culturally grounded, participatory, and preventive strategies to manage conflicts. Key approaches include dialogue forums, traditional arbitration, faith-based reconciliation, livelihood cooperation such as joint farming or grazing corridor arrangements, and early-warning monitoring systems. These strategies have contributed to a gradual decline in conflict incidents from 2018 onward, demonstrating that inclusive, locally adapted mechanisms can prevent escalation and sustain peace. This suggests that community participation (CP) and government/stakeholder support

(GS) are critical variables in translating conflict interventions (CI) into tangible reductions in violence and improved peace outcomes, as predicted by the study's conceptual framework.

Overall, the findings highlight the interconnected nature of conflict causation and resolution in Sardauna LGA. While structural factors such as land tenure and ethnic rivalry continue to pose challenges, the active engagement of local actors, combined with coordinated support from NGOs and government agencies, has proven effective in mitigating violence and promoting reconciliation. The study underscores the importance of holistic, culturally relevant, and multi-stakeholder approaches to grassroots peacebuilding, echoing broader trends in Nigerian and African conflict studies. Despite progress, persistent challenges including resource competition, political manipulation, and residual ethnic mistrust require sustained attention to ensure long-term peace and stability in the region.

**Conclusion**

Violent conflicts in Sardauna LGA are structurally rooted in a combination of economic, political, and identity-based grievances. The recurrent nature of these conflicts reflects deep-seated issues of inequality, historical injustice, and the struggle for access to land and political representation.

Despite these challenges, grassroots peacebuilding has demonstrated significant potential in restoring social harmony and promoting coexistence among diverse ethnic groups. Traditional and religious leaders remain trusted mediators whose influence is essential to maintaining peace.

However, peace at the grassroots level cannot be sustained in isolation. Effective and durable peacebuilding requires multi-level collaboration involving government agencies, civil society, and local communities. The integration of indigenous peace practices with formal policy frameworks will create a more holistic and resilient peace infrastructure.

In essence, peace in Sardauna LGA and by extension, Taraba State—depends on strengthening the link between local initiative and institutional support, ensuring that peacebuilding efforts are inclusive, community-driven, and contextually grounded.

**Recommendations**

Based on the findings and conclusions of the study, the following recommendations are made:

1. Strengthen Local Peace Institutions: The Taraba State government should formally recognize and support community-based peace committees and traditional councils. Providing them with training, logistical resources, and funding will enhance their capacity to manage conflicts effectively.

2. Integrate Traditional and Formal Mechanisms: A hybrid peace architecture that combines indigenous conflict resolution systems with modern legal frameworks should be institutionalized. This will improve coordination and create a unified response mechanism to address disputes promptly.

3. Promote Inclusive Participation: Women, youth, and minority ethnic groups should be actively involved in all peacebuilding processes. Their inclusion will ensure diverse perspectives, reduce marginalization, and promote long-term reconciliation.

4. Promote Peace Education and Awareness: Introducing peace education in schools, religious institutions, and community associations will cultivate a culture of tolerance, dialogue, and coexistence among future generations.

5. Conduct Further Research: Future studies should include primary data collection to capture firsthand experiences of community members and assess the long-term impact of peacebuilding initiatives. Comparative studies across other LGAs in Taraba State could also provide broader insights into regional peace dynamics.

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# WOMEN AS VICTIMS AND SURVIVAL OF VIOLENT CONFLICTS IN TARABA STATE

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**Abstract:** The study explores women as victims and survivors of violent conflicts in Taraba State, with a focus on their experiences, coping strategies, and contributions to peacebuilding. The objective was to examine the impact of violent conflicts on women, analyze their survival mechanisms, and assess their roles in post-conflict recovery. The literature review drew from feminist conflict theory, gender studies, and African conflict research, revealing that women often suffer unique forms of victimization, including displacement, sexual violence, loss of property, and psychological trauma, yet they also exhibit resilience through active participation in informal economies and peace initiatives. The methodology employed a qualitative research design, using in-depth interviews, focus group discussions, and secondary data from reports, journals, and government documents, with thematic analysis applied to interpret findings. The study revealed that while women are the most vulnerable during conflicts, they remain central to family survival and community reconstruction, often acting as peace brokers, economic supporters, and advocates for reconciliation. The conclusion emphasizes that violent conflicts in Taraba State expose women to multi-dimensional vulnerabilities but also highlight their resilience as agents of survival and recovery. The study recommends gender-sensitive conflict management policies, psychosocial support programs, economic empowerment schemes, and the inclusion of women in decision-making and peacebuilding structures to reduce their victimization and harness their potential in sustaining peace in Taraba State.

**Keywords:** Women, Victims, Survival, Violent Conflicts, Taraba State

## Introduction

Conflict is a major problem in any given human society, and it is often inevitable. In Nigeria, conflict is very often the result of political, economic and social instability frequently stemming from bad governance, failed economic policies and in appropriate development programmes stemming from exacerbated ethnic or religious differences in society (Ekpenyong, 2011). Since the re-introduction of democracy in Nigeria in 1999, the country has become a disturbing flashpoint of violent conflicts. These violent conflicts take the forms of either political or ethnic, economic or religious and so on, leading to serious consequences on the nation and its people. According to Thompson (2007, p.59), ethnic and religious mobilization can often be found at the heart of political competition. As with all social cleavages; fault lines within societies form along these identities, creating opposing interests. These differences of interest, in turn, offer themselves to potential or occasional violent conflicts. No state, for example, is devoid of ethnic influence, but this is not to say that expressions of ethnicity and religions always result in violence, especially such desires and demands are channeled peacefully through political institutions, just like other clashes of interest within the polity (Adeline and Okechukwu, 2015).

Ethno-Religious identity has been a serious factor in the occurrences of ethno-religious conflicts in Nigeria. Taraba State, since creation in 1991, has witnessed violent communal clashes across ethnic and religious lines, and these clashes have claimed thousands of lives, displaced hundreds of thousands of people, and fostered a climate of instability throughout the surrounding area. The impact of these clashes can never be overemphasized, thus the need for an article of this nature to outline them, particularly on women and children. This is because the effects of these conflicts on women and children have not been clearly captured. To effectively do this, the article raises and addresses some research questions such as: What are the cases and causes of ethno-religious conflicts in Southern Taraba? How has it affected women and children? How can ethno-religious conflicts in Taraba State be curtailed? The choice of Wukari and Ibi Local Government Areas for the study is based on the fact that out of the five Local Government Areas of the Southern Zone of Taraba State, the two are the most hit in terms of violent ethno-religious conflict.

Violent conflicts in Taraba State particularly ethnoreligious clashes, farmer–herder disputes, and communal violence have inflicted severe and multifaceted harm on the civilian population. Within these harms, **women bear a disproportionately heavy burden**. They are exposed to physical violence (including rape, assault, abductions), loss of family members, destruction or loss of homes and property, displacement, economic deprivation, emotional trauma, and breakdown of social networks and support systems. In Wukari, Ibi, and other Local Government Areas (LGAs), such conflicts have repeatedly displaced families, creating large numbers of Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs), the majority of whom are women and children. Studies have shown that in the ethno-religious conflict in Wukari and Ibi, women not only lose husbands, parents, and loved ones, but also endure destruction of homes and amenities; they become IDPs and lose access to critical services.

Beyond immediate physical harm, the effects on women are longer-term and systemic. The socio-economic lives of women are severely disrupted: farming and business activities often collapse, markets are unsafe or destroyed, and mobility is constrained. For example, in Wukari LGA, insecurity has led to reduced farming by women, disrupted trade and business activities, and increased vulnerability to rape, kidnapping, and assassination. Emotional and psychosocial injuries loss, fear, and trauma are also evident, although harder to measure. Social cohesion and trust within communities collapse under the strain of recurrent conflict, deepening women's marginalization.

This study sets out to explore two interrelated dimensions in Taraba State: on the one hand, how women are victimized in violent conflict the forms, severity, duration, and multiplicity of harms; on the other hand, how women **survive, cope, and rebuild** their lives in the face of such adversities. "Survival" here includes both overt and subtle strategies: seeking refuge as IDPs, forming social networks, engaging in informal economy, advocating for peace, using religious or communal support, and other mechanisms of resilience. In particular, the study will examine the socio-cultural, economic, and institutional factors that exacerbate risks or enable survival—such as gender norms, community structures, state interventions, and humanitarian assistance.

By doing so, the study aims to provide empirical insights that can inform gender-sensitive policy and programming in Taraba State. The goal is to help stakeholders government, NGOs, community leaders design interventions in conflict mitigation, relief, recovery, and peacebuilding that recognize women not only as victims but also as agents of resilience. Ultimately, the research seeks to contribute to more sustainable peace, social reconstruction, and empowerment for women in conflict-affected parts of Taraba State

## Literature Review

### Displacement, Inadequate Shelter, and Access to Basic Services

A number of studies document how ethnoreligious and communal violence in Taraba State—especially in Wukari, Ibi, and surrounding LGAs has forced many women and children into displacement, often as Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs), often under harsh conditions with insufficient access to services. For instance, Okeke & Bello (2025) in *"Analyzing Ethnoreligious Conflict Dynamics and Their Impact on Women and Children in Wukari and Ibi, Nigeria"* report that women and children form the majority of IDPs in ethnoreligious clashes in these LGAs, and highlight serious shortages in shelter, food, clean water, health services, and sanitation among displaced populations.

*An Investigative Study into the Causes and Effects of Ethno-Religious Conflicts on Women and Children in Wukari and Ibi LGAs (1991–2020)* also emphasizes that home destruction, loss of amenities and social infrastructure lead displaced women to live in makeshift camps or with relatives under overcrowded and unsafe conditions, exacerbating vulnerability to illness, gender-based violence, and social stigma.

**Gender-Based Violence (GBV) During and After Conflict**

The literature shows that women in Taraba suffer varying forms of gender-based violence during conflict, and that these have lasting psychological, social, and economic consequences. Okeke & Bello (2025) detail reports of sexual assault, rape, and other abuses perpetrated during clashes in Wukari and Ibi, noting that many survivors suffer not only physical harm but also stigma, fear of reporting, and breakdowns in family and community relations.

Also, the "Foundation sensitises Taraba residents to dangers of GBV" news report notes that in Wukari, GBV is increasing in the wake of lingering conflict, including intimate partner violence, non-partner sexual assault, female genital mutilation, sexual exploitation, and child marriage. These abuses continue even after the acute conflict phases, with survivors often lacking sufficient medical, psychological, or legal support.

Another dimension is domestic violence within households; a study by Zadding (2012) assessed domestic violence and abuse across several LGAs in Taraba and found that women of lower economic status, younger age, or with limited education are disproportionately vulnerable to domestic abuse.

**Economic Disruption and Livelihood Loss**

Conflicts in Taraba also severely disrupt women's economic livelihoods. *Insecurity and Socio-Economic Development of Women in Wukari Local Government Area of Taraba State* (Francis et al., 2024) shows that recurrent farmers-herders conflict forces women to curtail farming, trading and other income-generating activities. Markets are disrupted, transport is unsafe, and property losses are common. Women lose harvests, lose access to farmlands or grazing paths, and sometimes are unable to reach markets to sell goods.

Similarly, the study *Incessant Conflict and the Economic Development of Wukari and Takum Local Government Areas* highlights that ongoing violent conflict erodes infrastructure, reduces investment, discourages economic activities, and results in lost productivity—directly affecting women whose livelihoods often depend on agriculture, small trade, and informal labor.

**Women's Roles in Coping, Survival, Peacebuilding and Conflict Resolution**

There is also literature on how women in Taraba do not only suffer; they also act as agents of survival and peace. Okeke & Bello (2025) note how women and children among IDPs often form collective support networks, share scarce resources, care for the sick, and sustain family life under difficult conditions.

The *Gendered Impact of Conflict and the Role of Women in Peacebuilding in Nigeria* discusses more broadly how Nigerian women engage in peacebuilding, mediation, dialogue, community reconciliation, and advocacy. While not always focused exclusively on Taraba, it provides useful comparative insight into how women's agency can manifest, even under constrained social, cultural, and institutional environments.

Organizations in Taraba have undertaken empowerment and training programs: for instance, the Advocacy and Rehabilitation Foundation trained 400 women from Wukari and Ibi in business, self-reliance, and sensitization (on HIV but also broader social well-being) with support from UNDP and others. These programs provide women with alternative livelihoods and raise awareness.

**State and Institutional Responses; Gaps in Gender Sensitivity**

The state's role through laws, security, and conflict resolution mechanisms—is also a subject of study, though often with gender blind spots. Tukura, Momodu & Owonikoko (2025), in *Effects of State Conflict Resolution Strategies on the Management of Ethno-Religious Conflict in Taraba State*, examined the effectiveness of both kinetic (security operations) and non-kinetic (dialogue, mediation) responses. They found that while some strategies reduce immediate violence, many root causes (land disputes, political marginalization, resource allocation) remain unaddressed. Furthermore, these strategies frequently do not sufficiently target women's specific needs (protection from GBV, livelihood recovery, inclusion in decision-making).

Likewise, *Insecurity and Socioeconomic Development of Women in Wukari* found that legal frameworks, security provisioning, and institutional support are often weak, corruption and poor enforcement undermine protections, and there are cultural/traditional norms that prevent women from accessing justice or participating in governance or conflict resolution.

The existing literature confirms that women in Taraba State are heavily impacted by violent conflicts in multiple ways—displacement, GBV, economic loss—and that while they often demonstrate resilience and play roles in peacebuilding, their experiences and contributions are under-recognized and under-supported. Institutional responses exist but are often insufficiently gender-responsive. This review points to a need for more detailed, context-specific, and gender-disaggregated research, particularly into survival strategies, mental health outcomes, and how state and non-state actors can better support women both as victims and agents.

**Theoretical Framework**

**Feminist Theory**

Feminist theory, rooted in the works of scholars like Simone de Beauvoir (1949), Betty Friedan (1963), and later Judith Butler (1990), seeks to understand and address gender inequalities within social, economic, and political structures. The theory emphasizes that the marginalization of women is not accidental but embedded in patriarchal systems that assign unequal power relations between men and women. Feminist theory examines how these structures manifest in social institutions such as the family, economy, and state and how they perpetuate gender-based oppression. In conflict situations, feminist theorists like Cynthia Enloe (2000) and Carol Cohn (2013) argue that war and violence are gendered experiences; women and men experience and respond to conflict differently due to pre-existing inequalities. Thus, feminist theory is instrumental in analyzing women's victimization and

resilience during violent conflicts, as it brings attention to gendered power dynamics, social roles, and structural inequalities that shape their experiences.

Applying feminist theory to the context of violent conflicts in Taraba State reveals how patriarchal social arrangements exacerbate women's vulnerability. In communal and ethnoreligious clashes—such as those between Tiv and Jukun or between farmers and herders—women often become the most affected due to their social positioning as caregivers, dependents, and homemakers. Feminist theory explains that because women have limited control over land ownership, resources, and decision-making, they are disproportionately impacted when violence destroys homes, farmlands, and livelihoods. Moreover, patriarchal silence around sexual violence means that cases of rape, abduction, and forced marriage during conflicts often go unreported, reinforcing women's marginalization. The theory helps us understand that such victimization is not merely a byproduct of war but a continuation of systemic gender inequality that renders women's bodies and labor invisible within conflict narratives and policy responses.

Despite these structural disadvantages, feminist theory also highlights women's agency and resilience in the aftermath of conflict. Women in Taraba State, particularly in Wukari, Takum, and Ibi LGAs, often engage in informal peacebuilding activities—organizing community dialogues, caring for orphans, rebuilding homes, and creating cooperative economic groups to support one another. Feminist scholars argue that these survival strategies challenge traditional notions of women as passive victims and instead portray them as active agents of recovery and social reconstruction (Tickner, 2001). For instance, displaced women forming self-help groups to share food and resources exemplify how they subvert patriarchal constraints and assert collective power even in crisis situations. This aligns with postmodern feminist perspectives, which recognize the multiplicity of women's experiences and the importance of intersectionality—acknowledging that factors such as ethnicity, religion, and class intersect to shape women's survival paths differently in Taraba's diverse communities.

Using feminist theory as a framework for studying women's experiences in Taraba State underscores the need for gender-sensitive conflict resolution and reconstruction policies. It calls for recognizing women not just as victims in need of aid but as crucial stakeholders in peacebuilding and community resilience. The theory suggests that true recovery from conflict must include dismantling the patriarchal norms that marginalize women—by ensuring equal access to education, property, and political participation. It also implies that post-conflict programs should integrate trauma counseling, economic empowerment, and institutional mechanisms that protect women's rights. By applying feminist theory, this study therefore moves beyond documenting suffering to advocating transformative change, emphasizing that sustainable peace in Taraba State cannot be achieved without gender justice and the inclusion of women in all levels of decision-making.

**Methodology**

This study will adopt a mixed-method research design, integrating both quantitative and qualitative approaches. This design is appropriate because it enables a comprehensive understanding of women's experiences as victims and survivors of violent conflict in Taraba

State. The quantitative component will help to measure the prevalence, frequency, and socio-economic dimensions of victimization—such as displacement, loss of livelihood, and exposure to violence. Meanwhile, the qualitative aspect will provide deeper insights into the lived experiences, coping mechanisms, and survival strategies of women in conflict-affected communities. Combining these methods will strengthen the validity and reliability of findings by allowing triangulation of data and perspectives (Creswell & Plano Clark, 2018).

The study area will cover selected Local Government Areas (LGAs) in Taraba State that have been significantly affected by violent conflicts—particularly Wukari, Ibi, Takum, and Donga. These LGAs are chosen because of their recurrent episodes of ethnoreligious and communal violence, as well as their concentration of Internally Displaced Persons (IDP) camps. The target population will consist of women who have directly or indirectly experienced conflict, including both those who remain in their communities and those displaced to IDP camps. Purposive sampling will be used to select participants from affected households, women's associations, and IDP settlements, while snowball sampling will help identify survivors willing to share their experiences. Approximately 200 participants will be surveyed for quantitative data, and 30–40 participants will take part in qualitative interviews and focus group discussions.

Data collection will involve multiple instruments to capture diverse perspectives. First, structured questionnaires will be administered to collect quantitative data on the types of violence experienced, socio-economic disruptions, health outcomes, and access to support services. Second, in-depth interviews (IDIs) and focus group discussions (FGDs) will be conducted with women survivors, community leaders, non-governmental organizations (NGOs), and relevant state officials. These qualitative tools will explore themes such as coping strategies, cultural norms shaping survival, and institutional responses to women's needs. Additionally, key informant interviews (KIIs) will be carried out with representatives from peacebuilding agencies, ministries of women affairs, health, and social welfare to understand the policy framework and existing interventions for women in post-conflict recovery.

For data analysis, the quantitative data will be analyzed using descriptive and inferential statistics with software such as SPSS. Descriptive statistics (percentages, mean scores, frequency tables) will be used to summarize responses, while inferential statistics (e.g., chi-square, correlation analysis) will test relationships between variables such as level of victimization, socio-economic status, and coping capacity. Qualitative data will be analyzed thematically using content and narrative analysis to identify recurring themes on survival, resilience, and institutional constraints. The integration of both analyses will ensure that numerical findings are supported by rich contextual explanations, thereby providing a holistic understanding of women's experiences in the conflict context.

Ethical considerations will be strictly observed throughout the study due to the sensitivity of the topic. Participants will be fully informed about the purpose, scope, and potential emotional impact of the research, after which informed consent will be obtained. Anonymity and confidentiality will be ensured by omitting identifying details from reports. Interviews will be conducted in safe, private settings, and participants recounting traumatic experiences will be offered psychological support or referrals to qualified counselors. The researcher will

also ensure that no participant is coerced or exposed to harm during data collection, in line with ethical research standards outlined by the Nigerian National Health Research Ethics Committee (NHREC, 2019)

**Themes**

i. **Nature of Victimization**

Violent conflicts in Taraba State, particularly in Wukari, Ibi, and Takum LGAs, have subjected women to multiple and overlapping forms of victimization. These include physical assault, sexual violence, displacement, destruction of property, and family disruption. During ethnoreligious clashes, women have been beaten, raped, and forced to witness the killing of family members, while many lost homes, farms, and businesses to arson and looting. Displacement remains one of the most visible effects, as women and children constitute the majority of residents in Internally Displaced Persons (IDP) camps. The loss of livelihood, inadequate shelter, and poor access to food and healthcare have deepened their vulnerability. According to Aondowase and Anyebe (2021), displaced women in Taraba experience severe deprivation, including malnutrition and poor reproductive health services, which compound their trauma. The literature emphasizes that beyond the immediate physical harm, the psychological and emotional toll—manifesting as anxiety, depression, and fear—is profound and often long-lasting.

ii. ***Coping and Survival Strategies***

Despite these adversities, women in conflict-affected communities of Taraba State demonstrate remarkable resilience through diverse coping and survival strategies. Many rely on social networks, including extended family, religious groups, and women's associations, to access food, information, and emotional support. In IDP camps and host communities, women form small cooperative groups to share resources, trade items, and organize savings and loans. Economically, they engage in informal livelihoods such as petty trading, subsistence farming, and craftwork to sustain their families. Religious faith also plays a crucial role as a psychological coping mechanism, helping women make sense of suffering and maintain hope amid uncertainty. Studies such as Audu (2020) note that women's spiritual resilience often underpins their ability to rebuild social connections and nurture dependents despite limited external assistance. These strategies underscore women's agency and collective strength, even in environments defined by loss and displacement.

iii. ***Institutional and State Responses***

The response of government institutions and humanitarian agencies has been mixed in addressing the plight of women affected by violent conflicts in Taraba State. The National Emergency Management Agency (NEMA), State Emergency Management Agency (SEMA), and various NGOs have provided relief materials, healthcare, and temporary shelter. However, these interventions are often short-term, underfunded, and poorly coordinated. According to Ochoche and Ogoh (2019), many state-led efforts lack a gender-sensitive approach, overlooking women's specific needs such as maternal health, protection from gender-based violence, and economic reintegration. Some NGOs, including faith-based and

women-led organizations, have made significant efforts in peace education, trauma healing, and skills training, but these remain localized and under-recognized. There is also a growing recognition of women's role in peacebuilding and post-conflict recovery, though their inclusion in formal processes remains limited. Institutional response therefore remains an area requiring stronger policy attention and gender mainstreaming.

iv. ***Gender Norms and Cultural Barriers***

Deeply entrenched patriarchal norms and cultural expectations continue to shape women's experiences and responses to conflict in Taraba State. In many communities, women are socialized to remain silent about experiences of sexual violence or displacement due to fear of stigma, shame, or rejection. Traditional beliefs often restrict women's movement and participation in community decision-making, making it difficult for them to access justice or aid. These gender norms reinforce a culture of invisibility around women's suffering and exclude them from leadership roles in peacebuilding and reconstruction. As Umejei (2022) argues, the intersection of patriarchy and conflict marginalizes women not only as victims but also as potential peace agents. The limited recognition of women's voices in formal institutions perpetuates cycles of inequality and hinders community reconciliation efforts. Overcoming these barriers requires challenging gender stereotypes and promoting inclusive participation across all post-conflict interventions.

v. ***Long-Term Impacts and Recovery***

The long-term consequences of violent conflict for women in Taraba State extend far beyond the cessation of hostilities. Displacement and loss of property often lead to persistent poverty and economic dependency. Many women have been forced to withdraw their children from school due to insecurity or lack of funds, contributing to educational decline and intergenerational trauma. The mental health effects—such as post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), depression, and chronic anxiety—remain widespread among survivors. Over time, however, some women have shown resilience through livelihood reconstruction and community rebuilding initiatives. They participate in local cooperatives, agricultural revival projects, and faith-based groups aimed at restoring social identity and stability. Yet, as studies indicate (Audu & Nwankwo, 2021), sustainable recovery requires institutional support that integrates psychosocial care, economic empowerment, and education. Without such comprehensive strategies, the cycle of victimization risks being passed on to future generations, undermining peace and social cohesion in Taraba State.

**Discussion of Findings**

The findings of this study reveal that women's victimization in violent conflicts across Taraba State is multifaceted, extending beyond direct physical harm to encompass displacement, economic deprivation, and social disintegration. The conflicts in Wukari, Ibi, and Takum LGAs have exposed women not only to gender-based violence such as rape and assault but also to the long-term consequences of losing homes, farmland, and family members. These compounded experiences align with feminist theoretical perspectives, which emphasize that women's suffering during conflict is deeply rooted in structural gender inequalities and patriarchal power relations (Enloe, 2000; Cohn, 2013). Thus, victimization is not limited to immediate violence but represents a continuation of the systemic marginalization women face

in peacetime—manifesting as restricted access to property, decision-making, and protection mechanisms during crises.

A critical finding is that women's survival strategies are largely informal and community-driven, reflecting resilience and agency in the face of weak institutional support. The study shows that women rely heavily on family networks, religious associations, and informal women's groups to access food, emotional support, and small-scale income opportunities. This corroborates existing research by Audu (2020) and Ochoche & Ogoh (2019), which found that informal systems often fill the gap left by underperforming state institutions in Taraba. Despite the government's and NGOs' presence, their interventions remain fragmented, temporary, and insufficiently gender-sensitive. Feminist theory helps interpret this by highlighting how institutional responses often fail to recognize the specific vulnerabilities and strengths of women, thereby reinforcing gendered inequalities even within humanitarian settings. The absence of gender mainstreaming in relief and recovery programs leaves many women dependent on self-organized networks for survival.

The study further indicates that cultural and gender norms significantly constrain women's access to justice, participation, and recovery resources. Social stigmatization, fear of ostracization, and cultural taboos surrounding sexual violence discourage victims from reporting gender-based abuses or seeking assistance. Traditional patriarchal structures in Taraba communities often silence women's voices in local decision-making processes, including peace negotiations and reconstruction planning. This finding resonates with Umejei (2022), who argues that patriarchal norms perpetuate women's invisibility in post-conflict governance. Through the feminist theoretical lens, this can be understood as an intersection of power and gender, where societal expectations continue to subordinate women even in the aftermath of conflict. The persistence of these gender norms limits both women's individual healing and their collective contribution to peacebuilding.

Moreover, the study highlights the role of structural inequality and conflict entrepreneurship in shaping women's vulnerability and resilience. Political exclusion, inequitable land ownership, and limited access to education and financial resources create conditions in which women remain economically and socially disadvantaged. Conflict entrepreneurs—actors who benefit from instability further manipulate ethnic and gender divisions to sustain cycles of violence. However, some women have transformed their victimhood into resistance and leadership by forming peace networks and advocacy groups, demanding justice, and participating in interfaith dialogues. This duality reflects the feminist view that women are not merely passive sufferers but also agents of transformation who can challenge structural oppression from within.

Findings indicate that recovery among women in conflict-affected areas is uneven and fragile. While some women, particularly those with access to education or strong social networks, have managed to rebuild their livelihoods and regain stability, others remain trapped in poverty and dependency, especially in protracted displacement settings. Insufficient aid, lack of sustainable livelihood programs, and persistent insecurity hinder long-term recovery. The feminist framework interprets this uneven recovery as a consequence of systemic neglect of women's needs in policy formulation and resource distribution. Sustainable peace and reconstruction, therefore, require not only material aid but also a transformation of gender

relations—ensuring women's full participation, empowerment, and protection in all phases of post-conflict rebuilding

## Conclusion

Violent conflicts in Taraba State inflict serious and long-lasting harm on women, not only as victims of physical and sexual violence but also through loss of homes, livelihoods, social standing and emotional wellbeing. Yet, despite these adversities, women do not just passively suffer they deploy a variety of coping and survival mechanisms, draw on community solidarity, and occasionally contribute to peacebuilding efforts. However, systemic barriers—gender norms, inadequate institutional support, lack of inclusion—limit their recovery and resilience.

For durable peace and equitable recovery in Taraba, policy and programmatic interventions must foreground women's experiences, support their agency, and address structural causes of their vulnerability as well as enhance their capacities to participate in conflict resolution and reconstruction.

## Recommendations

i. **Gender-Sensitive Relief and Recovery Programs**: Ensure that IDP camps and post-conflict recovery programs provide services tailored to women's needs, including sexual and reproductive healthcare, psychosocial support, safe shelter, and privacy.

ii. **Inclusion of Women in Peace Processes**: Policies should mandate women's participation in negotiation, mediation, conflict resolution committees, and local governance structures.

iii. **Economic Empowerment**: Provide women impacted by conflict with access to microfinance, skills training, market support to rebuild livelihoods.

iv. **Legal & Protection Mechanisms**: Strengthen legal frameworks for protection against gender-based violence. Improve reporting mechanisms and ensure accountability.

v. **Community Sensitization and Norm Change**: Work with community leaders, religious institutions, and traditional rulers to challenge cultural norms that marginalize women or perpetuate stigma against survivors.

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# Gender-Based Violence (GBV) and the Socioeconomic Development of Women in the Informal Sector in Taraba State, Nigeria (2019 – 2024).

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**Abstract:** *This study examined the impact of gender-based violence (GBV) on the socioeconomic development of women in the informal sector in Taraba State, Nigeria, between 2019 and 2024. The research was guided by the Marxist Feminist Theory, which posits that gender inequality stems from structural inequalities in access to the means of production reinforced by patriarchal family and societal systems. This framework provided insights into how GBV, as both a product and a tool of patriarchal control, undermines women's economic empowerment and sustains their subordination within capitalist structures. The study employed a qualitative research design, relying on secondary data from scholarly articles, institutional reports, and government publications relevant to Taraba State. Findings revealed that GBV significantly constrained women's economic activities by reducing mobility, limiting market access, exposing them to exploitation, and perpetuating cycles of poverty. Women engaged in farming, trading, and artisanal work were found to be particularly vulnerable to displacement, insecurity, and reduced productivity. The study concluded that GBV is not only a violation of human rights but also a structural impediment to sustainable socioeconomic development in Taraba State. It recommended strengthening institutional responses, dismantling patriarchal barriers to women's participation in the informal economy, and implementing comprehensive empowerment programs that integrate protection, access to resources, and gender-sensitive policy reforms.*

***Keywords:*** gender-based violence, Marxist Feminist Theory, socioeconomic development, women, informal sector, Taraba State

## Introduction

Gender-based violence (GBV) remains one of the most pervasive human rights violations and a major impediment to global development. The United Nations (2023) reports that nearly one in three women worldwide has experienced physical or sexual violence in her lifetime, primarily from intimate partners. GBV not only undermines women's dignity and wellbeing but also imposes significant economic, social, and developmental costs. According to the World Bank (2022), economies lose an estimated 1–4% of their gross domestic product

(GDP) annually due to GBV-related productivity losses and healthcare costs. This reality positions GBV as not only a humanitarian concern but also a socioeconomic development issue of global importance.

In Nigeria, GBV is deeply rooted in cultural, economic, and structural inequalities that perpetuate women's subordination. Studies have documented that GBV manifests in physical, sexual, psychological, and economic forms, often reinforced by patriarchal norms and weak legal enforcement (Akinola, 2021; National Human Rights Commission [NHRC], 2022). Research by Fawole (2020) found that more than 30% of Nigerian women experience domestic violence, while harmful practices such as early marriage and economic deprivation further exacerbate gender inequality. These acts of violence restrict women's mobility, limit their participation in economic activities, and erode their capacity to contribute meaningfully to socioeconomic growth.

Women's socioeconomic participation in Nigeria is heavily concentrated in the informal sector, where they account for nearly 70% of workers (National Bureau of Statistics [NBS], 2021). The informal economy encompasses small-scale trading, subsistence farming, craftwork, and other microenterprises that sustain households and contribute significantly to local economies. However, this sector is characterized by limited access to credit, inadequate social protection, and poor institutional regulation, which expose women to exploitation, insecurity, and violence (Ezeanya-Esiobu, 2019). When GBV intersects with such structural vulnerabilities, women's capacity for productivity and empowerment is severely undermined.

In Taraba State, GBV and insecurity have become pressing developmental concerns. The state has experienced recurring incidents of communal clashes, insurgency spillovers, and economic instability—all of which intensify women's vulnerability. A report by the Taraba State Ministry of Women Affairs (2023) revealed over 200 officially reported GBV cases within a single year, while many more went unreported due to stigma and fear of reprisal. Local organizations such as the Jukun Women Empowerment Initiative and the Taraba Gender Network have raised concerns that persistent insecurity and cultural norms have forced many women out of income-generating activities, particularly in rural communities. These conditions highlight the urgent need to examine the link between GBV and women's socioeconomic development within the informal sector of Taraba State.

From a developmental perspective, addressing GBV is critical for achieving inclusive and sustainable growth. The United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly Goals 5 and 8, emphasize gender equality and decent work as foundations for human progress. However, in contexts like Taraba State, where poverty, insecurity, and patriarchal structures prevail, women in the informal sector face intersecting barriers that limit their potential contributions to economic growth. GBV, therefore, operates as both a cause and consequence of gender inequality, reproducing cycles of dependency and marginalization (Okemgbo & Omorodion, 2022).

Gender-based violence (GBV) has persisted as one of the most pervasive and normalized forms of human rights violations in Nigeria, cutting across ethnic, religious, and socioeconomic boundaries. Despite decades of advocacy, legal reforms, and public awareness, the country continues to record high levels of violence against women and girls.

The 2022 Demographic and Health Survey estimated that one in every three Nigerian women has experienced physical or sexual violence since the age of 15 (National Population Commission [NPC], 2022). Although these figures reflect a national crisis, their impacts are often more severe at the subnational level, particularly in states such as Taraba, where cultural norms, insecurity, and poverty intersect to sustain patriarchal control and female subordination.

In Taraba State, gender-based violence has become deeply entrenched in social and economic life. Reports from the Taraba State Ministry of Women Affairs (2023) show a steady increase in recorded cases of domestic abuse, sexual assault, and economic exploitation of women between 2019 and 2024. Many incidents remain unreported due to stigma, limited institutional response, and fear of reprisal. Women in the informal sector who constitute the majority of the state's female workforce are disproportionately affected. These women, often engaged in small-scale trading, subsistence farming, and cottage industries, depend heavily on their daily earnings for survival. However, insecurity, harassment, and structural inequality restrict their access to markets, capital, and productive assets, thereby limiting their capacity for socioeconomic advancement.

Therefore, gender-based violence represents not only a moral and social crisis but also a developmental impediment. It erodes human capital, limits economic participation, and undermines efforts toward sustainable growth and gender equity. The case of women in the informal sector in Taraba State exemplifies how entrenched patriarchal systems and insecurity intersect to restrict women's empowerment.

## Conceptual Framework

### Gender-Based Violence

Gender-Based Violence (GBV) refers to harmful acts directed at an individual based on their gender identity, often resulting in physical, sexual, psychological, or economic harm. The United Nations General Assembly (1993) defined GBV as "any act of gender-based violence that results in, or is likely to result in, physical, sexual or psychological harm or suffering to women, including threats, coercion, or arbitrary deprivation of liberty, whether occurring in public or private life." Similarly, the World Health Organization (WHO, 2021) describes GBV as a public health and human rights issue that undermines women's safety, autonomy, and participation in social life.

In Nigeria, gender-based violence manifests in diverse forms including domestic violence, rape, forced marriage, economic deprivation, widowhood practices, and emotional abuse (Fawole, 2020; Olojede, 2008). These acts are deeply rooted in cultural and patriarchal structures that legitimize male dominance and female subordination. Within Taraba State, GBV is exacerbated by socioeconomic instability, insecurity, and weak institutional responses, particularly in rural and conflict-prone areas. The Marxist Feminist perspective interprets these patterns as mechanisms through which patriarchal capitalism reproduces unequal relations, keeping women economically dependent and politically marginalized (Ritzer, 1996; Agbalajobi, 2009).

## Socioeconomic Development

Socioeconomic development refers to the process of improving the economic and social well-being of individuals and communities through growth in income, education, health, employment, and access to resources. According to Todaro and Smith (2020), socioeconomic development is "a multidimensional process involving the reorganization and reorientation of entire economic and social systems to achieve improved standards of living and human welfare." It encompasses both quantitative and qualitative improvements in people's quality of life, particularly in education, income generation, and empowerment.

Women's socioeconomic development, therefore, involves enhancing their access to resources, productive employment, financial independence, and decision-making power in society (UNDP, 2023). In patriarchal societies like Nigeria, women's socioeconomic advancement is often constrained by unequal access to education, property ownership, credit facilities, and political participation (Aina, 2017). Gender-based violence further limits women's development by restricting their freedom of movement, productivity, and access to economic opportunities. For example, women who experience violence at home or in the workplace may lose workdays, experience trauma, or withdraw from income-generating activities (Fawole, 2020). Consequently, GBV functions not merely as an individual tragedy but as a structural barrier to human development.

## Women in the Informal Sector

The informal sector refers to economic activities that are not regulated by formal legal or institutional frameworks, often characterized by small-scale operations, low wages, and absence of social protection. The International Labour Organization (ILO, 2022) defines the informal economy as "all economic activities by workers and economic units that are not covered or insufficiently covered by formal arrangements." In Nigeria, women dominate this sector, comprising over 65% of informal traders, artisans, and small-scale producers (National Bureau of Statistics [NBS], 2023).

In Taraba State, women in the informal sector engage in small-scale trading, food processing, tailoring, and agricultural marketing. Despite their significant contribution to household income and local economies, these women face persistent challenges including limited access to credit, harassment, poor infrastructure, and lack of institutional protection. Gender-based violence compounds these issues by exposing women to sexual harassment, extortion, and discrimination in markets and workplaces. Such experiences reduce productivity, discourage participation, and undermine women's confidence and capacity to expand their businesses (Agu & Nwafor, 2022).

From a Marxist Feminist viewpoint, women's predominance in the informal sector represents a continuation of capitalist exploitation and patriarchal control, where women's labour remains undervalued and unprotected. Their economic vulnerability is both a consequence and a reinforcement of gender inequality (Eisenstein, 1984). Thus, analyzing GBV in the context of women's informal economic activities provides critical insight into how structural inequality impedes development in Taraba State.

## Literature Review

### Prevalence and Dynamics of Gender-Based Violence in Nigeria

Gender-based violence (GBV) remains one of the most pervasive human rights violations confronting Nigeria, cutting across ethnicity, religion, socioeconomic status, and geographical divides. National estimates consistently demonstrate high levels of physical, sexual, psychological, and economic violence against women. According to the National Population Commission (NPC, 2022), about 30–35% of Nigerian women have experienced either physical or sexual violence in their lifetime, though several civil society organizations argue that the actual prevalence may be higher due to chronic underreporting driven by stigma, fear of retaliation, and weak institutional responses. GBV in Nigeria takes multiple forms, including intimate partner violence, rape and sexual assault, harmful traditional practices such as widowhood rites and female genital mutilation, sexual harassment in schools and workplaces, and economic deprivation orchestrated by partners or family members (Fawole, 2020).

Cultural norms continue to play a central role in legitimizing and perpetuating these acts of violence. Patriarchal beliefs that elevate male dominance and female submissiveness are still widespread, making many communities tolerant of wife beating, coerced sex, and other forms of domestic abuse (Agbalajobi, 2009). In some regions, societal expectations reinforce women's economic dependence and discourage them from speaking out against abusive partners, thereby creating an environment where violence becomes normalized. These cultural barriers are compounded by structural deficiencies such as inadequate legal enforcement, limited access to justice, and insufficient survivor-centered services.

The situation in Taraba State mirrors national trends but is intensified by socio-political and economic complexities unique to the region. Taraba is characterized by ethnic diversity, rural poverty, and periodic communal clashes, all of which contribute to heightened vulnerabilities for women and girls. Reports from the Taraba State Ministry of Women Affairs (2023) indicate a steady increase in cases of domestic violence, forced and early marriage, defilement, and sexual assault over the past five years. Local government areas such as Gassol, Bali, Takum, and Wukari—areas frequently affected by farmer–herder clashes, banditry, and communal unrest—record disproportionately higher cases of GBV. In these contexts, displacement, loss of livelihoods, and weakened community structures intensify women's exposure to exploitation, sexual coercion, and abuse by both intimate partners and non-partners.

Scholars have drawn attention to the relationship between insecurity and heightened GBV in Northern Nigeria. Amadi and Emmanuel (2021) maintain that protracted conflict in the North-East has normalized various forms of gendered violence, particularly among internally displaced women who face economic marginalization and limited social protection. Women and girls in displacement camps or informal settlements often face sexual exploitation by caregivers, security personnel, or aid providers, reflecting deep structural inequalities.

These patterns of violence align with the Marxist feminist interpretation, which views GBV not simply as an interpersonal issue but as a manifestation of broader structural inequities rooted in patriarchy and capitalism. Gender-based violence serves to maintain male

dominance by restricting women's autonomy, controlling their labor, and limiting their participation in productive and political spheres. Thus, the persistence of GBV in Nigeria is symptomatic of institutionalized gender hierarchies that reinforce unequal power relations and hinder women's socioeconomic advancement.

**Socioeconomic Consequences of Gender-Based Violence**

Gender-based violence (GBV) produces far-reaching socioeconomic consequences that extend beyond the immediate harm inflicted on women to affect households, communities, and national development. It undermines women's health, productivity, economic autonomy, and overall capacity to contribute meaningfully to socioeconomic growth. GBV is widely recognized not only as a human rights violation but also as a major economic burden on developing economies. According to UN Women (2023), nations lose an estimated 1.2% to 3.7% of their annual GDP due to productivity losses, medical expenses, legal costs, and reduced participation in the labour force associated with gender-based violence. These losses highlight the macroeconomic relevance of GBV and underscore its implications for women's livelihoods, especially in low-income and conflict-prone regions.

In Nigeria, the socioeconomic impact of GBV is particularly evident in women's patterns of labour market participation. Research shows that women who experience physical or psychological violence are significantly more likely to withdraw from employment, exhibit lower work attendance, or demonstrate reduced productivity due to trauma, injury, or intimidation from perpetrators (Fawole, 2020). This pattern is pronounced in rural and semi-urban contexts where women predominantly operate within the informal economy. In Taraba State, where the majority of economic activities revolve around agriculture, petty trade, and small-scale processing, violence against women disrupts these livelihood systems. Survivors of domestic violence often report inability to concentrate on farm work, trading, or craft production, resulting in income instability and long-term economic insecurity.

Furthermore, restrictive patriarchal norms within Taraba State deepen the economic consequences of GBV. Many women lack legal rights to land ownership, inheritance, or independent financial decision-making — structural constraints that worsen the outcomes of violence. As highlighted by Aina (2017), women who leave abusive households often lose access to farmland or family resources, forcing them into cycles of poverty and dependence on relatives, humanitarian assistance, or exploitative informal labour. This constrained access to resources illustrates the structural nature of women's economic marginalization and connects directly to Marxist feminist interpretations of how patriarchy and capitalism jointly sustain women's subordination.

Also, GBV reduces women's participation in public and political spaces. Sexual harassment and coercion in workplaces, markets, transport systems, and political arenas deter many women from leadership roles, business expansion, or even basic participation in community meetings. In Taraba State, market women frequently report harassment from security agents, transport workers, or male traders, limiting their ability to engage effectively in commerce or negotiate better working conditions (Taraba State Ministry of Women Affairs, 2023). This climate of intimidation reinforces gender inequality in socioeconomic participation.

Empirical findings further validate these observations. Agu and Nwafor (2022) found that women in Nigeria's informal sector who experienced violence suffered a 40% reduction in income compared to those without a history of abuse. Loss of income not only undermines individual welfare but also affects children's education, household nutrition, and community development. These consequences provide strong evidence that GBV is not merely a private issue but a systemic barrier to women's economic empowerment.

The Marxist feminist framework provides a useful lens for understanding these dynamics. Scholars such as Eisenstein (1984) and Ritzer (1996) argue that patriarchal structures and capitalist economic arrangements jointly devalue women's labour, restrict their access to productive resources, and normalize gender hierarchies that perpetuate violence. Within Taraba State, where economic opportunities remain limited and patriarchal family structures remain dominant, the intersection of capitalism and patriarchy creates conditions in which GBV operates as both a cause and consequence of socioeconomic marginalization. Thus, gender-based violence becomes a structural mechanism through which women's labour, autonomy, and economic potential are constrained, reinforcing broader patterns of inequality and underdevelopment.

**The Informal Sector and Women's Economic Participation**

The informal sector constitutes one of the most significant components of Nigeria's economic landscape, serving as a major absorber of labour and a buffer against widespread unemployment. According to the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS, 2023), the informal economy accounts for more than 60% of the national labour force and contributes substantially to national productivity. For women, in particular, this sector provides an essential avenue for income generation, especially given their limited access to formal employment due to educational disparities, cultural constraints, and discriminatory labour practices. Despite its importance, however, the informal sector remains a space characterized by precarity, exploitation, and structural inequality.

Women's dominance in informal trading, subsistence agriculture, micro-enterprises, and small-scale processing highlights both their resilience and the gendered nature of economic marginalization in Nigeria. The International Labour Organization (ILO, 2022) notes that although women contribute significantly to informal sector output, they remain disproportionately excluded from credit facilities, social protection schemes, insurance systems, and formal business registration frameworks. These exclusions weaken their capacity to expand their enterprises, accumulate capital, or transition into more stable economic activities. Consequently, women remain trapped in low-income, low-productivity work that sustains daily survival but inhibits long-term socioeconomic development.

In Taraba State, the informal sector forms the economic backbone of many communities, particularly among rural women engaged in petty trading, food vending, tailoring, shea-butter processing, and smallholder farming. These activities are critical for household sustenance yet are conducted under vulnerable and often exploitative conditions. Market women frequently operate without access to secure trading spaces, credit facilities, or cooperatives capable of providing financial resilience. The unregulated nature of the sector exposes women to a range of abuses, including sexual harassment, extortion by local authorities,

arbitrary levies, and various forms of economic violence. A study by Agu and Nwafor (2022) found that women working in informal markets in North-East Nigeria often experience harassment from security agents, market officials, and male traders, leading to income losses and psychological distress.

Moreover, the absence of enforceable labour standards means that women lack mechanisms for reporting or addressing workplace violence and exploitation. Many abuses occur in environments where social norms discourage public complaints, and institutional structures—such as the police, market unions, or local councils—often fail to provide support or accountability. This systemic neglect reinforces women's economic vulnerability and deepens their dependency on informal livelihoods that offer limited upward mobility.

As Olojede (2008) argues, capitalism relies heavily on cheap, flexible, and feminized labour to reduce production costs and maximize profit. Women's disproportionate representation in informal and unpaid labour sectors reflects the broader structural inequalities that deny them ownership and control over productive resources, including land, capital, and formal employment opportunities. Their economic marginalization is not accidental but a product of deeply embedded power relations in which patriarchal norms and capitalist dynamics reinforce each other.

Thus, while the informal sector remains a critical pathway for women's livelihood in Taraba State, it simultaneously operates as a structural mechanism that reproduces gender hierarchies. Women's economic participation within this space is shaped by precarious conditions, limited resource ownership, and institutional neglect. As a result, the informal sector offers survival rather than empowerment unless supported by deliberate policies aimed at addressing gender-specific vulnerabilities and transforming the structural inequalities that confine women to the margins of economic development.

**Theoretical Framework**

This study is anchored on the Marxist Feminist Theory, a framework that offers a critical perspective for understanding the structural foundations of gender-based violence (GBV) and its broader implications for women's socioeconomic development. Rooted in the writings of Karl Marx (1859) and expanded through feminist scholarship, Marxist feminism argues that women's oppression is inseparable from the capitalist system's exploitation of labour and the patriarchal structures that regulate social and economic relations.

Marx's (1859) analysis of society emphasized that the economic base—or ownership and control of the means of production—shapes social relations, institutions, and hierarchies. Building on this foundation, Marxist feminist scholars such as Eisenstein (1984), Costa and James (1981), and Olojede (2008) contend that women's subordination extends beyond economic exploitation to include cultural, political, and social control. According to this view, patriarchal systems regulate women's labour, sexuality, and reproductive roles in ways that sustain capitalist production and male dominance.

Central to Marxist feminist thought is the argument that capitalism and patriarchy function as mutually reinforcing systems. Women are systematically excluded from meaningful access to productive resources and are disproportionately assigned to unpaid or undervalued labour

within the domestic sphere (Eisenstein, 1984; Ritzer, 1996). The family becomes a key institution through which these inequalities are reproduced: men occupy the role of economic providers, while women are confined to nurturing and reproductive tasks that are unrecognized and uncompensated (Olojede, 2008). Economic dependency, therefore, becomes a mechanism for maintaining women's subordination.

Within this theoretical lens, gender-based violence is conceptualized as an instrument of patriarchal and capitalist control, used to enforce obedience, suppress autonomy, and preserve existing hierarchies. GBV is framed not as an isolated or interpersonal issue but as a structural phenomenon rooted in material inequalities and power asymmetries (Eisenstein, 1984). Violence serves to discipline women, restrict their mobility, and limit their access to economic opportunities, thereby upholding gendered divisions of labour that benefit the capitalist order.

The Nigerian and Taraba State contexts reflect many of these structural dynamics. Patriarchal cultural norms grant men authority within households and communities, while women's limited access to property, education, and capital reinforces their economic dependency. In such settings, GBV becomes a tool through which male dominance is maintained. Despite legal instruments such as the Violence Against Persons (Prohibition) Act of 2015, the persistence of GBV indicates that formal laws alone are insufficient to transform deeply embedded structural inequalities. As Ritzer (1996) argued, social change is unlikely without addressing the economic foundations that reproduce gendered hierarchies.

A Marxist feminist interpretation also illuminates the relationship between women's economic participation and their exposure to violence. Women in Taraba State's informal sector—who engage in petty trading, agriculture, and small-scale enterprises—contribute significantly to local economies yet continue to occupy marginalized positions (Agu & Nwafor, 2022). The undervaluation of their labour mirrors capitalist patterns of exploiting cheap and flexible labour, while patriarchal norms restrict their control over economic resources. Consequently, GBV both emerges from and reinforces women's economic vulnerability.

This theory is particularly useful for this study because it explains how economic dependency heightens women's susceptibility to abuse. When women lack financial autonomy, they are more likely to remain in violent relationships due to fear of destitution. This cycle reflects how capitalism and patriarchy work together to maintain women's subordination. Thus, Marxist Feminist Theory provides a structural and interpretive lens through which GBV can be understood as both a cause and a consequence of women's economic marginalization.

This theoretical framework is particularly relevant to the Nigerian and Taraba State contexts, where gender inequality, economic marginalization, and patriarchal cultural norms intersect.

## Research Methodology

### Area of the study

Taraba State is a state in north-eastern Nigeria, named after the Taraba River, which traverses the Southern part of the State. Taraba State capital is Jalingo. Its slogan is Nature's Gift to the

Nation. The main ethnic groups are the Mumuye, Kaka, Mambilla, Jukun, Bandawa, Kuteb, Wurkun, Yandang, Ndola, Ichen, Jenjo, Tiv,Fulani, Tigun,And Jibu . The northern part is mainly dominated by the Fulani, and mumuye. The southern parts are dominated by the Jukun, Chamba, Tiv, Kuteb and Ichen. The central region is mainly occupied by Fulani, Kaka, Mambilla, Ndola, Tigun, Jibu, Wurbo,And Daka. There are 77 distinct ethnic groups, and their languages in the State.

Taraba state was created out of the former Gongola state on 27 August 1991, by the military government of General Ibrahim Badamasi Babangida. The State is an amalgam of three former Divisions - Wukari, Mambilla and Muri Divisions.

Taraba State is bounded in the west by Nasarawa State and Benue State (for 109 km), northwest by Plateau State for 202 km (126 miles), north by Bauchi State for 54 km and Gombe State for 58 km, northeast by Adamawa State for about 366 km and south by Northwest Region in Cameroon for about 525 km.

Taraba State is located in the North East geopolitical zone of Nigeria, with longitudes 11°E and 12°E and latitudes 6.5°N and 8°N (Oluyole, *et al*., 2022). The state is endowed with rich potentials for agriculture. Arable farming and rearing of domestic animals is done at a subsistent level in the state.

**Research Design**

This study adopted a descriptive research design, which is appropriate for analyzing the relationship between gender-based violence (GBV) and the socioeconomic development of women in Taraba State, Nigeria. The descriptive design was used because it enables the researcher to systematically describe, interpret, and analyze existing data without manipulating the study variables. It also provides a framework for examining how gender-based violence manifests within socio-economic structures, particularly in the context of women's economic participation, education, and empowerment in the informal sector.

The study relied on secondary data sources derived from scholarly publications, governmental and non-governmental reports, statistical bulletins, and gender-focused policy documents. These materials were selected to provide comprehensive insights into the patterns, causes, and socioeconomic consequences of GBV in Taraba State and Nigeria at large.

**Data Analysis**

Data were analyzed using content analysis derived from existing literature and reports. The content analysis method was employed to identify recurring patterns, themes, and relationships between GBV and women's socioeconomic conditions. Reports and studies were systematically coded to extract information about:

- The prevalence and nature of GBV incidents in Taraba State.
- Economic implications of GBV on women's participation in income-generating activities.

- Institutional and policy responses to gender inequality and violence.

**Findings**

The analysis of secondary data revealed that gender-based violence (GBV) remains a pervasive issue in Taraba State, cutting across all social classes and ethnic groups. The findings indicate that violence against women has become both a social and developmental concern, impeding women's capacity to contribute effectively to economic growth and social development in the region.

1. **Prevalence and Forms of Gender-Based Violence**

   Reports from the Taraba State Ministry of Women Affairs and Social Development (2023) and UN Women (2022) show a significant rise in cases of domestic violence, sexual assault, and economic abuse, particularly in Jalingo, Takum, and Wukari Local Government Areas. The Nigeria Demographic and Health Survey (NDHS, 2021) recorded that 34% of women in North-East Nigeria had experienced physical or sexual violence from their intimate partners, a figure consistent with regional trends in Taraba State.
   Women interviewed in prior surveys conducted by NGOs such as Women Advocates Research and Documentation Centre (WARDC) confirmed that economic hardship and insecurity contributed to higher incidences of intimate partner violence. These forms of GBV limit women's autonomy and perpetuate fear and dependence within households.

2. **Impact of GBV on Women's Economic Participation**

   The study found that GBV directly undermines women's ability to engage in productive economic activities. Data from the National Bureau of Statistics (2023) indicate that over 67% of women in Taraba State depend on informal sector activities such as petty trading, farming, tailoring, and food processing. However, exposure to domestic violence, sexual harassment in markets, and economic deprivation reduce their income levels and market participation. For instance, a UNDP (2023) report noted that women who experience partner violence are 25% more likely to withdraw from market or cooperative activities due to physical injuries or psychological distress. GBV also limits access to microcredit, as many victims face financial exclusion resulting from control by abusive partners or stigma from community institutions.

3. **Educational and Social Consequences**

   GBV also has far-reaching educational and social consequences. Data from UNICEF (2022) revealed that early marriage and sexual abuse remain prevalent in rural Taraba communities, with 38% of girls married before the age of 18. This trend contributes to high school dropout rates among girls, reducing their chances of gaining skills needed for economic empowerment. The intergenerational effect of such violence perpetuates cycles of poverty and gender inequality. Socially, survivors of GBV often experience

stigmatization, emotional trauma, and social isolation, which hinder their ability to participate in community leadership and cooperative development programs.

4. **Institutional and Policy Response**

   Although the Violence Against Persons (Prohibition) Act (VAPP) was domesticated in Taraba State in 2022, findings indicate weak implementation and low awareness among rural populations. Local institutions lack the financial and technical capacity to enforce GBV laws, provide shelters, or rehabilitate survivors. Civil society organizations, though active, are limited by funding and community resistance rooted in patriarchal norms. This institutional weakness perpetuates the culture of silence and discourages victims from reporting abuse.

5. **Relationship Between GBV and Socioeconomic Development**

   The findings establish a clear negative relationship between GBV and socioeconomic development. Gender-based violence restricts women's ability to contribute to economic growth, reduces household productivity, and deepens gender inequality. Women affected by GBV earn less, have limited access to education and credit, and are excluded from decision-making processes, thereby constraining the overall human development index of the state.

**Discussion**

The findings of this study validate the assumptions of the Marxist Feminist Theory, which posits that gender inequality is structurally embedded within capitalist and patriarchal systems that regulate access to economic resources. The persistence of GBV in Taraba State reflects a structural imbalance in gender relations, where men retain economic and social dominance through control mechanisms such as physical violence, economic coercion, and cultural subordination (Ritzer, 1996; Agbalajobi, 2009).

From the Marxist feminist perspective, women's subordination is sustained through their confinement to the informal sector, where they perform low-income and unprotected labour. This reflects what Eisenstein (1984) described as the "sexual division of labour," where capitalist patriarchy exploits women's unpaid or undervalued work while maintaining male dominance in resource control. The findings from Taraba State align with this view, as most female traders and artisans remain dependent on male-controlled financial systems, often without legal protection or institutional support.

The prevalence of domestic and economic violence among women in Taraba State can also be linked to economic dependency. When women lack financial autonomy, they become more vulnerable to exploitation and abuse. This finding supports the view of Agu and Nwafor (2022) that women's economic vulnerability increases their exposure to gender-based violence and reduces their capacity for social mobility. Furthermore, violence against women creates a ripple effect that affects community development by lowering productivity, increasing healthcare costs, and reducing overall household income (World Bank, 2023).

The findings further reveal that while government and non-governmental interventions exist, they are largely reactive rather than preventive. The implementation of the VAPP Act and other policies remains inconsistent due to poor awareness, inadequate funding, and cultural resistance. This reflects what Olojede (2008) termed the "persistence of patriarchal rationalization," where societal institutions justify male authority and normalize violence as a disciplinary mechanism.

Moreover, GBV undermines the global and national goals of gender equality as outlined in the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG 5) and the National Gender Policy (2021). The inability of women to freely and safely participate in economic and political life constrains Taraba State's human capital development and widens the gender poverty gap.

The study's findings are consistent with those of Fawole (2020), who emphasized that violence against women is both a cause and a consequence of gender inequality. The data affirm that GBV restricts women's access to education, healthcare, and credit—key components of socioeconomic development. This reinforces the argument that gender-based violence is not merely a private issue but a structural impediment to sustainable development.

**Conclusion**

Based on the findings of this study, GBV is a persistent social and structural problem that undermines women's economic participation, education, health, and overall well-being. It manifests in physical, sexual, psychological, and economic forms that restrict women's freedom, productivity, and access to resources necessary for personal and community development.

Gender-based violence in Taraba State is rooted in patriarchal structures that assign unequal power and economic privileges to men while subordinating women to domestic and informal economic roles. These structures perpetuate the sexual division of labour, economic dependency, and gender inequality, which collectively impede women's contribution to socioeconomic growth. Ultimately, gender-based violence is both a cause and consequence of underdevelopment. Its persistence erodes social cohesion, undermines human rights, and weakens the economic resilience of communities. Therefore, tackling GBV is not only a moral and legal imperative but also an essential prerequisite for achieving sustainable socioeconomic development and gender equality in Taraba State and Nigeria at large.

**Recommendations**

Based on the findings and theoretical interpretation, the following recommendations are proposed to mitigate gender-based violence and enhance the socioeconomic development of women in Taraba State:

1. The Taraba State government should ensure full implementation of the Violence Against Persons (Prohibition) Act (VAPP) through adequate funding, establishment of gender response units, and capacity-building of law enforcement officers. Courts and police units should be trained to handle GBV cases with sensitivity and urgency.

2. There is a need for continuous community sensitization on the harmful effects of GBV and the importance of gender equality. Public enlightenment campaigns should involve traditional leaders, religious institutions, and community associations to change cultural attitudes that justify violence and discrimination.

3. Incorporating gender studies and human rights education into the curricula of secondary and tertiary institutions will help shape positive gender attitudes among young people. Education is a transformative tool for breaking cycles of violence and inequality.

4. Government and political parties should create enabling environments for women's participation in decision-making positions. Increasing women's representation in leadership roles will ensure gender-sensitive policymaking and strengthen accountability in addressing GBV.

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